



Jonathan Grossman

Abram to Abraham

A Literary Analysis
of the Abraham Narrative



DAS ALTE TESTAMENT IM DIALOG
an outline of an old testament dialogue
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Peter Lang

Abram to Abraham explores the Abraham saga (11:27-22:24) through a literary lens, following the legendary figure of Abraham as he navigates the arduous odyssey to nationhood. Rather than overlook the textual discrepancies, repetitions and contradictions long noted by diachronic scholars, this study tackles them directly, demonstrating how many problems of the ancient text in fact hold the key to deeper understanding of the narrative and its objectives. Therefore, the book frequently notes the classic division of the text according to primary sources, but offers an alternative, more harmonious reading based on the assumption that the narrative forms a single, intentionally designed unit.

The narrative's artistic design is especially evident in its arrangement of the two halves of the story around the protagonists' change of name. The stories of Abram and Sarai in the first half of the cycle (11:27-16:16) are parallel to the stories of Abraham and Sarah in the second half (18:1-22:24). A close reading of this transformation in the biblical narrative illuminates the moral and theological values championed by the figure of Abraham as luminary, soldier, family man, and loyal subject of God.

Dr. Jonathan Grossman is a faculty member of the Department of Bible at Bar Ilan University. His main field of interest is the Bible as literature. Among his previous books are *Esther: The Outer Narrative and the Hidden Reading* (Eisenbrauns, 2011); *Ruth: Bridges and Boundaries* (Peter Lang, 2015); *Text and Subtext: On Exploring Biblical Narrative Design* (Hakibbuz Hameuchad, 2015).

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Michael Fieger & Sigrid Hodel-Hoenes



PETER LANG

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Dedicated to the memory of

Dr. Noam Shudofsky

By his family and friends

Noam loved Biblical studies
and enabled generations of students to
“Understand and discern, to listen, learn and teach, to observe,
perform and fulfill all the teachings of the Torah with love”

Contents

Foreword	13
Introduction	15
“Abraham was but one man” (Eze 33:24).....	15
The Historical Era of the Abraham Narrative.....	16
Sources, Redaction, and Cohesion	21
The Interchangeability of God’s Names in the Narrative	28
The Abraham Cycle as a Cohesive Unit.....	31
Redaction as Interpretation of the Text.....	34
The Narrative and Artistic Structure of the Abraham Cycle	34
The Context of the Narrative Cycle.....	42
Family and Nationality	43
The Abraham Cycle: Between “Nation” and “People”	50
Citizen Will and Divine Will	59
Nationalism and Morality	64
Moral Nationalism and Post-Modern Nationalism	67
Chapter 1: The Line of Terah (11:27–30)	69
Terah’s Journey to Canaan (11:31–32)	72
Plot Development.....	74
Literary Significance	78
Chapter 2: Abram’s Journey to Canaan (12:1–9).....	83
The Omitted Introduction	83
Go Forth	84
Abram’s Journey.....	92
Abram’s Journey in Canaan and the Construction of Altars.....	96

Chapter 3: The Descent to Egypt (12:10–20)	105
Chapter 4: The Separation from Lot (Gen 13)	119
The Quarreling Herdsmen	121
Abram’s Proposal.....	123
Lot’s Choice: Sodom, like the Garden of Eden, like the land of Egypt.....	124
Chapter 5: War of the Four Kings –	
Lot’s Liberation (14)	131
Conquest of the Transjordan (1–7)	133
Lot’s Rescue (8–16).....	140
Abram Takes Action.....	145
Abram Meets with the Kings (17–24)	146
Chapter 6: Looking to the Stars and the	
Covenant between the Pieces (15).....	161
The Promise of Offspring (1–6)	163
The Covenant between the Pieces (7–21).....	169
Chapter 7: Hagar’s Flight (16)	187
“Her mistress was lowered in her esteem” –	
“Sarai treated her harshly” (1–6)	188
“Then Sarai treated her harshly, and she ran away from her”	195
The Meeting at the Spring (7–14).....	198
Naming Names (13–14).....	206
God Sees the Suffering of the Oppressed.....	211
Conclusion (15–16).....	214
Chapter 8: The Covenant of Circumcision (17)	217
a-a1. “Abraham was ninety-nine years old”	221
b-b1. The Beginning and End of the Revelation	222
c-c1. Covenant and Fertility	224
d-d1: Abram Throws Himself on His Face.....	228
e-e1: The Name Change	229

F – The Covenant Sign (9–14)	233
Circumcision and the Rainbow as Covenant Signs	244
Chapter 9: Angels Eat and Sarah Laughs (18:1–16)	249
Abraham's Guests (1–5).....	252
Preparing the Feast (6–8).....	259
Tidings of Isaac's Birth (9–15)	263
Sarah's Laughter	271
Chapter 10: The Debate over Sodom's Destruction (18:16–33)	275
"Judge of all the Earth".....	282
I Who Am but Dust and Ashes.....	286
Chapter 11: Sodom's Destruction and Lot's Rescue (19)	295
The Angels Arrive in Sodom (1–3).....	296
The Townspeople (4–11).....	300
The Verdict and Lot's Escape (12–17)	309
Saving Zoar (18–22)	313
The Destruction of the Cities (23–26).....	314
First Conclusion (27–28)	319
Second Conclusion (19:29).....	321
Why was Lot Saved from Sodom?	323
Lot's Liberation from Sodom and Israel's Deliverance from Egypt.....	330
Lot's Liberation from Sodom and Rahab's Rescue from Jericho	331
Chapter 12: Lot and his Daughters in the Cave (19:30–38)	335
Evaluation of the Characters.....	336
The Daughters.....	338
The Reasoning of the Elder Daughter.....	344
The Evaluation of Lot.....	356
Lot's Daughters as an Epilogue to the Destruction of Sodom...	358
Lot's Daughters in the Context of the Abraham Cycle.....	362

Chapter 13: Abraham and Sarah in Gerar (20).....	365
Abraham's Journey to Gerar (1)	367
Abimelech Takes Sarah (2)	371
The Dialogue between God and Abimelech (3–7).....	373
Early Next Morning (8)	378
Abimelech and Abraham (9–13).....	380
Reconciliation (14–18).....	385
A Double Reading	388
 Chapter 14: The Birth of Isaac and Ishmael's	
Expulsion (21:1–21)	399
Reactions to the Birth (6–8).....	403
The Expulsion of Ishmael (9–21).....	405
Sarah's Demand (9–10)	406
Ishmael is Sent to his Future (11–14).....	412
Saving Ishmael (14–21)	415
How Old is Ishmael?.....	419
The Structure and Purpose of the Narrative	421
Hagar's Flight (Gen 16) and Hagar's Expulsion (21)	426
 Chapter 15: The Treaty of Abraham	
and Abimelech (21:22–34).....	437
 Chapter 16: The Binding of Isaac (22).....	451
Introduction I: Did Abraham Pass the Test?.....	451
Introduction II: The Binding Narrative in Context	455
Introduction III: The Land of Moriah.....	460
Exposition (1).....	463
God's Command (1–2).....	464
Abraham's Implementation (3).....	468
First Dialogue: Abraham and the Servants (4–5).....	471
Second Dialogue: Abraham and Isaac (6–8).....	473
Abraham Binds Isaac and Picks up the Knife (9–10)	477
The Angel's Revelation and the Sacrifice	
of the Ram (11–14).....	479
Misleading Conclusion.....	481

God's Promise (15–18).....	484
Sacrifice of the Ram and the Structure of the Narrative	490
Conclusion (19)	495
Chapter 17: The Sons of Nahor (22:20–24).....	499
Conclusion	505
Bibliography	515

Foreword

History has seen few revolutionaries like Abraham, who left his home and crossed over to the “other side” of the Euphrates to found a new culture, changing the face of history. One man’s journey, at a specific point in time, was a giant leap for humanity. Religious and cultural history as we know it today was unquestionably shaped by the call to “Go forth,” which marked the first step of a national, ethical saga.

Often, exploration of origin awakens fundamental questions that touch upon the very question of existence. Abraham’s narrative cycle grapples with the very definition of the Israelite nation – or, to be more true to the spirit of the Genesis stories – the very definition of the Israelite family. Other raw, profound issues touch upon the tension between morality and nationality; and the tension between taking an autonomous stand against God and total, unquestioning submission to Divine authority.

This book was written in memory of Dr. Noam Shudofsky (1933–2005), an outstanding Jewish educator and activist. Noam began his career at the Ramaz School in Manhattan as a Bible teacher and served with dedication as Administrator for forty years. He was extraordinarily devoted to his students and faculty. One of the cornerstones of Noam’s Jewish identity was his love of Bible. Whether at the family’s Shabbat table or in study sessions with Soviet refuseniks, teaching Bible was his passion. Writing this book in his memory was a special privilege for me. I was also blessed to become acquainted with his wife, Nechi, and his entire family, people whose lives are deeply rooted in love of Torah and love of humanity and colored with humility and devotion.

With great pleasure, I wish to thank everyone who helped bring this book to light; from its first conception to its final design. First and foremost, from the depths of my heart, I wish to thank my dear friend Binny Shalev, who made this journey together with me, a journey that

taught me so much about humility and kindness. I hope we will always continue reenacting the verse, “And the two of them walked together.” We were accompanied on our journey by Itamar Eldar, whose contributions to the ideas expressed in this work were indispensable. As English is not my mother tongue, Atara Snowbell took on the formidable task of translating the manuscript into English. Her love for the words of Genesis translated technical grammatical discussions into precise, sincere explorations of the text’s meaning. My sincere thanks also go to Peter Lang’s dedicated publication team and the editors of the wonderful series this book now belongs to, Michael Fieger and Sigrid Hodel-Hoenes. Especial thanks go to Angelica Scholze and Friederike Meisner, whose generosity and professionalism guided this book’s publication from start to finish.

Last but not least, of course, thanks are due to my wife and children, who accompany me on every journey into the world of reading, writing and study, who so patiently and so fruitfully hear out every thought and dilemma; who color every ordinary day with joy.

יבואו כולם על הברכה.

Introduction

“Abraham was but one man” (Eze 33:24)

“Abraham was but one man, yet he got possession of the land,” declare the people of Jerusalem to the Babylonian exiles. But Abraham is no regular man; he is the founder of the Israelite people and the father of what may be tentatively referred to as ethical monotheism. Literary theorists define literary characters according to their actions and personalities, referring to characters as dynamic or static, flat or round; but the complex figure of Abraham eludes such definitions.¹ While Abraham’s fierce faith in God is unwavering, his character is wrought with internal contradictions and inconsistencies. He builds altars and invokes the name of God, but also goes to war to save Lot from captivity; he wordlessly accepts God’s commands to follow him to an unknown land and to sacrifice his son, yet he challenges God’s decision to destroy Sodom; he allows his wife Sarah the freedom to do as she will with Hagar (16:7), but is distressed by the prospect of expelling the maidservant and her son (21:11). The many conflicting layers of his personality construct a profound, inscrutable figure, a legendary founder of a legendary nation.²

1 See also Römer 1997. He identifies various characterizations of Abraham in the Cycle. For example, as a rural aristocrat on the one hand, and as an itinerant on the other hand.

2 See Simon 2002. He noted additional conflicts in Abraham’s character.

The Historical Era of the Abraham Narrative

Countless theories have attempted to elucidate the connection between the Abraham narratives and the historical period they reflect. Wellhausen surmised that the Abraham cycle reflects the philosophies of later eras; either the settlement period, or the monarchical era.³ Seeligman believed that the patriarchal narratives were originally unrelated stories of individual characters who were fused into one family at a later stage.⁴ Many scholars, such as Malamat, hypothesized that Abraham's character was fashioned in relation to the figure of David in order to legitimize and validate David's monarchy.⁵ Others believe that "the story of Abraham, as an important segment of the Priestly History of the Hexateuch ... was composed with the purpose of providing those who survived the disaster of 586 B.C.E. with a religious basis on which they could rebuild their lives. More specifically, the component of the History dealing with Abraham was intended to provide a paradigm or model for those who aspired to return, or actually did return, to Judah once this became possible after the fall of Babylon in 539 B.C.E."⁶

Such theories and their numerous variations are purely speculative, and essentially concern whether the patriarchs should be considered realistic-historical figures, and if so, of which era.⁷

Some claim that the purpose of the patriarchal narratives is independent of the historical question. Even the minimalists, who claim that Abraham is not a historical figure, believe that the stories reflect an array of messages, conveyed through narrative content and design. Moreover, the patriarch's portrayal is clearly not intended as a historical

3 Wellhausen 1994, 318–42.

4 Seeligman 1992, 102–40.

5 Malamat 2001. See also Mazar 1971/1; Lemaire 1993; Stoebe 1997; Dietrich 2000; Gosse 2009; Auld 2011; Lemaire 2013.

6 Blenkinsopp 2009, 225.

7 A survey of the central positions can be found in Römer 2001; Gelandner 2009, 353–418.

biography.⁸ While the biblical narrative depicts certain sequences of Abraham's life, long periods are completely omitted; highly significant personal events, such as his marriage to Keturah and the birth of six sons, are mentioned only briefly. The fact that certain events are abridged while sequences that promote the narrative's ideology are related at length (such as the War of the Kings in Gen 14), indicates that the Abraham cycle is more committed to promoting ethical messages than to historical accuracy; to use Buber's terminology, the patriarchal cycles should be considered "historical," not "archaeological."⁹

Nonetheless, Sarna is correct in stating that the tendency to view the patriarchal narratives as entirely fictional is exaggerated.¹⁰ He emphasized that the characters are depicted using concrete, ordinary detail, rather than as mythical figures – and pointed out that Mesopotamia and Canaan are represented with strong historical accuracy.¹¹ Many assert that there is importance in determining the time-frame of the Abraham narratives due to the connections between the literary setting and the real world, which are especially apparent in legal contexts. Speiser wrote: "These chapters are generally a true reflection of prevalent traditions and customs in the relevant era."¹² While new evidence has since disproved some of Speiser's assertions,¹³ the school

8 Brodie wrote that the first biblical biography is Jacob's, not Abraham's (Brodie 2001, 90).

9 Buber 1946, 13–19. Based on Buber's assertion, Hallo (1980) claimed that "Israeli[te] history" only begins with the enslavement in Egypt, whereas the patriarchal narratives do not purport to deliver a historical sequence relating to the nation.

10 See Wenhham 1987, xxii, who claimed that, whereas some narratives seem more legendary than biographical, the texts are still written in a historical setting of realistic characters. See also Mathews 2005, 36–37.

11 Sarna 1966, 81–85; Sarna 1977. Criticism of the approach that views Abraham as a divine myth or a half-god can be found in Cassuto 1950, 64; Cassuto 1964, 297–99; Gelandar 2009, 362.

12 Speiser 1967, 80. Kitchen (1994) reached a similar conclusion after examining various perspectives of links between the patriarchal narratives and literature from the end of the second millennium BCE. See also Grintz 1983; Cassuto 1950, 64–65.

13 See especially Thompson 1974, 315–330.

of biblical archeology's findings have significantly illuminated some aspects of the patriarchal narratives, which rely on "traditions and customs" that were prevalent in the ancient Near East.

Among the scholars who believe in the narratives' historicity, many date the patriarchal era to the second millennium BCE (2200–1550).¹⁴ This is supported by the correlation of names and places mentioned in the text;¹⁵ by the prevalence of wandering from land to land, as Terah and Abraham do; by the patriarchal lifestyle, which correlates

14 This position is not as broadly accepted as it once was. Many now believe that the ancestral period more likely took place during the 12th–14th centuries, such as Chandler 2008 (from 1396 to 1321); Lemaire 1984 (first half of the 13th century), and McCarter 1988 (1200). Finkelstein and Römer suggested that the early Abraham material represents traditions about the eponymous hero of the population of the southern highlands in the later phases of the Iron Age (Finkelstein and Römer 2014). Some scholars corrected the date based on the biblical text: Jacob descended to Egypt when he was 130 (Gen 47:9), placing 290 years between the birth of Abraham and Jacob's journey to Egypt. According to Exodus 12:40, the Israelites dwelt in Egypt for 430 years. Some 480 years elapsed from the Egyptian exodus to the inauguration of the Jerusalem Temple (1 Kgs 6:1). The Temple was inaugurated in the fourth year of Solomon's reign, around 967 BCE. According to this chronology (290+430+480+967) Abraham was born in 2167 BCE, and departed for Canaan in 2092. Kaufmann (1953, vol. 1, p. 1, note 1) noted appropriately that the calculation is nonsensical. On this position and additional refutations see Sarna 1966, 81–85. Saran demonstrated the symbolic significance of the numbers in the story cycle. See also Mathews 2005, 37.

15 See, e.g., Bright 1972, 70–71; Frayne 2001 (Concerning the names mentioned in Genesis 11:27–32), but also the critique in Van Seters 1975, 39–64. The central location that challenges this claim is Beer-sheba, which, based on archeological surveys, was "uninhabited until the settlement of the Israelite tribes" [Ne'eman 1992, 265 (in the bibliographical notes)]. However, the Negev and Beer-sheba valley were certainly settled earlier, and the text is unclear regarding whether Abraham lived in an actual city. Abraham might have lived his entire life in a tent as a nomad (18:1); he might have settled in Beer-sheba before it became a city, while the text uses the known name from a later period of settlement (cf. Yeivin 1967, 107). Based on the geographical locations mentioned in the narrative, Bimson (1980, 68–80) divided the patriarchal narratives into two periods: the Abraham narratives to Middle Bronze I, and the Jacob narratives to Middle Bronze II.

with documents found in Mari (which was destroyed by Hammurabi in the 17th century BCE); and by the use of the title “El” as a private name, among other details. Some of these details have been refuted, proving it is problematic to pinpoint the precise time of the patriarchal era.¹⁶ The relationship between the patriarchs and documentation from Nuzi has not been sufficiently established,¹⁷ but there is a strong connection between the lifestyle and social norms of the patriarchs and records from Mari and the Hammurabi Code.¹⁸

The legal and social norms reflected in these records correlate with many aspects of the Abraham narratives, which “supports the authenticity of the background circumstances described in the bible,”¹⁹ and, moreover, also sheds light on ambiguous episodes in the narrative. The enthusiasm that characterized the research of Speiser and his peers in the 20th century is not shared by current biblical scholarship, which has determined that legal correlation between these sources and the Bible is less convincing than previously believed. However, regarding social norms and lifestyle, the similarity continues to be most impressive; as Rowley points out,²⁰ some social details that are incongruent with biblical law are clarified in light of Mesopotamian documents. For example, in contrast with the law in Deut 21:15–17,

16 Based on the correlation with the Nuzi documents, Gordon (1940) suggested dating the patriarchal era at the 15th and 14th centuries; based on links with Aramaic literature Hermann (1975) suggested the 12th century BCE.

17 Selman (1980) noted 13 links between norms that arise in the patriarchal narratives and ancient Near East laws. He also asserted that based on the Nuzi documents, the patriarchal period is difficult to date. See also Thompson 1974, 196–297.

18 See, for example: Rocha Couto 2003; Rooker 2003. But see also Justel 2012. The documents found in Mari are impressively linked with the patriarchal narratives. See Dever 1977, 104–18; Cornelius 1984; Malamat 1989, 27–69; Anbar 2001. Based on the assumption that Abraham lived in the 18th century BCE, creating a social-cultural background for the story cycle is nearly impossible, since sources are sparse before the 17th century, both in Mesopotamia and in Egypt. See Tadmor 1967, 40. On the political situation in Canaan and the complex and unstable relationship between Canaan and Egypt at the time, see Mazar 1967; Ne’eman 1992.

19 Speiser 1967, 79.

20 Rowley 1949, 299–303. See also: Yeivin 1963; Bright 1972, 62–72.

the text in Gen 48:5 implies that Jacob has the authority to determine primogeniture, a custom reflected in ancient Near Eastern laws. Similarly, Abraham implies that in the absence of a son, the steward of his household, Damascus Eliezer (15:3), will be his heir, a norm which is reflected in adoption documents from Nuzi;²¹ the Hammurabi Code includes articles regulating the obligations and privileges of a barren woman who gave her maidservant to her husband, which are relevant to the Abraham/Sarah/Hagar drama (Gen 16). Ishmael's expulsion from Abraham's house (Gen 21:10) is also clarified in light of the Hammurabi Code (#170–71), which dictates that a master who fails to recognize the heir born of his maidservant is obligated to set the maid and her son free.

The status of the family patriarch as described in Genesis also correlates with the period in question, particularly the father's authority over his sons and daughters as reflected in the narrative of Judah and Tamar (Gen 38:24), and Reuben's statement about his sons (42:37). Lehmann believed that Ephron the Hittite gave Abraham the field in addition to the cave he requested because Hittite law dictates that even partial ownership of a piece of land obligates a person to pay taxes for the entire area, and only by selling the entire piece is the owner exempt from taxation.²² Weinfeld noted that according to Mesopotamian documents, a royal military chief's presence is required for a covenant ceremony, as reflected in Gen 21:22 and 26:26.²³ Similarly, planting trees (Gen 21:33) and building altars (Gen 28:18 and 22) were objectionable actions in later eras, but acceptable in the ancient world. Pons added that Gen 12–36 indicates that Abraham and Jacob were on good terms with nations that were rejected in Deuteronomy.²⁴ Moberly wrote:

21 See, for example, Parrot 1968, 103; but see also Thompson's criticism, 1974, 203–230.

22 Lehmann 1953. On additional encounters between the Abraham cycle and Hittite culture and literature, see Singer 2009, 241 (regarding the phrase "*EI-Elyon*, creator of heaven and earth"). See also pp. 106–07.

23 Weinfeld 1992.

24 Pons 1990.

Probably the most obvious argument for the ancient and pre-Yahwistic character of the patriarchal traditions is the number of religious practices to which they refer which are at variance with normative Mosaic Yahwism, especially as this is set out in Deuteronomy. For example, Abraham plants a tree in Beersheba at a place where he worships God (Gen 21.33), and also builds altars in two places where some special tree already exists (Gen 12.6–7; 13.18). Yet the law of Deut. 16.21 states, “You shall not plant any tree as an Asherah beside the altar of YHWH your God which you shall make.” Now of course none of the Genesis passages state that the tree which Abraham planted or beside which he built an altar was an “Asherah” (a sacred tree or pole, consistently associated in the Old Testament with Canaanite religious practice which is prohibited for Israel, e.g., Judg. 6.25–30; 1 Kgs 14.23; 2 Kgs 18.3–4); nonetheless, it is difficult not to feel that even so there is an obvious affinity between Abraham’s practice and that prohibited by Deuteronomy. How then is it that Abraham, the model for Israel’s faith, can carry out religious practices forbidden to Israel, yet with no adverse comment from the narrator? The obvious answer would appear to be that the writer takes seriously Abraham’s context prior to the giving of the Torah to Israel, in which the prohibitions of Deuteronomy simply do not apply because they were not yet given.²⁵

This work is not concerned with issues of historical accuracy, with the exception of those that touch upon social or legal questions which inform our understanding of the plot. The analysis in this book will therefore tentatively rely on documented social and legal customs from the second millennium BCE, which illuminate various details in the Abraham cycle.

Sources, Redaction, and Cohesion

While the Abraham cycle was previously believed to be founded solely on three sources: J, E, and P,²⁶ toward the end the previous century

25 Moberly 1995, 76.

26 Scholars debate the attribution of each biblical narrative to various sources. One example is Driver’s division (Driver 1894). Driver attributed the following sources to P: Gen 11:27 and 31–32; 12:4b–5; 13:6 and 11b–12a; 16:1a, 3, and

various scholars contested this position, and argued that the two primary sources J and E were in fact one.²⁷ In any case, there is general consensus that the narrative cycle was composed by more than one author.²⁸ As a result of the general consensus of this approach, few attempts were made to follow the unit as one cohesive cycle. Most scholars perceived stylistic or conceptual inconsistencies as the result of multiple authors.

Scholars who refuted this approach did so from two different perspectives. Some argued that the cycle's style does point to the hand of a single author:

The narratives in the text before us are designed in an elaborate harmonious structure, which does not seem like the result of the random combination of individual sections. Numeric harmony is apparent, founded on the numbers ten and seven. God's promises and blessings are repeated seven times; the first (12:2–3) includes seven repetitions of the root “blessing” (ברכה)...All these details point to the creation of a detailed and organized elaborate and harmonious structure, based on materials selected from the treasure of ancient tradition.²⁹

Others claimed that even if the cycle is based on a variety of sources, the intense redactive (or the ‘proactive editing’) process is apparent;³⁰ the reader is presented with a unified and highly organized narrative cycle, which should be analyzed and discussed as such.³¹ This approach

15–16; chapter 17; 19:29; 21:1b and 2b-5; chapter 23; 25: 7–11a. He attributed the following sources to E: 15:1–5, 12–16, and 19–21; 20:1–18; 21:6–32 and 34; 22:1–14 and 19. Driver attributed the remainder of the Abraham narrative to J, apart from ch. 14, which is not attributed to any of the known sources.

27 Van Seters 1975; Coats 1983, Radday 1981. Sometimes this position views E as a development or adaption of J, instead of a separate source.

28 Since according to this position the traditions of each source can be identified in the source (P1-P2; J1-J2), the position supports the idea of a multiplicity of authors and traditions.

29 Cassuto 1950, 62–64. The root of the word “blessing,” however, appears five times in 12:2–3, not seven.

30 On ‘proactive editing’ See: Amit 1992, 3–18.

31 The roots of this approach are evident in the work of Jean Astruc, who relied on the interchangeability of God's name in Genesis and Exodus, and suggested that Moses had possessed two different sources. He refuted Spinoza and wrote

views source criticism as essentially historical rather than exegetical; the commentator will read and analyze the text in its final form. While Gunkel accepted the premise of the documentary hypothesis, the fact that he was chiefly concerned with the literary form and the *Sitz im Leben* of the narrative transferred the focus of the debate from the question of sources to the narrative's social function. This approach values exploration of the examination of literary links between narratives that are attributed to different sources, as long as they are included in the same literary form. Even if the "matriarch in danger" narratives (Gen 12, 20, and 26) stemmed from different sources, they are still part of the same literary type, and their purpose should be examined accordingly. Recent generations of scholars have been attempting a synchronic reading, while taking into account the conclusions of the diachronic analysis.

The relationship between a synchronic and a diachronic reading is also expressed in the context of the theology of the Abraham narrative. While Yehezkel Kaufmann accepted the documentary hypothesis, he nonetheless believed in a "biblical theology."³² Israel Knohl contested this position, arguing that the acceptance of the documentary hypothesis negates the implementation of a unified biblical theology; rather, the theology of each source should be examined individually.³³ A middle ground was suggested by Brevard Childs, who justified the synchronic reading alongside a diachronic reading in the context of biblical theology. Childs believed the documentary hypothesis is relevant as long as the biblical text is regarded as a mirror of common beliefs and opinions in the ancient world. Nonetheless, the biblical narrative should be analyzed as a unified source, as assumed by the synchronic approach.³⁴

that Moses edited the Bible in the Plains of Moab in the fortieth year; therefore Moses should be viewed as the author of the Pentateuch, even if he relied upon earlier sources. See Lods 1924.

32 Kaufmann 1953.

33 Knohl 2007. For a critique of this study see Kasher 2007.

34 Childs 1992. For an alternate attempt to combine the two positions see Polak 1999, 347–54.

These deliberations have accompanied modern biblical scholarship in the past several years. Due to its nature, the Abraham cycle is one of the narratives at the center of the debate. Documentary hypothesis followers found evidence supporting their position in the double and repetitive texts (the wife-sister narratives, Hagar's separation from the house of Abraham, the tidings of Isaac's birth, etc.), repetitive descriptions in one literary unit (Abraham's journey to Canaan, Lot's rescue from Sodom, etc.), and chronological discrepancies (Ishmael's age at the time of his expulsion). These inconsistencies were interpreted as an indication of a variety of sources (or traditions) at the foundation of the text. Alternatively, the cycle is presented as an organic unit with a coherent sequence, which enables a synchronic reading.³⁵ This position is supported by several elements:

- a. *The literary structure includes the entire narrative cycle:* Various scholars have noted that an elaborate literary structure proves that the cycle cannot be viewed as an incidental combination of various sources.³⁶ Cassuto, for example, argued that the ten tests of Abraham are arranged in a chiastic structure: "The perfected form of this structure does not support the view espoused by most modern exegetes, who regard the text as the accidental product of the combination of a number of fragments from various sources that are cited word for word and joined together by a complicated process of repeated redactions."³⁷ The concentric structure proposed below further reinforces this approach. The links between narratives that were attributed to different sources led Gary Rendsburg to the conclusion that the documentary hypothesis should be

35 See, among others, Blum 1984, 297–339; Rendsburg 1986; Kirkpatrick 1988; Fokkelman 1989; Voges 1996; Whybray 2000, 133–219; Ska 2001. See also Römer 2001, 180–182.

36 Shea (1979) regarding the chiastic structure of the flood narrative; Fokkelman (1999, 80) in the discussion of the chiastic structure of the Joseph narrative, among others.

37 Cassuto 1964, 294.

discarded and replaced by the concept of a single author for the Abraham cycle.³⁸

- b. *Later stories in the cycle rely on information provided in earlier stories:* Various scholars have noted the dialogue between units in the cycle that are generally attributed to different sources. For example, the narrative regarding Sarah in Gerar (20) is based on information delivered in the narrative regarding Sarah in Egypt (12).³⁹
- c. The names Abram-Abraham and Sarai-Sarah are consistent throughout the cycle, in correlation with the sequence of the plot. Abram and Sarai are the only names mentioned before ch. 17, while the remainder of the cycle refers to Abraham and Sarah. The name change is in a narrative attributed to P; nonetheless, the following narrative (18), which is attributed to J, refers to the character by his new name. This is prevalently ascribed to the redaction process.⁴⁰ However, in light of the inconsistency in the references to Jacob/Israel after his name change, Hamilton viewed the consistency in the Abraham cycle as proof of a single author: “It is most unlikely that a final editor made the necessary

38 Rendsburg 1986, 28–29.

39 Many scholars believe the Sarah and Abimelech narrative softens the criticism of Abraham in the Sarah and Pharaoh Narrative (e.g., Van Seters 1975, 167–91; Westermann 1995, 159–68, 316–19; Carr 1996, 23–40; 196–202; Zakovitch and Shinan 1983, 38). Alexander (1992) refuted this reading and claimed that the criticism of Abraham in ch. 20 is not subtler than ch. 12, and viewed ch. 20 as an independent source. While Alexander’s comment regarding the criticism of Abraham in ch. 20 is correct, there is no question that ch. 20 assumes a familiarity of the reader with ch. 12. Similarly, Wenham (1991) viewed the links between the destruction of Sodom and the flood narrative as proof of the lack of validity of the documentary hypothesis. See also a comprehensive discussion by Williamson (2001) regarding the two covenants in chs. 15 and 17 of the Abraham cycle. Many of the abovementioned scholars noted the surprising dialog between chs. 12 and 20, and asserted that here the redactor’s signature is apparent in the creation of the links between the two narratives.

40 E.g., Coogan 2006, 572, among others. Kent (1904, 382) believed that the combination of the two names throughout the cycle proves that the original narratives included two different protagonists, which were combined by the final redactor. His idea proves the required caution in diachronic presumptions based on literary details.

stylistic changes. Any redactor who was not bothered by ‘inconsistencies’ in the Creation or Flood traditions he received, or in the interchange of the names ‘Jacob’ and ‘Israel’, would not feel compelled to smooth out the Abram-Abraham shift.”⁴¹ This position can rely on the fact that God’s names are far from consistent in the narrative; those who attribute the links between the narratives to a final redactor would have to explain why the redactor took pains to unify Abraham’s name in correlation with the plot, but failed to do so with God’s name.

- d. *Continuity*: The Abraham cycle can be read consistently and continuously. Apart from a few exceptions, the narratives report the events of Abraham’s life from his decision to leave his father’s house until the time of his death. The assumption that a redactor organized the units in this way without massive involvement in the writing of the units is not supported by the text; the feeling of continuity that exists in the text is difficult to create after the fact.⁴² As Adar wrote: “The Abraham cycle...is an exemplary story cycle...The narratives are gathered together to weave a comprehensive biography for Abraham, creating the broadest and most comprehensive cycle in the Bible. We are not faced with two or three life events, but rather with a life cycle; the rhythm of the story becomes slower, and the author takes the time to present all angles of Abraham’s character.”⁴³

Alexander’s definition of the story cycle has become broadly accepted by scholars: “However we explain the process of compilation, it is necessary to affirm that the final form of the narrative did not come about by chance; rather it displays the hallmarks of having been produced by a very competent writer.”⁴⁴

41 Hamilton 1990, 32.

42 See Rendtorff 1977.

43 Adar 1979, 80. See also Gelander (2009, 80–86), who noted that despite the fact that the story cycle comprises individual stories, the themes and purpose are only apparent in a study of the cycle as a whole.

44 Alexander 1997, 127.

Post-structuralistic readings of the narrative tend to dismiss diachronic analyses of the text, preferring to consider various inconsistencies as literary devices of either intentional or unintentional nature. One post-structuralism approach argued that the weight of textual analysis should be determined by the reader's reactions rather than the formation of the text. Greenstein, for example, wrote: "In my view it is the proper role of literary study to enable the reader to experience the text thoroughly – not to *explain* the text, but to *expose* it."⁴⁵ A similar approach values the comparison of double narratives and opposing theologies, either as part of an attempt to balance literary elements that promote the broader purpose of the cycle,⁴⁶ or as an attempt to portray the biblical narrative as presenting a complex and diverse worldview.⁴⁷ A third approach demonstrates the literary value of the tensions and discrepancies in the text, which emerge either from the structure of the text or from a careful reading that attributes literary significance to ambiguity.⁴⁸

The analysis in this book will follow a sequential reading of the unified cycle as demonstrated in the suggested structures above. Nonetheless, a sensitive reading cannot ignore the repetitions, discrepancies, and redundancies that exist in the text. The synchronic reading benefits from an awareness of the diachronic reading, and must examine whether the problems that arise from the text in fact contribute to the overall purpose of the text and the story cycle.

45 Greenstein 1982, 116.

46 Zakovitch 1992, 42: "The double narrative has become one of the cornerstones of biblical criticism, various scholars sufficed with attributing the double narratives to different documents. This chapter will demonstrate that the duplication of the narrative is not an editing error, but rather a deliberate style."

47 See Gunn and Fewell 1993, 204–05.

48 For a survey of this debate see Grossman 2006, 170–81.

The Interchangeability of God's Names in the Narrative

One fundamental issue that concerns diachronic readers, and is still considered the essential criterion for attributing texts to assumed sources, is the interchangeability of God's names. However, the changes contribute greatly to a conscientious literary reading that considers the design of the biblical narrative. This debate was researched extensively by modern scholars; the following is merely an outline of the working hypothesis underlying the analysis offered in this book.⁴⁹

While the position that views the interchangeability of God's names as proof of a variety of primary sources was broadly accepted by modern biblical critics, others refuted this claim.⁵⁰ Vetter believed that the context of the narrative sometimes demands the use of one name over another; in such places the use of a particular name cannot be evidence for the source of the text.⁵¹ For example, the name YHWH generally appears only in the context of the Israelite nation and its forefathers; consequently, the name cannot be used in the dialogue between Abraham and Abimelech (ch. 20), and the use of the name Elohim is contextual and does not indicate the identity of an

49 See also Blum 2008; Baumgart 2008; Otto 2009; Kalumba 2009; Van den Berg 2012. Concerning the phrase 'YHWH Elohim', see Mafico 1996; Freedman 2008; Harvey 2011.

50 See the comprehensive discussion in Cassuto 1989, 7–18, and recently: Polak 2012. Compare with Otto: „Diese Erklärungsversuche scheitern daran, dass sie keine Antwort darauf geben, warum die Gottesnamen zwischen Gen 1 und Gen 2–3 im Zuge des Redaktionsprozesses nicht ausgeglichen wurden, also JHWH auch in Gen 1 eingefügt oder in Gen 2–3 gestrichen wurde, handelt es sich doch keineswegs um eine theologische Beiläufigkeit, wie der Gott bezeichnet wird, auf den die Schöpfung der Welt als Eröffnung des Pentateuch zurückgeführt wurde. Auch die neuere Einsicht, dass Gen 1 und Gen 2–3 derart literarisch aufeinander bezogen sind, dass Gen 2,4–3,24 literarisch postpriesterschriftliche Interpretation von Gen 1,1–2,3 ist, steht vor dem Problem, den Wechsel der Gottesnamen erklären zu müssen.“ (Otto 2009, 60).

51 Vetter 1903.

earlier source.⁵² Vetter was one of the first modern scholars to attribute literary significance to God's names.⁵³ It is noteworthy that the interchangeability of God's names is also found outside the Pentateuch, in the books of Joshua, Judges, Samuel, Kings, Chronicles, Jonah, in the frame narrative of Job, and in Daniel 1. The name used to describe God in specific biblical narratives was selected according to the content and atmosphere of the text. This assumption is broadly accepted in reference to unique names such as El Shaddai; there is no reason to deny a similar conclusion regarding the literary contribution of the more common names Elohim and YHWH.⁵⁴

Scholars generally agree that the interchangeability of characters' titles in the text has literary significance.⁵⁵ One narrative will often refer to a character by several titles, which reflect various perspectives in the narrative: Sarai in Gen 12 is sometimes referred to by name, sometimes as the "wife"; Lot in ch. 14 is generally referred to as Lot, but also as Abraham's "brother" or "kin"; Hagar is referred to by name throughout the text, but also by her title as a "maidservant" or "slave"; the angels who visit Abraham and Lot are referred to both as "people" and "angels"; Ishmael in ch. 21 is the "son" of Abraham, the "son" of the maidservant, the "boy" and the "child"; Abraham's servant in ch. 24 is referred to as the "servant" and the "man"; and so forth. These changes are viewed as part of the figurative design of the narrative, which contributes to the reading process and develops the purpose of the narrative. While these changes relate to titles and not to names, the Jacob narratives will introduce interchangeability in the names Jacob/

52 This idea is discussed in further detail by Šanda 1924, 24–30.

53 Vetter (1903) noted phrases that integrate a specific name (such as "fear of Elohim"), and theorized that Elohim represents a metaphysical deity, whereas YHWH represents God's involvement in history. He also noted that both legal and prophetic formulations use the name YHWH. Heinisch, Metzger, Waltz, and others adopted this position. See Cassuto 1989, 14–16.

54 Kaufmann 1953, 131–32.

55 E.g., Leibowitz 1973, 99–104; Sternberg 1977; Alter 1981, 182–84; Weiss 1987, 303–06; Gelander 1997, 52–55; Polak 1999, 329–30. The idea is prevalent outside biblical literature as well. See Uspensky 1973, 20–32.

Israel.⁵⁶ However, the abovementioned names for God might also be viewed as titles instead of names. YHWH is used as a personal name, while Elohim is essentially a title describing divine power.⁵⁷ Syntactically the title functions as a common noun, even when the name is integrated into the text as a proper noun. This is evident from the inflections of the noun and the use of the definite article (e.g., Gen 17:18; 20:6 and 17; 22:3 and 9).⁵⁸ Additionally, the name Elohim often functions as an adjective as well as a noun (e.g., Gen 24:3).⁵⁹ Therefore, the interchangeability of God's titles is no different from the changing titles of biblical characters, which are sometimes referred to by name and at others by various descriptive titles.

The following analysis of the text relies on the connotations suggested by Cassuto, while focusing on one essential distinction between the names:

If this were the case, naturally an Israelite author...would occasionally, based on the situation, spontaneously be drawn toward using one of the two names YHWH and Elohim...the name YHWH – when presenting the personal image of the divine, and relating to the direct relationship of the divine with humanity and nature; and the name Elohim – when presenting the divine as transcendental to all creatures.⁶⁰

In his discussion of the unique anthropomorphism reflected in the book of Genesis, Gunkel noted the integration of the name YHWH in the following narratives:

56 Scholars debate whether the interchangeability of the names Jacob and Israel should be attributed to different sources, or whether they serve a literary purpose. See Cassuto 1965, 718–19. See also Weisman 1986, 50–51 (regarding the repetition of reasons for naming). In the Greek and Roman eras a double naming is a common phenomenon (Horsley, Double Name), and might have been in the biblical era as well.

57 Cross, “*el*.”

58 Precisely noted by Judah Halevi in the fourth essay of *The Kuzari*.

59 See comprehensive discussion by Baumgärtel (1914). Baumgärtel examined the appearances of God's name outside the Pentateuch, and concluded that the name Elohim is usually used as a general noun. His study did not relate to the names of God in the Pentateuch.

60 Cassuto 1989, 32.

God walks in Paradise, forms people with his own hands, and closes the doors of the Ark (7:16). Indeed, he breathes something of his own breath into the man and he makes failed attempts with the animals (2:19–20). He smells Noah's sacrifice (8:21). He appears to Abraham and Lot in the form of a traveler (Gen 18–19), or the angel calls from heaven (22:11). God appears to Abraham once in his true form as a burning torch and a smoking firepot (15:17)!⁶¹

Instead of relating the integration of the name to the theological perceptions of J, the reference to YHWH could be viewed in correlation with the narrative materials and atmosphere. A sensitive synchronic reading considers the discrepancies and contradictions presented by the diachronic approach. An avid reader of the text should seek the meaning of the integration of two narratives or the purpose of repetition; a keen reader should pursue the commutative context and the reading experience, rather than the historical aspects of the formation of the text. By doing so, the reader will discover that the name YHWH is integrated into narratives with a personal atmosphere that promotes and rewards ethical behavior, while the name Elohim is used in narratives that promote the fulfillment of historical commitments.

The Abraham Cycle as a Cohesive Unit

Regardless of whether the narrative in question stems from a single source or from multiple sources, it can be assumed that Abraham's stories were known in Israelite culture before the formation of the narrative cycle:

Based on the biblical text it is clear that traditions about Abraham and his family existed outside of the Genesis narrative. Prevalent oral traditions certainly included the story of Terah and his emigration from Ur of the Chaldeans to Haran, Haran father of Lot, Milcah and Iscah, Damascus Eliezer and his relationship with Abraham, the wells he dug, etc.⁶²

61 Gunkel 1997, x.

62 Cassuto 1950, 62.

Therefore, the narratives included in the cycle were selected to serve a specific purpose. The conscious choice to include certain stories and omit others emphasizes the purpose of the selection through the narratives.⁶³ The definition of a collection of stories as a “story cycle” necessitates two basic assumptions: (a) the units that create the cycle are independent literary units; and (b) the units can nonetheless be viewed as part of a continuous plot. While the central component that creates internal cohesion in the Abraham cycle is the protagonist, major themes can be followed throughout the cycle, such as God’s promise of land and offspring, and Sarah’s barrenness. Unique thematic, literary, and ideological characteristics seem to differentiate this cycle from the Jacob or Joseph narratives. However, the common approach in biblical criticism, which divides the narratives based on their primary sources, fails to emphasize the distinction between story cycles, focusing instead on the continuous story of each individual source. The sequence of such a story may begin in the pre-historical narratives in Genesis and culminate in the end of the book and beyond. According to this approach, literary and theological distinctiveness can be detected in a source sequence, but not in a story cycle. This approach was reinforced by Gunkel’s form criticism, since the Abraham cycle includes various traditions with unique characteristics that have thematic and literary links to units in other story cycles. In light of this approach each unit should be analyzed individually.

Rendtorff and Weisman, among others, refuted this approach, and argued that story cycles contain unique characteristics of their own, which are expressed in such elements as the essential challenges presented by the narratives, the geographical locations, the nations involved, and so forth.⁶⁴ Vogels followed God’s promises of land and offspring throughout the story cycle, and concluded that they are designed in a recurring methodical fashion. He believed the

63 See Zakovitch and Shinan 2004.

64 Rendtorff 1977; Weisman 1986.

theme of these promises unifies the story cycle;⁶⁵ therefore, “instead of sufficing with an emphasis on the difficulties, contradictions, and deviations in the text, we should be impressed by the brilliance of the author or redactor, who delivered the fabulous and artistic story of the Abraham cycle.”⁶⁶

Rendtorff believed that the classic documentary hypothesis can no longer contribute to the clarification of the Pentateuch’s development.⁶⁷ As an alternative he suggested a division of the Pentateuch (and the book of Joshua) into six independent units: Early History; Patriarchal History; the Exodus; the Sinai Narratives; Travels through the Wilderness; and the Settlement of Canaan. Rendtorff’s position was founded on the claim that there is no real correlation between the literary units. The patriarch narratives are not reminiscent of the initial narratives in Gen 1–11,⁶⁸ and the Exodus narrative is independent of the patriarch narratives. While this theory is questionable,⁶⁹ Rendtorff’s position enables an independent discussion of each literary unit. This approach was reinforced by Blum, who claimed, based on Rendtorff, that the patriarchal narratives possess a “literary independence” that is distinguished from other Pentateuch narratives.⁷⁰ This position, which examines the patriarch narratives, and specifically the

65 Vogels (1996, 31) associated the unit 15:1–18:16 solely with the promise of offspring, while the Covenant between the Pieces is explicitly focused on the promise of land.

66 Vogels 1996, 348.

67 Rendtorff 1977, 148.

68 Wénin (1996 and 1999) viewed ch. 12 as based on the creation narrative, and particularly on the Garden of Eden; however, as Römer (2001, 182) noted, the integration of the verb **יָדָע** in Gen 12:11 cannot be viewed as a deliberate link to the tree of knowledge, since the verb is used broadly.

69 Many similar links will be suggested throughout the text. In contrast with Rendtorff, Cassuto (1992, 303–306) claimed that the principle “the events of the patriarchs are signs for their descendants” is one of the cornerstones of the patriarchal narratives, and particularly of the Abraham cycle. See also Hamilton 1990, 26–27.

70 Blum 1984. He claimed that the Abraham cycle originated in the stories about Abraham and Lot (13, 18–19), which was then joined by additional independent narratives, and the cycle was joined to the existing Jacob narrative.

Abraham narrative, as independent units, is reinforced by the unified literary structure of the Abraham cycle.

Redaction as Interpretation of the Text

The redaction process, which creates a new context for the individual narrative, often adds new meaning to individual narratives.⁷¹ Similarly, the joining of two literary units can create an understanding that could not have existed in the individual units.⁷² Adding keywords and captions affects the reading experience and the purpose of the narrative. Since the Abraham cycle comprises several individual literary units, redaction serves an important role in adding curiosity, tension, and anticipation to the sequence, while emphasizing the purpose of the narrative as a whole. The analysis in this book will emphasize the unique role of redaction in the Abraham cycle, which necessitates an awareness of the structure of the cycle.

The Narrative and Artistic Structure of the Abraham Cycle

Two links are apparent between the stories tracking Abraham's life: one can be described as a "chain link," which creates continuity between the smaller units, while the other links the stories through a more complex overall structure. The chain link emphasizes that each individual story relates to the surrounding units. For example, Lot's settlement in Sodom (Gen 13) is the necessary background for his captivity (14); despite the diverse themes between the War of the Kings (14) and the

71 See, among others, Zakovitch 1992, 35–41; 50–71.

72 For example: Grossman 2007 – "Divine Command."

Covenant between the Pieces (15), the stories are linked by the fabric of the language, as well as the caption of ch. 15: “Some time later”; the motifs of suffering and liberation, which are so prominent in the Covenant between the Pieces (15), reappear in the following Hagar narrative (16). The angels’ visit to Abraham (Gen 18) opens with a verse that fails to introduce Abraham by name: “The Lord appeared to *him* by the terebinths of Mamre; *he* was sitting at the entrance of the tent,” relying on the previous narrative for this crucial information; the narrative relating the story of Sarah in the house of Abimelech ends with the resolution of the temporary infertility that afflicted the women of Gerar because of Sarah (20), while the following narrative resolves Sarah’s infertility (21), and so forth. These links will be discussed throughout the analysis of the text.

The general literary structure of the cycle includes two perspectives: the plot, and the artistic or creative structure. The narrative element that unites the cycle is God’s promises, which accompany Abraham throughout the narratives, along with Sarah’s infertility, which is a constant hindrance to the fulfillment of those promises. The cycle includes six narratives about God’s promise to Abraham: three promises/blessings (in Ur of the Chaldeans, Shechem, and Bethel), followed by two covenants between God and Abraham, in which he was promised the land and offspring (the Covenant between the Pieces and the Covenant of Circumcision), and God’s oath in the binding of Isaac. The other narratives between these revelations clarify the fulfillment (or lack of fulfillment) of the promises; therefore, the promises link the entire cycle. The question at the heart of the cycle is whether God will fulfill his promises of land and offspring to Abraham, and in what way.⁷³

Despite the obvious nationalistic tone of these themes, the narrative is presented as the elaboration of “the line of Terah” (11:27). As many have noted, the basic internal division of the book of Genesis is based on the genealogical “lines” described therein.⁷⁴ According to this

73 See among others Wenham 1987, 259–62; Vogels 1996.

74 E.g., Keil & Delitzsch 1980, 35–37; Alexander 1982, 255–58; Thompson 1987, 167–72; Carr 1998; Koch 1999.

division, the Abraham narrative is presented to the reader as part of Terah's genealogy: Terah had twelve grandsons by Nahor (22:20–24) and two nations by Haran, through Lot (19:30–38). However, Abraham's line is more complex: his wife Sarai was barren, and in addition to her infertility she was twice taken from Abraham by foreign kings; the alternative heirs – Lot and Ishmael – become irrelevant due to their separation from Abraham; and even Isaac, Abraham's true heir, was almost sacrificed to God. Despite these trials and tribulations, Abraham, too, contributed to the genealogy of Terah through Isaac, who survived to be his father's heir and maintain God's covenant with Abraham.⁷⁵

Presenting Terah's line as the general theme of the narrative highlights the underlying tension of the narrative: Abraham is required to disengage from his family (12:1–3), a fact that emphasizes the exclusionary approach that is also expressed in the purchase of the Machpelah cave and finding a wife for Isaac in the appendix of the narrative cycle.⁷⁶ On the other hand, Abraham marries his son to a member of his family, a practice that will later be adopted by his grandson as well. Arguably, despite Abraham's disengagement from his family, the approach of the text is not exclusionary. On the contrary, alongside the demand to separate from his family Abraham is told that his blessings will affect all “the families of the land” (12:3); in the Covenant of Circumcision Abraham is informed that God will make him “the father of a multitude of nations” (17:5).⁷⁷ The fact that the context of

75 This is apparent in the frame of the cycle, which opens with the genealogy of Abraham and ends with the genealogy of Nahor. See discussion below regarding the artistic structure of the narrative.

76 The idea of isolationism is emphasized in various studies on the Abraham Narrative: see Machinist 1994; Malul 2002; Gelernder 2009, 371–72. As stated above, while some elements of the narrative encourage this reading, the narrative also includes elements to the contrary, and the isolationism approach is balanced with a universal approach.

77 Simon emphasized: “Abraham is not the father of mankind, but the father of a nation; in contrast with Adam and Eve, Abraham was not created by God, but rather selected by God. The significance of this fact is that Abraham's choice is not genetic; it is designated” (Simon 2002, 42).

the stories of Abraham is the line of Terah proves that the approach of the text is integrative, despite the commandments that distinguish Abraham and temporarily separate him from his family.

The literary form of a narrative often hints to the nature of its content. Various scholars have attempted to arrange the Abraham cycle into a chiasmic or concentric structure, differing in their treatment of specific elements of the narrative. A common approach views the design of the cycle as two halves surrounding the narrative about the flight of Hagar and the birth of Ishmael (ch. 16). The structure below was suggested by Crotty:⁷⁸

- A.** Terah's genealogy (11:27–32)
 - B.** Abram and his barren wife Sarai depart from Harran: “Go forth” (12:1–9)
 - C.** Sarai in danger in Egypt (12:10–13:4)
 - D.** Lot's separation from Abram (13:5–18) and Lot's rescue from captivity (14)
 - E.** A covenant of sacrifice (15)
 - F.** Ishmael's birth and expulsion of Hagar (16)
 - E₁.** A covenant of sacrifice (17)
 - D₁.** The Abraham and Lot saga – continued (18–19)
 - C₁.** Sarah in danger in Gerar (20)
 - B₁.** The birth and binding of Isaac: “Go forth” (21–22) [including the expulsion of Ishmael and pact with Abimelech (21)]; Nahor's genealogy (22:20–24); the death and burial of Sarah (23); the marriage of Isaac (24)
 - A₁.** Abraham's death and genealogy (25)

While additional suggestions were made regarding the details of the structure, many scholars agreed that the expulsion of Hagar (16) is the center of the narrative cycle,⁷⁹ surrounded by the two covenants

⁷⁸ Crotty 2005, 36.

⁷⁹ E.g., Alexander 1982, 24, 26; Magonet 1992, 29; Wenham 1994, 263; Mathews 2005, 90; Yuval 2006. Römer (2001, 179–80), who did not attribute a concentric structure to the story cycle, nonetheless claimed that the flight of Hagar is a central narrative, surrounded by narratives that are designed concentrically: 15/17; 13/18–19. Like Crotty, Römer ended the cycle in chapter 25. Coats (1983, 97–98) suggested a concentric structure that centers on the covenants (15–17).

between God and Abraham: the Covenant between the Pieces (15) and the Covenant of Circumcision (17). Cotter viewed the centrality of the Hagar narrative as the moral theology of the cycle:

This chapter, then, when read from this perspective, teaches us what is central to God's way of being in the world...Central to God's way of being in the world is salvation – creating a place for Hagar, the alien, the homeless woman – for central to God's way of being in the world is justice. The God who commanded it later...could not have acted otherwise from the very beginning.⁸⁰

However, considering the fact that Ishmael was ultimately rejected from maintaining the covenant, the birth of Ishmael seems an unlikely focus for the structure, as Goldingay asserted.⁸¹ As a concentric structure assumes that the Abraham cycle has two parts, one crucial difference between them is the name change of the protagonist (and his wife) in ch. 17, which indicates an essential division into two parts: while the first part describes the events of the life of Abram and Sarai, the second focuses on the life of Abraham and Sarah.⁸² Therefore, the central axis of the cycle should focus on the name change in the Covenant of Circumcision (Gen 17), as illustrated below.⁸³ Furthermore,

80 Cotter 2003, 87. Yuval (2006, 175–78) suggested that the centrality of the story stems from the fact that from this point forward Abraham is no longer childless.

81 Magonet dubbed the phenomenon a “false climax”; however, this is unlikely, as Goldingay noted: “The difficulty with it is that it is too unequivocal. Can the center of a chiasm be a false climax?” (Goldingay 1998, 147; See also Williamson 2000, 19). In this case I agree with Goldingay, but on a methodological level, there are certainly structures which are designed in order to mislead the reader. See Grossman 2011 – *Esther*, 119–123.

82 A name in the biblical narrative is symbolic of the nature of the character, and often of the situation in which the name was given (See, among others, Dvir 1969; Heinemann 1954, 110–11; Garsiel 1991, 16–19).

83 Dorsey 1999, 56. Westermann (1985, 128–29) previously indicates a similar structure. Walsh (2001, 89–90) suggested a chiastic structure that centers on the promise of children: to Abram (ch. 15) and Hagar (ch. 16) and to Abraham (ch. 17) and Sarah (ch. 18). Compare with Rendsburg 1986, 41–45). Radday (1981, 104–05) suggested a more complex chiastic structure, which centers on Hagar's flight (16) and the Covenant of Circumcision (17), surrounded by the Covenant between the Pieces (15), which parallels the tidings of Isaac's birth in ch. 18.

biblical circumcision narratives are integrated into other dramatic crossroads for a given protagonist, as Goldingay wrote: “The act of circumcision in Exodus 4 is a rite of passage: Moses, Zipporah and their son(s) are on the way from Midian to Egypt, as Jacob had been on the way back from Syria to Israel. The same is true of the act of circumcision in Joshua 5.”⁸⁴

I believe the following structure is a more accurate reflection of the cycle structure:

- A.** The line of Terah: Abram, Nahor, and Haran (11:27–32).
- B.** Abram’s separation from his father’s house: “Go forth...to the land” (11:27–32).
- C.** Abram journeys through the land and invokes the name of God (12:1–5).
- D.** Abram’s separation from family members: Sarah is taken by Pharaoh, but returned to Abram (12:10–20); Lot departs for Sodom and does not return (13:1–18).
- E.** Lot is rescued from captivity (14:1–24).
- F.** The promise of offspring and land (15:1–21). Abram complains (15:2: “what can You give me”) and the word *zedaka* (“righteousness”) is used in the context of his belief in God (15:6).⁸⁵
- G.** The angel’s tidings to Hagar regarding the birth of Ishmael (16:1–16).
- H.** The Covenant of Circumcision: Abram and Sarai’s names are changed (17:1–27).
- G₁.** The angel’s tidings to Sarah regarding the birth of Isaac (18:1–15).⁸⁶
- F₁.** Debate over the destruction of the land (18:16–33). Abraham complains (18:25: “Far be it from You to do such a thing!”) and the word *zedaka* is used in

84 Goldingay 2000, 13.

85 The analysis of this narrative will clarify why the tidings of offspring (15:1–6) and the tidings of land (15:7–21) should be viewed as one story that includes two separate units.

86 The analysis of ch. 18 will demonstrate that this message is intended for Sarah (and not Abraham).

the context of God's decision to reveal his plan to Abraham (18:19).⁸⁷

E₁. Lot is rescued from the destruction of Sodom (19:1–37).

D₁. Abraham's separation from family members: Sarah is taken by Abimelech but returned to Abraham (20:1–18); Ishmael is expelled to the desert of Paran, and does not return (21:1–21).⁸⁸

C₁. The covenant of Abraham and Abimelech: Abraham invokes the name of God (21:22–34).⁸⁹

B₁. Abraham's separation from his son: "Go forth to the land of Moriah" (22:1–19).

A₁. The line of Nahor (22:20–24).

Transitional Narratives and Conclusion: Sarah's burial and purchasing the cave of Machpelah (23); finding a wife for Isaac (24); conclusion of Abraham's life and the burial of Abraham (25:1–11); [the line of Ishmael (25:12–18)].

As Dorsey noted, at times literary structures are based on captions that are forced on the text, and do not necessarily stem from the text.⁹⁰ Some of the captions suggested above are debatable, as are the borders of individual units. Additionally, the order of a story cycle is influenced by extra factors such as general correlation with the chronology and development of the character; therefore a solid literary structure that one might find in an individual unit is unlikely to be found in a cycle. Despite these disadvantages, the structure contributes to the clarification of the stories in the cycle by following the sequence

87 The term זְדָאָה (*zedaka*) is mentioned only in chs. 15 and 18 throughout the story cycle. The borders of the unit depicting Abraham's argument with God over the destruction of Sodom are complex; v. 18:16, which prefaces the argument with the conclusion of Abraham's hospitality, deliberately links the episode of Abraham's hospitality with the destruction of Sodom.

88 The reason behind the inclusion of the two parts of the narrative (the birth of Isaac and the expulsion of Ishmael) in one literary unit is discussed in the analysis of ch. 21.

89 The analysis of these narratives will demonstrate that by journeying through the land and by creating a pact with Abimelech, Abraham in fact assumes ownership of the land.

90 Dorsey 1999, 33–34.

of the protagonist's life and indicating the thematic links between the various sections. The significance of the structure will be discussed in detail in the conclusion, but one detail should be clarified at the outset. According to the suggested structure the episodes describing Abram and Sarai in Egypt (Gen 12) and Abram's separation from Lot (13) are included in the same caption (d), paralleled by Abraham and Sarah in Gerar (20) and the birth of Isaac/expulsion of Ishmael (21), which are also included under one caption (d1). While the design of the narrative links the two episodes of Abram's separation from Lot and Sarai,⁹¹ the links between the Gerar narrative and the expulsion of Ishmael are not as apparent. Nonetheless, in the analysis of the cycle the two pairs could easily be viewed as part of the ongoing theme of Abraham's separation from members of his family. Sarah's captivity by foreign kings poses a real danger to the fulfillment of God's promise of a son to Abraham and Sarah. Abraham's separation from Lot and Ishmael dismisses these viable options as an alternative for an inheritance by a son; Abraham's nephew Lot could have succeeded Abraham in the event that Sarah could not bear a child, but chose to separate from Abraham; and Ishmael – Abraham's biological child – could certainly be viewed as an heir had he not been expelled from Abraham's home. The order of the cycle creates a reading sequence that is not apparent in each separate unit, and the two sections should be viewed as "separation stories" with a similar conclusion: Sarah is returned to Abraham on both occasions, and the alternative heir does not return, making way for Isaac as Abraham's sole heir. The link between the Gerar narrative (20) and the binding of Isaac/expulsion of Ishmael (21) is supported by the fact that after the expulsion of Ishmael the narrative reviews the relationship between Abraham and Abimelech (the pact in Beer-sheba, 21:22–34). This episode is a direct extension of the Gerar narrative; Abimelech asks Abraham for fairness in return for his kind treatment

91 I prefer this link to Alexander's suggestion (Alexander 1982, 24), which linked Abram's separation from Lot (Gen 13) to Lot's captivity (Gen 14). While the connection between Lot's decision to settle in Sodom and his captivity is obvious, Lot's decision is linked with the episode in Egypt rather than the war that led to Lot's captivity.

of Abraham in Gerar (21:23). The expulsion of Ishmael is placed in the context of Abraham's relationship with Abimelech, deliberately linking Abraham's separation from Ishmael (21) to his separation from Sarah in Gerar (20).

The transitional narratives and conclusions (the deaths of Abraham and Sarah and the appointment of their successors Isaac and Rebekah), which do not focus on Abraham himself but upon the next generation, remain outside the literary structure, and are not paralleled in its first part. Moreover, these stories lack one of the major characteristics of the cycle, namely, God's involvement. According to various literary parameters the binding of Isaac is the climax of the entire narrative, and God's promise to Abraham concludes the theme of blessings and promises throughout the cycle.⁹² The concluding narratives are "transitional narratives",⁹³ or according to Coats, "Death reports."⁹⁴ The founding generation makes way for the next generation; the unit begins with Sarah's death and ends with the death of Abraham, and between the two deaths the narrative describes the quest for Sarah's replacement and the marriage of the successors. As they are not concerned with our protagonist, but rather with his descendants, a discussion of these episodes remains outside the scope of this study.⁹⁵

The Context of the Narrative Cycle

The cycle opens with a report of Terah's genealogy (A) and culminates with a review of Nahor's line (A₁). The reader is therefore drawn into

92 Bergen 1990.

93 Rendsburg 1986, 50–51.

94 Coats (1983, 28) includes 22:20–25:26. See also: von Rad 1963, 241; Davidson 1979, 98. Coats also surveyed the structure of the story cycle according to the text attributed to P (105) and to J (106–107). His efforts did not lead to a cohesive artistic structure.

95 See also Sutherland 1983, and the discussion of Byron Wheaton regarding chapters 23–25 (Wheaton 2006).

the plot from the perspective of Abraham's past, his father's family, which he will ultimately reconnect with when creating his future, since Abraham's son will marry a woman from the family of Nahor. Terah's son disengaged from his land and the house of his father and went to Canaan (A), while a daughter of the line of Nahor disengaged from her land and family to marry into Abraham's family in Canaan (A₁). The cycle is framed by Abraham's dichotomous relationship with his family, which emphasizes the consistent tension between the universal and separatist approaches expressed in the text. The theme of God's promises emphasizes the separation of Abraham's future nation from his surroundings, while the frame of the cycle accentuates the relationship between Abraham and his family. While God unequivocally commands Abraham to disengage from his family, Abraham ultimately reconnects with his family through the marriage of his son (see further below, in my discussion of family and nationalism).

In addition to the contribution of linking the individual literary units, the structure attests to the unity of the story cycle. The creation of such a solid elaborate structure for such a complex unit proves the cohesion of the Abraham narrative cycle.

Family and Nationality

The story of Abraham also marks the beginning of the story of the nation of Israel. A unique worldview of nationalism is reflected throughout his narrative cycle, touching upon questions already raised with the birth of classical political philosophy, but which gathered momentum in modern political science.⁹⁶ Despite the fundamental difference between the biblical notion of a nation and the modern concept of nationalism, which I will shortly discuss, the Abraham

96 See, for example, the collection of articles in: Hutchinson and Smith 1994, and the survey of Malach 2009, 15–98.

Cycle presents a view of nationalism that harmonizes elements which modern discourse generally perceives as conflicting.

I wish to begin by addressing a basic question pertaining to the definition of a nation: should a nation be defined “politically” – that is, national-political cooperation is what renders a group of people into a nation – or “culturally” – according to common cultural factors? Hans Kohn already proposed a division between political nationalism as the product of civil society, and cultural-ethnic nationalism; and even evaluated that the former is rational, humane nationalism, associated with Western Europe, while the latter form of nationalism is romantic and anti-rational, prevalent in East Europe, notably Germany.⁹⁷ Many in his wake adopted this division, either explicitly or covertly, to the point of establishing that an entity may be defined as a nation from a “political” point of view, or from a “cultural” perspective.⁹⁸

In modern political science, this question is accompanied by another debate:⁹⁹ is a “nation” the product of a human decision, of a group of people’s declaration that they wish to govern their lives together for a common purpose, either pragmatic or ethical, or should this concept be perceived as a framework imposed upon human society, one that people are involuntarily born into?

Notable members of the former approach are Thomas Hobbes, John Locke and Jean Jacques Rousseau. Despite their differences of opinion, they agree that the nation and state are founded upon its members’ free, voluntary union.¹⁰⁰ Locke, for example (1632–1704),

97 Kohn 1944, 329–331.

98 According to Meinecke. See also Smith’s discussion in Smith 2000, 22–23. Smith is a leading advocate of the fusion of ethnic nationalism in the ancient world and modern nationalism. He himself coined this school of thought “the ethno-symbolic approach” (Smith 2000, chapter 3). Concerning this division and the problems it poses, see also: Seymour et al, 1996.

99 In a certain sense, there is a connection between the two issues, and indeed, some have drawn this connection, such as Malachi 2009.

100 Many scholars use “nation” and “state” interchangeably, even though Connor is correct in stating that more room should be given to ethnic identification within the study of nationalism, and nationalism should not be identified with the state. He opposes Carl Deutsch and the school of “Nation-Building” (Connor 1972).

argues that a person's natural state is one of freedom to do as he wishes, and that he has "natural rights" (these assumptions challenge Hobbes' beliefs), but he freely chooses to forfeit these rights in order to form a single community:

Men being, as has been said, by nature, all free, equal, and independent, no one can be put out of this estate, and subjected to the political power of another, without his own consent. The only way whereby any one divests himself of his natural liberty, and puts on the bonds of civil society, is by agreeing with other men to join and unite into a community for their comfortable, safe, and peaceable living one amongst another, in a secure enjoyment of their properties, and a greater security against any, that are not of it. ... For when any number of men have, by the consent of every individual, made a community, they have thereby made that community one body.¹⁰¹

The individual's choice to forfeit his natural rights and hand them over to a greater entity stems from the unremitting, inevitable fears and dangers integral to the most basic form of freedom.¹⁰²

Proponents of the social contract theory are usually associated with the concept of a "nation state" whose members come together for the sake of a more convenient lifestyle. Essentially, however, the matter is more complicated; the philosophy of Rousseau (1712–1778), for example, illustrates this complexity. On one hand, he is the most salient advocate of the social contract theory, which is based on the individuals' free consent to form a political body. His work, *The Social Contract* (published in 1762) is entirely based on the notion of "the general will" as a fundamental basis for a legitimate political community and government. However, Rousseau is not merely concerned with a technical declaration of a way of life: "Unlike Hobbes and Locke, who justified the social contract through its regulation of existing interests, Rousseau holds that the citizens who sign the contract undergo an immediate process of change and generate a new form of society – a 'moral collective body, composed of as many members as there are votes in the assembly.'" ¹⁰³ Rousseau believes that the decision to

101 J. Locke, *Two Treatises of Government*, beginning of chapter VIII.

102 *Two Treatises of Government*, beginning of chapter IX.

103 Hoffman 2006, 23–24.

become a member of a political group is a triumph of the collective good over the individual's narrow personal interests, and therefore, despite the fact that a state's existence depends on its citizens' free will, it should not be considered a mere facilitator of technical needs:

This passage from the state of nature to the civil state produces a very remarkable change in man: the role that instinct used to play in his conduct is now taken over by a sense of justice, and his actions now have a moral aspect that they formerly lacked. The voice of duty has taken over from physical impulses and a sense of what is right has taken over from appetite; and now – only now – the man who has until now considered only himself finds himself forced to act on different principles and to consult his reason before listening to his inclinations. In this 'civil' state he is deprived of many advantages that he got from nature, but he gets enormous benefits in return – his faculties are so stimulated and developed, his ideas are extended, his feelings ennobled, and his whole soul uplifted. All this happens to such an extent that if the abuses of this new condition didn't often pull him down to something lower than he was in the state of nature, he would be bound to bless continually the happy moment that took him from it forever, and out of a dull and limited animal made a thinking being, a man.¹⁰⁴

As Smith shows, although Rousseau emphasized that consent is the fundamental basis of a nation, he also perceived a nation as a naturally occurring entity, and in several places he relates to various traits that characterize different nations.¹⁰⁵ Therefore, Rousseau also saw importance in allowing each nation the independence to express its cultural nature: "The first rule that we must follow is that of national character. Every people has, or must have, a character; if it lacks one, we must begin by endowing it with one".¹⁰⁶

We will explore the attempt to reconcile the notion that a nation has distinguishing traits with the idea that a nation is founded upon free will when we discuss the biblical model.

There are many other proponents of the approach that a nation is the product of its citizens' free will; some, like Rousseau, propose

104 Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract* (Jonathan Bennett edition, 2010), book 1, Chapter 8, p. 9.

105 Smith 2000, 8–9.

106 Quoted in: Smith 2000, 8.

intriguing analyses of these nations.¹⁰⁷ In this context, I wish to mention Ernest Renan (1823–1892), whose famous 1882 essay, “What is a Nation?” is considered a classic example of the voluntary approach in political thought. Renan opposed the racial criterion of defining a nation, claiming that many dominant nations, such as Britain, France, and Italy, are ethnically diverse. Renan also devoted a separate essay to the subject of Jewish nationalism, claiming that it is also problematic to claim common ethnicity in the context of the Hebrew nation, as in his opinion, many joined the Jewish nation over the generations. The problem with equating ethnicity with nationality, Renan argued, is not only technical; a nation should not be considered “natural” from a cultural or linguistic perspective. He opposes the approach that a nation is a collection of individuals who have gathered merely for the sake of common interests, but he does emphasize that “A nation’s existence is, if you will pardon the metaphor, a daily plebiscite, just as an individual’s existence is a perpetual affirmation of life.”¹⁰⁸ Indeed, those who object to any natural definitions of nationalism usually base their theory upon the unceasing consent of the individuals who comprise a nation.

In contrast to this approach, some perceive the formation of a nation as a natural trait of human society. Rousseau’s contemporary, Johann Gottfried Herder (1744–1803) claimed that cultural diversity is a fundamental human characteristic. He argued that the variety of human cultures in areas of different climates and other natural conditions result from the divine intention that humanity will not be uniform, but will fulfill the wide range of possibilities encoded within it. Every nation expresses a unique culture, and it is morally bound to

107 For example, John Stuart Mill (1806–1873) claimed that the definitive basis of a nation is the sense of solidarity and brotherhood that generates desire for political union. He emphasized that consciousness of a common past is a central factor in national unity. However, he does not perceive nationalism as an objective unto itself, or a supreme value, nor does he consider a nation a natural form of human existence, but rather something acquired (see further: Malach 2009, 17–18).

108 For a discussion of this statement, see: Smith 2000, 26–27; Malach 2009, 19–20.

do so.¹⁰⁹ Herder explicitly referred to language as the central means of national expression, claiming that each language determines the speakers' form of thought, and thus every person becomes a product of the nation he or she belongs to.¹¹⁰

Johann Gottlieb Fichte (1762–1814) also claimed that a person's affiliation with his nation is natural, and not merely the result of social consent. In Herder's wake, he underscored that each nation must prudently preserve the purity of its own language, and preached that the German nation must zealously prevent the German language from becoming contaminated with foreign words, particularly those of Latin or French origins, because such words reflect the corrupt world of the Romans.¹¹¹ According to Fichte, not only does a nation's defining language demand that it preserve its culture; its language is what grants a nation the privilege of its own state, in order to freely express its culture and maintain its own language.¹¹² These theories clearly reflect the connection between the two aforementioned issues: that a nation is "natural," and that this is fundamentally related to the perception of the nation as a "nation of culture," as a community with its own unique way of life.

Nowadays, the inherent danger of extreme nationalism is infamous, and in the wake of the trauma of the twentieth century's wars, many perceive nationalism as contradictory to liberal thinking. This danger was already manifest in the philosophy of Heinrich von Treitschke (1834–1896), who developed the idea of political nationalism in violent, anti-Semitic directions. For the sake of this discussion, it is important to mention his claim that a nation's power is a supreme, even sacred, value; that war is an expression of the participating nations'

109 See: Kedourie 1993, 4; Malach 2009, 8–10.

110 Kedourie 1993, chapter 5.

111 These ideas are discussed in the series of lectures Fichte gave in Berlin in the years 1807–08, called *Addresses to the German Nation* (J.G. Fichte, *Addresses to the German Nation* [Trans. R. F. Jones and G. H. Turnbull], Chicago: Open Court, 1922. Reprint ó Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, Inc., 1979.

112 Concerning Fichte's philosophy, see: Ozkirimli 2000, 17–19.

virility, and that this virility is what renders a people into a nation and binds its citizens together.¹¹³

For the sake of the present discussion, it suffices to present these two extreme positions, whose altercation escalated with the development of modern political philosophy, and is still a key component of global discourse. Some argue that the two approaches represent two different models of society that developed at different times over the course of history. This is the premise of Kedourie, who argues that modern nationalism is based on common collective objectives, in contrast to ancient tribalism, which formed naturally and spontaneously, and was the agent of cultural expression:

Nationalism is also sometimes described as a new tribalism. The analogy is meant to indicate that like the tribe, the nation excludes and is intolerant of outsiders. But such characteristics, as has been said, are common to all human groups, and cannot serve to define either tribe or nation. But the analogy is not only unable to shed light on the matter, it can also mislead. A tribesman's relation to his tribe is usually regulated in minute detail by custom which is followed unquestioningly and considered part of the natural or the divine order. Tribal custom is neither a decree of the General Will, nor an edict of legislative Reason. The tribesman is such by virtue of his birth, nor by virtue of self-determination. He is usually unaware that the destiny of man is progressive, and that he can fulfil this destiny by merging his will into the will of the tribe. Nationalism and tribalism, then, are not interchangeable terms, nor do they describe related phenomena."¹¹⁴

Kedourie's words are one example of a prevalent position, which dictates that perception of the nation as stemming from natural necessity ("tribal nationalism," in his terms), considerably reduces the discourse about a nation's purpose and progression, while those who argue that a nation's formation is based upon its members' free will seek to establish the ideological and objective platform of this collective gathering.

113 Batscha and Yassour 1975, 365. Nonetheless, it is worth mentioning that some favor the model of the "natural nation" and envisioned universal peace and harmony (such as Giuseppe Mazzini [1805–1872] and Adam Mickiewicz [1798–1855]).

114 Kedourie 1993, 69.

As we will shortly see, the story of Abraham attempts to reconcile these two apparently polar positions.

The Abraham Cycle: Between “Nation” and “People”

Exploring the Abraham narrative cycle through these terms produces a captivatingly ambivalent picture. Biblical exploration is rooted in a different sphere of discourse than modern political philosophy, as the biblical nation is explicitly defined in ethnic terms. Even though the concept of a “nation” exists in the Bible – and is apparently a conceptual innovation in ancient Near Eastern thought¹¹⁵ and even if Gordis is correct in asserting that “the concept of nationhood – of a distinct group identity based on common language, culture, land, and blood ties – was not a modern European innovation, as some scholars proclaim it to be, but rather an integral part of the Jewish tradition from its very beginnings,”¹¹⁶ nationhood in the Bible is still considered an extension of family. This is evident from the presentation of humanity as the product of three distinct families – Shem, Ham and Japhet: “These are the groupings of Noah’s descendants, according to their origins, by their nations; and from these the nations branched out over the earth after the Flood” (Genesis 6:32), which also seems to be reflected in the story of the Tower of Babel.¹¹⁷ In fact, the very appellation “the Children of Israel” illustrates that familial origin is what essentially defines a nation, and as Block emphasizes, the Bible considers all nations – and not just Israel – as extensions of family clans (such as Edom, Ammon and Moab), even if it is not at all clear if these nations also perceived themselves in these terms.¹¹⁸ Effectively, this perspective characterizes the Jewish people until this very day. As Blaise Pascal famously marveled:

115 Von Soden 1994, 13–14.

116 Gordis 2010, 19–36.

117 See, for example: Hiebert 2007.

118 Block, “Nations/ Nationality,” 968.

Advantages of the Jewish people – In this search the Jewish people at once attract my attention by the number of wonderful and singular facts which appear about them. I first see that they are a people wholly composed of brethren, and whereas all others are formed by the assemblage of an infinity of families, this, though so wonderfully fruitful, has all sprung from one man alone, and, being thus all one flesh, and members one of another, they constitute a powerful state of one family. This is unique.¹¹⁹

Perception of the nation as an extension of a family (not only in an ideal sense, as reflected in Aristotle, but when members of a nation are considered part of the same “clan”) has broad implications in the context of mutual responsibility. This is prominent in biblical laws that require compassion for another member of the community because he is “your brother” (particularly evident in the laws of Leviticus 25; Deuteronomy 15; and Deuteronomy 22–25). The law extends the concept of family responsibility to apply between every member of the nation.¹²⁰ In this respect, biblical nationalism is an extreme manifestation of the notion of a “natural nation,” wherein membership is the automatic result of being born to a certain family. This is consistent with the biblical perception of Israel as a “nation of culture” – as a nation who is distinguished from other nations not merely by its political context, but through its covenant with God; through its being “God’s nation.” Moreover, this is also true, in at least some books of the Bible, in relation to other nations; the culture of Egypt or Amalek can also be traced over the course of the text,¹²¹ among others.¹²² Nonetheless, this must be stated with caution, as the “culture” that defines

119 Pascal 1910, section 8, # 620.

120 For the notion of the nation as family as a basis for the moral guidelines of the Bible, see: Elmslie 1938, who even included the common covenant of the entire community as part of the moral guidelines.

121 Concerning Amalek, see, for example, Grönbäk 1964. Concerning Egypt, see, for example: Weiser 1966.

122 It is debatable, however, whether this defines the nation according to its culture, or on a literary-symbolic level. Egypt, for example, represents human pride in several prophecies, but Egypt may merely be a *symbol* of pride; this was not necessarily the cultural factor that unified the Egyptian nation into a single political entity.

Israel is not derived from its nature, but from the events that befell its ancestors. Abraham was chosen as the father of a nation because of his morality (Genesis 18:19), while Amalek is characterized as God's enemy because it attacked the weak, new-born nation that had only just left Egypt. That is, a biblical nation's culture is determined by its moral decisions. This issue is related to the ambivalence that accompanies the definition of the Israelite nation, which is already reflected in the Abraham cycle on a semantic level.

The distinction between a nation as an extended family and a nation in a political sense is also reflected in the language of the biblical narrative. There are two common biblical expressions for the word nation: "עַם" and "גוי." The word "גוי" is usually translated as "nation," while the word "עַם" may be translated as "nation" or "people"; sometimes the latter is used, it seems, to differentiate it from the word גוי if both are used in the same context (as in Isaiah 2, for example). Speiser claims that these terms actually have different meanings: the term "עַם" refers to an extended family that has evolved into a nation,¹²³ while the word "גוי" represents a nation in the political sense.¹²⁴ The choice of a particular word often affects the connotations of a particular phrase: the term "עַם" is often accompanied by a possessive suffix ("My people, your people," etc.), while such suffixes are rarely added to the word "גוי." This shows that "'am is something subjective and personal, *goy* objective and impersonal. Note, כִּי עַמֶּךָ הַגּוֹי הַזֶּה, וְרָאָה – "Consider, too, that this nation is Your people" (Exod 33:13).

123 Sometimes the word simply means "family" (as in Genesis 32:8; 48:19; Leviticus 21:1–4; Job 18:19). The expression "gathered unto his people" seems to be parallel to the phrase "gathered unto his forefathers" (Alfrink 1948). The meaning of the word is not limited to the Bible, but appears in other Semite languages. At the end of a broad survey of different languages, Lipinski writes: "In summary, we can say that the West Semitic word *'amm* refers to agnates, both individually and collectively... The biblical usage of *'am* appropriates this double meaning without any difficulty" (Lipinski, "'am", 169–170).

124 For a philological debate of these two terms, see also: Rost 1965 – Bezeichnungen; Block, "Nations/Nationality," 966.

The same utterance with the two nouns interchanged would be unthinkable in a biblical context, though not in translation.”¹²⁵

Speiser’s claim is somewhat exaggerated; Licht and Lipiński are more correct in their assertion that sometimes the two words are interchangeable, used in parallelisms, and the word “עַם” is also sometimes used in a political sense.¹²⁶ Cody’s conclusions are also a preferable version of Speiser’s, as he more subtly claims that the words do have different connotations, but in a literary sense:¹²⁷ that the terminological basis of the word “עַם” is semantically related to family, so this association arises even when the word is used in the more general sense of “nation.” These connotations serve an important function in the construction of the narrative sphere of discourse, and we will see this come into play in the story of Abraham.

Should Abraham be considered the head of a family, or the head of a nation? There is no contradiction between the two roles in biblical thought; on the contrary, Abraham would not be able to establish a nation without first establishing a clan, a tribe. At the same time, the story’s horizon looks out to the future, anticipating a distant time when Abraham’s seed will be as numerous as the stars. In these passages, are Abraham’s descendants represented as a “nation” in the political sense, or as a family extended to extremes? Within a broader biblical perspective – to the extent that it can be determined – Israel are presented as both “עַם” and “גֵּוִי” – they have common ancestors, but they can also be defined politically, as Speiser shows.¹²⁸ A more cautious picture, however, emerges from the Abraham cycle – the term “גֵּוִי” and its political connotations is used in relation to Abraham’s *chosen seed* in only two places: in God’s first revelation to Abraham: “I will make of you a great *nation*, and I will bless you; I will make your name great, and you shall be a blessing” (12:2); and in the narrator’s explanation as to why God involves Abraham in Sodom’s fate: “since Abraham is to

125 Speiser 1960, 159. Malamat claims that the term “גֵּוִי” also has military connotations, especially in Joshua 5:6; 2 Kings 6:18 (Malamat 2001), but others rejected this claim.

126 Licht, עַם; Lipiński, ‘*am*’, 174; see also: Clements, “*gōy*”, 426–427.

127 Cody 1964.

128 Speiser 1960; 162–63.

become a great and populous *nation* and all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him” (18:18).

In both contexts, the reader’s eyes are directed to the distant future. God’s promise to Abraham at the beginning of his journey is not merely a promise for the future, but a blueprint of his entire path: Abraham will eventually establish a great nation, through which “all families of the earth will be blessed.” The narrator’s intervention in 18:18, which justifies Abraham’s involvement with Sodom’s fate, hints to Abraham’s broader role, to the purpose of his election, and here, too, the narrator seems to gaze into the future: “since Abraham is to become...”

Besides for these two instances, the word “גוי” is not used again in relation to Abraham’s chosen seed, although it is constantly used in relation to other nations. This is particularly salient during the episode of the commandment of circumcision. Abraham is to be the father of many “nations,” but this particular word and its political connotations are not actually used to describe the chosen seed who will perpetuate the covenant with God:

As for Me, this is My covenant with you: You shall be the father of a multitude of *nations*. And you shall no longer be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham, for I make you the father of a multitude of *nations*. I will make you exceedingly fertile, and make *nations* of you; and kings shall come forth from you. I will maintain My covenant between Me and you, and your offspring to come, as an everlasting covenant throughout the ages, to be God to you and to your offspring to come. (17:4–7)

A multitude of nations will descend from Abraham, but the covenant shall be retained through “your offspring to come,” who are not described with the word “nation.” This is even more striking later on in the narrative, when Ishmael, who is rejected from the chosen line, is described as the founder of a nation – “As for Ishmael, I have heeded you. I hereby bless him. I will make him fertile and exceedingly numerous. He shall be the father of twelve chieftains, and I will make of him a great *nation*” (17:20), in contrast to Isaac, whose descendants will perpetuate the covenant: “But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear to you at this season next year” (17:21). This

phenomenon repeats itself in the story of Ishmael's expulsion from Abraham's household. Both Ishmael's mother and father hear that he is to be the father of a "nation": "As for the son of the slave-woman, I will make a *nation* of him, too, for he is your seed" (21:13); "Come, lift up the boy and hold him by the hand, for I will make a great *nation* of him" (21:18). This phrase is not used in conjunction with Isaac even once; rather, the term "offspring," or "seed," repeatedly occurs: "your offspring to come" (17:10); Isaac's children are also referred to as "his offspring to come" (17:19). The definition of Isaac's children does not seep from the family sphere into the national sphere.

This does not seem coincidental, as in other stories too, the term "גוי" with all its political associations applies to other nations, but not to Abraham's seed. During the Covenant between the Pieces, for example, God declares that "I will execute judgment on the nation they will serve" (15:14), while Abraham's seed at the time of their exodus from Egypt, who will already have become a nation, are still referred to as "your offspring" (13). Like the Egyptians, King Abimelech of Gerar refers to his own people as "nation" (20:4),¹²⁹ while Abraham repeatedly hears blessings showered upon the heads of his "offspring," but not upon the "nation" he is to establish.

This distinction is not merely linguistic; a careful reading of these narratives reveals that the text relates to the future nation of Israel not as a nation but as "Abraham's family." This is salient, for example, in the aforementioned narrative of the Covenant between the Pieces. On one hand, there is a clear national dimension to this revelation. The covenant ends with a description of the borders of the land (including the eastern side of the Jordan), anticipating the nation that will inhabit this territory, which transpires in David and Solomon's time. This conclusion would serve well as the ending of a narrative of national-political character, but this is not the case. The chapter opens with Abraham's complaint that he has no "heir" (15:2–3); God promises him that he will be granted a son of his own, and that his descendants will one day be too numerous to count. The discussion

129 Speiser (among others) claimed that the inclusion of the word "גוי" here is a corruption (Speiser 1960, 159).

of an “heir” connotes an intimate family atmosphere, and in this spirit the reader is also introduced to the subsequent discussion of inheritance of the land (I explore this juxtaposition in depth in the relevant chapter, below). Indeed, the term “inheritance,” with its striking familial connotations, is repeated in the chapter, mentioned in context of inheritance of the land. God promises “to assign this land to you as a possession,” whereupon Abram asks, “how shall I know that I am to possess it?” (15:7–8).¹³⁰ Therefore, the aforementioned linguistic distinction is consistent with the general atmosphere of this chapter. The nation who will enslave Israel is referred to as a “nation,” while Abraham’s seed are his “offspring,” the “fourth generation” of the head of the clan who will one day return to the land to inherit it.

The theme of Israel as a family also colors the scene concerning circumcision, which is also inherently related to the family sphere. Abraham will father “nations” and “kings” but the covenant will be perpetuated through “his *offspring* to come,” who will one day settle in the land “of [his] sojourning” (17:4–8).

We can now return to the two anomalous places where Abraham’s chosen seed is referred to as a “nation,” and read them in a new light. Cody shows that Israel is described as a nation in instances when the narrator seeks to present them as one nation among many:

Gôy is used of the Chosen People because Israel is being considered a *gôy* among *gôyim*, either because it is being looked upon as an individual within the class, or because the pagans in contexts of national consciousness do not distinguish Israel from other *gôyim*, or because God, in upbraiding the infidelity of the Chosen People, reduces it from the preferable status of His *‘am* to that of a mere *gôy* like all the rest.¹³¹

In order to emphasize the international significance of these two sources, the appellation “גוי” is used. Both sources focus on the relevance of Abraham’s seed for the surrounding nations: “All the families

130 Note that the biblical law of inheritance (Numbers 27:8–10) is given in the context of dividing the land into portions, so that “the Israelite law of inheritance originates in the division of land through tribal-familial organization” (Loewenstamm, ירושה, 789).

131 Cody 1964, 2.

of the earth shall bless themselves by you” (12:3); “all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him” (18:18).¹³² Hamilton adds that Abraham’s influence on the surrounding nations is actually fulfilled in the plot in chapter 18, in the context of his concern for Sodom.¹³³ This reading is supported by Noort’s exploration of Abraham’s universalistic significance. While “the linchpin (Gen 12:1–3) of the primeval history and the patriarchal narratives breathes universalism”; and in the Abraham-Lot cycle, “the question of 18:25 concerns all mankind and the mediator is Abraham,”¹³⁴ Noort demonstrates that the rest of the narrative is concerned with Abraham’s own family and descendants. Besides for these two passages, “the supposed universalism of Gen 12 is nowhere present” – not even in biblical references to Abraham in later biblical works – and most of the Abraham cycle itself is concerned solely with Abraham’s own family: with Lot, Ishmael, and chiefly, of course, the fate of his son and heir, Isaac.¹³⁵

If so, the definition of Abraham’s seed as a nation in the Abraham cycle is clearly ambiguous. The acknowledgment that a nation is to arise motivates God’s promises to Abraham, but there is also noticeable restraint exercised to prevent national connotations from coloring the story. Cody argues that the biblical reservations towards the term “גוי” stem from the negative connotations of this word, as it is not used to present Israel as the chosen people, but rather lowers it to the level of other political nations (to the extent that the word “goy” became a post-exilic term for a non-Jew).¹³⁶ The Bible, however, is capable of implementing this word in a positive sense, as in the case of 12:2 and 18:18. It seems to me that even when Abraham’s seed

132 Regarding this connection, see for example Hamilton 1995, 18. Schmidt and Westermann surmise that the difference at the end of the linguistic expression between “families of the earth” and “nations of the land” reflects two different sources (Schmidt 1976, 136; Westermann 1995, 288), however, the familiar phrase incorporating the rarer word “nation” in relation to Abraham’s offspring shows that there *is*, in fact, a connection between these two verses.

133 Hamilton 1995, 18.

134 Noort 2010 – Abraham, 18, 17.

135 Noort, 2010 – Abraham, 13.

136 Cody 1964, 1–6.

becomes a nation in the active political sphere – a “great nation” that all nations shall be blessed through – there is clear narrative intent to present this political entity in the context of its family ties; that is, as the product of its “forefathers.” The Israelite nation is depicted as the natural, unified progeny of a single family, a “natural nation” (needless to say, the theory of social contract is not the basis of this kind of nationalism). This presentation of nationalism commissions more mutual commitment from its members (as expressed, for example, in the story of Lot’s rescue from Sodom), which in turn contributes to the members’ emotional sense of belonging to their own nation.

This brings us to the unique approach of biblical familial-nationalism. Critics of natural-ethnic nationalism have claimed that this “natural” form of nationalism is liable to degenerate into fascism and negation of the Other – and history has proven them right. The premise of this criticism is clear: reinforcing the national sense of unity through emphasis on natural, unalterable factors constructs an insurmountable wall between members of the community – who were born into these circumstances – and outsiders.

The Abraham cycle, however, despite its emphasis on family as the basis of the nation, presents a completely different approach. Abraham’s family is chiefly characterized by its moral quality, and this morality is what serves as the chosen nations’ definitive cornerstone: “For I have singled him out, that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is just and right” (18:19). This declaration is followed – and illustrated – by Abraham’s efforts to prevent Sodom’s obliteration. As mentioned, the prevalent position – represented above by Kedurie – attributes common ideals as a collective basis to the liberal definition of a nation, while the tribal-ethnic definition of a nation does not set moral objectives. The biblical ethnic nationalism shatters this dichotomy, however, at least in relation to Israel. As I have already mentioned, it is not entirely clear whether the Bible holds that every nation has a definitive culture it must fulfill,¹³⁷ but Abraham’s offspring is elected for moral reasons,

137 Some of the philosophers mentioned above relied upon language differentiating between the nations as a gauge for difference in culture (Herder and Fichte).

as the text hints and implies in various ways, and the family-nation Abraham will establish is to be rooted upon moral values. In other words, although the nation in question evolves naturally, out of a single family, this “natural” nation is not solely characterized thus; rather, the narrative employs moral discourse about the nation’s foundation upon divine values of righteousness and justice. The nation’s morality is an immanent part of its character and purpose.¹³⁸

Citizen Will and Divine Will

This biblical configuration of a nation is described as the result of God’s voluntary election of Abraham. According to the social contract theory, the “nation of culture” is based on the “community’s will”; here, this collective will is replaced with divine will. Therefore, despite the “naturally” evolving depiction of the nation, it is not bound by a deterministic approach which creates the impression of a nation without moral value or purpose. The free will the nation is based on

Even if they did not state this explicitly, this can read in the story of the nations’ dispersal (chapter 10) and the Tower of Babel (11). In these narratives, the narrator emphasizes the dispersion of the nations together with the development of their individual languages. According to this reading, the linguistic differentiation between nations hints that each nation has a culture it must fulfill.

- 138 A similar model appears in Hegel’s work *Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts*, even if it is only similar structurally. When he seeks to explore the “ethical life,” he begins by presenting the family as every person’s first social framework, and from this framework a person progresses to “civil society” and eventually encounters “the state,” which in his opinion, is the fulfillment of the ethical ideal. He emphasizes that the ideal collective union (i.e. the “state”) should not only be considered as if it were solely intended to safeguard the individual’s property and individual freedom (which already occurs in “civil society”) but it should comprise the content and purpose of every individual in it, and only through the state can a person find ethical fulfillment. (G. W. F. Hegel, *Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts*, in: *Werke*, vol. 7, ed. by E. Moldenhauer and K. M. Michel, Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1970, Part 3 (see especially # 258). When Hegel refers to “general will” as something palpable, which surpasses individual will (even if the individual is not aware of it, he must submit to it), he already paves the way to the next step of God’s will being an expression of general will.

facilitates moral discourse; at the same time, however, because a single man is chosen as the father of the nation, the nation is still considered natural. As I mentioned earlier, even though the nation is considered a naturally evolving entity, the culture of this nation is not imposed upon its members merely because they were born into it. The covenant with God is a moral and religious obligation more than a definition of national character.

This approach has several important implications for the Abraham cycle:

1. *Rescue mission, not military campaign.* Von Treitschke emphasized the importance of military aggression as an expression of national virility and unity.¹³⁹ In his eyes, exercise of national power is an integral part of a nation's definition, and even a supreme value. Even without adopting his aggressive opinion, it should be noted that in the ancient world, a king established his might and won over his subjects through his success upon the battlefield and the extent of his military conquests. Abraham is also presented as a military figure who leads a campaign (Genesis 14). This chapter is so incongruous with the traditional perception of Abraham's character that many have questioned whether this is an original part of the Abraham cycle. I will discuss this at length below, in the relevant chapter, where I claim that his victory awards Abraham not only religious recognition but political renown. However, the battle in question is not the result of a military campaign, but a rescue mission – Abraham seeks to rescue his nephew Lot, who has been taken captive. This motive allows the narrator to hold the rope at both ends – Abraham rises to political fame through the accepted route of a victor returning from the battlefield, but he does not become characterized as a power-hungry conqueror because his underlying motive for attack is moral: saving his nephew, that is, family commitment.¹⁴⁰

139 Batscha and Yassour 1975, 365.

140 It may well be that for the sake of emphasizing this, Abraham's war reaches until north of Damascus (14:15), that is, north of the border of Canaan, which emphasizes that the present war is a rescue mission, and the time of conquering

2. *Particularism and universalism.* Modern political thought perceives nationalistic separatism as contradictory to universal liberalism. The reasoning is clear, as defining what is “national” inherently defines the Other, who is thereby excluded from the privileges granted to members of the nation.¹⁴¹ In the wider context of particularism versus universalism, many have correctly stated that the Bible is suspended in unresolved tension; some works are inclined towards one worldview, while others favor the opposite approach. The Abraham cycle also oscillates between these two extremes, which are, nowadays, largely presented as conflicting.

The beginning of the Abraham cycle already establishes that Abraham’s election is not a particularistic-chauvinistic election but a choice with universalistic implications: “All the families of the earth shall bless themselves by you” (12:3); this idea is confirmed on the eve of Sodom’s destruction: “the nations of the earth are

the land is not yet at hand. As we will see, this war granted Abraham rights to the eastern side of the Jordan. I will discuss this at length in my analysis of chapters 14–15.

- 141 Nonetheless, the beginnings of modern political philosophy already saw thinkers who combined a strong nationalistic approach and liberal-universalistic thought. For example, the French historian Jules Michelet (1798–1874) took a liberal stance that developed, on one hand, the importance of the specific nation, but also saw the nation as an agent of universal freedom. In his opinion, history is the story of humanity’s struggle for freedom, against nature and fate, and France is the nation that represents this spirit of freedom, which will influence all of humanity in the future. Michelet justified violence and denial of freedom over the course of the French Revolution (such as withholding the right to vote from most of the nation through the monarchical constitution of 1791) for the sake of the Revolution’s success, and because he believed that the minority sometimes reflects the nation’s innermost desires. Due to these approaches, some consider Michelet’s works a combination of political and cultural, mystical and historical, chauvinistic and universalistic nationalism. See especially: Kohn 1982, 97–102; Malach, 2009, 30–31.

Alongside the French Michelet, Assaf Malach also counts the Italian Giuseppe Mazzini (1805–1872) and the Polish national poet Adam Mickiewicz (1798–1855) (who never set foot in Poland). He argues that these thinkers also emphasize, in one way or another, that nationalism is not at odds with universalism, but rather is a preliminary stage of advancing universal concepts.

to bless themselves by him” (18:18); and reiterated during God’s final revelation to Abraham: “All the nations of the earth shall bless themselves by your descendants” (22:18). These universalistic statements frame Abraham’s election. They do not state that in the future, all nations will become part of the Hebrew nation, but that they will become “blessed” through them. The narrative thus presents a universalistic view. The post-diluvian world is comprised of many nations and the story of the Tower of Babel presents this phenomenon as the result of God’s will, similar to Herder’s aforementioned approach. It is well known that out of the major monotheistic religions, Judaism is the only one who has never attempted to impose its beliefs and culture upon non-members of the Israelite community. This attitude is already rooted in the Abraham cycle, which anticipates peaceful co-existence with other nations. At the same time, however, the establishment of the Hebrew nation is an unmistakable process of separation and segregation. Abraham openly fears his son’s intermarriage with the daughters of Canaan, similar to God’s command for him to leave his hometown and wander to another place. This issue is complex and will crop up repeatedly throughout the different stories. Here, I wish only to draw attention to the fact that in the Abraham cycle, incidents which hint to nationalistic particularism are balanced out by stories that elevate universal benefit as the ultimate objective of Abraham’s election. In this context, too, the narrative seems to be holding the rope at both ends: the “natural nation” that will evolve from Abraham’s seed is committed to the fulfillment of values of universal justice.

3. *Nation and territory.* The “national purpose” of Abraham’s election also complicates the issue of the nation’s relationship with its land. The promise of inheriting the land is obviously a central, fundamental aspect of the Abraham cycle, and there is virtually no revelation without explicit mention of this promise.¹⁴² At the same time, however, the narrative does not present the land as the

142 The only revelation which does not explicitly mention the land (15:1–6) is balanced out by this promise mentioned in the very next verses (15:7–21), which

nation's birthplace but rather as the land of their destiny. Intriguingly, Israelite culture does not tell itself stories of how its forefathers were born in the land, or of how the land was desolate until its ancestors came to settle it. On the contrary, there is repeated emphasis on Abraham's journey to the land; how the Canaanites already dwelled there (12:6; 13:7); and that his descendants will not immediately inherit the land because "the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete" (15:16).¹⁴³ This complexity is especially striking in the story of Abram and Sarai's descent to Egypt (chapter 12) which interrupts the sequence of his journey to the chosen land, and I will discuss this in depth below. Like the covenant at Sinai, which takes place outside of the borders of Israel, Abraham's election also occurs outside of the territory which his offspring are to inherit, rendering the chosen land a destination rather than a point of origin; Israel's destiny, not its birthplace.¹⁴⁴

4. "*The gods of my father.*" In his classic 1929 work, *Der Gott der Väter*, Alt claims that the ancestral gods did not have a name of their own; rather, they were named for the person who established their ritual worship; thus he interprets the references to "the God of Abraham"; "the Fear of Isaac," and "the Mighty One of Jacob." Only later, supposedly, were these gods identified with the Israelite God. Therefore, Alt argues that these ancestral gods were not cosmic deities, or even territorial-national deities, but gods identified with central historical figures, to the extent that they were referred to by the name of these figures (this form of religion, according to Alt, was common in nomadic tribes). This theory was accepted as widely as it was criticized.¹⁴⁵ For our purposes,

begin a new revelation, as I will show in my analysis of the two halves of chapter 15.

- 143 Weinfeld claims that besides the Bible, there are no other stories of the origins of the major cultures in the Ancient Near East. The first founding story which shows structural similarity to the Abraham cycle is the story of Aeneas, founder of Ancient Rome (Weinfeld 1992, 13–26).
- 144 Similarly: Machinist 1994, 49.
- 145 See, for example: Hoftijzer 1956, 84–97; Cross 1973, 3–75; McComiskey 1974, 195–206; Mathews 2005, vol. 2, 56–60.

the crucial aspect of this theory lies in his surprising claim that this phenomenon – the god’s naming according to his central worshiper – is only documented in the patriarchal narrative cycles. Westermann, however, is correct in asserting that this testifies to the familial-personal nature of the patriarchal cycles more than to a unique theological practice: “It is only from this context that the titles acquire their meaning.”¹⁴⁶ In other words, the obvious family nature of the patriarchal cycles does not only have bearing on the nation’s definition, but on the construction of its religious infrastructure. God appears to the forefathers privately, addressing them as the heads of the clan, rather than as chief representatives of the nation which is to arise from them.

Nationalism and Morality

Beyond the aforementioned implications, the most important principle that can be derived from the notion of Israel as a natural-yet-ideological nation is related to the field of morality. Once again, the denouncement of marked nationalism is practically a premise of modern political philosophy; the trauma of Nazism certainly serves as a red light against any radical displays of nationalism, but not only Nazi Germany has committed atrocities in its name. The list is long and grows longer with time. At the same time, nationalism has also achieved great things, as Lea Brilmayer neatly states in her opening address to the department of Law in New York University:

One of the puzzling things about nationalism is that it sometimes seems to be a force for good, and sometimes a force for very great evil. At this particular time, we are more likely to think in terms of the evil nationalism brings about; this association is the legacy of the war in the former Yugoslavia, the killings in Rwanda, the ongoing fighting in Chechnya, and many other examples that all too easily come to mind. Nationalism now tends to be associated with barbarism: with genocide, ethnic cleansing, rape and wanton murder. But nationalism can also be a force for great good. When Armenians living in America contribute

146 Westermann 1995, 108.

from their own limited resources to help Armenian earthquake victims, when Eritreans sacrifice their lives to liberate their country from a colonial power, or when Rigoberta Menchu commits herself to a life of personal hardship and danger to advance the human rights of Central American native peoples, it is hard to deny that national sentiment can play a noble role in world events.”¹⁴⁷

The solidarity between members of the nations that Brilmayer mentions has been witnessed among Jews throughout history. This phenomenon has baffled cultural researchers, and still remains somewhat of a mystery. There are too many examples to mention, but one notable case is the reaction to the Damascus Affair; Jews across the world endangered their positions and sacrificed their time and resources for the Jews of Syria during the blood libels of February 1840. The Jews of Damascus suffered terribly at the hands of the government.¹⁴⁸ Different scholars point to the Damascus Affair as a climactic point of national solidarity: Jews from across the globe enlisted to help their brothers in a distant land.¹⁴⁹ The Jews who went to extremes to help the victims in Damascus – despite the heavy personal prices they were forced to pay – had never met their Syrian “brothers,” nor is it even likely that had they met, they would have been able to communicate through the language barrier. Yet their belonging to the same nation served as sufficient motivation to leave their home for weeks on end in a desperate struggle to prevent injustice to their own people in Syria, while no such efforts were made by the victims’ own Arab neighbors.

Of course this story, or the countless incidents similar to it, does not have the power to negate the grievous atrocities committed in the name of nationalism; nor was this my intention. Brilmayer, however, is correct in noting that national solidarity moves citizens to sacrifice themselves for the sake of their people.

147 Brilmayer 1995, 7.

148 George Pieritz, a Protestant missionary, described how the detained Jews were dipped in freezing water; how their heads were squeezed until their eyes popped out; how they were dragged by their ears and set alight. The government even seized and tortured sixty Jewish children between the ages of three and ten in order to pressure their parents into “confessing” about the death of Father Thomas and his Muslim attendant.

149 Frankel 1997.

I wish to take this observation one step further and assert that nationalism in itself is neither positive nor negative; rather, it is employed to justify positive or negative actions, depending on that nation's culture and regime. For the sake of this discussion, I wish to adopt Brilmayer's working hypothesis:

The hypothesis I want to investigate here is that nationalism, itself, is morally transparent, and that this fact accounts for its ability to coexist equally well with good and evil. The argument is that the overwhelmingly relevant normative feature of today's nationalism is the justice (or lack of justice) of the claim nationalists advance on behalf of their nation. The single most important normative feature—indeed, perhaps, the only important normative feature—is the right of the nation to the thing that nationalists assert on its behalf, and this right is not itself a consequence of nationalism but a consequence of other underlying moral claims. What matters from a moral point of view is whether the claims of one's nation and co-nationals are worthy, and whether they are pursued by morally acceptable means. Resistance to colonialism, human rights abuses, and dictatorship is just, at least so long as morally defensible means are used, and ethnic cleansing, rape, and genocide are morally wrong; this is not so because of any reasons involving nationalism, but because of other moral features of the situation. Nationalism means simply that one identifies with the claims of one's nation and one's co-nationals, and takes them as one's own. Nationalists act as agents of their nation, and when agents act what matters is the rights of the principal (that is, the nation) rather than the agents' motivations (that is, their nationalism).¹⁵⁰

This position, even if not universally accepted, is important for the understanding of the legacy that the Abraham cycle leaves for the Israelite nation. Not only do the Abraham narratives – in their present redactive form – not pose a contradiction between nationalism and morality, but on the contrary: Abraham's election is presented as being contingent upon moral values of justice and righteousness. Weinfeld correctly notes that the description of Abraham's election in 18:19 implies that the upholding of "justice and righteousness" pertains to Abraham's entire household – that is, to the entire nation – and not only to the leader himself.¹⁵¹ As I will posit throughout my analysis

150 Brilmayer 1995, 7–8.

151 Weinfeld 1985, 125–26.

of the Abraham cycle, the central question of Abraham's election is explored through pairs of narratives; one of each pair addresses the issue of his continuity from a nationalistic perspective, while the other presents a moral perspective.¹⁵² This is true of the double Ishmael narratives (chapters 16, 21); of the story of Lot (chapter 19 includes two narratives of Lot's escape from the falling city); and of the double tidings of Isaac's birth (17, 18). In each pair, one narrative presents the birth of a nation bound to a covenant with God, while the parallel story depicts the birth of a nation as the result of divine reaction to certain moral actions of the characters. For example, Isaac's birth is justified twice: once in order to perpetuate the covenant with God (chapter 17), and once as Abraham and Sarah's reward for their hospitality (chapter 18). This dichotomy, which reoccurs at every narrative junction, ardently clarifies the relationship between nationalism and morality; between Abraham's election for national as well as moral purposes. Asserting the moral obligations of the nation's founder as a unifying justification of a nation's existence can be considered a revolution in ancient political thought. Irwin may well be correct in his argument that this revolution was already the result of a more fundamental theological revolution, that of the unique moral values of the God of Israel.¹⁵³ In any case, the Abraham cycle introduces a natural (ethnic) nation whose moral purpose and obligations are a fundamental condition for its existence; a natural nation who evolves from a single family yet is inherently established upon free choice.

Moral Nationalism and Post-Modern Nationalism

In Israel today, a lively public debate is raging in regard to the institution of a "Jewish nationality law," which seeks to ratify the State of Israel as a Jewish-democratic state. One of the main opponents of this law is Prof. Mordechai Kremnitzer, in whose eyes, the "Jewish

152 Compare to Brodie 2001, 89–94.

153 Irwin 1946, 326–359.

nationality” of the State of Israel is obvious and inherent, so that there is no need to anchor it through a legal definition:

The State of Israel is the national state of the Jewish people. It always has been, and will always be. Whether one considers our legal system superficially or in depth, there is only one conclusion: our State is of a Jewish and democratic nature. This is evident from mention of the expression “Jewish and democratic” in our constitution, but not only from that; it is evident from our Declaration of Independence, from the Law of Return, from our festivals and days of remembrance... it is evident from the special status of the Hebrew language.¹⁵⁴

The nature of this debate reflects a national reawakening attempting to define itself in light of contemporary philosophical discourse. This reawakening, of course, is not unique to the State of Israel. According to economist Guy Sorman, a national reawakening in East Asia is quashing liberal European assumptions pertaining to the decline of nationalism and the unlikelihood of war between democracies. In his opinion, Western attention is focused on the economic boom in East Asia, overlooking the fact that the region is sizzling with nationalistic debates that challenge the region’s stability as well as the notion that the time of nationalism is long past.¹⁵⁵

At the time of writing these lines, Scotland has rejected independence from the United Kingdom by majority opinion (September 2014). While this decision reflects other factors being privileged over nationalism, the very fact that this issue has come to a head at this point in time – with similar issues bubbling to the surface in other parts of the world – shows that nationalistic sentiment is still stirring across the globe. These political factions indicate that questions of nationalism are still relevant, and rather than attempt to quash these issues out of fear from shadows of the past, there is growing need to devote time and effort to formulate a nationalistic discourse through the employment of moral terms and obligations. The story of Abraham exemplifies the fusion of nationalistic and moral values; the ancient text has much to contribute to an age-old debate in new guise.

154 Kremnitzer 2014.

155 Sorman 2012.

Chapter 1: The Line of Terah (11:27–30)

Our hero is introduced at the end of a description of the genealogy of Shem, which culminates with the birth of Terah's three sons of: "Terah begot Abram, Nahor, and Haran" (Gen 11:27). Whereas biblical genealogies usually mention the firstborn son alone, Terah's three sons are named, indicating that the list has been leading up to him. A similar model is found in Cain's brief genealogy, which culminates in the three sons of Lamech (Yaval, Yuval, and Tuval Cain – Gen 4), and in the genealogy of Seth (Gen 5), which culminates with Noah's three sons (Shem, Ham, and Japheth).¹

Noah marks the tenth generation of Adam's genealogy; Terah marks the tenth in Noah's. While it is problematic to infer conclusions about the book's formation based on the connections between the lists, their parallels nonetheless produce a literary effect: their similarity generates anticipation that a leader might emerge in the next generation.² The very next verse, however, relates a family tragedy: the death of Terah's son.³ This recalls the story of Adam, who had three sons – Cain, Abel, and Seth – but lost one in his lifetime.⁴ The connections to Adam, as well as Noah, create anticipation of the birth of a new hero; the allusion to two previous biblical "beginnings" implies that the reader is on the brink of a new era.⁵

1 See: von Rad 1963, 152; Hamilton 1990–95, 362.

2 See further: Hasel 1980.

3 The claim that Haran died "in confrontation with Terah" (Retief 2010) is, in my opinion, somewhat exaggerated. The meaning of the expression "פני תרה אביו על" is chronological..

4 Based on the similarity to Gen 4, Wellhausen thought that there were originally only seven generations between Noah and Abraham. See Wellhausen 1994, 313.

5 Note that according to the "three son model" Terah (and not Abram) parallels Adam and Noah.

The introduction of Abram and Nahor further alludes to the exposition's meaning; inviting comparison between the brothers by initially presenting a unified description of their actions: "Abram and Nahor took to themselves wives," (11:29) followed by each brother's individual path: "the name of Abram's wife being Sarai and that of Nahor's wife Milcah, the daughter of Haran, the father of Milcah and the father of Iscah. Now Sarai was barren, she had no child" (11:29).

The names of the two wives also inspire comparison, as both connote power and monarchy.⁶ Intriguingly, both names are associated with Babylonian pagan mythology, predominantly in Ur and Harran: *Šarratu* was the wife of Sin, God of the moon and chief God of Harran, and *Malkātu* is the name of the Goddess Ishtar, daughter of Sin.⁷

A comparison of the two wives reveals two distinctions. Firstly, while Sarai's ancestry is omitted from the text, Milcah is introduced as daughter of Haran, and her sister Iscah is also mentioned. Readers familiar with the story might have expected more narrative focus on Sarai, who plays a central role in the story cycle, as opposed to Milcah, who is mentioned only twice more (Gen 22)20; 24:16). This incongruity led some scholars to assume that the verse originally mentioned Sarai's ancestry as well, and that Iscah is mentioned because she is Lot's wife.⁸ However, I believe it serves a literary function, especially considering another distinction drawn between Sarai and Milcah: Sarai's family status is noted and she is described as barren, while no such information is provided about Milcah's fertility. Each

6 The name Sarai is derived from Akkadian *šarratu* ("queen"), while Milcah's name clearly relates to the Hebrew root for monarch (Westermann 1995, 138; Sarna 1989, 87).

7 Dhorme 1928, 385–67; Westermann 1995, 138. Additional names that might be related to the worship of the moon are Terah, and Nahor's grandson Laban (see Hamilton 1990, 363).

8 Ewald 1883, 1:313. Dillmann (1897, 1:409) rejected this idea. Since Iscah's name was mentioned despite the fact that Iscah plays no role in the story cycle, Westermann asserted that Terah's genealogy is based on a more complex tradition, which is not written in its complete form in the final version of the narrative (Westermann 1985, 136).

distinction contributes to the reading of the text: Sarai's barrenness is vital to the rest of the story cycle, since her distress and its resolution are major themes throughout the cycle; additionally, within the broader narrative cycle, Milcah's relation to Haran is also vital information, as Isaac and Jacob's wives will be born of this family. Though Abram leaves his home, his family will reunite in the next generation, when Isaac marries Rebekah, daughter of Bethuel, son of Nahor and Milcah (daughter of Haran). Terah's line essentially comprises three disjointed branches that gradually, eventually, reunite. The mention of Milcah and her lineage in the exposition anticipate the stories of Terah's descendants.

Milcah is introduced in relation to her parents and family ("and that of Nahor's wife Milcah, the *daughter* of Haran, the *father* of Milcah and *father* of Iscah"), while Sarai is characterized by her infertility. The description of Milcah links her to her past – her parents – while Sarah is presented with no past and little hope for the future: "Not only at this point does Sarai have no beginnings; she also has no continuation through a child."⁹ This complication is to play a central role in a narrative cycle about God's blessings to the protagonist and his destiny as father of many nations, generating tension and suspense because Abram's barren wife cannot contribute to the continuity of the family.

The two wives' introductions seem to suggest that Nahor will become the story's protagonist: Terah's eldest, Haran, died young; Sarai, wife of Terah's second son, is barren; therefore Nahor, whose wife is deeply connected with the family past, and is presumably fertile, will continue Terah's line. The sudden change of focus to Abram is designed to enhance the sense of divine selection throughout the narrative cycle.¹⁰

9 Matthews 2005, p. 101.

10 In the broader context of the biblical infertility motif, Sarai's infertility might be viewed as an allusion to the fact that she is an exemplary character, and that a significant role is reserved for her and her child.

Terah's Journey to Canaan (11:31–32)

Terah's genealogy is followed by a description of his journey to Canaan: "Terah took his son Abram, his grandson Lot, the son of Haran, and his daughter-in-law Sarai, the wife of his son Abram, and set out with them¹¹ from Ur of the Chaldeans for the land of Canaan; but when they arrived in Harran, they settled there" (11:31). The narrator emphasizes Terah's relationships with Abram, his wife, and his nephew Lot.

No reason is provided for Terah's journey. Josephus wrote that Terah's grief over the death of Haran drove him away from Ur.¹² Others mention Sarai's barrenness,¹³ financial reasons, local conflicts,¹⁴ or religious reasons for his departure.¹⁵ Whatever the cause may be, this intentional lacuna indicates that the reason for Terah's departure plays no role in the story; in fact, its absence might serve as an indication of the story's objective.

Another omission worth noting is the absence of Nahor and his wife from Terah's convoy. While the journey seems to be a family affair ("his son," "his daughter-in-law," "his nephew"), Nahor and Milcah are not mentioned. In some versions of the Septuagint Nahor is listed as part of the convoy, and the Samaritan includes Milcah as well.¹⁶ Cassuto similarly suggested:

11 NJPS translated וַיֵּצְאוּ אִתָּם – "and they set out together."

12 Josephus, *Antiquities*, I:152 (Feldman 2000, 55. See also n. 476). See also Zakovitch 1999.

13 Kiel 1997, 205.

14 Dhorme 1928, 379.

15 I have difficulty with Mordecai Breuer's suggestion (and Patricia Berlyn 2005) that Terah went to the Land of Canaan because it is the land in which God resides, and that Terah felt this deeply in his soul (Breuer 1999, 224–25). There is no indication in the written text to this effect. However, according to Ibn Ezra's interpretation, perhaps Breuer's suggestion could be accepted for a different reason, as discussed below.

16 The Samaritan mentions Milcah without mentioning Nahor's participation in the journey: "Terah gathered his son Abram, and his grandson Lot, son of Haran, and his daughters-in-law Sarai and Milcah, wives of his sons Abram

They (Nahor and Milcah) are included like all the other members of Terah's house, in the indefinite subject of the verb "went forth." There was no need to mention them all individually, since the rest of the narrative is not concerned with them but with Abram, Sarai and Lot exclusively; only the names of these, the heroes of the next sections and the promoters of the migration, are specifically mentioned.¹⁷

This argument is problematic, however, because Nahor's family does reappear later in the cycle: when Abram's servant seeks a wife for Isaac (Gen 24); and when Jacob moves into the house of Laban (Gen 29–32); so the question of Nahor's relocation is no less relevant than Terah's.¹⁸ Regardless of whether Nahor journeyed with his father or traveled to Harran at a later point, the *omission* of his role serves a literary purpose: The narrator criticizes Terah for not completing his journey to Canaan. Omitting Nahor from the outset shields the father of Bethuel, and Rebekah's grandfather, from this criticism.

These two glaring omissions – the reason for Terah's journey and the question of Nahor's fate – are linked with the narrative design. Why is Terah's journey – a journey he never sees through; a journey that ends in Harran; a journey that never reaches its final destination – included in the narrative cycle starring his son?

A comparison between the beginning of Terah's journey and Abram's departure in the following chapter might shed new light on this matter, underscoring the perplexing fact that God commands Abram to journey to Canaan when Terah has already begun his journey to the very same destination. The formulation of God's command seems to indicate that Abram is still in Ur of the Chaldeans ("Go forth from *your land* and from *the place of your birth* and from your father's

and Nahor, and took them out of Ur of the Chaldeans to go to the land of Canaan..." (Samaritan Pentateuch, 35–36).

17 Cassuto, 1964, 281. Similarly, Brichto (1998, 355) suggested that the phrase "with them" alludes to Nahor and his family. He translated the verse accordingly: "and there went forth with them [others]."

18 Emerton (1994, 178–79) critiques Cassuto's suggestion from another perspective. Nahor's presence in Haran was used as proof for the theory of documentary hypothesis; which dictated that according to P, Terah is in Ur of the Chaldeans in P sources, and in Harran according to J (Wellhausen 1994, 313).

house”),¹⁹ despite the fact that in the previous episode, Abram has already reached Harran with his father. This surprising contradiction lies at the heart of the prevalent scholarly position that the narrative is a compilation of two different documents. According to the first (P), Terah initiated the journey to Canaan but settled in Harran, and his son Abram continued the journey to Canaan (12:4b), while in the second source (J), Abram’s journey is attributed to God’s command that he “go forth” from Harran (which according to this source, is Terah’s birthplace).²⁰ This diachronic view holds the stories should not be read in succession, but rather as contradictory accounts of Abram’s travels.

The journeys of Terah and Abram should be discussed on two separate planes: the development of the plot, and the literary purpose of the narrative. Terah initiates a journey that is unrelated to God’s command; how does this correlate with the command to Abram to journey to that very same destination? Additionally, there must be literary significance to the consecutive *presentation* of the two episodes. Seeking literary significance goes beyond the historical question, beyond the ‘fabula’ (*what happened?*) and instead relates to the narrative design, to the ‘syuzhet’ (*how is the story presented to the reader, and why?*).

Plot Development

The narrator relates that Terah begot sons at the age of 70, and died at 205 (11:31). Abram leaves for Canaan on God’s command at the age of 75, when Terah is 145 (70+75). The fact that Terah’s death (11:32) is recorded *before* God’s command to Abram (12:1) creates the false impression that Terah died before Abram left for Canaan,

19 NJPS includes the translation for “the place of your birth” – מולדתך – within the phrase “from your *native* land”. Cassuto’s assertion that homeland in this context means the family’s current dwelling is unconvincing. See Cassuto 1964, 273–75. I later argue that this phrase employs intentional ambiguity.

20 See, e.g., Wellhausen 1994, 313; von Rad 1963, 152–54; Westermann 1995, 135–36.

while chronologically Abram arrived in Canaan during his father's lifetime. Wenham wrote: "There may also be some symbolic significance: true life is to be found only in Canaan, and Terah, who set out for Canaan but settled in Harran, died there."²¹ However, biblical protagonists frequently exit the narrative stage long before their chronological lives are over; for example, though it seems Noah dies long before the Abraham narrative begins, a simple calculation in fact proves that Noah dies when Abraham is 58 years old; similarly, Isaac was still alive when his grandson Joseph was sold.²² Genesis is not a history book, but a sweeping series of portraits tracing a character from birth to death before the next character is introduced. The narrative follows Terah's life: the birth and marriage of his sons (11:27–30), the journey to Canaan that ends in Harran (11:31), and his death in Harran (11:32). The spotlight only falls on Abram once Terah has stepped down, despite the fact that some of Abram's episodes (such as God's revelation and his journey to Canaan) occur during Terah's lifetime.

This narrative style re-illuminates the correlation between Terah's journey and God's revelation to Abram. As the events are clearly not recorded in chronological order, it is reasonable to assume that Terah's decision to immigrate to Canaan is connected with God's command to Abram to journey to the very same place. In other words, according to the story's narrative sequence (*synzhet*), Terah departs for Canaan before the reader is aware that God had spoken to Abram and commanded him to go, while according to the chronological order

21 Wenham 1994 1–15, 269.

22 Isaac was 60 years old when Jacob was born, and Jacob was 91 when Joseph was born (and so, when Jacob came before Pharaoh he was 130 years old and Joseph was 39). That is to say, when Joseph was born, Isaac was 151 years old, and when Joseph was sold to Egypt at the age of 17, Isaac was 168 years old. Isaac died approximately ten years before Jacob discovered that Joseph was alive and governing Egypt, around the time when Joseph was taken from the pit to interpret Pharaoh's dreams.

of events (*fabula*), after Abram was commanded to go to Canaan, his father Terah decided to join him on his journey.²³

The *fabula*, or chronological sequence of the plot, could therefore be described thus: after God spoke to Abram and commanded him to go to the “land that I will show you,” he shared this information with his father, Terah. A religious man himself, Terah decided to join his son on his journey.

If so, then the revelation to Abram occurred while he was still in Ur of the Chaldeans and spurred the family’s move to Harran, where Terah settled, while Abram and other family members continued to the original destination of Canaan. Some scholars assert that God’s revelation to Abram is written in the past perfect tense. This reading is reflected in various modern translations (e.g., NIV and NKJV); in biblical Hebrew, however, the noun precedes the verb in the past perfect tense (אמר ה’ אל אברם instead of ויאמר ה’ אל אברם).²⁴ Nonetheless, the formulation of the revelation assumes that Abram is in Ur of the Chaldeans at that time, for the following reasons:

1. Abram is commanded to abandon the land in which he was born and raised: “Go forth from *your land* and from *the place of your birth* and from your father’s house” (12:1). Some commentators suggested that Harran is referred to here as Abram’s place of birth and the house of his father. Rashi wrote: “He had already left there with his father, and had come until Harran; however, He said to him, distance yourself from there and leave the house of your father...” According to this commentary, “your land” refers to Ur of the Chaldeans, and not to Abram’s current land of residence, Harran; however, traveling to Canaan takes Abram one step farther from his original native

23 A similar suggestion is offered by medieval commentators, Ibn Ezra and R. David Kimhi, in their commentary on the verse.

24 Cf. Mathews 2005, 108–09. In the discussion below regarding the literary perspective I will comment on the reason the text fails to indicate the past perfect tense in this instance.

land.²⁵ One's land, and the house of one's father, is more commonly a reference to the family's current place of residence, even if the family had only settled there recently. Another possibility is to regard the area of Aram–Naharaim as one geographical unit, without differentiating between Ur of the Chaldeans and Harran.²⁶ All of these possibilities are explored in the literary context of the revelation; in other words, in a continuous reading of the text Abram should be in Harran. From a purely linguistic perspective, the verse is clearly describing Abram in the place of his birth and his native land – Ur of the Chaldeans.

2. God's words to Abram in ch. 15 also assumes that the revelation was in Ur of the Chaldeans: "Then He said to him: I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to assign this land to you as a possession" (15:7).²⁷ Similarly, the Levites chant to the exiled people who returned to Zion: "You are the Lord God, who chose Abram, who brought him out of Ur of the Chaldeans and changed his name to Abraham" (Neh 9:7).²⁸

25 Nahmanides, and later Spero (1996) claimed that Terah's family had always been in Harran, and Terah moved to Ur of the Chaldeans, where Haran was born. Later, he made his way back to his homeland, Harran.

26 See Cassuto 1989, 187–88; Sarna 1989, 358; Wenham 1994, 272; Mathews 2005, 109–11.

27 See especially: Peleg 2007.

28 Perhaps the plural pronoun אִתָּם, "with them," in "Terah took his son Abram, his grandson Lot, the son of Haran, and his daughter-in-law Sarai, the wife of his son Abram, and set out *with them*" (11:31) is an indication that Abram and Terah lead the way together, otherwise, the plural אִתָּם ("with them") is surprising in reference to Terah, and should read אִתּוֹ ("with him"). Some ancient translations, such as the Septuagint and the Vulgate, reflect another variant of the verse and read the word in the active causative tense: וַיֵּצֵא אוֹתָם ("and he took them out"). The Peshitta reads: וַיֵּצֵא (תֵּרָח) אִתָּם ("Terah left with them").

Literary Significance

Despite the logic of presenting the narrative sequence in chronological order, the narrative is not related thus. We are therefore faced with a real gap: according to the *fabula*, Terah began his journey as a result of God's revelation to Abram, while according to the *synzhet* Terah initiated the journey independently, with no correlation to God's message to Abram, which was only delivered at a later point in the story.

Not only does the narrative sequence of events deviate from the actual sequence of events; various verses seem intent on misleading the reader into thinking that Abram received the divine message in Harran, after Terah's journey had begun: "Abram was seventy-five years old *when he left Harran*. Abram took his wife Sarai and his brother's son Lot, and all the wealth that they had amassed, and the people *they had acquired in Harran*; and they set out to go forth²⁹ to the land of Canaan" (12:4–5). The premise of these verses is that Abram sets out from Harran, not Ur of the Chaldeans! Indeed, Abram departed from Harran after his family had settled there; however, Abram's journey had begun in Ur of the Chaldeans when God commanded him to go forth, and the focus on Harran seems unnecessary in this context.

The story is designed to convey the impression that Abram's journey (from Harran) is a continuation of Terah's (from Ur of the Chaldeans), while in fact Abram's journey began at the same time as Terah's. This ambivalence is expressed in the deliberate ambiguity in the description of Abram's journey. The formulation "*and they set out to go forth to the land of Canaan, and they arrived in the land of Canaan*" (12:5) parallels the description of Terah's journey: "*and they set out together from Ur of the Chaldeans for the land of Canaan, but when they arrived in Harran they settled there*" (11:31). This is the standard biblical formulation for traveling from one land to another.³⁰ With regard to Terah's journey, however, the narrator describes the starting point (Ur of the Chaldeans), the destination (Canaan), and the place in which

29 NJPS translated ויצאו ללכת: "and they set out for."

30 Cassuto 1989, 190

they ultimately settled (Harran), while in reference to Abram's journey only two components are mentioned, the destination and the place of arrival: "and they set out to go forth to the land of Canaan, and they arrived in the land of Canaan." The omission of an additional station in Abram's journey is jarring because the initial formulation is identical to that of Terah's journey – but the place of departure is omitted. I believe this omission is intentional, and wishes to avoid unequivocally stating Abram's place of origin. According to the plot the place of departure is Ur of the Chaldeans, but the order in which the plot is delivered conveys that the departure was from Harran. Omitting the "place of departure" component of the standard formulation enables both readings.³¹

Some scholars took the bait and accepted the order of the story without noting the complexity of the plot. Gunn and Fewell wrote:

By the time God's call comes to Abram, he has already left his land and the place of his birth. Abram, along with his father, has already started for the land of Canaan. During the delay in Haran, Abram's father dies. There is nothing to hold him in Haran. God's call comes at an opportune time with an opportune content: Abram is to leave his native land, which he has already done, and his father's house of which there is nothing left, to go to the land that is already the destination of his migration. We might ask ourselves, how much faith does it take to do what one has already decided to do?³²

This reading reflects the vagueness of the unit: the narrative sequence encourages the sense that God's revelation intends to encourage Abram to continue with the process that his father has already initiated. What is the purpose of this method? What is the significance of the disparity between the *fabula* and the *synzbel*?

The focus of the narrator on Terah as an independent protagonist contributes to the analogical design of the two journeys: father and son embark on one journey, which is described to the reader as two separate journeys, enabling the reader to compare the individual experiences of father and son. Both journeys are depicted through a "standard journey formulation"; moreover, the subtle differences

31 For more examples of this technique, see Grossman 2008, 40–41.

32 Gunn & Fewell 1993, 91.

between the two episodes, which are highlighted through the similar formulation of each verse, might carry some significance.³³ But the striking difference is the outcome of the journey: Terah set out for Canaan but only got as far as Harran, while Abram set out for Canaan and indeed arrived in the land of Canaan. Another background difference differentiates between the two journeys: the narrator omits the reason for Terah's journey, and the reader has no reason to believe the reason behind it is anything but his own free will. In contrast, Abram embarks on his journey "as the Lord had commanded him" (12:4). Even if both characters did leave together, there is a literary purpose in presenting the story through two different journeys: one without cause or purpose, which does not culminate in the desired destination, and the other ordained by God, culminating in the desired destination of Canaan.

The narrative initiates the relationship between Abram and Canaan, and is designed to convey that this relationship is based on God's command, not on Abram's personal choice or preference. This is the reason Abram does not remain in Harran, despite the comforts of the progressive civilization found there at the time. The advantages of Harran might have impressed Terah, who embarked on his journey by choice, while Abram was bound to the will of God, and therefore continued to Canaan. Terah's journey precedes Abram's so that the reader can contrast Terah's choice to remain in Harran with the choice of his son to follow God's command.³⁴

33 Kiel proposed that the omission of property from the description of Terah's departure from Ur of the Chaldeans (in contrast with the mention of property in the description of Abram's departure), proves that Terah and his family fled from Ur of the Chaldeans due to fear of the local government, and thus did not take their belongings with them (Kiel 1997, 205). (See also b. B. Bat. 91a, which states that Abram was taken prisoner in Ur of the Chaldeans; also Genesis Rabbah 38:13). R. Joseph Bekhor Shor suggested that the narrator's focus on Abram taking his property is to his merit, as the reader senses that Abram is not migrating in order to explore the possibility of settling a new land, but as a permanent and final move. See more on this matter below.

34 Compare with Peleg 2006. According to Peleg, the narrator omits the reasons for Terah's departure from Ur of the Chaldeans because Terah is a secondary character, and only information that is needed to further the plot is provided

Another significant difference between the two journeys is expressed through the verb ending the journey. Terah and his family “arrived in Harran” and “settled there,” while Abram’s group “arrived in the land of Canaan.” The comparable settling in Canaan does not take place at this point in time; Abram continued his journeys through Canaan until he reached Mamreh, and only there does the narrator conclude: “And Abram...came and settled³⁵ in the terebinths of Mamre” (13:18). The postponement of settlement in Canaan is linked with the reason Abram is told to walk through the land.

Despite the differences, the story is designed to convey the feeling that Abram’s journey is a continuation of Terah’s; this is the reason Abram is described as departing from Harran (12:4–5), the very place Terah had ended his journey.³⁶ Abram’s journey is therefore presented ambivalently: while Abram obeys God’s command and leaves his native land to go toward the unknown, he chooses to take Lot (and his possessions) along with him, elements that seem to be continuous to his father’s journey. Lot is described twice in joining Abram’s convoy: “Abram went forth as the Lord had commanded him, *and Lot went with him*” (12:4); “Abram took his wife Sarai *and his brother’s son Lot*” (12:5).

Verse 4 attributes the initiative to join Abram as Lot’s, whereas v. 5 describes Abram taking Lot with him. There is no indication of the narrator’s assessment of this act; however, Lot joining the journey seems to contradict God’s command to disengage from Terah’s family. Cotter compares Abram’s first test of faith: “Go forth from your

with regard to secondary characters. I believe the narrator’s silence here is critical, as the literary purpose of Terah’s character in the narrative is to go without a particular reason, and of his own volition. In this way, Terah is contrasted with Abram’s character.

35 NJPS translated **וַיָּבֹא וַיֵּשֶׁב** – “and came to dwell,” despite the fact that the Hebrew text uses the same root **יָשַׁב** in both cases.

36 Perhaps the emphasis on the move “from Harran” intends to demonstrate the difference between Terah and Abram; whereas it is Terah’s own decision to stay in Harran, Abram is obligated by divine decree to leave Harran and continue to Canaan. Perhaps this is also the reason that Abram’s age (v. 4) and the people accompanying him (v. 5) are mentioned in context of the departure from Harran.

land” (12:1) with his last: “Go forth to the land of Moriah” (22:2), and asserted that Abram only succeeded in proving his faithfulness in the second test, when he disengaged from his son, since by taking Lot he failed to disengage from the house of his father.³⁷ The order of v. 4 expresses a certain discomfort with Lot’s inclusion: “Abram went forth *as the Lord had commanded him*, and Lot went with him.” Abram went forth, thus fulfilling God’s command; Lot’s inclusion is technically outside the parameters of this command, and its place in the sentence structure is an expression of this.³⁸

At this point, Abram does not seem to be criticized for taking his possessions; later in the narrative, however, the matter of property (specifically in the context of Lot’s role) is debated. The ambivalence toward possessions and Lot’s role in the journey is addressed in the following narratives.

In conclusion, the narrative design, which presents Abram’s journey to Canaan as an extension of Terah’s, conveys a certain criticism of Abram’s perception of his journey. The similarities in the depiction of the two journeys highlight the contrast between them; only the journey sanctioned by God concludes in the desired destination. Conversely, the stylistic similarity also generates continuity between Terah, who took his family, and Abram, who was commanded to disengage from the house of his father, but, like his father, also takes his family with him.

This criticism cannot diminish the magnitude of self-sacrifice: leaving Ur of the Chaldeans and going toward the unknown on God’s command is ultimately praiseworthy. The first chapters of Abram’s story, therefore, paint a complex picture of Abram, who faithfully follows God’s command and journeys to Canaan; Abram, who physically abandons the house of his father, but maintains an emotional bond by following in his path.

37 Cotter 2003, 84–85, 90–91. A similar approach was proposed by Andrew Vaughn (2004).

38 Breuer 1999, 228.

Chapter 2: Abram's Journey to Canaan (12:1–9)

The Omitted Introduction

Learning from omission is challenging, particularly with regard to the succinct style of biblical narrative. Nonetheless, sometimes the silence of the text is so powerful that it cannot be ignored.¹ The fact that no details are given regarding Abram's character prior to God's revelation is surprising. The reader is supplied with Terah's genealogy, including such details as Sarai's barrenness and the tragedy of orphaned Lot, but no information is supplied about Abram himself to explain why he stands out, and why he is an appropriate choice for the position assigned to him by God. A comparison between Abram and Moses will reveal this notable difference: Moses' story is complex, and includes such components as his birth and escape from Pharaoh's edict, as well as a rare and highly evolved moral personality that is expressed through his actions in Egypt and Midian (Ex 2). These stories are an appropriate introduction, which provides the reader with the information necessary to understand God's revelation to Moses through the burning bush (Ex 3). The absence of a similar story about Abram, and the reason behind God's choice, is troubling. Early midrashic literature sought to fill this void, and integrated foundations of Abram's devotion and escape from the edict of a king, similar to Moses.² The midrashic literature might reflect earlier traditions that were rejected in

1 Cf. Bachar 2007. He studied the silence of characters who do not respond when addressed. In these instances, attributing a literary purpose to the silence is plausible. However, he also includes instances in which there is an expectation for the clarification of an issue, and yet the narrator remains silent, without satisfying the expectation of the readers (pp. 20–21). My reference relates to the insufficient delivery of details in the narrative, when an omission may occasionally have a rhetorical purpose.

2 See *Book of Jubilees*, chs. 11–12. See also Ginzberg 1961, vol. 1, 203–06.

the canonical text of Genesis,³ or an attempt to creatively fill the void in the text. One way or another, the omission of Abram's past requires consideration.

This vacuum makes two contributions to the narrative: Firstly, the omission highlights the centrality of choice in the Abraham cycle. The reader seeks Abram's unique qualities within the stories themselves, without being exposed to those characteristics from the outset. The experience of reading the story cycle is best described by the Mishnah: "Ten tests were given to Abram...and he endured them all, to show the affection of God toward Abram" (*m. Avot* 5:3). Since the reason Abram is singled out is not given, the reader seeks a justification for God's choice through Abram's behavior throughout the cycle.

A second aspect of the silence relates to the theological statement expressed by the omission. An introductory story to the concept of choice portrays the choice as conditional. If Abram had been selected for his principles, or for his devoutness, or for any other quality, then the absence of that same attribute in Abram later on, or in his descendants, might lead to questioning the initial choice. The silence of the narrator makes God's choice of Abram indisputable and unconditional.

Go Forth

The verb **הלך** ("go" or "walk") is a key word and an evolving motif in the Abraham cycle. Both Abram's initial revelation in Ur of the Chaldeans and his final revelation in which he was commanded to sacrifice his son were formulated using this verb (12:1 and 22:2), and on other occasions Abram is also commanded to "walk" (13:17; 17:1). The concept of walking or going forth is linked with the shaping of an

3 As formulated by Zakovitch (1999). Zakovitch demonstrates this theory from the use of the verb **צלה**, which indicates rescue and escape (p. 437). See also Cassuto 1964, 186; Zakovitch and Shinan 2004, 129–37.

active and dynamic character. Moreover, walking and traveling represent spiritual vitality and the capacity to begin anew. Abram is expected to leave one land and make room for another, both on the geographical and emotional planes.⁴ The boundlessness is expressed by the fact that the initial command omits the destination,⁵ and instead focuses on what is being left behind.⁶

The demand to abandon the familiar location is presented in stages:⁷ “The Lord said to Abram, ‘Go forth from your land and from the place of your birth and from your father’s house to the land that I will show you.’” The command opens with “your land,” and then uses a term with a heavier association of personal connection – “the place of your birth.” An even more difficult demand is the separation from “your father’s house.” The gradual emphasis reflects the growing demand of Abram’s complete and total disengagement, and indicates the challenge of the command. This feeling is intensified by the double meaning of the word מולדת, which sometimes is used to refer to a place of birth (e.g., Gen 31:13) and other times implies family (e.g., Gen 48:6; 18:9 and 11).⁸ Both denotations seem equally relevant in this context, and this seems to be a case of “Janus Parallelism,”⁹ as

4 Cf. Poirier 2008.

5 Compare with the parallel command in the binding of Isaac: “go forth to the land of Moriah,” and with Genesis Rabbah 39:9: “R. Levi said, two times it is stated ‘go forth,’ and we do not know which is more favorable, the first or the second; but since the second says ‘to the land of Moriah,’ we now know the second is more favorable than the first.” Cf. Hamilton, who noted the stylistic parallel between the two commandments (Hamilton 1995, 370–71; 376). See also discussion below about the commandment in the context of the binding of Isaac.

6 Muraoka (1978) suggested that the linguistic function of the preposition לך (literally: “for you”) in the phrase לך לך is to focus on the character who takes action, and differentiate the character from their surroundings. This distinction creates an independent identity through differentiation. Rashi’s commentary reflects a similar reading: “Go forth – for your own benefit.”

7 Cf. Hamilton 1990, 369; Cotter 2003, 90.

8 BDB, 409; Kaddari 2006, 588.

9 This type of double meaning is termed “Janus Parallelism,” after the two-faced Roman god Janus, who had a face in front and back, and would sit at the gate

the concept falls between “your land” (and מולדתך means “the place of your birth”),¹⁰ and “your father’s house” (and מולדתך means the extended family). This repetition further emphasizes the demand for a total disengagement from his past, particularly from land and family. Identity and self-perception are fundamentally linked with one’s family and land; this is true in the modern world, but was infinitely more significant in the biblical era. Abram’s disengagement from both will turn him into an isolated individual with no familial ties. Abram’s disengagement is an essential step in anticipation of building a new and different life. The two aspects emphasized in the demand to disengage are addressed in God’s promises of land and family. The command to “Go forth” is not only geographical in nature, but emotional and cultural as well.¹¹ Later (15:7), God will intimate that Abram was “reborn” when he left Ur of the Chaldeans, and God’s protection of Abram is a replacement of the more common protection offered by one’s family.

In context, the blessing that accompanies the demand seems to be conditional:

I will make you a great nation,
 And I will bless you;
 I will make your name great,
 And you shall be a blessing
 I will bless those who bless you
 And curse him who curses you;
 And all the families of the earth shall be blessed by you.¹²

and watch those who entered and exited the city. For additional examples, see Noegel 1996.

10 In other words, together with ארצך, “your land,” which opens the command, the term should be read as a hendiadys – one concept divided into two words. The hendiadys is common in abstract nouns (Brongers 1965, 109–14), but is frequently used in concrete nouns as well. See Alter 2004, 62.

11 Sarna noted that the creation of a monotheistic religion in the area at that time was utterly inconceivable for several reasons, but particularly due to the religious culture. Mesopotamia at the time was inundated with gods. Every geographical location and every structure were steeped in symbols of idolatry (Sarna 1989, 101). See more on Abram’s journey in the land below.

12 NJPS translated – וברכו בך “shall bless themselves by you.”

If Abram obeys God's command to disengage from his land and family, and go to the land that God will show him, he will receive these blessings. Therefore, by following the realization of the blessings the reader can also estimate the level of Abram's devotion to his mission.

God's blessing to Abram has four components, and the division of verses reflects the two parts of the blessing.¹³ Each of the three elements in the first verse relate to a different aspect of the blessing, as follows.

"I will make you a great nation"

God's first promise to Abram is that he will become "a great nation." This promise balances the demand of Abram to disengage from the house of his father. The purpose of severing connections with the past is creating a future based on the roots of Abram himself, as mentioned in the introduction. The surprising use of "nation" in this context indicates a national aspect, well beyond the nuclear family.¹⁴ The phrase "a great nation" will crop up again in the narrative cycle, in relation to both Abram (18:18) and Ishmael (17:20; 21:18), and beyond the story cycle, in the Jacob narrative (46:3).¹⁵ Each appearance of the phrase is a reminder of God's initial revelation to Abram. When Moses is told: "Now...that I may destroy them and make of you a *great*

13 Carrol (2000, 21) suggested a different division. According to his position, the statement "and you shall be a blessing" is part of the second half of the promise. In his view, both parts of the promise begin with an imperative: "go forth" and "you shall be a blessing."

14 Speiser 1964, 162–63.

15 On the similarity between Abram and Jacob's revelations (Gen 41:1–5), see Westermann 1995, 147. Assuming the Jacob narrative refers to the Abraham narrative (in contrast with Weisman 1989), the link should be perceived as a comfort to Jacob, who is required to leave his home and go to Egypt. But God promises him that He will accompany him on his journey, just as He had accompanied his grandfather.

nation” (Ex 22:10), this is an indication that God wishes to turn Moses into “Abram,” the father of the new nation.¹⁶

“I will bless you”

The second element of the blessing is more ambiguous; it is unclear how this blessing will be realized. Mathews proposes that this blessing is a promise of material wealth.¹⁷ Indeed, the term “blessing” has two main meanings in the book of Genesis: family and prosperity.¹⁸ As God has already promised Abram that he will become a great nation, the second blessing probably refers to wealth. The concept of riches as a blessing is established later in the text; throughout the story cycle wealth is regarded as both a blessing (13:2) and a point of contention (13:5–13). Another possibility is that this repetition is mere formality to establish the motif of blessing in God’s first revelation to Abram, artistic repetition that adds no new meaning in itself.¹⁹

“I will make your name great”

The term “great” was mentioned earlier in the verse in the context of the nation Abram was destined to become, and is now used in connection with Abram himself. Joseph Bekhor Shor wrote: “your name and nature will become known and apparent to all”;²⁰ the greatness of a person is measured against the people around him, and relates to his relationship with his surroundings. The formulation might be taken to create an implicit dialogue with the story of the Tower of Babel. The builders of the tower are described as wishing to make a name for themselves: “Come let us build us a city, and a tower with its top in the

16 See, e.g., Goldingay 1987, 411. The Septuagint was aware of this option (Suomala 2004, 47).

17 Mathews 2005, 113.

18 See with regard to Isaac, Gen 27:12 and 29.

19 Hamilton 1990, 372.

20 Joseph Bekhor Shor, commentary on Gen 12:2.

sky, to make a name for ourselves, else we shall be scattered all over the world” (11:4). Now God intends to “scatter” Abram in the land, while promising him that he shall “make his name” great. The story of the Tower of Babel should be viewed as introductory to the Abraham cycle: the concept of creating a unique and chosen nation can only be discussed after the scattering of the nations, which enabled cultural diversity and the ability to privilege one nation over another. However, the statement to Abram is poignant: one cannot make a name for oneself, as the builders of the tower had believed; God is the only one who could “make a great name” for the one to walk in His path.²¹

Sarna viewed the blessing literally: Abram’s name will be made “greater” when it is expanded to Abraham.²² The concept is intriguing, as the name change is linked with the fact that Abraham will become “father of a multitude of nations” (17:5). This is an expansion of the initial blessing according to which Abram will become a “great nation.” According to this interpretation, the extension of the name indicates an expansion of the initial blessing from “a great nation” to “a multitude of nations.”²³

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- 21 See Hamilton 1990, 372; Awabdy 2010; Levenson 2012, 19. Jenkins also linked “to make a name” (11:4) with “I will make your name great.” He argued that this is a motif that strings together all the stories of the Patriarchs, and the book of Genesis in general; there is an apparent effort in these verses to create a “literary bridge” between the initiation stories in Genesis and the stories of the Patriarchs. Mann presents Abram’s election as a solution for the problems of chapters 1–11, emphasizing that through Abraham, blessing is channeled to the world instead of curse (Mann 1991). Similarly, see Noort 2010 – Abraham, 21–22; 29–30: “The accumulation of blessings indeed counteracts Gen 1–11.” Jenkins linked the naming motif with the selection of the chosen offspring, which could save humanity from its primal sins (as demonstrated in the verses about Noah: “And he named him Noah, saying, this will provide us relief from our work and from the toil of our hands, out of the very soil that the Lord had placed under a curse” (5:29). See Jenkins 1978; Carrol 2000, 21; Awabdy 2010.
- 22 Sarna 1989, 124. This approach was previously established by R. Hezekiah ben Manoah in his commentary, *Hizkuni* on Gen 17. See also Genesis Rabbah 29:11; Mathews 2005, 114.
- 23 This reading touches on the question of plot development throughout the story cycle. It is possible that the blessing of a multitude of nations is the result of Ismael’s birth (as described in ch. 16). Had Hagar not been given to Abram,

The fourth element of the blessing, in v. 3, looks beyond Abram and relates to those who surround him: those who bless Abram shall be blessed, and he shall be a blessing to all the nations.²⁴ As I discuss in the introduction, the blessing of Abram does not contradict the blessing of the surrounding nations; rather, it expands and spreads the blessing.²⁵

The key word that stands out in this short unit is בְּרָכָה (“blessing”), which is repeated five times. Wenham noted the wordplay between Abram’s name – אַבְרָם – and the words נֶאְבְּרָכָה (“I shall bless you”) and נֶאְבְּרָכָה מְבָרְכֶיךָ (“I will bless those who bless you”).²⁶ However, tracking the root reveals the implied development: initially, Abram is blessed by God (“I will bless you”), but ultimately his blessing will be spread to others around him; at first those who are close to him or identify with his cause (“I will bless those who bless you”) and eventually all of humanity (“And all the families of the earth shall be blessed by you”).²⁷ Moreover, initially God is the one blessing Abram and his surroundings, but in conclusion the formulation indicates that Abram himself will become the source of blessing: “And all the families of the earth shall be blessed by you.”

The transition from Abram’s blessing to the blessing that affects all nations is expressed with a peculiar phrase: “and you shall be a blessing.” How can a person become “a blessing?” Various interpretations were offered for the verse; some scholars chose to emend the text.²⁸

only one nation would have been destined to come from him. At this point in the plot there is no indication of a multitude of nations.

24 I believe the verb וְנִבְרַכְתָּ is passive, similar to הִתְבְּרַכְתָּ, meaning “they shall be blessed” (cf. Kiel, Cassuto, Hamilton, Sarna, Alexander and others), and not reflexive, meaning that the gentiles will use Abram’s name to bless themselves (cf. von Rad, Speiser, Albrectson and Noort). Carrol (2000, 23–24) suggests a median approach, according to which Abram acts as an agent for blessing the nations of the world, and also as a model of faith that the nations would adopt. See more: Lenzen 2011.

25 Cf. Carrol 2000, 22.

26 Wenham 1987, 276.

27 See Westermann 1995, 146.

28 The Septuagint and Onkelus read “you shall be filled with blessing,” and various scholars accepted this formulation (e.g., Dillmann, Procksch and Schmidt).

The most convenient reading was the one suggested by Kiel, Delitzsch, Wolff, and Westermann, preceded by Rashi, who wrote: “The blessings are entrusted into your hand. Until now, they were in My hand; I blessed Adam and Noah. From now on, you may bless whomever you wish.”²⁹ The verses imply that Abram becomes a source of blessing for others.³⁰ In light of the introduction’s discussion of the dichotomic aspects of Abraham’s election, it can be noted that this phrase creates a delicate balance between the first half of the blessing, which designates him as the father of the chosen nation, and his moral obligation to bring blessing to his environment. He is not only blessed himself; he will channel blessing to all nations of the earth.

Nahmanides viewed the verse as an indication that the name of Abram will become an expression of blessing, along the lines of “by you shall Israel invoke blessings, saying: God make you like Ephraim and Menashe” (Gen 48:20). Cassuto (1964, 313–14) accepted this approach based on Zachariah 8:13 (see also Wenham 1987, 276). Gunkel (1966, 164) suggested changing the vowels to וְהָיָה בְרָכָה (“and he was a blessing”) in reference to Abram, and idea that might be based on the Samaritan, while Winkler suggested וְהָיָה אֲבִרְכָה (See Gunkel, *ibid.*). See also Baden 2010, 227–30.

- 29 Ed Greenstein mentioned (in private conversation) that the process described here can be compared to the convention of naming in the two creation stories: in the first narrative, God gave names; in the second narrative, man is the one who names the animals.
- 30 Wenham noted that the five appearances of the root “to bless” parallel five curses mentioned up to this point in Genesis (3:14 and 17; 4:11; 5:29; 9:25). See also Mann 1991, 341–353; Noort 2010 – Abraham, 29–30. Cassuto asserted that there are seven indications of blessing; he adds “I will make you a great nation” and “I will make your name great” to the explicit mentions of the root, since “Seven is the number of perfection and the blessing bestowed upon Abram is perfect and complete” (Cassuto 1964, 312). Regarding the biblical tendency to create lists with seven components, see Gordis 1976, 19. Carroll (2000) also identifies “bless” as an antithesis to the curse that had accompanied man from the beginning of the book, and indicates that the revelation to Abram is the turning point of human history, which recognized the potential in Abram’s offspring to overcome the evils of history.

Abram's Journey

Before the reader is given the chance to hear Abram's thoughts and feelings regarding God's surprising command, Abram is already on his way: "Abram went forth as the Lord had commanded him," as Hamilton wrote: "God speaks and the narrator speaks, but Abram is silent."³¹ Obedience will become a recurring theme in the Abraham narrative. In the context of the previous discussion, Abram is led by others, without expressing his own position in the matter – like a newborn.

One of the differences mentioned above between Terah's journey and the journey of Abram was expressed in the culmination of the journey: Terah's destination was Canaan, but his journey ended in Harran (11:31), while Abram's journey ended in the desired destination (12:5). However, while the verse states that Terah "settled" in Harran, Abram is said to have arrived in Canaan, but no "settling" is mentioned. The shortening of the standard formula cannot be ignored in this instance, since settlement is deeply significant when one travels from one location to another. God's promises create an expectation that Abram will successfully "settle" in his new land; the omission of this standard detail is surprising.

However, as Abram's story continues to unfold the reader will discover that the verb is not omitted; it is merely postponed. Abram continues to travel through Canaan, and in Bethel he is commanded: "Up, walk about the land, through its length and its breadth" (13:17). Abram only "settles" when he reaches the city of Hebron: "And Abram...came and settled³² in the terebinths of Mamre" (13:18).³³

31 Hamilton 1990, 376.

32 NJPS translated **וַיָּבֵא וַיֵּשֶׁב** – "and came to dwell."

33 The verb does make one other previous appearance in the context of Abram's separation from Lot: "Abram settled in the land of Canaan, while Lot settled in the cities of the plain, pitching his tents near Sodom" (13:12). However, this stage cannot possibly be viewed as the conclusion of the journey, or the "settling down" that the reader has come to expect, since immediately afterward God commands Abram to travel across the land. The purpose of the verb in

The postponement has dramatic significance with regard to understanding the function of the stories placed between Abram's arrival in Canaan and his settlement in Hebron (chs. 12–13). Only after Abram has gone through his experiences in Egypt (12) and separated from Lot (13) does he truly merit settling in the land of Canaan. The larger literary unit is therefore constructed as follows:

1. God commands Abram: Go Forth.
2. Implementation, stage I: Abram journeys to Shechem and builds an altar.
3. Implementation, stage II: Abram journeys to Bethel and builds an altar.
4. Interjection A: Abram goes to Egypt due to the famine, and then returns to Bethel.
5. Interjection B: Abram separates from Lot, and experiences another revelation.
6. Implementation, stage III (final): Abram journeys to Hebron, settles there, and builds an altar.

This structure explains the two interruptions of the general story – Abram's detour to Egypt, where he nearly loses his wife, and the conflict between the herdsmen, which leads to Abram's separation from Lot.

The first stage of implementation begins with a double description of Abram's actions: "Abram went forth as the Lord had commanded him, and Lot went with him; Abram was seventy-five years old when he left Harran" (12:4). The following verse repeats the description of Abram's departure from Harran: "Abram took his wife Sarai and his brother's son Lot, and all the wealth they had amassed, and the persons they had acquired in Harran, and they set out to go forth to the land of Canaan, and they arrived in the land of Canaan" (12:5). The verse does take the journey one step further, since the party's arrival in

this context is to contrast Lot's settling in Sodom with Abram, who remained in Canaan.

Canaan is mentioned; but why is the fact that they had departed from Harran, which appears in the previous verse, repeated here?³⁴

Diachronic scholars have attributed the repetition to the combination of various documents in the text.³⁵ But this writing style is prevalent throughout the Bible: the narrator describes a general action, and then provides more detailed information. Abram is said to have obeyed God's command to go forth; the following verse gives the details of Abram's departure from Harran. This literary style gives the narrator the opportunity to emphasize specific features in the general description; in this case, the emphasis is on Lot. Sarai, the wealth, and the acquired people, are not mentioned initially; only Lot seems to accompany Abram: "and Lot went with him." At first glance the reader might think that Lot's unique status is the reason for his exclusive mention. Some scholars believe that Lot is set up as an antagonist alongside Abram. Lot is indeed introduced as the viable male heir for Terah's family; his father is deceased; he has two sisters, but no brothers; Abram's wife, Sarai, is barren. Since Nahor failed to accompany his father on his journey to Harran, the future of the family seems to depend on Lot.³⁶ According to this approach, Terah's story is continued through Lot. This fascinating approach is difficult to accept. First, the fact that Nahor did not join Terah on his journey does not preclude him from continuing the family line. More importantly, since Lot will play a significant literary role in the Abraham narrative cycle,

34 The verb **הלך** (translated here: "went forth"/"set out") is used in both verses. Use of this verb in the context of the implementation of God's command mirrors the formulation of the command itself: **לך לך** ("go forth"); however, as we have already mentioned, the verb becomes a key phrase throughout the entire unit. Some translations substituted **הלך** with the verb "departed"; King James Bible translated v. 4: "So Abram departed, as the Lord had spoken unto him... and *they went forth* to go into the land of Canaan." NIV substituted the verb in both places: "So Abram left, as the Lord had told him...and they set out for the land of Canaan, and they arrived there." While the text flows better according to these translations, the reader misses out on the delicate wordplay around the integration of this verb, as we will demonstrate below.

35 E.g., Skinner 1930, 245; Westermann 1995, 152–53.

36 Hamilton 1990, 326.

the more likely reason to focus on his character is for the purpose of highlighting Abram's character.

The correlation between the two verses indicates a tension in the delicate relationship between Abram and Lot. In v. 5 Lot is named as one of the many elements that are included in Abram's journey. Lot is Abram's ward, his adopted nephew; he is thus displayed as one who has no free will. In contrast, the general formulation of v. 4 indicates that Lot is an independent being, who joins Abram on his journey by choice. Here, Lot cannot be portrayed as Abram's subordinate; he is separated from the list since he is an independent character with free choice. There is no need to mention Sarai, not because of her lesser importance, but because she is perceived as an organic part of Abram's family; the reader expects her to accompany her husband. In contrast, the mention of Lot in the general description of Abram's journey separates him from the rest of the group. Lot accompanies Abram, despite the fact that he is not an integral part of Abram's journey. This tension relates to a broader issue that is clarified through the stories of Abram's initial tentative travels in Canaan: should Abram have taken Lot with him, despite God's demand to disengage from his father's house? Is Lot's accompaniment of Abram an indication that Abram did not fully withstand the trial of separating from his past,³⁷ and that the separation from his father's house was too difficult a trial to endure?³⁸

On some level, the same dilemma arises with regard to the assets that Abram took along. The description of "the wealth that they had amassed" deviates from the comparison with Terah's journey (11:29–30). If this is a consistent biblical formulation, there is room to explore and compare the appearance of wealth in various episodes.³⁹ Property is not mentioned in the context of Terah's journey, since there is no

37 Cotter 2003, 91.

38 Vaughn (2004, 117–23) wrote similarly, that Abram did not adopt Lot formally; therefore Lot falls into the category of "the house of Abram's father." However, he asserted that the lack of a more complete obedience creates a sense of development in Abram's personality, until his final trial of obeying God's command in the binding of Isaac.

39 Cassuto 1964, 277–78. Cf. Gen 36:30.

particular significance in what Terah took with him on his journey. In contrast, Esau's possessions are mentioned on his journey to Edom, since the wealth of possessions was the reason for his departure: "For their possessions were too many for them to dwell together, and the land where they sojourned could not support them because of their livestock" (36:7).

In what way does mentioning Abram's property contribute to the purpose of the narrative? Perhaps the developing motif of property in the initial stories of the cycle (12–15) should be read as a reaction to the fact that Abram takes his wealth when he departs from Ur of the Chaldeans. Taking possessions might be another example of Abram's reluctance to wholeheartedly obey God's command; is there indeed an expectation that Abram will neglect his possessions and start over financially as well? This quandary will be addressed in the ongoing saga involving Abram's possessions throughout the narrative cycle.

Abram's Journey in Canaan and the Construction of Altars

Abram's travels through the land can be separated into three sections, each culminating in the construction of an altar:

1. Ur of the Chaldeans/Harran → Shechem: "And he built there an altar" – 12:7
2. Shechem → Bethel: "And he built there an altar" – 12:8
3. Bethel → Hebron: "And he built there an altar" – 13:18

There are three central stations in Abram's journey through the land: Shechem, Bethel, and Hebron. Why does Abram stop in these places and build altars? Rashi links the location of the altars with future Israelite history, noting that Abram prayed for the good fortune of

his offspring in places of need.⁴⁰ Rashi omitted an explanation about Abram's settlement in Hebron, since Hebron was perceived as the final destination, rather than a station. On a literary plane, the locations are linked with the perception of the patriarchal stories as foreshadowing future national events.⁴¹

The stations of Abram's journey include the central cities in Israel's central mountain ridge, which can be viewed as the "spine of the land" (see Josh 20:7). Two valleys emerge from the central mountain: the west coast valley in the west, and the Jordan valley in the east. The cities mentioned in Abram's journey were settled in the patriarchal era.⁴² The reader is not told about encounters between Abram and the locals; but Abram sets up camp in settled areas and builds altars, creating a religious-cultural alternative in those major cities. Perhaps this idea is alluded to in the narrator's comment on Abram's first stop, in Shechem: "Abram passed through the land as far as the site of Shechem, at the terebinths of Moreh; *the Canaanites were then in the land*" (12:6). This statement reflects the silent conflict that is beginning to come to realization in the land of Canaan.⁴³ Gitay wrote in reference to Abram's altars that Canaan is not a regular territory that Abram intends to settle; it is a holy place, which one merits the right to settle through one's relationship with God, by building altars.⁴⁴

Elizur noted that Abram built his altars near the cities but did not enter the cities.⁴⁵ Abram reached "[a]s far as *the site* of Shechem,

40 Rashi on Gen 12:6: "until the place of Shechem: to pray for Jacob's sons when they would come to wage war in Shechem," and 12:8: "and there he built an altar: He prophesied that his sons were destined to stumble there because of the iniquity of Achan, and he prayed there for them."

41 See in particular, Cassuto 1964, 303–06.

42 Regarding Shechem, see Toombs 1972; Achituv, Shechem. Regarding Bethel and Ai, see Brodsky, Bethel; Cassuto 1954; Calloway, Ai.

43 One might argue that the narrator's choice to ignore Abram's encounters with the local tribes creates the impression that Abram travels as an independent personality, with no regard of, or interest in, the social and cultural conditions of the land.

44 Gitay 1996, 209.

45 Elizur 1984.

at the terebinths of Moreh,” but did not go into Shechem.⁴⁶ Similarly, it is related in regard to Bethel: “From there he moved on to the hill country *east of Bethel* and pitched his tent, with *Bethel on the west and Ai on the east*”;⁴⁷ Abram does not settle *in* the Canaanite city; he settles east of it, between Bethel and Ai. Only in Hebron is there room to debate whether he actually entered the city: “And Abram moved his tent, and came and settled in the terebinths of Mamre, which are in Hebron” (13:18). Most scholars agree that Mamreh is not Hebron, but rather 2 kilometers north of the city.⁴⁸ Elizur thus concluded that Abram’s plan was calculated, and that wandering is in fact the alternative to the Canaanite culture: instead of becoming a citizen of the city, Abram settles outside it.⁴⁹

The two following episodes, Abram’s detour to Egypt (12:10–20) and Abram’s separation from Lot (13:1–14), interrupt the storyline of Abram’s wanderings in the land. These two episodes will be discussed at length. Nonetheless, Abram’s travels should be read comparatively. The events in Bethel are separated into two episodes, which take place before (Bethel I) and after (Bethel II) Abram’s descent to Egypt, and Abram’s separation from Lot.

46 Some scholars equated “site” with “temple,” similar to the common Deuteronomy phrase, “the site that the Lord will choose.” This is also alluded in the binding of Isaac (Gen 22:3, 4, and 9) (Skinner 1930, 246). However, Cassuto (1964, 323–24) wrote appropriately that even if the locations were sacred, the indication of their status would not emerge from the description as “site,” but rather from the context.

47 Cooper and Goldstein (1997, 205, note 17) noted that the verb יָטָא (“pitched”) in reference to pitching a tent is only used with regard to the patriarchs and Moses. They believe the verb serves as a link between the tent of Moses and that of the patriarchs.

48 E.g., Hamilton 1990, 395.

49 Cassuto (1964, 324) asserted that the reason behind Abram’s wanderings was his (and Lot’s) chosen profession as a shepherd: “and they undoubtedly did not pitch their tents in the city but in its environs, in the area that was uninhabited and uncultivated, in the region that could serve, without let or hindrance, as a site for the dwelling of the shepherds.”

| <i>Shechem</i> (12:6–7) | <i>Bethel I</i> (12:8) | <i>Bethel II</i> (13:3–17) | <i>Hebron</i> (13:18) |
|--|--|--|---|
| <p>Abram passed through the land
As far as the site of Shechem
At the terebinths of Moreh</p> <p>The Canaanites were then in the land
The Lord appeared to Abram and said: “I will assign this land to your offspring”</p> <p>And he built there an altar to the Lord who had appeared to him.</p> | <p>From there he moved on to the hill country east of Bethel and pitched his tent, with Bethel on the west and Ai on the east</p> <p>And he built there an altar to the Lord and invoked the Lord by name.</p> | <p>(13:3) And he proceeded by stages from the Negeb as far as Bethel, to the place where his tent had been formerly, between Bethel and Ai</p> <p>(13:7) And the Canaanites and the Perizzites were then dwelling in the land
(13:14) And the Lord said to Abram after Lot had parted from him: Raise your eyes and look out from where you are, to the north and south, to the east and west, for I give all the land that you see to you and your offspring forever.
I will make your offspring as the dust of the earth, so that if one can count the dust of the earth, then your offspring too can be counted.
Up, walk about the land, through its length and its breadth, for I give it to you.</p> | <p>And Abram moved his tent
And came and settled in the terebinths of Mamre, which are in Hebron.</p> <p>And he built an altar there to the Lord.</p> |

Three consistent features characterize Abram's wanderings:

1. Abram travels throughout the land, and arrives at a given station (with an indication that the Canaanites are dwelling in that area).
2. God speaks to Abram, and blesses him.
3. Abram builds an altar.

All three components are present at Shechem: Abram arrives at the location; God reveals Himself and promises Abram the inheritance of the land; and Abram builds an altar.⁵⁰ One unique feature of this revelation is the actual revelation: "The Lord appeared to Abram," in contrast to Ur of the Chaldeans, where God speaks to Abram but does not appear to him. This element is given great significance; only when Abram builds an altar in Shechem is he said to have built an altar "to the Lord who had appeared to him." Apparently, in Canaan God can be seen, and not only heard.

In Bethel, all of the features are present, but divided between Abram's two excursions to Bethel. The revelation and the promise are only given to Abram after the Egypt episode, and more significantly – as the narrator emphasizes – "after Lot had parted from him." This element will be discussed at length in the following chapters. In Bethel, building an altar does not suffice; Abraham also "invoked the Lord by name" (12:8; 13:4).

In Hebron, the Canaanites are not mentioned; and although Abram builds an altar, God does not appear to Abram, by vision or voice. At first glance the reader might wonder about the absence of a revelation in Hebron, but in fact the question should be why is there a need for two successive revelations in Shechem and Bethel? Why

50 Westermann believed that the promise of the land in this episode is secondary, since the mention of offspring, and use of the verb נָתַן ("assign") do not correlate with Abram's current situation (Westermann 1980, 146–47). Others asserted that the revelation is appropriate in this place (e.g., Emerton 1982). As stated above, since the revelation in Ur of the Chaldeans makes no explicit identification of the land, the purpose of the revelation in Shechem is to indicate that Canaan is the destination of the journey and the object of God's promise.

does Abram need a reinforcement of the promises of land and offspring throughout his first journey in the land? Abram finally settles in Hebron, and merits revelations and blessings. Why is the revelation in Shechem insufficient? Why are the promises given in two different locations?

Perhaps the repetition relates to the fact that the Canaanites dwelt in the area at that time, which is mentioned with regard to both Shechem and Bethel. Perhaps since Abram has no intention of settling in either place permanently, there is need for an explicit promise that in the future Abram's offspring will inherit the places currently inhabited by the natives. However, this explanation seems insufficient in light of the fact that the Bethel revelation is postponed until after the Egypt episode and Abram's separation from Lot. Perhaps the absence of revelation in Bethel is the reason for Abram's invoking of God's name; since God did not appear, Abram decided to initiate contact with Him, or perhaps publicly announce His name.⁵¹

As already mentioned, God's revelation in Shechem should be viewed as a continuation of the promises Abram was given in Mesopotamia. There, God had commanded Abram to go to "the land that I will show you." Once Abram reached Shechem, God revealed to him that this was the land he had intended. Reading the revelation in Shechem against the backdrop of the revelation in Ur is necessary due to the succinct nature of the latter: "I will assign this land to your offspring." This promise must rely upon another, since Abram has no offspring at the time of this statement. It is noteworthy that Abram is not explicitly promised both land and offspring in this revelation,

51 The meaning of "invoking God's name" has been the subject of much debate. Clearly this is a "religious practice" (Hamilton 1990, 378); but of what nature? Onkelos translated the word into "prayer," while Nahmanides wrote "Abram would call out the name of the Lord before the altar, to announce His divinity" (Nahmanides *ibid*; see similarly Cassuto 1964, 232, based on Ex 33:19). Both possibilities are logical within the context of the verse; Ibn Ezra mentioned both possibilities in his commentary on the verse. See also Brongers 1965, 12–14.

as some scholars have asserted.⁵² Abram's offspring are alluded to as a means of conquering the land; even if the promise of offspring is insinuated, this is not an explicit promise. The crux of the promise remains the inheritance of the land, which should be viewed as a direct continuation of God's revelation in Ur of the Chaldeans, where the identity of the land was veiled, and now revealed to Abram.

However, the succinct formulation of the promise is surprising for another reason: when contrasting the other revelations to Abram in Canaan, the reader will discover that the content of the revelation in Bethel is broader and more festive. There is a special emphasis on the two components of God's promise: the inheritance of the land and the multiplicity of offspring. Why is this promise postponed until Abram reaches Bethel, and not stated upon Abram's arrival in Canaan, in the revelation in Shechem?⁵³ Moreover, the revelation in Bethel would seem appropriate for the first promise Abram was to receive in the land of Canaan, since it indicates an initial familiarity with the land: "Raise your eyes and look out from where you are, to the north and south, to the east and west, for I give all the land that you see to you and your offspring forever...Up, walk about the land, through its length and its breadth, for I give it to you" (13:14–17). Opening one's eyes and taking in one's surroundings seem fitting as an introduction to a new location. The timing of the command "Up, walk about the land" is surprising as well, considering that Bethel was Abram's second station in Canaan; why would God command Abram to do what he was already doing?⁵⁴ In light of Abram's separation from Lot there

52 E.g., Mathews (2005, 119) wrote: "the Lord reassured Abram by reiterating the two signal promises: children and land."

53 Additionally, Hamilton noted that Abram is promised in the Bethel revelation that the land will be given to him, not only to his offspring: "for I give all the land that you see to you and your offspring forever," in contrast with the revelation in Shechem: "I will assign this land to your offspring" (Hamilton 1990, 377).

54 Some scholars asserted that the revelation in Bethel is a late addition to the original story (Wellhausen; Gunkel; and others). Proof of this idea is found in the fact that the revelation interrupts the story, since after Lot settles in Sodom (13:12) the verse should turn to describing Abram settling in Hebron (13:18);

might be a need to repeat the broader promise, as we will discuss in future chapters. However, even in this case, one would expect that the introduction to Abram's new land would appear in connection with Shechem, and perhaps be repeated in connection with Bethel. The full extent of the promises of land and offspring seem to be deliberately postponed to Bethel: for some reason, Abram is not yet worthy.

Understanding this matter requires analysis of the purpose of the two intervening stories in the description of Abram's journey to Canaan: Abram's detour to Egypt, and the separation of Abram from his nephew Lot.

however, the text places the revelation between these two verses (Westermann 1995, 172). The textual location of the revelation is indeed baffling, and will be discussed in later chapters.

Chapter 3: The Descent to Egypt (12:10–20)

The first episode that interrupts the sequence of Abram's travels through Canaan reveals Abram's distress when faced by a famine in Canaan. This occurrence is surprising in light of God's recent promises to Abram: the Promised Land turns out to be insufficient for Abram's current household, let alone a promised multitude of offspring. The reader was previously made aware that Sarai was infertile; now the land turns out to be infertile as well. Thus, the fulfillment of both aspects of God's promise to Abram – land and offspring – seems unlikely.

Abram and Sarai's descent to Egypt has been criticized by commentators and scholars alike. Many pointed to textual indications that Abram mishandled the crisis. Nahmanides stands out in his harsh review of Abram's actions:¹

Now Abram went down to Egypt on account of the famine to dwell there in order to keep himself alive in the days of the drought, but the Egyptians oppressed him for no reason and took his wife. The Holy One, blessed be He, avenged their cause with great plagues, and brought him forth from there with cattle, silver, and gold. Pharaoh even commanded his men to escort them away. He thereby alluded to Abraham that his children would go down to Egypt on account of the famine to dwell there in the land, and the Egyptians would mistreat them and take the women from them, just as Pharaoh said, "If it is a girl, let her live." But the Holy One, blessed be He, would avenge their cause with great plagues until He would bring them forth with silver and gold, sheep and oxen, very rich in cattle, with the Egyptians pressing them to send them out of the land.

Nothing was lacking in all the events that happened to the patriarch that would not occur to the children².

1 Nahmanides on Gen 12:10.

2 This issue is explained in *Genesis Rabbah*: "R. Pinchas said in the name of R. Oshaya: the Holy One, blessed be He, said to Abraham, 'Go forth and tread out a path for your children!' Thus you will find that whatever is written concerning Abraham is also written concerning his children. Concerning Abraham it is written, 'And there was a famine in the land'; concerning Israel it is written 'It is

Know that our father Abraham unintentionally committed a great sin by bringing his righteous wife to a situation of sin on account of his fear for his life. He should have trusted that God would save him and his wife and all his belongings, for God surely has the power to help and to save. Leaving the land to which he had been ordered from the outset on account of the famine was also a sin that he had committed.

In famine God will redeem him from death. It was because of this deed that an exile in the land of Egypt at the hand of Pharaoh was decreed for his children. In the place of justice, there is wickedness, and sin.

Nahmanides initially discusses the literary analogy between the narrative regarding Abram in Egypt and the slavery and redemption from Egypt in the book of Exodus. He explains that this is a realization of the principle “the events of the patriarchs are signs for their descendants,” or, in his own formulation, “Nothing was lacking in all the events that happened to the patriarch that would not occur to the children.” However, he then adds an additional layer to his interpretation, offering a harsh criticism of Abram’s actions: “our father Abraham unintentionally committed a great sin.”³ Nahmanides focuses on two issues in his criticism. First, there is no justification to leave Canaan in a time of famine, since “in famine God will redeem him from death.”⁴ According to Nahmanides, only a few verses earlier, while Abram was in Shechem, God had promised him that his offspring would inherit the land; Abram should have trusted God and awaited His assistance.

Nahmanides’ second criticism relates to Abram’s abandonment of Sarai. Here, too, Nahmanides believed Abram “should have trusted that God would save him and his wife and all his belongings.”⁵ Nahmanides concludes that the slavery in Egypt is a punishment of Abram’s

now two years that there has been famine in the land.” (Genesis Rabbah, 8:6, Theodor-Albeck ed., 385–86).

3 Nahmanides’ ambivalence is certainly present in this formulation, regarding Abram’s “great sin,” which was committed “unintentionally.”

4 Paraphrase on Job 5:20: “In famine He will redeem you from death, In war, from the sword.”

5 I have presented the two criticisms in the order of appearance in the narrative. Nahmanides intentionally reverses the order, and opens with the sin involving Sarai, which is a greater sin in his opinion. See Shammah 2009, 209–10.

offspring for the deeds of their forefather: “In the place of justice, there is wickedness, and sin.”⁶

The correlation between the different levels of Nahmanides’ commentary raises various issues, first and foremost regarding the literary connection between the enslavement of the Hebrews in Egypt and the story of Abram’s descent to Egypt. Should Abram’s story be viewed as a model (or foreshadowing) of what would happen to Abram’s offspring (as implied by the first part of the commentary), or is the nature of the relationship between the two episodes one of crime and punishment (as Nahmanides concludes)? If God “alluded to Abraham that his children would go down to Egypt,” the episode should be viewed as part of God’s plan.⁷ Abraham Shammah suggested that the two comments were written at different stages, and that Nahmanides’ criticism of Abram was written only after he himself had immigrated to Israel,⁸ and added new interpretations to the commentary he had written in Spain.⁹

Whether the comment was included in his initial commentary or added at a later stage, Nahmanides’ criticism of Abram is harsh. Not only does Abram’s action convey a lack of faith in God, it seems extraordinarily immoral to sacrifice his wife to the Egyptians in order to save his own life. In a society where morality and ethics are underdeveloped, one will naturally go to great lengths, and perhaps even sacrifice oneself, to save family members, while here Abram chooses to abandon his wife in order to save himself. Furthermore, Abram seems to be abandoning his wife without any sign of imminent danger. If the danger seemed imminent, would Abram not have been better off

6 Cf. Ecc 3:16.

7 Regarding the rabbinic concept “the events of the patriarchs are signs for their descendants” in Nahmanides’ commentary, see Funkenstein 1980, 48–59; Harlap 2005; Ben-Meir 2008.

8 Shammah 2009. This position is based on various proofs, including Nahmanides’ commentary on Gen 27:1, where he repeats his initial comment that Abram’s journey to Egypt foreshadows the Egyptian exile, but mentions no criticism of Abram (see pp. 206–08).

9 Regarding later additions by Nahmanides to his commentary, see Kahana 1969; Sabato 1995; Sabato 2005; Ofer 2008; Ofer and Jacobs 2014.

taking his chances in Canaan than endangering his life, or giving up his wife, by going to Egypt?

The formulation of Abram's request of Sarai only adds fuel to the fire: "As he was about to enter Egypt, he said to his wife Sarai: I know what a beautiful woman you are. If the Egyptians see you, and think, 'She is his wife,' they will kill me and let you live. Please, say that you are my sister, that it may go well with me because of you, and that I may remain alive thanks to you" (12:11–13). Abram's words, "that it may go well for me because of you," reappear later in the story, in the context of the wealth Abram had accumulated in Egypt: "And because of her, *it went well with Abram*; he acquired sheep, oxen, asses, male and female slaves, she-asses, and camels" (12:16). The reappearance of the phrase in this context leads the reader to assume that Abram's intentions were to accumulate wealth through his sacrifice of Sarai, as Rashi reiterated: "that it may go well for me – they will give me gifts." If this is the case, Abram's plan is disgraceful: using Sarai to save his life is surprising and perhaps immoral, but sacrificing his wife to gain riches is appalling. Shula Keshet wrote in this context:

The weak attempts made by medieval commentators to interpret this statement, as though Abram had not meant to receive gifts, but only to save his life, do not withstand the test of an attentive read of the text. The recurring phrase portrays Abram as a panderer, and the dowry he received as a harlot's fee.¹⁰

Others have derived criticism of Abram from the design of the story, particularly from Abram's failure to respond to Pharaoh's accusations. The fact that the narrator gave Pharaoh the last word, and that Abram is silent when faced with Pharaoh's accusations, was interpreted as an indication that Abram admits his mistake, as Delitzsch wrote: "Abram

10 Keshet 2002, 43. This approach is prevalent among scholars (e.g., Skinner 1930, 249; von Rad 1963, 220–25). Aharoni remarked in less extreme terms: "Defense [of Abram] is made particularly difficult by the unequivocal formulation of the text, which implies that Abram took an adaptive approach, and decided to profit from the situation, 'that it may go well for me because of you'; indeed, as the text indicates, this objective was fully achieved: 'and because of her, it went well with Abram'" (Aharoni 1979, 218).

is silent, and in his shame and regret, he incriminates himself.”¹¹ Van Dijk-Hemmes went as far as comparing Abram with Lot, who offered his daughters to the lascivious Sodomites in order to save the lives of his guests (19:8), and the Levite who gave his concubine to the people of Gibeah in order to save himself (Judg 19:25).¹² According to this reading, there is certain irony in presenting Sarai as a sister, as in the ancient world the responsibilities of the brother included caring for his younger siblings and sisters in particular.

There is no doubt that the criticism of Abram is justified if based on this reading; if the reading were correct, I would certainly have positioned myself among Abram’s critics.¹³ However, the reading fails to correlate with the design of the story, and erroneously interprets facts that are mentioned at the start of the story in light of their appearance later on. First, the structure of the story does not support criticism of Abram. The story begins with Abram’s “descent” to Egypt due to a severe (כבד) famine: “There was a famine in the land, and Abram went down to Egypt to sojourn there, for the famine was severe in the land” (12:10), and ends with Abram’s “ascent” to Canaan, inundated (כבד) in riches: “From Egypt, Abram went up into the Negev, with his wife and all that he possessed, together with Lot. Now Abram was very rich in cattle, silver, and gold” (13:1–2).

The literary structure of the unit is based on the geographical movement: Abram “goes down” to Egypt, and eventually “goes up” to Canaan (the opposing directions create a literary inversion). In addition to the geographical structure, the narrator integrated the adjective כבד into both sentences, and the common term describes

11 Delitzsch 1887, 256. For a similar position see: Gunkel 1966, 177; Schmitt 1973; Westermann 1995, 166–67. Hamilton wrote that Abram favored his own life over Sarai’s to ensure the fulfillment of the promise he was given at the beginning of the chapter – that Abram will become a great nation: “It is impossible for God to make of Abram a great nation if Abram is dead before he fathers one child” (Hamilton 1990, 383). However, Abram’s basic moral responsibility is to ensure his wife’s safety; keeping God’s promises should not be his concern.

12 Van Dijk-Hemmes 1997, 229–30.

13 According to Clines, Abram’s initial concern are invalidated later in the story (Clines 1990, 68).

two contradictory situations. The former use of the word describes the severe distress caused by the famine, while the latter describes the abundance of Abram's riches.¹⁴ It is difficult to imagine that a story with such harsh criticism of Abram would support a process beginning in such distress and ending with such reward. The conclusion of the story negates criticism of Abram, and instead portrays him as having accumulated great wealth. It is noteworthy that the reader is not informed at any point that the famine has ended, and the emphasis of the story shifts from the distress of the land to Abram's blessing.¹⁵ This shift of focus to the fact that Abram merits the fulfillment of one of God's promises is important background for the alternative reading we shall now offer.

Don Isaac Abrabanel (1437–1508) asked what Abram and Sarai's plan was when he decided to go down to Egypt, and what his intentions were when he introduced Sarai as his sister. According to the prevalent (abovementioned) position, they had intended for Sarai to be taken by the Egyptians, and Abram would receive gifts in exchange.¹⁶ However, this reading ignores the linear progression of the narrative: Abram asks Sarai to introduce herself as his sister, not to separate from him.¹⁷ A more plausible scenario would be that Abram hoped one of the Egyptians would ask "Sarai's brother" for her hand in marriage. A negotiation would ensue, and Abram would ask for an unreasonable bride-price. He could authenticate the process by loosening his demands from time to time, and then pull back. If Abram and Sarai ever felt they were in danger, they could always run away and return to Canaan.¹⁸

14 See, among others, Van Dijk-Hemmes 1997, 226.

15 Gunkel 1966, 172.

16 Van Seters (1975, 169) wrote that there is full correlation between Abram's plan and the implementation.

17 Unless we accept Rost's suggestion, that the phrase "you are my sister" is a formal divorce formulation. His interpretation relies upon sources regarding Muslim divorce laws. Rost believed that Abram temporarily divorced Sarai, and God's afflictions upon Pharaoh were not punishment for incest, but an indication that Sarai belongs with Abram (Rost 1965).

18 Cf. Luzzato 1998, 129; Cassuto 1964, 350.

This reading is reinforced in the description of the implementation. Abram's concern ("If the Egyptians see you" in v. 12) is validated ("When Abram entered Egypt, the Egyptians *saw* how very beautiful the woman was" in v. 14). To this point, the plan is proceeding as expected, and Abram is able to ward off Sarai's suitors. However, v. 15 surprises both Abram and the reader:

She was seen by the courtiers of *Pharaoh*
and they praised her *to Pharaoh*
and the woman was taken *to the house of Pharaoh*

The epistrophe of the name "Pharaoh" emphasizes the narrator's disbelief: Pharaoh has his eye on Sarai! Within the context of Abram's plan, what price could he possibly name that is too high for Pharaoh? Abram's plan thus fails; he was able to "haggle" with the common Egyptians, but he is helpless before the king.

The integration of the verb ראה ("to see") supports this reading:

| | |
|--|--|
| <p><i>Plan</i> (12–13)</p> <p>If the <i>Egyptians</i> see you...</p> | <p><i>Occurrence</i> (14–15)</p> <p>The Egyptians <i>saw</i>...</p> <p>She was <i>seen</i> by the courtiers of Pharaoh</p> |
|--|--|

Abram was concerned that the Egyptians would "see" Sarai, and prepared a plan accordingly. But he never expected his wife to be "seen" by Pharaoh's courtiers, or for Pharaoh himself to express interest.

The verse describing Sarai's "sighting" by the royal courtiers is almost poetic. The three sentences end with the same word ("Pharaoh"), and are festively descriptive of Sarai ("*she* was seen," "they praised *her*").¹⁹ Sarai's lack of control – indeed, loss of identity – is emphasized in the third sentence, when the nameless "woman" is taken to the house of the king.

In light of this analysis we can return to the gap between Abram's plan ("that it may go well with me because of you") and the actual

19 Another addition to the flowery style might be the use of the word פְּרֵעָה (הַעֲרַפ יִרְשָׁ) to describe Pharaoh's courtiers: the spelling is identical to that of Sarai's name.

occurrence (“And because of her, it went well with Abram”). Did Abram plan to become rich by sacrificing his wife to Pharaoh? The meaning of “well” is of course affected by context. When Joseph says to the chief cupbearer, “But think of me when all is *well* with you again” – “כִּאֲשֶׁר יִטֵּב לְךָ” (Gen 40:14), “well” means release from prison; when Moses encourages the nation to obey God’s commandments and says: “Do what is right and good in the sight of the Lord, that it may go well with you” – “לַמַּעַן יִטֵּב לְךָ” (Deut 6:18), “well” means inheriting the Promised Land: “that you may be able to possess the good land.”²⁰

The intent of Abram’s words must then be determined by the immediate context. Abrabanel (followed by various others) believed the verse contains two parallel statements:²¹

(A) That it may go well with me (B) because of you

(A) And that I may remain alive (B) thanks to you

Cassuto noted that the order of the verse reinforces this idea: if Abram sought riches, he still would have mentioned saving his life first, as a higher priority, and only then he would have spoken of the added financial benefit.²² The order of the verse indicates that the “well” that Abram had wished upon himself in his initial plan was simply the gift of life.²³

20 The root טוב (good/well) is mentioned in three different contexts in this verse: “Do what is right and *good* (טוב) in the sight of the Lord that it may *go well* (יִטֵּב) with you and that you may be able to possess the *good* (טובה) land that the Lord your God promised on oath to your fathers.”

21 “The “good” is not gifts as Rashi wrote, for this is the way of prostitutes; rather, the second statement is the interpretation of the first, as if to say, that I may remain alive because of you, and they will not kill me” (Abarbanel on Gen 12; Zakovitch 2005, 42).

22 Cassuto 1964, 349.

23 There are additional biblical verses that pair the concepts well/good – live/survival (יִטֵּב-חַיָּה), e.g., “for our lasting *good* (טוב) and for our *survival* (לַחַיִּיתֵנוּ), as is now the case” (Deut 6:24); “that it may go well with you and your life be spared” (Jer 38:20). Regarding the link between Gen 12:13 and Jer 28:20, see Jacob 1974, 350.

Nonetheless, one cannot ignore the link between Abram's desire "*that it may go well with me*" and the outcome "And because of her, *it went well with Abram*; he acquired sheep, oxen, asses, male and female slaves, she-asses, and camels" (16). The link between the two episodes is emphasized in an elaborate concentric structure suggested by Wenham.²⁴ Based on his structure, the benefits that Abram reaps parallel Abram's planned "wellness"; however, the linguistic link is not an indication that the initial phrase shares the same meaning. Rather, the repeated phrase demonstrates the irony of the complicated plot, and emphasizes the gap between the plan and the outcome. While Abram wished only to survive Egypt, he was granted a great deal of wealth; but although he was given cows and donkeys, slaves and servants, camels and oxen, he was still missing his wife!²⁵

What, then, is the literary purpose of the narrative, and how does the story contribute to the broader context of Abram's travels through Canaan? God's protection of Abram demonstrates the fulfillment of one component of the blessings: "I will bless those who bless you, and curse him that curses you." Even those who wish to harm Abram inadvertently are severely punished.²⁶ Even those who found implicit criticism of Abram were forced to admit that the protection offered by God in the story is unequivocal, as Westermann noted, "It is like the way parents deal with their children – they shame them only in their watchful care to protect them."²⁷

24 Wenham 1994, 286. Van Dijk-Hemmes (1997, 226) suggested two parallel halves.

25 Cassuto 1964, 350; Ararat 1993, 54. Zakovitch (2005, 128) wrote: "Abram's inappropriate behavior, his willingness to abandon his wife, to lie and say that Sarai is his sister; all these brought upon him a shameful reward. Abram sold his wife to save himself." Hamilton noted that the other patriarchs gain their fortune as an explicit result of God's blessing, while Abram does not (Hamilton 1990, 383); I believe the link is ironic, but instead of a criticism, it deepens the tragic dimension of the story. See further: Grossman 2006, 45–47.

26 Cf. von Rad 1963, 164.

27 Westermann 1995, 16. He later emphasizes that Abram is reprimanded throughout the story.

This is emphasized in the description of God's affliction of Pharaoh, without explaining how the latter knew that the reason for his suffering was Sarah's captivity. Some scholars believe there is a missing verse that explained the matter,²⁸ while others noted the literary reason for omitting the explanation. Van Seters suggested that since the story follows Abram, a lengthy diversion to Sarai and Pharaoh would divert the reader's attention to other characters.²⁹ Westermann suggested that omitting the details creates an emphasis on the dialogue between Pharaoh and Abram.³⁰

I agree with Westermann's assertion that the narrator's silence emphasizes another detail; however, the emphasis is not on Pharaoh's discussion with Abram, but rather on God's intervention. Instead of discussing the reason for Pharaoh's suffering, the narrator chose to focus on God's protection of Abram's wife.

Regarding the broader context, the narrator illuminates the fact that Sarai is meant to accompany Abram on his journey to Canaan. This might sound obvious, but Abram is commanded to disengage from the house of his father, put his past behind him, and begin anew. Within the context of this command, God had promised Abram that he will become a great nation (12:2), while the reader is aware from the outset that Sarai is barren. Might God not have expected Abram to leave Sarai behind, with the rest of his father's family? The first story, which interrupts Abram's wanderings in Canaan, makes the explicit statement that Sarai belongs alongside Abram. Sarai was taken from Abram by force, but God returned her. Sarai is an integral part of Abram's future in Canaan.

Not only does Abram reclaim his wife; he also gains an immense fortune. The descent to Egypt concludes with the statement: "Now Abram was very rich in cattle, silver, and gold" (13:2). One purpose of

28 Gunkel 1966, 171; Koch 1969, 125.

29 Van Seters 1975, 167–77. Peleg noted that the omission of details, among other literary tools, leaves the question of Pharaoh's actions toward Sarai open-ended (Peleg 2006).

30 Westermann 1995, 162. He believes the two dialogues (the dialogue between Abram and Sarai and the dialogue between Abram and Pharaoh) are emphasized, and frame the story on both ends.

this information is to prepare the reader for the conflict of the following literary unit – Abram’s separation from Lot due to their amassed wealth. Moreover, this verse serves to emphasize the fact that Abram returned to Canaan not only with his wife, but with cattle, gold and silver. God’s initial seemed to promise wealth; now, that blessing is beginning to be fulfilled. The immense riches he acquires in Egypt render irrelevant any possessions brought from his birthplace. The famine in Canaan proves to be a blessing in disguise; through his descent to Egypt and the dangers he and Sarai must face, Abram is granted a new beginning. Perhaps before Abram is able to receive the blessings that await him in Bethel (13:14–17), he must disengage completely from his previous life. Abram’s possessions are now presented as having accumulated after his arrival in Canaan. The famine and the episode in Egypt ultimately becomes a means for the fulfillment of God’s blessings.

One aspect of the episode’s objective and placement, therefore, is to enable utter detachment from Abram’s previous life in a maneuver that simultaneously affirms Sarai’s status as Abram’s chosen life-partner and nullifies the possessions he brought with him from his birthplace. A more fundamental objective of this story, which seems to disrupt the sequence of Abram’s journey to and settlement in Canaan, lies in the episode’s striking dialogue with the story of the children of Israel’s exodus from Egypt. This analogy was already noted by Nahmanides, and many scholars in his wake.³¹ Reich summarized the literary links:³²

31 See Cassuto 1964, 349–52; Pratt 1983; Wenham 1994, 291–92; Becking 2009, 42–43; Römer 2010. Van Dijk-Hemmes (1997, 228) used the comparison to the edict to kill the male babies as proof that Abram was correct to fear that the Egyptians would kill him and sustain his wife. See also Roning 1991, 19; Kilian (1966, 212–13) believed the analogy was incidental. Westermann (1985, 166) mentioned the link between the plagues in Genesis and Exodus, but also believed the analogy was incidental. I believe that in light of the multitude of analogies they cannot be brushed aside as incidental.

32 Reich 2005, 36. I have omitted links mentioned by Reich that I found unconvincing. Becking mentioned two linguistic connections – the roots נגע (plague) and שלח (begone) – and wished to use these links to determine the historical timeframe of redaction in these stories. He believed the story of Abram in Egypt and the Exodus have a common theme: offering encouragement to the

| <i>Abram and Sarai in Egypt (Gen 12)</i> | <i>Israel in Egypt (Gen 43-Ex 12)</i> |
|---|--|
| Abram went down to Egypt
to sojourn there
for the famine was severe in the land (19)
they will kill me and let you live (12)
When Abram entered Egypt
the Lord afflicted Pharaoh and his household with mighty plagues (17)
Pharaoh sent for Abram (18)
take her and be-gone! (19)
and they sent him off with his wife and all that he possessed (20)
Now Abram was very rich in cattle, silver, and gold (13:12)

And he proceeded by stages from the Negev as far as Bethel (13:3) | They made their way down to Egypt (Gen 43:15)
We have come...to sojourn in this land...
For the famine is severe in the land of Canaan (Gen 47:4)
look at the birth stool: if it is a boy, kill him; if it is a girl, let her live (Ex 1:16)
These are the names of the sons of Israel who entered Egypt (Ex 1:1)
And the Lord said to Moses, "I will bring but one more plague upon Pharaoh and upon Egypt (Ex 11:1)
Then Pharaoh summoned Moses and Aaron (Ex 8:4)
Take also your flocks and your herds, as you said, and be-gone! (Ex 12:32)
The Egyptians urged the people on, impatient to have them leave the country (Ex 12:33)
Each woman shall borrow from her neighbor...objects of silver and gold... (Ex 3:22; 11:2)
Moreover, a mixed multitude went up with them, and very much livestock, both flocks and herds (12:37)
From the wilderness of Sin the whole Israelite community proceeded by stages as the Lord would command (Ex 17:1) |

The connection between the narratives are salient from a linguistic perspective, but moreover, from the perspective of plot – descent to Egypt due to famine; life-threatening danger for the males of the family; divine intervention and physical punishment for the Egyptians;

nation in times of distress, and particularly in times of exile, when the disappointment of unfulfilled promises is identifiable (Becking 2009, 42–44).

and finally, Israel's triumphant emergence and great wealth. Cassuto summarized these parallels in a general statement regarding the link between the stories of the patriarchs and their offspring:

In the account of how Abram went to Egypt, what befell him there and how he went forth from there, the Torah presages, as it were, the migration of the Israelites to Egypt after they had settled in the land of Canaan, their servitude and their liberation. The narrative is so worded as to emphasize the parallelism in all its aspects. The whole course of events experienced by the scions is revealed to us as though depicted from the beginning in the life of their sires... The bondage of the children of Israel in Egypt was not an accidental calamity but part of a plan prepared beforehand, in accordance with God's will, already in the days of Abraham...³³

However, Cassuto did not relate to the significance of the connection. Reich believed the link points to the connection between the fertility of man and land: Abram's temporary disengagement from Sarai mirrors the disengagement of the nation from their land.³⁴ Reich's link surfaces in the story of Abram in Egypt, which opens with the distress of the earth, and proceeds to describe the distress of Abram and Sarai's relationship when Sarai is taken from Abram. However, this link fails to explain the significance of the comparison with the oppression suffered by the Children of Israel in Egypt.³⁵

The captivity in, and redemption from, Egypt are perceived as a necessary introduction to the inheritance of the Promised Land, as described in the Covenant between the Pieces in Gen 15. Perhaps Abram's detour to Egypt is an introduction to *his* inheritance of the land. Disengagement from the land nullifies the sense of possession and political control. Canaan is unique, in that the land does not belong to its inhabitants, but rather to God, who is Lord of the land and who

33 Cassuto 1964, 336–37. Compare with Joosten 2012, 374–5.

34 Reich 2005, 35–39.

35 Römer argued that this analogy influences the reader's evaluation of Pharaoh's character: "Contrary to the Exodus narrative, Abram, representing Israel, plays a rather dubious part, while the Pharaoh is endowed with positive features. The narrator does not tell us of what Yhwh's plagues consist and the means through which the pharaoh learned Abram's involvement, but he points out that the Egyptian ruler behaves according to the divine will." (Römer 2010, 8).

will ensure that the land is inherited only by deserving parties. In biblical philosophy, a famine is an indication that the local population has lost its right to continue inhabiting the land (e.g., Deut 11:17). Abram, and later Jacob's family, need to leave the land for some time, in order to be granted the privilege of returning and inheriting it. In the spirit of T.S. Eliot:

And what you own is what you do not own
And where you are is where you are not.³⁶

As I discussed in the introduction, the unique nationalistic philosophy expressed in Abraham's narrative cycle establishes the new nation upon the foundations of "righteousness and justice," which enables the possibility of a Jewish lifestyle without dependence upon national borders. Abraham only receives the promise of inheritance of the vast land after his descent and exodus from Egypt, because the privilege of inheritance can only be granted after his disconnection and reconnection with the land. Neither inheritance of the land of the birth of offspring is granted freely; both are inextricably contingent upon the moral nature of the nation Abram will establish.

His separation from the barren land and his barren wife are a necessary precondition for God's promise of fruitfulness, and both will be restored to him with God-given fertility. In order to receive the blessing at Bethel, however, Abram must undergo another separation; this time, from his nephew Lot.

36 T. S. Eliot, "Four Quartets" (East Coker, part 3).

Chapter 4: The Separation from Lot (Gen 13)

Defining the unit regarding Abram's separation from Lot is a complex task. The previous unit had described Abram's journey to Egypt, and concluded with the return of Abram and his family to Bethel, to "the site of the altar that he had built there at first" (13:4).¹ Based on the conclusion of the previous unit, the current unit seems to begin in v. 5: "Lot, who went with Abram, also had flocks and herds and tents." Abram's significant wealth is essential to understanding the quarreling of the herdsmen; some scholars therefore believe this verse begins the current unit.² But the earliest possibility for beginning the unit is 13:1, since Lot is specifically mentioned in the context of Abram's return to Canaan: "From Egypt, Abram went up into the Negev, with his wife and all that he possessed, *together with Lot*" (13:1). Lot is incorporated into the story of Abram's return to Canaan, despite the fact that he is not mentioned among those who traveled to Egypt. The fact that Lot is the only character mentioned by name aside from Abram foreshadows Lot's central role in the following story. Leibowitz compared

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- 1 Cf. Cassuto 1989, 248. Cassuto viewed Lot's mention in 13:1 as an introduction to the following episode (ibid. p. 248). However, v. 5 begins with the word **וְגַם** (also), which is unusual in an independent unit (Samet 2004, 46; Cohen 2011, 9, note 3). This difficulty will integrate into the analysis of the link between the journey to Egypt and the separation from Lot.
 - 2 For example, Westermann 1995, 173–175; Matthews 2005, 133. According to Matthews, the story of Abram's journey to Egypt began with "a *great* (**כבוד**) fame" (12:10), and the story of Abram's separation from Lot began with "Abram was *greatly* (**כבוד**) rich" (13:2); these opening statements also link the two episodes (ibid., 132). Many scholars (among them Skinner 1930, 251) believe that v. 1, which describes Abram's return from Egypt, concludes the previous story, and therefore have a difficult time understanding Lot's mention in the verse, since he had no role (and in fact was not even mentioned) in the Egypt episode. Many asserted that Lot's name was a later insertion (among others, Gunkel, von Rad, and Eissfeldt). I believe the vague boundaries of the story relate directly to its message, and should not be viewed as careless editing.

Lot's position in the order of the list of returnees in our verse with the order of those traveling to Harran. In the description of the initial journey from Harran (12:5), Lot is mentioned immediately after Sarai ("Abram took his wife Sarai and his brother's son Lot"), whereas in our verse Abram's property separates Abram and Sarai from Lot, perhaps an indication that it is property that will ultimately separate the family. Gen 13:1 depicts Abram and Lot as two separate clans that join together on a journey to Canaan, rather than a unified family.³ For this reason Stephen Langton asserts that Abram's separation from Lot begins with the joint journey to Canaan.⁴ The indefinite parameters of the separation story indicate that the sojourn to Egypt is connected with the fact that Abram later parts with his nephew. One might say there is a continuous storyline in which Abram and his family journey to Egypt, accumulate wealth, and consequently separate from Lot.⁵ In addition to the literary connection, we will demonstrate a deep thematic link between Abram's journey to Egypt and his separation from Lot.

The quarrel is conveyed through standard biblical formulations in the event of accumulation of wealth that leads to a separation between brothers. A similar model can be found when Jacob parts from Esau in Gen 36:6–7:

Esau took his wives, his sons and daughters, and all the members of his household, his cattle and all his livestock, and all the property that he had acquired in the land of Canaan, and went to another land because of his brother Jacob. For their possessions were too many for them to dwell together, and the land where they sojourned could not support them because of their livestock.

The design of the story is similar to ours: two families who had acquired an amount of property, which prevented them from continued coexistence on the same land, decided to separate from one another. All of these motifs are present in the story of Lot's separation from Abram,

3 Leibowitz 1966, 88–89; Jeansonne 1988, 124; Shimon 2009, 265.

4 Cf. among others, Speiser 1964, 9; Kiel 1997, 345; Tzohar 2005, 94–95; Cohen 2011, 9.

5 For a different formulation based on a similar reading, compare: Procksch 1913, ad hoc.

with the addition of other literary components: the quarrel of Abram and Lot's herdsmen; Abram's suggestion to part ways; and the reason behind Lot's choice to settle specifically in the plain of Jordan. The purpose of the story of Lot's separation from Abram is expressed through the plot that leads to the separation. Rudin-O'Brasky wrote that the story of Abram and Lot is delivered in chs. 18–19, and the separation should be viewed as an introduction to the story.⁶ However, as I shall demonstrate below, the “introduction” depicts the nature of the characters and the values they hold dear.⁷ Gen 13 presents the reader with the opportunity to meet the essence of the characters, while chs. 18–19 relate the results of this essential separation.⁸

The Quarreling Herdsmen

The developing argument between the herdsmen relates to the multitudes of cattle that require pasture, while space in the land of Canaan is limited, since the “Canaanites and Perizzites were then dwelling in the land” (13:7).⁹ These verses present the misleading impression that Lot's wealth is equal to that of Abram: “Now Abram was very rich in cattle, silver and gold” (13:2), while “Lot, who went with Abram, also had flocks and herds and tents” (13:5). A closer look reveals that all three components of Lot's wealth – flocks, herds, and tents – are included in the category of cattle, whereas Abram's wealth includes cattle as a general category, but he is also said to have silver and gold.¹⁰ This false impression of Lot is significant when attempting to

6 Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 19–27 (note 17 refers to previous authors).

7 Coats 1985, 116–17.

8 Similarly, Shimon 2009, 263.

9 Nahmanides offered a similar interpretation. Gunkel, among others, believed the statement does not integrate well into the story and should be viewed as a later addition; many other scholars disagreed (e.g., Westermann 1995, 176) and suggested a variety of possible contributions to the verse.

10 Cf. Cohen 2011, 13.

determine the mindset of the characters, since in a state of dispute people rarely assess the facts realistically. Lot's herdsmen clearly feel that Lot's assets are equal to those of Abram, and more importantly, that their master is equal to the master of the herdsmen with whom they are arguing. The reader is thus tuned in to the complexity of the situation: Lot is portrayed as equal to Abram ("also"), but also as part of the convoy directed by Abram ("Lot, who went with Abram").

The development of the dispute is designed gradually, including three stages:

1. Because the land could not support them staying together.
2. For their possessions were so great that they could not remain together.
3. And there was quarreling between the herdsmen of Abram's cattle and those of Lot's cattle.

Initially, Abram and Lot cannot stay together because "the land could not support them." The land is introduced as the instigator – a seemingly objective source of dispute. In the second stage the focus shifts from the reason to the personalities involved – Abram and Lot become the subject of the sentence: and *they* cannot remain together due to their many possessions. In the third stage of the conflict the formulation becomes active and subjective: "and there was quarreling."¹¹ This turn for the worse might be the reason the narrator wished at this point to deflect attention from Abram and Lot and attribute the dispute to the herdsmen.

Nahum Sarna linked the root ריב ("quarrel") in 13:7 and 13:8 with the nation's complaints regarding lack of water (Ex 17:7; Num 20:3 and 13; Deut 32:51 and 33:8, among others). Sarna believed this is an indication of Lot's lack of gratitude toward Abram, like to the lack of gratitude of the nation toward God, who protected them and supplied them with all their needs in the desert. Lot fails to attribute his success to his connection with his uncle, and allows (perhaps even encourages)

11 Note the (insignificant) alliteration between **היה רכושם רב** (for their possession were great) and **ויהי ריב** (and there was quarreling).

his herdsmen to quarrel with Abram's herdsmen.¹² If we accept his suggestion, two parallel analogies can be created: just as Abram and Sarai's journey to Egypt and back is analogous to the enslavement of the Children of Israel in Egypt and their exodus, the grievances against God in the desert are analogous to the pasture problems that led to the separation of Abram and Lot.

Abram's Proposal

The narrator's description of the argument culminates with the herdsmen, but an extra level of the quarrel is revealed in Abram's words: "Abram said to Lot, 'Let there be no strife between you and me, between my herdsmen and yours, for we are brothers'" (8). According to Abram, the argument between the herdsmen represents an argument between Abram and Lot. Abram does not deflect responsibility by blaming the herdsmen; he takes full responsibility for the actions of his employees, despite the fact that the narrator presented the argument as one among the herdsmen.

Presumably, Abram's herdsmen know that Abram is superior to Lot. He is Lot's elder and respected uncle, who follows a direct command from God, while Lot is merely the younger nephew who accompanied Abram on his journey. Despite the fact that Abram is the head of the family, his choice to deal with Lot as an equal, "for we are brothers" (8), portrays him as a modest and reasonable leader who values peace within his family unit above his own honor. Nonetheless, Westermann is correct that the separation from Lot is not altruistic, and will serve Abram's needs as well as Lot's. Continuous fighting among the herdsmen will ultimately damage Abram's flocks, and apparently there is an objective problem in finding sufficient pasture.¹³ However, this fact does not diminish the respect and kindness with which Abram

12 Sarna 1989, 98.

13 Westermann 1995, 176.

addresses Lot.¹⁴ Abram's formulation – "please, separate from me," leaves the choice to separate in Lot's hands; here, too, Abram does not shed responsibility for the orphaned nephew he had previously taken in. He does not banish Lot (as he will later be compelled to banish his son Ishmael); instead, he offers Lot the option of separation.

Lot's Choice: Sodom, like the garden of the LORD, like the land of Egypt

God appears to Abram following his separation from Lot. Both the separation and the revelation take place in Bethel and are textually linked, and the text of God's revelation can be read as a response to Abram's parting from Lot.¹⁵

The first link between the two episodes stands out in the caption: "And the Lord said to Abram after Lot parted from him" (13:14). Since God's revelation is adjacent to the separation from Lot, the obvious link adds no information regarding the time of revelation, and is clearly designed to link the parting of Abram and Lot with the content of the revelation. The choice of similar words in the formulation of each of the episodes reinforces this link:¹⁶

14 Hamilton claimed that Abram's portrayal in the second story is contrasted with his portrayal in the initial story: In Egypt Abram was manipulative and created an argument unnecessarily, whereas when faced with Lot, Abram does everything to avoid conflict. Hamilton links this change with Abram's return to the altar that he had built (Hamilton 1990, 391). I stand by my previous position, and cannot justify Hamilton's criticism based on textual analysis; however, Hamilton creates an important distinction between Abram's noble composure when he is faced with Lot, as opposed to his defensive strategies as a guest in Egypt. Abram recognizes his fragility as a stranger in Egypt, whereas in Canaan he acts with the confidence and nobility befitting a master of the land.

15 In contrast to Westermann 1995, 178.

16 Cf. Shimon 2009, 269.

| <i>Abram's Separation from Lot (13:8–13)</i> | <i>God's Revelation to Abram (13:14–18)</i> |
|--|--|
| <p>Is not <i>all the land</i> before you?¹⁷
 Lot looked about him, and saw how well watered was <i>all</i> the plain of Jordan, <i>all</i> of it</p> <p>Before the Lord had destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah</p> <p>So Lot chose for himself <i>all</i> the plain of the Jordan, and Lot journeyed eastward</p> <p>Now the people of Sodom were very wicked sinners against the Lord.</p> | <p>Raise your eyes and see and look out from where you are, to the north and to the south, to the east and to the west... For I give all the land that you see to you and your offspring...
 ...forever.</p> <p>And Abram moved his tent and came to dwell at the terebinths of Mamre, which are in Hebron</p> <p>And he built an altar there to the Lord.</p> |

The text contrasts Lot's choice with God's demand of Abram: Lot raised his eyes and saw *one* specific place ("all the plain of Jordan"), while Abram was asked to look out upon the *entire land* ("north and south, east and west").¹⁷ Whereas Abram had offered Lot "*all the land*," Lot's vision is limited to the plain of Jordan. The word "all" is ironically sprinkled throughout the description of Lot's choice: "Lot looked about him, and saw how well watered was *all* the plain of Jordan, *all* of it"; "So Lot chose for himself *all* the plain of the Jordan." However, the word "all" is omitted in the description of the outcome of Lot's decision: "Lot settled in the cities of the plain" (13:12). While Lot *felt* he was choosing a vast area, he abandoned the possibilities of inheriting the "all" that was offered to Abram when he chose to separate from his uncle.

Lot's choice to relinquish his portion in God's promise to Abram is also expressed in his specific geographical choice to leave the land of Canaan.¹⁸ Abram offers Lot "north or south" of the land, while

17 Compare: Skinner 1930, 253.

18 Heard (2001, 33–34) claimed that Lot had no choice but to accept Abram's command. I identify with Zvi Shimon, who wrote that the narrator describes Lot's choice as one based on financial and ethical considerations (Shimon 2009, 270).

Lot chooses to travel east of the Jordan River, outside the borders of the Promised Land.¹⁹ Lot's view of his land of choice is expressed through metaphors that create a strained reading, often attributed to later additions to the original text (Gen 13:10):

Lot looked about him, and saw how well watered was *all* the plain of Jordan, *all* of it – this was before the Lord had destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah – all the way to Zoar, like the garden of the Lord, like the land of Egypt.

Some scholars attributed the clarification “before the Lord had destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah” to the detachment of the verse from its original context, the destruction of Sodom (Gen 18–19).²⁰ The comparison of the Jordan plain to Egypt is even more surprising, since it lacks relevance in the specific context.²¹ However, the depiction of Lot's perspective on the Jordan plain might be an indication of the ethical drama that takes place in the story.

The reference to the destruction of Sodom is necessary, since the reader who is familiar with the dry and barren characteristics of Sodom will wonder how Lot views a lush and fertile land. However, such clarifications often contribute to the reading process. The clarification that Lot sees Sodom before the destruction is contrasted with God's promise to Abram: “For I give all the land that you see to you and your offspring *forever*.” Lot chooses a seemingly fertile and valuable land, but the value of the land is measured in temporary terms, as opposed to Abram's choice to continue wandering in difficult conditions without sufficient pasture, while relying on God's promise that his inheritance of the land will be everlasting. This contrast is communicated to the reader, without awareness on Lot's part, since he is unaware of God's plans for Sodom. However, the verse offers an additional evaluation that contrasts Lot's values with those of the protagonist and

19 Vogels 1979; Helyer 1983; Coats 1985, 117.

20 E.g., Gunkel 1966, 174.

21 Westermann 1995, 177. He added that perhaps the integration of Egypt stems from the placement of the final version of the edited story after the journey to Egypt. Below we will demonstrate that Egypt indeed links the two units, and this link is an indication of the purpose of unit, not of later additions to the text.

the reader. The Jordan plain is described as “the garden of the Lord,” but also “like the land of Egypt.” The two comparisons seem contradictory, until they are contrasted with the view of the narrator: “Now the inhabitants of Sodom were very wicked sinners against the Lord” (13:13). The land is indeed fertile, but its inhabitants are evil; Sodom, like Egypt, is a place of questionable values; perhaps the type of place where beautiful women are taken against their will to satisfy the sexual desire of the inhabitants.

Sodom is described from Lot’s perspective, so the comparison with Egypt should be attributed to Lot as well. Lot is aware of the link between Sodom and Egypt. How then did the association with Egypt contribute to Lot’s decision to settle in Sodom? Clearly, the significant link between the Garden of Eden and Egypt is the constant source of water, which contributes to the fertility of the land. A river had emerged from Eden to constantly water the garden of the Lord (Gen 2:10), and in times of famine everyone sought relief in Egypt, since the Nile was a consistent and dependable source of water for the gardens of Egypt. The two units are therefore linked by Lot’s revelation: the journey to Egypt opened his eyes to a lifestyle to which he was previously unaccustomed, in which farmers and shepherds need not rely on rain to sustain them. Lot lifts his eyes and recognizes the area bordering Canaan that is most similar to Egypt, and sets forth to settle there.²²

Abram’s values and priorities are thus contrasted with Lot’s, with regard to the source of financial security. Lot chooses to settle in a

22 Lubetski commented on the expression כולה משקה (NJPS: “well watered;” literally: “is all drink”), remarking that the mention of drink is meant to create an association with Egyptian wine. Egyptian hieroglyphics describe heavenly gardens bursting with wine. According to Lubetski Lot saw the agricultural potential of Sodom, and was contemplating trading his sheep for a career in wine-making (Lubetski 1999). If he is correct, perhaps the final story about Lot – where he is found drunk with his daughters in a cave in Gen 19 – is an ironic closure to Lot’s decision to settle in Sodom. The question relates to the exact geographical location of Sodom, which is disputed among scholars. For a wealth of biblical, historical, and archeological information on this subject see Harland 1943; Harland 1942.

place as similar to Egypt as possible, whereas Abram chooses to continue wandering, while observing God's command to "walk about the land, through its length and its breadth" (13:17). Kyu Sik Hong rightfully observes a marked parallel between the story of the descent to Egypt and Abram's departure from Lot;²³ in fact, the parallel is even more profound that he proposes.

Both on his journey to Egypt and in his separation from Lot, Abram is required to separate from a close family member who has journeyed with him from Harran: he is temporarily forced to separate from his wife Sarai (who portrays herself as his sister) and permanently separates from Lot (whom he regards as a brother, despite the fact that he is a nephew).²⁴ Within the broader concentric structure of the story cycle (which is described in the introduction), the two stories are regarded as one unit:

| <i>The Journey to Egypt</i> | | <i>Abram's Separation from Lot</i> | |
|---|--|---|---|
| Introduction | "For the famine was severe in the land" | Introduction | "Now Abram was very rich in cattle, silver, and gold" |
| Challenge | Infertile land (famine) | Challenge | Abundance of property leads to difficulty finding sufficient pasture |
| <i>Abram is (temporarily) separated from his wife</i> | | <i>Abram is separated from his nephew</i> | |
| Suggestion | "Please say that you are my sister" | Suggestion | "for we are rothers... please, separate from me" |
| Conclusion | "The Egyptians saw how very beautiful the woman was" | Conclusion | Lot looked about him, and saw how well watered was <i>all</i> the plain of Jordan, <i>all</i> of it...like the land of Egypt" |

23 Hong 2007, 247.

24 Regarding the various biblical connotations of the word "brother," see Fishbane 1970.

Abram's distress in both episodes is intensified when considering Sarai and Lot's central role in the fulfillment of God's promises to Abram. Abram departs for Egypt due to the infertility of the land, but in the course of his journey he is separated from his wife, who is also infertile; nonetheless, Abram's separation from his life partner lessens his chances of realizing his destiny as the father of many nations. Since Abram abandoned the land, and now stands to lose his wife, he has lost everything – the promise of both land and seed given at his departure from Harran. Similarly, Abram and Lot discover that the land cannot contain both flocks; however, this dilemma leads to a greater challenge to Abram, that of parting with his brother's son, who was perhaps viewed by Abram as a substitute for the son Sarai had not given him.

The two stories also contain differentiating factors, most significantly the initiator and the duration of the separation. Both stories open with Abram's suggestion; however, the purpose of Abram's request of Sarai is to *keep* her, whereas the purpose of his suggestion to Lot is to separate them. Both stories culminate with a show of divine perspective on current events: God intervenes on behalf of Sarai and reunites her with Abram, while the divine revelation after the second episode shows God's approval of the separation from Lot.

Both stories seek to clarify a common theme: who is worthy of joining Abram on his journey to Canaan? When God demands that Abram abandon the house of his father, the role of various members of his father's family, namely, Sarai and Lot, becomes unclear. Abram's (failed) attempts to protect Sarai prove that he views her as a worthy partner, and he wants her by his side. More importantly, God's intervention to save Sarai and return her to Abram proves that it is also the will of God to have Sarai join Abram. This idea will be stated explicitly to Abram in ch. 17, but despite her barrenness, Sarai is clearly given God's approval at this early stage. Alternatively, Abram *chooses* to separate from Lot, and God affirms Abram's decision in His revelation.

In conclusion, Abram took his orphaned nephew under his wing, but decided to part ways as a result of their dispute; in doing so, Abram finally fulfills God's initial command to separate from his father's home. If so, we can assert that the episodes leading up to God's revelation to

Abram in Bethel and the explicit blessing of offspring and inheritance of the land explore Abram's relationship with several entities that call his right to the blessing into question: his relationship with the land, with his wife, and with his nephew Lot. Abram retains and reaffirms his connection with the two entities God is interested in – the land and his wife – but he takes leave from his nephew, who will not walk along the path that leads to a covenant with God.

Chapter 5: War of the Four Kings – Lot's Liberation (14)

The Battle of Siddim has troubled many scholars: “One of the most unusual of the patriarchal stories, and at the same time one of the most perplexing, is that relating to the ‘battle of the kings.’”¹ The chapter’s exceptional nature is evident in light of the fact that even diachronic scholars have despaired of determining its source, which cannot be ascribed to any of the usual document sources: “There is virtual unanimity that Gen 14 does not belong to any of the known sources...”²

This agreement is based on the style of the unit, specifically the first part, which is written in the style of a war chronicle (with the names of the fighting parties and geographical locations),³ but also on the fact that Abram the Hebrew is portrayed as a war hero and diplomat who negotiates with ancient kings. Throughout the story cycle, Abram is consistently depicted as a man of spirit, a prophet, a moralist who promotes justice, an excellent host, and above all as one who merits an everlasting covenant with God. This portrait is incompatible with the diplomatic strategist who divides his troops and leads them

1 Sarna 1966, 110.

2 Westermann 1995, 188. Gunkel (1977, 282) has a similar approach. See also Emerton 1971, 404–07; Schatz 1972. In contrast, an approach of unified editing is found in both nineteenth-century and modern literature. This approach bases the uniformity of the text on linguistic and literary links. See Wenham 1987, 306.

3 This style led various scholars to assert that this chapter contains great historical reliability (Delitzsch 1887, 260–63; Albright 1961, 10; von Rad 1963, 177; Sarna 1966, 111–12). Others claim that the multiplicity of names and places indicate fiction (Wellhausen, Noth, Van Seters, Benson). According to Bowker (1967, 36–37), the nucleus of the narrative is historical, but it was written as fiction. Westermann (1985, 187–90) believed that each unit should be discussed individually, and that historical elements can only be found in some parts of the story. In addition to the style, some scholars noted unusual language as proof of the independence of the unit (Dillmann 1897, 30–31).

in a dangerous nighttime rescue operation. The portrayal of Abram as a military commander led some scholars to assert that the story was written after the Babylonian exile, when models of Israelite war heroes in foreign kingdoms were more prevalent (e.g., the book of Daniel, or Judith).⁴

Gunkel added an ethical element that distinguishes this story from the surrounding narratives: Abram refused to take property from the Sodomite king, while in the previous narrative he accepted riches from the Egyptian king (12:16), and in the next episode he is told that his offspring will receive treasures when they leave Egypt (15:14). Gunkel concluded that the narrative of the four kings reflects a different ideology than that found in other Abram narratives.⁵ Other stylistic differences include the absence of active participation by God and His angels, and the absence of Abram's divine blessings, which play a major role in all other Abram narratives: "The tone of the story is more secular than religious, the latter note appearing only toward the end."⁶ These stylistic characteristics are foreign to the Abraham cycle. The narrative includes new motifs that add to the complexity of Abram's character, and the foreign style of the unit is prominent. However, in addition to the historical discussion, the literary contribution of the anomalous story to the wider narrative cycle should be determined. The portrayal of Abram as a military commander, the absence of explicit divine intervention, and the details of the war of the four kings are all vital to the narrative's significance and messages.

4 Gunkel (1966, 283–84) also mentions Esther in this context; Westermann 1995, 192; Glissmann 2009. Van Seters even claimed that it is unlikely that such an extensive alliance (between Babylon, Elam and Ellasar) would exist during so early a period, and therefore argued that the chapter was compiled at the end of the time of Ezra, before the Maccabean period (Van Seters 1975, 115, 308). For criticism of this late dating, see: Soggin 1995.

5 Gunkel 1966, 283.

6 Sarna (1966, 111). The absence of God from the narrative is emphasized in the following story, where He responds to the events that took place in the previous chapter: "After these events, the word of the Lord came to Abram in a vision. He said, 'Fear not, Abram, I am a shield to you; your reward shall be very great'" (15:1). A similar statement does not appear in the present narrative.

The narrative is divided into three central units:⁷

1. The four kings east of the Jordan go to war (1–7).
2. Lot is taken captive and rescued by Abram (8–16).
3. Abram meets with the King of Sodom and Melchizedek (17–24).

We will analyze each unit, and then try to determine the purpose of the narrative.

Conquest of the Transjordan (1–7)

Two different readings were suggested for vs. 1–7. Some viewed the verses as a long and dynamic exposition, which includes a general caption in vs. 5–7 relating to the detailed events that are described later in the unit (v. 10 ff. describes the fall of the King of Sodom and his troops into the bitumen pits, followed by their retreat). According to this reading, only one of the battles between the four and five kings is described. The report initially appears as a caption that includes general details: the identity of the kings and location (“all the latter joined forces at the Valley of Siddim, now the Dead Sea”) and the reason behind the war (a rebellion against the oppressive four kings). Later, when the narrative discusses the events relating to Lot, the description of the battle is repeated.⁸

7 The common position views Lot’s captivity as part of the first unit; therefore scholars tend to begin the second unit in v. 12 or 13. Additionally, most scholars do not view Abram’s meeting with the King of Sodom as the conclusion of the second unit – saving Lot from captivity – since the meeting with Melchizedek is a separate unit, which is not an organic part of the story (see Westermann 1995, 190–92). The alternative structure suggested above is based on a different interpretation of Abram’s meeting with the kings at the end of the story, as we will explain below. For an extensive discussion regarding the possibility of various layers in the chapter see Van Seters 1975, 296–308.

8 See, for example: Cassuto 1990, 309; Mathews 2005, 142–145.

In contrast, others have claimed that the two descriptions relate to two different battles, and that the narrative is written in chronological sequence. The four kings were victorious in the Battle of Siddim, and subjugated the nations of the five kings for 12 years. On the thirteenth year, the five kings rebelled. On the fourteenth year the four kings, led by Chedorlaomer, led their troops into battle to suppress the rebellion. After the battle they pillaged Sodom and took Lot hostage.⁹ According to this reading, the exposition is not a general caption relating to the details ahead; rather, the initial verses describe another battle, which offers background regarding the domination of the four kings in the area, and the rebellion that was repressed in the fourteenth year.

Both interpretations are legitimate, and the plot is unaffected by the difference between these battles. It is unclear, however, as to why the battle is described in such great length. At first glance, the excessive review of the events of the initial battle and the 13 years that followed do not seem to contribute to the battle or to Lot's captivity. The image of a captured Sodom is ironic in light of the previous story, which explains why Lot chose to live in Sodom. The previous unit described Sodom as a fertile and blessed land, while the very next chapter reveals that Sodom is under the rule of another powerful nation, and the fertility of the land feeds four foreign rulers, who demand an unreasonable levy. Sodom was probably already subject to the four kings when Lot moved there, which intensifies the irony: Lot looked at the land itself, not at the human conduct upon the land. The land is blessed with abundance, but the inhabitants "were very wicked sinners against the Lord" (13:3), and the fertility of the land is enslaved to the eastern superpower.¹⁰

At first glance, the order of the verses in the unit seems out of order:

9 E.g., Westermann 1995, 187; Wenham 1987, 304–05. Wenham wrote that the two battles won by Chedorlaomer and his allies portray Abram as victorious over a king who has already won two battles; see p. 313.

10 In the patriarchal era, Egypt was the dominant ruler of Canaanite cities. The rule of Chedorlaomer and his allies in Sodom was unusual, and created a political border that separated Sodom from the rest of Canaan.

- 1: “Now, when King Amraphel of Shinar, King Arioch of Ellasar, King Chedorlaomer of Elam, and King Tidal of Goiim”
- 2: “made war on King Bera of Sodom, King Birsha of Gomorrah, King Shinab of Admah, King Shemeber of Zeboiim, and the King of Bela, which is Zoar.”
- 3: “All the latter joined forces at the valley of Siddim, now the Dead Sea.”
- 4: “Twelve years they served Chedorlaomer, and in the thirteenth year they rebelled.”
- 5–7: “In the fourteenth year Chedorlaomer and the kings who were with him came, and defeated the Rephaim at Ashteroth-karnaim, the Zuzim at Ham, and the Emim in Shaveh-kiriathaim, and the Horites in their hill country of Seir, as far as El-paran, which is by the wilderness. On their way back they came to En-mishpat, which is Kadesh, and subdued all the territory of the Amalekites, and also the Amorites, who dwelt in Hazazon-tamar.

Westermann noted that the integration of the names of the five kings in v. 2 seems awkward, since v. 3 is a continuation of v. 1. The expression “all the latter” (v. 3) relates to the four kings in v. 1: these are the distant nations who come together at the Valley of Sidim. The list of the five kings should open v. 4, which describes the reason for the attack.¹¹ This is supported by the syntax, since the indefinite pronoun in v. 4 (“they” served, “they” rebelled) seems to relate to the previously mentioned five; but after the five are mentioned, the narrator reports the meeting of the four in Siddim, and only then returns to the rebellion described by the pronoun. The initial reading causes confusion as to who was subjugated and who rebelled. Apparently, as Westermann noted, the purpose of the confusion is to position the four and five, names and countries, against each other.¹² For some reason, confusion is privileged over clarity for the sake of placing the kings side by side, with this resulting in v. 2’s placement after v. 1.

11 Westermann 1995, 193.

12 Ibid.

Perhaps this curious arrangement relates to an additional question, regarding the change in the order of the names of the four kings upon their second appearance, in vs. 8–9:

| Vs. 8–9 | Vs. 1–2 |
|---|---|
| <p>Then
the king of Sodom,
the king of Gomorrah,
the king of Admah,
the king of Zeboiim,
and the king of Bela which is Zoar,
went forth and engaged them in
battle in the Valley of Siddim</p> <p>King Chedorlaomer of Elam,
King Tidal of Goiim,
King Amraphel of Shinar,
and King Arioch of Ellasar;
four kings against the five.</p> | <p>Now, when
King Amraphel of Shinar,
King Arioch of Ellasar,
King Chedorlaomer of Elam,
and King Tidal of Goiim</p> <p>made war on King Bera of Sodom,
King Birsha of Gomorrah,
King Shinab of Admah,
King Shemeber of Zeboiim,
and the king of Bela, which is Zoar.</p> |

In the second list the order of the kings is reversed, and the five kings are mentioned before the four. This difference is easily explained by the context of the plot. Another surprising difference is the internal order of the list of four kings. In the initial list Amraphel was at the head of the list, whereas the second list opens with Chedorlaomer. The positioning of Chedorlaomer at the head of the list is not surprising in itself, since he seems to be the leader of the four-king superpower: v. 4 states that the five kings were subject to him, and v. 5 has him leading the three other kings in a war of conquest. Therefore, the surprising component is Amraphel's appearance at the head of the first list.

The question, of course, is based on the assumption that biblical lists correspond to the content they express, and that they represent a certain hierarchy. Therefore, when the text lists a person's belongings, their slaves and maidservants will be mentioned before their possessions (Gen 36:6); Judah will be the first of the tribes mentioned in the order of encampment (Num 2:3); the burnt offering will open the list of sacrifices (Lev 1:3; 6:2), and so forth. The second list, which opens

with Chedorlaomer, reflects the military and political hierarchy. But perhaps the model of the first list reflects another theme. The names in the first list appear according to alphabetical order in the Hebrew text: Amraphel, Arioch, Chedorlaomer, and Tidal.¹³ This order sets a technical tone of a military chronicle that exists outside the narrative, as if to say, this is not a “story”; it is a “dictionary,” a technical list of participants taken from a military record.¹⁴ Perhaps this is why the names of the five kings are omitted in the second list. The second list is part of the story, and in the story the four kings are defeated; the omission of their names foreshadows this. This indication of future occurrences has no place in the initial dry and technical description of the war. The technical list blends in with the style of the first unit in the narrative, which is foreign to the Abraham cycle.

The most surprising element in the unit is the detailed description of the places conquered by the four kings. The locations themselves are irrelevant to the story, since Abram only chased the kings once they had left the area and traveled north. Nonetheless, the course of war is described at length.

The verses (14:5–7) mention four nations (Rephaim, Zuzim, Emim, Horites) who settle four areas (Ashteroth-karnaim, Ham, Shaveh-kiriathaim, and Seir), which were all conquered by the four kings in the fourteenth year. Later, two additional nations/locations were also conquered: the territory of the Amalekites, and the Amorites, who dwelt in Hazazon-tamar. This description plays no part in the present narrative, but the significance of the unit exceeds the

13 Kahana 1903, 45. For a discussion of when the order of the alphabet was established, see Assis 2007, 710, n. 1. As alphabetical order is common to western Semitic languages (beginning with Phoenician, and continued in Hebrew and Aramaic), it is reasonable to assume that from the beginning of written language in Israel, the alphabetical order of the consonants was the same as it is today. In fact, alphabet order was retained and reflected in the Greek written language as well (Naveh 1989, 169), which proves the stability of the accepted alphabetical order.

14 Van Seters (1975, 300) believes the first part of the story is taken from an ancient source. However, most scholars agree that the alliance against the eastern kings is incongruent with the patriarchal era (e.g., Kitchen 1994, 71–74).

scope of the story, and relates to later Israelite history. Cassuto (followed by others),¹⁵ noted that the names and nations mentioned in our narrative are repeated in Moses' description of the nation's journey to Canaan in Deuteronomy. In Deuteronomy the directions are reversed: the four kings traveled north to south, while the Children of Israel traveled south to north. The context of the journey in Deuteronomy is the prohibition to conquer certain areas from Ammon and Moab, the descendants of Esau and Lot, who received their portions of land from God. While in Gen 14 the four kings are the conquerors, in Deut 2 they are Abram's family (Lot and Esau):

| <i>The Journey of Israel (Deut 1–3)</i> | <i>The Journey of the Four Kings (Gen 14)</i> |
|--|---|
| It too counted as Rephaim country. It was formerly inhabited by Rephaim, whom the Ammonites call Zamzumim; a people great and numerous and as tall as the Anakites (2:20–21) | and defeated the Rephaim at Ashteroth-karnaim the Zuzim at Ham |
| It was formerly inhabited by the Emim, a people great and numerous, and as tall as the Anakites; they are counted as Rephaim, but the Moabites call the, Emim (2:11) | and the Emim in Shaveh-kiriathaim |
| Similarly, Seir was formerly inhabited by the Horites; but the descendants of Esau dispossessed them, wiping them out and settling in their place (2:12) | and the Horites in their hill country of Seir, as far as El-paran, which is by the wilderness |
| Thus, after you had remained at Kadesh all that long time, we marched back into the wilderness (1:46) | On their way back they came to En-mishpat, which is Kadesh, and subdued all the territory of the Amalekites |

The mention of Rephaim, Zuzim, Emim and Horites seems unnecessary both in Genesis, where the list fails to contribute any significant information to the narrative, and in Deuteronomy, where Moses describes the ancient history of the nations who used to inhabit those

15 See especially Astour 1966, 66–74; Schatz 1972; Kallai 1982; Mathews 2005; 143–144.

locations before they were conquered by Ammon and Moab. What is the significance of the link between the stories? Cassuto wrote:

Therefore, the nation of Israel can claim an ancient right, the merit of historical occupation – this is the purpose of the story before us – over the conquered areas, which they settled instead of the original occupants, and under the sovereignty of Edom, Ammon and Moab, whom David subverted... [T]hose areas were conquered in earlier generations by the Eastern Kings, and these were conquered by Abram, the father of Israel. Moses, in his conquests and passage through peaceful roads, and leaders of Israel in future generations until David, were only pursuing what was rightfully theirs from the days of Abram.¹⁶

Cassuto saw the link between the journey of the kings and that of the Israelite as an indication of the nation's merit as they traveled through the Transjordan. Since Abram was victorious over the four kings (even if symbolically – by returning the Sodomite captives and their belongings), from a broader historical perspective he merited those areas they had captured in the battle of Gen 14.¹⁷ Cassuto describes a complex biblical perception of the relationship between the nation of Israel and the Promised Land. According to his view, the inheritance of the land is multilayered: Canaan was promised to Abram at the start of his journey, when he was chosen by God; however, the Transjordan was added to Abram's initial inheritance after his heroic deeds in the War of the Kings. The addition is formalized in the following chapter, during the Covenant between the Pieces. This is the reason the Transjordan conquests by the four kings are described in such detail: this is no military chronicle with outdated background information; rather, the text provides details that justify Abram's rights to areas in the Transjordan. However, Cassuto's assertion that the link between Gen 14 and Deut 1–3 signifies that the national right to the Transjordan is unlikely, especially since the context in Deuteronomy is the prohibition on conquering those very same areas from the descendants

16 Cassuto 1990, 312–13.

17 Similar: Benzinger 1925. Compare with Astour 1966, 74, in contrast with Van Seters (1975, 306), who claimed that Abram is not portrayed as obtaining land for himself or his offspring.

of Esau.¹⁸ Therefore, the link should be redefined as Abram's right to the Transjordan – which is indeed inherited by his family. The Transjordan is not inherited by the sons of Jacob, but by other rejected members of Abram's family: the offspring of Lot and Esau.¹⁹ Here, too, the familial-nationalistic approach of Genesis comes into play (as I discussed in the introduction). As the descendants of Lot and Esau are considered part of Abraham's family, they are also granted inheritance in Abraham's merit, despite having been rejected from his covenant, and despite the perpetual conflict between Israel and these nations over the course of history. The nature of the initial list of kings, which was arranged alphabetically, reflects this broader historical perspective. Based on the internal relationship between the four nations, Chedorlaomer should be at the top of the list; however, the significance of the conquests supersedes the boundaries of this narrative and necessitates an order that indicates a broader historical perspective than the temporary political hierarchy of the time.

Lot's Rescue (8–16)

Verse 8 reviews the battling parties, and concludes: "Four kings against the five." Rashi commented on this mathematical equation: "Four kings against the five – and yet the fewer were victorious; this statement is expressly made to tell you how powerful they were, and yet Abram did not refrain from pursuing them." The reader, who knows that the four kings rule over northeastern world powers who have subjugated the

18 The narrative connection makes it difficult to accept Mathew's claim that the meaning of the connection between the stories is: "If father Abraham could defeat the invincible Kedorlaomer, the Israelites could take courage facing enemies in their own day" (Mathews 2005, 144). The context in Deuteronomy is that Israel is *prohibited* from fighting their enemies in Seir, Moab and Ammon.

19 There is therefore no reason to view vs. 5–7 as a vague geographical description or a later addition (Westermann [1985, 193] believes the ancient names of these nations originate in Deuteronomy).

entire ancient world, is not surprised that four such kings are victorious over five kings of medium-sized cities surrounding the Dead Sea. The suppression of the uprising was only done in the context of conquering the entire Transjordan. Cassuto, for example, refers to the four kings as “four wretched kings” throughout his commentary. The forces are far from equal, and there is no logical reason to assume the outcome would be different. Therefore, if the mathematical conclusion is meant to address the reader’s expectations, it should be read as an ironic comment, mocking the behavior of the King of Sodom: the five kings act as though they have some sort of advantage over the eastern empires. The five kings are the ones who go out to war in the Valley of Siddim; from their perspective, the forces battling are “four against five,” when the results of the battle are obvious from the outset. In the words of Beno Jacob: “The Bible ridicules these little potentates; their enterprise is megalomania. They, too, are “kings” even favored by the odds of five against four. The proud military expedition comes to a quick and sorry end.”²⁰ However, the literary purpose of the mathematical conclusion is to set a tone to the centrality of this world war: nine kings worldwide congregate in the battlefield, from Shinar, Ellasar, Elam, Goiim, Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah, and Zeboiim, and Zoar.²¹ A tenth king will be mentioned at the conclusion of the story – Melchizedek king of Salem, who greets Abram warmly when he returns from the battlefield. This design is significant to the purpose of the story: for the first time in his narrative cycle, Abram is portrayed as an important figure in the international political realm. The story also reveals that Abram has allies – Mamre, Eshkol, and Aner – as well as a battalion of 318 men.²² Abram’s entry into the military-political arena will be emphasized in his defeat of the

20 Jacob 1974, 95. This is a reinforcement of Rashi’s view: the mockery of the five kings enhances Abram’s heroism; perhaps not his physical heroism, but certainly his devotion to the cause. He risks his life and fights against a superpower in order to save his nephew. However, as stated above, I believe the math has another purpose.

21 Cf. von Rad 1963, 177.

22 Zimmerli wrote that the story reveals that Abram’s household consists of approximately 1000 people. Westermann argued that this was impossible, and suggested that the size of Abram’s camp was part of the analogy to the Judges narratives (especially Gideon) (Westermann 1995, 201).

four kings: “At night, he and his servants deployed against them and defeated them; and he pursued them as far as Hobah, which is north of Damascus” (14:15). Abram’s battalion could not have defeated hundreds of thousands of soldiers, and then chased them down; instead, they probably attacked one camp of war prisoners late one night, and released them and their possessions (similar to the military operation managed by Gideon in Judg 7:16–22). However, the phrases “defeated” and “pursued” convey complete military victory. The portrayal of the battle turns Abram into a true and equal statesman: he “defeated” the four kings just as they had “defeated” their adversaries in vs. 5 and 7.²³ According to Cassuto, this portrayal of Abram as a military commander merits Abram more land, as seen in the Covenant between the Pieces.

The mockery of the King of Sodom is enhanced by an additional wordplay in the conclusion of the war. The connotation of the word “fell” in the context of the battle might be “died in battle” (e.g., Ex 32:28). The reader’s first impression is that the King of Sodom died at the outset of the battle; only later does it become clear that he was in fact in hiding.

Here, a comparison is generated between the fleeing Kings of Sodom and Gomorrah and Abram and his troops, who pursue the eastern kings in an attempt to rescue the prisoners. While the Kings of Sodom and Gomorrah hide to save themselves, Abram and his allies take action for the good of others. Abram becomes a legitimate candidate for lordship in the land of Canaan; moreover, he valiantly chooses to maintain his status as Lot’s patron, even when the latter has chosen to settle in Sodom. The King of Sodom does not take an interest in the captives taken from his city, while Abram, who resides “at the terebinths of Mamre the Amorite” (13), risks his own life to return the prisoners to safety.

Wealth and possessions are emphasized as a motif in the narrative. The narrator focuses on these elements when describing the results of the initial battle:

23 Cf. Wenham 1987, 314. Westermann (1985, 201–02) “accused” v. 17 of creating the incorrect impression that Abram defeated empires using only foot soldiers. He believes this is nothing but “sloppy editing” and “a false impression”). However, we will demonstrate below that this relates to the purpose of the story, which seeks to portray Abram as relevant in the political field.

[The invaders] took all the wealth of Sodom and Gomorrah and all their provisions, and went their way.

They also took Lot, the son of Abram's brother, and his possessions, and departed; for he had settled in Sodom (11–12).

The four kings “take” two things: “all the wealth of Sodom and Gomorrah and all their provisions,” and “Lot...and his possession.” Only later does the reader discover that additional prisoners were taken – “the women and the rest of the people” (16). The initial omission of this fact, and the excessive focus on the possessions in place of the people, led some scholars to suggest an alternative version; instead of reading “and all their provisions” they suggested “all their prisoners.”²⁴ The fact that the narrator would ignore the prisoners is indeed surprising, and intends to greatly emphasize the possessions motif. From the perspective of the four kings, the battle centered on the possessions of Sodom; their victory is measured in terms of the wealth they had acquired. This motif will be emphasized in Abram's victory as well, but mention will be made of the people as well:

| <i>Return of the Wealth by Abram (16)</i> | <i>Capture of the Wealth by the Kings (11–12)</i> |
|--|--|
| He brought back all the possessions | [the invaders] took all the wealth of Sodom and Gomorrah and all their provisions, and went their way |
| He also brought back his brother ²⁶ Lot and his possessions | They also took Lot and his possessions, the son of Abram's brother, ²⁵ and departed; for he had settled in Sodom. |
| And the women and the rest of the people | |

24 Halevy 1895, 331. Westermann wrote that there is an incoherence between the military-political narrative (which only notes taking assets) and the family narrative (which mentions captives, particularly Lot; Westermann 1995, 198–99).

25 NJPS changed the order of the verse to “They also took Lot, the son of Abram's brother, and his possessions.”

26 NJPS translated אחי – “brother.”

Abram's retrieval of the possessions mirrors the taking of the possessions: the verb "brought back" appears twice in the former, while "took" appears twice in the latter.²⁷ When the possessions are returned, they are not attributed to Sodom and Gomorrah, as they are when they are taken. This abbreviation is reasonable, as it will later emerge that Abram has no interest in the possessions. One other difference between the compared scenes is the initial distance placed between Lot's name and his description as "the son of Abram's brother"; Lot's name and relation to Abram are separated by Lot's possessions: "They also *took Lot and his possessions*, the son of Abram's brother." The formulation is so strange, and so disruptive, that many viewed the words "and his possessions" as a later addition to the text.²⁸ This awkward phrase, however, serves to further emphasize possessions as a major motif in this episode; implying that Lot cannot be separated from his possessions, not even when he is taken captive, not even by a statement revealing his family connections and describing him as Abram's nephew.²⁹ The formulation is "corrected" after Abram's rescue mission: "He also brought back *his brother Lot and his possessions*." The third and most significant distinction between the two episodes is the mention of the "women and the rest of the people," who were apparently also taken captive. Their captivity is only revealed to the reader after Abram rescues them. The fact that the women and the others are an addition is emphasized by the chiasmic form of the other components in the verse:

He brought back
All the possessions
 And also his brother Lot
 And his *possessions*
He brought back

27 Wenham 1987, 315.

28 BH, 18.

29 This is reminiscent of Gen 12:5; see discussion on this verse in previous chapters.

The reader's impression is that the list of returned components is complete, and includes Lot and possessions.³⁰ This impression is reinforced by the fact that it mirrors the original list of components that were taken, and the reader has no additional expectations. It is then related that there were other captives who were returned to Sodom by Abram. The design emphasizes the centrality of possessions, which are given even more attention than the people of Sodom.³¹

Abram Takes Action

Abram is not mentioned in the story at all as an active character; only when the rumor of recent events reaches Abram's ears is the reader reminded of the context of the story, which is in the middle of the Abraham cycle. Many scholars feel this is the beginning of a "new story"³² and argue whether the earlier story is the Battle of Kings (von Rad) or Abram's intervention (Procksch, Emerton). In this instance, however, the unique design of the story also contributes to its purpose.

The narrative describes the rumor Abram hears, and then inserts a comment about his allies: "A fugitive brought the news to Abram the Hebrew, who was dwelling at the terebinths of Mamre the Amorite, brother of Eshkol and brother of Aner, these being Abram's allies" (13). The reader learns that Abram is not alone; he is surrounded by allies who can assist him in his war. However, since Aner and Mamre do not take part in the actual battle, the mention of these allies seems irrelevant. The names are mentioned again only at the end of the story,

30 In an attempt to make the translated text flow, the translator sometimes "loses" the wordplay. The Septuagint omitted the root הָשִׁיב ("brought back"), which appears after Lot's name, and before the women and the rest of the people.

31 Based on verses that depict the women as part of the spoils of war (Deut 21:10–14; 2 Kgs 5:2), Wenham suggested that the women here are depicted as an element of the spoils (Wenham 1987, 315). However, his interpretation fails to relate to the absence of the women from the outset.

32 Dillmann 1897, 46.

when Abram insists that they receive a portion of the spoils (14:24). This, of course is even more surprising: why are Abram's friends significant enough to warrant mention at the end of the story, when they made no apparent contribution to the war?

Perhaps the verse should be read as preface to the following verse: "When Abram heard that his brother had been taken captive, he mustered his retainers, born into his household, numbering three hundred and eighteen, and went in pursuit as far as Dan" (14). The narrator emphasizes the distance between Abram's "brother," who dwells in Sodom, and the strangers who surround Abram and become his allies. "Allies" is described using the same word as "covenant" – ברית, which is only one of many links between this narrative and the Covenant between the Pieces in the following chapter.³³ The covenant with God was previously described as a replacement for family ties; here the allies are replacements for the biological "brother." Abram is not as lonely as one would think, since he forms alliances with the inhabitants of the land. The fact that Abram has allies highlights his devotion to his nephew; when Abram hears that his nephew has been captured, there is no deliberation or hesitation. He takes immediate action: "When Abram heard that his brother had been taken captive, he mustered his retainers." Lot is not described as Abram's "brother's son," but rather as Abram's "brother," both here and in vs. 14 and 16. While Lot willingly distances himself from his uncle, Abram comes to his nephew's rescue without a second thought.

Abram Meets with the Kings (17–24)

When Abram returns from the battle, he meets with the King of Sodom (17; 21–24) and Melchizedek, King of Salem (18–20). Many scholars question whether both meetings are included in the same original unit. Some assert that the original story ended with Abram's meeting with

33 Regarding the term ברית בעל ("ally"), see Schmitt 1964; Kutsch 1967.

Melchizedek, and the meeting with the King of Sodom is a later addition to the text (Procksch; Astour), while others argue that the meeting with Melchizedek was added to the text of Abram's meeting with the King of Sodom (Morgenstern, Gunkel, von Rad, Kutsch, Bowker, Emerton, Westermann, and Eissfeldt).³⁴ The textual trigger for this debate is the sudden leap from the King of Sodom to Melchizedek. Following a caption that amply prepares the reader for the meeting with the King of Sodom ("the King of Sodom came out to meet him when he returned from defeating Chedorlaomer" – v. 17), suddenly the reader is told of Abram's meeting with Melchizedek, who is mentioned for the first time ("And King Melchizedek of Salem brought out bread and wine; and he was a priest of God Most High" – v. 18). After the meeting with Melchizedek, the dialogue between Abram and the King of Sodom is then related (22–24). This leap seems like an indication of a disharmonious text. Additionally, there are scholars who claimed that the content of the two meetings is incompatible: "18–21 is a separate story, conflicting to the other; the one reveals that Abram gave one tenth of the spoils to Melchizedek, while there is no indication of this in v. 24!"³⁵ Kahana noted that after Abram relinquished his rights to the property, he ensured the rights of his allies to whatever they had eaten to sustain themselves during the war; but he did not mention the tithe he had given to Melchizedek.³⁶

Other scholars, however, have pointed to the similarity in the formulation of the two episodes, which seem to be deeply linked. The

34 This approach is based on the etiological-liturgical approach regarding the meeting between Abram and Melchizedek (see esp. Emerton 1971, 407–26).

35 Kahana 1903, 48. See also Astour 1966. Wenham objected: "To see a conflict between v. 20 and vs. 21–24 is over-subtle (Wenham 1987, 317).

36 R. Samuel ben Meir was sensitive to this point, but explained to the contrary: "Therefore, there is a break between 'And the king of Sodom went out' and 'And the king of Sodom said,' and between these it is written 'And Melchizedek king of Salem brought forth bread and wine,' in order to show that Abram is truthful when he said to the king of Sodom, 'save only that which the young men have eaten,' for he said the young men had eaten, not 'we have eaten'; he had eaten from that of Melchizedek" (printed in Rashbam's commentary on Gen 14:18, *Torat Haim* edition, based on *Hadar Zekenim* 6:1 and *Sefer Minbat Yehuda* 6:3).

stories “argue” with each other, but also “converse” with each other. The joint subject – the king of a major city in Canaan greeting Abram upon his return from battle – creates an essential analogy between the two scenes. This analogy is enhanced by the linguistic and textual similarities:³⁷

| <i>King of Sodom (14:18–20)</i> | <i>Melchizedek (14:17 and 21–24)</i> |
|--|---|
| the King of Sodom came out to meet him | and King Melchizedek of Salem brought out bread and wine; he was a priest of God Most High. |
| Abram said to the King of Sodom, “I swear to the Lord, God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth” | blessed be Abram of God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth;
20: and blessed be God Most High, who has delivered your foes into your hand |
| Give me the persons, and take the possessions for yourself | And he gave him a tenth of everything |

Both kings go out to greet Abram. In the Hebrew syntax, Melchizedek’s name and title appear before the verb, whereas the verb “came out” precedes the name and title of the King of Sodom. This style often indicates contrast: while the King of Sodom “came out” – “וַיֵּצֵא” - toward Abram, Melchizedek “brought out” – “וַהֲרִיצֵא” - bread and wine. The unique name Abram uses for God, “God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth,” is learned from his meeting with Melchizedek; the significance of naming one’s God indicates the impact the meeting with Melchizedek had on Abram.

Others suggested a chiasmic structure for the unit:³⁸

37 E.g., Smith 1965; Zimmerli 1967. Both believe that the meeting of Abram and Melchizedek is a later addition to the original narrative, which had only discussed the King of Sodom (see Smith, p. 130). However, neither referred to the dialogue conducted between the two units. In an attempt to establish the uniformity of the text, Wenham emphasized some of the links between various parts of the story (Wenham 1987, 305). See also Elgavish 2001, 506–07.

38 Ross 1988, 295. An alternative chiasmic structure is suggested by Wenham 1987, 315. I am skeptical about the stability of the structure.

- a. *King of Sodom (17)*
When he returned from defeating Chedorlaomer and the kings with him, the King of Sodom came out to meet him in the Valley of Shaveh, which is the Valley of the King.
- b. *Melchizedek offers Abram (18)*
And King Melchizedek of Salem brought out bread and wine; he was a priest of God Most High.
- c. *Melchizedek blesses Abram (19)*
He blessed him, saying, “blessed be Abram of God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth.
- c1. *Melchizedek blesses God (20)*
And blessed be God Most High, who has delivered your foes into your hand
- b1. *Melchizedek receives from Abram (20)*
And [Abram] gave him a tenth of everything.
- a1. *King of Sodom (21–24)*
Then the King of Sodom said to Abram: “Give me the persons, and take the possessions for yourself”... as for the share of the men who went with me – Aner, Eshkol, and Mamre – let them take their share.

If the structure is convincing, the meeting with Melchizedek and the King of Sodom should certainly be viewed as part of the same organic unit; but even so, why does the meeting with the King of Sodom interrupted by a report about Melchizedek? Verses 21–24 should logically resume at v. 17. Perhaps the two meetings were depicted thus in order to allow for a simultaneous and comparative reading between them. The comparison is enhanced by the similar formulations used to describe both meetings. The essence of the comparison is Abram’s relationship with each of the kings.

Abram clearly regards each king differently: the meeting with Melchizedek emanates pleasant friendship, and an exchange of goods as part of a respectful normative and religious relationship. Melchizedek inexplicably offers Abram “bread and wine.” This gift might be a symbol of agreement,³⁹ although a more likely explanation would be a feast

39 This was pointed out by Vawter (1977) and later by Elgavish (2001, 499–500). The word “blessing” connotes the covenant in this context.

honoring kings.⁴⁰ Abram offers Melchizedek “a tenth of everything,” since Melchizedek is defined as a priest. The syntax of this verse is vague, and since Melchizedek is the explicit noun related to previous actions in the verse, and there is no indication that the subject has changed, at first glance it would seem that Melchizedek is the one who offers Abram a tenth of everything. However, based on the context it is clearly Abram, who has returned with the spoils, who offers Melchizedek a tenth of everything, which is of course appropriate since Melchizedek is a priest.⁴¹ The tension between the syntax and the content of the verse⁴² led most translators to prefer the content, and name Abram as the giver of the tithe.⁴³ But an alternative reading can also be found among biblical scholars.⁴⁴

40 See, among others, Wenham 1987, 316. Cf. Rashi: “This is done for those weary from battle,” and similarly R. Obadiah Sforno. Skinner also viewed the meal as one offered to soldiers returning from the battlefield (Skinner 1930, 268). Hamilton commented that Melchizedek’s concern for the soldiers attests to his humane personality (Hamilton 1990, 407–08).

41 Some commentators viewed this scene as etiological with the ritualistic purpose of establishing the receiver of tithes as a priest (e.g., Westermann 1995, 203). For additional etiological-ritualistic approaches see Emerton 1971, 414–26.

42 Kogut 2002, 101: “an ambiguity surrounds the people behind [he] gave him.” See also Peter 1979.

43 Modern translations agree that Abram is the subject of the sentence (e.g., Skinner; Hertz; Cohen; Wenham; Rosenberg; Sherman; Speiser and Kaplan). Some included Abram’s name in their translation: “Abram gave him a tithe of all the booty” (Speiser 1964, 100; Kaplan 1981, 65; Davidson 1979, 32. Hamilton (1990, 413, note 12) viewed the tithe as similar to the division of spoils between the fighters and the people who remain in the camp in the war against Midian (Num 31). However, the narrative does not portray Abram and Melchizedek as a united front against the kings, as in the war against Midian. Elgavish compared the tithe to the division of spoils at the conclusion of the war against Midian, of which a donation was made by the Israelites to the tabernacle (Num 31:28–30). He believed the tithe given by Abram to Melchizedek was symbolic of a political alliance (similar to the alliance made between Abram and Abimelekh in ch. 21) (Elgavish 2001, 502).

44 Smith wrote that the giver is Melchizedek, so that Abram may leave his city in peace (Smith 1965, 130, note 3). A similar idea was expressed by the medieval commentators Radak and Hizkuni. It is worth noting that Radak and

Even if the reader can easily figure out that it was Abram who gave the tithe, the vague writing style creates a literary awareness that plays an important role in the design of this scene.⁴⁵ The reader is made to feel that even if in reality it was Abram who offered the tithe, the literary reality would *justify* a reversal of roles. The advantage of this dual reading is the reciprocal relationship between Abram and Melchizedek, as if to say, it really doesn't matter who gave to whom; the two characters are inseparable and equal.⁴⁶ Perhaps the two meet in the Valley of Shaveh ("equal") for this reason.⁴⁷

The ambiguity in the story is also indicative of the high regard in which Melchizedek is held. In early exegetical literature Melchizedek merited special status: in Qumran he is regarded as an angel, and rabbinic literature identifies him as Shem, son of Noah.⁴⁸ This identification is probably based on the presumption that the expression "God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth" refers to the God of Abram. The general atmosphere of the narrative cycle assumes that only Abram recognizes God, and only because of God's revelation to him. Melchizedek is the king of a Canaanite city, and is most likely the priest of a Canaanite god. Generations of scholars believed that the expression *El-Elyōn* relates to a specific god (the name of the god being El), in reference to the head of the Canaanite pantheon.⁴⁹

Hizkuni did not use the syntax as proof of their position, and instead relied upon content.

- 45 Based on the ambiguous syntax in the verse, Fitzmyer (2000, 67) asserted that in the original source Melchizedek gave Abram a tithe, thus becoming his ally; in our version the act became ambiguous. As stated above, I believe the ambiguity is a deliberate literary tool.
- 46 Hamilton (1990, 410) compared the double positions that they both seem to serve: priest and king. In his opinion, Abram functions as a priest in the story as well (he builds altars and performs circumcisions) and is compared to a king ("you are a mighty prince among us" – Gen 23:6).
- 47 For this meaning of "Shaveh" see BDB, p. 1001.
- 48 See Kugel 1997, 160. The gospels describe Melchizedek as a child of God and an everlasting priest (Fitzmyer 2000). See also Enoch 2:23.
- 49 Della Vida 1944; Pope 1955; Clements 1965, 40–62; Rendtorff 1996, 1967; Cross 1973, 44–60; Miller 2000, 24–44 ("El, the Creator of Earth") and 45–50 ("El the Warrior"); Uffenheimer 1977. Regarding the correlation between the

Recently this theory has been questioned because no documentation exists referring to the Canaanite *El* as “Most High.”⁵⁰ The debate has not been resolved, but if the expression “God (El) Most High” indicates a Canaanite god, clearly that would make Melchizedek a Canaanite priest. Thus, when Abram uses the very same name to describe his god, he “converts” the name from a private/Canaanite name to a general title accompanied by the name of God: “I swear to *Yahweh*, God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth.”⁵¹ Speiser’s translation reflects this reading.⁵²

Blessed be Abram by *El-Elyōn* / Creator of heaven...
and praised be *El-Elyōn* Who has delivered...
I have sworn to *Yahweh*, *God Most High*...

Mathews added that Melchizedek’s formulation “Blessed be Abram by *El-Elyōn*” differs from other biblical blessings. The common formulation of a biblical blessing is “blessed...of the Lord” (Judg 17:2; Ruth 2:20 and 3:10; 1 Sam 15:13 and 23:21; 2 Sam 2:5; Ps 115:15). He believes the distinction indicates that Melchizedek is a Canaanite king who has no knowledge of God’s name, and therefore surmises that *El-Elyōn* is a private name of a specific God.⁵³ While his proof is not indisputable, the text lacks sufficient information to clearly determine the identity of Melchizedek and his god. This omission is surprising considering that Abram seems to form an allegiance with him and offers him a tithe, without the reader knowing his background and beliefs. If Melchizedek is indeed a Canaanite priest, the purpose of

expression “Creator of heaven and earth” and the Canaanite god “El,” see de Moor 1980, 87–171.

50 See Elnes & Miller 1999. Cf. Emerton 1990; Pagolu 1998, 185–86.

51 See comprehensive discussion in Grossman 2008, 35–36. For historical speculation regarding the time of authorship in light of the wordplay, see Wenham 1987, 318.

52 Speiser 1964, 100.

53 Mathews 2005, 149.

the omission might be the attempt to present Melchizedek and his relationship with Abram in a favorable light.⁵⁴

The meeting with the King of Sodom leaves the reader with an entirely different impression. In v. 17 the King of Sodom goes out to greet Abram, which creates anticipation for a friendly welcome or a call for peace. Instead, the conversation with the King of Sodom revolves around the question of possessions. The King of Sodom offers Abram the possessions he had recovered from the four kings; but here – in contrast with the episode with Melchizedek – Abram absolutely refuses to accept the offer: “But Abram said to the King of Sodom, “I swear to the Lord, God Most High, Creator of heaven and earth; I will not take so much as a thread or a sandal strap of what is yours; you shall not say, ‘it is I who made Abram rich.’” (14:22–23). Various elements in Abram’s statement emphasize his hostility toward the King of Sodom:

1. Whatever the reason for Abram’s refusal, he could have chosen to express himself in another way. Abram’s oath expresses firmness and determination. Abram leaves no room for negation or reevaluation. Moreover, an oath in the name of God adds a religious element to his refusal; it is Abram’s loyalty to God that prevents him from accepting gifts from Sodom.⁵⁵
2. While Abram absolutely refuses to forge a friendship with the King of Sodom, he consistently alludes to his friendly relationship with Melchizedek. Abram repeats the name for God that he had

54 Westermann wrote: “The purpose is to designate the god of a Canaanite shrine, but at the same time to speak of him in such a way that Abraham can acknowledge him” (Westermann 1995, 204).

55 Similar to Samuel’s command to Saul on the eve of the war against Amalek: “Now go and smite Amalek, and utterly destroy all that they have, and spare them not; but slay both man and woman, infant and suckling, ox and sheep, camel and ass” (1 Sam 15:3). The expression “infant and suckling,” as the expression “camel and ass” signifies “not only an infant, but even a suckling,” “not only a camel, but even a donkey,” in contrast to “both man and woman,” or “ox and sheep,” which function as a standard polar merismos (a description of boundaries, which in fact include everything in between; however, see also Berlin 2008, 7). On the classic merismos, see Alonso Schökel 2000, 83–84.

learned from Melchizedek; in other words, Melchizedek taught Abram a divine name, which Abram uses to disengage from the King of Sodom. The word **העשרתי** (“it is I who made Abram rich” – v. 23) is reminiscent of the word **מעשר** (“a tenth”), which Abram offers Melchizedek (20).⁵⁶ This too is an accentuation of the difference between the king Abram awards with a tithe, contrasted with the king with whom Abram rejects any type of association. This reinforces Abram’s rejection of the King of Sodom; the reader cannot assume that the reason Abram rejects the King of Sodom so vehemently is his desire to distance himself from the kings of Canaan. Abram’s relationship with Melchizedek would make this interpretation unacceptable.

3. Abram explains that he does not accept the offer of the King of Sodom so that the latter will not be able to say “it is I who made Abram rich.” This information is offered without further explanation. Is this a personal statement against the King of Sodom? A theological statement? Why is Abram suddenly reluctant to become rich by another king, when in Egypt he had no qualms about doing so? The significance of Abram’s refusal needs to be examined within the greater significance of the story as a whole, through the perspective of the recurring motif of possessions.

The distinction between the two kings who met with Abram in the Valley of Shaveh is expressed in the associations with the kings’ names. The King of Sodom is called Bera, which, as Rashi (on 14:2) pointed out, connoted “Bera – Evil (**רע**) towards God and evil towards mankind.”⁵⁷ The people of Sodom were described similarly in the previous story: “Now the inhabitants of Sodom were very wicked sinners against the Lord” (13:13); the king’s name represents (or reflects) the

⁵⁶ Dore 1981; Wenham 1987, 318.

⁵⁷ Commentators have discussed both the literary and etymological significance of the names of the five kings (e.g., Albright 1961, 49; Sarna 1966, 111–12; Wenham 1987, 309; Hamilton 1990, 401). Elgavish (2001, 496) noted the negative connotation, and claimed that the names should only be viewed as a literary tool. He wrote that this is the reason the names are not repeated when the names of the four kings are mentioned for the second time (v. 8–9).

nature of his community. Melchizedek's name is more difficult to decipher: is the component *zedek* part of the full name, or is Melchizedek comprised of two components that describe the nature of the king – *Melchi* (“my king”) *zedek* (“justice”), whereas his private name is omitted from the text altogether? If *zedek* is part of his private name, this connotes a positive evaluation of the king. Speiser's interpretation was more technical: he wrote that Melchizedek means “the just king,” which legitimizes Melchizedek's monarchy (like Sargon the Ashurite);⁵⁸ nonetheless, the concept *zedek* carries strong, positive connotations. The following story will use the same term to describe the relationship between Abram and God: “And because he put his trust in the Lord, He reckoned it to his *merit* (מֶצֶדֶק – *zedaka*)” (15:6); the narrator will use the same term to justify the selection of Abram in the discussion on the discussion of Sodom: “for I have singled him out that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is *just* (מֶצֶדֶק – *zedaka*) and right” (18:19).⁵⁹ Whether *zedek* denotes a personal quality, a city, or a name, the associations that accompany the word are unequivocally positive.⁶⁰

What, then, is the literary purpose of the contrast between the two kings? It seems unlikely that Abram had been employed to fight Melchizedek's wars.⁶¹ Rather, presenting the alliance between Abram and Melchizedek contributes to characterization on two levels. Many scholars believe that Melchizedek is a symbol of Jerusalem. This concept is based on the etymological identification of “Salem” with

58 Speiser 1964, 104.

59 This position was adopted by Hamilton 1990, 409 (although he also raises the possibility “my king is legitimate”). Westermann, and Wenham – following Noth – viewed the root מֶלֶךְ (“king”) in Melchizedek's name as a deity (Westermann 1995, 204); Wenham 1987, 316. This does not contradict the positive connotation of Melchizedek's name, although it is less reflective of his personality.

60 Albright asserted that the meaning of the word שָׁלֵם (Shalem/Salem) in the verse is peace, and the combination שָׁלֵם מֶלֶךְ denotes “man of peace” or “ally” (Albright 1961, 52). According to Albright this is not an association but the primary literary significance of the name.

61 Together with Pagolu 1998, 188; unlike Fisher 1962, 269.

“Jerusalem.” This interpretation can be found as early as Onkelos’ translation of v. 18: “and Melchizedek king of Jerusalem brought out bread and wine.”⁶² This intimation is reinforced by the definition of Melchizedek as a priest and the tithe given to him by Abram.⁶³

According to this interpretation, the purpose of the contrast between Melchizedek and the King of Sodom in the story reflects the contrast between Sodom and Jerusalem. This conflict accompanies the reader throughout the Bible, and is expressed explicitly in Isaiah 1 and Ezekiel 16. The story alludes to God’s choice of Jerusalem and what the city represents: justice. This choice is in itself a rejection of Sodom and the values it represents, as seen in Gen 19.

The evidence that links Melchizedek with Jerusalem is not unequivocal. Moreover, the biblical Salem often connotes the Shechem area, not Jerusalem (Gen 33:18).⁶⁴ The true literary purpose of Melchizedek’s offer is the contrast his character offers to the King of Sodom.⁶⁵ The reader might have thought that Abram’s participation in the war and the retrieval of Sodom’s captives and riches could have been the foundation for a relationship between Abram and the King of Sodom. The final episode of the story refutes this possibility. Abram’s clear disengagement from the King of Sodom illuminates the fact that Lot’s rescue was a personal endeavor. Melchizedek, who had nothing to gain from the war, greeted Abram with bread and wine, and Abram offered him his allegiance, while the King of Sodom, who had prisoners and riches returned to his city by Abram, did not go out to

62 Cf. 1 Sam 18:18. This is the impression from the Amarna letters, which refer to Jerusalem as “Uru-salim” (“uru” probably denotes “city”). See Westermann 1995, 204; Hamilton 1990, 409–10.

63 Schatz 1972; Baltzer 1990; Amit 2000-B. Elgavish (2001) claims that the root **שָׁלַם** is frequently incorporated into names of characters associated with Jerusalem, and added that this identification is apparent in the Genesis Apocryphon found by the Dead Sea.

64 Some ancient translations viewed the word **שָׁלֵם** (Salem) as the name of a place (Septuagint; Peshitta; Vulgate). This interpretation is accepted by many modern scholars. MacKay (1948/9, 127) identified Salem with a city near Shechem. Elgavish (2001, 498) claimed that the word Salem indicates both Shechem and Jerusalem.

65 See Leibowitz 1966, 93–96.

greet him with a celebration, and Abram refused to forge any kind of relationship with him.⁶⁶

Abram's disengagement from Sodom is also reflected by the choice of meeting place: the Valley of Shaveh, which is the Valley of the King; in other words, not in Sodom. Abram does not return the prisoners to their city; the King of Sodom goes out to him and receives his people in the valley. The geographical locations are symbolic of Abram's values: Abram will not set foot in Sodom. His antipathy toward the people of Sodom relates to their description in the previous chapter: "Now the inhabitants of Sodom were very wicked sinners against the Lord" (13:13). This implies that Abram does not reject alliances with Canaanite kings on principle, as illustrated by the fact that Abram does forge an alliance with Melchizedek, a just king with acceptable morals.⁶⁷

Abram's objection to connect with the King of Sodom might also be expressed by an analogical reading of the narrative alongside the story of Gideon (Judg 6–8). Various scholars noted the many links between the stories,⁶⁸ including Westermann, who argues that the analogy suggests that Abram's refusal to connect with the king of Sodom should be viewed as a rejection of suggested monarchy, as Gideon rejected the kingship he was offered when he defeated the enemies of Israel.⁶⁹ This reading might clarify the meeting place in the "Valley of

66 Gelandner (1990, 48–56) suggested that the purpose of the scene is to show that although Abram received the honor of kings (when honored by Melchizedek), he was not blinded by this honor when facing the King of Sodom, and was willing to forgo significant riches.

67 Wenham (1987, 321–22) wrote that Abram's attitude toward the King of Sodom (particularly his impertinent request) foreshadows the future of Sodom, in accordance with "I shall curse those who curse you" (Gen 12:3).

68 Among others, Emerton 1971; Sasson and Grossman 2007, 23–25. Harvey (2004, 38), shows that the analogy between Abram and Gideon exceeds chapter 14 and includes elements of the entire Abraham cycle.

69 Westermann (1985, 202) asserted that Abram's rejection of the offer to become king is similar to Gideon's rejection of the kingship. However, McConville (1994, 100–01) rejected this conclusion and suggested another context: Gideon is portrayed as a charismatic warrior acting on behalf of his nation and land, while Abram saves his nephew from captivity.

the King”; as the midrash comments in its colorful language: “How do we know that [Abraham] was made king? As it is written ‘to the Valley of Shaveh, which is the Valley of the King’; why ‘Shaveh the Valley of the King?’ They all agreed and chopped down cedars and made a chair and enthroned him as their king.”⁷⁰ Westermann’s formulation might be extreme, and there is certainly no explicit offer of kingship; however, the atmosphere of the story certainly supports the concept. In this narrative, Abram becomes an influential political figure and is regarded as such by the inhabitants of the land.⁷¹

Another interesting element in the conclusion of the story is the absence of Lot. After everything Abram went through to rescue his nephew, one would expect Lot to return to the household of his uncle. Instead, no emotional reunion is mentioned, and the reader only discovers inadvertently in a later story that Lot had in fact returned to Sodom. Instead of mentioning Lot, Abram ensures the just reward of his “replacements,” Aner, Eshkol and Mamre (24). The final verse of the narrative mentions Abram’s current allies; instead of the anticipated reunion with Lot, Abram’s new friends emphasize his renewed absence.

In light of these observations, we can return to the broader meaning of the story. As noted earlier, one of the dominant and consistent characteristics in the story is the absence of divine intervention. The literary void is filled with stories about Abram, who transforms into a military commander and a politician who associates with Canaanite kings and battles the kings of the east. Until this point Abram merited God’s blessings; in this chapter he receives the blessings of Melchizedek.⁷² Abram becomes part of the political map of ancient

70 Num Rab 15:14 (and parallels).

71 Perhaps this relates to עברי (Hebrew), the unique term used in the narrative to describe Abram. For a broader discussion of various uses of the term, see Van Uchelen 1964. He discussed genealogical aspects (pp. 5–26); geographical aspects (pp. 27–47); the integration of the term in our chapter (pp. 48–70), and the sociological significance of the term (pp. 71–105).

72 Wenham (1987, 317) viewed the blessing as a fulfillment of God’s promise to Abram: “I will bless those who bless you” (12:3).

Canaan. He is no longer only a private person who has gained God's protection; he is an important public figure.

The details embedded in the story give the feeling of a historical chronicle. This idea is expressed through the style of the narrative in details such as the alphabetical list of kings and the conquered territories, the number of Abram's troops, and the details of the midnight rescue operation. The difference between the reality of the rescue operation (a nighttime action against one prisoner camp) and the terms in which it is described (as though Abram defeated the entire army and successfully chased them) wishes to portray Abram as a military commander who leads his troops to war. The purpose of this portrayal is to convey that Abram's inheritance of the land is not only a result of God's blessings, but is also due to his own application of wisdom and might in his involvement in local and world politics. On the moral plane his merit is also expressed by his attitude toward the two kings: he rejected the company of those who are "evil sinners against the Lord," and accepted the companionship of those who recognize the Creator of heaven and earth.

This idea also sheds light on the emphasis of the possessions motif. The story ends with Abram's refusal to accept riches, which might have been linked to Abram's refusal to be associated with the values of an evil place, had the previous chapter not revealed that Abram was willing to receive riches from Egypt. We previously noted that the riches Abram received in Egypt were regarded as a fulfillment of God's blessings to Abram. Why can't the Sodomite riches be perceived in the same way?⁷³

In the context of Abram's oath, he names God "Creator of heaven and earth." This borrowed title is also an explanation for Abram's refusal to receive possessions from the King of Sodom. Since Abram's mission is to acknowledge God and His possession of heaven and earth, accepting wealth from the King of Sodom, who

73 Regarding the legitimacy of Abram taking spoils from the battle he had won, researchers of the era agree that according to prevalent war laws the spoils belonged to Abram. See Muffs 1982, 86, note 1; Elgavish 2001, 502. (Regarding the custom of taking spoils in the Bible, see De Vaux 1965, 254–57).

would take credit for enriching Abram, would contradict his life's work.⁷⁴ Abram's statement conveys that becoming rich by the King of Sodom is an alternative to becoming rich by the hands of God. The difference between Egypt and Sodom is the way in which the riches were acquired: in Egypt, God intervened on Abram's behalf, and the "battle" resulted in Abram becoming rich. Since God does not intervene in Abram's war against the kings, and the battle is won on a natural human plane, receiving riches as a result would not be perceived as connected to God's blessing, and instead might be attributed to the King of Sodom.⁷⁵

Now we can examine the meaning of the narrative and its contribution to the story cycle. The unique design of the story indicates a unique purpose. In this narrative, Abram merits inheriting the land not because he was chosen to be blessed by God, but due to his conduct as an ambassador and an army general, forced to take action against kings and lead troops in battle. The story focuses on the description of the battle between the kings, thereby emphasizing Abram's entry into a true military arena, and how significant he has become in the political realm. The story lacks God's direct involvement, and the blessings of land and offspring. In this narrative, Abram proves that he is worthy of inheriting the land by natural actions and involvement in the political and military sphere. And as I discuss in the introduction, Abram's political breakthrough is achieved through a story of moral conquest – for the sake of rescuing his nephew from prison, not in order to display his power and might. It should therefore not be surprising that in the next chapter – which is linked with ours – God will make a covenant with Abram, and promise him that he will inherit the Promised Land.

74 This reading is reinforced by Nahmanides' position that קונה ("Maker") does not denote "creator," but rather "owner of." According to this interpretation, Abram's emphasis is not on God as the creator, but rather as the owner of all land and property (see Leibowitz 1966, 95–96. See also Katz 1954; Vawter 1980.

75 Moreover, Sodom is included in the borders of Canaan – the Promised Land; thus receiving assets from Sodom is a hinted approval of Abram's association with the city, as opposed to accumulating wealth in Egypt, which is not included in the promises to Abram.

Chapter 6: Looking to the Stars and the Covenant between the Pieces (15)

Gen 15 can be read as either one or two literary units. In the first part of the chapter (vs. 1–6) Abram is promised a son, while the second part (7–22) describes the Covenant between the Pieces – the covenant of the land. Many scholars believe the two accounts are unrelated, and some believe they stem from different sources, or two different literary layers.¹ Anbar wrote: “The chapter is the result of a combination of two different stories: the first comprises vs. 1–6, and the second vs. 7–21...each of the units is an independent composition, inspired by ancient sources. The first story is based on two motifs: the promise of a son, and the promise of a multitude of offspring, while the second story centers on the motif of the Promised Land.”² Others argued that the story is unified: “Thus, at both levels of theme and literary composition, Gen 15 is a coherent and closely knit whole, whose unity has been remarkably worked out by its author.”³ And in a more extreme formulation: “There is no real break of continuity but,

1 E.g., Staerk 1899, 61; Gunkel 1966, 176–78; Skinner 1930, 276–77; von Rad, 1963, 177 (von Rad ultimately agrees that although the units are separate, there is an effort to unify them into one story – p. 181); Kilian 1966, 36–72; Zimmerli 1967, 48–59; Schmidt 2006. According to some scholars, there are traces of E in the text (e.g., Skinner 1930, 276–84; von Rad, 1963, 177).

2 Anbar 1979, 35; 51.

3 Ha 1989, 58. See also Van Seters 1975, 249. This approach was also adopted by Schmid (1976, 119–43), who discusses the date of authorship; however, beyond the historical question, he interprets both stories as one unit; Rendtorff (1977) believed that the unity of the chapter is realized in the final stage of editing. He noted linguistic links between the two parts of the chapter, such as the recurring roots ירש (inherited) and זרע (seed/offspring). See also Westermann 1995, 250–75.

on the contrary, an unbroken thread ties up all the verses and themes into a neat whole.”⁴

Three textual elements indicate that the two promises should be viewed as two separate units:

- a. Opening and closing statements: v. 6, which concludes the promise of an heir, clearly marks the end of a unit. The narrator appears to summarize the previous dialogue. Moreover, in v. 7, which opens the covenant on the land, God introduces Himself to Abram, a statement that conveys the feeling that this is a new episode.
- b. Definition of time: Gen 15 includes gaps in time that make continuous reading impossible. In the first unit Abram is shown stars (15:5), indicating that the conversation takes place at night. The second unit takes place at sundown: “As the sun was about to set” (12), and later “When the sun set and it was very dark” (17). The story cannot be continuous if it begins at night (when the stars are out) and continues at sundown; there is no indication that an entire day has passed between the first and second definition of time.⁵
- c. Narrative materials: The two units carry two different tidings: one regarding offspring and the other relating to the promise of land. The two tidings are organically linked in future revelations. For example, ch. 13 relates entirely to the inheritance of the land, but in v. 16 God promises: “I will make your offspring as the dust of

4 Ha 1989, 39. See pp. 33–38 for a survey of studies that view the chapter as one unit.

5 This is the proof of the majority of scholars who separate the story into two units; however, the story can be read as continuous nonetheless: Abram was told about the multitudes of offspring he is going to father one night, and the following day he received another prophecy regarding the covenant on the land; he proceeded to prepare for the covenant that entire day, and at sunset the flaming torch passed between the pieces, and only then Abram heard the contents of the covenant (see Kiel 1997, 425). In light of this difficulty, Noegel suggested that God had taken Abram outside to count the stars during the day, and the statement “if you are able to count them” is rhetorical. He believed this is symbolic of Abram’s test, since he is expected to believe “blindly.” This indeed, should be “reckoned to his merit” (Noegel 1998).

the earth..." (13:16) and immediately returns to the discussion of the Promised Land. The two tidings are frequently linked, but not in this case. In ch. 15, each message is portrayed independently of the other, which reinforces the contention that the units are separate.⁶

However, there are other parameters that indicate a unified story, or at the very least a strong link between the two episodes. In order to determine these connections, we will first examine each promise in turn, and then explore their juxtaposition.

The Promise of Offspring

The surprising term "vision" is used to describe God's revelation to Abram: "Some time later, the word of the Lord came to Abram in a vision" (15:1). There are no other visions in the Abraham cycle (cf. Num 24:4 and 16; Eze 13:7). Some scholars viewed this as evidence of the historical question of authorship: von Rad, for example, argued that the incongruity is the result of the social circle in which the story was written: "The narrator and the circle in which this tradition was alive could only imagine God's communication with Abraham as a kind of prophetic call, mediated by a 'vision' and a prophetic experience of authorization."⁷

An additional anomaly in the formulation appears even earlier in the verse. The standard formulation of God's revelations to Abram is "The Lord/God said to Abram/Abraham" (Gen 12:1; 17:9 and 15; 18:13; 21:12) or: "The Lord appeared to Abram and said"

6 According to von Rad (1963, 177), the portrayal of Abram's character can be listed among the narrative materials that separate the two units. In the first unit Abram believes God's promise (v. 6), while the second unit opens with Abram doubting God's promise (v. 8). However, von Rad fails to note Abram's doubts in the first unit.

7 Von Rad, 1963, 178.

(12:7; 17:1; 18:1). The passive formulation “the word of the Lord came to Abram” is reminiscent of the prophetic books.⁸ This deviation was interpreted by some scholars as evidence of a later writing period: “The occurrence of the formula twice in Gen 15:1–6, but not elsewhere in the whole of the Pentateuch, is a sign that the passage can have arisen only in the later period of the monarchy.”⁹ Here too, however, what often initially seems to be a corruption or later addition emerges as part of the work’s artistic design. Here, too, this detail is associated with the portrayal of the revelation as a “vision,” and the two details break the regular model of Abram’s revelations, which are not depicted as regular dialogue, but as two parallel monologues.

Regarding the content of the revelation, God’s reassuring words, “fear not,” clearly address the fact that Abram is afraid.¹⁰ Hamilton believed the source of Abram’s fear was the revelation itself, which was delivered in the form of a vision, which is foreign to Abram; therefore,

8 E.g., 1 Kgs 18:31; Jer 1:2, 14:1, 20:8, 28:3, 32:6, 39:15, 46:1, and many more in Ezekiel, Haggai, and Zachariah. Gunkel (1997, 178) noted the parallel to Gen 20:7, where Abram is defined as a prophet, while here a prophetic formulation is used, which implies that Abram is a prophet who experiences a nighttime revelation.

9 Westermann 1995, 218. Gelandner (1997, 23–24) views the heading as part of a gradual change in the type of revelations Abram receives: initially God speaks to him directly, and later he is addressed “formally and ceremoniously.” The height of ceremoniousness is, in his opinion, the entourage that appears to Abram in ch. 18. However, Gelandner is forced to ignore several revelations in order to develop his gradual process.

10 In contrast with Westermann (1985, 218), who claimed that the phrase “fear not” is a general formulation that does not relate to a specific situation. Although the phrase “fear not” is found in Mesopotamian and Egyptian writings (Cazelles 1962), this is insufficient evidence to determine whether the integration of the phrase in the story is an allusion to a specific context. The phrase appears in other biblical contexts in which the protagonist is afraid of meeting with strangers (Gen 26:24 and 46:3; Num 21:34; Deut 1:21 and 21:3). This reinforces the assumption that the phrase relates to a concrete concern, and that here, too, God’s intention is to reassure Abram that the four kings will not retaliate.

God reassures him.¹¹ Alternatively, Abram's fear can be attributed to the content of the revelation – the question of his heir. However, the proximity of the revelation to the war against the four kings reinforces the traditional reading, which views Abram's fear against the background of the previous narrative. The narrator indicates that the chapter should be read against the background of the previous unit by beginning ch. 15 with the words "some time later." In addition to the broader significance of the connection between the two chapters, the link gives context to Abram's fear; Abram could not have known how the great power would react to his military action and the release of the prisoners.¹² However, God's encouragement exceeds Abram's security when He adds, "Your reward shall be very great." This is the background for Abram's words, which are integrated into the story as a reaction to God's encouragement. Therefore, God's encouragement should be viewed as a transitional passage, which relates to the previous narrative but prepares the ground for the tidings of Abram's heir, which is introduced in the following unit.¹³ After God's reassurance, Abram complains about God's failure to fulfill his promises. The phrase "Abram said" is repeated twice, at the start of each of Abram's statements:

2: Abram said, "O Lord God, what can You give me, seeing that I shall die childless, and the one in charge of my household is Damascus Eliezer!"

11 Hamilton 1990, 418. Hamilton himself expresses reservations about this reading later on, when he writes that Abram's fear relates to the fact that he is childless, and that God's reassurance relates to this matter as well.

12 Among others, Wenham 1987, 327.

13 Rendsburg (1992) suggested that the verb מָנָה (shield) should be read with a double meaning ("Janus Parallelism"), denoting both protection and contribution (as in the previous narrative – Gen 14:20, and in Prov 4:9). Protection is a reasonable reading based on the beginning of the sentence ("fear not"), and contribution is reasonable based on the end of the sentence ("Your reward shall be very great"). If the entire chapter is one unit, Kiel might be correct in asserting that God's reassurance of Abram relates to the Covenant between the Pieces as well, due to the difficult message of enslavement included therein (Kiel 1997, 397).

3: Abram said,¹⁴ “Since You have given me no offspring, and the member of my household will be my heir.”

Both statements relate to the fact that Abram has no heir.¹⁵ The repetition of the word בן in the description of Eliezer emphasizes Abram’s problem. Since he has no son (בן – “ben”), he stands to have a member of his household as his heir (בן ביתי – “ben beiti”). The repetition highlights the fact that this is only a replacement.¹⁶ The need for both statements, with an identical opening formulation, is unclear.¹⁷

But the repetition of captions is not uncommon in biblical literature, and the literary purpose should be taken into account here. Meir Shiloach conducted a study of repetitive headings in the biblical narrative, and viewed the repetition “Abram said” as an expression of “waiting for a response or action indicated by the first part of the dialogue.”¹⁸ Since God failed to respond to Abram’s first statement,

14 NJPS translated “Abram said further.”

15 The phrase בן משק ביתי (translated “the one in charge of my household” by NJPS) is unusual and difficult to decipher. The Septuagint translated the word משק as Eliezer’s mother’s name; in rabbinic literature the word denotes “leader” or “in charge of the household” (some read משקה – supplier of drink). Others suggested that משק is an ancient name for Damascus, and that the narrator is explaining, “and the one whose home is from Meshek – which is Dammesek – is Eliezer.” See additional possibilities in Thompson 1974, 203–206; Ha 1989, 19–22; Westermann 1995, 219–20.

16 This is the only biblical narrative to mention Eliezer by name. Mathews notes that the name Eliezer is a play on the word זרע – *zera* (offspring) (Mathews 2005, 164).

17 Those who assume that this is a gloss base their assumption on the fact that there is no other way to explain the repetition of Abram’s complaint. Hence, if a literary reason could be found for the repetition, there is no justification for this claim (nor for the position of von Rad [1963, 179] and Gelandner [1997, 24–25] who attribute the repetition to different sources). Wenham (1994, 220) claimed that the integration of הן (since) at the opening of Abram’s second speech indicates that he is continuing the previous dialogue, which disproves the gloss theory (Wenham 1987, 328). Gelandner (1997, 25–26) divided the story into two narratives – one private and the other national – which together create a complex story.

18 Shiloach 1964, 251–52. For critique of Shiloach’s analysis see Meier 1992, 68–91.

Abram repeats his complaint. In other words, this is not a dialogue between Abram and God; instead, Abram repeats his grievance over and over, and God never responds. Although Abram's grievance is portrayed as Abram's response to God's promise, the repetition indicates that this is a description of Abram's continuous state: he stands before God and asks for an heir.¹⁹

This reading is reinforced by God's reaction to Abram's complaint, which is introduced by the words "Behold,"²⁰ the word of the Lord came to him in reply." The term "behold" (והנה) is used to imply surprise. If the dialogue were continuous, there would be no surprising element; however, if Abram frequently prays for an heir but is never answered, God's sudden response to his ongoing state is appropriately prefaced by the phrase "Behold."²¹ The verses invite the reader to experience Abram's difficulty: God's promise of a son has not been fulfilled, and all other promises seem irrelevant without an heir. Month after month Abram and Sarai are disappointed to discover that her barrenness persists, and their other successes seem meaningless to them in light of their situation.

The term "vision" and the caption "the word of the Lord came to Abram" both sublimate the sense of regular dialogue. The verse does not describe a continuous and evolving discussion, but rather a divine statement meant to reassure Abram in light of his ongoing difficulty in accepting the content of God's promise. The complexity of the dialogue is expressed through distancing terminology: "vision," "the word of the Lord came," the repetition "Abram said," and "Behold."

God reinforces His promise to Abram by taking him outside and having him look at the stars. The symbol is not abstract (as in the case of comparing the multitude of offspring to the dust of the earth in 13:16), but tangible, as Abram is expected to take physical action by *going* outside and *looking* at the stars. Abram undergoes a process in this

19 It is noteworthy that this is the first dialog between Abram and God in the story cycle, and even this dialog is two parallel monologues.

20 NJPS omits the word "behold" (והנה), and offers no alternative translation.

21 Regarding the word הנה – ("behold") connoting surprise, and the special use of the word between different viewpoints in the story, see Berlin 1983, 62–63; Bar-Efrat 1989, 35–36; Yamasaki 2013, 47–48.

symbolic act: going outside the tent represents escaping conventional boundaries. The stars are the unreachable reality beyond concrete everyday life. God's initial response to Abram's doubts is expanding the boundaries of his belief: Abram must dare to look beyond his reality and aim high, to the stars.

The narrator ends the "dialogue" with an evaluation of Abram: "And because he put his trust in the Lord, He reckoned it to his merit" (6).²² This conclusion invites the reader to reevaluate the scene, since the conclusion turns the promise into a test of Abram's reaction. The conclusion declares that Abram passed his test, and believed that God will keep His promises, even though the reality Abram is faced with does not support this conclusion. The syntax of the phrase "he reckoned it to his merit" lends itself to two opposing interpretations, which were discussed by medieval commentators.²³ Rashi wrote that God is the subject of the sentence: "God considered this Abram's merit, and piety for believing in Him."²⁴ According to this interpretation, the verse is a summary of the two characters in the scene: Abram believes in God, and God appreciates Abram's faith.²⁵ However, Nahmanides and Bekhor Shor viewed Abram as the subject of the entire sentence: "He believed in God, who in His righteousness would give him a child despite everything, not because of Abram's merit or as a reward."²⁶ According to this reading, the entire conclusion is focused on Abram, who believes that God will keep His promises, and also appreciates the righteousness of the undeserved promise. Both possibilities are convincing.²⁷ It would be convenient to assume that the subject of the beginning of the sentence has not changed; since Abram "put his

22 NJPS. מֵקָדָה – *zedaka* also denotes righteousness or charity.

23 Kogut 2002, 109–11.

24 Rashi on Gen 15:6; cf. Sforno, *ibid.*

25 See Johnson 1987 (in response to Oeming 1983). On the link between *zekhut* ("merit") and *zedaka* ("justice/righteousness"), see Ps 51:6; Job 15:14 (and 25:4).

26 Nahmanides and Bekhor Shor on Gen 15:6. See Gunkel 1966, 179; Oeming 1983.

27 Some scholars preferred to maintain the duality of the statement (Hamilton 1990, 425). For a survey of opinions on this matter see Oeming 1998, 16–17.

trust” in God, he is also the one who “reckons” at the end. In contrast, attributing such evaluations as “reckoned” and *zedaka* (merit/righteousness) to God is possible, but incongruent with the style of the story and the current portrayal of the relationship.²⁸ Therefore most scholars assumed that God viewed Abram’s faith as righteousness or merit.²⁹ This ambiguity may well be intentional, and designed to emphasize the reciprocity of the relationship. The concluding verse closes the first part of the chapter, the promise of an heir to Abram, while portraying Abram as one who believes in God’s promise. Clearly Abram’s faith is not to be taken for granted. His current reality does not support the fulfillment of God’s blessings, and in order to believe, Abram needs to look at the stars.³⁰

The Covenant between the Pieces (7–21)

The second part of the chapter begins with God’s promise to Abram that he will inherit the land: “Then He said to him, I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to assign this land to you as an inheritance”³¹ (7). Three verbs mentioned in God’s words link the promise to the previous unit and the promise of offspring:

28 Interestingly, the two additional appearances of the word **וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ** (translated here as “reckoned”) in the Bible describe a person who is mistaken about the identity of another. Judah mistook Tamar for a prostitute: “When Judah saw her he took her (**וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ**) for a harlot” (Gen 38:15), and Eli mistook Hannah for a drunk: “so Eli thought (**וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ**) she was a drunk” (1 Sam 1:13).

29 Cf. Ps 106:31.

30 Wenham suggested that Abram’s faith is mentioned here “because the word of promise had come to him in a crisis situation following the battle of ch. 14” (Wenham 1987, 329). I will demonstrate below that the test of Abram’s faith becomes the central axis of the entire chapter, beyond the specific scope of Abram’s reaction to the battle. See also: Köckert 2012.

31 NJPS translated: “to assign this land to you as a possession.”

| | |
|--|--|
| <p>“That one shall not be your heir; none but your very own issue (אשר יצא ממעריך) shall be your heir” (4)</p> <p>“He took him outside (ויוצא אתו חהוצה)”</p> | <p>I am the Lord who <i>brought</i> you out (הוצאתיך) from Ur of the Chaldeans</p> |
| <p>“what can You give me (מה תתן לי)” (2)</p> <p>“You have granted me no offspring (לא נתת זרע לי)” (3)</p> | <p>to <i>assign</i> this land to you (לתת לך)</p> |
| <p>“my steward will be <i>my heir</i> (יורש אתי)” (3)</p> <p>“That one shall not be <i>your heir</i> (יירשך); none but your very own issue shall be <i>your heir</i> (ירשך)” (4)</p> | <p>to assign this land to you as an <i>inheritance</i> (לרשתה)</p> |

This semantic cohesion links the two units; in addition to the structural contribution, however, the repetition of the verb יצא (“go out”) portrays the unique relationship between God and Abram. In the initial unit the verb is used to describe the heir, אשר יצא ממעריך (literally: “the one who will *come out* of you”), while in the second unit, God takes Abram “out” of Ur. The comparison is meant to portray God as Abram’s adoptive father. Abram was instructed to abandon the house of his own father; the depiction of God as one who “took Abram out,” in juxtaposition with the previous promise of an heir, illustrates that leaving Ur was Abram’s rebirth to his new father. This scene, in particular, hints at Abram’s adoption by God, as some scholars have noted. Abram’s complaint that his servant Eliezer will inherit him is reflected in the Nuzi tablets: if a man dies without children, his servant is considered his adopted son and heir.³² While Abram is lamenting that his only son is his “adopted” servant, God hints to him that he, himself, has been “adopted” by God.

God begins His tidings of the land with Abram’s departure from his homeland: “I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to assign this land to you as an inheritance.” This phrase is a recurrent formulation, typically referencing the exodus from Egypt (Ex 20:2; 29:46; Lev 19:36; 26:13; Num 15:41);³³ however, the complete

32 See, for example: Parrot 1968, 103.

33 Arnold viewed this link in relation to the general concept of “the events of the patriarchs are signs for their descendants” (Arnold 2009, 158).

formulation of our chapter, which also states the Promised Land as a destination, appears in Lev 25:38, at the conclusion of the Covenant of Sinai: “I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, to give you the land of Canaan, to be your God.” Both verses relate to the departure as the beginning of the road toward a new destination – the land of Canaan.³⁴ The Promised Land is portrayed as a replacement for Abram’s place of birth. The inheritance of the land is not a reward or a simple gift, but a destiny: the purpose of Abram’s journey is the inheritance of the new land to which he is led. This portrayal justifies Abram’s unique response, which does not accept the promise but instead requests evidence and reassurance. If God were offering Abram a gift or making him a promise, Abram would have had to accept gracefully; since God reveals that the land is Abram’s destiny, he is justified in questioning and seeking proof.

Abram’s request for concrete commitment, “how shall I know that I am to possess it?” was interpreted in various ways,³⁵ but the simple meaning is that Abram is seeking a sign that this destiny will come true.³⁶ In this context there is no mention of Abram’s offspring, and God seems to be implying that Abram’s inheritance of the land is imminent. The reader will soon discover that this impression is misleading; but the deceptive reading process has a role in introducing one of the essential messages of the narrative.³⁷

34 The formulation in Leviticus adds “to be your God.” This expression is intentionally omitted in the Abram narrative; God officially becomes Abram’s God only in the revelation regarding circumcision (17:7–8).

35 See Elizur 1984. This form of the word במה (“how”) is only mentioned two other times in the Pentateuch: in Ex 22:26: במה ישָׁכֵב (“in what else shall he sleep?”) and in Ex 33:16: וְכִמָּה יֵדוע אֶפְסָא כִּי מַצָּאתִי חֵן בְּעֵינֶיךָ אֲנִי וְעַמֶּךָ (“For how shall it be known that Your people have gained Your favor”).

36 Delitzsch wrote: “the question is not an expression of doubt, but rather a request” (Delitzsch 1887, 276). Westermann compared Abram’s request to that of Abram’s servant, who asked for a sign from God (Westermann 1995, 225).

37 I do not identify with Westermann’s assertion that the omission of Abram’s offspring is related to Abram’s portrayal as a representative of the entire nation (Westermann 1995, 224). Abram does act on behalf of the future nation in the context of the Covenant between the Pieces; however, the omission of his

God does not tell Abram what to do with the animals he is commanded to gather: “Bring Me a three-year-old heifer, a three-year-old she-goat, a three-year-old ram, a turtledove, and a young bird” (9); somehow Abram knew what he was expected to do: “He brought Him all these and cut them in two, placing each half opposite the other; but he did not cut up the bird” (10). Perhaps the reader is expected to assume Abram’s actions are based on God’s instruction.³⁸ Another possibility is that God’s list of animals is sufficient context for Abram to understand what needs to be done; in other words, the covenant is clear in the context of the given era. Jeremiah 44:18 echoes a covenant involving cutting a calf in two, while external documents record this custom in the context of forging agreements.³⁹ Despite variations, such as use of different animals (the Amorites in Mari used donkeys, and the expression “sever a donkey” signifies “make a covenant”),⁴⁰ the common ground is the passage between pieces of animals, which obligates the parties in the agreement. The use of the root כרת (“cut”)

offspring from the formulation of the promise is misleading, and therefore plays a literary role in the reading process.

38 Wenham 1987, 331.

39 See Elizur’s example: “An Assyrian document in cuneiform from the 8th century BCE – regarding an oath of allegiance between Mathiel King of Arpad (northern Syria) to Ashur Nireri VI King of Assyria – explicitly describes a dismembered ram. Mathiel apparently passed between the pieces while committing to the King of Assyria” (Elizur 1984, 40–41). Hamilton (1990, 432) also referenced this example. It is noteworthy that in this document the dismemberment of the ram is deciphered as a punishment: “as this ram was cut in two, so too Mathiel shall be cut in two...” however, this document was created later than the patriarchal era. See a summary of this position by Collins 1997; Bar 2001, 151. For (partial) comparisons between Abram’s ceremony and similar ceremonies in Greece and Rome, see: Snijders 1958. For comparison with ceremonies in ancient Africa, see: Jensen 1960, especially p. 453. Concerning these and other connections, see also: Isaac 1964, 447–48.

40 See Mendenhall 1954, 26ff. Regarding the documentation found in Nuzi of the Horite custom to take “one ox, one ass, and ten sheep” when making a covenant, see Speiser 1955, 9 ff. A document found in Mari contains an apology from a person making a covenant, who out of fear of his patron did not carry out the ceremony with the puppy and goat he was given, but rather with an “ass born of donkeys.” (Charpin 1993, 165–91).

in the expression כרת ברית (literally “to cut a covenant,” meaning “to make a covenant”), and the phrase לעבור בברית (literally “to pass through a covenant”) are both prevalent in Semitic languages.⁴¹ If this is indeed a standard and accepted ceremony for the event of finalizing an agreement, God’s reference to the animals is sufficient for Abram to understand what he is expected to do. Westermann summarized: “The law of saying only what is necessary also holds for the factitious narrative... It is presupposed that the commission itself is enough for Abraham to know what he has to do.”⁴²

The narrator notes Abram’s compliance: “He brought Him all these and cut them in two, placing each half opposite the other; but he did not cut up the bird” (10). Some scholars viewed the actions as a threat to the side that violates the covenant, whose end will be similar to that of the cut animals.⁴³ This is undoubtedly the intention of similar ancient Near Eastern rituals. One example was found in a 17th-century text from Alalakh that describes a covenant between Abban and Iarimlim. Abban transferred control of the city to Iarimlim, and the agreement document reads: “Abban placed himself under oath to Iarimlim and had cut the neck of a sheep (saying): ‘Let me so die if I take back that which I gave thee!’”⁴⁴ Interestingly, in this case it is the superior party who commits to the inferior party, just as in the Covenant between the Pieces, God is the one who commits to Abram.⁴⁵ In contrast to the covenant in Genesis, however, the documented covenants in Near Eastern texts include slaughtering animals but not passing between them. Only one Hittite text from the relevant period includes evidence of passage between the animal parts, and the text does not clarify the procedure.⁴⁶

Some scholars viewed the cutting of animals not as a threat, but as a sacrificial act. Westermann noted that all of the animals used in

41 Hartom 1954, 350; Soggin 1968; Carpenter, כרת, 729. See also the discussion of John Day 2013, 123–136.

42 Westermann 1995, 225.

43 For example: Parrot 1968, 118.

44 Wiseman, Abban and Alalah 1958, 129; quoted in Hamilton 1990, 431.

45 See Weinfeld 1970, 196; Weinfeld 1976, 400–01; Hamilton 1990, 431.

46 Hamilton 1990, 431–32.

the covenant are pure and linked with sacrificial texts, particularly the paired turtledove and young bird, and perhaps the opening statement “bring *me*,” which might indicate sacrifice.⁴⁷

A major missing component, which negates the link of the covenant to the sacrificial world, is the absence of an altar; nothing in the passage is sacrificed, and Abram fails to use the blood ritualistically. The fire of revelation does not eat the animals, but rather passes between them.⁴⁸ Additionally, the narrator does not describe Abram’s action as “slaughter” (שחיטה) as in the case of all biblical sacrifices, but rather as “cutting” (בתר) (11). Westermann’s observation is correct; the animals mentioned in the narrative are linked with the ritualistic world. It is noteworthy in this context that the she-goat is not offered for classic sacrifices, but rather a male calf (one exception is 1 Sam 16:2). The ritual that does utilize a she-goat is the law of the Decapitated Heifer in Deut 21:3, a ritual that is unequivocally *not* sacrificial. The two birds are indeed reminiscent of the birds used for the final stage of purification from leprosy; however, if there had been intention of linking the birds to the sacrificial world, the common pair “pigeon and turtledove” would have been used instead of “pigeon-dove and young bird.”⁴⁹

Two other seemingly minor details need to be examined before an alternative suggestion can be made. First, the gory placement of bloodied pieces of cut animals is described using a surprising phrase. The Hebrew phrase איש בתרו לקראת רעהו is worded in an almost romantic

47 Petersen 1977; Hasel 1981 (see also Wenham 1982, who critiques Hasel). This suggestion was previously made in ancient exegesis; see, e.g., Genesis Rabbah 44:14.

48 Kiel (1997, 424) attempted to overcome this difficulty: “If you should wonder what happened to the “pieces”...some commentators assume that these were burned in God’s fire, as we have seen in the inauguration of the altar (Lev 9:24) and Solomon’s Temple (2 Chr 7:1).” The problem with this reading is that it adds elements that are in no way indicated in the text.

49 In order to link this to the realm of sacrifice, Anbar was forced to write: “the phrase “a young bird” denoting a pigeon is found in Rabbinic literature; therefore, the formulation here is likely belated” (Anbar 1979, 43). A more reasonable conclusion would distinguish between birds that are intended for sacrifice and the birds in this story.

way, literally reading “he laid the half of each (אֵישׁ) toward its companion (רֵעֵהוּ),” meaning, the pieces of each animal were placed across from each other. The word לִקְרֹאת, which denotes “toward/against,” implies two opposing biblical connotations: one of friendship and longing (“Joseph ordered his chariot and went toward [לִקְרֹאת] Goshen to meet his father Israel” – Gen 46:29), and the other relating to violence and war (“Sihon gathered all his people and went out toward Israel...and engaged Israel in battle” – Num 21:23). There is no doubt that the connotation of the verse in Genesis is positive, as the sentence ends “toward *its companion*.” The associative reading connotes closeness and fondness, the feeling of Joseph going toward his father, or Moses meeting with his brother Aaron (Ex 4:27), or the nation going toward God in Sinai (Ex 19:17). The difference between the reality and the choice of words is strange, and necessitates an interpretation that relates to the symbolic significance of the ritual.

Another noteworthy detail is the “birds of prey” that come upon the carcasses. The birds do not seem to contribute to the development of the plot in any way; therefore, commentators felt compelled to suggest various symbolic meanings, such as an indication of punishment to the party who would violate the covenant.⁵⁰

Commitments in the ancient world included two components: speech and action. The symbolic action varies (e.g., lifting a hand; placing a hand on the other’s thigh; etc.), and is accompanied by words of commitment, often with an oath to maintain one’s commitment.⁵¹ The Covenant between the Pieces includes both components: the passage of a smoking oven and flaming torch between the pieces is the symbolic act upon which the covenant is created,⁵² and God’s words to Abram include the details of His commitment to Abram’s offspring regarding their inheritance of the land.

50 E.g., Weinfeld 1970, 198, note 132; Anbar 1979, 44. See in particular Jer 34:19–10.

51 Hartom 1954, 350.

52 The etymology of the word בְּרִית – “berit” is vague (McConville, בְּרִית, 747). Noth suggested, based on texts found in Mari, that the word is derived from the Akkadian word *birit* (“between”), connoting the mutual commitment between two parties (Noth 1966). If this is correct, the Covenant between the Pieces visually represents the etymological meaning of the word.

The verses describing the covenant (12–16) are designed in a concentric structure:

- a. *As the sun was about to set*, a deep sleep fell upon Abram, and a great dark dread descended upon him.
- b. And He said to Abram, “Know well that your offspring shall be strangers in a land not theirs and they shall be enslaved and oppressed for four hundred years. But I will execute judgment on the nation they shall serve, and in the end they shall go free with great wealth.
- c. As for you, you shall go to your fathers in peace; you shall be buried at a ripe old age.
- b1. And they shall return here in the fourth generation, for the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete.”
- a1. *When the sun set* and it was very dark, there appeared a smoking oven, and a flaming torch that passed between those pieces.

The setting sun frames the chiasm of the covenant (a-a1). Before the sun sets, a great dark dread falls upon Abram, and after the sun has set a smoking oven and a flaming torch appear and pass between the pieces. The specification of time is unusual for Abram’s revelations, and might indicate that the setting sun relates to the exile content of the revelation. Darkness and nighttime are recurrent representation of exile (see especially Jacob’s exile to Harran – Gen 28:11 and 32:32); therefore after “the sun set and it was very dark” would be an appropriate time for Abram to hear about the future exile of his offspring.⁵³

The frame includes separate descriptions of Abram (a) and God’s revelation (a1), an appropriate setting for a two-sided covenant in which the two parties commit to each other. However, throughout the ritual Abram is described as completely passive – in fact, he is asleep, and even his sleep comes about passively – “a deep sleep *fell upon* Abram,” and “a great dark dread *descended upon* him.” In contrast, God is active, and passes between the parts. McComiskey wrote that the covenants

53 See, e.g., Smith’s comment on Zachariah 1:8: “The night often symbolizes a time of suffering and distress, while the dawn can refer to the time of God’s deliverance (Ps 30:5; 46:5). In the first vision Zechariah appears as a watchman through the long night of distress and is informed of the first signs of God’s return to his people and land” (Smith 1998, 189).

in Genesis are not a mutual commitment but rather a divine promise,⁵⁴ and Weinfeld added that in light of covenant ceremonies in the ancient world, the covenants should be viewed as a contractual commitment between vassal and lord.⁵⁵ Here the essence of the covenant is God's commitment to Abram; therefore He is the one to pass between the pieces.⁵⁶ However, the narrator defines the revelation in terms of a covenant, and therefore designs the revelation in covenant style.

Element b1 continues the story sequence of b; in other words, c interrupts the logical sequence of reading b1 immediately after b: the enslavement of Abram's offspring in a foreign land, and their exodus with great wealth (b), followed by the return of Abram's offspring to Canaan (b1). In addition to the continuity factor, the two elements are linked by the number four – "four hundred years" and "fourth generation," and by God's attitude toward the offending nations – judgment of the enslaving nation (b) and of the Amorite when their sin is complete (b1).⁵⁷

The central axis, c, stands out due to the subject matter; God suddenly stops describing the future of Abram's offspring, and turns to focus on his personal future: "you shall go to your fathers in peace; you shall be buried at a ripe old age" (15). The personal note to Abram

54 McComiskey 1985, 139–77.

55 Weinfeld 1970. Fidler wrote that the Covenant between the Pieces precedes the promise of an heir, since it takes place at sundown (vs. 7–17), while the promise of a son occurs at night (vs. 3–7). Therefore, in her opinion the two tidings are a continuous story, and the order of the promises was reversed so that on a literary plane the tidings of an heir would precede the tidings of the land (Fidler 2007, 170–71). Her reading dissolves the one-sidedness of the Covenant between the Pieces, since if the order is reversed, Abram's complaint that God had not given him offspring is answered in God's second message.

56 See, among others, Skinner 1930, 283.

57 The "fourth generation" might be viewed as the general biblical principle of postponing punishment for four generations (Ex 20:5 and 34:7; Num 14:18; 1 Kgs 10:30). According to this reading, "four generations" might have a dual meaning: a completion of exile on the part of the nation, and a completion of the sin on the part of the Amorite (cf. Mathews 2005, 175).

interrupts the central theme of God's revelation, which led some scholars to wonder whether the verse was a secondary addition.⁵⁸

However, the concentric structure of the unit justifies the placement of the verse as a central axis that is separated from the essential unit. Regarding the contribution of this interruption, some scholars presumed that Abram needed encouragement that he will not suffer a fate similar to that of his offspring; however, the context of the general message indicates that the verse relates to the distant future. Therefore, the message of Abram's peaceful aging and death emphasizes the fact that the inheritance of the land will not occur in his lifetime,⁵⁹ or in the lifetime of his children. The formulation of Abram's question "how shall I know that I am to possess it" assumes that Abram will inherit the land himself; God clarifies here that the inheritance of the land is a long-term goal, and will only come to pass after the return of the fourth generation, long after Abram is gone.

With this new perspective in mind, we can now summarize the purpose of the ritual and the covenant. The animals are not sacrificial, and they do not represent punishment; instead, they are symbolic of the commitment of the two parties. The Bible frequently adopts prevalent customs, but adds meanings that are appropriate for the purpose they are meant to serve. The concept of cutting an animal as a threat to the violator of an agreement was taken in this instance, but interpreted differently. The two parts of the cut animal are personified ("he laid the half of each toward its companion"), indicating the symbolic significance of the act: the two parts of the animal symbolize the two parties that are united in covenant. These are the companions who "go toward" each other. Passing between the parts symbolizes a unification of the severed parts, and closing the gap between them.⁶⁰ The birds of prey that threaten to devour

58 "15 is a parenthesis, if not an interpolation, reassuring Abram as to his own personal lot." (Skinner 1930, 282).

59 The statements "You shall go to your fathers in peace/You shall be buried at a ripe old age" are in juxtaposition with "you will send my white head down to Sheol in grief/sorrow" (Gen 42:38; 44:29, 31) (Speiser 1964, 113).

60 I partially agree with Wenham (1982), and Mathews (2005, 172–73), who viewed the cut animals as a representation of the suffering of Abram's offspring in

the animals symbolize those who would harm the nation by enslaving them for 400 years,⁶¹ and threaten to separate them from Lord and land. Josephus inserted this idea in his description of the ritual: “while birds were flying towards it with a lust for blood, a heavenly voice came announcing that his descendants would have evil neighbors for 400 years in Egypt.”⁶² Cazelles added that birds of prey were a well-known symbol of ancient Egypt.⁶³ The enslaving nation attacks both the offspring of Abram and God, by threatening the covenant between the two parties. Abram banishes the birds, thereby protecting his offspring and defending the covenant.

This reading is reinforced by the play on numbers found throughout the narrative. The link between the two elements that describe the future of Abram’s offspring (b-b1) also rely on the number four, which represents the end of enslavement (400 years; fourth generation). The number three stands out in the preparation of the ritual, and is repeated in reference to the heifer, the she-goat, and the ram (9). Early commentary debated whether the word משולש (“triple/threefold”) refers to the age of the animal,⁶⁴ or the required number of animals,⁶⁵ and the debate is continued in modern commentary.⁶⁶ Some assumed

Egypt. Mathews noted that the animals do not serve a sacrificial purpose; instead they represent the parties in the covenant. I believe God is also symbolized in the animals. The birds of prey were deciphered by Mathews as above.

61 The birds of prey may have been interpreted differently in the Septuagint, which reads וַיֵּשֶׁב אֲתָם אַבְרָם (“Abram sat with them”) instead of וַיָּשֶׁב אֲתָם אַבְרָם (“Abram returned them”). According to this interpretation, Abram does not oppose the birds of prey.

62 Josephus, *Antiquities* I:185 (Feldman 2000, 69).

63 Cazelles 1962, 338.

64 E.g., the Septuagint; Targum Pseudo-Jonathan; Ibn Ezra. Other commentators maintained that the reference was not to age, but rather to a fine fat beast (R. Joseph Bekhor Shor; Hezekiah ben Manoah [Hizkuni]).

65 E.g., Onkelos; Rashi. Nahmanides proves that a 3-year-old calf is no longer called a calf, but a cow.

66 Scholars unanimously agree that the text refers to cattle three years of age. This is apparent in all modern translations of the text. See Speiser 1964, 112; Westermann 1995, 225 (who claims that 3-year-old cattle are an integral part of the sacrificial ritual); Hamilton 1990, 430. See also Peter 1975, 491.

the prominence of the number relates to the guidelines of ancient covenants, but no tangible evidence could be found to this effect.⁶⁷ A more reasonable approach views the number/age of the animals as symbolic of the three enslaved generations. The young bird and turtledove stand apart; they are not cut, and their age/amount (which is three in the other animals) remains undefined. The symbolism is enhanced by combining these birds with the cut animals: “clearly the number wishes to emphasize the significance of the number three, and compare the three cut animals with the birds, which remain whole.”⁶⁸ The turtledove and young bird represent the generation that will leave the enslaving country and return to the land. Birds often symbolize freedom in the biblical narrative (Noah’s dove in Gen 8:13, the leper’s bird in Lev 14:7, etc.).⁶⁹ Three generations represented by the cut animals signify God’s unfulfilled commitment to Abram, while the dove and bird represent the fourth generation, which will return to Canaan and realize God’s promise to Abram.⁷⁰

This suggestion is supported by the imperative demanding release of a laborer (as opposed to a slave) after three years. Zakovitch quoted the law in Deuteronomy relating to the release of a slave on the seventh year: “when you do set him free, do not feel aggrieved; for in the six years he has given you *double the service of a hired man*” (Deut 15:18); similarly in Is 16:14: “in three years, fixed like the years of a hired laborer, Moab’s population will shrink.”⁷¹ The three animals therefore represent three enslaved generations, while the fourth is set free, just as a laborer is set free on the fourth year.

67 See Speiser 1938. His discussion relates to 1 Sam 1:24, which he believes should read “a heifer of three years” instead of “three heifers” in the Masoretic text.

68 Zakovitch 2005, 70.

69 While the bird symbolizes freedom, the dove – and perhaps also the pigeon – symbolize a return home, to one’s origins. See Isaiah 60:8, where doves symbolize the return of the nation to Israel. See also Cassuto 1982, 74–75.

70 Cf. Kiel 1997, 425.

71 Zakovitch 2005, 71.

One Unit or Two?

Should the two parts of the chapter be viewed as one or two units? The reasons to separate the units were explored above, but several parameters indicate that the units are two parts of one story:

- a. The link between the two units is apparent in the opening verse to the second message: “Then *He said to him*, I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans” (7). The style indicates a new unit; however, it also indicates literary continuity, since the name of the protagonist is absent. Clearly the reader is supposed to know to whom the verse is referring based on the previous paragraph.⁷² Those who insist that the chapter includes two separate stories have to assume that “the second story is missing its original introduction...the omission of the introduction is the result of linking the second story to the first.”⁷³
- b. The similar structure of the two units also links them.⁷⁴

| <i>Promise of Offspring</i> | <i>The Promised Land</i> |
|---|---|
| (1) God’s promise to Abram
(2–3) Abram’s misgivings
(4–5) God’s response: the promise of offspring → Reinforcement of the promise with a symbolic act (viewing the stars) | (7) God’s promise to Abram
(8) Abram’s misgivings
(9) God’s response: the promise of land → Reinforcement of the promise with a covenant, which includes a symbolic act (passing between the pieces of animals) |
| (6) Narrator’s conclusion: Abram put his trust in the Lord | (18–21) Narrator’s conclusion: God made a covenant with Abram |

This similarity cannot be viewed as incidental. Abram’s misgivings towards God’s promise are not a common theme in the Abraham

⁷² Van Seters 1975, 257.

⁷³ Anbar 1979, 42, preceded by Staerk 1899, 73; Eerdmans 1908, 38.

⁷⁴ Similarly, Van Seters 1975, 260–61 (following Lohfink); Sarna 1966, 120–21; Alexander 1982, 161–64; Coats 1983, 123–24; Wenham 1987, 325; Westermann 1995, 216; Ha 1989, 39–62; Seebass 1997, 66; Schmid 1999, 175–76; Römer 2001, 200; Mathews 2005, 161–65. See also Cotter 2003, 98; Fidler 2007.

- cycle, and here two consecutive promises elicit a similar response from Abram, followed by a symbolic act. The similarity in plot development also indicates a deep connection between the two tidings.
- c. Semantic unity: key words, or words that share a semantic field, often create uniformity within a literary unit.⁷⁵ In both parts of the chapter Abram uses the unusual name “O Lord God” in reference to God (v. 2 and 8). This double appellation only appears twice more in the Pentateuch, both times in Deuteronomy (3:24; 9:26). The appearance of such a rare expression in both units creates a deep semantic correlation between the two parts of the narrative. Moreover, the rare name fills the same semantic function; in both places it is integrated with Abram’s doubts regarding the promise he had received: “O Lord God, what can You give me, seeing that I shall die childless” (2); “O Lord God, how shall I know that I am to possess it” (8). As I already noted at the beginning of the discussion, additional words that link the two parts include, among others, the recurring root ירש (“inherit”), which appears three times in vs. 3–4 and twice in vs. 7–8, and the root יצא (“go out”), which appears twice in vs. 4–5 and once in vs. 7. Rendtorff noted that the root זרע (“seed/offspring”) recurs in both messages; in the first part as the essence of the tiding, and in the second part “To your offspring I assign this land” (18).⁷⁶
 - d. In addition to the literary links between the two parts of ch. 15, the entire chapter seems to be related to ch. 14.⁷⁷ The chapter’s opening, “Some time later” already creates a sense of continuity between this story and the preceding passage, but, as mentioned, various scholars have noted a variety of linguistic connections between the two chapters that bind them together. As these connections are evident throughout chapter 15, it seems that the chapter is a single unit in dialogue with chapter 14.⁷⁸

75 See: Polak 1999, 90–106.

76 Rendtorff 1977, 75, 79.

77 Regarding these links, see Sarna 1966, 121–22; Alexander 1982, 43–44; Caquot 1962, 66 (who viewed ch. 15 as an interpretation of ch. 14); Schmid 1999, 176–77; Römer 2001, 205–06; Elizur 2003, 34–35.

78 Wenham 1987, 325.

Those who view the chapter as one unit have to explain the ending in v. 6 and the new opening in v. 7, as well as the discrepancy between time definitions. In contrast, the position that views the two parts as two separate units is faced with the issues raised above. Each position relies on the proofs it provides.⁷⁹ The lack of ability to reach a satisfactory conclusion stems not from lack of evidence, but rather from contradictory evidence. The ambivalent delineation of units stems from the intentional design of the chapter, which should be simultaneously viewed as two separate units and as one cohesive story. The complex demarcation may be viewed in three spheres (which do not negate one another):

- a. God's revelations throughout the story cycle include two components: the assurance of offspring and the promise of land. Chapter 15 presents the reader with an overview of both promises: Abram will have multitudes of offspring, like the stars in the sky, and eventually they will inherit the land.⁸⁰ The two tidings are joined together in ch. 15, thereby blurring the boundaries of the chapter. As a result, the reader is exposed to one unit that includes two promises – offspring and land.
- b. The prayer of the Levites in Neh 9 is the first source that relates to Gen 15 as one unit. This context might indicate the value of combining the two revelations.⁸¹ The Levites say: "You are the Lord God, who chose Abram, who brought him out of Ur of the Chaldeans and changed his name to Abraham; Finding his heart true to You, You made a covenant with him to give the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Perizzite, the Jebusite,

79 The two interpretations lead to different modes of discussion on the chapter. Viewing the stories as one unit raises the discrepancy between Abram's faith in God ("he put his trust in the Lord") and his later questioning "how shall I know" (Wenham 1987, 331; Wenham wrote that Abram's statement is not a question, but a request for a sign [similar to Nahmanides' interpretation]). In contrast, if the two stories are separate units, Abram's faith and questioning are unrelated and do not contradict one another (Williamson 2001, 98).

80 Similarly, Anbar 1979, 35: "the purpose of adjoining them...was to unite three promises into one festive context: the promise of a son, the promise of multitudes of offspring, and the promise of the land."

81 Cf. Anbar 1979, 40–41, note 40.

and the Girgashite – to give it to his descendants. And You kept Your word, for You are righteous” (Neh 9:7–8). The expressions embedded in this prayer are based on Gen 15:⁸²

- * “You are the Lord God, who chose Abram, who brought him out of Ur of the Chaldeans” – “I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans” (Gen 15:7).
- * “Finding his heart true to You” – “And because he put his trust in the Finding his heart true to You Lord” (Gen 15:6).
- * “You made a covenant with him to give the land of the Canaanite” – “On that day the Lord made a covenant with Abram, saying, ‘To your offspring I assign this land’” (Gen 15:8).
- * “And You kept Your word, for You are righteous (צדק)” – He reckoned it to his merit ((צדקה))” (Gen 15:6).

The prayer is designed in a way that defines the correlation between the two parts of the chapter: “Finding his heart true to You, You made a covenant with him.” In other words, in the first part of the chapter Abram withstands the test of faith in God’s yet-unfulfilled promises, and as a reward for his faith, God made a covenant with him regarding the land, which will be inherited by his offspring. Gunkel wrote similarly: “The fact that this extremely impressive sign of divine grace is only given now, when Abraham’s faith has been proven, may be well understood as a religious profundity. The sign that strengthens faith is not given to the unbeliever or the doubter, but to the believer.”⁸³ Based on this depiction, the two parts of the chapter should be viewed as a test of Abram’s faith and reward for his devotion. Gunkel views the two units as separate, but since they correlate with each other in this way, they were written as one continuous story.

82 See Boda 1999, especially pp. 101–11 (and discussion there of various positions). Blenkinsopp (1988, 303–04) noted appropriately that the prayer in Nehemiah is based both on the Covenant of Circumcision and the Covenant between the Pieces, and that this fact should be considered in the context of the discussion regarding the time of authorship of Abraham’s covenants.

83 Gunkel 1966, 179–80. Compare with Köckert 2012.

- c. Besides these aspects, it seems that the two sections of the chapter are linked through the unique message emphasized in these revelations. Unlike the atmosphere that accompanies God's blessings to Abraham throughout the narrative cycle, the two revelations of chapter 15 express the hardships Abram faces; the emotional and conceptual ordeals of his situation. These revelations implicitly demand Abram's patience and endurance because these blessings will only be fulfilled in the distant future. In the first promise, the blessing of an heir, this emerges from Abram's double prayer. As discussed, the design of Abram's complaint and God's reaction show that Abram regularly appeals to God, expressing his fears and doubts. This design explores the depth of his anguish and misery; the emotional and spiritual trials of his everyday life. Despite all this, it is still stated that "he put his trust in the Lord." This is the fundamental theme of this chapter: not the promise and blessing itself, but Abram's unwavering faith in God despite his harsh reality. This is also the essence of the covenant of this chapter – not the promise of the land, but the postponement of the promise's fulfillment for four hundred years. In this context as well, Abram and his seed must show extraordinary patience before they will be granted dominion over the land; the covenant demands their undying faith and perseverance.

Perhaps this is the reason for the two promises' juxtaposition. Each section relates a different story, but they pose a common challenge: belief in both promises, despite the deferment of their fulfillment. The tidings of seed (in the chapter's first half) and the tidings of the land (in the second) both demand Abram's far-seeing, undying faith. In this sense, Sarai's barren state (and perhaps Rebekah's and Rachel's as well) reflects the land's yearning for its children's return. The womb is a metaphor for the earth, as reflected, for example, in Isaiah's prophecy: "Shout, O barren one, You who bore no child! Shout aloud for joy, you who did not travail! For the children of the wife forlorn shall outnumber those of the espoused – said the Lord. Enlarge the site of your tent, extend the size of your dwelling, do not stint! Lengthen the ropes, and drive the pegs firm. For you shall spread out to the right and

the left; Your offspring shall dispossess nations, and shall people the desolate towns.” (54:1–3).

The chapter of the Covenant between the Pieces discloses, for the first time, the dark world of exile; the travails of separation and severance; the yearning of the believer. Abram’s faith that the promise will be fulfilled – even if it tarries – becomes a paragon for the undying faith demanded of his descendants.

Chapter 7: Hagar's Flight (16)

Abram was promised in ch. 15 that he would be given a son and heir. The follow-up in Gen 16 focuses on this detail; but instead of emphasizing God's promise, the chapter concerns human initiative in achieving this goal. Sarai is the driving force of the plot in her initiative to offer her maidservant Hagar to Abram: "Consort with my maid; perhaps I shall have a son through her" (2); however, due to the dynamic of the story, the narrative follows Hagar to a greater extent than Sarai. This is expressed by the various suggested captions for the chapter, which all focus on Hagar and her son. Many entitled the story "The Birth of Ishmael";¹ Hamilton offered the caption "Hagar and Ismael" for the entire chapter,² and Skinner entitled the chapter "The Flight of Hagar and Birth of Ishmael."³ Westermann mentioned Sarai, but indicated that the focus of the story is Hagar: "Sarah and Hagar: Flight and Promise of a Son."⁴ This focus is reinforced in the conclusion of the story, when Abram names his son instead of Sarai. This conclusion is fundamental to the narrative, and relates to the purpose of the story.

1 Speiser 1964, 116; Wenham 1994, 1; Kiel 1997, 430.

2 In addition to the heading, Hamilton divided the chapter into two parts: "family feud" (1–7) and "the birth of Ismael" (7–16). See Hamilton 1990, 441–58.

3 Skinner 1930, 284.

4 Westermann 1995, 232. For the possibility of viewing the tension between Sarai and Hagar as the essence of the narrative, see p. 235.

“Her mistress was lowered in her esteem” –
 “Sarai treated her harshly” (1–7)

The exposition describes Sarai’s distress, and thereby introduces a possible solution: “Sarai, Abram’s wife, had borne him no children. She had an Egyptian maidservant whose name was Hagar” (1). The verse juxtaposes Sarai with Hagar. Hagar’s nationality might seem like an irrelevant detail: why should the reader care that Hagar is Egyptian? In addition to the clarification of Hagar’s choice of direction when she escapes Abram’s house, Leon Kass noted that the theme is an extension of the Egyptian fertility model in ch. 12.⁵ In ch. 12 Abram is faced with the infertility of the land; in ch. 16 Sarai comes to terms with her own infertility. In both narratives, Egypt is the fertile alternative. Moreover, the story of Hagar’s flight is deeply linked with the previous narrative of the Covenant between the Pieces. Abram discovered that his offspring will be tortured in a foreign land (which the reader can decipher as Egypt), while in the very next chapter the roles are reversed and Sarai is the one to torture Egyptian Hagar. This point will be discussed at length below, but the reversal of roles from the previous chapter might be the reason the verse notes Hagar’s nationality.

The opening verse focuses on Sarai instead of Abram; Sarai continues to serve as the protagonist on the following verses as well. Sarai emphasizes *her* infertility and the possible solution for *her* situation – the problem is portrayed as Sarai’s, not Abram’s: “the Lord has kept *me* from bearing. Consort with *my* maid; perhaps *I* shall have a son through her” (2). Sarai’s suggestion is directly linked to the information provided by the exposition:

| <i>Sarai’s suggestion (2)</i> | <i>Narrator (1)</i> |
|--|--|
| Look, the Lord has kept me from bearing | Sarai, Abram’s wife, had borne him no children |
| Consort with my maid; perhaps I shall have a son through her | She had an Egyptian maidservant whose name was Hagar |

5 Kass 2003, 279.

The differences between the two perspectives are subtle but significant. While focus is directed upon Sarai, she is also referred to as “Abram’s wife.” Moreover, Sarai’s infertility is described through its direct effect on Abram – “had borne *him* no children,”⁶ while Sarai focuses on her own predicament – “the Lord has kept *me* from bearing.” This is also emphasized in Sarai’s conclusion: “perhaps *I* shall have a son through her,”⁷ instead of *we* or *you*. Another delicate difference concerns Hagar, who is described by the narrator by name and nationality – “an Egyptian maidservant whose name was Hagar.” Sarai does not relate to Hagar by name, but rather by assignment: “my maid.” Sarai should not be judged harshly at this point of the narrative; the term “maid” is appropriate in the context of Sarai’s discussion with her husband, since it is the nature of their relationship that enables Sarai to have Abram’s child through Hagar. However, the omission of Hagar’s name portrays Sarai’s transaction as a technical-legal act, devoid of personal implications. Hagar is not an independent personality, she is nothing more than Sarai’s maidservant; Sarai is portrayed as the one affected by the transaction, not Hagar.⁸

The unit is designed in two parallel parts:⁹

-
- 6 According to the documentation theorists, this formulation associates the verse with P, unlike most of the chapter, which is associated with J. However, the appearance of the word “maid” later in the verse is associated with J, and the verse comprises two earlier sources (see, e.g., Skinner 1930, 285; Speiser 1964, 116, 119). This argument is repeated in the concluding verses, which scholars view as non-original and a later addition by P. However, I believe the unique style that opens and concludes the story has literary value: these verses offer the “Abramic framework” for the chapter, from which the story departs and then returns in the concluding verses. See discussion on the concluding verses below.
 - 7 The word אֲבִנִּי (literally: “I will be built;” NJPS translated: “I shall have a son through her”) in Sarai’s words highlights the terrible distress that accompanied a barren woman in the biblical era. Without a son she is “destroyed,” and can only be “built” through the birth of a son.
 - 8 The meaning of the name Hagar is unclear, and probably originated in ancient Arabia. See Drey 2002, 181–82; Knauf, “Hagar.”
 - 9 Alexander 1990, 137; Wenham 1994, 5–6. See also Mathews 2005, 182.

| | 2–4 | 5–6 |
|-------------------------------------|--|---|
| <i>Sarai's suggestion</i> | Look, the Lord has kept me from bearing. Consort with my maid; perhaps I shall have a son through her | And Sarai said to Abram, “The wrong done me is your fault! I myself put my maid in your bosom; now that she sees that she is pregnant, I am lowered in her esteem. The Lord decide between you and me.” |
| <i>Abram's reaction</i> | And Abram heeded Sarai's request | Abram said to Sarai, “Your maid is in your hands. Deal with her as you think right.” |
| <i>Sarai's actions</i> | So Sarai, Abram's wife, took her maid, Hagar the Egyptian...and gave her to her husband Abram for a wife ¹⁰ | Then Sarai treated her harshly |
| <i>The result: Hagar's reaction</i> | He cohabited with Hagar and she conceived; and when she saw that she had conceived, her mistress was lowered in her esteem | she ran away from her |

Each part opens with Sarai speaking to Abram about Hagar: initially Sarai offers Hagar to Abram, so that she may have a child for Sarai (2), and later Sarai complains about Hagar's attitude toward her (5). A comparison of the two parts sheds light on Sarai's frustration. Sarai had planned to have Hagar carry a child in her own name. In reality, not only is Hagar's pregnancy disassociated from her, but she is also lowered in the esteem of her maid. In both instances Sarai mentions God: she attributes her barrenness to God's hand (“the Lord has kept me from bearing”) and she later calls upon God to mediate between herself and her husband (“The Lord decide between you and me”). Sarai's mention of God highlights His lack of involvement in the scene, even when He is called upon by Sarai to intervene. The narrative develops

10 NJPS translated נִשְׂאָה – “as a concubine.”

in a natural way, through human initiative and reaction. Sarai's dialogue reveals the emotional overload of all characters involved in this brief story. Instead of focusing on the problem of Hagar's scornfulness, she repeats the entire story from her point of view: "The wrong done me is your fault! I myself put my maid in your bosom; now that she sees that she is pregnant, I am lowered in her esteem." The phrase "put my maid in your bosom" has surprisingly romantic connotations,¹¹ while Hagar was meant to be no more than a fertile womb in the service of Sarai.¹² However, a careful reading of the initial interaction reveals a similar tone:

| <i>Narrator (3–4)</i> | <i>Sarai's perspective (5)</i> |
|---|--|
| and gave her to her husband Abram for a wife | I myself put my maid in your bosom! |
| and when she saw that she had conceived, her mistress was lowered in her esteem | now that she sees that she is pregnant, I am lowered in her esteem |

In light of this comparison, Sarai has good reason to attribute romantic connotations to the relationship between Abram and Hagar. Sarai's comment, "I myself put my maid in your bosom," parallels "[Sarai] gave her to her husband Abram for a wife." "Wife" is a status that deviates from Sarai's original plan. Based on documents of the era, even if a maid were to gain a higher status by providing the master with a son, (and it was prohibited to banish her and her son),¹³ she still would not be given the status of a proper wife. Sarai's intention had

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- 11 Cf. Num 11:12; Deut 13:7; 28:54, 56; 2 Sam 12:3, among others. Muffs (1992) demonstrated that phrases that sound like a show of expression to the modern reader (such as "love," "joy," "desire") often serve a legal purpose. In this context as well, the description of a woman "in the bosom" of a man might only be a formal-legal expression. I believe that in the context of the narrative, incorporating a legal expression that denotes a normal marriage is also indicative of Sarai's distress, due to the circumstances that brought about the relationship.
- 12 It is noteworthy that there is no dialog between Sarai and Hagar throughout the narrative. Hagar is a "fertile womb" to Sarai (Trible 1985, 221–46). The only one to converse with Hagar directly is the angel in the following scene.
- 13 Parrot 1968, 103–04.

been to give Hagar to Abram for the sole purpose of bearing a child, as a surrogate mother. However, following Hagar's titles throughout the scene demonstrates the difference between Sarai and Abram's view of Hagar's role (and the delicate process Abram undergoes in the narrative). The story begins by introducing Hagar as Sarai's maid ("an Egyptian maidservant" – 1); Sarai continued to call Hagar a maid when she had offered her to Abram ("Consort with my maid" – 2). However, when Sarai actually gives Hagar to Abram ("Sarai, Abram's wife, took her maid" – 3) her status suddenly and unexpectedly changes ("and gave her to her husband Abram for a wife" – 3). Despite the title and pregnancy, Hagar returns to her original status as Sarai's maid, both from her own perspective ("her mistress was lowered in her esteem") and in Sarai's view ("I myself put my maid in your bosom"). After Sarai's criticism of Abram, he also changes his view of Hagar, who returns to her original status as Sarai's servant ("Your maid is in your hands"). Abram's title for Hagar has legal significance; he dismisses his responsibility for Hagar, who carries his child, and returns her to Sarai's ownership and discretion.¹⁴

When Sarai tells Abram she had placed her maid "in his bosom" she is in fact relating to Hagar's achievement of the unexpected status as Abram's wife.¹⁵ The discussion takes place on the legal plane, but there is also a possibility that it reflects the emotional space of the characters. When Abram heard that Hagar was expecting, he would have begun to care for her well-being. While Sarai watched this special treatment, she might have been berating herself for having brought

14 Willi-Plein (2010, 37–39) claimed that the tension of the narrative is contained in the term "mistress." She believed this to be a specific term to describe the mother of the king, and reflect the position of the firstborn son. Sarai was concerned that if Hagar would give Abram a son, she would inherit Sarai's position as the mistress of the house; according to Willi-Plein, Hagar thought this as well. I believe this to be an overload on the intention of the verse.

15 Tribble views Sarai giving her maid to Abram as a legal action: Sarai redeemed Hagar from her status as a servant and gave her the status of a wife. This deed created an opportunity of equality and reciprocity between the two women; however, Sarai's inability to adjust to the new reality led to Sarai's harsh treatment, followed by Hagar's escape (Tribble 1984, 11–12).

the situation upon herself; but the emotional effects of watching a second wife suddenly walk into one's home are not necessarily logical. The barren Sarai sees her husband consorting with another woman, and she cannot stand such a reality. Whether Abram interprets the situation in the same way or not, Sarai's anger leaves an impression on him; he releases Hagar and returns her to Sarai.

Both parts portray Abram as a passive character, who leaves the decision-making up to Sarai. The first part describes Abram's compliance (2); in the second part Abram speaks, but the content of his dialogue emphasizes his passivity: "Your maid is in your hands. Deal with her as you think right" (6).¹⁶

The third stage of each part describes Sarai's actions as a result of Abram's reaction: Sarai offered Abram Hagar (3) and later acted harshly toward Hagar (6). The fourth stage reports Hagar's actions in light of the previous occurrence: when Hagar discovered she is pregnant, "her mistress was lowered in her esteem," and following Sarai's harsh treatment, she "ran away from her." Following Hagar's actions in the conclusion of the first two episodes prepares the reader for the focus on Hagar in the next episode, which features Hagar as the protagonist.

Two more noteworthy details emerge from the scenes discussed above. First, Abram's passivity in the story cannot be incidental. His inactivity sets this story apart from all others in the Abraham cycle. Even the parallel story of Hagar's Dismissal (21), which begins with Sarai's initiative to banish "this maid and her son," invites the reader to share Abram's emotions (21:12); ultimately, Abram is the one who acts, following God's revelation (21:14). The gap left by Abram's passivity in the story of Hagar's flight is filled by a new protagonist: Sarai. Sarai initiates the process; Sarai implements her idea; Sarai acts harshly toward her maid, thereby advancing the next stage of the plot. The depth of Sarai's dominance is particularly apparent in the way the narrator describes Sarai's transference of her maid to Abram. The

16 Some argued that Abram's words include an implied criticism of Sarai: "Nonetheless, Abram's words are disapproving...the carefully obscured criticism lands with the ease of a soft stick" (Shapira 1996, 47); I find his claim unconvincing.

narrator uses the word לקח (“took”), the common verb describing marriage; however, instead of simply stating “Abram took Hagar,” a long and winding verse makes Sarai the subject of the sentence: “So Sarai, Abram’s wife, took her maid, Hagar the Egyptian...and gave her to her husband Abram for a wife” (3). The lengthy description highlights both Sarai’s authority and Abram’s inactivity. Abram’s thoughts and feelings are concealed, and he seems to be acting only on behalf of his wife’s wishes and instruction.

This unusual design has a role in the purpose of the story, which will be discussed at length in the discussion of Hagar’s banishment (ch. 21). At this point Abram’s silence is one of several indicators that the story deviates from God’s plan. Von Rad wrote regarding Sarai’s initiative: “the narrator probably sees a great delinquency precisely in this.”¹⁷ Westermann wrote in contrast: “she must do as she does.”¹⁸ Westermann is correct: the Bible is not averse to the prevalent custom of using a maid as means of acquiring a child for a childless couple.¹⁹ Therefore, there is no explicit criticism of human initiative with regard to the process of building a family. But von Rad is also correct in noting that the question of Abram’s heir deviates from the regular context of a childless couple. God’s promises and the development of the Abraham cycle both indicate that the birth of Abram’s son is destined at a specific time. Although if at this point the reader does not know why the fate of Abram’s family must be delayed, there is a sense that Sarai’s initiative might harm the planned sequence of Abram’s history. One might say that the story interrupts God’s plan. The following chapter (17:19) reveals that Abram and Sarai’s joint son will be the one to inherit Abram’s covenant. To this end, their son will have to be born in a miraculous way, when Abram and Sarai are too old to have a child naturally. The birth of Ishmael does not advance the divine process; in fact, it disturbs its complete realization. The narrator “hides” Abram’s thoughts and feelings, and places the weight of the plot’s development on Sarai’s shoulders. The reader thereby is made to feel not only that

17 Von Rad 1963, 86–187.

18 Westermann 1995, 238.

19 Regarding related accepted customs in the Near East, see Frymer-Kensky 1981.

the story deviates from God's will, but that Abram is not an entirely willing participant. This portrayal relates both to the evaluation of the characters and to the clarification of Ishmael's status, as we will discuss below.

The second detail is the recurrence of the combined verbs ראה ("to see") and שמע ("to hear"). The combination has been noted as a key phrase in many biblical stories,²⁰ and seems to play a crucial role later in our narrative as well. At this early stage the reader might sense the unique intensity of the use of the verbs. Abram *heeded* (וַיִּשְׁמַע) his wife (2); Hagar *saw* (וַתֵּרָא) she was with child, which made her *view* her mistress in a different light (בְּעֵינֶיהָ) (4); Sarai described from her perspective that Hagar *saw* (וַתֵּרָא) she was pregnant and *viewed* (בְּעֵינֶיהָ) her differently as a result (5). The two verses use the verb "saw" alongside Hagar's "eyes," while Abram's reaction (6) contrasts Sarai's eyes with Hagar's: כָּטוֹב בְּעֵינֶיךָ (literally "as is good in your eyes," "as you see fit"). The description of Sarai's harsh treatment toward Hagar with the word וַתַּעֲנֶה is a play on the sound of the word עֵין ("eye"). The significance of these key words will be discussed at length below (vs. 13–14). In any case, the judgment of both Sarai and Hagar in this scene is complex, and will only be determinable in light of the episode's continuation.

"Then Sarai treated her harshly,
and she ran away from her"

The details of Sarai's harsh treatment are left to the reader's imagination. Some scholars suggested that Sarai's behavior was not physical, based on section 146 in the Hammurabi Code:

*šumma awilum naditam ibuzma amtam ana mutiša iddinma mārī ittala warkānum amtum
šī itti beltiša uštatabbir aššum mārī uldu, belessa ana kaspim ul inaddiššī. Abuttam išak-
kanšimma itti amātim imannūšī.*

20 Frish 1998.

Translation: If a man take a wife and she give this man a maidservant as wife and she bear him children, and then this maid [will] assume equality with the wife: because she has borne him children her master shall not sell her for money, but he may keep her as a slave, reckoning her among the maidservants.²¹

The case in our narrative is similar to the case in the law: Hagar the maidservant was given to Abram, husband of the barren mistress, for the purpose of producing a child, and the maidservant assumed “equality with the wife.”²² In light of this similarity, some interpreted the meaning of the verb וַתַּעֲבֹד based on the law:²³ “reckoning her among the maidservant.”²⁴ Benjamin Halevi added that various biblical verses use the verb in the context of enslavement, “to make one feel that they are dependent,”²⁵ which reinforces the link with section 146 in the Hammurabi Code. However, the narrative is not entirely compatible with the letter of the law.²⁶ First, the law refers to a priestess, not to an ordinary woman.²⁷ Moreover, according to Babylonian law the maidservant only gains special status if she births a son. Otherwise, section 146 notes that the mistress may sell the maidservant and has no further obligation toward her. In our narrative Hagar conceives, but acts disrespectfully toward Sarai before she has any sons. According to the Hammurabi Code, Sarai would be well within her rights to banish Hagar. Although the Hammurabi Code is an important background

21 Some translated *imannūši* as a transitive verb: the mistress will appoint her maid to be among the other mothers. I prefer Richardson’s translation (2000, 87), which reads the verb as passive.

22 For additional links to Ancient Near Eastern Texts, see Speiser 1964, 120–21; Van Seters 1968; Grayson and van Seters 1975; Hamilton 1990, 444–46. For a comparison of this case to a custom reflected in the Nuzi documents, see: Parrot 1968, 103–04; Rocha Couto 2003; Rooker 2003. But see also Justel 2012.

23 The Hebrew verb וַתַּעֲבֹד literally means: “she tormented her;” NJPS translated in general terms “treated her harshly.”

24 E.g., Ahuvia 1994, 72.

25 Halevi 1966, based on KBL, 721 (= HAL, vol. 2, 856).

26 As Westermann noted (1985, 239). See references to additional discussion on the matter.

27 Teubal believed Sarai was a priestess, and explains that her bareness was elective. This position is unreasonable; however, it does explain why Sarai owns her own maidservant. See Teubal 1984.

for understanding the narrative, caution should be exercised about applying the law in details that are incongruent to the story, as we will discuss below.

Hagar's response to Sarai's "harsh treatment" is to escape to the desert; this extreme reaction indicates something worse than standard maidservant working conditions. A pregnant maid is unlikely to escape to the desert alone and without protection unless she has a good reason to do so. However, the angel later tells Hagar that she is to return to Sarai's home despite the treatment she will no doubt endure (9), indicating that the treatment is reasonable enough to allow Hagar a safe return. While Sarai's precise actions are not disclosed, the choice of the verb **וַתַּעֲנֶה**, which has negative connotations throughout the Bible, certainly indicates inflicting suffering.²⁸ Skinner wrote: "The word suggests excessive severity; Hagar's flight is justified by the indignities to which she was subjected."²⁹ The negative connotation is reinforced by the integration of the verb in such close proximity to the Covenant between the Pieces, in which the same verb is used to describe the oppression of Abram's offspring: "and they shall be enslaved and oppressed (**וַיַּעֲבֹד וַיַּעֲנֶה אוֹתָם**) four hundred years" (15:13). The verb is later used in the same context of the nation's suffering in Egypt: "So they set taskmasters over them to oppress them (**וַיַּעֲבֹדוּ**) with forced labor...but the more they were oppressed (**וַיַּעֲבֹדוּ**), the more they increased" (Ex 1:11–12). Sarai, who "oppresses" her Egyptian maid, reminds the reader of the Egyptians, the future oppressors of Abram's offspring. The comparison is, of course, unflattering to Sarai; regardless of the actual interpretation of the verb **וַתַּעֲנֶה** in this context, the story receives its significance from the use of a verb with such harsh connotations.

28 BDB, p. 776.

29 Skinner 1930, 286.

The Meeting at the Spring (7–14)

The next scene opens with Hagar finding a spring of water (7) and concludes by mentioning and naming the spring (14). Seemingly we have before us an etiological story that clarifies the name of the desert spring; however, the integration of the scene into the broader context of the narrative adds new meaning to the story and to the specific location of Hagar's meeting with the angel. The emphasis on the spring is apparent in the first verse, which describes the location through a parallel:

by a spring of water in the wilderness
the spring on the road to Shur

The emphasis on the geographical location of the meeting between Hagar and the angel forms the necessary atmosphere for the content of the revelation. The desert symbolizes aridity and barrenness, while the spring or well represents abundance and blessing, especially the blessing of fertility. It is no coincidence that biblical couples meet at wells; Alter wrote perceptibly that the realistic element of young girls drawing water from the well is enhanced by the symbolism of wells as a sign of fertility.³⁰

Hagar's spring is not located in a place of settlement, but in the wilderness, "on the road to Shur."³¹ This complexity indicates the diverse nature of the blessing Hagar is about to receive: she is blessed with fertility ("the spring"), but the fruit of her labor will find his place outside a place of settlement ("the wilderness"). This mixed blessing also gives meaning to the boundaries of the narrative: naming a source of water in the desert transforms a place in the wilderness into one with human significance. Places in the desert are rarely named, since they are not frequented by people. Here, a source of water in the

30 Alter 1981, 55.

31 Regarding the identification of Shur, see Simons 1959, 217; Baly and Tushingham 1971, 104.

wilderness is given a definition. Hagar's offspring will make their home in the wilderness and name places in it.

The definition of Hagar as "Sarai's maidservant" delegitimizes Hagar's escape from the outset of the dialogue between her and the angel: "Hagar, maidservant of Sarai, where have you come from?" Hagar does not argue with this perception; in fact, she fully acknowledges her position: "I am running away from my *mistress* Sarai." Hagar's recognition of her status sublimates the criticism against her; even while fleeing from Sarai, she knows her place and obligation.³²

The angel asks Hagar two questions: "where have you come from?" and "where are you going?" Hagar only responds to the first question: "I am running away from my mistress Sarai." Since the narrator revealed that Hagar is "on the road to Shur," it seems likely that Hagar is heading back to her family in Egypt. The omission of Hagar's destination in her dialogue with the angel indicates that she is more intent on running away than she is on reaching her destination. This is emphasized in Hagar's change of the angel's terminology in the dialogue: in response to the angel's question, "where have you *come* from?" Hagar says, "I am *running* away."

The story reaches its climax in the angel's blessing. Amazingly, the blessing is based on the standard formulations of the blessings given to the forefathers in the book of Genesis; in our narrative, the receiver of this blessing is none other than an Egyptian maidservant! Assuming the text includes no interpolations,³³ the angel's message can be divided into three parts, as the three captions indicate:

32 Tribble views this as the deep power of social conventions – Hagar cannot free herself from her own self-perception as a slave (Tribble 1984, 15).

33 Gunkel believed the triple repetition has no literary significance, and was the work of an editor who wished to link the narrative with Hagar's banishment in ch. 21 (Gunkel 1997, 183; see also Skinner 1930, 285–87). In contrast, Cassuto wrote: "the tripled expression 'And the angel of the Lord said to her' is not useless; rather, it is an impressive expression of the festivity of the divine message" (Cassuto 1989, 265). Alexander wrote two explanations; the first suggested: "Possibly it serves to emphasize who was speaking. The reader is left in no doubt that the angel of Yahweh spoke these words to Hager" (Alexander 1990, 139). His second interpretation is similar to the position suggested above.

- *And the angel of the Lord said to her*, “Go back to your mistress, and submit to her harsh treatment.”
- *And the angel of the Lord said to her*, “I will greatly increase your offspring, and they shall be too many to count.”
- *And the angel of the Lord said to her*, “Behold, you are with child And shall bear a son; You shall call him Ishmael, for the Lord has paid heed to your suffering. He shall be a wild ass of a man; his hand against everyone, and everyone’s hand against him; he shall dwell alongside of all his kinsmen.”

The third statement is particularly lengthy, and seems to be the essence of the angel’s revelation. As mentioned in the discussion of chapter 15, Meir Shiloach demonstrated the diverse contributions of the common repetition of captions in the biblical narrative.³⁴ The recurrence of the heading “And the angel of the Lord said to her” might be viewed as “awaiting a response or action” in the words of Shiloach.³⁵ Hagar failed to respond to the angel’s initial appeal; she had just escaped her abusive mistress, and was now urged to return by a stranger in the wilderness.³⁶ Hagar’s silence indicates that she is disinclined to comply.³⁷ As a result, the angel spoke again, and made various promises in order to convince Hagar to return to her masters.³⁸ However, the second

34 Shiloach 1964.

35 Ibid., 251.

36 It is difficult to determine at precisely what point Hagar understands that she is being addressed by an angel. A similar ambiguity is present in Abram’s meeting with the angels in ch. 18. Gunkel believed Hagar only realized she was conversing with an angel in vs. 9–12, when the angel blessed her (Gunkel 1997, 186).

37 Tribble’s formulation seems excessive: “a divine word of terror to an abused, yet courageous, woman.” (Tribble 1984, 16).

38 Cf. Ahuvia 1994, 73. In his opinion, Hagar is tired and thirsty, and the angel speaks the thoughts she would have had regardless. He wrote that the difficulties of travelling through the desert defeated her, and she reluctantly returned to Sarai’s house. His reading is unlikely, since the angel meets Hagar “by a spring of water.” In contrast with ch. 21, where Hagar needed her eyes opened in order to find water, in ch. 16 she reached the spring before meeting the angel. Noort wrote that Hagar is portrayed as knowledgeable in the paths of the desert. He noted that Shur is several days of travel from Hebron, and the

plea fails to convince the frightened and tortured maid to return to the source of her grief. Hagar only conforms to the angel's instructions after his third statement.

In addition to this dramatic development, Shiloach noted that the separation into three parts highlights the various issues addressed in the angel's discourse:³⁹

1. The angel initially tells Hagar: "Go back to your mistress, and submit to her harsh treatment."⁴⁰ This formulation might create the impression that the angel identifies with Sarai and justifies her harsh treatment of Hagar;⁴¹ however, this is a misreading of the verse. The angel does not condone Sarai's actions; rather his statement should be read "Go back to your mistress *despite* her harsh treatment."⁴²
2. In the second utterance the angel attempts to convince Hagar to return to her mistress despite her obvious reluctance to do so. Hagar is promised: "I will greatly increase your offspring, and they shall be too many to count" (10). Remarkably, the angel uses the formulation of God's blessings to Abram. The blessing is particularly reminiscent of the future blessing at the conclusion of the binding of Isaac: "I will bestow My blessing upon you and make your descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven and the sands

pregnant Hagar made it as far as Shur. In his opinion there is therefore a similarity between the portrayal of Hagar and the qualities she is told her son will possess: "a wild ass of a man" (Noort 2010 – Created, 39).

39 Shiloach 1964, 257–58. He places the following verses in Genesis under the same category: Gen 9:1–7; 9:8–11; 9:12–16; 17:3, 9, 15; 21:6–7; 24:24–25; 31:49–51; 32:9–10; 37: 21–22.

40 The angel's words translate literally into "under *her* hand," repeating the expression Abram uses when he permits Sarai to do as she pleases with Hagar (Mathews 2005, 189).

41 Samet 2002, 36.

42 Some scholars assumed that Hagar was obligated to return to the house of Sarai because "God does not forgive a violation of the law," in this case the escape of a maid from her mistress (von Rad 1963, 189). However, this is clearly not what the angel is referring to: apparently there is significance to Ishmael's birth in Abram's house and legal-official banishment.

on the seashore; and your descendants shall seize the gates of their foes” (22:17). This is the blessing that characterizes God’s relationship with the forefathers; the blessing of offspring that are “too many to count” is spoken to Abram and Sarai, Isaac and Jacob, and none other, with the exception of the Egyptian maid, Hagar.

3. But Hagar remains unconvinced, and unwilling to return to the house of her mistress. In the third and final phase, the angel offers Hagar a concrete blessing that relates to her present reality: “Behold, you are with child and shall bear a son...” (12–13). The predetermined name of Hagar’s child is consistent with conventions of birth-tiding narratives,⁴³ but effectively, this continues to shed unusual light on her character.⁴⁴ In the following chapter Abram’s second son, Isaac, will also be named by God, in a similarly articulated verse: “God said, Nevertheless, Sarah your wife shall bear you a son, and you shall name him Isaac” (17:19). The fate of Abram and Hagar’s offspring is compared; God offers patronage to Hagar’s son, just as he intends to sponsor Isaac. The fact that Hagar will name her own son instead of Sarai seems to indicate that she will be free of the burden of her mistress. Rachel and Leah themselves name the sons born to Jacob through their handmaidens, while here the angel informs Hagar that she will name her baby herself instead of Sarai.⁴⁵ The blessing balances the angel’s appeal for Hagar’s return to her mistress by stating that Hagar will be the one to name her child. The reason for the name is no less significant: “For the Lord has paid heed to your suffering.” This statement positions God Himself on Hagar’s side. Additionally, the phrase “the Lord has paid heed to your suffering” is reminiscent once again of the enslavement in Egypt: “I have seen the plight of My people in Egypt, and I have heard their outcry because of their taskmasters;⁴⁶ yes, I am mindful of their

43 Neff 1972.

44 “R. Isaac said: three were named before they were born, Isaac and Solomon and Josiah...some say Ishmael as well: ‘you are with child and shall bear a son; You shall call him Ishmael’” (Genesis Rabbah 45:8, ed. Theodor-Albeck, pp. 455–56).

45 Shapira 1996, 46.

46 NJPS translated רָאָה רֵאִיתִי – “I have marked well;” שָׁמַעְתִּי – “heeded.”

suffering” (Ex 3:7). Clearly God identifies with the Hebrew slaves and not with their Egyptian oppressors, just as God seeing Hagar’s suffering is a clear indication that he deplores her oppression. The angel concludes Hagar’s blessing: “He shall be a wild ass of a man; his hand against everyone, and everyone’s hand against him; he shall dwell alongside of all his kinsmen.” The significance of the metaphor “wild ass” was debated among scholars.⁴⁷ Gunkel and von Rad noted that in the book of Job in particular the wild ass is a paradigm of freedom: “Who sets the wild ass free?... Whose home I have made the wilderness, the salt land his dwelling place? He scoffs at the tumult of the city, does not hear the shouts of the driver; he roams the hills for pasture...” (Job 39:5–7).⁴⁸ The reason the wild ass does not hear the shouts of the driver is that the wild ass is never caught, and lives forever free in the wilderness. Von Rad believed the verse in Job 39 depicts the wild ass in a negative light from a biblical perspective, although not from Hagar’s viewpoint: “He will be a real Bedouin, a ‘wild ass of a man’, i.e., free and wild, eagerly spending his life in a war of all against all – a worthy son of his rebellious and proud mother!”⁴⁹ I believe the symbolic freedom is better explained within the context of the narrative in Gen 16. Hagar has only recently escaped her oppressive mistress; what will become of her if she should return to the house of her master and mistress? What will become of the status of her child, now the son of a rebellious maidservant? The angel offers the encouragement Hagar needs to hear: her son will be free as a wild ass.⁵⁰ He will live in the desert where none will

47 Köhler argues that *pere*’ actually means ‘zebra’ (*equus grevyi*), since in Somali *far’o* refers to the zebra (Köhler 1945, 64–70). But see Humbert 1950 and Zobel, *pere*’.

48 Gunkel 1997, 188; von Rad 1963, 189 (similarly, Kahana 1903, 26). The ass’ wildness is also expressed through the breaking of conventions, as reflected, for example, in Job 11:12: “A hollow man will understand, when a wild ass is born a man.” This verse indicates that a wild ass is uncivilized, and has to be educated in order to become civilized.

49 Von Rad 1963, 189. See also: Wenham 1994, 11; Moberly 2007, 26.

50 In fact, the verses in Job may well be alluding to Ishmael, who is defined as a “wild ass” in our story, and whose tribes roam the desert. In the parallel

discipline him, as Ibn Ezra wrote: “most free among people... none will rule him outside of his own family.”⁵¹

The significance of Ishmael’s freedom and independence is also essential for understanding the angel’s statement *ידו בכל ויד כל בו* (literally “his hand in all and the hands of all in him”), which seems to allude to financial success.⁵² The hand indicates the “measure for measure” element of the story: Abram said to Sarai: “Your maid is in your *hands*” (6); the angel ordered Hagar to return to her mistress and submit to the harsh treatment *תחת ידיה* (literally: “under her hand”) (9); now the angel informs Hagar that her son will have his [own] “hand” which will be in high demand.⁵³ The final part of the blessing, “He shall dwell alongside of all his kinsmen,”

narrative in chap. 21, Ishmael is “cast” out to the desert, just like the verse in Job 39:5: “Who sets the wild ass free?” Moreover, the wild ass in Job “scoffs (*צוחק*)” at the “tumult of the city,” just as Ishmael scoffs (*מצחק*) at Isaac prior to his expulsion (21:9).

- 51 Ibn Ezra, commentary on Gen 16:12. See also Noort 2010 – Created, 35. Gevirtz and Hamilton understood the word *אדם* (“Adam”; “man”) as a derivative of *אדמה* (“earth”), connoting wilderness. They translate *פרא אדם* as “wild in the wilderness.” See Gevirtz 1975, 43 note 35; Hamilton 1990, 449, note 3. The word *פרא* (“*perel*”; “wild”) is similar-sounding to the word *פורה* (“*poreh*”; “fertile”); in this case the image is linked with the blessing Hagar received from the angel. Cf. Shapira 1996, 119–22.
- 52 Onkelos translated: “He will need everyone, and he will be needed at the hand of people.” For interpretation see De Vaux 1965, 14. NJPS among others attributed a military connotation to the statement and translated: “his hand against every man and every man’s hand against him.” Hamilton assumed based on this translation that the statement alludes to the many wars in which Ishmael will participate (Hamilton 1995, 454; cf. Gunkel 1997, 188; Wenham 1994, 11). However, this translation is inaccurate (Drinkard 1979); therefore, there is no basis for Hamilton’s comparison between the angel’s message and Naomi’s words to her daughters-in-law: “My lot is far more bitter than yours, for *the hand* of the Lord has struck out against me” (Ruth 1:13).
- 53 Regarding “hand” as a key word, see Tribble 1984, 17. Noort (2010 – Created, 41) wrote that there is closure to this comforting theme in Gen 21:18: “Come, lift up the boy and hold him by the hand, for I will make a great nation of him.”

indicates that Ishmael will inherit his own portion of land, equally among his brothers.⁵⁴

These three elements of the angel's address are conveyed through three sections with identical captions. The correlation between the three blessings and the previous chapter is difficult to ignore. In ch. 15 Abram was promised a multitude of offspring (15:5); he was told that his offspring will be enslaved and mistreated in a foreign land (15:13); and finally, he is promised that his children will be freed, accumulate great riches, and inherit their land. All of the elements predicted in Hagar's future seem to be taken from God's covenant with Abram. As earlier noted, the links between the stories exceed the blessing, and are apparent throughout the narrative (Hagar's national identity; God heeding Hagar's suffering; even Hagar's name, which is reminiscent of God's words in Gen 15:13: "your offspring shall be strangers [גר – "ger"])."⁵⁵

Cassuto (in his first suggestion) and Zakovitch viewed the stories as a demonstration of "measure for measure": Sarai's offspring were enslaved in Egypt as punishment for her mistreatment of her Egyptian slave.⁵⁶ But the order of the text disproves this theory, as the Covenant between the Pieces appears before the Hagar narrative. If the purpose of the link between the stories was to indicate crime and punishment, the order of the texts should have been reversed. Instead, the link implies the way in which the correct evaluation of the characters appears in the narrative. The evaluation of Sarai and Hagar is complex and unclear in the immediate context; perhaps the link

54 Kahana viewed this expression as negative as well: "He shall dwell alongside of all his kinsmen – intrusively; he will do them harm and anger them frequently" (Kahana 1903, 26). There is reason to believe the verse indicates the inheritance of an eastern land (see Driver 1935).

55 See Cassuto 1989, 66–267; Zakovitch 1987, 31–32. Zakovitch believed the escape to the wildernesses also links the stories of Hagar and the Exodus, and Römer added: "Yhwh's angel meets Hagar on the way to Shur. According to Exod 15:22, Shur is the place of Israel's first stop after the withdrawal from Egypt" (Römer 2012, 15).

56 Cassuto, *supra*, n. 22.

with the previous episode, specifically the comparison between Hagar and Abram's enslaved offspring, demonstrates the attitude toward Hagar's treatment. We will return to this analogy in the conclusion to this chapter.

Naming Names (13–14)

The angel informs Hagar that she will name her son Ishmael, in recognition of the fact that God heard her plight. When the angel has completed his message, Hagar names not her unborn son, but the angel: "And she called the Lord who spoke to her, 'You are El-roi,' by which she meant, 'Have I not gone on seeing after He saw me!'" (13). The name Hagar offers the angel, "El-roi" ("the God who sees me"),⁵⁷ is similar in content to the name she is expected to offer her son, "Ishmael" ("God has heard"). Being heard and seen by God are frequently linked,⁵⁸ as in the Exodus narrative: "I have seen the plight of My people in Egypt, and I have heard their outcry because of their taskmasters; yes, I am mindful of their suffering" (Ex 3:7). Therefore, when Hagar names the angel "El-roi" the reader is meant to be reminded of Ishmael. Naming God and His messengers is a rare phenomenon in biblical literature. The act of naming connotes ownership and control.⁵⁹ Parents name their children to indicate parental authority; Adam named the animals to demonstrate his mastery over them; Pharaoh changed Joseph's name to turn him into a loyal subject and emissary; God changed Abram and Sarai's names to express their acceptance of their covenant with Him. In all of the examples above, the superior changes the name of the inferior; examples of the contrary are rare. In fact, in some cases the *omission* of the angel's name is an indication that

57 El-roi could also be interpreted as "the God who is seen." For a review of ancient translations see Hamilton 1990, 455. See also Koenen 1988.

58 Regarding the pair ראה-שמע (saw-heard) as a key words, see Frish 1999; Terrien (1978) also noted this pair throughout his work.

59 Cashdan 1967, 32; Eissfeldt 1968; Ross, *sem*, 147–48.

the angel is of the divine realm (e.g., Gen 32:30; Judg 13:18). The fact that Hagar names an angel expresses unusual intimacy.

The narrator explains Hagar's choice: "Have I not gone on seeing after He saw me!" (13). Many scholars adopted Wellhausen's interpretation: "Have I seen God and am I kept in life after my seeing?"⁶⁰ The advantage of this suggestion is Hagar's reasoning: just as Manoah feared for his life after meeting face to face with an angel (Judg 13:22), Hagar expresses her wonder at having seen an angel and surviving. The disadvantage is the intense changes the verse must undergo in order to justify this reading, none of which are supported by ancient translations or variants.⁶¹

The position that accepts the Masoretic text views the word אַחֲרֵי ("after") as a description of time, but others have suggested that the word alludes to a location instead, similarly to God's words to Moses in Ex 33:32: "Then I will take My hand away and you will see My back (אַחֲרַי), but My face must not be seen," or to 1 Sam 2:23: "and the spear protruded from his back (מֵאַחֲרָיו)."⁶² According to this interpretation, Hagar expresses her wonder at having received a revelation specifically in *the wilderness*, which is considered to be a godless place according to prevalent Near Eastern beliefs: "*here* too I have seen the back of Him who sees me."⁶³ Although the verse remains vague and difficult, all possibilities have Hagar expressing her wonder at the revelation,

60 Wellhausen 1994, 326.

61 Wellhausen substituted the word הֵלֶם in the verse with the word אֱלֹהִים, and added וְאֵחָי. This reading was accepted by various modern translations, such as NAU: "Have I even remained alive here after seeing Him?" For this and other suggestions see Seebass 1971, 13 (who replaced הֵלֶם with לַחַיִּים – "to life"); White 1975; Booiij 1980; Westermann 1995, 247–48.

62 BDB, p. 30.

63 Lindblom 1961, 102, note 21. Hamilton also adopted this position and translated the verse: "Have I here really seen the back of Him who sees me?" (Hamilton 1990, 449). Cf. White 1975, 285 note 60. Schoors suggested that originally the verse read פָּנִים ("face," "forward") instead of אַחֲרֵי ("after") (Schoors 1982, 494–5). Ahuvia suggested reading "after" as a euphemism for "before" – and compared the verse to Jacob's words to Esau: "for to see your face is like seeing the face of God" (Gen 33:10), which is similar to the meaning of the verse above: "have I seen the face of He who sees me?" (Ahuvia 1994, 73–74).

whether due to her inferior position, or to the location of the revelation in the wilderness.⁶⁴ The name is accepted and becomes known as the name of the location of Hagar's revelation, as the narrator concludes: "Therefore the well was called Beer-lahai-roi; it is between Kadesh and Bered" (14).

The transference from the angel to the spring seems to indicate a formal, authoritative approval of Hagar's name for the angel; on the other hand, approval is given to the naming of the spring, while distracting from the conclusion regarding the name of the angel. The spring replaces the name Hagar wanted to give the angel, which indicates disapproval of Hagar's action, which deviates from accepted human boundaries. Even if Hagar's name is appropriate, it will be accepted with regard to the location of the revelation, not with regard to the messenger of God.⁶⁵

Gunkel believed that the purpose of the narrative was the etiological effect of naming of the spring.⁶⁶ However, the reality portrayed by the narrative often exceeds the experience of its characters; here, too, the etiological conclusion indicates that Hagar's private revelation exceeds the boundaries of her own personal story, which will become relevant to future generations.⁶⁷ This significance is apparent from the location of the spring, which is described by the narrator. The angel appeared to Hagar by "the spring on the road to Shur" (16:7), while in the concluding verse the spring is located "between Kadesh and Bered" (16:14). The narrator initially emphasized the wilderness, an

64 See: Talmon, מדבר. For a contrasting position that views the primitive Israelite philosophy as one that links God with the desert ("the classic home of Yahwism") see Budde, Osée, 106.

65 It is additionally noteworthy that the conclusion of the story correlates with the literary components prevalent in revelation narratives (Niehaus 1995, 30–42).

66 Gunkel 1997, 190–91.

67 The name might have been original, or Hagar might have added personal significance to an existing name. Among those who view Hagar's statement as a personal interpretation of an existing name, some suggested that לחי ראי ("Lahai roi") indicated the name of an animal (*hai* denoting "living beast"), while others read *lehi* ("cheek"), indicating the cheek of an animal, similar to *Ramat Lehi* in the Samson narrative (Judg 15:18–20). See Wellhausen 1994, 326; Gunkel 1997, 188.

appropriate location for messages relating to Ishmael, who is destined to make his life in the desert. Additionally, the desert emphasizes the revelation to Hagar in the symbolic location of water within a desert. Once Hagar accepted the fact that she has to return to the house of her mistress, the desert can also become a defined location: “Naming brought things into describable existence.”⁶⁸

Kadesh is also linked with two biblical connotations beyond Hagar’s personal story: first, the location connects Hagar’s story with the extended Abraham cycle, in which it is later noted: “Abraham journeyed from there to the region of the Negeb and settled between Kadesh and Shur” (Gen 20:1). The similar style of the verses “between Kadesh and Shur” and “between Kadesh and Bered” is noteworthy.⁶⁹ Second, the geographical location mentioned at the conclusion of the Hagar narrative is once again reminiscent of the Exodus from Egypt; Kadesh was the central location in which the nation stayed on their journey to Canaan.⁷⁰ Additionally, the water source in Kadesh was the location in which Moses and Aaron were informed that they will not enter Canaan (Num 20:1–13).⁷¹

The naming of the spring is concluded in vs. 13–14 with a poetic tone:

And she *called* the Lord who *spoke* to her, “You are *El-roi*”
 By which she *meant* (אמרָה – literally: “said”),
 “Have I not gone on *seeing* after He *saw* me (*roi*)!”
 Therefore the well was *called* Beer-*lahai-roi*
 It is between Kadesh and Bered.

68 Ross, *šēm*, 147.

69 The location “Bered” does not appear elsewhere in the Bible.

70 Deut 1:46.

71 Dozeman suggested a broad analogy between Hagar and Moses regarding the following components: oppression, escape to the desert, revelation, return for the purpose of regaining freedom (Dozeman 1998). If he is correct and the analogy is intentional, this is another example of the fact that the significance of the story exceeds the concrete-historical boundaries of the narrative.

The first three statements begin with a verb relating to speech (אָמַרְהָ, קָרְאָה), and end with the epistrophe “*roi*.” The first and third statements include other appearances of the verbs “see” and “spoke” with relation to the angel: “the Lord who *spoke* to her,” and “after He *saw* me.” The emphasis on sight is particularly noteworthy: as mentioned above, the verb “to see” and related words (“eyes”) are used intensively at the start of the narrative, while the angel’s message to Hagar revealed that God had “heard” her plight. The hearing motif culminates in Ishmael’s name, which means “God heard.” Hagar concludes the narrative with the motif of “seeing,” noting her awe at having “seen” (or being seen by) God’s messenger, which she expresses by naming the angel accordingly. Von Rad, followed by the more radical position of Kilian, noted two etiological elements in the narrative: the creation of Ishmaelite tribes who roam the southern deserts of Canaan,⁷² and the sanctification of *lahai-roi*.⁷³ Ishmael’s birth is linked with the special attention Hagar merited for her suffering, which is expressed through the verb “to hear,” while “seeing” indicates the choice or sanctification of a location.⁷⁴ The transfer from the verb “hear” to “see” emphasizes the *fact* of revelation over the *content*; therefore, the name of the spring relates to the *fact* of revelation. The message of Ishmael’s birth (“God has heard”) is given in the place in which God “has seen” a distressed maid. Both parts of the narrative emphasize God’s compassion toward Hagar, which is then expressed through the naming

72 Many of the classic biblical scholars (such as Gunkel, Noth, Benson, Zimmerli, and others) viewed this as the essential purpose of the story. The formulation of biblical critics often emphasizes the etiological purpose, which defines the complexity of the relationship between Israel – whose social structure is settled and agricultural – and the nomads of Ishmael (see, e.g., Noort 2010 – Created, 35 and 44). Eissfeldt’s comment on this interpretation of the story is edifying: “But there they are almost submerged under the short story form and dressing...The tribal history element that lies at the base has been given further depth and extension so as to produce a human story” (Eissfeldt 1965; see also Westermann 1994, 235).

73 Von Rad 1963, 190; Kilian 1966, 98.

74 E.g., the Binding of Isaac in Gen 22:14: “And Abraham named that site YHWH yireh, whence the present saying, ‘On the mount of the Lord there is vision.’”

of three dimensions: man (Ishmael); God (represented by the angel) and the physical world (the spring). Thus, a narrative that began with human initiative, and not by divine decree, changed the face of reality on various planes. The common denominator of the renamed subjects is the reason for change: God's compassion, which is expressed by the verbs "see" or "hear."

God Sees the Suffering of the Oppressed

We can now return to the purpose of the story within the context of the Abram narrative. The evaluation of the characters is broadly debated among commentators and scholars alike. The narrator clearly identifies with Sarai's plight and pain, and criticizes Hagar's treatment of her mistress. The angel orders Hagar to return home, which downplays Sarai's actions. Although the text doesn't seem to support direct criticism of Sarai's actions, the narrator's unusual empathy toward Hagar is nevertheless unequivocal: the fact that a mere maidservant merits a revelation; the content of the blessings; the statement that God has heard her distress; the links to the enslavement of the nation in Egypt, and their redemption; the naming of the angel/spring – all indicate that God is on Hagar's side.⁷⁵

The evaluation of the characters is critical to understanding the purpose of the story and Hagar's blessings. Ishmael's blessing seems to be linked to Abram in the parallel text of Gen 21,⁷⁶ but there is no

75 As noted earlier, Tribble believed the story unequivocally identifies with Hagar and criticizes Sarai, who had abused her status, the fertility of her maid, and even God, by entering Him into the equation (Tribble 1984, 11–19). Although Tribble is correct that the narrator sides with Hagar's position, the criticism of Sarai is negligible and hardly apparent in the story.

76 "As for the son of the slave-woman, I will make a nation of him, too, for he is your seed" (Gen 21:13).

indication of this link in ch. 16.⁷⁷ In fact, Hagar and Ishmael explicitly merit the blessing as a compensation for Hagar's suffering at the hands of her mistress, due to the angel's demand that Hagar return to the place of her suffering. Hagar will suffer under the hands of her oppressor, thereby buying her son freedom, riches, and land, just as Abram's offspring will suffer under their oppressors but will ultimately escape with riches and inherit the land of Canaan. Hagar's blessing is portrayed as a moral compensation for the injustice she endured, unrelated to Abram.⁷⁸ Sarai demands, "The Lord decide between you and me"; ironically, her demand is met. God assesses the situation with Sarai and Hagar, and decides to hear Hagar's distress. Cassuto wrote similarly with reference to the binding of Isaac: "There is an emphasis on the lesson that should be learned; that God helps the oppressed, and not the oppressor, no matter who they may be...the Children of Israel and the Egyptians are equal before God's supreme justice, and His fatherly love. [But] He always sides with the oppressed."⁷⁹

Buber raised a similar idea in reference to the triple caption in the angel's dialogue with Hagar:

I assume the triple repetition intends to remind the reader or listener of something significant: the first person to experience the revelation of an angel is an Egyptian and a maidservant; God, who "loves the foreigner," justifies Sarah's necessary choice-rejection (21:12), but also takes pity on the one who is

77 Drey (2002, esp. pp. 193 and 195) asserted that the similarity between the formulation of Hagar's blessing and the blessings of the forefathers indicates that Ishmael will receive Abram's blessing, and the blessing does not relate to Hagar personally. Based on this Drey explained the placement of the story between the two covenants – as a realization of the blessings of Abram. However, Drey ignores the literary design of the story, which emphasizes Hagar's status as an independent personality, who is given a child on her own merit. Drey relies upon Abram's request regarding Ishmael in 17:18, and God's response in 17:20: "As for Ishmael, I have heeded you. I hereby bless him... I will make of him a great nation." However, the dialogue in ch. 17 cannot reflect upon the nature of the narrative in ch. 16. While in ch. 17 Ishmael is blessed in merit of Abram, in ch. 16 Ishmael is blessed in merit of Hagar.

78 In contrast with the parallel story in ch. 21. Regarding the correlation between the stories, see the discussion on ch. 21.

79 Cassuto 1989, 18–52, 66–267.

oppressed by her: she will temporarily suffer under her hands, but she will rest assured that the God who has heard her suffering will take care of her and her offspring.⁸⁰

Sarai's actions cannot be justified by reading Gen 16 on the background of Hammurabi's laws. In fact, God's compassion toward Hagar might be a covert polemic against the procedures described in the Hammurabi Code.⁸¹ The God of Israel frowns upon the mistreatment of a maid, even if the maid overstepped her boundaries. Even if Sarai acted in accordance with the laws of her time, God compensates Hagar for her suffering at the hands of her mistress.⁸²

As noted in the introduction, some scholars believed the Abraham cycle was arranged in a concentric structure around Hagar's flight.⁸³ According to this position, the story portrays God as a moral Lord who is sympathetic even to the suffering of a lowly maidservant who escaped to the desert. Even Hagar is surprised by the uncommon and unexpected empathy. Even if pointing to the story as the central axis of the Abraham cycle is an exaggeration, the narrative includes certain elements that do not reappear in the story cycle or in biblical literature. One particularly noteworthy element is the intimate relationship between Hagar and the angel, which is expressed in the mutual exchange of names ("Ishmael" – "El-roi"). In ch. 16 Hagar is paralleled with Abram in her independent standing before God, and the inheritance of blessings on her own merit. This episode's message is particularly salient in light of one of the narrative cycle's main objectives: to depict the nation of Israel's establishment upon moral grounds, as I discussed in the introduction. Here, too, in this context, the narrative does not shy away from exploring the moral aspects of national history.

80 Buber 1997, 315.

81 See also Angel 2013.

82 Similarly, von Rad 1963, 86–187.

83 Such as Cotter 2003, 84–85; Mathews 2005, 89–91. Even according to Radday, who suggested a chiasmic structure for the story cycle, the stories of Hagar's flight and the circumcision are the two central stories in the cycle. See at length in the introduction, regarding the literary structure of the story cycle.

Conclusion (15–16)

The narrative is concluded with the birth and naming of Ishmael:

Hagar bore a son to Abram,
And Abram gave the son that Hagar bore him the name Ishmael;
Abram was eighty-six years old when Hagar bore Ishmael to Abram.

All three concluding statements mention Hagar and Abram, emphasizing that Abram's son was borne by Hagar. The repetition of this fact highlights the character omitted from the conclusion: Sarai. Hagar has a baby; Abram gives his son a name; but Sarai is altogether absent. This oversight is surprising since the purpose of Abram taking in Hagar was to produce a child for Sarai: "Consort with my maid; perhaps I shall have a son through her" (2). The heroine who initiated the plot disappears at its conclusion. Many scholars asserted that the conclusion was a product of P, in contrast with the essence of the story that was a product of J.⁸⁴ These noted the absence of Sarai from the final verses, as well as the contradiction between the naming of the baby by Hagar (and the angel) in v. 11 and by Abram in v. 15.⁸⁵ However, the literary contribution of these two details is significant. Sarai's disappearance and Abram's renewed involvement indicate the change in Ishmael's status, and contain implicit criticism of Sarai. Sarai is omitted at the conclusion as an enhancement of the purpose of the story; Hagar and Ishmael merit an independent blessing, and Ishmael

84 E.g., Ball 1896, 66; Skinner 1930, 288; Gunkel 1997, 159; Westermann 1995, 249; Speiser 1964, 119. See Alexander 1982, 123, and Van Seters's (1975, 194) reservations.

85 E.g., Granerød 2010, 67. Galpaz-Feller debated whether Abram had been told by Hagar that his son should be named Ishmael, or whether he came up with the name independently of Hagar: "Abram gives his son the name given by the angel, but gives the name personal meaning relating to him...the narrator is silent. He fails to inform the reader whether Abram is aware of the name the angel gave Hagar's son. The meaning given by the angel of God emphasizes Hagar's distress due to Sarai's treatment, while Abram emphasizes the grace of God who heard his distress and gave him a son" (Galpaz-Feller 2006, 23).

exceeds the purpose Sarai had intended for him. Instead of being Sarai's son, Ishmael becomes the son of his biological mother.⁸⁶ When the angel tells Hagar that she will be the one to name her son (11), he essentially confirms Sarai's loss of control over her maid. As mentioned above, Leah names the children of her maidservant (Gen 30:11 and 13), and Rachel names the children of her maidservant (30:6–7), as an indication of their "ownership" of the maids and their children. Ishmael becomes Hagar's child when she is given the opportunity to name him, and his status is elevated further when Abram ultimately gives him his name instead of Hagar. Ishmael thus becomes Abram's official firstborn son and heir.⁸⁷

The opposing viewpoints of the two heroines provide the story with two opposing characteristics: Sarai's story is tragic, almost ironic. She wished to give Abram a son, but by bringing her maid into her house to this end she created an alternative heir to her own son. By mistreating Hagar, Sarai brought about God's blessings for Hagar. Hagar's story is one of salvation and redemption. God is portrayed as one who hears the cries of the oppressed and the inferiors of society's hierarchy; a maidservant will be compensated by God for her suffering at the hands of her mistress.

And where does Abram stand? He tells Sarai, "Your maid is in your hands," waiving his relationship with Hagar; but at the end of the story he names his son Ishmael, as the angel had told Hagar she would name her son. In the present narrative Abram's role is paired with God: as long as God remains uninvolved, Abram, too, is passive, while after the angel says that God has seen Hagar, Abram actively names his son. Based on the naming of Ishmael, Abram identifies with God's compassion toward the mistreated maidservant.

86 Cf. Tsevat 1980; Alexander 1990; Wenham 1994, 11.

87 Similarly, Grintz 1983, 54; Hamilton 1990, 457–58; Mathews 2005, 192.

Chapter 8: The Covenant of Circumcision (17)

The two commitment narratives in chs. 15 and 17 are both termed “covenant” (15:18; 17:2). McComiskey showed that these two covenants serve as prototypes of all the biblical covenants that come afterwards – in his terms, other covenants are all “admissions” of Abraham’s covenants with God.¹ Despite the similar terminology, the two covenants could not be more different. In the Covenant between the Pieces, Abram is portrayed as a passive character who practically commits to nothing. His passivity is highlighted by the fact that he “falls asleep” while God passes between the cut pieces. Additionally, the only information Abram was given that would directly affect his life related to his death at an old age; in other words, Abram would not witness the fulfillment of his covenant with God. While he believed God’s plan and commitment to his offspring, the covenant had no direct impact on his life. Some defined the covenant as a “political-national-historical treaty,”² in contrast with the Covenant of Circumcision.

The Covenant of Circumcision features a mutual commitment between Abram and God. Abram’s name is changed to Abraham, indicating a changed status before God, and he is called to take action and circumcise himself, his son, and the men of his household. The covenant is implemented immediately – “on that very day” (17:23), and not 400 years later, as in the Covenant between the Pieces.³ The

1 McComiskey 1985, 139–77. Concerning the relationship between the two covenants, see: Alexander 1998, 52–54.

2 Bin-Nun 2003, 44–48.

3 Alexander’s formulation is misleading: “As in 15:1–6, the promise of a son prepares the reader for future developments in the cycle” (Alexander 1982, 48). While the two messages prepare the reader for the rest of the cycle, ch. 15 was designed as a promise for the distant future, while the promise of a son in the covenant of circumcision is given a specific time in the near future (17:21).

Covenant of Circumcision is not a “national covenant,” but rather a “personal/family covenant.”⁴ Emanuelli noted appropriately:

The innovation he [Abram] hears about here [in the Covenant of Circumcision] is “between Me and you” (2). There [in the Covenant between the Pieces] the covenant was one-sided, since only God had made a commitment, while Abram remained passive, but this time he was also expected to commit to the covenant. This time the covenant is reciprocal: “this is My covenant with you” (4) – “you...shall keep My covenant” (9).⁵

The reciprocity or one-sidedness of each covenant is the result of a more essential difference. The Covenant between the Pieces is a national covenant that is only fulfilled long after Abram’s death, which is the reason Abram is portrayed as a passive observer. The Covenant of Circumcision is one that involves Abram and his family in historical processes that take place in Abram’s present reality. The covenant is valid from the moment the two parties agree; therefore, in this case Abram is expected to keep “the sign of the covenant.”⁶

The chapter is devoted to God’s dialogue with Abram: out of twenty-seven verses in the chapter, eighteen are spoken by God.⁷ The chapter is therefore indefinable by modern literary standards,

4 For another definition of the correlation between the two covenants see Alexander 1994; Williamson 2001. Alexander and Williamson emphasized the condition element: while the Covenant between the Pieces is unconditional, the Covenant of Circumcision is conditional. They also emphasized the replacement of the promises of land and offspring with a more universal approach in the Covenant of Circumcision, which continues the blessings of ch. 12. See also Speiser 1964, 126 (who believed the two chapters express different approaches to the term “covenant”).

5 Emanuelli 1978, 254.

6 The distinction is expressed in the phrases used in each of the covenants. The term used in the Covenant between the Pieces is “made a covenant” (15:18), while in the Covenant of Circumcision the term is “establish My covenant” (17:2) or “maintain My covenant” (17:7, 19, 21). The distinction is often attributed to the alleged different sources: P tends to avoid reciprocity or equality between God and man. However, “to make a covenant” suggests a long-term commitment, while “to establish/maintain a covenant” relates to an immediate commitment. See Cassuto 1989, 18–52; 96–100.

7 Emanuelli 1978, 254.

which distinguishes between legal and narrative texts.⁸ God's message to Abram is divided by subcaptions ("God said"), which turn the long sermon into several short ones. The structure simplifies the act of location and comparison of the various components in God's message.

Some scholars have asserted that the chapter lacks a coherent structure and continuity.⁹ Von Rad noted the different portrayals of Abram and the shifting nature of the promises in 1–14 and 15–27.¹⁰ But the unity of the chapter can be confirmed from two angles. First, since the chapter contains a "covenant narrative," the various components should be analyzed in light of similar narratives or contracts. Külling conducted a comparative study between Gen 17 and prevalent contracts from the ancient Near East, and concluded that the order of the chapter is deliberate.¹¹ Second, McEvenue demonstrated that the chapter is concentric, which indicates unity.¹² Von Rad wrote suitably that the chapter includes two parallel halves (1–14; 15–27). The two halves are concentrated around the central axis: the circumcision of

8 Westermann wrote that ch. 20 is "a factitious promise narrative," which could be portrayed as "a story about a divine revelation to Abram." However, he believed the frame story about the revelation is only present to enable the delivery of the law of circumcision, which is the essence of the chapter (Westermann 1995, 224–25).

9 Weimar (1988) is of the extreme opinion that the chapter includes four layers. Despite his important and well-researched analysis, his conclusions are unconvincing. For a less extreme position see von Rad 1963, 192, 197.

10 Ibid.

11 Külling (1964) predominantly relied on Hittite covenants from the second century BCE. The general structure of such contracts includes: 1. Introduction. 2. Historical overview. 3. Definition of future relationships between the parties. 4. Obligations relating to the covenant. 5. Calling on the gods as witnesses. 6. Blessings and curses (pp. 228–83). For critique of the presumed similarity between ch. 17 and Hittite contracts see Brockington 1965, 475.

12 McEvenue (1971, 157–58) named the structure "A palistrophe." Cf. Van Seters 1975, 179–93; Alexander 1982, 170–17; Radday 1981, 105; Wenham 1994, 17. In addition to the structure, McEvenue suggested a classic parallel of the two parts of the chapter (pp. 158–59). He also noted the continuity throughout the chapter: "The chapter always moves from intention to fact, and from vague to specific" (McEvenue, 1971, 156).

the male foreskin. Since ch. 17 is the general central axis of the entire Abraham cycle, the commandment of circumcision (and Abram and Sarai's name changes, which enclose it on both sides) becomes the focal point of the entire story cycle. Circumcision is the only command Abram receives that affects future generations, and the location of the directive expresses its unique status. The discussion of the covenant details will therefore stem from the structure:

a. Introduction (Abram is ninety-nine) (1)

Abram was ninety-nine years old.

b. Beginning of Revelation (1)

The Lord appeared to Abram.

c. Covenant and the Promise of Fertility (1–2)

I am El Shaddai. Walk in My ways and be blameless.

I will establish My covenant between Me and you, and I will make you exceedingly numerous."

d. Abram's reaction (Abram throws himself on his face) (3)

Abram threw himself on his face.

e. Name change for Abram; the promise of kings (3–8)

and God spoke to him further, "As for Me, this is My covenant with you: You shall be the father of a multitude of nations. And you shall no longer be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham, for I make you the father of a multitude of nations. I will make you exceedingly fertile, and make nations of you; and kings shall come forth from you..."

f. The Covenant Sign (9–14)

You and your offspring to come throughout the ages shall keep My covenant. Such shall be the covenant between Me and you and your offspring to follow which you shall keep: every male among you shall be circumcised...

e1. Name change for Sarai; the promise of kings (15–16)

As for your wife Sarai, you shall not call her Sarai, but her name shall be Sarah. I will bless her; indeed, I will give you a son by her. I will bless her so that she shall give rise to nations; rulers of peoples shall issue from her.

d1. Abraham's reaction (Abraham throws himself on his face) (17–18)

Abraham threw himself on his face and laughed, as he said to himself, "Can a child be born to a man a hundred years old?"

c1. Covenant and the Promise of Fertility (19–21)

Nevertheless, Sarah your wife shall bear you a son, and you shall name him Isaac *and I will maintain My covenant with him* as an everlasting covenant for his offspring to come. As for Ishmael, I have heeded you. I hereby bless him. I will make him fertile and exceedingly numerous. He shall be the father of twelve chieftains, *and I will make of him a great nation.*

b1. End of Revelation (22)

And when He was done speaking with him, God was gone from Abraham.

a1. Conclusion (Abraham is circumcised at ninety-nine) (23–27)

Abraham was ninety-nine years old when he circumcised the flesh of his foreskin.

a-a1. “Abraham was ninety-nine years old”

Abram’s age is mentioned in other episodes (12:4; 16:3; 16:15; 21:5; 23:1 (Sarah); 25:7); however, in these instances the detail is offered casually, whereas the Covenant of Circumcision begins and ends with Abram’s age, calling for special attention to this detail as the frame of the story. Kiel suggested two possible literary contributions by emphasizing Abram’s age: “The age demonstrates that Abraham – even at an old age – was not deterred by keeping the commandment on the day it was given, or because the act of an “everlasting covenant” should be awarded an accurate date.”¹³

The reader is made aware of Abram’s adherence to God’s command despite his advanced age. However, the specific age, 99, plays an additional literary role. Since Abram is nearly 100 years old at the time of the Covenant of Circumcision, one might have expected a more dramatic, symbolic round number to indicate Abram’s age. A round number would have contributed to the sense of a new beginning in the life of the protagonist, complete with a new covenant and a new name.

13 Kiel 1997, 444.

But “almost one hundred” is exactly what this detail is meant to convey: in addition to the admiration of Abram’s continued devotion to God despite his old age, the text wishes to indicate that the main event is yet to come. The covenant is complete only when God’s promise to Abram is fulfilled.¹⁴ The covenant precedes the birth of Isaac, so that Isaac could be born *into* the covenant; this event only takes place when Abram turns 100. This idea will be discussed further in the context of the significance of circumcision.

b-b1. The Beginning and End of the Revelation

The revelation begins using the root רָאָה (“to see” – here, “appeared”), which is found in two other revelations in the cycle (12:7; 18:1). A differentiation should be noted between divine revelations that include or exclude a visual component. Westermann wrote incorrectly that the revelation of ch. 17 leans on God’s first revelation to Abram in 12:1–4,¹⁵ while ch. 12 is a different model of audial revelation without a visual element.¹⁶ A comparison with Abram’s revelation in Shechem would be more appropriate: “The Lord appeared to Abram and said: “I will assign this land to your offspring.” And he built an altar there to the Lord who had appeared to him” (12:7).¹⁷ This association can help clarify the conclusion of the revelation in 17:22 (b1 in the structure above), which includes the unusual description “God was gone from Abraham.” This account does not reappear in the Abraham cycle, as Wenham noted: “Usually nothing is said about God ceasing to speak or going away: he just stops and the next event is described.”¹⁸ The verb וַיַּעַל (literally: “arose,” translated by NJPS

14 Cf. Westermann 1995, 257.

15 Westermann 1995, 257.

16 Westermann is correct in stating that the content of the blessing given to Abram in ch. 12 resonates in the blessing of ch. 17.

17 Cf. Hamilton 1990, 460; Kiel 1997, 444.

18 Wenham 1994, 27.

above: “was gone from”) seems a more appropriate description of an angel (e.g., Judg 13:20. Cf. Gen 18:33; 35:13).¹⁹ The personification of God, who descends to the land and returns to His place at the conclusion of the revelation, might be related to the mutual design of the covenant; as if to say, in order to make a covenant with man, God must materialize Himself, abandoning the divine realm for some time.

The narrator refers to God by his “private” name: “YHWH appeared to Abram,” shortly followed by God’s own introduction of a new name: “I am El Shaddai” (17:1). The new name is not mentioned again throughout the story, which continues to refer to God with the generic Elohim. Many biblical critics (Gunkel, Eissfeldt, and Speiser, among others) assume that opening the story with YHWH was a scribal error, or a deliberate supplement by a late redactor, intended to link the Covenant of Circumcision with the previous narrative.²⁰ Others viewed the integration of the name YHWH as deliberate and significant (Westermann and Wenham, among others).²¹ A new name for God – one that was previously unknown to Abram and the reader – is appropriate in the context of Abram’s name change later in the narrative, and enhances the reciprocity of the covenant. There might also be a literary link between the changes, as shown below.

19 Jacob’s name was also changed by an angel; “God parted from him at the spot where He had spoken to him” refers to the angel, not to God Himself. See Grossman 1996, 19–20.

20 Skinner (1930, 289) raises the possibility of deliberate editing and of a scribal error; Gunkel (1997, 263) suggested a deliberate change by the redactor; Speiser (1964, 124) offered a scribal error, based on the previous text.

21 Westermann 1995, 257; Wenham 1994, 18–19.

c-c1. Covenant and Fertility

The covenant begins with an introduction of God by name: “I am El Shaddai” (1).²² Diverse definitions were offered for the name “El Shaddai.” Most medieval commentators viewed the word *Shaddai* as an adjective, while most modern biblical scholars see it as a proper noun.

The book of Job includes the majority of appearances of the name (thirty-one of forty-eight in the Bible, not preceded by the name “El”). The Septuagint translated all as “the Powerful God.” Some adopted this interpretation,²³ which is reinforced by Is 13:6: “Howl! For the day of the Lord is near; it shall come like havoc from Shaddai.”²⁴ The havoc in the verse is the result of the force and strength of the Lord.²⁵ Some objected to the comparison with Job, since they believe the name does not function exclusively, but rather as a means of diversification in parallels, with the connotation of an ancient name.²⁶ Alternative suggestions include deriving Shaddai from שָׂדֵי (“field”);²⁷ linking the term with שָׂדֵי (“breasts”) as a symbol of breastfeeding and

22 Similar to the Covenant between the Pieces: “I am the Lord who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans” (15:7). See also Gen 28:13; 35:11; 46:3; Ex 3:6, 14; 6:2, 29. McEvenue (1971, 152–53) noted structural links between the two covenants; however, Alexander appropriately noted that the links are not convincing enough, and that the Covenant of Circumcision is better linked with the Covenant of the Rainbow in Gen 9 than with the Covenant between the Pieces. See Alexander 1982, 175. However, the introduction of God by name does link the two covenants.

23 Walker referred to the Sumerian SHA(G)-ZU, assuming the pronunciation changed in the transfer to Aramaic (Walker 1960).

24 König, for example, derived the name Shaddai from the root שָׂדֵי (König 1895, 118; see note 1 for additional possibilities). This interpretation is offered by R. Samuel ibn Naghrela, quoted by Ibn Ezra, Gen 17:1.

25 Hamilton 1990, 462.

26 Westermann 1995, 258.

27 Weippert 1961. Similarly, some linked the name El Shaddai with the Amorite god “Bal Sade” (Lord of the Field). See Ouellette 1969; Bailey 1968.

abundance;²⁸ and connecting Shaddai with the Akkadian *šadū*, mountain,²⁹ or with the etymology of the Hebrew word הָר ("mountain").³⁰

All appearances of the combination "El Shaddai" in Genesis are linked with the blessing of fertility,³¹ supporting the position that connects *Shaddai* with fertility.³² Based on this connection an internal link might exist between the revelation of God's new name and the new name given to Abram, which is related to the blessing of fertility bestowed on Abram.³³

The actions expected of each of the parties are described at the outset:

Abram's commitment (1): "Walk in My ways and be blameless"

I will establish My covenant between Me and you

God's commitment (2): "I will make you exceedingly numerous."

This short statement summarizes the conditions of the covenant. Abram has to walk in God's ways, while God commits to making Abram "exceedingly numerous." "The covenant" connects the two commitments. This is the essence of the covenant, while the following verses contain extensions and consequences. God's commitment is clear, and centers on fertility. However, the expectation from Abram is vague: "Walk in My ways and be blameless." Clearly walking in God's ways indicates, in general terms, "fearing God" and "committing to

28 Dhorme 1922; Canney (1923) believed the name represented a feminine matriarchal entity before it was attributed to God.

29 *Šadū* A, *CAD* Š, 49–58.

30 Albright 1935, 180–87.

31 The only deviation is 43:14: "May El Shaddai dispose the man to mercy toward you..." However, while the context of the verse is the unity of the family, from Jacob's perspective the subject of concern is the survival of his sons.

32 I am not convinced by Fleishman's assertion that this is the preferred name for God in the patriarchal narrative (Fleishman 2001, 310). YHWH and Elohim are integrated in patriarchal texts no less than El Shaddai; moreover, the phenomenon should not be evaluated with statistical tools. The name is more common in fertility and family contexts, since it is connected with the blessing of fertility.

33 Westermann believed the unique name El Shaddai indicates the unique revelation to the forefathers, which is different from revelations to the nation, and not only different content (Westermann 1995, 258).

His will.”³⁴ Some limited the term to the religious context, and not to ethical-social situations.³⁵ The phrase “walking before God” is generally interpreted as “at the service of God,” but in the context of the Abraham narrative cycle the demand is dramatized by the use of the verb הָלַךְ (“go/walk”), which has accompanied the reader intensively throughout the cycle. The integration of this verb in the covenant creates a dialogue with its previous appearances, and gives the term renewed significance. Until this point, Abram walked through the land, interacted with the inhabitants (12:6; 13:7), and negotiated with the leaders (14:17–24). The Covenant between the Pieces formalized God’s commitment to Abram with regard to the land (15:18–21). In the Covenant of Circumcision, Abram is expected to engage once again in the act of going forth, and walking before God. Abram’s relationship with God becomes more intimate after the Covenant of Circumcision; the inclusion of the verb הָלַךְ indicates a change in the function of the protagonist of the story cycle.

In addition to the demand to walk in God’s ways, Abram is told to “be blameless.” While some read the phrase as a result of the previous demand (‘you will be blameless as a result of walking in God’s ways’),³⁶ or a completion of the previous statement (‘walk in God’s ways, completely, blamelessly’),³⁷ the phrase might express an independent demand.³⁸ While the imperative to “walk in God’s ways” is religious in nature, blamelessness has an ethical-moral standing. Many verses interpret “blameless” as “honest and fair”: “He who lives without blame;

34 Gunkel 1997, 263; von Rad 1963, 193; Speiser 1964, 124. According to Abraham’s servant, he was told: “The Lord, whose ways I have followed, will send His angel with you and make your errand successful” (Gen 24:40). Cf. Hezekiah’s prayer: “Please O lord, remember how I have walked before you sincerely and wholeheartedly” (2 Kgs 20:3; Is 38:3).

35 Von Rad 1963, 193.

36 “Thus you will be perfect” (Gunkel 1997, 263).

37 This position might be based on Weinfeld’s claim that the phrases discussed here have an Akkadian parallel: “Walk in My ways” parallels *ina mabriya ittalak*, and “be blameless” parallels *ittallaku šalmiš* (Weinfeld 1972, 76–77). Since the parallel for “be blameless” includes a connotation of walking, perhaps “be blameless” defines “walk in My ways,” creating a hendiadys.

38 Westermann 1995, 259.

who does what is right, and in his heart acknowledges the truth” (Ps 15:1–2).³⁹ This interpretation is emphasized in Psalm 101, which combines the verb הלך with the expression תמים – “blameless.”⁴⁰

I will study *the way of the blameless*; when shall I attain it? *I will walk*⁴¹ *without blame* within my house. I will not set before my eyes anything base; I hate crooked dealing; I will have none of it. Perverse thoughts will be far from me; I will know nothing of evil... My eyes are on the trusty men of the land, to have them at my side. He who *walks*⁴² *the way of the blameless* shall be in my service. He who deals deceitfully shall not live in my house; he who speaks untruth shall not stand before my eyes.

The poet’s blameless conduct is expressed through moral sensitivity and a rejection of evil; the poet wishes to be enveloped in a society of those who walk in the way of the blameless – who do not deal deceitfully or speak untruth.⁴³

The demand to be socially ethical is integrated into the covenant of those who walk with God. The verse is based on the concept that Abram is expected to walk in God’s ways not only religiously, but socially and ethically, by being charitable and just.

The transitions from component c to c1 will be discussed below.

39 According to Craigie, the meaning of living without blame is interpreted in light of the correlation between vs. 2 and 3: “Three positive conditions are followed by three negative conditions, then two positive followed by two negative – total ten” (Craigie 1973, 150). He parallels “walking blamelessly/no falsity.”

40 According to Briggs the introduction to the psalm was a late addition, and originally the psalm began “I will live without blame” (Briggs & Briggs 1907, 313–14). This position emphasizes the link of the psalm to the Covenant of Circumcision even more; however, his position is based on pure speculation.

41 NJPS translated אתהלך – “I will live.”

42 NJPS translated הלך – “he who follows.”

43 Dahood translated הולך תמים – “The man of blameless conduct” (Dahood 1970, 1). Regarding v. 7 as an antithesis of v. 6, see Briggs & Briggs 1907, 315.

d-d1: Abram Throws Himself on His Face

While Abram throws himself on his face in reaction to both of God's messages, there seems to be a real difference between the two episodes. The first time Abram falls (3) he does so as an expression of awe and respect. The revelation began with God's appearance before Abram (1); hiding one's face is the appropriate reaction (Ex 3:1; 33:20–34:8; Lev 9:24–25; 1 Kgs 18:39; 18:1 and 28), and falling on one's face indicates self-depreciation before God. In contrast, the second time Abram throws himself, he does so in laughter: "Abraham threw himself on his face and laughed" (17). This episode fails to contain the respect and awe that generally accompanies the biblical act of falling on one's face.⁴⁴ I agree with Westermann's analysis, which saw the combination of Abram's laughter and throwing himself down as a meaningful conflicting phrase. Abraham laughs skeptically, yet throwing himself down diminishes the effect of his skepticism.⁴⁵ The laughter directly affects the name of the child, which makes the element of laughter essential to this tidings (and to the tidings of ch. 18, as demonstrated there). Abram's laughter expresses wonder and surprise at the impossible breach of the natural order: a woman of ninety bearing a child. The element of surprise is known to be an essential comedic element, which leads to laughter. God commemorates Abram's laughter, which expresses the miraculous conditions of his son's birth, through Isaac's name.⁴⁶

44 As opposed to Kiel 1997, 462. Regarding the diverse uses of falling to one's face in biblical literature and ancient Near Eastern texts, see Gruber 1980, 133–36.

45 Cf. Gunkel 1997, 266.

46 This seems to be the reason there is no criticism of Abram's laughter, in contrast with the parallel in ch. 18, where Sarah is criticized for laughing in a similar context. The lack of criticism is established by the fact that God commemorates Abram's laughter in the son's name, which shows that God does not perceive his reaction in a negative light, or it would not be commemorated in his name. When tidings of a child are delivered to Sarai in ch. 18, no name is mentioned. See discussion below on the correlation between the two chapters, and why Sarah's laughter is criticized.

e-e1: The Name Change

After Abram-Abraham's reaction to God's message, God's commitment is explained further: "I will make you exceedingly fertile" (6). The blessing is an expansion of the generic "be fruitful and multiply" of Gen 1:28 and 9:1; the same verbs are used in Abraham's blessing (פרה; רוב) but expanded beyond the scope of the original blessing (מאד-מאד).⁴⁷ A comparison of Abraham's blessing (e) with Sarah's (e1) shows that the parallel is complete, with one major distinction:

| <i>Abram – Abraham (3–6)</i> | <i>Sarai – Sarah (15–16)</i> |
|--|---|
| and God spoke to him further
As for Me, this is My covenant with you: You shall be the father of a multitude of nations
And you shall no longer be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham,
for I make you the father of a multitude of nations
I will make you exceedingly fertile
and make nations of you
and kings shall come forth from you | And God said to Abraham

As for your wife Sarai, you shall not call her Sarai, but her name shall be Sarah

I will bless her; indeed, I will give you a son by her
I will bless her so that she shall give rise to nations
rulers of peoples shall issue from her |

47 A similar literary phenomenon occurs in the description of the fertility of Jacob's offspring in Egypt (Ex 1:7), which leans on the basic blessing "be fruitful and multiply," but also expands the original blessing. See Grossman 2008, 39–40.

| | |
|--|--|
| <p>I will maintain My covenant between Me and you, and your offspring to come, as an everlasting covenant throughout the ages, to be God to you and to your offspring to come. I assign the land you sojourn in to you and your offspring to come, all the land of Canaan, as an everlasting holding. I will be their God.</p> | |
|--|--|

The two basic components of name change and the blessing of fertility are repeated in both blessings. The change to each of the names is identical: an addition of the letter ה (“he”) and both blessings of fertility include components of “nations” and “rulers/kings.” The one change seems to the covenant: whereas Abram’s name change is enveloped in the covenant, which is mentioned at the beginning and end of the blessing, the covenant is omitted altogether from Sarai’s blessing.

This inconsistency is related to the ambivalent position of women with regard to circumcision. Sarai was not mentioned in Covenant between the Pieces, or in any of the revelations prior to ch. 17. This is the first time Sarai seems to be regarded as Abram’s partner in his covenant with God; she, too, merits a name change and a personal blessing.⁴⁸ On the other hand, the terms of the covenant relate to Abram and are not even mentioned in Sarai’s blessing, and the covenant sign is performed in Abram’s body and not Sarai’s.

The name change is manifest in the text, which no longer refers to Abram and Sarai, but rather to Abraham and Sarah.⁴⁹ The changing of the names of the protagonists should be viewed as a border between two parts of the Abraham cycle. Commentators raised three central possibilities regarding the significance of the name change:

48 In contrast with previous revelations, now Abram has a son, Ishmael, who will be mentioned in Abram’s reaction to God’s promise. Perhaps this is the reason for the emphasis on Sarah’s partnership in the covenant and Abram’s blessings, as opposed to previous revelations.

49 Wenham used this detail to prove that the story cycle is unified, and lacks sufficient proof of different sources (Wenham 1994, 18).

- a. Early exegetes viewed the addition of the letter ה as an indication of God's name (YHWH), which is inserted into Abram's name.⁵⁰ Although the letter ה is prominent in God's name, there is no indication in the text that the letter was taken from God's name. Additionally, if the reason for the change was to link Abram's name with God's, one would have expected YHWH to be the prominent name for God in the text, while the name YHWH does not appear once in Gen 17.
- b. The addition of the letter ה enables the intentional play on words אב הַמֶּוֹן גוֹיִם ("av hamon goim" – father of a multitude of nations), which is directly linked with the name change.⁵¹ Despite the obvious wordplay, this might not be the meaning of the new name; the letter ה was also added to Sarai's name, where the wordplay is absent.⁵² A more likely possibility is that the word הַמֶּוֹן ("multitudes") was used here as a play on the new name, and not the source of change.⁵³
- c. A more identifiable option views the name change as an expression of fertility; the increase of the blessing of fertility is expressed through the expansion of the names. The diverse uses of the letter ה, which can serve as either a vowel or a semi-consonant, enable this addition to act as both an expansion of the noun and an addition of a consonant, altogether enhancing the possibilities of the name.⁵⁴

50 *Midrash Aggadah II in Torah Shlema*, ed. M. Kasher, 79. See also Zohar I 96a; Kiel 1997, 451. Heinemann (1954, 106) discusses Philo's position that the meaning of the name is changed as well.

51 Previously noted by Rashi and Ibn Ezra, and Samuel David Luzzato. Similarly, for example: Parrot 1968, 83, n. 51; Mathews 2005, 202.

52 No meaning is noted in reference to Sarai's name change. This detail supports the position that views the explanation by Abram's name change as a homily with a literary purpose, rather than the etymology of the name.

53 Garsiel 1991, 18.

54 As various scholars have shown, there is no significant etymological difference between Abram and Abraham, and they seem to be different dialects of the same name (Bauer 1930, 75; Clements, "Abraham," 52). Montgomery added that the same is true of the names Sarah-Sarai (Montgomery 1927, 144).

The multiplicity of possibilities indicates that the change itself is the essence, not the significance of the name. Speiser, Sarna and Westermann wrote that the change indicates a new phase in the lives of Sarah and Abraham.⁵⁵ They proved this claim using the well-documented custom of changing the name of a king upon coronation.⁵⁶ Fleishman contested Westermann's claim that the change relates to fertility; he believed the change is a disengagement from Abram's past and present Canaanite surroundings, particularly with regard to sexual habits. Nonetheless, he agreed with Westermann that the name change indicates a new beginning; a new stage of life.⁵⁷

As mentioned in reference to Hagar (Gen 16:13) changing another's name (in her case, the angel) is a display of authority. However, other cases offer additional meaning: when Pharaoh changed Joseph's name to Zaphenath-Paneah, he indicated that Joseph was "reborn" into Pharaoh's patronage. Joseph became a member of Pharaoh's household, and merited a new name that expressed his new position.⁵⁸ The change from Abram to Abraham should be viewed in a similar light. The name indicates a new beginning, a new chapter; but since God is the one who gives Abraham his new name, the name also indicates Abraham's dependence on God, who takes Abraham in under his patronage; the new name expresses his new position. Abraham

55 Speiser 1964, 127; Thompson 1974, 23–24; Westermann 1995, 26; Sarna 1989, 129–31. Sarna wrote that the name change indicates a new dynastic choice, and brings examples from ancient Egypt. See another interpretation below.

56 See Key 1964.

57 Fleishman 2001. Kunin wrote in reference to the circumcision of Moses (Ex 4) that the sign of circumcision is linked with the name change; both signify a new beginning. A symbolic death is expressed by cutting the reproductive organ, while a rebirth is expressed by the new name (Kunin 1996, 10).

58 See Hamilton 1995, 507; Dvir 1969, 28–29 ("the name is a sign of subordination and subjugation; of ownership"). Pharaoh Neco changed the name of Eliakim son of Josiah to Jehoikim in 2 Kgs 23:34. The meaning of the name remains the same; the change signifies Jehoikim becoming a ruler on behalf of the Egyptian Pharaoh. Similarly, the king of Babylon changed Mattaniah's name to Zedekiah in 2 Kgs 24:17, to express the commitment of the Judean kingdom to Babylonia.

commits to walking in God's ways, while God spreads His wings over Abraham and adopts him, like a son.⁵⁹

Dhorme and Fleishman noted appropriately that Abram's original name was linked with Mesopotamian idolatry. All members of Terah's household were given idolatrous names (Nahor, Haran, Milcah, Sarai), and Abram's name was no different (cf. Josh 24:2).⁶⁰ Abram was expected to disengage from the house of his father and seek out not only a new land, but also a new theology. The name change "is another stage...continuing his disengagement from his land, the place of his birth, and his father's house."⁶¹ Abram left behind his Mesopotamian past – culminating in the change of his name – and arrived in Canaan, God's realm, where he will start anew under the auspices of his God. As this marks a "new beginning" for Abraham, this revelation also refers to the "nations," which, as mentioned in the introduction, does not appear often in the Abraham narrative. God's first revelation to Abraham (12:2–3) reveals that Abraham will be the father of a "nation," and here too, when his new name symbolizes a new beginning, nationalistic terminology features. The label "nation," however, is not used in conjunction with Isaac, Abraham's successor.

F – The Covenant Sign (9–14)

The main message is contained in the longest passage, designed in a legal style that is used throughout the Bible.⁶² In Genesis the style is

59 Symbolically the addition of a the letter from God's name indicates a unique internal connection created by the covenant, which is expressed by God changing Abram's name.

60 Dhorme 1928; Fleishman 2001. Cf. Wenham 1994, 252.

61 Fleishman 2001, 313.

62 Cf. Gunkel 1997, 165. The legal style affects both the transition to plural and the passive phrasing. The threat of punishment does not indicate that the story was not composed in an environment where this law was not observed (as held

limited to ch. 17 alone (with some similarity to Gen 9:1–7),⁶³ since the law of circumcision is the only law in the book obligating the offspring of Abraham. In this, the chapter's central axis hints at the broader historical significance of the Abraham cycle; that it far exceeds the scope of Abraham's individual life. The entire chapter is concentric, and some of the short speeches within are also designed in an internal chiasmic structure. This is the case in the verses describing the covenant sign:

- a. As for you, you and your offspring to come throughout the ages shall *keep My covenant*.
- b. Such shall be the covenant between Me and you and your offspring to follow which you shall keep: *every male among you shall be circumcised*.
- c. You shall circumcise the *flesh* of your foreskin, and that shall be the *sign of the covenant* between Me and you;
- d. And throughout the generations, every male among you shall be circumcised at the age of eight days. As for the homeborn slave and the one bought from an outsider who is not of your offspring.
- d1. They must be circumcised, homeborn, and purchased alike.
- c1. Thus shall My covenant be marked in your *flesh* as an *everlasting covenant*.
- b1. And if any *male* who is *uncircumcised* fails to *circumcise* the flesh of his foreskin, that person shall be cut off from his kin;
- a1. He has broken *My covenant*.

The setting of the law introduces the demand and the consequence for violating the covenant (a, b-a1, b1). The focal point of the law specifics the obligation to circumcise dependants (d-d1: “eight days” and “homeborn slave and the one bought from an outsider”). The focal point is enveloped by two contradictory definitions of the obligation. Initially (c) the removal of foreskin is defined as the *covenant sign*, while later (c1) circumcision is called the actual covenant: “Thus shall *My covenant* be marked in your flesh.” A similar idea is expressed

by Hall, “Circumcision,” rather, that the law is composed in an accepted legal style.

63 Regarding the similarities between Gen 9 and 17, see McEvenue 1971, 170–71.

in v. 10: “Such shall be *the covenant*...every male among you shall be circumcised.”

The definition of circumcision as a sign indicates that the act is a reminder of the covenant, not the essence of the covenant. If circumcision is a sign, it is meant to remind Abraham of his commitment to walk in the ways of God and be blameless. A similar model is found with regard to Noah after the flood: the content of the commitment is the avoidance of a flood, and the rainbow is a sign – a reminder of the commitment (Gen 9:13).⁶⁴ According to the formulation that depicts circumcision as the actual covenant, the obligation to circumcise parallels God’s promise of fertility. Many scholars viewed the removal of the foreskin as Abram’s commitment in the covenant, and as the content of the covenant.

Verse 11 simplifies this matter: “You shall circumcise the flesh of your foreskin, and that shall be the sign of the covenant between Me and you.” The removal of the foreskin is a sign of commitment to the content of the covenant. The verses that seem to indicate otherwise should be viewed as a metonymy: since circumcision is the “covenant sign” and a reminder of the covenant, the covenant is represented by the flesh itself. The covenant is not theoretical or abstract; rather, the essence of the covenant is in the flesh, which symbolizes man’s yielding to its obligations.

The significance of removing the foreskin requires attention. Circumcision functions as a sign of the covenant; one would expect the sign to be in plain sight; the phylacteries, which are also called a sign, are worn on the head, like a crown. In contrast, the sign of the Covenant of Circumcision is in a hidden place. This matter is enhanced by another: although Sarai’s name is also changed in the story, the sign is exclusively in the male body. Could another sign that is in plain

64 Compare: McComiskey 1985, 139–77. Fox wrote that the sign of circumcision is a reminder of the covenant directed at God, which parallels the rainbow (Fox 1974, 595–96). As he emphasizes, this has much significance, because unlike ancient world beliefs, circumcision is not considered a form of magical protection in itself, but rather only functions as a sign of the covenant. Regardless, Hamilton (1990, 470–72) debated the moot question regarding toward whom the symbol is directed.

view, and that involves women as well, not have been selected? Bekhor Shor suggested that the sign needs to be hidden from the gentiles: “the gentiles should not say about Israel, ‘they are lame.’”⁶⁵ According to his interpretation, hiding the covenant is the chief factor in God’s choice of the sign. However, the assumption that circumcision was not known because of the location of the sign is unrealistic. Additionally, an essential part of the concept of a sign is the statement that accompanies the sign. Even if the sign causes physical damage, the statement should be public; a defect that declares devotion to the God of the forefathers.

Since the content of the covenant is specifically linked with the blessing of fertility, the covenant sign is made in the reproductive organ. In the past, removal of the foreskin was considered a coming-of-age or initiation rite. The bodily site of circumcision also encouraged various psychoanalytical interpretations.⁶⁶ However, Isaac is correct in asserting that several factors attest to the fact that in the Bible, circumcision is not perceived as an initiation rite: all members of Abraham’s household, regardless of age, were required to undergo circumcision; the usual age for performing circumcision is eight days old; and in the Bible, the ceremony was never performed by priests nor any figures of authority.⁶⁷ The sign indicates the essence of the covenant. God committed to bless Abram’s fertility, while Abram committed to walk blamelessly in the ways of God. The mutual commitment – the acceptance of El Shaddai as the God of Abraham and his descendants, meriting the blessing of fertility – is expressed by a mark on the reproductive organ of those loyal to El Shaddai.

The structure raises several key points that clarify the narrative: the structural link between Abraham and Sarah, which relates to the birth of Isaac; the focus on the command for future generations to circumcise all male children; and the frame that emphasizes that Abram

65 R. Joseph Bekhor Shor on Gen 17:11. He also views maintaining the laws relating to menstruation as the female alternative to circumcision.

66 See an extensive survey of this in: Hastings 1951.

67 Isaac 1964, 450. And see the conclusion of this chapter, below.

is “not yet one hundred,” indicating that the story has not reached its conclusion.

The literary structure clarifies Ishmael’s position, which undergoes an unseen process throughout the chapter. Isaac is unequivocally the central son in the covenant from God’s perspective; however, Abraham’s request, “O that Ishmael might live by Your favor” (18), creates an overt conflict between the two sons, which demands an explicit divine resolution. Vs. 19–21 are also concentric:⁶⁸

- a. Nevertheless, Sarah your wife shall bear you a son;
 - b. And you shall name him Isaac; and I will maintain My covenant with him as an everlasting covenant for his offspring to come.
 - c. As for Ishmael, I have heeded you. I hereby bless him. I will make him fertile and exceedingly numerous. He shall be the father of twelve chieftains, and I will make of him a great nation;
 - b1. But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac,
- a1. whom Sarah shall bear to you at this season next year.

The verses emphasize the preference of Isaac over Ishmael: God tells Abram twice that the everlasting covenant will be realized through Isaac, not Ishmael. Nonetheless, Ishmael’s inclusion specifically in the center of the text cannot be ignored, and the blessing he merits has to be clarified.⁶⁹ The wording of the blessing is similar to the blessings directed at Abram in previous chapters; however, the parallel between Ishmael’s blessing and the one given to Abram earlier in the chapter is apparent. God says in reference to Ishmael: “I will make him *fertile* and *exceedingly numerous*,” mirroring Abram’s blessing in v. 2: “I will make you *exceedingly numerous*,” and v. 6: “I will make you *exceedingly fertile*.” Similarly, God says in reference to Ishmael: “He shall be the father of *twelve chieftains*, and I will *make of him a great nation*,” mirroring Abram’s blessing in v. 6: “I will *make nations of you*; and *kings* shall come forth from you.” Ishmael disengages from the covenant that will be maintained by Isaac; nevertheless, he stands to inherit Abram’s blessing of fertility. The covenant and the blessing of fertility seem to be divided between Isaac and Ishmael. This division is apparent from the general

68 McEvenue 1971, 175; Alexander 1982, 172; Wenham 1994, 26.

69 Goldingay 1998, 147.

chiasm in the chapter, which parallel the verses regarding Isaac and Ishmael's blessings with God's initial message. The similar wording links the two episodes and indicates a division between the sons:

| <i>Component C (vs. 1–2)</i> | <i>Component C₁ (vs. 19–21)</i> |
|---|--|
| I will establish My covenant between Me and you | I will maintain My covenant with him as an everlasting covenant for his offspring to come... But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac |
| and I will make you exceedingly numerous | As for Ishmael, I have heeded you. I hereby bless him. I will make him fertile and exceedingly numerous. He shall be the father of twelve chieftains, and I will make of him a great nation. |

While component C introduced the covenant and the blessing of fertility, the parallel C₁ clarifies that the covenant will be maintained through Isaac, while the blessing of fertility is given to Ishmael. This conclusion might seem implausible; Sarah is also blessed with fertility, a blessing that clearly will be fulfilled through her only son. However, the structure and development of the text indicate that Abraham's outburst led to the inclusion of Ishmael in the dialogue, warranting him a blessing that was originally part of the covenant. The conclusion is therefore that Isaac's fertility will stem from his inclusion in the covenant, while Ishmael's fertility is unconditional on a religious or mutual covenant.

Ishmael's unique status is also expressed in relation to his blessing in the previous chapter, particularly in reference to the implied meaning of his name in each of the chapters. In ch. 16 Ishmael's name signified God having heard Hagar's distress. Hagar's blessing of fertility is portrayed as her compensation for suffering at the hands of her mistress. These accusations are diminished in ch. 17, and Ishmael's name takes on new meaning: "As for Ishmael, I have heeded you (שמעתך)" (20). According to this homily, the name and blessing of Abraham's son are not a compensation for Hagar's suffering, but rather for Abraham's request, "O that Ishmael might live by Your favor" (18). In ch. 17, Ishmael's status is not a criticism of Sarai but rather a merit to Abram,

whose offspring – even the one that is not part of the covenant – is blessed. In ch. 17 Ishmael inherits the blessing of fertility not because of his mother, but because of his father.

The feeling that Ishmael was not originally supposed to be included in the narrative is apparent from the concluding verses (a1: vs. 23–27). These verses are also designed concentrically:

- a. Then *Abraham* took *his son Ishmael*, and *all his homeborn slaves and all those he had bought*, every male in Abraham’s household, and he *circumcised* the flesh of their foreskins,
 - b. *on that very day*, as God had spoken to him.
 - c. Abraham was ninety-nine years old when he circumcised the flesh of his foreskin;
 - c1. and his son Ishmael was thirteen years old when he was circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin.
 - b1. *on that very day*
- a1. *Abraham* and *his son Ishmael* were *circumcised*, and *all his household, his homeborn slaves and those that had been bought from outsiders*, were *circumcised* with him.

The center of the structure focuses, surprisingly, on Abraham and his son – Ishmael. The narrative begins by stating Abram’s age, and ends by repeating his age, this time alongside the age of his son. These details specify Ishmael’s status, which is improved throughout the story. Following Abraham’s request on behalf of his son, Ishmael merits a portion of Abraham’s blessing.

The circumcision of Abraham’s servants mirrors vs. 12–13, with a subtle variation:

- v. 12: the homeborn slave and the one bought from any outsider who is not of your offspring.
- v. 13: your homeborn, and those purchased by you⁷⁰
- v. 23: all his homeborn slaves and all those he had bought
- v. 27: the homeborn slaves and those that had been bought from outsiders

In addition to the change to plural in v. 23, the middle verses shorten the phrasing of the outer verses. McEvenue wrote: “these lists exemplify

70 NJPS translated: “homeborn and purchased.”

once again the principle of repetition with variety, and of broken symmetries, as a stylistic feature of priestly writing.”⁷¹

This stylistic-esthetic phenomenon might not carry strong significance; interestingly, however, the two cases that omit the “outsider” from the definition of the slave are written in the context of Abraham’s obligation to circumcise *his* dependents. Verse 13 directly associates the slaves with Abraham: “*your* homeborn, and those purchased *by you*,” as opposed to v. 12, which refers generally to “the homeborn slave and the one bought.” Similarly, in v. 23 Abraham circumcises the males of his household, including “*all* his homeborn slaves and *all* those he had bought,” while in v. 27 the narrator concludes: “the homeborn slaves and those that had been bought from outsiders.” The changing formulation is related to the integration of the law into the specific narrative; the law, which obligates future generations, is implemented in the specific narrative relating to Abraham. The homeborn and bought slaves who are obligated in circumcision are the people circumcised along with Abraham when he accepts God’s covenant. Perhaps this is the reason the phrase בן נכר (“outsider”) is omitted from the verses about Abraham: this phrase is appropriate for a general law relating to the social status of a separated nation, which employs slaves from other nations. The style seems less relevant to Abraham’s personal story, before he could be called “a nation.” Ishmael, Abraham’s own son, will later be considered “an outsider” – clearly this definition is inappropriate in the context of Abraham’s present.

This chapter cannot be concluded without noting the biblical innovation regarding circumcision, which was prevalent in the ancient world. Although many cultures have documentation on circumcision,⁷² as noted in a variety of biblical sources,⁷³ scholars debate the source

71 McEvenue 1971, 177.

72 Cf. Jer 9:24–25 (Sarna 1989, 132). See review by Fox 1974; Sasson 1966; Westermann 1995, 165; Sarna 1989, 131–33; Hamilton 1990, 469; Hall, “Circumcision,” 1025–31; Fleishman 2001, 314; Wyatt 2009.

73 E.g., the Dinah narrative in Gen 34; Moses and Zipporah in the encampment in Ex 4; Jer 9:24–25. Sarna suggested that the Passover law that excludes the uncircumcised from the sacrifice attests to the widespread “pre-Sinai” circulation of the law of circumcision (Sarna 1989, 132). Also, according to the

of the custom and the purpose of circumcision in other nations.⁷⁴ Since circumcision affects the reproductive organ, the custom seems to relate to fertility. This idea is reinforced by the prevalent custom to circumcise men before marriage.⁷⁵ There are two major differences between biblical circumcision and the prevalent custom in the ancient Near East. First, the context of the law portrays circumcision as part of a covenant, and the removal of the foreskin is a “sign” of the covenant between Abraham (and his offspring) and God.⁷⁶ Second, biblical circumcision is performed on infants at the age of eight days, and not as a rite of passage prior to marriage.⁷⁷

These two details shed a unique light on circumcision, and on the purpose of the narrative in Gen 17. The covenant sign is performed in the reproductive organ, because the essence of the covenant relates to the blessing of fertility.⁷⁸ But the covenant is not as significant to the infant as it is to his parents. The performance of circumcision on a helpless baby makes the sign into a testimony of the covenant between the *parents* and their God.⁷⁹ White noted that a circumcision at the age

biblical narrative the law was given to Abraham, and there is no reason his children should not know and follow the law. Goldingay claimed correctly that the integration of circumcision in the Dinah narrative creates an ironic effect. See Goldingay 2000, 9–10.

74 Hall, “Circumcision,” 1025, and Fleishman (2001, 314) summarized the debate.

75 Hamilton 1990, 46. Sasson (1966, 474) raises the possibility that this is a rite of passage.

76 Sarna 1989, 132; Fox 1974; Hall, “Circumcision,” 1027.

77 See among others Wyatt 2009.

78 See especially: Isaac 1964. Fleishman viewed sexual purity as the essence of the covenant and the distinction of the offspring of Abraham from the prevalent sexual morality in Egypt and Canaan (Fleishman 2001). He demonstrated that the inheritance of the land is dependent on maintaining high moral sexual standards, and that this concept materializes in the book of Genesis as well.

79 The fact that the parents are the focus of the covenant and not the circumcised baby is emphasized in Ishmael’s circumcision. Abraham is obligated to circumcise Ishmael; nonetheless, Ishmael is not included in the Covenant of Circumcision, as God says: “But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac.” The demand for circumcision at eight days might relate to a broader biblical concept relating to “the eighth day,” particularly in relation to the purification process, which lasts seven days and requires a sacrifice on the eighth day. Wyatt (2009, 416)

of 13 (i.e., Ishmael's) could mean a rite of passage, while circumcision at eight days is part of the birth rituals.⁸⁰ When parents circumcise their son, they recognize that God has fulfilled His commitment to the fertility of Abraham's offspring. Simultaneously, by circumcising their son, the parents enter their son into the family covenant with God. Since the sign of the covenant is in the reproductive organ, the next generation to be born to the circumcised baby will be born into the sanctity of the covenant, because his parents had walked in the ways of El Shaddai. Each circumcision represents a multi-generational acceptance of the covenant: the parents who make the covenant; the baby who will be an instrument for the covenant sign; and the next generation to be born of the covenant sign.

In light of all this, Abraham's age is an appropriate frame for the Covenant of Circumcision. As earlier noted, timing of the covenant when Abraham was "almost one hundred" was an indication that the real and essential starting point would only occur when Abraham was 100: "But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear to you at this season next year" (17:21). Abraham circumcises himself one year before the birth of Isaac, to ensure that the process of Isaac's conception and birth is included in the covenant. Hamilton expressed this idea by saying the covenant was made now, but only realized a year later.⁸¹

As for the reason circumcision is performed on males alone, Hamilton suggested that since the sign is a reminder for the married couple, who are perceived as "one flesh" (Gen 2:24), a sign on one of the two is sufficient.⁸² This suggestion is supported by the concentric structure, since Sarah is paralleled to Abraham; the two seem to be regarded equally with regard to the divine blessing of fertility. Laffey suggested that ultimately the biblical text itself emphasizes

viewed circumcision as a type of sacrifice, shedding new light on the "eighth day" concept in Ex 22:9; Lev 22:27. Others viewed the removal of the foreskin as a protection from the constant threat to those who would violate the covenant. see Isaac 1965.

80 Wyatt 2009, 411–12. See also Isaac 1964, 450.

81 Hamilton 1990, 479.

82 Hamilton 1990, 470. See also Fleishman 2001, 315.

the significance of circumcision as a metaphor (the circumcision of the soul and lips) rather than physical circumcision. In this context there is no distinction between men and women.⁸³ Goldingay, however, correctly stated that even if internal circumcision is more important, there is reason to question the choice of a sign that can only be implemented by men.⁸⁴ Goldingay believes “the cutting of the foreskin starts off looking like a sign which establishes that full membership of the Israelite community belongs especially to males...The very fact that it is the males who bear this sign means that it is the males who embody spiritual and mental unfitness to belong to the people of promise.”⁸⁵

A more plausible explanation relates to the fact that the male contingency is viewed in biblical philosophy as the successor of the dynasty. The nature of the Covenant of Circumcision is realized through lineage: “I will maintain My covenant between Me and you, and your offspring to come, as an everlasting covenant throughout the ages, to be God to you and to your offspring to come” (17:7). When the women of the household marry, they leave the family and join the family of their husband; they thereby leave the covenant of their original home, and join the covenant of their husband’s family. Perhaps one can say that if the covenant sign was on the female body, leaving her home for marriage would essentially be a desecration of the covenant and an offense toward the unique intimacy that accompanies the covenant.

83 Laffey 1988, 62–64.

84 Goldingay 2000, 4.

85 Goldingay 2000, 15–16.

Circumcision and the Rainbow as Covenant Signs

The broader purpose of the Covenant of Circumcision becomes apparent in light of the contrast with the Rainbow Covenant. The language and style of the two covenants are similar:⁸⁶

| <i>Abraham's Covenant (17)</i> | <i>Noah's Covenant (9)</i> |
|--|---|
| I make you the father of a multitude of nations; I will make you exceedingly fertile | Be fertile, then, and increase; abound on the earth and increase on it. |
| I will maintain My covenant between Me and you, and your offspring to come | I now establish my covenant with you and your offspring to come, and with every living thing that is with you – birds, cattle, and every wild beast as well – all that have come out of the ark, every living thing on earth. I will maintain my covenant with you. |
| ...as an everlasting covenant throughout the ages | For all ages to come. |
| You shall circumcise the flesh of your foreskin, and that shall be the sign of the covenant between Me and you | I have set My bow in the clouds, and it shall serve as a sign of the covenant between Me and the earth. |
| as an everlasting pact | I will see it and remember the everlasting covenant. |

Additionally, God's demand, "Walk in My ways and be blameless," is reminiscent of the characterization of Noah: "Noah was a righteous man; he was blameless in his age – Noah walked with God" (Gen 6:9). The narrator attests that Abraham did "as God had spoken to him" (17:23) just as Noah did "as God had commanded him" (7:16).⁸⁷

86 See, among others, Isaac 1964, 451; McEvenue 1971, 170–71; McComiskey 1985, 139–77; Cassuto 1989, 18–52, 41–43.

87 The link between the Covenant of the Rainbow and the Covenant of Circumcision is expressed in Ezekiel's chariot vision: "From what appeared as his loins up, I saw a gleam as of amber – what looked like fire encased in a frame; and from what appeared as his loins down I saw what looked like fire. There was a radiance all about him. Like the appearance of the bow that shines in the

Despite the obvious link between all covenant narratives, these two seem to have a special affinity.⁸⁸ The Covenant of Circumcision is portrayed as though it promotes the Rainbow Covenant to another level. There are four advances from the Rainbow Covenant to the Covenant of Circumcision:

1. The partnership: After the flood, God made a covenant with “all flesh,” including animals. This fact is emphasized four times in the text,⁸⁹ starting from the very first declaration regarding the creation of a covenant (9:9–10). “I now establish My covenant with you and your offspring to come, and Similarly, the covenant sign – the rainbow – is “a sign that I set for the covenant between Me and you and *every living creature* with you, for all ages to come” (9:12; and so 9:15–16). Finally, the conclusion of the narrative states: “That shall be a sign of the covenant that I have established between Me and *all flesh that is on earth*” (9:17). In contrast, the Covenant of Circumcision includes only Abraham and his offspring. Abraham is promised that he will be “father of a multitude of nations” (17:4); the formulation of the covenant constantly repeats the exclusivity of those included in the covenant. Unlike the detailed list in the Rainbow Covenant, the Covenant of Circumcision has only the intimate description “between me and you and your offspring to come.” Anyone outside Abraham’s family is not included in the covenant.⁹⁰

clouds on a day of rain, such was the appearance of the surrounding radiance. That was the appearance of the semblance of the presence of the Lord” (Eze 1:27–28). Ezekiel describes a fire and radiance “from his loins down,” and compares the radiance to a rainbow.

- 88 Regarding the linguistic formulations that distinguish the covenant narrative, see Mendenhall 1954; Weinfeld 1975; McCarthy 1978.
- 89 McEvenue demonstrated that in God’s address to Noah in 9:8–10, those affected by the covenant gradually expand, and ultimately include all animals (McEvenue 1971, 73).
- 90 As earlier noted, Westermann believed that the Covenant of Circumcision reflects a universalistic approach, similar to Gen 12:3, since in both instances the blessing is said to affect many nations. While Abram is blessed that he will be father to many nations, the nations to merit God’s blessing in the Covenant

2. **Location:** The purpose of each of the covenants leads to the implementation of each covenant in a different location. The word “earth” appears seven times in the text of the Rainbow Covenant. Since the purpose of covenant is the maintenance of the world, the covenant is valid everywhere. In contrast, the Covenant of Circumcision is only maintained within the narrow borders of Canaan: “I assign the land you sojourn in to you and your offspring to come, all the land of Canaan as an everlasting holding, and I will be their God” (17:8). Abraham and his offspring will inherit the land of Canaan, where God will be acknowledged as the Lord of Abraham’s offspring.⁹¹
3. While the scope of the covenant is reduced, human commitment in the Covenant of Circumcision is expanded. The Rainbow Covenant is predominantly God’s commitment, but there seems to be an expectation of human contribution: man is expected to reproduce, while God commits not to destroy the world with another flood. This demand was stated twice in the covenant, as a literary frame for the unit before the covenant: “Be fertile and increase, and fill the earth” (9:1), and “Be fertile, then, and increase, abound on the earth and increase on it” (9:7). The demand is to devote oneself to a natural survival instinct. The demands are mutual in that both parties have committed to maintain the existence of the world. In contrast, God’s demand of the party to circumcision is religious: “Walk in My ways and be blameless” (17:1).

of Circumcision are those descended from Abraham; this is not a universal approach, but rather a blessing to Abraham’s extended family. In contrast, the blessing in 12:3 relates to nations that are independent of Abraham.

- 91 Regarding the unique depiction of Canaan as the land of the fathers, without particular religious indications, see Lohfink 1973–2001, 125–28. However, this description is not apparent in Ex 6, particularly compared with Ex 3–4. Rashi wrote: “there – ‘I will be their God,’ but one who dwells outside the land, it is as though I am not their God” (Rashi on Gen 17:8). According to reliable manuscripts cited by Avraham Grossman 2006, 174. The author discusses Rashi’s unique approach toward the Land of Israel, which is reflected in the aforementioned comment.

4. Finally, the party responsible for maintaining the sign varies in each of the covenants: while God commits to “set My bow in the clouds” (9:12–14), Abraham is the one who must maintain the sign of the Covenant of Circumcision: “You shall circumcise the flesh of your foreskin, and that shall be the sign of the covenant between Me and you” (17:9–11).

The four differences stem from the fact that God’s covenant with Noah is a natural covenant, which relates to the very existence of the world. In this covenant, there is a human commitment is to be fruitful and multiply; this commitment relates to all living beings at all times; its nature is unrelated to religion. In contrast, the Covenant of Circumcision relates to a specific group, which committed to walking in the ways of God; the covenant is therefore religious in nature. A religious declaration by those committed to the covenant is necessary, and so the maintenance of the covenant sign is incumbent upon man. Upon the birth of his son, God’s faithful subject will declare his commitment to God, and acknowledge the source of his fertility. Such a statement could not be expected in the Rainbow Covenant, which comprises all living beings, and the earth itself.

Chapter 9: Angels Eat and Sarah Laughs (18:1–16)

By all accounts, Gen 18:1 marks the beginning of a new literary unit. Stephen Langton began a new chapter; the Jewish division into portions began a new section (15); even the Babylonian division began a new reading portion (“Vayera”). Nonetheless, the story is linked to the previous narrative from the outset: “The Lord appeared to *him* by the terebinths of Mamre; he was sitting at the entrance of the tent as the day grew hot” (18:1). Abraham is not mentioned by name but by the preposition אֵלָיו (“to him”), and this anonymity is retained in the following verses: “*he* was sitting,” “*he* saw,” “As soon as *he* saw them, *he* ran,” “bowing to the ground, *he* said.” This assumes that the reader knows the protagonist’s identity, since the unit relies upon a preceding narrative;¹ Rudin-O’brasky suggested that the preceding unit in question concerns Abram and Lot, which ends “And Abram moved his tent and came to dwell at the terebinths of Mamre, which are in Hebron, and he built an altar there to the Lord” (13:18). Verse 18:1 seems to be a direct continuation of this narrative: “The Lord appeared to him by the terebinths of Mamre.”² This raises the question, however, as to why the location “the terebinths of Mamre” is repeated; alternatively, if Rudin-O’brasky is correct in claiming that the repetition is the result of redaction, one would expect repetition of the protagonist’s name as well as his location.

Early exegesis generally read the narrative as a continuation of the Covenant of Circumcision; some even contended that the angels came to visit the elderly Abraham as he recovered from his circumcision.³

1 Cf. Hamilton 1995, 5. Gunkel and Westermann claimed that v. 1 (the caption) is later than the original narrative, and that the omission of the protagonist’s name is the result of an editing error (Gunkel 1997, 192; Westermann 1995, 277).

2 Rudin-O’brasky 1981, 48–49.

3 See survey by Rudin-O’brasky 1981, 34–35.

Indeed, Letellier demonstrated the extensive connections between the two chapters.⁴ Another possibility is that this chapter refers back to the narrative of Ishmael's birth (16). As previously noted, ch. 17 connects the two halves of the Abraham cycle. Putting ch. 17 aside, the thematic connection between chs. 18 and 16 emerges: two tidings of a son and heir delivered by angels to two of Abraham's wives. The two narratives are also theologically related, which will be further discussed in the context of ch. 21. Ishmael's birth ends with Abram: "Hagar bore a son to Abram, and Abram gave the son that Hagar bore him the name Ishmael; Abram was eighty-six years old when Hagar bore Ishmael to Abram" (16:15–16); ch. 18's opening pronoun might rely upon this previous verse and describe "him" sitting in the terebinths of Mamre. The angels who met Hagar proceed to Abraham's tent. The desert revelation by the spring, delivering tidings of a son who will leave home and roam the wild, now comes inside Abraham's tent, bringing the promise of an heir to Abraham's home.

However, reading the chapter in conjunction with the previous episode highlights the question that lies at the heart of the chapter: why is another revelation regarding the birth of Isaac necessary, considering Abraham was told in the Covenant of Circumcision that Sarah will give him a son?

The repetitive nature of the narratives is striking, apparent in the phraseology and narrative materials. The angels inform Abraham that Sarah will have a baby "next year" (18:14), just as God had told Abraham that his son will be born "at this season next year" (17:21). Abraham laughed in disbelief when he heard God's tidings, since "Can a child be born to a man a hundred years old, or can Sarah bear a child at ninety?" (17:17); Sarah reacted similarly, and for the same reason, when she heard the prediction: "Now that I am withered, am I to have enjoyment – with my husband so old?" (18:12).

Traditional biblical criticism views this duplication as the result of the fusion of different sources: the decree regarding circumcision (17) is attributed to P, while the tiding of the angels (18) is associated with J. This position clarifies the repetition and the stylistic differences

4 Letellier 1995, 36–37.

between the two narratives, but it overlooks the exclusive contribution of each narrative within the wider Abraham cycle.⁵

Out of the wide range of scholarly justifications of the double episodes, we can mention two positions that seek to justify the fundamental difference between the narratives:

1. Victor Hamilton discussed whether Sarah's laughter reveals her knowledge of the previous episode. He explains that Abraham does not share the revelation with her, and "she hears about it (18:10b) quite by accident." Alternately, Hamilton suggests that "the rebuke aimed at Sara indicates that Abraham had shared the news about Isaac with Sara, but that she still persisted in unbelief. She was not convinced by her husband."⁶
2. While Hamilton addresses the realistic question of Sarah's awareness, Yair Zakovitch utilized the narrative focus' shift from Abraham to Sarah to explain the literary repetition. He believes the integration of the two episodes creates a necessary literary balance:⁷ "Reading ch. 18 might create the impression that Abraham stood in the shadow of Sarah with regard to the tidings – the juxtaposition of the two chapters creates a balance between Abraham and Sarah. After ch. 17, where Abraham is told about the birth of his son, there is no longer reason to inform Abraham of what he already knows."⁸

Hamilton's suggestions are both problematic: if a realistic explanation is what he seeks, then the stories do not feasibly function on the premise that Abraham concealed God's plan from Sarah, who would

5 "[T]he repetition of narratives is one of the cornerstones of biblical criticism. Various scholars sufficed with attributing the repeated stories to different documents. This chapter will demonstrate that the duplication is not an editing error, but rather a deliberate act" (Zakovitch 1992, 42).

6 Hamilton 1995, 13. See also Kidner 1967, 132.

7 A similar approach was suggested by McEvenue, who believed ch. 17 is familiar with the narrative of ch. 18; however, according to McEvenue the two narratives relate to each other, while Zakovitch believes the narratives complete each other (McEvenue 1971, 153–54).

8 Zakovitch 1992, 42. A similar suggestion is already made by Nachmanides on the relevant verse.

presumably have questioned why Abraham is suddenly seized with the desire to circumcise every male on the premises, including his 99-year-old self; moreover, Abraham would undoubtedly have explained the reason behind their new names. Additionally, one would have expected the text to be explicit about Sarah's lack of faith in her husband's news.

These points require additional clarification, but the analysis must begin with the essential difference noted by Hamilton and Zakovitch: in the Covenant of Circumcision bears tidings to Abraham, while the angels address their message to Sarah.⁹ The apparent repetition of the tidings of Isaac's birth will be clarified through analysis of the text itself.

Abraham's Guests (1–5)

The narrative begins by describing a divine revelation ("The Lord appeared to him") that lacks verbal content. In other revelations God appears and then speaks (see 17:1; 27:2; 27:24), while here the revelation serves as a caption for a narrative description of the revelation. While the reader is aware that the people who arrive at Abraham's tent are in fact part of a divine revelation, to Abraham they appear to be three guests in need of rest and shelter. The disparity between the protagonist and the reader raises hidden messages that the story wishes to convey. Some have proposed that this question remains open throughout the narrative: even at the chapter's end, it is not clear if Abraham is aware of his guests' true identity.¹⁰ I believe this disparity plays a literary function: The reader is deprived of the element of surprise when the true identity of the visitors is

9 Hamilton's formulation is more complex; he believed Sarah "accidentally" heard the tidings of the angels. We will demonstrate below that Sarah's over-hearing of the angels is intentional, and the message is intended for Sarah from the outset.

10 Ska 1993 (see also Ska 2008).

revealed, but it serves to shift his or her focus to Abraham's story.¹¹ The reader, who knows their true identity, is aware that Abraham needs the information they carry more than they require his ministrations. Abraham's actions can therefore be viewed as a trial and test of Abraham's kindness and grace.

The definition of time contributes to the evaluation of Abraham's hospitality. Verse 1 was translated by the Septuagint: "And God appeared to him by the oak of Mamre, as he sat by the door of his tent at noon."¹² The Masoretic text reads literally, "in the heat of the day," or "as the day grew hot" (NJPS). The Septuagint interpreted this phrase as a definition of time, meaning "noon."¹³ This interpretation corresponds with the definition of time in the following chapter: "The two angels arrived in Sodom in the evening, as Lot was sitting in the gate of Sodom" (19:1). Abraham sits at the entrance to his tent, while Lot sits at the gate of Sodom; the angels depart from Abraham in the afternoon, and arrive in Sodom to see Lot in the evening. However, while here the narrator chose to plainly say "evening," Abraham greets his guests not "at noon" but "in the heat of the day." This phrase is calculated to give the reader a sense of the scope of Abraham's hospitality, which transcends usual working hours.¹⁴ Abraham's actions (running, prostrating, inviting, preparing, and serving) take place in the heat of the day, emphasizing the self-sacrifice involved. The phrasing provides not only a time-frame, but a sense of the objective reality that makes Abraham's actions more admirable.

Abraham's first glimpse of the people is described in two sentences, both of which begin with the word **וַיַּרְא** ("saw"):

11 "The partial knowledge will temper the question 'what happens next?'" and replace it with the question 'how?'" (Polak 1999, 175).

12 Zipor 2005, 226.

13 This phrase appears in 2 Sam 4:5. The Septuagint there also translated "in the afternoon."

14 "With this short comment (only two words in Hebrew) the author evokes a complete picture. The old patriarch is resting in front of his tent on a typically hot day, when the landscape turns hazy and one's vision is blurred" (Speiser 1964, 129).

- Looking up, he suddenly saw three men standing near him.
- He saw them, and ran from the entrance of the tent to greet them and, and bowed to the ground.

The two verses provide the feeling of predictable continuity, mainly due to the integration of the word הִנֵּה (“suddenly”) in the first verse, and its omission in the second. Abraham, at first unexpectedly, saw three men standing “over him,” so he ran and greeted them. The repetition of the verb וִירָא (“to see”) in the second verse is unclear, since Abraham doesn’t see anything different. The repetition seems to indicate that in addition to the chronological continuity, the two sentences are meant to be compared, a comparison that serves to characterize Abraham.

The first sentence indicates that the arrival of guests was unexpected; in fact, Abraham did not see them coming until they were standing near him. The second sentence has Abraham running to greet his guests, meaning they could not have been very near as previously indicated. In other words, three strangers at a considerable distance arouse in Abraham the feeling of responsibility for their comfort and well-being.

The “entrance to the tent” is noted twice in the initial verses, and this location will be referenced later in the story as well. Verse 1 describes Abraham sitting “at the entrance of the tent,” while v. 2 has Abraham running “from the entrance of the tent.” The entrance motif is repeated in the following narrative regarding Lot in Sodom. The literary symbolism of the entryway is related to the transition and boundaries between inside and out.¹⁵ The entrance in Gen 18 is a defining motif, since Abraham brings outsiders into his home and as a result he is about to discover that the boundaries of his home will expand by means of a son. By inviting guests into his home, Abraham quite literally opens the door to divine blessing.

As previously mentioned, by revealing the angels’ identity, the narrator creates a gap between the reader and the protagonist. This gap is

15 See also Ex 33:7–11; Num 12:5; Deut 22:21; Judg 19:26–27. See also Bartelmus, פתח.

utilized for a clever wordplay at the outset of Abraham's conversation with his guests: "he said, **אֲדֹנָי**, if it pleases you, do not go on past your servant" (3). The word **אֲדֹנָי** can be interpreted in one of three ways. Depending on the placement of vowels, the word **אֲדֹנָי** can be read as plural (**אֲדֹנָיִם** – my lords) or as singular (**אֲדֹנָי** – my lord). Additionally, if the title is read in plural, it might simply refer to Abraham's guests (my lords), but it might also be a divine title – one of God's names (my Lord).

Some scholars read the title in the singular simply because of the context of the sentence, which continues to address the guests in singular form.¹⁶ Others preferred the Samaritan version that continues the sentence in plural.¹⁷

The debate regarding the term "*adonai*" ("my lords"), has been discussed throughout the generations of biblical exegesis.¹⁸ The term is used interchangeably as a divine and human title throughout the Abraham cycle.¹⁹ The debate is emphasized in modern translations of the verse: some translated "my lords" (e.g., NJPS; NAU; RSV) while others wrote "My Lord" (e.g., KJV; NKJ).²⁰

The confusion surrounding the expression reflects two different readings of the entire story: (1) Abraham knows he is experiencing

16 Speiser 1964, 128; Hertz (1952, 63) explains that Abraham is unaware of the identity of his guests at this stage; therefore there is no reason he would address them using a divine title. He explains that Abraham spoke to the greatest authority among the three. See also Wenham 1994, 33.

17 Davidson (1979, 62) translated: "'Sirs', he said, 'if I have deserved your favor.'"

18 For the Rabbinic debate, see b. Shavuot 35b; cf. b. Shabbat 127a. See also Genesis Rabbah Theodor-Albeck edition, p. 486, note on line 5. The punctuation indicates that according to the Masoretic text the word reflects the divine name. Onkelos translated accordingly ("He said, *God*, if it pleases you..."); Rashi noted this as a second possibility, as did Nahmanides and R. Joseph Bekhor Shor. R. Levi ben Gershon believed the term was secular.

19 E.g., 15:2 and 8; 18:27 and 31; 20:4, among many others, in reference to God; alternatively, 19:2 (from Lot's viewpoint!); 23:6, 11, 15; 24:18, and many others.

20 See also Skinner, who believed there are two possible readings based on interchangeable vowels: a. **אֲדֹנָי** (secular/singular) and b. **אֲדֹנָיִם** (secular, plural). He leaned toward the second possibility due to the parallel to 19:2, where Lot addresses the angels by calling them **אֲדֹנָיִם**.

divine revelation, and the title is in fact a divine name; or (2) Abraham assumes his guests are ordinary people, whom he addresses with respect and hospitality,²¹ and the title is devoid of divine connotations. Abraham's use of the address "Adonai" is a playful reflection of the disparity between Abraham and the reader; the reader may hear divine connotations, even though Abraham does not yet know of the guests' true identity.

This disparity is also expressed through the verb that describes the actions of the people-angels: "three men *standing* near him (נִצְבִּים עָלָיו)" (18:2). It has been noted that the verb is used elsewhere to describe a divine revelation.²² An interesting comparison in this context is Jacob's dream: "And the Lord was standing (נִצַּב עָלָיו) beside him" (28:11–13). Jacob also saw angels, and there too we find a physical description of the protagonist, who "lay down" before he saw God "standing." Similarly, in ch. 18 Abraham is described as "sitting" when he sees the visitors "standing over" him.²³ On the other hand, the verb is often used in other contexts, denoting human action (Gen 24:13; Ex 17:9; 18:14, among others).²⁴ Therefore, this verb reflects two different narrative levels of awareness: Abraham sees people standing over him, while the reader knows this is in fact a revelation, and can appreciate the divine connotations of the word.

Perhaps this disparity also explains the constant interchangeability of plural and singular throughout the text. Many noted this confusing style,²⁵ which begins as early as Abraham's discussion with his guests: "He said, 'My Lords, if it please you [בְּעֵינֶיךָ – singular], do not go on past your servant [עַבְדְּךָ – singular]. Let a little water be brought; bathe your feet [רַגְלֵיכֶם – plural] and recline under the tree. And let me fetch

21 Abraham's lack of knowledge regarding the true identity of his visitors makes his hospitality sincere and kind: "if he had known, his hospitality would not have been as impressive" (Kahana 1903, 55).

22 Hamilton 1995, 3–4.

23 See also 1 Sam 3:10; Amos 7:7; 9:1. Compare with the phrased נִצַּב בּ ("stand in") in Num 22:23; Ps 82:1; 119:89).

24 BDB, 662.

25 See Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 31–32, who notes that the confusion is continued in 19:18–19; however, the reason is easier to determine there than in ch. 18.

a morsel of bread that you may refresh yourselves [סַעְדוּ לַבָּנִים – plural]; then you shall pass [תַּעְבְּרוּ – plural], seeing that you have passed [עָבַרְתֶּם – plural] your servant's way.” They (plural) replied, “Do as you have said.”²⁶ This shifting continues throughout the narrative: the three men wash their feet, lean under the tree, eat, and ask Abraham about the whereabouts of his wife (9). The tidings are delivered in the singular: “Then he said, ‘I will return to you next year, and your wife Sarah shall have a son!’” (10). This oscillation between plural and singular has generally been explained as a result of redaction, or as a literary tool. Ball, Smend, Eissfeldt and Westermann, among others, favor the first explanation. They believe the text is a combination of two different source narratives, one describing the visit of three men (or divine visitors) to Abraham's tent, and the other relating a single angel (or God Himself announcing birth of a son).²⁷

In contrast, traditional exegesis generally favors reading the group of three visitors as a central figure accompanied by two attendants,

26 Instead of עָבַרְתֶּם עַל עַבְדְּכֶם (“you have come your servant's way”) the Septuagint reads: סֵרְתֶם אֶל עַבְדְּכֶם (“you have turned aside”); some preferred this version (Ball 1896, 68). I believe the intensive use of the verb עָבַר (“to pass:” “My Lords, if it please you, do not go on *past* your servant...then you shall *pass*, seeing that you have *passed* your servant's way”) is intentional, and emphasizes Abraham's perception of the situation, and the fortuitousness of his unexpected guests (cf. Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 54). Garsiel demonstrated that the word עָבַר (“Hebrew”) is used when the text indicates passing by chance (Garsiel 1991, 40). Perhaps the use of the verb hints to Abraham, who is called by this name elsewhere.

27 Ball 1896, 67; Smend 1912, 55–60; Eissfeldt 1962, 27–31; Westermann 1995, 278. Rudin-O'brasky (1981, 40–43) reviews the approach that views the story as one element that went through various stages of processing and editing. Some suggested that the confusion of singular and plural in the story is the result of the nucleus of the story, in which three gods came to bring Sarah tidings of a son (similar to the Birth of Orion by Ovid). Zakovitch wrote: “Clearly these were replaced by three people-angels in an attempt to eliminate the myth. In another stage of the process the three are replaced by God; this development is partial and deliberate” (Zakovitch 1981, 79). For the conversion of another myth that was originally related to volcanic phenomena in the Dead Sea area, see Kraetzschmar 1897. Ska claims that the story is read to the fullest effect when read in full sequence: Ska 1993; Ska 2008.

which is a common biblical convention (Abraham went to the binding of Isaac accompanied by two escorts, Balaam went to curse Israel accompanied by two men). In this case, Abraham would address the leader in the singular rather than speak to all three.²⁸ This idea is supported by the text: when a decision has to be made whether to go or stay in Abraham's tent, Abraham addresses the leader, whereas hospitality is extended in the plural form. The message is given to Abraham in the singular, indicating the dignitary's authority.

This reading is reflected in the position claiming that the leader of the three is God Himself.²⁹ The position relies predominantly on the caption of the story ("The Lord appeared to him"), but also on the fact that the narrator refers to one of the guests by God's name: "Then the Lord said to Abraham, 'Why did Sarah laugh, saying, 'Shall I in truth bear a child, old as I am?'" (18:13–14). Later on, Abraham argues over Sodom's fate with one of his guests, who is revealed as God. While the chief guest remains to debate with Abraham, the "two angels" continue to Sodom.³⁰ If God is indeed part of the delegation, addressing Him while ignoring the accompanying angels would be appropriate conduct.

This interpretation aside, however, the constant shift between plural and singular contributes to the purpose of the text by maintaining the double perspectives of Abraham and the reader. The singular reinforces the divine revelation: God, the main speaker, is present in

28 See Genesis Rabbah 48:3: "R. Hiyya said: He addressed the greatest among them, which was Michael."

29 This reading was accepted by the early church, and can be found in Justin Martyr's *Dialogue with Trypho*. See Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 35–36. Some scholars also accepted this interpretation, which clarifies why the debate regarding the future of Sodom was before God, while two angels went to see and destroy the city.

30 Von Rad rejected this position, since the inquiry regarding the whereabouts of Sarah in v. 9 was posed by all three; had God been one of the three, the verse would have been written in the singular. He suggested instead that all three be viewed as God's representatives (Von Rad 1963, 199–200). This approach was previously suggested by the Alexandrian school of the early church fathers. See Thunberg 1963. However, the suggestion is unreasonable considering that two of the three guests are later referred to as angels.

Abraham's tent, while the plural reflects Abraham's perception: three passers-by in need of assistance.

Abraham's "mistake" is, of course, not accidental; God Himself deceived Abraham by instructing his messengers to conceal their identity and the true purpose of their visit. In order to hide their identity convincingly, they appear to eat the food that Abraham had prepared and served.³¹ Abraham's lack of knowledge turns the story into a test. Since the reader knows the identity of the guests, the focus is shifted to Abraham's actions in light of the situation.

Preparing the Feast (6–8)

Abraham's haste to prepare the food involves two additional characters: Sarah, who is charged with baking the cakes, and the servant-boy, who is in charge of preparing the meat. Abraham motivates both characters: he hurries to Sarah and gives specific instructions; he chooses the calf himself and gives it to the servant. Sarah is issued three commands (no words are recorded between Abraham and the servant): "(1) Quick, (2) three seahs of choice flour! (3) Knead and make cakes!"

The bid for haste emphasizes Abraham's devotion to hospitality. Sarah is instructed to prepare a massive amount of flour: when Abigail prepared food for David and his men, she prepared five seah of roasted wheat (alongside 200 loaves of bread!) (1 Sam 25:18); the large channel Elijah digs around the Carmel altar was the size of "two seah of grain" (1 Kgs 18:32). Based on these examples, preparing cakes from three seah of flour would yield far more than the amount required to feed three or four people. This detail highlights Abraham's generosity, and Sarah's willingness to comply; moreover, Abraham instructs his wife to use "choice flour."

31 Hamilton 1995, 9, as opposed to other scholars who claimed the story was modified, and the image of God eating was replaced by eating angels (Eichrodt 1961, 144).

These details are clearly intended to serve Abraham's virtuous characterization. Further enthusiasm may be noted in his specification that Sarah "knead" the dough. Although this particular detail may further testify to the quality of the fare he bids her to prepare, the fact that Abraham gives her such specific instructions despite Sarah's presumable proficiency in her own kitchen shows that Abraham is clearly excited and seeks to be involved in every detail of the preparation of the feast, which is expressed through this unnecessary instruction.

Abraham's enthusiasm is also expressed in the preparation of the meat. Abraham "ran" to the herd,³² found a "tender and choice" calf, and handed it to the servant. In reality Abraham probably delivered a set of instructions to the servant as well; in Abraham's silence the reader can detect his haste and eagerness to return to his guests and offer them the finest of meals. The conclusion of v. 7 states "who hastened to prepare it." Who is the subject of this sentence? Presumably the servant, to whom Abraham had handed the calf; however, the omission of a direct reference creates the possibility that Abraham himself prepares the meat, since he is the only explicit subject of the sentence. Samuel David Luzzato interpreted "and hastened – Abraham did, by means of his command to the servant."³³ This vagueness is preserved in the following verse as well: "He took curds and milk *and the calf that he had prepared* and set these before them." Clearly the subject of this verse is Abraham, and the preparation of the meat is attributed to him. The ambiguity intends to express Abraham's concern and attention to all the details of the preparation of food for his guests.

Above all, Abraham's enthusiasm is expressed in the key phrase מָהָר ("haste").³⁴ The verb is mentioned three times, one for each of the

32 Anthony Abela notes a break in the wayyiqtol chain of Genesis 18 at verse 7a, which features an inverted word order (object, verb, subject), and claims that it expresses how Abraham ran out to his herd, which was kept at a distance from his living quarters. Thus, the phrase is best translated as, 'Even to the herds did Abraham go in all haste.' (Abela 2009).

33 Luzzato 1998, 165.

34 Jacob 1974, 441; Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 54–55.

people involved in the preparation of the meal: Abraham (“Abraham hastened into the tent”), Sarah (“Quick, three seahs of choice flour!”), and the servant (“who hastened to prepare it”). This verb is supported by an additional verb indicating haste: “he *ran* from the entrance of the tent” (2), and “Then Abraham *ran* to the herd” (7). Abraham’s haste is also reflected in the omitted descriptions, there is no time for description, for the guests are waiting! In Abraham’s instructions to Sarah, for example, “Quick, three seahs of choice flour,” he clearly means “[take] three seahs of choice flour,” but the omitted word indicates Abraham’s haste.

Ninety-nine-year-old Abraham, sitting at the entrance to his tent in the heat of the day, rushes to host three unknown and unexpected guests. Abraham’s efforts are fully supported by the people of his house. Sarah and the servant do not hesitate to join Abraham in his rush to supply his guests with the very best.

Abraham’s unique efforts and the narrator’s positive review of his actions are emphasized in the final verse describing Abraham’s hospitality: “He took curds and milk and the calf that he had prepared and set these before them; and he waited on them under the tree as they ate” (8). The narrator does not omit elegant touches, milk and butter, which upgrade the basic meal of bread and meat (the bread Abraham initially offers is also upgraded to cakes). Despite the presence of a servant-boy in v. 6, Abraham does not sit and dine with his guests, but insists on serving them himself. The contrast between Abraham’s offer and his actions reveals the extent of his hospitality:

| <i>Abraham’s Offer (4–5)</i> | <i>Abraham’s Hospitality (6–8)</i> |
|--|---|
| Let a little water be brought; bathe your feet | |
| and recline under the tree | and he waited on them under the tree as they ate. |

| | |
|--|---|
| And let me fetch a morsel of bread that you may refresh yourselves | Abraham hastened into the tent to Sarah, and said, "Quick, three seahs of choice flour! Knead and make cakes!" Then Abraham ran to the herd, took a calf, tender and choice, and gave it to a servant-boy, who hastened to prepare it. He took curds and milk and the calf that had been prepared and set these before them |
|--|---|

The rabbinic Sages commented on this comparison: "The righteous say little and do much."³⁵ The narrator reports Abraham's actions by using many verbs in quick succession.³⁶ Perhaps the attempt to portray haste is the reason for the omission of certain details, such as offering water and washing feet.³⁷ Biblical "ellipsis" indicates occurrences while omitting explicit details. Here, omission of the guests' washing quickens the pace toward the more significant preparation of food.

While Abraham offered his guests rest ("recline under the tree"), in practice "he waited on them under the tree as they ate." While the story began with the visitors "standing" over Abraham, now he "stood" over them, to serve them. Abraham's diligence and generosity is expressed through the difference between his initial modest offer and the feast he serves them, which included cakes (instead of bread), a tender calf, curds, and milk. Each dish's preparation is described with the word ויקח ("and he took") in parallel to his initial offer to "fetch" (ואקחה) a morsel of bread.

The narrative design emphasizes Abraham's virtue as the reader eagerly awaits Abraham's discovery of his guests' true identity.

35 Numbers Rabbah 20, among others.

36 Regarding the purpose of this literary style, see Bar-Efrat 1989, 203–06.

37 Malul asserted that "washing feet" indicated a concubine, and Abraham was offering his guests a woman as well (Malul 2004). Although in other texts washing feet is sometimes a euphemism for sexual relations, there is no indication that this is so in the current text.

Tidings of Isaac's Birth (9–15)

The essential difficulty regarding ch. 18 pertains to the relationship between the first part of the scene, which depicts Abraham's hospitality, and the second part announcing Isaac's birth. This debate is related to a more fundamental issue: as mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, ch. 18 seems to repeat the message given to Abraham in ch. 17. Abraham has already been informed that Sarah will give birth; like Sarah, he laughed at the very idea. A careful comparison of the two tidings has the power to clarify this repetition.

1. The Message's Recipient

Both messages pertain to the couple, but one is addressed to Abraham, and the other focuses upon Sarah. In the Covenant of Circumcision God appears to Abraham: "I will bless her; indeed, *I will give you* a son by her" (17:16); Sarah will be blessed but she will birth *Abraham's* son. This is consistent throughout the chapter: "God said, 'Nevertheless, Sarah your wife *shall bear you* a son'" (17:19); and finally, "But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear *to you* at this season next year" (17:21).³⁸ In contrast, the visitors' message is directed towards Sarah. Although they do not address Sarah directly (probably due to etiquette), they ask about her whereabouts before they begin to speak (9). This emphasizes that she is their addressee, as the message itself repeatedly clarifies: "Then he said, 'I will return to you next year, and *your wife Sarah* shall have a son!'" (18:10);³⁹ "I will return to you at the time next year, and Sarah shall have a son" (18:14).

38 It is broadly accepted that this style ("bear to you") is characteristic for P, and contains no special significance. Cassuto altogether rejected the linguistic differences used to distinguish the sources according to the documentary hypothesis (Cassuto 1952, 80–131; Cassuto 1989, 80–131); additionally, the style emphasizes the husband over the wife, a design that carries significance and invites literary analysis.

39 Based on the comparison of the two chapters, von Rad incorrectly stated that Sarah was the protagonist of ch. 17 (von Rad 1963, 197). Although Sarah is paralleled with Abraham in ch. 17, and is portrayed as his partner, the emphasis

2. Who Laughed?

In like with the previous distinction, the addressee of each message is the one to react with laughter. Abraham laughs after receiving tidings of Isaac's birth during the Covenant of Circumcision, and in ch. 18, Sarah reacts the same way.⁴⁰

3. Content

The messages also differ significantly in content. In both narratives the elderly couple is told that they will bear a son, but the function and purpose the child will serve is dramatically different in each of the stories. The angels emphasize the birth itself; not a word is mentioned about the child's unique destiny or historical significance – the purpose of the child is to bring joy to his elderly parents, who have waited for so long to hold a child in their arms. In contrast, the Covenant of Circumcision defines Isaac's role as the guardian of the covenant.⁴¹ Abraham's future son is entrusted with a national-historical mission: "you shall name him Isaac; and I will maintain My covenant with him as an everlasting covenant for his offspring to come... My covenant I will maintain with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear to you at this season next year" (17:19–21).

4. The Child's Name

In the Covenant of Circumcision, Abraham's son is named, while the guests do not discuss the name of the child. Sarah's laughter and the ensuing dialogue allude to Isaac's name, but it is not mentioned explicitly. The absence of the name is surprising, as birth tidings often

of the chapter is on Abraham, as opposed to ch. 18. Regarding Sarah as the main character with regard to the tidings of the birth of Isaac, see Westermann (1985, 279), who believed that in the nuclear story the message was delivered directly to Sarah.

40 God's reaction to the laughter in the two narratives should also be compared. Sarah's laughter is questioned, while Abraham's laughter is not, although I believe Abraham's laughter in the Covenant of Circumcision is not taken lightly. However, as already mentioned, the fact that Isaac's name commemorates this laughter shows that Abraham's reaction is not openly criticized.

41 Cf. McEvenue (1971, 154), who believes ch. 17 relies on ch. 18.

include this component (see the tidings to Hagar in 16:11, as well as 1 Kgs 13:2; Is 7:14–16; 1 Chr 22:9–10).⁴²

5. Divine Names

In the Covenant of Circumcision, with the exception of the introduction as El Shaddai, God is referred to as Elohim, while ch. 18 uses YHWH throughout the narrative.

6. The Nature of the Revelation

The Covenant of Circumcision is a prophetic revelation: Elohim reveals Himself to Abraham, who “threw himself on his face.” In the angel narrative God meets with Abraham in his tent and appears to him in anthropomorphic form. Instead of a formidable prophetic revelation, the atmosphere is intimate and personal.

These differences reveal the purpose of each tiding and its contribution to the Abraham cycle.

Two plot threads are apparent throughout the Abraham cycle, at times separate, at others intertwined. The first is the “covenant thread”: the national-historical story behind the establishment of the nation. The second is the “personal thread,” the story of Abraham and Sarah’s private life. While both threads have theological significance, the covenant thread is naturally ideological-theological, clarifying God’s plan to establish a nation, while the personal thread describes the couple’s everyday lives and challenges. These scenes do not reveal any divine “master-plan” as much as natural human action leading to God’s response. The couple’s infertility has great bearing on each thread: a son and heir is necessary to maintain the covenant, establish a nation, and realize God’s promises to Abraham; on another plane, Abraham and Sarah’s natural desire for a child is independent from the historical ideology that they are expected to promote. Like any other couple, Sarah and Abraham yearn to raise a child of their own.

The two juxtaposed and consecutive tidings demonstrate two aspects of the message of Isaac’s birth. The son promised to Abraham

42 Noted by Alexander (1982, 202–03). The problem led Van Seters to read the birth and naming of Isaac as a direct continuation of the angels’ tidings in ch. 18 (Van Seters 1975, 203 and 209–21).

in the Covenant of Circumcision will be the successor of his covenant with God: "But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac" (17:21). The child is named in the message because his destiny awaits him even before his conception. In contrast, the divine messengers bring tidings irrespective of the child's destiny, so the child is not named; rather, the promise focuses upon the fulfilment of Abraham and Sarah's personal longing for a child. *They* are the focus of the blessing; they deserve a child because they are good and decent people, champions of the values of charity and justice, regardless of the covenant between them and God.

This distinction clarifies other literary components that characterize the narrative as separate episodes. Both Abraham and Sarah live their lives on both planes: both are significant with regard to the covenant, and both have their own hopes, dreams and ambitions. When the covenant is emphasized, however, Abraham is the protagonist, and the story revolves around him. Abraham is the focus of these national-historical narratives because he was the one elected to establish God's nation, while Sarah joined the journey as his wife. Therefore, in the Covenant of Circumcision *Abraham* is given a son; the son is a continuation of Abraham's choices and values. But Sarah is the focus of the personal episode. In this sense, Nahmanides and Zakovitch's distinction between the recipients of the blessing encapsulates the essence of the double narratives and their tidings, which reflect the national and personal planes of Abraham's narrative cycle.

The atmosphere of each tiding is consistent with this difference. In the Covenant of Circumcision Abraham is rendered unconscious by God's revelation. Abraham's state emphasizes the hierarchy and disparity between God and man. In contrast, the divine visitors appear to Abraham and Sarah in their home, in human form, to bring personal tidings that their heartbreaking barrenness is shortly to end.

The interchangeable names for God should also be viewed in this context. As noted in the introduction, this is a complex matter, and while the documentary hypothesis relies upon these changes to determine the source of the text, the names of God also function as a

literary tool. Cassuto,⁴³ among others, discussed whether the use of the name Elohim in ch. 17 contributes to the nature and purpose of the narrative, and whether the use of YHWH contributes to the purpose of ch. 18. Elohim is essentially a general name that expresses divine power, while YHWH is used as God's private name, which differentiates Him from hundreds of gods that were worshipped in the ancient world. Throughout the Abraham cycle, the name YHWH is used in narratives with an intimate setting: stories of a personal encounter with God. YHWH is the appropriate name for Sarah's story, where God responds to the kindness of His creations, whereas the name Elohim sets the appropriate tone for the obligations and commitments of making a covenant with God in the Covenant of Circumcision.

This difference is also reflected in the reason for the birth of a child in each episode. In ch. 17 Abraham is given a son to maintain his covenant with God. Isaac is not born as a result of Abraham's virtue, but as part of God's historical design.⁴⁴ The personal story of ch. 18 is deeply rooted not in divine but human actions. In this episode, God is not portrayed as an initiator, but as one who reacts to human initiatives. What, then, is the reason for giving Abraham and Sarah a son in this chapter?

The answer lies in how the divine messengers are received with Abraham and Sarah's great hospitality. The purpose of the divine messengers' visit seems to be the discussion with Abraham regarding the destruction of Sodom (18:17), not to deliver tidings of a birth that was already revealed to Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision. However, when the visitors arrived at Abraham's tent, they were received

43 Cassuto 1952, 19–38; Cassuto 1989, 18–52.

44 Compare with Polak: "Humility in view of divine sovereignty is also the point of the tale about the revelation of divine identity to Abram and the circumcision command (Genesis 17). This narrative is characterized by the use of three different names... The use of the personal name fits the idea of divine-human communication. However, when Abraham reacts to the divine call, the narrator prefers the appellation: 'Abram threw himself on his face; and God spoke to him further' (17.3). Thus the narrative presents Abraham's point of view as a devoted servant who loyally accepts the commands of his overlord." (Polak 2012, 171–72).

with such gracious human initiative that Abraham was rewarded with additional blessing.⁴⁵ This blessing, indeed, almost seems to be offered as a host-gift.⁴⁶ In ch. 18 Abraham and Sarah are granted a son as a reward for their good deeds, not as part of a divine plan to maintain the covenant with Abraham's offspring.

The "tent" in the narrative links where Sarah prepares food for her guests ("Abraham hastened into the tent to Sarah") with her position when she hears the tidings of a son ("Where is your wife Sarah?" And he replied, "There, in the tent"), hinting that she is granted blessing "in the tent" because of her activity "in the tent." The tent is certainly an appropriate location for the news of expansion of the family. In this chapter, Abraham and Sarah are rewarded on the principle of "measure for measure": they nurture their guests, and are rewarded with a child to nurture;⁴⁷ they open their home to others, expanding their household from without, and are rewarded with a household expanding from within.⁴⁸

This reading is supported by the linking of the two motifs of hospitality and the blessing of fertility in biblical narratives and other stories from the ancient Near East.⁴⁹ There is a striking similarity

45 Regardless of whether this is a normal procedure that reflects the life of wanderers (Shapira 1996, 54) or a historical deviation, Abraham's character is portrayed nobly. Even if he acts in accordance with the customs of the time, he is praiseworthy.

46 See Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 63–64; Grossman 1997.

47 Eichrodt 1961, 144.

48 This reading was previously suggested by Clement (1925, 24–25). Rudin-O'brasky (1981, 74) also noted the link between the hospitality motif and the message of fertility; however, she believes the link is missing in our narrative since Abraham was previously promised a son as part of his destiny, so the son cannot be portrayed as a reward for Abraham's hospitality. Even if the link between hospitality and the promise of fertility is not overt, it is certainly implied in the text, and reinforced by the reappearance of the two threads in additional duplicate stories in the cycle.

49 Regarding the connection between Gen 18 and the Birth of Orion by Ovid (which reinforces the perception of the birth of a son as a reward for hospitality), see Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 72–73. Concerning the story of Aqhat and its analogies to our narrative, see: Avishur 1986.

between Sarah's story and the episode of Elisha and the woman from Shunem (2 Kgs 4:13).⁵⁰ After a woman from Shunem takes great pains to make Elisha comfortable in her home, the prophet promises that she and her elderly husband would be granted a son, alluding directly to Gen 18: "At this season next year, you will be embracing a son." Just as Sarah laughed in disbelief at the prospect of bearing a child, the woman responded: "please my lord, man of God, do not delude your maidservant" (2 Kgs 4:16).

Many have noted that the analogy between the two narratives criticizes Elisha, who oversteps his authority by promising the barren woman a child.⁵¹ Regardless, the narrative clearly links the concept of fertility as a reward for hospitality to strangers; in this respect, the Elisha story relies on the model presented in the Abraham story. In the Elisha narrative, the woman from Shunem is granted a son as a reward for her hospitality, just as Sarah and Abraham are granted a son for welcoming strangers into their home.

The two narratives foretelling the birth of Isaac (ch. 17–18) indicate that he is to be born twice: once in the name of Elohim, as the heir of Abraham, and the maintainer of God's covenant; and once in the name of YHWH, as Sarah's pride and joy. The birth of Isaac relates to both aspects (21:1–6):

YHWH took note of *Sarah* as He had promised,
and YHWH did for *Sarah* as He had spoken.
Sarah conceived and bore a son *to Abraham* in his old age
at the set time of which *Elohim* had spoken.

50 Regarding the analogy between Gen 18 and Elisha's interaction with the woman from Shunem, see Bronner 1968, 86–99; Rudin-O'brasky 1981, 66–72; Kiel 1988, 498 (who differentiated between an angel and a prophet); Sabato 1992; Simon 1996, 279–316; Amit 2001.

51 Sabato 1992, 48; Simon 1996, 301; Amit 2001, 7; Markus 2010, 33; 279–316. Skinner claimed that although the phrase כעת הִיא ("next year") is incompatible with the narrative in Kings, the author is influenced by Gen 18 (Skinner 1930, 301). Bergen demonstrated that there is implicit criticism of the prophet in the birth process, where the words "next year" compare Elisha with the angels in Gen 18, indicating that he is out of place predicting a birth (Bergen 1999, 98–99).

Abraham gave his newborn son, whom *Sarah* had borne him,
the name of Isaac.

And when his son Isaac was eight days old, *Abraham* circumcised him, as Elohim
had commanded him...

Sarah said, "Elohim has brought me laughter."

YHWH fulfilled His promise to Sarah. Hamilton, among others, interpreted פקד ("took note of") to mean "visited," in correlation with the words of the divine guest: "I will return to you next year."⁵² He views ch. 21 as a direct extension of Abraham's hospitality, and a direct fulfillment of the tidings delivered on that occasion. The focus on Sarah in this verse correlates with the message intended for Sarah, in the name of YHWH. The next verse conveys the second perspective of Isaac's birth. God is called Elohim, since this second aspect is a fulfillment of *His* promise to Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision. These verses focus on Abraham, and occur "at the set time" that Elohim had stated on that occasion. Isaac's naming and circumcision, and finally, Abraham's age, all correspond to the Covenant of Circumcision, while Isaac is said to bring the joy and comfort to Sarah that she had not dared to wish for.

Isaac is a different son to each of his parents; or, he is the son of Abraham and Sarah, and also the son of Sarah and Abraham. He is the joy of an old and childless couple, and he is the heir to the forefather of a new nation, the keeper of Abraham's covenant with God. Similarly, God plays two roles: in the Covenant of Circumcision He establishes a nation, while in the hospitality narrative He displays divine morality, and rewards kindness to strangers with the expansion of the home and the comfort of a son.

52 Hamilton 1995, 12.

Sarah's Laughter

The episode ends with Sarah's laughter at the news of her child's impending birth and a surprising exchange between Sarah and God. The angel informs Abraham: "I will return to you next year, and your wife Sarah shall have a son!" (10), which elicits disbelief: "Sarah laughed to herself, saying, 'Now that I am withered, am I to have enjoyment – with my husband so old?'" (12). The narrator interrupts the sequence of the message and response to provide the two following details: "Sarah was listening at the entrance of the tent, which was behind him" (10); and "Now Abraham and Sarah were old, advanced in years; Sarah had stopped having the periods of women" (11).

The first detail explains how Sarah was able to hear the divine messenger's words to Abraham even though she was in the tent: the divine messenger could not see Sarah since the tent was behind him, but Sarah, who stood at the entrance to the tent, was able to overhear the conversation. The second intriguing detail seems to legitimize Sarah's reaction. The narrator reminds the reader that Sarah and Abraham were exceedingly old; in addition, Sarah was no longer menstruating, so it was physically impossible for her to bear a child. Sarah's laughter relates directly to this detail, since she says, "Now that I am withered, am I to have enjoyment" (paralleling "Sarah had stopped having the periods of women") and "my husband so old" (paralleling "Abraham and Sarah were old"). The biblical narrator tends to avoid making an appearance in a live dialogue ("telling" instead of "showing"),⁵³ and such infrequent occasions usually contribute to the analysis of the speaker. This case is particularly unusual, as a "disagreement" is created between God and the narrator,⁵⁴ as the narrator justifies Sarah's reaction while God criticizes Sarah for laughing. This complexity creates a delicate and balanced critique of Sarah's reaction: while Sarah's laughter is inappropriate, it is also understandable. The

53 Regarding these characteristics, see Booth 1961, 3–20; Wiesenfarth 1963; Stanzel 1979, 190–92; Genette 1980, 162–89; Rabinowitz 2005, 530.

54 See more on shifting perspectives in: Sternberg 1985, 153–59.

narrator interrupts yet again when Sarah denies her laughter: “Sarah lied, saying, ‘I did not laugh,’ *for she was frightened*” (15). This interruption also minimizes the disapproval of Sarah, who only lies because she is nervous (and perhaps only laughs nervously as well, and not for lack of faith). This sublimation indicates the nature of Sarah’s laughter, as Otto Procksch wrote: “The contrast between the little woman who was reduced to hiding out of fear, and attempts to lie, and the sudden, hostile interruption – “no!” – by God, is an impactful and severe conclusion to the scene.”⁵⁵

There is a jarring contrast between the depiction of Sarah’s actions and the unequivocal and harsh reprimand she receives. The dramatic ending – “you did laugh!” – continues to resonate after the story is over. Nonetheless, Procksch’s analysis does not reflect the atmosphere of the narrative: the narrator preempted Sarah’s reaction and designed a reading consciousness that justifies her laughter. Sarah does not know the speaker is a divine messenger; therefore there is no reason to portray her hesitation as a lack of belief in God. Sarah probably interprets the conversation as a polite blessing by strangers who are utterly unaware of her situation. Her laughter expresses her pessimism in light of repeated disappointment. Her lack of belief in herself and her future are the setting for God’s intervention. The words “Is anything too wondrous for the Lord?” teach Sarah that she must not give up hope, even in the face of nature and logic. The test of Sarah’s faith is similar to Søren Kierkegaard’s perception of faith: she is expected to continue believing during the very darkest of hours, when the option of childbearing seems impossible.

Perhaps this is the result of the gap between what Sarah says to herself: “Now that I am withered, am I to have enjoyment – with my husband so old?” (18:12), and how God repeats her words. Sarah mentions her own age as well as Abraham’s while God omits her description of Abraham: “Why did Sarah laugh, saying, ‘Shall I in truth bear a child, old as I am?’” (18:13). While traditional exegesis derive from

55 Procksch 1913, 120.

this verse that one is permitted to lie in order to keep the peace,⁵⁶ perhaps the change serves to focus Sarah's laughter on herself, rather than upon her husband. Sarah's challenge was to believe that she, and not only others, could be the receptacle of God's blessing.

The element of laughter, which features in both narratives, is given much weight in the episode, which concludes with this word. Westermann and Hamilton might be correct that the insistence that Sarah laughed indicates that Sarah's laughter has additional significance (and that her son's name is implied in this action).⁵⁷ Why is this laughter so significant?⁵⁸

Sarah's disbelief contributes to the unique and miraculous atmosphere surrounding the birth of her son, which culminates in the statement "is anything too wondrous for the Lord?"⁵⁹ Had the characters in the story taken the tidings at face value, the reader might have believed their age is not a factor, perhaps due to their era. The laughter – and the process of denial and reaffirmation – indicates that something truly wondrous, which defies the laws of nature, is about to happen. The couple has given up on their ability to conceive – the very idea of conception is utterly preposterous – when God offers them a surreal blessing. This clarifies that the impending birth is not natural, but miraculous – so miraculous that both characters are moved to laughter. Laughter helps Abraham and Sarah internalize the illogical reality

56 Genesis Rabbah 48:18 (Theodor-Albeck edition, 494–95). The midrash indicates that God lied when He repeated Sarah's words, when in fact He only spoke a partial truth.

57 Westermann 1995, 282; Hamilton 1995, 14 (see also Zakovitch 2005, 134, who discussed Isaac's name, which represents both delighted laughter and laughter of disbelief).

58 Warner proposed that Isaac is taken from Sarah as a punishment for her laughter (Warner 2012). According to this reading, it is clear why this laughter is so important prior to Abraham's debate about the fate of Sodom (which, Warner argued, conceals a debate about the future of his own son) as it explains the reason for the Binding of Isaac).

59 Compare with: Ska 1993. The term פֶּלֶה (*peleh* – literally, "wonder") is used in other biblical texts, connoting supernatural divine intervention (e.g., Ex 3:20). See Kruger, פֶּלֶה.

born of God's intervention. Their openness will allow the impossible into their home.⁶⁰

Now we can better understand the ambivalence between the narrator's sympathy for Sarah's laughter, and God's criticism of her reaction. Sarah is not like Michal daughter of Saul, who mocks David as he dances before God's ark; Michal's mocking laughter was punished with childlessness, while Sarah's laughter leads to the conception of a child. The episode ends with the statement "you did laugh," because laughter is what opens Sarah's heart and womb.⁶¹

60 This approach was expressed in a poem by Alexander Pushkin, in *Eugene Onegin* (translated by Babette Deutsch, Baltimore: Penguin Books, 1964):

Indeed, thrice blessed / Is he who can believe a fiction,
Who, lulling reason, comes to rest / In the soft luxury of feeling,
Like a poor sot to shelter reeling / Or (since its ugly to be drunk) / An incest
in a flower sunk;

But wretched is the man who never / Can be surprised, whose view is dim /
Of word or gesture strange to him, / Who cannot feel: he is too clever,
Whose heart experience has chilled, / Whose raptures are forever stilled.

61 Recent studies have shown a physiological connection between laughter and conception. See Friedler 2011.

Chapter 10: The Debate over Sodom's Destruction (18:16–33)

One of the complex issues of this episode relates to the boundaries of the text. Can the discussion about the destruction of Sodom (18:16–33) be separated from the divine visit to Abraham (18:1–15)? The difficulty is particularly apparent in v. 16, which closes one unit and opens the next, thereby linking the two: “The men set out from there and looked down toward Sodom, Abraham walking with them to see them off.” Most scholars saw the verse as an introduction to the Sodom narrative,¹ while some regarded it as the conclusion of the previous story.² Others suggested a division of the verse, so the first part can conclude the previous narrative and the second can serve as an introduction to the next.³

The verse “disbands characters” from the previous scene, thereby concluding the divine visit with Abraham.⁴ Additionally, the phrasing of the verse relies on the previous verse: “the men set out *from there*.” The location “there” can only be understood in relation to the previous episode. The description of Abraham, who accompanies them to “see them off,” is a direct continuation of his role as a host. However, the verse also has the angels looking toward Sodom, clearly introducing a new chapter; the angels go to Sodom for the purpose of

1 E.g., Skinner 1930, 303; Speiser 1964, 132; Coats 1983, 139 (he emphasizes the profound connection between the two units); Wenham 1994, 40 (he provided one general caption for chs. 18–19: “The Overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah,” which he viewed as one story); Hamilton 1995, 14.

2 Von Rad 1963, 203. Von Rad was aware that v. 16 prepares the ground for the following unit; however, he chose to view the verse as the conclusion of the hosting narrative – “any reader feels v. 16 is, to some extent, a conclusion.” This was also surmised by Avishur, as is evident from the title of his article (Avishur 1986).

3 Westermann 1995, 273, 282.

4 E.g., Frish 1986, 18; Bar-Efrat 1989, 130–32.

evaluating the city, to determine whether it should be destroyed. One of the “visitors,” in fact, stays behind to discuss that very matter with Abraham. The conclusion of the hosting scene is unique, as Walsh argues, because the characters do not “disband” as usual, each departing in a different direction; rather, Abraham and the angels continue on their way together.⁵ There is therefore no justification for separating the stories from each other; the two episodes must be viewed as part of the same story.

The nature and purpose of the link between the two parts of the story therefore requires analysis. Many scholars have noted the literary connections between Abraham in ch. 18 and Lot in ch. 19, adding a third and final chapter to the story, which is now seen to have three episodes: the divine visit to Abraham and Sarah and tidings of the birth of Isaac; the debate about the destruction of Sodom; the angels’ visit to Lot and the destruction of Sodom. Perhaps the narrative about Lot’s daughters in the cave could also be included – this option will be discussed in the conclusion and analysis of the complete narrative.

Despite the link between Abraham’s visit and the Sodom narrative, there is reason to view the latter as an independent unit that should be read separately from the angels’ visit. The story forms an *inclusio*, opening in 18:16: “The men set out from there and *looked down* toward Sodom (וַיִּשְׁקֹפוּ עַל פְּנֵי סֹדֶם), Abraham walking with them to see them off,” and ending in 19:27–28: “Next morning, Abraham hurried to the place where he had stood before the Lord, and, *looking down* toward Sodom (וַיִּשְׁקֹף עַל פְּנֵי סֹדֶם) and Gomorrah and all the land of the Plain, he saw the smoke of the land rising like the smoke of a kiln.”⁶ In addition to the phrase “looking down,” which is repeated in both verses, the content indicates the beginning and end of an episode: initially the angels look down at Sodom with Abraham at their side, and the story ends with Abraham looking down at the very same place. The vantage point is the same in both verses (“the place where he had stood before

5 Walsh 2001, 133.

6 E.g., Wenham 1994, 41, 49; Mathews 2005, 221. The unique significance of v. 29 (which provides an outsider’s look on the narrative) will be discussed in due course.

the Lord”); thus the *inclusio* has the protagonist return to the original location of debate to view the conclusion of the narrative.

Wenham suggested an elaborate concentric structure that unites the Sodom narrative in one closed unit, which is separate from the story of Abraham’s hospitality and Sarah’s tidings. The plot materials separate God’s discussion with Abraham on the destruction of Sodom (18:16–33) from the angels’ survey of Sodom (19:1–29). This separation is reinforced by Abraham’s movement: initially he walks with the angels and sees them off (18:16), and after his discussion with God Abraham “returned to his place.”⁷ According to Wenham’s suggestion the story is divided elsewhere:⁸

- a. Abraham’s guests look down on Sodom (18:16)
- b. God plans to destroy Sodom (18:17–21)
- c. Abraham attempts to save Sodom from destruction (18:22–33)
- d. The angels arrive in Sodom and Lot beseeches them to stay with him (19:1–3)
 - e. Lot fails to convince the people of Sodom (19:4–11)
 - f. The angels announce the fate of the city (19:12–13)
 - e1. Lot fails to convince his sons-in-law (19:14)
 - d1. Lot and his family leave the city after the angels beseech them (19:15–16)
 - c1. Lot attempts to save Zoar (19:23–26)
 - b1. The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah (19:23–26)
- a1. Abraham looks down at Sodom (19:27–28)
- Conclusion (19:29)

Caution must be used when naming subunits in a story for the purpose of paralleling a larger text.⁹ However, in addition to the captions listed above, there are literary-linguistic links that reinforce Wenham’s structure. For example, in subunit C God says: “I will forgive the whole place for their sake” (18:26), to which Abraham responds: “Here I venture to speak to my Lord, I who am but dust and ashes”

7 Mathews 2005, 221.

8 Wenham 1994, 41 noted the changing location of the plot, which begins and ends in Mamre, but focuses on Lot’s home in the central axis. The captions below are my formulation.

9 As appropriately noted by Dorsey 1999, 33–34.

(18:27). In the parallel subunit C₁ Lot asks: “Oh no, my lord! You have been so gracious to your servant, and have already shown me so much kindness in order to save my life; but I cannot flee to the hills, lest the disaster overtake me and I die” (19:18–19), and the angels respond: “I will grant you this favor too, and I will not annihilate the town” (19:21).

The suggested structure raises various informative points; first and foremost, it highlights the turning point of the story. As mentioned above, the obvious division parallels ch. 18 with ch. 19; however, according to this creative structure, the angels’ revelation to Lot regarding the destruction of the city is the turning point of the narrative. The fate of the city remains undetermined until this point; the words of the angels are therefore not only revolutionary for Lot, who suddenly realizes the identity of his guests and the purpose of their visit, but also for the city, whose fate is finally sealed.

The structure indicates several other interesting links. Abraham unsuccessfully attempted to save the city (C), while Lot makes a great impression on the angels and succeeds in saving Zoar (C₁). Lot’s preference over Abraham might seem surprising; however, Abraham’s discussion with God was conducted on the legal plane, and relates to the legal status of the city (righteous or evil), while Lot pleads to the angel for mercy on the personal plane, out of fear for his life.¹⁰ Lot prefaces his request: “You have been so gracious to your servant, and have already shown me so much kindness in order to save my life” (19:19), a formulation lacking in the discussion between Abraham and God. Lot asks for an additional favor, based on the previous kind treatment awarded him, while Abraham asks in the name of justice. The different setting allows Lot to achieve in his request of the angels what Abraham could not in his discussion with God.¹¹

10 Cf. MacDonald 2004, who wrote that Abraham was disturbed by divine justice, while God sought to teach him that divine mercy also exists in the context of “the ways of God.” Bolin (2004) believes the integration of divine grace into divine justice is revealed in the saving of Lot.

11 At the end of the story the reader learns that Lot’s favor is in fact in merit of Abraham (v. 29); however, there is also another portrayal that relates to Lot’s actions, which will be discussed below.

The link between the arrival of the angels in Sodom (D) and Lot leaving the city (D₁) sheds light on the reason Lot is saved. Lot invited strangers into his home and protects them; they reward him by taking him out of his home when it is destroyed, and protecting him when his life is endangered. The design of the text supports the reading that views Lot's rescue in light of his good deeds. In contrast with this positive impression of Lot, twice Lot deals with groups associated with the city – townspeople and his sons-in-law – and fails to convince them to do as he pleases (E-E₁). Had the townspeople or his sons-in-law listened to his advice, they could have been saved. These two scenes portray Lot as a lifeline for the doomed, who choose to turn their backs on Lot. The evaluation of the townspeople is clear, but their refusal might also reflect on Lot, as we will discuss below.

The significance of the suggested literary structure will become apparent in the analysis of ch. 19. It is noteworthy that according to this structure Abraham's story is separate from the Sodom narrative, but maintains certain literary links. This ambivalence relates to the reason behind the angels' visit to Abraham, and the unexpected developments in that plot, which clarify the reason Abraham became involved in the decision to destroy Sodom. Between the description of Abraham seeing off his guests (16) and God's discussion with Abraham (20), a window is opened into God's thought process (18:17–19):

“Now the Lord had said: Shall I hide from Abraham what I am doing?¹² Abraham is to become a great and populous nation, and all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him; For I have singled him out, that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is charitable and just,¹³ in order that the Lord may bring about for Abraham what He has promised him.”

These unusual verses provide a glimpse into God's thoughts, which indicate the reason behind His choice of Abraham. Scholars found the verses disruptive to the narrative sequence, and often attributed

12 NJPS translated “what I am about to do.”

13 NJPS translated: “just and right.”

them to a later addition to the original story.¹⁴ However, the sense of disruption is not justified, and neither is the historical conclusion some wished to derive.¹⁵ The verses explain why God shared His plan to destroy Sodom with Abraham; they absolutely belong here, before the dialogue with Abraham, which they serve to explain.

There is added value in the placement of the verses at this point – between the tidings of the son and the argument about the destruction of Sodom. God’s words are usually depicted as an introduction to the following dialogue between God and Abraham. But as Hamilton noted, God’s vague statement “Shall I hide from Abraham what *I am doing*” (not “what I will do to Sodom”) enables a broader reading.¹⁶ The next verse focuses on Abraham’s destiny and blessings: (“Abraham is to become a great and populous nation, and all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him”); at this point the link to Sodom is still weak.¹⁷ Therefore, in addition to the justification for involving Abraham in the discussion about Sodom, God’s thoughts also justify the tidings of a son, and the fact that Abraham will become a great nation, instead of hiding His future plans for Abraham. The rhetorical question (“shall I hide...”) relates both to the future discussion of Sodom and to the previous discussion about Abraham’s son.

This analysis sheds new light on the original purpose of the angels’ visit to Abraham’s tent. God and His delegation came to Abraham to discuss the destruction of Sodom. When the delegation arrived, Abraham’s warm hospitality was so extraordinary that it warranted a reaction; the discussion of Sodom was therefore delayed until after his

14 E.g., Skinner 1930, 303. This approach is expressed severely by Mackenzie, who omitted vs. 17–19 from his discussion (Mackenzie 1955, 159, note 7). Academic positions on these verses are diverse; some separated between vs. 17–18 and v. 19; others noted that v. 17 implies that God had already made up His mind, while in v. 21 He seems to be indecisive. See, among others, Schmidt 1976, 131–64; Gunkel 1997, 201–02; von Rad 1963, 204).

15 Lapointe 1970, 177.

16 Hamilton 1995, 17. See also the discussion in Walsh 2001, 134.

17 Westermann 1995, 288.

hospitality was awarded with the tidings of a son. Finally, in vs. 17–19 the main purpose of the visit is revealed.

This reading agrees with the idea that the discussion about Sodom was conducted with the head of the delegation – whether God or a central angel. The conclusion supports this theory by stating: “When the Lord had finished speaking to Abraham, He departed; and Abraham returned to his place” (18:33); the next verse continues: “The two angels arrived in Sodom in the evening” (19:1). Skinner claimed that the text initially read that “the ‘people’ arrived in Sodom” (not ‘angels’ and not ‘two’), but because Abraham began to debate with God, the text was emended to “two.”¹⁸ This claim, however, is baseless. The text does reflect that one of the guests remained to discuss the matter of Sodom with Abraham, while the two remaining angels went on to Sodom. At the end of ch. 18, God went back to His place, which is the reason only two angels continued to Sodom.

The purpose of the angels’ visit is not disclosed from the outset in order to emphasize Abraham’s “interference” with God’s plan. Abraham’s hospitality was entirely voluntary, and to his credit, his actions should not be viewed as premeditated. Abraham took people into his home of his own free will, for entirely unselfish reasons; the angels felt indebted and responded by offering Abraham and Sarah the blessing of a son. Once this unexpected interaction is over, the narrator can return to the original purpose of the visit: the discussion about Sodom, followed by the evaluation of the city and ultimately its destruction – the final two parts of the narrative.

The Abraham episode is clearly separate from the rest of the narrative, since it is not part of God’s plan, but the episode is simultaneously inseparable from the rest of the story. This solution, which might appear technical, will prove to have a depth of its own in the comparison of Lot’s hospitality with that of Abraham.

18 Skinner 1930, 306.

“Judge of all the Earth”

The discussion about the destruction of Sodom is not conducted as a prayer for the purpose of sparing Sodom. Abraham’s argument is not based on compassion, but on justice: “Abraham came forward and said, Will You sweep away the innocent along with the guilty?... Far be it from You to do such a thing, to bring death upon the innocent as well as the guilty, so that innocent and guilty fare alike. Far be it from You! Shall not the Judge of all the earth deal justly?” (18:23–25).¹⁹ God’s position, according to Abraham, is that the whole city should be destroyed, the innocent along with the guilty. God does not correct Abraham on this point, and the conclusion of the dialogue confirms that if ten righteous people are not found in the city, the entire city will be destroyed, including the handful of righteous people who might exist. According to Abraham’s position, the people of the city should be spared because of merit of the righteous people: “What if there should be fifty innocent within the city; will You then wipe out the place and not forgive it for the sake of the innocent fifty who are in it?” (18:24). Both positions are surprising within the context of justice, where one would expect a middle ground: punishing the guilty and sparing the innocent. This option is not raised at any stage of the legal dialogue, although in a sense this is the option that is realized in the story: Lot is spared, while his guilty neighbors meet their demise. The absence of this option relates to the two key words throughout the dialogue – “place” and “city.” From the outset, Abraham does not argue for the *people*, but for the *place*: “will You then wipe out the *place* and not forgive it?” (24). God’s response to Abraham’s request mirrors his intentions: “If I find within the *city* of Sodom fifty innocent ones, I will forgive the whole *place* for their sake” (26). The next stage of the discussion continues to revolve around the city: “What if the fifty innocent should lack five? Will You destroy *the whole city* for want of the five?” (28). Some might say “city” is a metonymy for “the people

19 In contrast with McDonald 2004 and Mathews 2005 who believed Abraham’s prayer is based on two components: divine justice and mercy.

in the city.” The punishment of the people is described as inadvertent: “Then the men said to Lot, ‘Whom else have you here? Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters, or anyone else that you have in the city – *bring them out of the place*, for we are about to destroy *this place*; because their outcry before the Lord has become so great that the Lord has sent us to *destroy it*’” (12–13). Lot understands perfectly, and conveys the message to his sons-in-law: “Up, get out of this place, for the Lord is about to destroy *the city*” (14). Later, “the angels urged Lot on, saying, ‘Up, take your wife and your two remaining daughters, *lest you be swept away because of the iniquity of the city*’... So the men seized his hand... and left him *outside the city*” (15–16). This description is apparent in the destruction itself as well: “He *annihilated those cities and the entire Plain*, and all the inhabitants of the *cities* and the vegetation of the ground” (19:25). The people seem to only be destroyed because they are “inhabitants of the cities,” just as the “vegetation of the ground” was destroyed along with the city. When Abraham went to “look down” upon the result, “he saw the smoke of *the land* rising” (28), and the conclusion of the destruction is described in the same terms: “Thus it was that, when God *destroyed the cities of the Plain* and *annihilated the cities* where Lot dwelt...” (29). The cities of Lot were destroyed – and he had to extract himself from the city to be saved. Looking back, the city – not the people – appears to be the center of the discussion from the outset, since God went “to see whether they have acted altogether according to her outcry that has reached Me.” The midrash in Genesis Rabbah noted: “not ‘their cry,’ but rather ‘her cry’” – the cry of the city.”²⁰ The choice of punishment is the ultimate proof that the city was being judged, rather than the people. Instead of a plague or wild animals to hurt the people, God chose to destroy the infrastructure of the cities themselves. The lush, fertile land of Sodom is to become desolate.

20 Genesis Rabbah 49:6. Based on the word “her,” the midrash describes several incidents of abused girls in Sodom, whose outcry was the reason God decided to destroy Sodom. The literal meaning in the text regards the entire city as one unit.

The particular focus on the “place” and the “city” relates to each party’s perception of retribution on the eve of the destruction. “The place” is a symbol of the entire population, as one unit, or one culture. This is a public trial. The biblical text is familiar with the concept of national retribution,²¹ though here the retribution is municipal-social in nature. The people of a city forge a shared culture, which is examined and judged by God. Perhaps in the context of personal retribution God will decide to rescue someone from destruction, but this is not the level on which the discussion between God and Abraham is conducted. Their discussion is about “place” – will the place be destroyed or maintained.²² The conclusion necessitates an examination of the definition of the public. Abraham believes that the place could be defined by a small group. Ten (but no fewer!) righteous people are sufficient to categorize the city as a righteous city.²³ Some might

21 For example, God threatens to destroy the Nation of Israel after the Sin of the Golden Calf, despite the active participation of only 3000 people (Ex 32); similarly, the nation is punished for the sin of a single person in the case of Achan (Josh 7); in the narrative about Korah his actions lead to a plague in the nation (Num 16:22). For a survey of the concept of biblical retribution see Weiss 1987, 512–48.

22 There is no evidence for the claim that the concept of retribution in Gen 18 reflects a primitive stage of biblical retribution. Daube wrote: “From a precise legal perspective this is still an earlier phase” (Daube 1958, 41). Weiss responded similarly to that which is suggested above (Weiss 1987, 47–49). A similar position is found in Ezekiel’s prophecies: there is no prophet more outspoken about personal retribution (Eze 18:4: “the person who sins, only he shall die”), while when the prophet speaks about Jerusalem and the Land of Israel he says: “O mortal, set your face toward Jerusalem and proclaim against her sanctuaries and prophecy *against the land of Israel*. Say to *the land of Israel*, thus said the Lord: I am going to deal with you! I will draw my sword from its sheath and *I will wipe out from you both the righteous and the wicked*. In order to wipe out from you both the righteous and the wicked, My sword shall assuredly be unsheathed against all flesh from south to north. And all flesh shall know that I the Lord have drawn My sword from its sheath, not to be sheathed again” (Eze 21:7–10).

23 Blenkinsopp summarized the different positions that address why Abraham did not continue arguing for fewer than ten righteous people (Blenkinsopp 1982). He also mentions Schmidt’s claim that ten is the minimal number that can be considered a group, a public (Schmidt 1976, 151–56). This approach is also

view this as a leaning toward benevolence in judgment, but this is still a far cry from Abraham asking for the city to be spared.²⁴ Apparently, human perspective can drive judgment toward compassion, and a rejection of punishment.

Biblical philosophy does not view compassion and justice as conflicting values.²⁵ This is apparent from the phrase “just and charitable,” which describes Abraham’s household, and is stated as the reason God feels compelled to share His plans for the destruction of Sodom with Abraham (18:19). The phrase should be viewed as a hendiadys that expresses a broader brand of social justice, which goes beyond the legal sense.²⁶ God Himself is described in the same terms: “for I, the Lord, act with kindness, *justice and benevolence* in the world, for in these I delight, declares the Lord” (Jer 9:3), as is the expectation of mankind: “Do what is *just and charitable*; rescue from the defrauder him who is robbed; do not wrong the stranger, the fatherless, and the widow; commit no lawless act, and do not shed the blood of the innocent in this place” (Jer 22:3). Benevolence enhances justice; the combination of these qualities leads one to protect the weak and prevent wrongdoing.²⁷ Abraham’s mission is therefore reinforced by the Sodom episode. His sensitivity to morality is demonstrated in his attempt to persuade God to be not only just but benevolent, and this delays punishment for as long as possible, so that merit can be found.

reflected in the rabbinic law that a *minyan*, or prayer group, must consist of at least ten members (Brueggemann 1985, 410).

24 Beno Jacob made a similar suggestion; however, he believed Abraham did not ask God to spare the actual sinners – rather, he thought the sinners should die and the city should be spared in merit of the righteous (Jacob 1974, 121–22).

25 Skinner, for example, writes thus: “In the Old Testament, righteousness and clemency are closely allied; there is more injustice in the death of a few innocent people than in the sparing of a guilty multitude” (Skinner 1930, 305).

26 Ranier, ٧٦٣; Weinfeld 1992; Kaddari 2006, 679.

27 See Hos 2:21; Mic 6:8; Zac 7:9–10.

I Who Am but Dust and Ashes

The argument between God (or the angel) and Abraham is one of the most audacious scenes in biblical literature. Whereas religious theology generally emphasizes human emptiness in the presence of God, Abraham is called upon to express his opinion on divine justice, and actively participate in the final verdict. The scope of the discussion goes beyond Sodom to the essential judicial principle of judging a group that includes various types of individuals. The justification for including Abraham in the process is noted in the verses that introduce the argument with a rare report of God's "thoughts":²⁸

For I have singled him out,²⁹
that he may instruct his children and his posterity
to keep the way of the Lord
by doing what is just and charitable,
so that the Lord may bring about for Abraham what He has promised him.

According to the Masoretic version of the first line ("for I have known him"), Abraham was chosen for two reasons. The first reason relates

28 Cf. Hamilton 1995, 17. Wenham wrote that the senior angel addresses his two companions, who are about to depart for Sodom (Wenham 1994, 50). A similar suggestion was previously offered by Nahmanides, who wrote that God had addressed the heavenly host.

29 According to the Masoretic text: **כִּי יָדַעְתִּיו** (literally: "for I have known him"). NJPS translated "for I have singled him out," as above. The Septuagint, Samaritan, and Vulgate offer a more comfortable reading: "for I know that he instructs his children..." (Zipor 2005, 232). This interpretation is reflected in the common version of Onkelos' translation as well (Nahmanides cites another version): "It is known to me that he instructs his children..." regarding the Masoretic text, the verb **יָדַע** ("know") should be read as a formal verb denoting knowledge (see Huffmon 1966, 34–35); however, the connotations of the verb are more intimate and personal than the parallel verb **בָּחַר** ("chose"), which is prevalent in Deuteronomy (Fretheim, **יָדַע**; Mathews 2005, 223). See more on the choice of the verb below.

to the education of his family in the ways of God;³⁰ in other words, Abraham's actions. The second reason relates to God's actions for the benefit of Abraham: the fulfillment of the blessings bestowed upon him. Since Abraham intends to instruct his family in the ways of God – justice and righteousness – he is invited to take part in the design of this path, by witnessing the process of God's judgment and contributing his own understanding. Abraham will learn from the *zeaka* ("cry") emanating from Sodom how better to distribute *zedaka* ("righteousness").³¹ The scene is exceedingly bold in the context of religious philosophy, since Abraham's "partnership" with God is explicit. The narrative indicates that God and Abraham contemplate the verdict of Sodom together.³² This dialogue emphasizes the development of Abraham's position in the second half of the story cycle. God appears to Abraham in human form, and Abraham is asked to "advise" God on judicial matters. In recognition of his position, Abraham will emphasize the difference between him and God throughout the dialogue ("I am but dust and ashes").

Some scholars noted a contradiction between the two verses that conclude God's thoughts (20–21):

30 As previously stated, לַמַּעַן does not always denote purpose or intent. Gunkel (1997, 201) and Westermann (1995, 289) noted that this is the only place in the patriarchal narrative that presents the choice of the forefathers as conditional on their deeds.

31 The wordplay between צדקה (righteousness) and צעקה (cry) is implemented in Isaiah, who relies on our verses in his prophecy: "But behold, injustice for *righteousness* (צדקה), but behold, *iniquity* (צעקה)" (Is 5:7). See Oswalt 1986, 154 note 22; Mathews 2005, 224–25.

32 An extreme expression of this position is a rabbinic view of the verse "Abraham remained standing before the Lord" as a theological editing correction (*tiqqun sofrim*), while the original text stated that God stood before Abraham (Genesis Rabbah 49:7, ed. Theodore-Albeck, 505). See McCarthy 1981, 70–76. The link between Abraham standing before God and standing to serve his guests is noteworthy; perhaps the connection indicates a similar position – Abraham tends to the wellbeing of his guests, and later to the fate of an entire city.

Then the Lord said, “The outrage of Sodom and Gomorrah is so great, and their sin so grave!

I will go down to see whether they have acted altogether according to the outcry that has reached Me; if not, I will take note.

God initially comments on the severity of the outcry of Sodom and Gomorrah, and the gravity of their sin,³³ while in the following verse God expresses His intention to investigate the city, in order to determine whether the outcry is justified,³⁴ and whether the situation is as bad as it seems.³⁵ However, the verses offer the necessary context for the arrival of the angels in Sodom. Even after God has noted the severity of the sin, He does not hasten to punish before conducting a thorough investigation.

Hamilton viewed the verses not as part of God’s thought process, but rather as God’s dialogue with Abraham.³⁶ This interpretation is possible, since Abraham responds to these verses (v. 23: “Abraham came forward and said, ‘Will You sweep away the innocent along with the guilty?’”). However, the sequence of the verses describes the angels journeying to Sodom while Abraham continued to stand before God immediately after this verse, and only later cites Abraham’s response. So reading the verses as part of God’s thought process is a viable possibility. According to this reading God’s exact conversation with Abraham is not revealed in the text, which leads to a difference between the information possessed by Abraham and the reader. In the initial episode the reader knew the identity of Abraham’s guests, but Abraham

33 Abraham’s possessions were previously described as כבד (“heavy”) in the introduction to his separation from Lot (Gen 13:2). Abraham’s multiplicity of possessions does not prevent him from seeking out justice, while Sodom is lush and wealthy, but great with sin and outcry.

34 צעקה and זעק are entirely interchangeable, and used for variety. See 1 Sam 4:13–14; Jer 25:34, 36; Is 65:14, 19; Jer 48:3–5; Neh 5:1, 6). See Konkel, זעק, but also Bergey 1985, 121: “It is clear that in exilic and postexilic times a change occurred in the use of the emphatic sibilant ז in comparison to the use of the voiced sibilant ט in the verb זעק – זעק and the noun צעקה – זעקה.”

35 See discussion in Schmidt 1976, 131–64.

36 Hamilton 1995, 20. See also Westermann 1995, 289–90; Wenham 1994, 50; Mathews 2005, 224.

did not; here Abraham might be under the impression that the angels are already on their way to destroy Sodom, while the reader knows the angels are going to Sodom to investigate, and that the verdict is not yet known. Abraham's initial reaction indicates his lack of information: "Far be it from You to do such a thing, to bring death upon the innocent as well as the guilty!" (18:25). This gap might diminish the extent of Abraham's influence on God's decision.

The legal debate is designed as a negotiation between merchants. Abraham uses colloquial rhetoric to convince God that ten righteous people are sufficient to save the city.³⁷

The discussion is framed by the meeting (22) and departure (33) of the characters. The frame highlights the unique reciprocity that is expressed in the discussion itself. There is no doubt that God has the upper hand; it is Abraham who stands before God,³⁸ and He alone will determine the fate of the city. Nonetheless, Abraham and God together reflect upon Sodom and discuss the future and appropriate response to the sin of the city.

Three changing elements are included at every stage of the discussion: the narrator's introduction; Abraham's argument; and God's response. The introductions become shorter throughout the dialogue. The first three introductions include two verbs: "*came forward* and *said*" (23), "*spoke up, saying*" (27), and "he *spoke* to Him again, and *said*" (29). The last three arguments are briefly prefaced with "and he said" (30, 31, 32). The transfer from the first model to the second is somewhat gradual: although the third argument is prefaced with two verbs, Abraham's name is omitted, in contrast with the initial two arguments. The writing style phases out the narrator and enables the characters to converse "directly" ("telling" instead of "showing"), resulting in a lively and animated dialogue.

37 Regarding the common nature of negotiation in this episode, see Roshwald 1989, 154; Ben Zvi 1992, 36; Lundbom 1998, 141.

38 According to rabbinic tradition, the verse that describes Abraham standing in the presence of God (18:22) was edited (*tiqqun sofrim*), and had originally stated: "the Lord remained standing before Abraham" (Genesis Rabbah 49:7). See also Skinner 1930, 304–05.

Following the process of Abraham's arguments is complex. After setting the parameters of the discussion at fifty righteous people, Abraham avoids directly lowering the "price" to 45; instead he presses, "what if the fifty innocent should lack five? Will You destroy the whole city for want of the five?" (28). The formulation of the argument presents the absurdity of destroying a city *due to the absence* of five people. God's response indicates that although He accepts Abraham's argument, rhetoric will not help Abraham in this instance: "I will not destroy if I find 45 there" (28). Abraham continues appropriately, focusing on the number (rather than the absence) of righteous people.

Abraham introduces his arguments using two models of humility:

Phase II: "I venture to speak to my Lord, I who am but dust and ashes" (27)

Phase IV: "Let not my Lord be angry if I go on" (30)

Phase V: "I venture again to speak to my Lord" (31)

Phase VI: "Let not my Lord be angry if I speak but this last time" (32)

The first argument does not include a show of humility, since Abraham has to test the waters by posing his initial question, to see whether there is any flexibility on God's part. Surprisingly, the third argument – "what if forty should be found there" (29) – is not introduced with Abraham begging his pardon. Following Abraham's responses reveals that he uses two alternate formulations: "I venture to speak," and "let not my Lord be angry." The purpose of the alternation seems to be creative variation, but since the discussion is designed as a negotiation, the variation serves a rhetorical purpose as well: Abraham does not want to sound repetitive. He wants each of his arguments to sound independently convincing, not as a mere expansion of his previous request. The alternation makes each phase sound like a new argument, when contrasted with the preceding argument. The identical models also include small variations, such as the omission of "I who am but dust and ashes" from the fifth argument.

Abraham's rhetorical style and the development of the dialogue are designed like a buyer and a merchant haggling over the price of a product. This enhances Abraham's personal involvement in the subject matter. To Abraham, justice and charity are not abstract ideals; he

is personally invested in these principles, and is willing to haggle with God to ensure their implementation.

Small variations can be detected in God's responses, but He refrains from revealing his methods of administering justice in the world. In fact, the divine position is only detectable through the analysis of Abraham's counter-arguments. The only detail revealed directly about God is His willingness to investigate the outcry from the city, and destroy the city if He finds that the outcry is justified. Abraham is the active conversant, while God only reacts. This is apparent from God's choice of words, which mirrors Abraham's arguments: Abraham says, "*will You... not forgive it for the sake of the innocent fifty?*" (28); God responds, "*I will forgive the whole place for their sake*" (26). Abraham asks, "*Will You destroy the whole city for want of the five?*" (28) and God responds, "*I will not destroy*" (28). Although the response does not correlate at every stage, the initial phases set the tone of the discussion and enhance the feeling that Abraham initiates and God responds.

The theological ramifications of this episode are overwhelming, as von Rad noted:

The paragraph is concerned with an important theological matter. God does not wish that Abraham learn of the frightful event at Sodom only, as it were, from without. God intends to tell him whom He, God, has called into a relationship of trust ("I have made him acquainted with my"), so that God's act outside, in history that otherwise is hidden from man, shall be revealed to him. He is to understand what will happen in Sodom!³⁹

Despite von Rad's justified enthusiasm, he failed to note the more dramatic implications of the verses: nowhere in the narrative does God instruct Abraham about divine justice, so that Abraham will know how to pass along God's message to his children. Moreover, God seems to seek Abraham's opinion on the distribution of justice, and perhaps, at first glance, even changes His mind as a result of Abraham's arguments. In contrast with other biblical texts, Gen 18 seems to suggest that God could benefit from the human perspective on justice and benevolence. The premise of the narrative is that man can understand

39 Von Rad 1963, 204–05.

divine justice, and is expected to argue when God seems to be acting unjustly; moreover, his arguments might be accepted! Although the ultimate decision is left to God's discretion, Abraham's opinion is portrayed as influential; he is called upon to assist God in defining the boundaries of justice.⁴⁰

The conclusion of the legal debate is that if ten righteous people are found in Sodom, God will avoid destroying the city for their benefit. The narrative reports that God intended to investigate the city before His debate with Abraham (18:21); at the end of the discussion the reader might question whether Abraham changed a divine decree, or whether this was God's intention from the outset. Abraham assumed that God's intention was to destroy the city even if there were righteous people in it, but this presumption was never verified in the text. Abraham's participation in designing divine justice is diminished by the vagueness of God's initial position.

The conclusion of the discussion is that the city must be investigated. The following chapter therefore becomes the realization of ch. 18. The angels do not journey to Sodom for the purpose of destroying the city, but rather to investigate; the result of their inquiry will determine the outcome of the verdict and the future of the city. This assumption deeply affects the interpretation of ch. 19.⁴¹

40 Some commentators found Abraham's involvement theologically disturbing, and asked whether God really needs "an outside perspective" to perceive the catastrophic effect of destroying the cities. Some attributed this to the "dark side" of God (Whybray 2000, 17), while others viewed God giving Abraham the opportunity to change His mind as evidence of His mercifulness. MacDonald suggested an entirely different interpretation for the one-sided dialogue – he portrays Abraham as bursting through an open door. Abraham encourages the negotiation, and God agrees with each of Abraham's arguments, indicating that He will follow Abraham's suggestion. MacDonald claims that Abraham could have saved Sodom had he asked; however, he underestimated his influence (MacDonald 2004, 34–41).

41 Eliezer Schweid wrote: "God, who agree to the claims of his advocate without contest, already knows that there are not even ten righteous in Sodom, and its doom is sealed...the angels were sent to Sodom to carry out the verdict that had already been sealed and to rescue the lone righteous man who had not sinned" (Schweid 2009, 125). Schweid's comment contradicts the narrative that

This sheds a new light on the invisible conflict between Abraham and the people of Sodom. Abraham brings guests into his home and cares for their comfort, while the people of Sodom seek to harm outsiders; Abraham instructs his children in the ways of *zedaka* – benevolence, while the dwellers of Sodom cause *zeaka* – an outcry; God “knows” Abraham, and, after His investigation, He “will know” what goes on in Sodom (18:21). As Hamilton noted sarcastically: “Or again, perhaps the narrator wants to draw a contrast between Yahweh who knew Abraham and the Sodomites who wanted to ‘know’ Lot’s guests (19:5). Here benign knowledge and diabolical knowledge are juxtaposed.”⁴²

indicates that God wishes to investigate the city; there is no indication that the results of the investigation are known in advance.

42 Hamilton 1995, 18–19.

Chapter 11: Sodom's Destruction and Lot's Rescue (19)

Lot's name is omitted from the dialogue about the destruction of Sodom. In fact, at this point the reader might be skeptical about Lot's whereabouts. Abraham had returned the captive people and possessions to the King of Sodom in ch. 14, but the text failed to specify where Lot settled after his release. Clearly Lot did not return to Abraham's home, since he is absent from all narratives after ch. 14, but the narrator does not comment that Lot returned to Sodom. Chapter 19 determines that Lot had indeed returned to Sodom. From this point forward the story follows two linked threads, and Lot's fate becomes one of the focal points of the narrative: What will happen to Lot if Sodom is destroyed? The second story thread relates to the investigation and fate of Sodom. The angels go to Sodom to conduct an investigation, which will lead to the destruction of the city unless ten righteous people are found.¹

The narrative concludes with a guilty verdict for Sodom, and the city is destroyed for the sins of its residents, though Lot and his family are saved. The narrator reasons Lot's escape by stating, "Thus it was that, when God destroyed the cities...God was mindful of Abraham and removed Lot from the midst of the upheaval" (29). Lot's rescue is attributed in this verse to the merit of Abraham. This reading is supported by the concentric structure of the Abraham cycle (see

1 Westermann claimed that the story has two focal points: Lot's rescue and the destruction of the city. The Sodom narrative resembles the flood narrative, which also includes two threads: the destruction and the saving of Noah and the contents of his ark: "Annihilation by water corresponds to annihilation by fire" (Westermann 1995, 297). I only disagree with his definition of the "destruction axis," since in the first part of the narrative it is unclear that the city will be destroyed; I therefore prefer the caption "investigation of the city, and ultimate verdict." Regarding the comparison between the Sodom and the flood narratives, see below.

Introduction), which parallels the two narratives about Lot's rescue: in ch. 14 Abraham saves him from captivity, and in ch. 19 Abraham's merit leads once again to Lot's escape from disaster. When the threat was political-military (ch. 14), Abraham intervened directly on Lot's behalf; in ch. 19 the source of the threat is God, and it is therefore Abraham's merit that "intervenes" on Lot's behalf. In both cases, Lot owes his life to Abraham.

Nonetheless, v. 29 requires interpretation. The verse seems to offer an outside perspective on the long and detailed story of the investigation of Sodom. The story frame ("looking down" at the city in 18:16 and 19:28) excludes the verse entirely. Additionally, the use of the name Elohim in the verse is foreign and inconsistent. Therefore, despite the external perspective offered by the verse, there is reason to seek another reason for Lot's rescue within the boundaries of the narrative.

The Angels Arrive in Sodom (1–3)

Until this point in the text, Abraham's guests are referred to as "people." But when they arrive in Sodom the narrator reveals their true identity, and refers to them as "angels": "The two angels arrived in Sodom in the evening" (19:1).² The term is only used once more throughout the narrative, in v. 15. The sudden change might relate to the changing perspectives in the story: the angels arrive at Sodom as God's messengers, and at His command; they are therefore regarded as "angels" in the introduction to the story; however, since they appear to Lot and the townspeople in human form, they are referred to as "people" throughout the text.³

2 This deviation led some scholars to read "the people" here and in v. 15 (BH, 24; Ball 1896, 69–70; Gunkel 1966, 206, 210; Skinner 1930, 306); however, there is no evidence to support the correction, beyond the expectation of consistency.

3 Speiser 1964, 138.

The angels are on the move, while Lot is settled at the gate: “The two angels *arrived* in Sodom in the evening, as Lot was *sitting* in the gate.” The moment Lot detects the unexpected visitors, he springs to action: “When Lot saw them, he rose to greet them and, bowing low with his face to the ground, he said, ‘Please, my lords, turn aside to your servant’s house.’”⁴ Lot’s reaction is reminiscent of Abraham’s response when the “people” had visited him: he, too, was sitting at an entrance (to his tent), and he also sprang to action when he saw he had visitors. Beginning the story with a comparison between Abraham and Lot affects the reading experience, and particularly the evaluation of Lot’s character. In fact, Lot exceeds Abraham’s actions by “bowing *low with his face* to the ground,” while Abraham only “bowed to the ground” (18:2).

Lot sits at the gate as an indication of his official position,⁵ as opposed to his permanent place of dwelling.⁶ Or, perhaps Lot wishes to see that guests are coming to town and offer them protection before the townspeople get their hands on them.⁷

4 The combination שָׁב (“sat/settled”) and קָם (“arose/got up”) will reappear in the appendix to the Sodom narrative (v. 30–35: “Lot *went up* from Zoar and *settled* in the hill country... and the younger one *got up* and lay with him”). The “arousal” characterizes activity, in contrast with the “sitting,” which connotes passivity.

5 See Gen 23:10, 18; Deut 21:19; 22:15, 24; Prov 24:7; Jer 20:2. Therefore, the verse “Her husband is prominent in the gates/as he sits among the elders of the land” (Prov 31:23) indicates a public position held by the husband of the Woman of Valor. The significance of the gate in the biblical era is apparent from archeological digs, prominently in the findings of Bethsaida of the Galilee, where large altars and other ritual accessories were discovered by the gate. The view of the gate as a definition of the city might be the reason for the obligation to place a mezuzah on the doorpost. See Hess, שַׁעַר; Herzog 1992, vol. 2, 844–52.

6 E.g., Wenham (1994, 54), Lyons (2002, 215–16), and Mathews (2005, 4) all wondered – according to the position that places Lot at the gate as a judge – why he sits at the gate alone.

7 See, e.g., Kiel 2000, 27. Gunkel also viewed Lot’s position at the gate as temporary; he believed Lot was resting after a day’s work (Gunkel 1997, 206). Although that reading is possible, it is surprising that Lot would rest after a day’s work at the gate instead of in his house. Von Rad wrote unconvincingly that

An alternative approach was suggested by Bekhor Shor. He viewed the phrase “Lot was sitting in the gate” as the description of an ongoing state; in other words, Lot’s residence was close to the gate: “he resided there, for he did not reside inside Sodom, but rather close to the gate, as it is written, ‘pitching his tents near Sodom.’”⁸ Bekhor Shor’s reading is particularly intriguing in light of the extensive comparison between the Lot narrative and the narrative of Rahab and Joshua’s spies to Jericho, as demonstrated below. Bekhor Shor notes the first link between the two narratives: Rahab’s house was “at the outer side of the city wall and she lived in the actual wall” (Josh 2:15) just as “Lot was sitting *in the gate*.” Bekhor Shor’s reading indicates that the use of the verb יָשַׁב (“to sit”) connotes permanent dwelling. When Lot and Abraham separated in ch. 13, the verb יָשַׁב was used to describe Lot’s decision to settle in Sodom; perhaps the use of the verb here indicates that the current plot stems from Lot’s initial decision to settle in Sodom. In view of this, Lot’s residence at the gate is appropriately symbolic; residents of a city dwell within the walls of the city (Ex 20:10; Deut 5:14).⁹ Lot and Rahab dwell on the borders of the city; they are associated with the city but are not “insiders.” Their position on the borderline requires a decision: Are they in or out? Do they view themselves as part of the city (and fated to be destroyed with its residents), or do they stand apart (providing themselves with the option of escaping the fate of the city)?¹⁰ Lot’s position creates contradicting impressions: Is Lot’s assimilation in the evil city so complete that he

men would congregate at the gate at the end of their workday (von Rad 1963, 212; cf. Hamilton 1995, 32, note 20). Morschauser wrote that Lot sat at the gate as part of the city’s defense system, in light of the attack of the four kings described in ch. 14 (Morschauser 2003, 466–67).

8 Bekhor Shor’s commentary on 19:1.

9 Hess, שַׁעַר, 209.

10 As previously noted, in the angels’ tidings to Sarah the entrance to the tent had a significant literary role, symbolizing the invitation Abraham extends to his guests, which parallels the expansion of the tent with the blessing of a son. The symbolism of the entrance in the Sodom narrative will be discussed below.

has risen to an official position of power within his community? Or is his position in the gate an indication that he can leave the city at will?¹¹

Lot invites the angels to “turn aside to your servant’s house to spend the night, and bathe your feet; then you may be on your way early,” only to be rejected by the angels: “No, we will spend the night in the square.” The rejection is particularly surprising in comparison with Abraham’s offer, which was happily accepted by the angels (18:5). Gunkel, among others, attributed the refusal to prevalent social etiquette,¹² but this is unlikely in view of the easy acceptance of Abraham’s offer. Rather, the refusal seems to be linked with the fundamental plot: the angels were charged with the task of investigating the deeds of the city, and examining whether it contains any righteous people.¹³ If the angels had gone to Lot, they could investigate Lot’s family, but not the general culture of the city. The seemingly rude statement “we will spend the night in the square” is in fact an explanation of their refusal: the purpose of their visit is to investigate the city. They need to spend the night in the town square, where they can gather information about the social situation in the city.¹⁴ Lot’s insistence changes the anticipated course of the plot. The angels would have been “forced” to wait until morning before they were able to conduct their investigation,¹⁵ had not the entire city shown up at Lot’s doorstep and demonstrated prevalent social customs; whereupon the angels were able to proceed with their investigation within the confines of Lot’s house.

As opposed to Abraham, Lot does not involve his wife and servants in his act of hosting his guests; they are absent from this scene.

11 Cf. Letellier 1995, 140.

12 Gunkel 1997, 206–07; Lyons 2002, 217; Mathews 2005, 4.

13 Keil & Delitzsch 1980, 232.

14 As opposed to Wenham 1994, 54, who viewed their refusal as unexplained for the purpose of enhancing the tension.

15 Tonson viewed the angels’ refusal of Lot’s offer as part of a consistent pattern that is repeated in a number of scenes: offer or demand → refusal → repetition of offer or demand. In this context the refusal enhances Lot’s hospitality, and comments on his nature (Tonson 2001, 102–03, 108, 111).

¹⁶ He bakes the unleavened bread himself; he serves his guests a feast. Although this demonstrates that Lot has not managed to instruct his household in Abraham's ways, his actions, like Abraham's, still speak louder than words. He fails to mention a feast in his initial offer, but serves one nonetheless, baking bread – at night! – for his unexpected guests.¹⁷

The Townspeople (4–9)

The people who gather around Lot's house inadvertently eased the angels' mission, since they no longer have to go out into the town to inspect the culture of the city. The Sodomites offer themselves for judgment, and unwittingly step into their own trial. The narrator emphasizes the fact that the entire city congregated around Lot's house by using three different phrases:

The men of the city, the men of Sodom, gathered about the house,
From young to old¹⁸
All the people
To the last person.

This emphasis validates the inspection of the city: God and Abraham had agreed that if ten righteous people are found Sodom will be spared. The gathering of the entire city around Lot's house, with the intention of harming his innocent guests, unequivocally negates the possibility of ten righteous people.

16 Gossai wrote that the reader can sense from the outset that Lot's enthusiasm cannot compete with that of Abraham (Gossai 1995, 76).

17 Fields was sensitive to the ambivalent analogy between Abraham and Lot. He claimed that the analogy portrays Abraham as a "prototype," while Lot is designed "in his image." However, he adds that there is a reason the "dangerous night" motif is realized specifically with regard to Lot (Fields 1997, 39; see also Fields 1992). See also Safren 2012.

18 NJPS translated "The men of Sodom..."

The rumor spread through the city like wildfire – “They had not yet lain down” – and the entire town congregated around Lot’s house. No explanation is provided as to how or why the news had spread so fast, and this literary gap is left to the reader’s imagination. One mid-rashic text attributes the rumor to Lot’s gossipy wife. Alternatively, Lot invited his guests in a public place, and was undoubtedly seen as he walked through town with two strangers.¹⁹ Regardless of the reason, however, this omission serves to highlight the eagerness of the townspeople to come and harm strangers who made the grave mistake of visiting Sodom; the arrival of guests is big news, since an opportunity is thereby provided for the Sodomites to unleash the evil within.

The people surrounding the house wish to “know” the guests; at this stage the reader might wonder what it is that the townspeople want. The verb יָדַע (literally “to know”) was integrated twice before in the narrative, both in positive contexts. God describes His view of Abraham in 18:19: “For I have known him, that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is just and right.” In Gen 18:21, the verb is used to describe the alternative to the justification of the outcry emerging from the city: “if not, I will take note (אֲדַע).”²⁰ Based on these previous uses, the innocent reader might assume the townspeople wish to “get to

19 See discussion in Wenham 1982, 54, regarding whether Lot was the only judge to invite guests to his home, as opposed to the other elders at the gate, or whether Lot sits at the gate alone.

20 The expression is difficult, and there are three approaches to its interpretation: Some (e.g., Hezekiah ben Manoah, among others) believe the verb connotes fondness and blessing, similar to its usage by Abraham (יָדַעְתִּי – “I have known him”). According to this interpretation, after investigating the city God will decide whether to punish the city with destruction – or *bless* the city. In contrast, others (e.g., Bahye ben Asher; Thomas 1941, 65, among others) interpreted אֲדַע as indicative of punishment. A third and simpler approach reads the verb as a conclusion of the entire sentence, as if to say, “I will go down to see whether they have acted according to the outcry that has reached Me, or not, I shall know.” (e.g., Rashi; Bekhor Shor; Emerton 1970, 171; Westermann 1995, 284; Alter 1996, 81). All of the approaches above do not diminish the significance of the integration of the verb twice in the verses, one in relation to Abraham and again in relation to Sodom.

know” Lot’s gests.²¹ However, the false impression is immediately corrected by Lot, who knows his town, and immediately understands that the townspeople intend to sexually assault his guests.²² Lot’s realization is apparent from his offer to substitute his two daughters for the two guests. Lot describes his two daughters by stating they “have not known a man” (19:8); had the townspeople wanted guests for any other purpose, it is unclear why Lot’s virgin daughters could be considered a replacement.²³ The verb **יָדָע** is therefore used in two different ways throughout the text. It expresses the unique intimacy between God and Abraham, a connection based on justice and benevolence, but also the blatant wickedness of Sodom, whose people would use a sacred act to promote evil.

This should also be viewed as the context of the sin of Sodom. Early and modern exegesis has two primary approaches toward their sin. One approach focuses on the sin of preventing hospitality, while the other focuses on the sexual offense of rape or homosexuality.²⁴ The main contrast between Lot and the Sodomites is expressed in the text as the difference in attitude toward guests; Ezekiel reinforces this view in his description of Sodom (Eze 16:49–50):

Only this was the sin of your sister Sodom: arrogance!
She and her daughters had plenty of bread and untroubled tranquility;
yet she did not support the poor and the needy.

21 Some scholars reached this conclusion. See Morschauser 2003, who wrote that Lot was concerned by the security issue; Doyle 2004.

22 Doyle 2004, 437, claims that Lot misunderstood the request of the Sodomites. They wished only to see Lot’s guests, since, as opposed to Lot, they recognized the guests as angels, while Lot perceived the request as sexual. Doyle concluded that the sin of Sodom was vanity, since they assumed they can meet with angels despite their inferiority (p. 438). The angels’ retribution against the townspeople and the destruction of the city both indicate that the angels correctly understood the intent of the townspeople.

23 Kidner 1967, 136–37; Bartlett 1977, 134; Ukleja 1983, 260–66 (this is contested by Bailey, who claimed the demand of the Sodomites was not sexual).

24 See survey by Loader 1990; Doyle 2004.

Sodom's financial power did not lead its residents to "support the poor and the needy," despite their God-given ability to do so. Ezekiel ignores the sexual motif, which in Genesis as well is not portrayed as the chief sin of the city. The sexual assault on the guests emphasizes the lack of morality toward the apparently defenseless visitors, who lack the protection of family. Not only do the townspeople refrain from offering guests food and shelter, they also take advantage of their frailty and seek to harm them.²⁵

Before Lot's response to the demand of the townspeople, his position is indicated: "Lot went out to them to the entrance, and shut the door behind him" (6). Closing the door seems, at first glance, to be entirely superfluous, the type of detail generally ignored by the biblical narrator. Technically, Lot has to close the door in order to prevent the mob from entering his home;²⁶ however, the door features twice more, when the townspeople threaten to break it down (9), and again when the angels reach outside the door to pull Lot inside (10). The repeated reference to the door indicates that it serves a symbolic-literary purpose.²⁷ The door separates the townspeople from the angels, and Lot stands at the threshold and has to determine where he belongs. Does he identify with the Sodomites, the people among whom he chose to dwell, or does he belong in his own house, which is separated from the events that take place outside? Lot goes out, and later goes back in; the door opens and closes; the literary reality creates

25 Even if the sexual issue is not the essence of the sin, Mathews might be correct that words with sexual connotations are deliberately scattered throughout the text. He emphasized the verb **בא** in vs. 3, 5, 8, 9, 10 and the verb **שכב** in v. 4 (Mathews 2005, 233).

26 Waltke (1984, 265–81) appropriately emphasized that this detail portrays Lot as self-sacrificing, blocking his escape route into the house. Waltke also remarked that closing the door resembles God closing the door to Noah's ark (Gen 7:16). Hamilton noted this similarity as well (Hamilton 1995, 37).

27 Doyle viewed "door" and "entrance" as key words that link ch. 19 with ch. 18, where Abraham sits at the entrance to his tent. He believed the door symbolizes a place of revelation, similar to the entrance of the Tent of Meeting (Doyle 2004, 442–48). This symbolism is congruent with the position that the townspeople sought to meet with the angels of God.

a distinction between the “few righteous people” inside the house, and the wicked on the outside.²⁸

Lot’s address is confusing: he does all that is in his power to protect his guests; he prevents the angry mob from breaking into his house to harm his people. Lot stands apart from the culture of the city: he takes pity on passers-by and defends them faithfully. Ironically, it is the people of Sodom who point to Lot’s righteousness:

But they said, Move away!

They said, the fellow dwells here as a stranger, and now he passes judgment!

Now we will deal worse with you than with them. (19:9)

The repeated caption “they said” deepens the barrier between Lot and the townspeople. Initially they tell him to leave, separating him from themselves. The second statement reveals their true feelings toward Lot: “The fellow dwells here as a stranger, and now he passes judgment!” Lot is perceived as a stranger in Sodom, who could never belong – because his culture is rooted in justice. The phrase *וַיִּשְׁפֹּט שֹׁפֵט* has been interpreted by some denoting authority, instead of judgment.²⁹ However, the use of the verb *שָׁפַט* (literally “to judge”) is not accidental: Lot wishes to distribute justice, identifying himself with Abraham, who instructs his household in the ways of “justice and benevolence” (18:19);³⁰ Lot thereby chooses to walk in the way of God, who is also called “Judge of all the earth” by Abraham, instead of the ways of Sodom. While the townspeople clearly meant to mock Lot, they separated him from the fate of Sodom by categorizing him as part of Abraham’s “household,” which is based on justice and benevolence.

However, the offer Lot makes to give up his daughters – assuming he was serious – is shocking, and readers throughout history find the

28 Jacobs viewed the emphasis on the door as an indication of “measure for measure:” “Lot shuts the door in a heroic act, in order to protect his guests from the Sodomites who wish to harm them. In a positive ‘measure for measure’ the angels reward Lot when the people of Sodom turn on him, and close the very same door, protecting their protector” (Jacobs 2006, 83).

29 Mathews 2005, 237.

30 Compare with Alter 1996, 86.

passage difficult to comprehend.³¹ In Lot's zealousness to protect his guests he was willing to sacrifice his virgin daughters; Lot is charged with the protection of his own flesh and blood, but his daughters will pay the price for his charitable act of protecting the foreigners. The irony of Lot's offer is indicated in Lot's use of the roots רע ("evil/wrong") and טוב ("good"): "I beg you, my friends, do not commit such a *wrong* (אל תרעו). Look, I have two daughters who have not known a man. Let me bring them out to you, and you may do to them *as you please* (כטוב בעינכם)" (19:7–8). Ironically, Lot employs ethical semantics, portraying himself as one who fights against evil, while he is willing to commit the unspeakable act of throwing his own daughters into the hands of a lascivious mob.³² Later, in another context, Lot will express his fear of being caught in the fate of the city, "lest the evil stick to me and I die" (19:19); here one might say some of Sodom's evil seems indeed to have stuck to Lot.³³

Lot's character is therefore portrayed ambivalently, as a generous and kind host but also as a villain who is willing to abandon his daughters to a gang of rapists.³⁴ This ambivalence will accompany Lot throughout the story.

At this point the narrator stops "showing" (the characters' voices are no longer heard) and begins "telling" (describing the events from the perspective of the narrator). The distant perspective enables the narrator to describe both the actions of the townspeople and the angels. The townspeople press Lot to let them in, and threaten to break down the door. The people inside send out a hand and pull Lot inside, and close the door. The door becomes the object of struggle between the two groups. The reader is called upon to differentiate between Lot and the Sodomites: Lot "urged" the angels to come to his home (19:3) and the Sodomites "urge" Lot to let his guests out so

31 Regarding the possibility that Lot's suggestion was insincere, see Bechtel 1993.

32 See Tribble 1984, 75; Bechtel 1993; Sacks 1990, 132. Sacks viewed Lot's request, "I beg you, my friends, do not commit such a wrong," as evidence of Lot's cowardice.

33 NJPS translated הרעה כני – "lest disaster overtake me."

34 The title of Turner's essay is a harsh expression of this idea: "Lot as Jekyll and Hyde" (Turner 1990).

that they could have their way with them (19:9). The use of the same verb (פָּצַר – “urge”) indicates the difference between Lot, who wishes to host and protect his guests, and the townspeople, who would take the guests out of the house to harm them.³⁵

The “people” approach the door and try to break it down; however, the “people” send out their hand and bring Lot inside. The protector becomes the protected. The narrator misleads the reader by using the same name – “people” – for two different groups: Lot’s guests (vs. 5, 8, 12, 16) and the Sodomites (vs. 4, 11). The context enables the reader to easily determine which group is referred to in most instances, but v. 10 (“and the people raised their hands”) is confusing. In a consecutive reading the “people” seems to refer to the Sodomites, who were discussed in the previous verse: “And they pressed hard against the person of Lot, and moved forward to break the door; and the people raised their hands...” Since there is no direct indication that the subject has been changed, the verse might imply that the townspeople stretched out their hand to break down the door as they had intended.

Moreover, the expression “[to] raise/stretch out a hand” is frequently used in the context of doing others harm, as in: “Do not raise your hand against the boy, or do anything to him” (Gen 22:12); “So I will stretch out My hand and smite Egypt” (Ex 3:20); “Yet He did not raise His hand against the leaders of the Israelites” (Ex 24:11); “‘How did you dare,’ David said to him, ‘to lift your hand and kill the Lord’s anointed?’” (1 Sam 22:17); and many others.³⁶ The associative connotation also encourages the reading that views the Sodomites as the ones who extend a hand to break the door and harm Lot’s guests. But the verse later reveals that the hand was in fact extended by the “people” who are inside the house, and not by the Sodomites on the outside; additionally, the extension of the hand is generally intended to offer help, not harm.³⁷

35 Kiel 2000, 31; Mathews 2005, 234.

36 E.g., Ex 9:15; 1 Sam 24:6; 1 Sam 26:11, 23; Est 2:21; 3:6; 6:2; 8:7; 9:2; Job 1:12.

37 In fact, having read the latter part of the verse one might think that the text refers to the angels only with the verb וּבִיָּאֵר (“they brought”), saving Lot from the harm the “people” wished to inflict upon them.

This deliberate ambiguity is not apparent in various modern translations, whose authors were uncomfortable with the Masoretic text. Some added a contrasting link, to clarify that this is not a direct continuation of the actions of the Sodomites: “*But* the men put forth their hand.”³⁸ Davidson was more explicit: “*But the two men inside* reached out, pulled Lot in, and closed the door.”³⁹ Kaplan outdid both in his translation: “The *strangers* [inside] reached out and pulled Lot to them.”⁴⁰ Kaplan consistently referred to the angels as “strangers” throughout the narrative, openly distinguishing them from the Sodomites.

The temporary ambiguity regarding the identity of the “people” in the verse is not accidental.⁴¹ The writing style has a dramatic effect: the chaos in the scene is well recorded.⁴² The reader’s confusion reflects the ambivalence of Lot, who has to decide who to side with. With which “people” does Lot identify?

The overt conflict is enhanced by the subtle pitting of the two groups against one another. The two groups of “people” confront each other in three focal points:

1. While the Sodomites wanted to break down the door, the angels close the door (10). In view of the significant symbolism of the door in the narrative, the conflict over the door can be given symbolic meaning: the townspeople wish to nullify the border between good and evil, while the angels attempt to reconstruct those boundaries. The boundaries are unequivocal in the conclusion of the episode: “And the people who were at the entrance of the

38 Hertz 1952, 67; Speiser 1964, 136; Fisch 1977, 18.

39 Davidson 1979, 71.

40 Kaplan 1981, 85.

41 On the implementation of this literary technique in the biblical narrative, see Sternberg 1973, 223; Grossman 2006, 10, 49–51.

42 Rahman suggested that the confusion between the “people” in the story (the angels and the Sodomites) exhausts the reader: “The effect of exhaustion is theatrical; it enables the narrator to affect the reader’s mind and emotions, and create an illusion of encountering angels” (Rahman, 1997, 191).

house, young and old, they struck with blinding light, so that they were helpless to find the entrance” (11).⁴³

2. Both groups ask Lot to remove the people under his care. The Sodomites demanded: “Where are the men who came to you tonight? Bring them out (הוציאם) to us, that we may know them” (5), while the angels commanded: “Whom else have you here? Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters, or anyone else that you have in the city – bring them out (הוצא) of the place!” (12).⁴⁴ Neither of the demands were carried out; however, while Lot objected vehemently to the request of the townspeople, he (reluctantly) agreed to cooperate with the angels. Despite Lot’s ambivalence, he leans toward justice and righteousness, and attempts to prevent overt evil; he therefore identifies with the people inside his house.
3. Lot uses similar wording when he addresses both groups:
 - “*I beg you*, my friends, do not commit such a wrong. *Behold*, I have two daughters...” (8–9).
 - “*I beg you*, my lord! *Behold*, You have been so gracious to your servant...” (18–19).

Lot goes in and out and then back in again; with each move the tension grows: which side will he choose? Despite the complex evaluation of Lot (due to the offer of his daughters), the subtleties of the plot seems to indicate that Lot chooses to identify with the “people” he chose to bring into his home, and to separate himself from the townspeople.

43 Lasine defined the scene as comical: the Sodomites seek the entrance, and cannot understand why it can’t be found (Lasine 1984, 40).

44 The root **צא** (“went out”) is repeated throughout the narrative, appropriately for a narrative about saving a man from the destruction of his city. Lot *goes out* to the townspeople to protect his guests, and suggests that he will *send out* his daughters as a replacement for his guests (6–8). After the angels tell him that the city will be destroyed, he *goes out* to his sons-in-law, and tells them to *get out* of Sodom (14). This theme will be discussed further with regard to the sun, which also “*comes out*” (23).

The Verdict and Lot's Escape (12–17)

The reader can guess at the results of the investigation based on the previous episode: “young and old – all the people to the last man” inadvertently walked into their own trial outside Lot's house. Nonetheless, the verdict is exposed directly when the angels reveal their identity to Lot: “Then the people (i.e., the angels) said to Lot, ‘Whom else have you here? Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters, or anyone else that you have in the city – bring them out of the place, for we are about to destroy this place; because the outcry (צַעֲקָתָם) against them before the Lord has become so great that the Lord has sent us to destroy it’” (12–13). The divine dilemma that opened the narrative – “I will go down to see whether they have acted altogether according to her outcry (צַעֲקָתָהּ) that has reached Me; if not, I will take note,” is finally resolved. The outcry was entirely justified, and the city must be destroyed.⁴⁵

The angels mention Lot's family members in a surprising order: “Sons-in-law / your sons / and daughters / or anyone else that you have in the city” (12). If Lot had had sons, one would expect them to be mentioned before sons-in-law; however, opening the list with the sons-in-law sets the tone for the next episode, which will focus on Lot's sons-in-law.⁴⁶ Lot follows the angels' instructions and addresses his sons-in-law. A comparison between the angels' instructions and Lot's repetition demonstrates that Lot believed the city will be destroyed, though he omits the reason provided by the angels:

45 Initially the “outcry” is attributed to the city, and stated in singular (18:21); however, in v. 13 the angels tell Lot that “their outcry” has become intolerable, emphasizing the many individuals harmed by the city's culture. Although the angels specify that God had sent them to destroy the city, one can still assume that the verdict is dependent upon the angels' findings; in other words the angels are instructed to destroy the city in the event that the city is found guilty, and ten righteous people cannot be found.

46 The absence of Lot's wife from the list is also ominously surprising, and might be viewed as foreshadowing her fate in the story, unless the angels do not relate to those who are already in Lot's house.

| <i>The angel's instructions to Lot (12–13)</i> | <i>Lot's advice to his sons-in-law (14)</i> |
|---|---|
| Whom else have you here? <i>Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters</i> , or anyone else that you have in the city | So Lot went out and spoke to <i>his sons-in-law, who had married his daughters</i> , and said |
| <i>bring them out of the place</i> | <i>Up, get out of this place,</i> |
| For we are about to <i>destroy</i> this place | for the Lord is about to <i>destroy</i> the city |
| because their outcry ⁴⁷ before the Lord has become so great that the Lord has sent us to destroy it. | |

Lot's omission of the reason for Sodom's destruction might be due to typical biblical brevity, but since Lot's advice parallels the angel's instructions, the omission stands out. The omission might be another expression of Lot's ambivalence: whereas he believes the angels and adheres to their instructions, he does not identify with everything they say. Lot hesitates to stand before his sons-in-law and say that the financial prosperity of their city was accompanied by an immoral culture. The textual criticism of Lot is apparent in the reaction of his sons-in-law: "he seemed to his sons-in-law as one who jests" (14). Their rescue would have been based on their connection with Lot, since they are married to Lot's daughters;⁴⁸ Lot's failure to sound convincing indicates that he does not identify with the cause wholeheartedly.⁴⁹ Something in Lot is reluctant to leave town; although he decided to

47 NJPS translated כִּי גְדֻלָּה צַעֲקָתָם: "the outcry against them before the Lord..."

48 The narrative later shows that Lot had daughters who died in Sodom. The angels tell Lot: "Up, take your wife and your two *remaining* daughters" (15), indicating that Lot has daughters who are not with him, presumably the married daughters, married to his previously mentioned sons-in-law (see Abraham Ibn Ezra's commentary on Gen 19:14). Tonson wrote that the daughters who escaped were engaged, not married, to the sons-in-law who refused Lot's advice that they escape the city. This would create symmetry between the fallen: Lot's wife and two sons-in-law; and the rescued: Lot and his two daughters (Tonson 2001, 100, note 7). According to Tonson, each of the people who were saved lost a spouse; this idea provides an interesting background for the following narrative about Lot and his daughters in the cave.

49 Instead of a mere expression of contempt toward Lot, as generally assumed (e.g., Coats 1985, 123).

listen to the angels (whose powers he witnessed when they blinded the townspeople at his door), his doubt is expressed through his children's disbelief.⁵⁰ Essentially, this seems to be the chief function of his son-in-laws in the story: their lack of faith and decision to stay behind mirrors Lot's own doubts.

The description of Lot's narrow escape is filled with complications, which seem to indicate his emotional attachment to the city: "As dawn broke, the angels urged Lot on...Still he delayed. So the men seized his hand, and the hands of his wife and his two daughters – in the Lord's mercy on him – and brought him out and left him outside the city" (15–16). The angels have to urge Lot to escape, but even after they warn him, he continues to delay, and there seems to be no way to get him out of town but by gentle force: the angels literally took Lot by the hand and led him out. This indicates Lot's emotional difficulty in leaving the city.

The exaggerated emphasis on his delay seems symbolic of Lot's ambivalence. The angels urge Lot on by saying "lest you be swept away because of the iniquity of the city." The punishment of the city might apply to Lot, because Lot is a resident of the city and part of its culture. Lot made the decision to lock his door before the people of the city; he made his choice to leave the city, but he made his choices hesitantly and without conviction. The image of the angels grasping the hands of Lot, his wife, and his daughters, and "placing" him outside the city, portrays Lot's family as dependents who require assistance; like a small child who is reluctant to take the correct step, and separate himself from evil. Earlier, the angels "sent their hand" and disengaged Lot from the townspeople (10); now they take him by the hand and remove him from the city.⁵¹

This seems to also be the reason behind the angel's warning not to look back or stop anywhere in the plain: "When they had brought them outside, one said, 'Flee for your life! Do not look behind you, nor stop anywhere in the plain; flee to the hills, lest you be swept

50 Regarding the implementation of this literary technique in the biblical narrative, see Lev-Ran 2009.

51 Tonson 2001; 102–03.

away” (17). Various interpretations were offered for this verse; the most convincing argument seems to be that the directive relates to the need for haste.⁵² The context of the angel’s warning indicates that all instructions relate to the need to hurry without delay. Looking back at the city would slow the pace of escaping from disaster. The chiasmic structure of the angel’s instructions links the two directives.⁵³

- a. Flee (המלט) for your life!
- b. Do not look behind you
- b1 And do not stop anywhere in the plain
- a1 Flee (המלט) to the hills, lest you be swept away!

The angel’s instructions are framed by urgency (“flee for your life!” “lest you be swept away!”),⁵⁴ while the center of the structure specifies two prohibitions: “do not look” and “do not stop.” The structural link indicates that the purpose of both instructions relates to the same objective: escaping from the dangerous area before it is too late. The directive “do not stop” (i.e., delay) stems from the need for haste; the instruction “do not look behind you” should seemingly be viewed in the same light.

However, the severity of the punishment inflicted on Lot’s wife, who looked back and turned into a pillar of salt, necessitates additional explanation of the angel’s warning.⁵⁵ The directive “do not look behind you” should be viewed as a symbolic indication of disengagement from the city. Lot’s position “on the border” of the city necessitates an unequivocal act of physical and emotional separation from the

52 Commentary on Gen 19:17. Rahi later raises Nahmanides’ second possibility as an alternative option.

53 Regarding the structure of the verse, see Mathews 2005, 239–40.

54 Garsiel might be correct in his assertion that the intensive use of the verb המלט (“flee”) integrates a deliberate wordplay with Lot’s name (Garsiel 1991, 155–56). Garsiel believes the wordplay emphasizes Lot’s focus on himself, in contrast with Abraham: “The name emphasizes the thematic conflict between Lot, who saves himself and his family, and Abraham, who saves others.” See also Hamilton 1995, 43.

55 In contrast with von Rad (1963, 222) and Hamilton (1995, 48), who viewed the punishment of Lot’s wife as a reaction to the violation of a direct order.

city. Looking back at the city creates an emotional bond of identification and grief over the destruction; the one who looks back is linked with the city, and is therefore destroyed along with it.

The angel's wording, "flee to the hills, lest you be *swept away*," is reminiscent of Abraham's discussion with God regarding the destruction of Sodom. Abraham uses the expression "swept away" twice in his initial argument against the destruction: "Will You *sweep away* the innocent along with the guilty?...will You *sweep away* the place and not forgive it for the sake of the innocent fifty who are in it?" (18:23–24).⁵⁶ The context implies that the city's punishment might affect Lot despite his innocence; although he is given the opportunity to run, if he delays he might be "swept away" in the fate of the city.

Saving Zoar (18–22)

Lot's request from the angels has two parts (19–20):

1. "You have been so gracious to your servant, and have already shown me so much kindness in order to save my life; but I cannot flee to the hills, lest the disaster overtake me and I die."
2. "Look, that town there is near enough to flee to; it is such a little place! Let me flee there – it is such a little place – and let my life be saved."

Both statements begin with the phrase "Behold,"⁵⁷ and both conclude with matters of life and death – "I die" – "let my life be saved." The greatness of the angel's kindness is contrasted with the diminutive size of the city Lot asks them to save. Initially, Lot focuses on the difficulty of escaping to the mountain ("lest the disaster overtake me and I die,")

⁵⁶ Hamilton 1995, 43.

⁵⁷ The phrase **הנה נא** (commonly translated "behold now") in the Pentateuch is only used in the book of Genesis; out of ten appearances in Genesis, six are incorporated in our narrative (chs. 18–19).

and only later suggests a solution – escaping to the closer small city of Zoar.⁵⁸

The name of the city carries great significance, and Lot mentions the unusual expression **מצער** (*mizʿar* – “small”) twice in his description of the city.⁵⁹ The integration of the explanation lends the narrative an etiological touch: “Hence the town came to be called Zoar.”⁶⁰ The explanation demonstrates that the city owes its continued existence to Lot; had he not requested that the city be spared, it would have been destroyed. The restoration of the city warrants a new name, in honor of Lot.

The Destruction of the Cities (23–26)

Time plays a definitive role in this narrative, highlighting how the plot rapidly unfolds within a single diurnal course. While we will focus on this movement below, it is already worth noting that the sun’s role in the narrative is emphasized. The narrator links the emerging sun with the arrival of Lot in Zoar. Placing the noun (“Lot”) before the verb (“came”) parallels and links Lot with the sun: as the sun “came out” upon the land, Lot “came to” Zoar. Note the correlation of the verbs **צא** (“went out,” in reference to Lot) and **בא** (“came,” in reference to the sun) throughout the text.⁶¹ The time definitions turn the night into

58 Zoar seems to be the endpoint of the Jordan plain, as the verse indicates: “Lot looked about him and saw how well watered was the whole plain of Jordan – all of it...all the way to Zoar” (13:10).

59 The expression denotes something small. Cf. Job 8:7: “Though your beginning be small, in the end you will grow very great.” (Akkadian: *ṣaḫāru*; Ugaritic: *ṣḡr*). See also Isa 63:18; 2 Chron 24:24.

60 Note that as opposed to other texts, the etiological conclusion is not mentioned at the end of the story, but rather at the conclusion of a specific dialogue. The city was previously mentioned by the same name (Gen 13:10; 14:2, 8; see also Deut 34:3).

61 Regarding the combination of **בא** (“come”) and **צא** (“leave”), see *HALOT* 1:113.

a dramatic period, in which the fates of Sodom and Lot are determined.⁶² A similar narrative model is prevalent in the Exodus narrative, which will be expanded on below.

The use of the verb **צא** (“came out”) is unusual in reference to sunrise (19:23), which is usually described with the verb **זרח** (“rose”).⁶³ The word **צא** is one of the keywords of the narrative: Lot “came out” of his house to face the townspeople; the angels urge Lot to “get out” of the city before it is destroyed. The use of the word to describe sunrise attempts to portray the sun as participating in the significant human events of the day.⁶⁴ The verb “came out” does create a more aggressive impression than the word “rose,” as though, in Keel’s words, the sun has come out to attack the earth. The city was attacked by fire and brimstone from the heavens (19:24); to the people it might seem that the sun is sending fiery arrows at the city.⁶⁵ However, the detail is not a component of the original story, as Keel claimed, but rather an integration of the sun into the narrative. It is twice emphasized in the verse that it is God, not another deity or the sun itself, who rains fire: “the Lord rained upon Sodom and Gomorrah sulfurous fire

62 Gunkel (1966, 209–10) claimed that the destruction must occur at night, when the demons come out of hiding; therefore ch. 19 is not sequential to ch. 18, where the angels are active during the day. Hamilton (1995, 46) disagreed, and wrote that if the destruction had occurred at night Abraham would not have seen the smoke from so far away, and that the smoke would have evaporated by morning (“a flame can be seen from a great distance at night, but not smoke”). According to the analysis offered above, the original plan was to destroy Sodom at night; however, the destruction was delayed to enable Lot’s rescue. Therefore, on some level both Gunkel and Hamilton are correct.

63 E.g., Genesis Rabbah 32:32; Ex 22:2; Judg 9:33; 2 Sam 23:4; 2 Kgs 3:22; Mal 3:20; Ps 104:22, among many others.

64 Here, as in many places, the strangeness of the language is not amply expressed in most modern translations, which attempted to ease reading by using the more common term. See, e.g., NJPS: “As the sun rose upon the earth and Lot entered Zoar.”

65 Perhaps the military association is the reason for the choice of the verb **צא** (“came out”) in the description of sunrise by Deborah as well: “But may his friends be as the sun coming out (**כצאה**) in might” (Judg 5:31). See similar descriptions in Ps 19:6 and in Is 13:10.

from the Lord out of heaven” (19:24).⁶⁶ However, God utilizes nature itself to punish Sodom; even the heavenly elements were perturbed by the unnatural ways of the people of Sodom, and the sun, as a result, “came out” to participate in the destruction.

Of the two verses concluding the story, one verse is devoted to the destruction, and the other to the aftermath.⁶⁷ Hamilton noted that this is the third time in the book of Genesis that refers to God as the giver of rain.⁶⁸ The first reference described the earth’s inability to grow, because “the Lord God had not sent rain upon the earth” (Gen 2:5). The second described the flood rains that will destroy the entire world: “In seven days’ time I will make it rain upon the earth, forty days and forty nights” (Gen 7:4). The Sodom narrative correlates with the inability of the earth to grow. All three verses – the exposition that describes the world before it is put in order (2:5); the destruction of the world in the flood, and the scorching of the earth by Sodom – relate to the restoration and re-creation of the world. The Sodom narrative creates a dialogue with the other two, indicating that here, too, God intervened and returned the state of pre-creation.⁶⁹ Since Sodom and Gomorrah will not be restored, it

66 The repetition is not the result of “two different descriptions of God’s judgment [that] have merged” (Westermann 1995, 306), but rather stems from the significance of the fact that Sodom was destroyed by the hand of God. The biblical narrative often uses repetition as a means of resonating the main theme of the story.

67 The verb *הִכָּה* (“annihilated”) is only mentioned in v. 25, while in v. 24 the verb used is *הִמְטִיר* (“rained”); however, this is not evidence of diverse sources (Dillmann 1897, 274), but rather of the act and results of destruction. See also Westermann 1995, 307, who wrote that attributing the destruction to an earthquake negates the description of fire and brimstone from the heavens; annihilation indicates nothing less than total destruction, or catastrophe.

68 Hamilton 1995, 47.

69 Many scholars noted the links between Sodom and the flood. See, among others, Lods 1927, 211–15 (the link left a strong impression on him, leading him to suggest that Sodom is a rewrite of the flood); Wenham (1991, 108–09) used the link to prove the harmony of the narrative and note problems in the documentary hypothesis; Turner (1990, 96–98) believed the text contrasts Lot’s mediocrity with Noah’s righteousness; Zakovitch (1995, 48) compared the sexual motif in the Sodom narrative with the sexual sin of the divine beings and the human daughters that prefaces the flood, and the sin of Canaan in the epilogue of the flood (Gen 6:1–4; 9:20–27).

will remain desolate and uninhabitable, as though it is no longer part of the world. For this reason the consequences of the destruction are not limited to the cities and people, but also affect the “vegetation of the ground.” This completes the annihilation of land, man, and vegetation, all of which cease to exist in that place.

There seems to also be a correlation between crime and punishment, in the “measure for measure” model. When Lot chose Sodom, he did so because of the abundance of the land. The text emphasized the fact that the plain is “well watered,” and compares Sodom both to Egypt and to the Garden of Eden (13:3). Apparently, the abundance and fertility of the land were the foundations for a society that had no need for others, and in turn refused to assist others. Turning the place into a barren, parched wasteland is in fact “turning” a blessing into a curse. The Sodomites had had an abundance of water; God made it rain fire. The people who would not allow guests to rest on their turf would lose that turf altogether, never to be rebuilt, and lose themselves in the process.

The details relating to the fate of Lot’s wife are succinct and confusing: “Lot’s wife looked back, and she thereupon turned into a pillar of salt” (19:26). The nature of the wife’s sin and the significance of her punishment are omitted from the text. Some medieval commentators suggested that Lot’s wife did not, in fact, become a pillar of salt; rather, the phrase describes what Lot’s wife saw: she looked back at the city, and saw that the city had become a pillar of salt.⁷⁰ However, the angel’s warning to Lot specifically warned him against “looking back”; since Lot’s wife “looked back,” the reader anticipates some form of consequence. This reading was generally accepted: Josephus attested to having seen the pillar of salt that was Lot’s wife,⁷¹ while in rabbinic literature a special blessing was written for one who views the pillar (*b. Berakhot* 54a-b). However, the dilemma highlights another interesting omission in the narrative, which fails to describe the city turning into salt. This motif is mentioned in Deut 29:22, where God warns the

70 Levi ben Gershom (Rabag), commentary on Gen 19:26. He believed Lot’s wife was “swept away” with the Sodomites. The innovation in his commentary is that the events in the verse are described from the perspective of Lot’s wife.

71 Josephus, *Antiquities* I:203 (Feldman 2000, 77).

Children of Israel that their land might turn into one devastated by sulfur and salt, and compares the devastation to Sodom and Gomorrah.⁷² The absence of this detail was particularly upsetting to the etiological approach, which viewed the narrative as an explanation of the fact that Sodom is filled with salts and minerals.⁷³ However, the literary school is also affected by the absence of the salt, since Lot's wife, whose fate is linked with the city, turns into a pillar of salt, while the city is not explicitly salted. For some reason, the motif of salt penetrates the story through Lot's wife; through her description, the reader is invited to consider the fate of the city itself. The connection between Sodom and Lot's wife is related to her actual punishment.

As well as slowing the pace, the act of looking back creates identification with the city. When Lot's wife looks back, she comments on her difficulty in leaving her home; she still feels like part of Sodom. Coats named the fate of Lot's wife "a tragicomedy": the people who were chosen to be rescued from the city cannot leave, and have to be removed forcefully (19:15–16), and even after they have left one character cannot disengage from the city.⁷⁴ Perhaps the identification with the city can shed light on the severity of the punishment. A metamorphosis to salt is rare in biblical literature, and was perhaps utilized here to express that Lot's wife was affected by the punishment of Sodom. The sulfur that rained upon the city and turned the area into a barren wasteland caught up with Lot's wife as she looked back, and she, too, was punished with infertility and death. The contrast with the blessing of fertility given to Sarah at the beginning of the narrative is apparent, and will be discussed further below.

Some scholars claim that the fate of Lot's wife is mentioned in the wrong place, and that v. 26 (which describes her punishment) should be read after v. 17, in which the angel warned Lot not to look back at the

72 Salting a city was common practice among conquerors who wanted the destruction to be irreversible, and turned the place into an eternal wasteland (e.g., Abimelech in Shechem – Judg 9:45). A salted land can never regrow crops. See Sarna 1989, 138. Cf. Gevirtz 1963, who suggested that the salting was an act of purification before the place was sanctified in God's name.

73 Gunkel 1967, xxi.

74 Coats 1983, 144–45.

city. According to this reading the verse should be read as an appendix to the main story.⁷⁵ The story of Lot's wife returns to Lot's personal family, after they were abandoned by the narrator, who focused instead on the destruction of Sodom. However, the verse is written from the viewpoint of Lot's wife as she witnesses the destruction; clearly the verse can only appear after the city is destroyed.⁷⁶ Nonetheless, there is literary value in the placement of Lot's wife at the end of the story. Two people view the destroyed city after the fact: Lot's wife and Abraham.⁷⁷ Abraham looks down at the city as one who identifies with God's evaluation and judgment of the city, while Lot's wife identifies with the city. By looking back, she expresses her affiliation with the city, and will therefore share the fate of its people.

First Conclusion (27–28)

The narrative concludes with the description of Abraham returning to the place from where the angels had looked down on Sodom; the place in which the discussion about the fate of Sodom was conducted: "Next morning, Abraham hurried to the place where he had stood before the Lord, and, looking down toward Sodom and Gomorrah and all the land of the Plain, he saw the steam of the land rising like the smoke of a kiln" (27–28). The verse attributes a significant role to Abraham in the destruction of the city, despite the fact that he did not take any active part. Some commentators were troubled by the phrase "all the land of the Plain," since the area throughout the text is referred to as "the plain"

75 Holzinger 1898, 156; Westermann 1995, 307. Gunkel (1997, 214–15) wrote that Lot's wife was added to the text at a later stage; however, Lot's wife seems to have a significant literary role, both in the reflection of Lot in his family, and in the analogy to the angels in Abraham's tent.

76 Compare with Lyons 2002, 245.

77 Von Rad 1963, 216.

or “the cities of the plain (or the Jordan plain in ch. 13).⁷⁸ Perhaps the alteration means to emphasize the magnitude of destruction.⁷⁹ The word “land” frequently denotes “area” (e.g., Gen 22:2; 24:62); the verse therefore describes Abraham looking down on the entire area of the Jordan plain, not only at the cities that were destroyed.

The “looking down” (השקפה) motif with regard to the demise of evildoers is implemented in the death of the Egyptians in the Red Sea:

At the morning watch, the Lord looked down (וישקף) upon the Egyptian army from a pillar of fire and cloud, and threw the Egyptian army into a panic (Ex 14:24).

The Egyptians were “thrown into a panic” as a result of God “looking down” upon them. This ambiguous action took place before the Egyptians drowned in the sea. God looked down on the Egyptians in the process of their destruction, while Abraham looked down on Sodom after it was destroyed. God and Abraham agreed on the terms of the fate of the city; as a result, God destroyed Sodom, and Abraham “looked down” upon the city. The phrase is an expression of Abraham’s partnership with God.

In this light, we can return to the centrality of the function that time plays in the story and how it hints to cooperation between Abraham and God: the narrative opened with Abraham sitting at the entrance to his tent “at the heat of the day”; the angels came to Sodom “in the evening”; the angels urged Lot to leave “as dawn broke”; God rained fire on the cities when “the sun came out.” Finally, the narrative concludes with a description of the time in reference to Abraham, who began the cycle: “Next morning, Abraham hurried...”⁸⁰ The chronological sequence of the story weaves Abraham’s actions into those of God and His angels.⁸¹

78 Ball omitted the word “land” for this reason (Ball 1896, 71. See also Gunkel 1997, 212).

79 Regarding deliberate misuse of idioms in the biblical narrative as a literary tool, see Grossman 2008; Grossman 2015 – Text and Subtext, 153–181.

80 Cf. Gunkel 1997, 212.

81 The comparison of the steam rising from the city to “smoke of a kiln” is used in Sinai: when God appeared in the image of fire on the mountain, “the smoke

The verse deliberately avoids relating to the souls of the characters. What was Abraham feeling when he watched the smoke rising from what was once a great city? Apparently there were not even ten righteous people in the whole area, and an entire region was lost. What fate did Abraham assume became his nephew? No reunion is reported between Abraham and Lot; in fact the two characters do not meet on the literary plane after Abraham rescues Lot in ch. 14. The literary gap can be filled with various feelings (anger? bitterness? reconciliation?); the choice of silence upholds the detachment between the characters. Lot will not be Abraham's heir or successor.

Second Conclusion (19:29)

The first conclusion had described Abraham looking down on Sodom and viewing the aftermath of the destruction; the second conclusion describes God's mindfulness of Abraham, which is the reason He had rescued one of the residents of Sodom. The verse is designed in a chiastic structure:

Thus it was that when *God annihilated* the cities of the Plain,⁸²
God was mindful of *Abraham*

rose like the smoke of a kiln" (Ex 19:18). The fire and brimstone of Sodom left a scorched and smoky land. Note that the focus of the verse continues to refer directly to the land: "he saw the steam *of the land* rising like the smoke of a kiln." Smoke is often mentioned in the context of the destruction of a city (Josh 8:20–21; Is 9:17); the use of the word קיטור ("steam") is an interesting deviation. Mathews noted that in the sacrificial world smoke relates to incense, and the verb להקטיר (from the root קטר, which is used in this verse) is used to describe the act of offering incense (Mathews 2005, 242 note 467). Perhaps there is an attempt to link Sodom's fate with sacrificial concepts.

82 השחית denotes complete and total destruction, while הפך literally denotes "turned over" or "reversed," and is used in various biblical contexts connoting an upheaval or destruction. NJPS translated the former "destroyed" and the latter "annihilated" based on the context; however, regardless of the fact that

and removed *Lot* from the midst of the upheaval
when He *turned* the cities where *Lot* dwelt.⁸³

The link between the two parts of the verse is apparent: the frame of the statement reveals that God destroyed Sodom, while the central content describes His kindness toward Abraham and Lot. But there is also a distinction in the focus of each part: the first half of the verse emphasizes God (who destroys and remembers) while the second half emphasizes Lot (who is sent away from the city). Two different verbs describe the destruction of the city: *השחית* (“annihilated”) and *הפך* (“turned”). The two parts also distinguish between the cities that were destroyed, which are initially referred to as “the cities of the plain,” and later as “the cities where Lot dwelt.”⁸⁴ These differences correlate with the two focal points of the verse. The term *השחית* (“annihilated”) is extremely harsh, and expresses total obliteration. The second half of the verse, which describes Lot’s rescue, uses a “gentler” verb – *הפך* – which expresses the substitution of one situation for another (e.g., Ex 7:15; 7:17 and 20; 14:5; Lev 13:3–4; Deut 23:6). A single person can be saved from an upheaval (*הפיכה*), but not from annihilation (*השחיתה*).⁸⁵ The third difference correlates with the purpose of the first two: when the subject of the verse was annihilation, the cities of the plain were a geographical datum, but when the text shifts its attention to Lot, the cities are also described from his perspective: they are his home. The Sodomites view Lot as a temporary resident and provide excellent references for his rescue: they do not see him as one of their own. The term “dwelt” that describes Lot’s relationship with the city revisits the question of Lot’s merit. Does Lot

the meaning of the two words is the same in the verse, the first Hebrew term should be harsher than its counterpart.

83 NJPS reversed the order of the verse: “Thus it was that, when God destroyed the cities of the Plain and annihilated the cities where Lot dwelt, God was mindful of Abraham and removed Lot from the midst of the upheaval.”

84 The second part of the verse has an internal chiasmic structure of its own: “and removed *Lot* from the midst of the upheaval (*הפיכה*). when He *annihilated* (*בהפך*) the cities where *Lot* dwelt.”

85 See Chisholm, *הפך*; Kaddari 2006, 224–25.

really stand apart from the residents of Sodom? The word יָשַׁב (“settled/dwelt”) was a keyword in the narrative describing Abraham’s separation from Lot.⁸⁶ The text there was implicitly critical of Lot when he chose to “dwell” in Sodom, where the people were “very wicked sinners against the Lord,” when he separated from Abraham (Gen 13:12).

Additionally, Wenham noted that the statement “God was mindful of Abraham” is reminiscent of another case of destruction and mindfulness: “God was mindful of Noah” (Gen 8:1).⁸⁷ In the Noah narrative, God remembers the person He saves, whereas in Lot’s case God is mindful not of Lot, but of Abraham.⁸⁸ This detail highlights the main message conveyed by the verse: Lot is not saved by his own merit but by the merit of his uncle. Perhaps the fact that Abraham is mentioned (instead of Lot, who parallels Noah in the story) is the reason that the destruction is reiterated in the verse (“when God *destroyed* the cities of the Plain”) using the verb שָׁחַת, which described the destruction of the earth in the flood (Gen 6:17; 9:11–15). This way the reader, who is reminded of the flood and Noah’s rescue, becomes more mindful of the surprise of God remembering Abraham instead of Lot.⁸⁹

Why was Lot Saved from Sodom?

Does v. 29 reveal the true reason of Lot’s redemption? According to this verse Lot was saved on Abraham’s merit alone, but the verse is not

86 Mathews 2005, 243.

87 NJPS translated וַיִּזְכֹּר – “mindful” in Gen 19:29, and “remembered” in Gen 8:1.

88 Wenham 1994, 59. He claims that this refers to Abraham’s prayer in ch. 18, which brings about Lot’s salvation (59–60). In my opinion, Lyons is correct that the phrase refers to “ancestral merit” in a more general sense (Lyons 2000, 203–06; 249–50).

89 However, it is noteworthy that the verb שָׁחַת was also integrated into the narrative about the angels in Sodom (19:13; see also 13:10).

an integral part of the narrative, but rather inserted as an addendum.⁹⁰ The supplementation is apparent in two parameters:

- a. According to the concentric structure of the narrative mentioned above, verse 29 is outside the story. The narrative has a solid frame in the parallel scenes at the beginning and end of the story: before the angels depart from Abraham they “look down” at Sodom (18:16), and after the destruction Abraham “looks down” at the destroyed plain (19:27–28). Verse 29 remains outside these boundaries.
- b. The verse stands apart from the narrative in the name used to describe God. The name YHWH is used consistently throughout the narrative (from the beginning of ch. 18), while v. 29 calls God by the name “Elohim.” Verse 29 should therefore be seen as outside the general sequence of the narrative.⁹¹

The separation of this verse encourages an additional look at the reason behind Lot’s rescue. Throughout the story Lot was required to decide on which side of the door he belongs: does he identify with the culture of Sodom, or did he build a home that is separated from the culture of the city? Lot needed the angels to physically pull him into the house, and then urge him out of the city; however, there is no question that his hospitality toward the angels and attempt to rescue his guests portray Lot as charitable and separate from the culture of the city. The analogy between Lot’s hospitality and that of Abraham, Lot’s insistence that the angels come and stay with him, and his self-sacrifice in attempting to protect them all portray Lot as one who is worthy of being saved by his

90 Dillmann 1897, 112, viewed the verse as the first of two addendums – v. 29 and the narrative about Lot and his daughters in a cave.

91 The documentary school associates v. 29 with P, based on three parameters: the verb שחית (“annihilated”); the phrase “the cities of the plain”; and the allusion to God’s memory. See Skinner 1930, 306; von Rad 1963, 217; Westermann 1995, 308; Gunkel 1997, 258–59. Kraetzschmar noted that in prophetic literature a phrase is used that integrates the name Elohim with the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah: “As when Elohim destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah” (Am 4:11; Is 13:19; Jer 50:40). This indicates that the prophets viewed the verse as part of the narrative (Kraetzschmar 1897, 87–88).

own merit.⁹² Westermann noted that Lot's rescue is described in greater detail than the destruction, which is narrated in only two verses.⁹³ The rhythm of the narrative and the emphasis on Lot's attempt to save his guests demonstrate that Lot's rescue is not obvious, and not necessary, but a result of the way he treats his guests.

If so, then two reasons for Lot's rescue are described in the text. Throughout the narrative, Lot's hospitality and the protection of his guests are described as the reason for his rescue. There is no need for the correlation to be explicit; Lot's actions speak for themselves. In the concluding verse, however, another viewpoint attributes Lot's rescue to God's mindfulness of Abraham; here Lot was saved because of Abraham's merit.

This duality sheds new light on the ambivalence of Lot's character throughout the narrative. There is clear sympathy with Lot, but there are also indications that Lot is more connected with the culture of Sodom than it seems. The most obvious indication is Lot's willingness to offer his daughters to the lascivious mob outside his house; however, his delays in leaving the city also express his hesitation toward disengaging from the city, and so does his lack of ability to convince his sons-in-law. From this perspective, Lot's wife plays a key role in the narrative. The text offers no background on the wife; her origins, Sodomite or otherwise, are unknown.⁹⁴ But the fact that she is swept away in the destruction of the city indicates that she is ultimately judged as a Sodomite. Lot's wife failed to sever her emotional and ethical ties with the city. The angels took her out of the city but could not take the culture of the city out of her. Lot's sons-in-law might be an expression of Lot's ambiguity; his wife's fate is certainly a manifestation of his doubts.

92 Many scholars consider the analogy to Abraham as a credit to Lot (among others, Skinner 1930, 307; Morgenstern 1965, 126; Schmidt 1976, 141; Vawter 1977, 235–36; Alexander 1985; Clements 1985, 20; Ben Zvi 1992, 42; Matthews 1992, 6; Wenham 1994, 55–56; Rashkow 1998, 106–07). See also Lyons 2002, 219–22.

93 Westermann 1995, 299.

94 See, among others, Dillmann 1897, 113–14, who believed she was not a Sodomite, since Lot was described as master of a household with possessions in ch. 13, and was likely married.

The incident of Lot's wife completes the analogy between Lot and Abraham. As previously mentioned, the angels' visit to Lot (19) and to Abraham (18) are described in similar terms.⁹⁵ The comparison relates, among other things, to the protagonists' wives:

| | <i>Abraham</i> | <i>Lot</i> |
|--------------------|---|--|
| Meeting the Angels | The Lord appeared to him by the terebinths of Mamre; <i>he was sitting at the entrance of the tent in the heat of the day.</i> | The two angels arrived in Sodom <i>in the evening</i> , as <i>Lot was sitting in the gate of Sodom.</i> |
| | Looking up, he <i>saw</i> three men standing near him. <i>As soon as he saw them, he ran from the entrance of the tent to greet them and bowed to the ground.</i> | <i>When Lot saw them, he rose to greet them and bowed low with his face to the ground.</i> |
| | <i>he said, My lords, if it please you, do not go on past your servant</i>
Let a little water be brought; bathe your feet
and <i>recline under the tree...</i>

and let me fetch a morsel of bread that you may refresh yourselves;
<i>then go on –</i>
seeing that you have come your servant's way. | <i>he said, Please, my lords, turn aside to your servant's house</i>

<i>to spend the night, and bathe your feet...</i>

<i>then you may be on your way early.</i> |
| | They replied, Do as you have said. | But they said, “No, we will spend the night in the square
But he urged them strongly, so they turned his way and entered his house. |

95 See Van Seters 1975, 215–16, who noted 17 parallels between the narratives; Kilian 1966, 150–51; Culley 1976, 54–55; Letellier 1995, 39–41; Lyons 2002, 218; Rendsburg 1986, 49. Rendsburg noted the motifs of “entrance” and the similarity of the minor characters in the two narratives. Hamilton 1995, 30, added the wordplay with the verb יָרָא. The solid link between the two scenes proves that the stories are not completely separate as stated by Kilian (1970 – Überlieferungsgeschichte) and Noth (1948, 151–54).

| | <i>Abraham</i> | <i>Lot</i> |
|--------------------|---|---|
| Preparing the Meal | Abraham hastened into the tent to Sarah, and said, Quick, three seahs of choice flour! Knead and make cakes... Then Abraham ran to the herd, took a calf, tender and choice, and gave it to a servant-boy, who hastened to prepare it. He took curds and milk and the calf that had been prepared and set these before them; and he waited on them under the tree as they ate | He prepared a feast for them and baked unleavened bread,

and they ate. |
| Identity | They said to him,

<i>Where is your wife Sarah?</i>

And he replied,
There, in the tent. | And they shouted to Lot and said to him,
<i>Where are the men who came to you tonight?</i> Bring them out to us, that we may be intimate with them.... Look, I have two daughters who have not known a man. Let me bring them out to you, and you may do to them as you please. |
| Tidings | Then one said, I will return to you next year, and your wife Sarah shall have a son! Sarah was listening at the entrance of the tent, which was <i>behind</i> him | Then the men said to Lot, Whom else have you here? Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters, or anyone else that you have in the city – bring them out of the place. For we are about to destroy this place; because the outcry against them before the Lord has become so great that the Lord has sent us to destroy it. |
| Doubt | And Sarah laughed to herself, saying, Now that I am withered, am I to have enjoyment – with my husband so old? | But he seemed to his sons-in-law as one who jests |
| Fate of the Wife | I will return to you at the time next year, and Sarah shall have a son. | Lot's wife looked back, and she thereupon turned into a pillar of salt. |

| | <i>Abraham</i> | <i>Lot</i> |
|------------|---|---|
| Conclusion | The men set out from there and looked down toward Sodom, Abraham walking with them to see them off. | Next morning, Abraham hurried to the place where he had stood before the Lord, and, looking down toward Sodom and Gomorrah and all the land of the Plain, he saw the steam of the land rising like the smoke of a kiln. |

Based on this analogy, some scholars have claimed that Lot's character pales in comparison with Abraham.⁹⁶ Some of the gaps between the two descriptions, however, are unrelated to the evaluation of the characters, but rather to the different situations. Lot baked unleavened bread instead of preparing meat because the angels arrived in Sodom in the evening; meat is not customarily prepared for the evening meal, and cattle cannot be slaughtered after dark. Unleavened bread is an appropriate food for an evening meal because it is quick to prepare. The timing is also the reason behind Lot's suggestion that the angels "spend the night," which is absent from Abraham's hospitality. Other delicate differences make Abraham's hospitality stand out. Whereas Lot "rose to greet" the angels, Abraham "ran from the entrance" of his tent. This is the first of many expressions of enthusiastic haste in Abraham's hospitality, which are absent from Lot's treatment. Although this might be an indication that Abraham surpasses Lot in the treatment of guests, Lot's respect toward the angels exceeds Abraham's, since Lot "bowed low with his face to the ground," while Abraham "bowed to the ground."⁹⁷

The delicate differences above show that the similarity is greater than the contrast. The main distinction, of course, is the content of the angels' tidings: whereas Sarah received a message of life and fertility,

96 Some, however, read this comparison as implicit criticism of Lot (Keil and Delitzsch 1980, 233; Coats 1983, 141, 143; Waltke 1984, 265–81; Turner 1990, 94–95; Gossai 1995, 76–81).

97 Cf. Speiser 1964, 143, who wrote that in contrast with Abraham, Lot is portrayed as groveling before his guests. I believe this comment is incorrect.

Lot was given an omen of death and destruction. But therein lies the similarity: Abraham was awarded a son as a reward for his generosity toward strangers, and Lot was offered his own life in recognition of his hospitality. But whereas Abraham involved Sarah in his kind hospitality, and Sarah cooperated fully with her husband, out of her devotion to the values they both held true, Lot's wife is entirely absent from the interaction with the guests.⁹⁸ This detail stands out because of the comparison above; in light of the fate of Lot's wife, it is reasonable to assume that her lack of participation in Lot's hospitality is deliberate. Sarah, who shares her husband's generosity, merits a blessing of fertility. Lot's wife, who fails to identify with his values, is cursed with salt. Salt is antithetical to fertility, as a salted land loses its vitality and can never grow (Judges 9:45).⁹⁹

In the context of the narrative, the women cannot be separated from their husbands. Abraham is praised in the text for sharing his values with his household; Abraham and Sarah are partners in their good deeds, and the servants also participate. Abraham is portrayed as a patriarch who "instructs his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord," not only by setting a personal example of kindness toward strangers, but by expecting the entire household to participate. In contrast, although Lot's kindness and hospitality is indisputable, it remains a personal quality, rather than a shared value and a household philosophy. Lot's sons-in-law mock his ideas; his wife is part of the Sodomite culture, instead of a daughter of the house of Abraham. The reader will meet Lot's daughters in the following episode, and they will be portrayed in a Sodomite light. Lot's family might be a representation of part of his own psyche: they could represent his repressed pull toward Sodom and all that it represents.

The ambivalent portrayal of Lot serves two purposes. The first relates to the question of Abraham's continuity; the second relates to Lot's rescue. As long as Abraham has no heir, Lot will be portrayed

98 Gossai 1995, 80–81, contra Lyons 2000, 218, who believes that "He, or as with Abraham, more likely his female family... hurriedly bakes unleavened bread."

99 See further: Ps 107:34; Jer 17:6; Zeph 2:9; Hamilton, מלח. Compare with Gray 1967, 325; Block 1999, 330.

as an alternative to his son. Throughout the Abraham cycle Lot is depicted as an elusive part of Abraham's household. After the separation in ch. 13, Abraham saves Lot in ch. 14 and the question of inheritance is revisited. The Sodom narrative portrays Lot as a successor to Abraham's values: he invites guests to his home, feeds them, and defends them, but his lack of ability to instruct his family in the ways of Abraham negates his ability to be a true heir.¹⁰⁰

The double narrative of Lot's rescue becomes a model of two different types of biblical narratives relating to redemption: redemption based on hospitality and kindness, and redemption based on the merit of the forefathers.

Lot's Liberation from Sodom and Israel's Deliverance from Egypt

Following the midrash, Rashi noted the unleavened bread that Lot had baked for his guests, and commented on Gen 19:3: "He baked unleavened bread – for it was Passover." The idea is based not only on the reality of eating unleavened bread, which is so heavily associated with the Exodus, but also with the exact phrase *וּמַצֹּת*, which appears only in these two narratives (Gen 19:3; Ex 12:8).¹⁰¹ Later scholars expanded the core idea to a broader analogy between the two redemptions.¹⁰² Both narratives attribute a unique role to the entrance as an indication of those worthy of saving; festive meals are conducted in both instances on the night before the redemption; both meals included unleavened bread; and a "destructive" angel features in both stories. On a linguistic plane, Pharaoh's command in Ex 12:31, "Up, depart from among my people," bears a striking similarity to Lot's advice to his sons-in-law in Gen 19:14, "Up, get out of this place." The need for haste, and in this

100 Cf. Turner 1990.

101 However, see also: Judg 6:19–21; 1 Sam 28:24.

102 Bin Nun 2005; Hepner 2010, 171–87.

context the use of the uncommon root *מהמה* (“delay”), is also emphasized on both occasions: “Still he delayed (*וַיִּתְּמַקֶּה*). So the men seized his hand...and brought him out and left him outside the city” (Gen 19:16); “And they baked unleavened cakes of dough that they had taken out of Egypt...since they had been driven out of Egypt and could not delay (*לֹהֲתַמְקֶה*). The “smiting” of the Sodomites – first with blindness and later with death – is of course reminiscent of the plagues on Egypt. It is noteworthy that the analogy between Sodom and Egypt was created at an earlier stage, when Lot chose to disengage from Abram and go to Sodom (13:10). The similarity between Lot’s escape from Sodom and the exodus from Egypt is therefore not surprising.

Lot’s Liberation from Sodom and Rahab’s Rescue from Jericho

The two spies sent by Joshua, who come to Jericho and are hosted in Rahab’s house (Josh 6), are called “angels,” just as the two angels who come to Sodom and are hosted in Lot’s house are called “people.”¹⁰³ Just as the Sodomites asked Lot to bring out his guests, so too the King of Jericho orders Rahab, “produce the men who came to you and entered your house” (Josh 2:2–3). In both cases the hosts protected their guests and failed to surrender them on demand, while risking their own lives to protect them. The similar wording supports this analogy: Yair Zakovitch noted that the expression *טָרַם יִשְׁכַּבּוּ* (“they had not yet lain down”) appears only in these two biblical texts (Gen 19:4; Josh 2:8).¹⁰⁴ Additionally, the verbs *יָדַע* (“know”) and *בּוֹא* (“come”) are used intensively in both narratives, with interchangeable

103 Regarding this analogy, see Langlame 1971 (17 linguistic links between the stories!); Hawk 1992; Zakovitch 1995, 83–86; Nelson 1997, 43–44; Reis 2000, 124–32.

104 Zakovitch 1995, 83–84.

sexual and non-sexual connotations.¹⁰⁵ The “closing of the gate” in Josh 2:7 is phrased similarly to the “closing of the door” in Gen 19:10; and Rahab’s advice to the spies, “make for *the hills*, lest the pursuers come upon you” (Josh 2:16) is reminiscent of the angels’ advice to Lot: “flee to *the hills*, lest you be swept away” (Gen 19:17).¹⁰⁶

Various interpretations have been offered for the analogy, including the positive evaluation of the spies, who are compared to God’s angels, and the negative evaluation of Jericho, which is compared with Sodom, perhaps as divine justification for the destruction of the city. Alternatively, Zakovitch noted the irony of the need for Joshua’s spies to rely on a prostitute to save them; in other words, the analogy can also indicate the gap between the two situations and the implied criticism of the spies.¹⁰⁷

For the purpose of this discussion, I would like to recall the double Lot narratives, which enable the analogy with each of the narratives. All three stories describe the liberation of a single house within an entire city that faces destruction or severe punishment.¹⁰⁸ There is, of course, a great difference between the redemption of the nation of Israel from Egypt, which is part of a broad divine plan delivered in Gen 15, and the rescue of Rahab. Israelite history goes through a fundamental and dramatic change on the night of the Exodus; their redemption is not described as reward for good deeds, but rather as a result of the merit of their forefathers, specifically the covenant between God and Abraham: “God remembered His covenant with Abraham and Isaac and Jacob” (Ex 2:24); “I have remembered my covenant” (Ex 6:5).¹⁰⁹ The links to the Lot narrative relate to the element of the merit

105 Grossman 2015 – Text and Subtext, 360–4.

106 Note the reverse analogy: God’s angels are compared with Rahab, instead of Joshua’s spies. The reader of the Rahab narrative has to ask, who is protecting whom? This point supports Zakovitch’s analogy.

107 See Zakovitch 1990. Reis suggested a more delicate and complex criticism of Joshua’s spies (Reis 2000, 124–32).

108 The Exodus and the capture of Jericho include an explicit date. Regarding the date of the destruction of Sodom, see Genesis Rabbah 50:12.

109 The reason for the Exodus from Egypt is more complex. Two different reasons are stated in the two prophetic inaugurations of Moses: the merit of the

of the patriarchs, since Lot's rescue was also attributed to Abraham's merit (Gen 19:29). On the other hand, the link to Rahab highlights the second reason for Lot's rescue: Rahab is saved not because of a divine plan but because of her actions. Rahab endangered her life to protect the spies, and they repaid her appropriately by sparing her life when the city was destroyed. Lot was rescued due to Abraham's merit, but also, in spite of God's plan, due to his own actions. Lot endangered his life to protect the angels, and they in turn protected him when the city was destroyed.

The double narratives might be viewed as a continuation of the double tidings of Isaac's birth in chs. 17–18. As earlier noted, the birth of Isaac in ch. 17 relates to the implementation of God's plan, while the tidings in ch. 18 portray Isaac's birth as a personal reward to Abraham and Sarah for their hospitality. Similarly, Lot was rescued from Sodom as part of the selection of Abraham (expressed in the text by the name *Elohim*), but also due to his own actions (expressed in the text by the name *YHWH*).

Although the text separates the two reasons for Lot's redemption, they seem to be linked. The narrative that relates Lot's actions indicates a criticism of Lot; this enables a consistent reading in the final verses, which say that Lot was rescued by the merit of his uncle. But since Lot's hospitality is comparable to Abraham's, the reader is left with the impression that Lot has learned the ways of his uncle. This is not a literary analogy but an actual influence of one character on another. Rashi commented on the verse describing Lot sitting at the gate: "he learned from the house of Abraham to seek guests."¹¹⁰ Abraham's merit is apparent in the conduct that he passes on to his nephew. Perhaps v. 29 indicates that although Lot is saved by Abraham's merit, Lot has to be worthy of saving, and he proves his worth by emulating the ways of Abraham.

forefathers and the unjust suffering of the nation. However, addressing the injustice done to the Hebrews is unlike Lot creating his own merit.

110 Rashi on Gen 19:1. See also *Genesis Rabbah* 50:4.

Chapter 12: Lot and his Daughters in the Cave (19:30–38)

The story of Lot's daughters should be analyzed on three levels: (1) the design of the independent story, and particularly the evaluation of the characters; (2) in relation to Lot's escape from Sodom; and (3) the incorporation of the narrative in the Abraham cycle, particularly as a continuation of previous scenes relating to the relationship between Abraham and Lot.¹

The story can be read independently of the textual context, a fact that led Gunkel and others to claim that "the legend is ethnological in nature. It deals with the origin of the peoples of Moab and Ammon, Lot's sons."² Moreover, Gunkel believed the development of the two nations from a drunken act reflects the Moabite culture, which is broadly linked with vineyards (Is 16:7 ff.; Jer 48:11 and 32 ff.).³ Gunkel viewed the story as a mockery of the culture of Ammon and Moab. This scorn is reflected in Deut 32:32: "Their vine is from Sodom, from the vineyards of Gomorrah; the grapes for them are poison, a bitter growth their clusters." The enemy described in this verse is Ammon and Moab, who dwell near Sodom and Gomorrah.⁴

However, the narrative materials are deeply rooted in the broader context of the destruction of Sodom, as we will discuss in the chapter's conclusion.

1 Tzohar (2008, 65) suggested an additional plane, "which discusses the nations Ammon and Moab later in history."

2 Gunkel 1997, 216.

3 Lyons 2002, 252–53.

4 Gunkel 1997, 216–17. From a structural perspective the scene was analyzed both independently and in relation to other seduction stories (Fisch 1977).

Evaluation of the Characters

Our analysis of the narrative will focus primarily on the evaluation of the characters. Von Rad, Coats, and many others have stated appropriately that the evaluation of Lot's daughters in the cave (Gen19:30–38) is complex. Some scholars have argued that there is no apparent evaluation of Lot or his daughters in the narrative, and that this absence enables a diverse range of interpretations.⁵

The opening verse (19:30) serves both as an exposition to the story and a transitional clause between Lot's escape to Zoar and the occurrence in the cave. The verse comprises two parallel statements:

| | |
|--------------------------------------|--|
| Lot went up from Zoar | for he was afraid to dwell in Zoar |
| and settled in the hill ⁶ | and he settled in a cave |
| with his two daughters | him and his two daughters ⁷ |

The first half of both parts of the verse describes Lot's retreat from Zoar. The initial delivery of this detail is neutral: Lot "went up" from Zoar, while the second part of the verse states a reason: Lot "was afraid to dwell in Zoar."⁸ Both parts of the verse then describe Lot's new location: the first half of the verse describes Lot settling "in the hill," the second part "in a cave."⁹ The final clause in each part describes the characters, emphasizing the fact that Lot's daughters are with their father in the cave on the hill.

Despite the obvious correlation between the two parts of the verse, each part is accompanied by an entirely different atmosphere. The first part delivers the information drily and neutrally: Lot traveled

5 Von Rad 1963, 218; Coats 1983, 147; Exum 1986; Bruckner 2001, 83.

6 NJPS translated "in the hill country."

7 NJPS translated: "and he and his two daughters lived in a cave."

8 Regarding the timing of Lot's escape from Sodom in relation to the destruction of the other cities, see Lyons 2002, 250–51.

9 Dillmann (1897, 114) assumed the cave was a later addition, due to the incongruence with the earlier description of the mountain location; however, there is no real contradiction between the two locations.

from Zoar and settled on the hill with his two daughters. The second part essentially repeats the same information, but the details are accompanied by intense emotion. Lot's desire to leave the area of Zoar stemmed from panicked distress; Lot did not settle in the comfort and abundance of a mountainside, he hid in a dark cave.¹⁰ Cave-dwellers escape the reality outside a cave, but are also susceptible to dangers from within. Other biblical stories involving caves relate to escape and death: Sarah is buried in "a cave" in the field of Ephron (Gen 25); the five southern kings escape Joshua's sword and hide in a cave, which becomes their prison and ultimately the place of their death (Josh 10); Saul fell into the hands of David when he entered a cave (1 Sam 24); Obadiah hid 100 prophets in a cave to protect them from Isabelle (1 Kgs 18:3–4). These connotations can create a distressful atmosphere in a seemingly innocent caption such as: "A maskil of David, while he was in the cave: a prayer" (Ps 142:2). The psalm concludes with the speaker's plea: "Free me from prison, that I may praise Your name" (8), indicating that the cave was a metaphor for the poet's emotional prison.¹¹ There is no contradiction between Lot dwelling in a cave or a hill; however, the atmosphere that accompanies the description of each of these locations is entirely different.¹²

The third clause of each part should also be read carefully in light of this distinction. Both parts of the verse clarify that Lot did not travel from Zoar alone but with his two daughters. The first part of the verse reads "with his two daughters," while the latter part of the verse reads "him and his two daughters." Whereas the initial formulation created a sense of unity in the family (Lot the father travels with his two daughters), the absence of "with" in the second part of the verse leaves the reader with the impression of two groups (Lot, and his daughters).

10 Cf. Rashkow 2007, 62. Rashkow emphasized the cave as a symbol of pandemonium and death.

11 See the opening verses of Ps 57.

12 Perhaps the word *מערה* (*me'ara* – "cave") is a play on the word *עמורה* ("Gomorrah") (Sutskover 2011, note 25). Lot escaped "Gomorrah" and ended up in a *me'ara*: will his fate in the latter be an improvement on the former?

This dual design might be an early indication of a dual reading of the scene: the narrative could be read both as a continuation of the Sodom narrative and Lot's escape from the city (part II of the exposition), and as a realization of the "line of Terah," which introduced the Abraham cycle, through the birth of Ammon and Moab (part I of the exposition). In relation to the destruction of Sodom, Lot hides in a cave, and a tension is apparent between him and his daughters; with regard to the Abraham cycle, Lot leaves Zoar and seeks another home; he settles on the mountains with his daughters and is involved in the creation of two nations, Ammon and Moab. The duality is later expressed in the evaluation of the creation of Ammon and Moab.

The Daughters

Contradictory positions on the evaluation of Lot and his daughters date back to early exegetical commentary. The *Book of Jubilees* (16:8–9) states:

And [Lot] and his daughters committed sin upon the earth, such as had not been on the earth since the days of Adam till his time; for the man lay with his daughters. And behold, it was commanded and engraved concerning all his seed, on the heavenly tablets, to remove them and root them out, and to execute judgment upon them like the judgment of Sodom, and to leave no seed of the man on earth on the day of condemnation.

In order to emphasize the criticism of Lot, *Jubilees* retells the cave narrative, but makes Lot into the central active character – "the man lay with his daughters." *Jubilees* proceeds to compare the future of Lot's descendants with the punishment inflicted on Sodom, implying that Lot may have been temporarily saved from the fate of Sodom but did not escape the influence of its culture, and therefore will ultimately share the its fate.¹³

13 On the dual representation of Lot in *Jubilees* see van Ruiten 2004, 29–46.

In contrast, Philo expressed the following view:

These virgins, because of their ignorance of external matters and because they saw those cities burned up together with all their inhabitants, supposed that the whole human race [had been destroyed at the same time], and that no one remained anywhere except the three of them.¹⁴

Josephus similarly stated:

And the virgins, having supposed that all of mankind had been obliterated, had sexual relations with their father, having taken care beforehand to escape notice.”¹⁵

Philo and Josephus defended the intentions of Lot’s daughters by emphasizing the daughters’ belief that mankind had been annihilated.¹⁶

A good illustration of the ambiguity surrounding the evaluation of Lot’s daughters can be found in rabbinic sources. Some midrashic sources define the daughters’ act as a *mitzvah* – comparing the act to a precept: “R. Hiya b. Abin said in the name of R. Joshua b. Korha: A man should always be quick to perform a precept, for as reward for anticipating the younger by one night, the elder daughter merited four generations of monarchs in Israel” (BT *Nazir* 23b-24a).¹⁷ Other sources refer to the act as a sin: “R. Yehuda b. Simon and R. Hanin said in the name of R. Johanan: Lot’s daughters committed a sinful act and were impregnated, in what merit? In the merit of Moab – [whose name denotes] ‘who is the father,’ as it is said by Abraham, ‘for I have made you father of many nations’” (Genesis Rabbah 51:11).¹⁸

14 *Questions and Answers in Genesis* 4:56.

15 Josephus, *Antiquities* I:205; Feldman 2000, 77–78.

16 On Josephus’ generally favorable attitude toward Lot, see Avioz 2006, 338–40. See also: Kugel 1998, 338–40.

17 This statement appears in other places in the Babylonian Talmud (Bava Kama 38b; Horayot 11a); the statement is not disputed in any of the parallel sources.

18 In Genesis Rabbah 51.10, R. Huna contrasts Lot’s daughters with the Moabite women of Num 25, and concludes that Lot’s daughters are praiseworthy, while R. Simon contrasts them with Ruth (Ruth 3), and criticizes them.

The diverse assessment of Lot's daughters continued throughout history and in modern critical analysis.¹⁹ Surprisingly, both positions are supported by the text, and seeds of positive evaluation seem to have been planted alongside the criticism, as clarified in the following analysis. After considering the opposing positions and their textual foundation, I will examine the associative meanings in the scene, which generate a different evaluation for each of Lot's daughters. These differences simultaneously sympathize with and criticize them.

Many scholars have viewed the narrative as etiological, relating to various contexts. Gunkel suggested that the purpose of the narrative was to explain the ancestries of the Moabite nation. He concluded that the narrative praises Lot's daughters, who are perceived as women of valor. Gunkel found approval for the origins of the Moabite nation in two aspects of the narrative: the daughters are presented as women who possess initiative and courage; but more importantly, the Moabite nation is created internally, without need for a stranger. Gunkel believed that the perception of the narrative as a mockery of the incestuous origins of Ammon and Moab is a later development.²⁰

Gunkel found additional approval for the daughters' actions in the literary form of the narrative. The primary components of the narrative – a daughter who forces her father to impregnate her in order to carry on the family line – can be found in the narrative about Judah and Tamar (Gen 38) and the Greek myth about the birth of Adonis. The myth describes Aphrodite punishing Myrrha with a never-ending lust for her own father, Zeus, resulting in the birth of Adonis. The two narratives of Tamar and Myrrha include no criticism of the seductive daughter or of the sexual act; on the contrary, they are described as champions, and the sexual act is described as heroic.²¹ According to

19 The ambiguity towards Lot's daughters and the nations born of them is duly noted by Noort 2010 – Abraham, 13–15.

20 Many scholars, including some from the literary school, followed. See, among others, Alter 1996, 90.

21 Gunkel's assertion that Myrrha's lust for her father is evaluated positively is debatable. The lust was implanted by Aphrodite due to her anger at Myrrha; when the king discovered his daughter in his bed he was furious, and wanted to kill her. Special intervention by the gods saved her, and she gave birth to Adonis.

Gunkel, in this form the seductive daughter is a positive character, and Lot's daughters should be viewed in the same way.²² Adolf Lods took this idea one step further, and claimed that the narrative was originally a Moabite creation narrative about the origins of civilization, which began with a father and two daughters.²³

The positive evaluation clarifies the generally positive atmosphere of the narrative, which lacks direct criticism of the daughters and commemorates the event by giving the sons names that reflect conception by the mothers' father.²⁴ The naming reflects a lack of shame by the daughters, who do not attempt to conceal their actions.²⁵ The fact that both daughters are impregnated after spending one night with their father creates a sense of wonder that is common in the praise

Therefore, even if Gunkel is correct that the narrative ends on a positive note (the birth of Adonis as a result of intervention by the gods), the sexual act itself is viewed negatively. See also Galpaz-Feller 2006, 55.

22 Gunkel 1997. Benno Jacob (1974, 465) referred to the link between Lot's daughters and Tamar. He wrote that the husbands of Lot's daughters were killed in the destruction of Sodom, leaving them childless, like Tamar whose husbands died and left her childless. This explanation would only be possible if the daughters in the cave were not the virgin daughters mentioned in Gen 19:8. Since a simple reading implies that these are the same daughters, they could not have been married. In the context of the literary form some scholars mention Ruth, who seduces Boaz on the threshing floor. See Fisch 1982; Zakovitch 1987; Wenin 1998; Yaron 2001.

23 Lods 1927, 204–19. Lods also leaned on the above-mentioned myth of the birth of Adonis. Porter went even further. He believed the narrative was originally written in relation to myths about copulation between gods and women. Such copulation led to the birth of giants. Therefore, the narrative includes a pre-Moabite stage. See Porter 1978, 127–41.

24 The link between the name Moab and the Hebrew root for father (אב) is explicit in the Septuagint. Wellhausen assumed that the etymology of the word Moab stems from the Arabic verb that connotes "shame." According to this interpretation, the word Moab connotes "born of shame." However, it seems unlikely that this would be an acceptable explanation for a nation's foundation. See Liver's review of this and other positions (Liver, Moab, 707–08). Even if Hommel (1904, 261) is correct that the name Moab is derived from "Immo-ab" ("his mother is his father"), the narrative links the names with birth from the father, which is implied in the names of both sons – עמון and מואב.

25 Wenham 1994, 60; Aschkenasy 2007.

form. Porter explained that the purpose of the double emphasis that Lot “did not know when she lay down or when she arose” (33:35) is “to exonerate Lot from any blame for what happened.”²⁶

I believe these speculations lack foundation in the text, despite their reflection of a deliberate reading consciousness that validates the actions of Lot’s daughters. Nonetheless, a variety of positions regarding the evaluation of Lot’s daughters range from early exegesis to modern biblical criticism,²⁷ which led some scholars to view the textual ambiguity as deliberate.²⁸

The scholars who deny any criticism of the daughters base their position primarily on three details:

1. The elder daughter introduces her idea by stating: “Our father is old, and there is not a man on earth to consort with us in the way of all the world” (19:31). The daughter’s actions are not based on lust or promiscuity, but rather on her desire for continuity. She assumes that “there is not a man on earth to consort with us,” and that her father is the only option for the survival of the human species. This detail seems reminiscent of the actions taken by Tamar and Ruth to ensure the family line.²⁹
2. The fact that both daughters are impregnated after spending one night with their father might imply divine assistance. Lot’s daughters are virgins (19:8); the fact that both daughters conceive on the

26 Porter 1978, 128. In light of the absence of a prohibition to have sexual relations with one’s daughters in Lev 18, Potter assumes that at the time there was no such prohibition.

27 Dillmann (1897, 113) wrote “this odious story”; Jacob (1974, 129) reflected: “their action testified to magnificent heroism.” Vawter (1977, 242–43) claimed the story shows an appreciation of the initiative to save the family line, while Mathews (2005, 244) wrote: “their efforts are not honorable but decadent, and Lot is not a hero but a dope.”

28 Tonson 2001.

29 Many scholars have noted this threefold link. See esp. Ficsh 1982, and Alter 1996. Tamar clearly seduced Judah on the highway by pretending to be a prostitute. The Ruth narrative is more complex; although the idea of seduction is suggested by Naomi, Ruth seems to have decided not to realize this option (see Grossman 2015, 199–227).

night of their deflowering defies well-established statistics. Once again, Lot's daughters are reminiscent of Tamar, who conceives Judah's child after one sexual interaction with him on the roadside.

3. The etiological conclusion of the narrative describes the establishment of the two nations Ammon and Moab. The story ends on a positive note. Even if the reader is aversive toward the two nations, the establishment of two nations should clearly be deciphered as a reward for the actions of the daughters in the context of the narrative.

The narrative materials simultaneously include indications of criticism. The biblical narrative is particularly sensitive to incest. The disregard of this taboo is attributed to the Canaanites, and stated as the reason they lose their claim to the land. While the correlation between incest and the Canaanites is merely alluded to in Genesis (9:18–27),³⁰ Leviticus names the act of incest after the Canaanites: “You shall not copy the practices of...the land of Canaan to which I am taking you; nor shall you follow their laws” (Lev 18:3). These customs are the reason the Canaanites were banished (Lev 18:24–30; 20:23–24). From this perspective, the reader should not take the daughters' actions lightly: the act itself is powerfully negative. The difference between Lot's daughters and the stories of Tamar and Ruth is fundamental: Tamar and Ruth do not copulate with their father, an unspeakable act in biblical philosophy.³¹ In addition to the severe sin of incest, the daughters add to their negative evaluation by tricking their father. However, there is yet another possibility of reading the text, one that challenges the assumption that both daughters are criticized equally in this episode; I wish to explore this direction.³²

30 See esp. Cassuto 1964, 149–58.

31 Ficsh 1982, 433.

32 I have already proposed the basis of this theory: see Grossman 2014.

The Reasoning of the Elder Daughter

The names of the daughters are not revealed in the narrative; instead, they are referred to by their age hierarchy: “the older one said to the younger.”³³ Use of the term *צעירה* (“younger”) generates wordplay with the name of the city Lot had left – *צֶעֱרָה* (19:23); the letters of both words are identical and distinguishable only by their vowelization. The verse describes Lot “coming” (*בא*) to the city, and in the cave Lot’s daughter “came upon” (*ותבא*) her father (19:33).³⁴ However, there is additional literary value to naming the daughters by their family status instead of their individual names. The two daughters are not independent characters; their purpose is to shed light on Lot’s action (or in this case, inaction). Lot is therefore the only character to be named in the scene.³⁵ However, by emphasizing the different status of the two sisters, the reader is invited to evaluate the actions of each sister separately. The elder sister makes her suggestion out of her position of authority. As the eldest sister she initiates action; in fact, the younger sister might have felt obligated to take her advice because of this. The text indicates that the younger sister acts in accordance with the authority of the older sister, and not of her own volition.

The motive for seducing the father is stated by the elder sister: “Our father is old, and there is not a man on earth to consort with us in the way of all the world” (31). Lot is described as “old,” which might mean one of two things: either Lot is too old to remarry and bear more children,³⁶ or the sisters have to act fast before their father

33 This detail led to a debate among scholars regarding the possibility of an ancient Moabite tale at the core of the narrative. Stade (1887–88, 118) rejected this assumption based on the omission of the daughters’ names. Gunkel (1997, 216) refuted this claim, since the names could have been omitted in the transfer to the biblical text.

34 Sutskover 2011.

35 Reinhartz 1998, 127.

36 Westermann 1995, 313; Hamilton 1995, 51, among others.

dies.³⁷ Either reason is appropriate in the context of the scene: Lot's voice is not heard throughout the narrative. The daughters speak with one another but not with their father; he is ignorant of his role in the conception of his sons-grandsons; he is given wine in a dark cave, which might signify a burial cave. Lot's passivity might be understandable, given the recent loss of his wife and other daughters, of his home and community. Lot's definition as "old" can be viewed as a broader characterization of his current state. The eldest surviving daughter inherits the leadership of the family from her dying father.³⁸

The assessment of the situation by the elder daughter can be interpreted in more than one way. Lot's daughters might indeed be under the impression that the catastrophe they had witnessed was worldwide, like Noah's flood, and that their father is the only surviving male.³⁹ This should be ample justification for violating their father. Even according to a more minimalistic interpretation, which states that there is no man to consort with *right now*,⁴⁰ or that their father will no longer take care of them and provide them with a husband,⁴¹ her intentions are clearly not promiscuous or ritualistic. The daughter's motive clearly and directly relates to her desire to have children, as Wenham noted: "what she really wanted was children, not a husband."⁴² At the very

37 Gunkel 1997, 217. Ehrlich (1969, 51) uniquely read: "our father is old; he is like a small child, and we can do as we wish with him." Regarding the daughters' motivation, see Schlosberg 1993.

38 See an extensive discussion by Sternberg (1985, 349–54) on the term "old" in the book of Genesis.

39 Rashi, Ibn Ezra, R. Samuel ben Meir, and Joseph Bekhor Shor, offered a similar commentary on Gen 19:31. Gunkel (1997, 217) noted the similarity to God's instruction to take male and female species into the ark "to keep seed alive upon all the earth" (7:3); he believed the similarity enhances the impression that the daughters believe there is no-one left. See also Skinner 1930, 313; Speiser 1964, 145; Westermann 1995, 313.

40 Hamilton 1995, 51.

41 Wenham 1994, 61.

42 Ibid.

least, the action should be viewed as desperate.⁴³ Desperation links this narrative with other biblical seduction narratives. Athalia Brenner noted that biblical incest narratives initiated by men (e.g., Amnon and Tamar; Absalom and David's wives) are frequently an expression of a struggle for control, while incest stories initiated by women (e.g., Lot's daughters; Judah and Tamar) express a desire for family continuity.⁴⁴

Over the course of two nights, Lot had relations with each of his daughters after drinking wine; both daughters were impregnated as a result, and each gave birth to a boy. The facts are identical, but the events of each night are described in different words. Various scholars have referred to the descriptions of the two nights, and most agree that there are no significant differences in the narrative. Gunkel wrote:

The two consummations are recounted in almost the same words (vs. 33, 35) as are the two summons (vs. 32, 34b). In a broader sense, the summons and the consummations also correspond to one another, as do, finally, the two births. These parallels are no accident, but intention. The second summons (v. 34) would not have been necessary for the continuation of the action and is only present because of its counterpart.⁴⁵

Similarly, Westermann wrote: "What is striking here is the almost literal repetition in both cases (33, 35), and that the execution corresponds word for word with the plan that is repeated again in v. 34... This... is simply to say that the plan went without a hitch."⁴⁶ This is the prevalent position among modern scholars.⁴⁷ Other scholars attributed the repetition to Lot's secret lust for incest.⁴⁸ These positions are based on the presumption that the descriptions of the two nights are identical.

43 E.g., Keil and Delitzsch (1980, 237) wrote that the daughters thought no one would want to marry them, since they are the sole survivors of God's curse; Speiser (1964, 145) wrote: "All of this adds up to praise rather than blame".

44 Brenner 1994, 127.

45 Gunkel 1997, 217.

46 Westermann 1995, 313; Wenham 1994, 61.

47 Cf. Wenham (1994, 61): "The execution of the elder sister's scheme goes without a hitch. So simple was it the first night that exactly the same procedure was followed the next evening by the younger sister."

48 Rank 1992, 303; Rashkow 1998, 94. See also Polhemus 2005.

However, whereas the occurrences of the two nights are indeed identical, the choice of words and reflected meanings vary:

| | First Night: Elder Daughter | Second Night: Younger Daughter |
|---|---|--|
| Initiative | And the older daughter said to the younger,
“ <i>Our father</i> is old...
Let us make <i>our father</i> drink wine and then we shall lie with him and preserve our family line through <i>our father</i> .” | The next day the older daughter said to the younger,
“Last night I lay with <i>my father</i> . Let us get him to drink wine again tonight, and you go in and lie with him so we can preserve our family line through <i>our father</i> .” |
| Giving the father wine | So they made their father drink wine that night... | That night also they made their father drink wine |
| Relations with the father | and the older one came (וַתָּבֹא) and lay with her father (אֶת אָבִיהָ) | and the younger rose (וַתָּקֶם), and lay with him (עִמּוֹ) |
| Lot’s lack of awareness | and he did not know when she lay down or when she rose. | and he did not know when she lay down or when she rose. |
| Thus the two daughters of Lot came to be with child by their father | | |
| Birth of the son | The older one bore a son | And the younger also bore a son |
| Naming the son | and named him Moab | and she called him Ben-Ammi |
| Etiological Conclusion | he is the father of the Moabites of today | he is the father of the Ammonites of today |

The use of shared consistent formulations is apparent in the description of the two events and their outcome. These similarities attract the reader’s attention to delicate distinctions between the two descriptions. The events of both nights are initiated by the elder daughter. This shared fact actually breaks the full comparison between the two nights, since it is the younger daughter who lies with her father on the second night. The younger daughter could haven spoken instead of the elder, saying “Last night *you* lay with our father. Let us get him to drink wine again tonight, and *I* will go in and lie with him so we can preserve our

family line through our father.” Instead, the reader is presented with an older sister who initiates while the younger sister is hesitant, perhaps even reluctant, to take action. In addition to the initiative of the older daughter on the second night, there are other subtle differences that do not seem arbitrary. On the first night the elder daughter consistently refers to the father in the plural: “*Our father* is old... Let us make *our father* drink wine...and preserve *our family* line through *our father*.” On the second night, the older daughter seems to distinguish between the sexual act and the desired result: she refers to the father in the singular – “*my father*” – when recalling the sexual act of the previous night; she continues to use the singular “*my father*” when encouraging her sister to give the father wine and lie with him; and she only reverts to the plural “*our father*” in reference to the desired outcome of preserving the family line by bearing a child. This style enables the elder sister to repeat her suggestion while sublimating the demand of her younger sister. The older daughter never verbalizes that her sister is required to lie with “her father”; this blunt description is reserved for her own actions on the previous night. On the second night “he” is to be given wine, and the younger daughter will lie with “him.” The indirect terms do not change the meaning, but they do offer sublimation.⁴⁹

The slight variations are extremely significant. The older daughter’s action is described with the verb **ותבא** (“came”), whereas the younger daughter’s action is described with the verb **ותקם** (“rose”).⁵⁰

49 Leech (1974, 22–23) noted that the order of words affect both meaning and perception. Perhaps the changed order of words in the sentences describing the daughters giving their father wine also contributes to sublimation of the act. In the description of the first night the direct object (*their father*) is adjacent to the verb, and the sentence is concluded with the time adjunct (*that night*); in the description of the second night the direct object (*their father*) is distanced from the verb, and the time adjunct, *that night also*, is placed between them. The more loaded sentence, *they gave their father wine to drink*, does not appear in the description of the second night; here, too, the formulation does not change the meaning, but is presented in a more delicate way, diminishing the harsh reality of the daughters getting their father drunk.

50 The Septuagint unifies the two formulations and reads: **הצעירה ותשכב את אביה ותבא**. By doing this the Septuagint annuls the use of a different verb, as well as the different word describing the subject, which is described using the word **עמי**

Within the context of the narrative, the verb **ותקם** prepares the reader for the main act, which appears in the form of another verb later in the same sentence.⁵¹ The choice of **ותבא** is clever, since this verb is often used in the Bible to describe sexual relations. Although it is not used with a sexual meaning in v. 32, the complementary meaning of the verb integrates nicely with the general atmosphere of the verse.⁵² The absence of **ותבא** from the description of the younger daughter seems deliberate in light of the integration of the verb twice in the words of the older daughter: on the first night with direct sexual meaning: “and there is not a man on earth to consort with us (**לבווא עלינו**) in the way of all the world” (19:31), and on the second night with the meaning of getting from one place to another: “and you go (**ובאי**) and lie with him, that we may maintain life through our father” (19:34). In light of the older daughter’s statement, the reader anticipates the use of the verb in the description of the younger daughter’s actions, as a direct parallel to her older sister in the first night. Instead, the narrative reads “and the younger rose,” surprising the reader with a changed formulation.⁵³

Moreover, the choice of **ותקם** as a replacement for **ותבא** also plays a part in sublimating the younger sister’s actions. The verbs **קם** – **שכב** have opposite meanings in various biblical contexts, such as: “If people quarrel and one person hits another with a stone or with their fist and

is the Masoretic text. Some preferred the Septuagint’s unified description (Ball 1896, 71); however, I believe the subtle differences between such similar texts carry significance.

- 51 The Septuagint transfers the verb to the older daughter’s initiative: “Let us make our father drink wine, and let us lie with him, and let us *raise up* (**נקים**) seed from our father.” Had the Septuagint maintained the description of the younger daughter in the Masoretic text, the result could have been a clever word play: the daughter rose in order to *raise up* the father’s seed. However, the Septuagint uses the verb **ותבא** to describe the actions of the younger daughter as well.
- 52 Mathews (2005:233) noted that verbs with sexual connotations are purposely incorporated throughout the narrative about the angels in Sodom (**שכב**; **ידע**; **בא**), even if in the present narrative they are used in a non-sexual sense. The use of **באה** with regard to the elder daughter’s actions carries similar significance. See also Sutskover 2011.
- 53 On breaking expectation as a literary tactic see Perry 1979, 35–64; Sternberg 1979, 126–29; Grossman 2008.

the victim does not die but is *confined to bed* (משכב). If he should *arise* (קום) and walk outside..." (Ex 21:18); "Like a lion they crouch and lie down (שכב), like a lioness – who dares to rouse them (יקימנו)?" (Num 24:9); "Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you *lie down* (בשכב) and when you get up (ובקומך)" (Deut 6:7); "So *she lay* (ותשכב) at his feet until morning, but arose (ותקם) before anyone could be recognized" (Ru 3:14). The stark contrast between the two verbs led to Beuken's definition of the verb שכב: "The basic meaning of the vb. Škb, 'lie down, lie (there),' emerges from its antonym קום, 'get up, stand (there).'"⁵⁴ The two verbs appear as antonyms in our narrative as well: "and he did not know when she lay down or when she rose" (19:33, 35). Thus the ambivalence of the younger daughter is tangible as she *rises* in order to *lie* with her father. She seems to be acting against her better judgment, and against her instincts, in contrast to the elder daughter who *comes* and *lies*.

Additional subtleties correspond with the distinctions clarified above. The father is mentioned explicitly in the action of the older daughter ("and the older one came and lay with *her father*"), whereas the father is not mentioned directly by title in the actions of the younger daughter ("and the younger rose and lay with *him*"). Here, too, the distinction is deliberate, and is confirmed by its effect on the naming of the sons. The older daughter who lay את אביה ("with *her father*") names her son מואב ("from father"), whereas the younger daughter who lay עמו ("with *him*") names her son עמון.⁵⁵ The narrator's variations thus affect the etymological conclusion of the narrative.

Another subtle difference contributes to the distinction between the two nights. The word את is used to describe the older daughter's sexual encounter with her father, while the word עם describes the younger daughter's act. The semantic distinction here is difficult to prove. Orlinsky claimed that *D* has a tendency to use the combination עם שכב, whereas *P* tends to use את שכב.⁵⁶ This division is irrelevant in the case of

54 Beuken, שכב, 661.

55 Zakovitch 1980, 168–69.

56 Orlinsky 1944, 19–44. Orlinsky noted that the combination את שכב appears 20 times in the Bible, while עם שכב appears 27 times. See a review of ancient

Lot's daughters, as – according to Orlinski – J and E use the combinations equally and arbitrarily. Moreover, because both are used here, any attempts to ascribe the narrative to different authors are largely irrelevant.

Even if the semantic distinction is vague, various texts indicate that שכב את represents a forced sexual act in which the partners are unequal, while שכב עם represents a mutual sexual act.⁵⁷ This is evident in Abimelech's reprimand to Isaac: "What is this you have done to us? One of the men might well have lain with (את) your wife, and you would have brought guilt upon us" (26:10). The word את emphasizes the magnitude of disaster that could have been brought upon a man who would have wrongfully lain with Rebekah. So, too, with regard to Dinah: "He took her, and he lay with (את) her, and he violated her."⁵⁸

In contrast, sexual relations between Jacob and his wives are described using the preposition עם: "Rachel said, 'He can lie with you [עמך] tonight in return for your son's mandrakes...So he lay with her [עמה] that night.'" (Gen 30:15–16).⁵⁹ The clearest demonstration of the distinction in terms is in the narrative about the rape of Tamar (2 Sam 13). When Amnon's initially attempts to seduce Tamar, he says "come and lie with me [שכבי עמי], sister" (v. 11); after she refuses, the

translations in pp. 33–37.

57 Ahuvia 1995; Lipka 2006, 185–99. Orlinsky claimed that Malbim's commentary on the narrative and Ehrlich's analysis lead in this direction. See also Malbim's commentary on Lev 20 (*HaTorah ve HaMitzvah* 109), which states that שכב את indicates that the submissive partner enjoys the sexual act, while שכב עם indicates a lack of enjoyment by the submissive partner. Malbim presented a similar analysis in his book, *Ayelet HaShahar* 51:529. See Ehrlich's analysis (Ehrlich 1968, 172–73), and commentary on Gen 39:7. See also Greenberg 1997, 477). For criticism of the division suggested above see Orlinsky 2010, 130.

58 This is assuming Dinah was indeed raped, as is generally presumed (See Bader 2006, 9, note 1). If Dinah and Shechem's relationship was consensual, this verse cannot be used as proof for my position. See Bechtel 1994, 19–36; Frymer-Kensky 1998, 79–96; Lipka 2006, 184–99; Wyatt 1990, 433–58. Gruber (1999, 127) wrote: "It is clear that there is not even the slightest hint that Shechem the son of Hamor raped Dinah." For criticism of this approach see Noble 1996, 173–203; Scholtz 2000. See also Gen 34:7; 35:22; ISam 4:22.

59 See the words of Potiphar's wife to Joseph (Gen 39:7) as well as 2 Sam 11:11; 12:24.

rape is described: “And he refused to listen to her, and he held her forcefully and violated her and lay with her [וישכב אתה] (v. 14). This division is inconsistent throughout biblical text (more so in texts of biblical law),⁶⁰ but the difference is apparent in the present narrative: The older daughter lies אה, emphasizing the rape of the old drunken father who cannot discern left from right; the younger daughter lies עם, which deemphasizes the rape. The change does not reflect a new chain of events; Lot is just as unaware of his daughter’s violation on the second night as he is on the first. However, the choice of words changes the atmosphere of the second night and evaluates the younger daughter in a more favorable manner.

There are no other significant differences between the descriptions of the two nights. Lot is oblivious to the events of both nights, and the etymological conclusion is described in an identical manner.⁶¹

The impact of this analysis on the evaluation of the daughters is complex. The initiative is described favorably: the intention of the daughters is not promiscuous or self-indulgent. Nonetheless, there is room to question whether the daughters felt repelled by their actions, despite their desperation. In this context, the complementary meanings, the specific choice of words, and the delicate contrast between the sisters paints two different pictures of the two nights. While the description of the younger daughter sublimates the vulgarity of the father’s rape, the older daughter’s actions are described openly and explicitly. Here there is a distinction between the evaluation of the older and younger daughters.

This distinction is expressed in Philo’s allegorical commentary (*On Drunkenness*, 165), and in some ancient midrashic texts, such as BT *Bava Kamma* 38b:

60 See in particular: Deut 22:25, 28. On the unique combination לשכב אצלה (Gen 39:10) see Orlinsky 1944, 34–36. This is a deliberate digression from the regular combination שכב עמה for the purpose of a literary tactic (Grossman 2008, 38–39).

61 Each of the daughters names her child based on the verb that describes her sexual encounter with the father, as stated above.

The Holy One, blessed be He, does not deprive any reward due to any creature, even if only for a pleasant discourse; for regarding the elder [daughter] who named her son “Moab” the Holy One, Blessed be He, said to Moses, “Do not harass the Moabites or provoke them to war”; while actual hostility against them is forbidden, demanding from them was allowed, whereas regarding the younger [daughter] who named her son “Ben-Ammi,” the Holy One, Blessed be He, said to Moses: “When you come to the Ammonites, do not harass them or provoke them to war at all; they may not even be subjugated to forced labor.”

The midrash’s premise is that the younger daughter gave her son a more modest name than that given by the older daughter. The difference in naming the sons is extremely significant to the author of this rabbinic text; he sees the names as the core of a more favorable general attitude toward Ammon. Medieval commentators such as Rashi and R. Bahya b. Asher evaluated the younger daughter more favorably on the basis of this text. We have demonstrated here that the design of the narrative alludes to such a similarly complex and subtle evaluation.

In light of this analysis I would like to return to the correspondence between the older sister’s suggestion and the execution of her plan. The accepted premise is that the older daughter intended to have each daughter lie with her father on a different night. Therefore, as Westermann concluded, the execution is compatible with the original plan. However, as Sutskover pointed out,⁶² such a distinction cannot be found in the verbalization of the plan by the older daughter.

The comparison between the elder daughter’s suggestion (in Sternberg’s terms, “member of forecast”) and the action that follows (“member of enactment”) ⁶³ demonstrates that the older daughter initially spoke in the plural about the actions of giving the father wine and lying with him: “Let us make *our father* drink wine and then *we shall* lie with him and preserve our family line through *our father*” (19:32). However, in the account of the following events the giving of wine is described in the plural – “So *they* made their father drink wine,” whereas the older daughter proceeded to act alone: “and *the older one* came and lay with her father.” (19:33). When push came to

62 Sutskover 2011.

63 Sternberg 1985, 375–87.

shove, the initial partnership made way for the brave older daughter's action, while the younger daughter seemed to have lost her nerve to act out the plan the sisters had agreed upon.⁶⁴ One might argue that both daughters could not have lain with their father simultaneously, but this argument does not clarify why the younger daughter needs to be convinced of the plan again on the second night. The reader is left with the impression that the plan was not completed on the first night due to the hesitation of the younger daughter. Although both possibilities present an acceptable reading, the more delicate choice of words throughout the events of the second night indicates that the daughters experienced a different degree of identification with the rape of the father; therefore a reading is preferred according to which the younger daughter lacks the nerve to lie with her father on the first night.

Why are the daughters presented differently? The younger daughter is commended for her hesitance; the narrator has her lie with her father against her better judgment and out of desperation. The etiological conclusion should be that the narrative projects a different attitude towards Moab than towards Ammon. This distinction is expressed in the law prohibiting marriage with Amon and Moab:

No Ammonite or Moabite or any of their descendants may enter the assembly of the Lord, not even in the tenth generation. For they did not come to meet you with bread and water on your way when you came out of Egypt, and he hired Balaam son of Beor from Pethor in Aram-Naharaim to pronounce a curse on you. The Lord your God would not listen to Balaam but turned the curse into a blessing for you, because the Lord your God loves you. Do not seek their peace or their prosperity as long as you live (Deut 23:4–7).

Ammon and Moab are mentioned in one breath. Additionally, the reason for the directive (*they* did not come to meet you) and the concluding remarks (*their* peace; *their* prosperity), which are stated in the plural, relate equally to both nations. However, the central reason for the directive focuses on Moab, and is therefore delivered in the singular: “and he hired Balaam son of Beor...” This lengthy statement

64 A similar suggestions was made by Sutskover 2011, 49.

points to specific animosity between Israel and Moab, which is deeper than the animosity with Ammon. There is no clear historical evidence for such a distinction,⁶⁵ but ancient Hebrew poetry does reflect such a distinction. As opposed to Moab and Edom, the people of Ammon were not mentioned negatively in the Song of the Sea (Ex 15) or in Balaam's poem (Num 24:17).

I believe the delicate distinction between the daughters serves a literary purpose. Sutskovier wrote that this narrative presents an innovative concept of preference toward the younger sibling, since the elder daughter is presented as the initiator, while the younger sister is frightened and hesitant.⁶⁶ I believe the opposite to be true: the hesitation of the younger daughter is commended in the narrative. The presentation of the younger daughter highlights the fact that what the sisters felt compelled to do should have been avoided altogether, had they had a choice. The presentation of the younger sibling in a more positive light is part of a known motif of preference for the younger sibling in the book of Genesis. It is noteworthy that the present narrative was placed between the message of the birth of Isaac (Gen 17–18) and the realization of that message (Gen 21). In this context, Lot can be compared to Abraham: Lot has two daughters, and Abraham two sons; Lot's elder daughter takes the initiative and lies with her father, and her younger sister is preferred as a result, as later the elder son of Abraham will act inappropriately (Gen 21:9) and preference will be given to the younger sibling.

65 The two are frequently mentioned as a pair in biblical texts. See Finlay 2005, 203. Oded claimed that the hostility toward Ammon seems to have evolved later than that toward Moab and Edom (Oded, "Ammon").

66 Sutskovier 2011, 7.

The Evaluation of Lot

Lot is an entirely passive character throughout the scene: he does not speak, and his reaction to the events is not recorded. However, the narrator seems to hint at his unflattering evaluation of Lot.⁶⁷ In addition to his portrayal as “old,” his ignorance of the events is described in the same words on both occasions: “he did not know when she lay down or when she rose” (33 and 35). This detail at the conclusion of the first night is necessary, since it explains how the daughters were able to get away with the second night. The repetition of the detail on the second night, however, seems entirely unnecessary. In fact, the emphasis elevates the anticipation of Lot’s response, which then fails to be reported. The repetition of the statement might indicate the narrator’s evaluation of Lot. Throughout the biblical narrative the verb יָדַע (“to know”) interchangeably denotes the sexual act and intellectual understanding. Introducing the verb with regard to Lot in this scene creates an ironic wordplay: Lot “did not know” that his daughters “knew” him.⁶⁸ While the daughters are active in a way that exceeds their normal role, their father is utterly passive, and so ignorant of his surroundings that he is unaware of what his own body is doing.⁶⁹

67 However, Coats (1983, 147) exaggerated when he claimed that Lot is the main character being judged in the story. He believed Lot was portrayed as a fool in the cave, just as he was portrayed as a fool when he was saved from Sodom.

68 Jackson 2002, 39.

69 Otto Rank’s theory overloads the text with more information than it contains. Perhaps he is correct, and the purpose of portraying Lot as passive is to exempt him of responsibility for violating the taboo of incest; however, he went too far with the claim that the story demonstrates Lot’s secret lust for incest (Rank 1992, 303). Shira Stav (2010, 87) wrote similarly: “the sexual act is characterized by increased, aberrant, and redundant activity (the act occurs twice), as well as lethargy and senselessness, which represent the deep denial that is an integral part of all fatherly desire.” Similar readings refer to the fact that Lot offers his daughters to the townspeople, demonstrating his subconscious lust toward them (Rashkow 1998). Exum (2000, 94) attributed the secret lust to the author (see also Seifert 1994). Despite well-known postmodern inclinations,

Lot's ignorance is enhanced by the notorious analogy with Noah and his sons after the flood (Gen 9:18–27). The flood had destroyed all of humanity, leaving only Noah and his family, and the perception of Lot's daughters is that they, too, are the sole survivors of the destruction of the world; Noah becomes drunk inside his tent, and Lot becomes drunk in his cave on the hill; Noah's son viewed his father's nakedness in his drunken state, and Lot was engaged in incestuous relations with his daughters.⁷⁰ The analogy is broken by the father's reaction to his child's action. Noah "woke up from his wine *and knew*"⁷¹ what his youngest son had done to him" (Gen 9:24). Noah's lucidity led him to regain control; he blessed his two sons, and cursed his youngest son. In contrast, Lot "*did not know*" what his daughters had done.⁷² The first appearance of the statement might have portrayed Lot as a victim, but the emphasis of the repetition portrays Lot as someone who has given up. Lot lost not only his wife and daughters, but his own vitality and will to live. In light of this Lot's daughters are correct: without taking action Lot's line might end (and according to their perception, the end of Lot's line will be the end of mankind). Lot's lack of knowledge stems from his choice to know no more; he hid in his cave and allowed himself to become oblivious to the surrounding reality.

The repeated comment is the only reference to Lot within the short story. However, the primary expression of Lot's evaluation is in the analysis of the story in the context of the destruction of Sodom, as well as the greater context of the Abraham cycle.

commentators should read the text rather than conform the characters to their philosophies.

70 Westermann viewed the analogy as part of the literary motif "fertility after destruction," which relates to the establishment and characterization of nations (Westermann 1995, 312; see also Coats 1983, 147). However, the correlation between the scenes involves concrete literary elements, such as drunkenness and incest with children.

71 In this instance NJPS translated וידע – "and learned."

72 Turner 1990, 98; Hamilton 1995, 52; Mathews 2005, 245.

Lot's Daughters as an Epilogue to the Destruction of Sodom

The linguistic and thematic links between the narrative about Lot's daughters and the destruction of Sodom are not coincidental.⁷³ Lot's daughters are said to escape the city along with their father: "As dawn broke, the angels urged Lot on, saying, 'Up, take your wife and your *two remaining daughters*, lest you be swept away because of the iniquity of the city.' Still he delayed. So the men seized his hand, and the hands of his wife *and his two daughters*...and brought him out and left him outside the city" (19:15–17). The detail is likely emphasized in preparation for the story of the daughters in the cave: Lot escapes with his wife and two daughters; the wife is lost, leaving Lot and his daughters. The elder daughter's words, "there is not a man on earth to consort with us in the way of all the world," can only be explained in relation to the destruction of Sodom. Lot and his daughters come to the hill because "he was afraid to dwell in Zoar" (19:30), a fear that can only be explained if the reader is aware of the previous story.⁷⁴ In fact, Lot's arrival on the hill relates directly to the angel's instruction in 19:17: "flee to the hills, lest you be swept away."⁷⁵

There are also thematic connections between the scenes: Lot's daughters give him wine to drink, just as Lot offered his guests wine (19:3).⁷⁶ In both instances the drinking is offered as literary context for the demand to sexually abuse the drinkers. The sexual motif links

73 E.g., Smith 1997, who concludes that reading the cave scene as the conclusion to the destruction of Sodom demonstrates that the daughters are correct, in contrast with Lot, who is a weak character throughout the story. This idea was also developed by Coats.

74 Among others, Coats 1985, 125.

75 Coats 1985, 146.

76 On the motif of food and drink in rape narratives see Shemesh 2002, 324–25. Shemesh notes that the motif appears in the Sodom narrative, as well as the Levite's concubine and the Rape of Tamar – all the biblical rape narratives aside from Dinah's. The motif has unique significance in the "rape" of Lot by his daughters, since the motif is essential in advancing the plot.

the cave scene with the broader narrative through the choice of words. The verbs שכב ("lie") and ידע ("know" with a clear sexual implication) are used regarding both the angels who come to Sodom and the cave scene. While the neutral meaning of the verb שכב is used in the Sodom narrative (19:4), the sexual connotation is clearly implied in the cave narrative (19:32, 33, 34, and 35). The neutral meaning of the word ידע is used in the cave scene (19:33, 35) but has a clear sexual connotation in the Sodom narrative (19:5, 7). As shown below, additional motifs link this scene with the broader context as well. The episodes are fundamentally linked, beyond the technical correlation of time and space.

Lastly, the incorporation of the narrative in the Abraham cycle should also be analyzed. According to Martin Noth this narrative is the nucleus of the entire Lot tradition, which was integrated into the Abraham narrative.⁷⁷ However, even those who accept this claim must admit that the question of the episode's integration into the cycle is significant. Whereas Abraham was somewhat involved in the destruction of Sodom, the story of Lot's daughters is utterly unrelated to Abraham. Therefore, in addition to exploring the purpose of the independent story, the placement of the story necessitates clarification as well.

In addition to the narrative materials that link the occurrences in the cave with Lot's escape as discussed above, the texture of the phrasing and the key motifs in the text create a veiled dialogue with the broader narrative relating to the family's escape from Sodom. The exposition integrates the root ישב ("to sit/settle"). The same root is used to describe Lot in his initial encounter with the angels (19:1) and to conclude the destruction of Sodom (19:29), but also in his separation from Abraham (13:12). The integration of the verb in the various narratives indicates a harsh irony: Lot "settled" in Sodom because he sought a stable and permanent dwelling, but as a result he eventually had to "settle" in an unstable and temporary cave, deprived of all the financial and social securities of urban culture.⁷⁸

77 Noth 1948, 152–53.

78 Westermann (1995, 315) had reservations about evaluating Lot in such a short story, considering he is entirely passive throughout the narrative. He did,

The statement by the eldest daughter regarding her father's old age in the context of fertility (19:31) links the scene to the angels' visit to Sarah, who laughed at their tidings of fertility because of her husband's old age (18:12).⁷⁹ Sarah's barrenness is somewhat reminiscent of Lot's wife, who turns into a pillar of salt – the symbol of infertility. The issue of family continuity in both scenes is based on the old age of the father, but ultimately resolved. Wenham found an additional ironic link between the sister's words, "there is not a man on earth to consort with us *in the way* of all the world," and God's comment on Abraham in 18:19: "that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep *the way* of the Lord."⁸⁰ Sexual violence also links the two scenes, as does the integration of the verbs שָׁכַב and יָדַע, which add to the sexual atmosphere of both narratives. Hamilton added that Lot is portrayed in both narratives as a confused character who lacks appropriate awareness of his surroundings. Lot fails to recognize the identity of his guests, and in the cave Lot "did not know" what his daughters had done to him.⁸¹

Rabbinic literature noted the ironic link of the relationship between Lot and his daughters in each of the scenes.⁸² The Sodomites wished to force themselves upon Lot's guests, and he offered his daughters for their sexual pleasure instead; eventually, the very same daughters forced themselves upon Lot in the cave. This irony goes beyond mockery of Lot's suggestion, and indicates a connection between Lot and the townspeople: he personally engaged in the sexual act he had offered them.⁸³ Turner saw this as a criticism of the daughters: the few who were saved from Sodom stooped to the level of those who

however, attribute significance to the contrast between the "settlements": "The contrast between his choice at the beginning and his life in the cave at the end is certainly deliberate."

79 Hamilton 1995, 51; Mathews 2005, 246.

80 Wenham 1994, 61.

81 Hamilton 1995, 52.

82 Tanhuma, Veyera, ch. 12.

83 See Smith 1997.

were lost in the destruction of the city.⁸⁴ But the link should also be seen as a comment on Lot. As previously demonstrated, the evaluation of Lot throughout the story is complex, but leans toward a positive evaluation based on the fact that he is ultimately saved by the merit of his own actions. The rescue narrative is devoid of explicit criticism of Lot in order to enable a reading that portrays him as worthy of being saved. In the epilogue, however, Lot's offer to the lascivious mob outside his door is finally criticized.⁸⁵ The implicit criticism of Lot who "did not know" is reinforced when the cave narrative is read in the broader context of the destruction of Sodom.

The analogy with the Abraham and Sarah episode continues to establish the criticism of Lot. The previously discussed analogy between the arrival of the angels at each of the locations culminates in the cave scene, in the resolution of the problem of family continuity. Whereas Abraham and Sarah's problem is resolved by God's intervention, it is the daughters' actions that solve the question of Lot's continuity. The divine intervention in Isaac's birth comes as a stark contrast to the incestuous act that leads to the birth of Amon and Moab. Sarah, who was a full partner to her husband's hospitality, enjoyed the reward of a miraculous birth, while Lot's nameless and discourteous wife turned into a pillar of salt.⁸⁶ Lot, like Abraham, invited people into his home; like Abraham, he was rewarded for his hospitality. But Abraham, who shared his values with his wife, was able to also share his reward of fertility with his wife, while Lot, who did not instruct his family in the ways of his beliefs and was willing to give up his daughters for rape and maybe worse, was rewarded with fertility through an incestuous act with his daughters.

Various theories exist with regard to the universal taboo on incestuous relations. According to the biological theory, the aversion to incest reflects the natural need to prevent the unwanted genetic results

84 Turner 1990, 95–96. Cf. Wenham 1994, 61: "The angels have rescued Lot and his virgin daughters from the Sodom mob; now they sacrifice their virginity and their father's honor when there is no actual danger."

85 Low 2010, 40.

86 Polak 1999, 196–97.

of intra-family breeding. In 1934 Edward Westermarck explained that the abstention from incest is part of the evolutionary process of natural selection. He believed that only people who possessed an instinctive aversion to incest survived.⁸⁷ Anthropologists and psychologists challenged this idea and claimed that the prohibition attests to a natural attraction, which needs to be limited by instating a law.⁸⁸

A widely accepted alternative theory was suggested by Claude Levi-Strauss. He believed the prohibition on incest was not focused on preventing intra-family relations, but rather on forcing the family to marry the daughter outside the hereditary line, in what he called “the alliance theory.” Application of this theory through exogamy enables the growth and development of society, and the creation of broad and supportive social networks.⁸⁹ In light of this theory, the incestuous narrative involving Lot cruelly mirrors Lot’s choice to settle in Sodom. Both Lot and Abraham exhibit hospitality, which is based on the need to open one’s door and utilize one’s good fortune for the benefit of a foreigner. The sin of the people of Sodom was their refusal to use their fortune and prosperity to benefit others; despite the fertility of their land and prosperity of their community, they only sought to harm visitors in their city. Incest is an expression of the refusal to open the closed gates of family and share the wealth. The fact that Lot’s fertility remains inside the family unit is another indication of the negative values on which his Sodom-based family was raised.

Lot’s Daughters in the Context of the Abraham Cycle

The design of the narrative encourages a reading based on the broader background of the Abraham–Lot relationship. The verb יָשַׁב (“to sit/settle”), which is emphasized in the exposition, carries dramatic

87 Westermarck 1934, 147.

88 E.g., Frazer 1910, 97–98. Freud also adopted this position.

89 Levi-Strauss 1969, 481.

significance with regard to Lot's character throughout the Abraham cycle. The verb initially appears with regard to the separation of Abraham from Lot, because "their possessions were so great, they could not *settle* together" (13:6), and "the Canaanite and Perizzites were then *dwelling* in the land" (13:7); therefore, each chose to settle in a different location: "Abram *dwelt* in the land of Canaan, while Lot *settled* in the cities of the Plain" (13:12). Lot's choice related specifically to the fertile land of Sodom, which was "well watered" (13:10). The war in ch. 14 affected Lot who, in contrast to Abraham, had "*settled* in Sodom" (14:12–13). In the narrative about the destruction of Sodom, Lot is seated at the gate of the city (19:1), and the narrative concludes by reminding the reader that Lot had chosen to settle in Sodom: "Thus it was that, when God destroyed the cities of the Plain and annihilated the cities *where Lot dwelt...*" (19:29). The epilogue opens with the same root: "Lot went up from Zoar and *settled* in the hill country with his two daughters, for he was afraid to dwell in Zoar; and he and his two daughters *lived* (וִישָׁב) in a cave" (19:30). Lot's story culminates on the hill, instead of his original choice of the plain. Without mentioning Abraham's name, the narrator introduces an additional retroactive evaluation of Lot's choice in juxtaposition with Abraham's.⁹⁰ Abraham's choice to continue journeying through Canaan with God as his guide gave him greater stability than Lot, who was guided by a desire for stability but sought it in a godless place. Wenham wrote: "Lot, the rich rancher who had so many flocks and herds that he had to separate from Abraham (13:8–11), chose to live in the fertile Dead Sea valley, which has been destroyed and with it all his other relations and property. He and all he has can be accommodated in a cave. His ruin can hardly be more complete."⁹¹

The story brings to a close the broader circle of Terah's line. Von Rad claimed that the biblical interest in Lot's story and the establishment of Ammon and Moab is surprising, as is the interest in Ishmael,

90 The plain relates also to the location of Sodom. See, among others, Harland 1942, 45. See also Gen 11:2, which might indicate a general preference of hill-dwelling as opposed to settling in the valley.

91 Wenham 1994, 60.

since they have disengaged from the house of Abraham. He concluded that the narratives were an expression of “the intellectually free and humanized atmosphere which our narrator breathed.”⁹²

What von Rad views as intellectual freedom is better described as the utmost concern for the establishment of family. The book of Genesis is internally structured according to the establishment of families and the tracking of family lines.⁹³ Since the Abraham cycle began with the line of Terah (11:27), the cycle alludes to the establishment of Nahor’s line (22:20–24), through Lot (19:36–38) and of course, ultimately, through Abraham. In spite of the mockery and criticism of Lot, the birth of Ammon and Moab is a positive development in the establishment of the Haran-Lot branch of the Terah line.

92 Von Rad 1963, 219–20.

93 Keil & Delitzsch 1980, 25–37; Thompson 1987, 167–72; Carr 1996; 1969.

Chapter 13: Abraham and Sarah in Gerar (20)

The brevity and omission of explanations imply that this episode of “the endangered ancestress” relies on the narrative in ch. 12.¹ There is no need to explain why Abraham tells his wife to pretend she is his sister, or why the king of Gerar took Sarah (20:2). The information provided in the parallel narrative in ch. 12 is presumed in ch. 20. Some suggested that the purpose of ch. 20 is to moderate the criticism of Abraham in ch. 12. The moderation is perceived in four central areas:

1. In ch. 12 Abraham leaves the Promised Land, while in ch. 20 he remains within the borders of Canaan. Therefore, “the question which was posed on the religious and moral analysis of the story, regarding Abraham’s descent to Egypt, does not exist in the second story.”²
2. Chapter 12 leaves the question of Sarah’s violation open: “in addition to avoiding stating explicitly whether such actions took place, the narrative uses ambiguous terms such as ‘the woman was *taken* to the house of Pharaoh,’ and ‘I *took* her to be my wife.’³ Even if God had afflicted Pharaoh before he had had a chance to do anything to Sarah,⁴ there is no explicit statement to that effect. In contrast, in ch. 20 God Himself says: “I knew that you did this with a blameless heart, and so I kept you from sinning against Me. That was why I did not let you touch her” (20:6).

1 See, among others, Van Seters 1975, 167–91; Ball 1896, 71–72; Jacob 1974, 131; Westermann 1995, 159–68; Coats 1983, 151; Alexander 1992; Aharoni 1979, 220; Wenham 1994, 68. Contra: Seebass 1997, 24 (He claimed that only Gen 20 gives a complete version of the story while Gen 12 and Gen 26 omit important elements).

2 Aharoni 1979, 221.

3 Ibid., 219.

4 Such as the firm opinion of Cassuto 1964, 356, and as opposed to Peleg 2006.

3. While Abraham does not attempt to justify his lie to Pharaoh, Abraham did attempt to justify his lie by explaining to the king of Gerar: “And besides, she is in truth my sister, my father’s daughter though not my mother’s” (20:12). Abraham misled the king to assume he was not married to Sarah; however, the definition of Sarah as Abraham’s sister is not an absolute lie.
4. The gifts Abraham received from each king are presented in a different light in each of the stories. Pharaoh’s gifts were offered as part of Abraham’s deception, as a dowry for Sarah: “And because of her, it went well with Abram; he acquired sheep, oxen, asses, male and female slaves, she-asses, and camels” (12:16). In contrast, Abimelech’s gifts were offered legitimately; in fact, the gifts were offered after Abraham’s secret was revealed (20:14).⁵

The Gerar narrative is therefore often portrayed as a moderation of the Egypt narrative, as Shammai Gelandier noted: “Apparently the link between the three narratives [chs. 12, 20, and 27] indicates a correction and improvement of [Abraham’s and God’s] image.”⁶

However, an analysis of the narrative actually indicates greater criticism of Abraham in the Gerar story. Aharoni appropriately stated, “The second narrative shifts the focal point to the ethical plane,”⁷ but his conclusion that Abraham is portrayed in a more positive light is entirely incorrect.

The narrative lends itself to a dual reading, and the final verse reveals a critical detail that was previously concealed from the reader. The new information creates a demand for a second reading of the

5 Aharoni (1979, 222) wrote that Abraham was portrayed differently as well: in the Egypt narrative he is a “common wanderer,” while in the Gerar narrative he is “Chosen by God, and a prophet,” who can heal Abimelech and his household with his prayer.

6 Gelandier 2009, 87–88. See, among others, Van Seters and Westermann (above); Zakovitch & Shinan 1983, 141. Exum (1993) believed the three narratives express ambivalence toward the idea of the woman being taken by a stranger, which is viewed as both a threat and a secret passion. The fantasy is sublimated from one episode to the next, and the characters eventually overcome forbidden sexuality.

7 Aharoni 1979, 222.

story.⁸ We will therefore attempt to read this episode with emphasis on the narrative's criticism of its characters; once we reach its conclusion, however, we will be forced to retrace our footsteps and reanalyze the narrative as a whole.

Abraham's Journey to Gerar (1)

While standard formulations are used to describe Abraham's journey to Gerar, three details in the verse demand interpretation: "Abraham journeyed *from there* to the region of the Negeb and settled between Kadesh and Shur, and he settled in Gerar." The phrase "from there" seems superfluous, and could easily have been omitted;⁹ alternatively, the place of Abraham's departure could have been mentioned.¹⁰ Instead, the verse describes that Abraham departed from a certain place ("from there") but maintains the anonymity of that location.¹¹ Usually in such biblical descriptions, the new journey is linked to the previous location. When Abraham journeys from Shechem to Bethel, the verse reads: "from there he moved on to the hill country east of Bethel...and he built there an altar" (12:8). Abraham's journey is portrayed as ongoing, so his journey "from there" intends to relate directly

8 Garsiel (1983, 85–89) believed there is an implied criticism of Saul from the outset, which only becomes apparent at the end of his monarchy. With regard to this phenomenon in the Abraham and Abimelech narratives, see Novick 2004; Grossman 2006, 251–65.

9 Cf. Gen 12:9; 35:21; 46:1 and many references outside of Genesis. Ball (1896:15) believed the verse should be corrected accordingly.

10 Cf. Gen 35:16. This is the common formulation in the description of the travels of the Israelites through the wilderness.

11 Westermann (1985:320) wrote that there is no way of determining the location of "from there." Others suggested a variety of locations: "'From there' in context must be Mamre" (Wenham 1994, 69); "the narrative space since 13:18" (Jacob 1974, 131). In contrast with my suggestion above, Koch (1969, 117–18) viewed this as evidence that ch. 20 is an independent story (E) that was originally part of another story cycle.

to the previously mentioned location where Abraham previously built an altar. Similarly, when the angels journey from Sodom they “set out from there and looked down toward Sodom, Abraham walking with them to see them off” [18:16 (and 22)]. The purpose of the report is to link the previous scene (the angels in Sarah’s tent) with what follows (the discussion about the destruction of Sodom). The phrase “[journeyed] from there” is especially prevalent in sequential scenes, such as “Abimelech said to Isaac, ‘go away from us, for you have become far too big for us.’ So Isaac departed *from there* and encamped in the wadi of Gerar, where he settled” (Gen 26:16–17); Isaac departs for Gerar as a response to Abimelech’s request. The incorporation of the phrase is appropriate, since the plot progresses by stages.¹²

In contrast with the examples above, figuring out the place of departure in Abraham’s journey to Gerar is not as simple as looking at the previous verse. The scene preceding the journey was not about Abraham, but about Lot’s daughters.¹³ In this instance, the use of the phrase seems to create a sense of continuity where there is none. The episode in Gerar really has no correlation with the previous two Abraham episodes (Abraham’s hospitality in ch. 18, and Abraham’s viewing of Sodom’s fate in 19:27–28), and the reference “from there” creates a literary link between the episodes.

According to this reading, Abraham’s journey to Gerar should be viewed as a reaction to the destruction of Sodom. Both narratives share a common theme: the sexual corruption of the people of the land. The verses opening each of the episodes correlate in the following way:

The men set out *from there* and looked down toward Sodom, Abraham walking with them to see them off (18:16)

12 See also vs. 22–23.

13 Following the midrash, Rashi links the fact that Abraham left the area to the episode with Lot’s daughters: “To distance himself from Lot, who had acquired a bad reputation, because he had been intimate with his daughters” (Rashi on 20:1). The midrash relates to the hint “from there,” which relates Abraham’s journey to the previous episode.

The men went on *from there* to Sodom, while Abraham remained standing before the Lord (18:22)

Abraham journeyed *from there* to the region of the Negeb and settled between Kadesh and Shur, and he settled in Gerar (20:1)

The angels and Abraham leave the tents in the terebinths of Mamre together, but then go their separate ways: the angels depart for Sodom, and Abraham heads toward Gerar. The arrival of the angels parallels Abraham's arrival in Gerar. Both journeys involve punishment of the locals due to sexual corruption, and in both stories someone is saved from punishment due to Abraham's merit (19:29; 20:17).¹⁴ In both stories Abraham advocates for the people of the land; as noted in the introduction, the use of the word "nation" (גוי) is unusual in the Abraham narrative, and Lipton added that the phrase "all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him" (18:18) replaces "and the families of the earth shall bless themselves by you" (12:3). Perhaps the purpose of the change is to link Abraham's advocating of Sodom with Abimelech's statement, "will you slay a nation, even though innocent?" (20:4).¹⁵

Additional links found throughout the narrative might indicate that the reference "from there" indeed intends to link the two seemingly unrelated episodes. A deliberate link would indicate that the three stories preceding the birth of Isaac relate to the sexual corruption in the societies that surround Abraham: the rape of strangers (Sodom); incest (Amon and Moab); and taking the wife of another (Gerar). The severity of the action is gradually diminished: the Sodomites had premeditated intent to harm Lot's guests; while Lot's daughters were fully aware of their actions, the motives for their actions were positive (to sustain the family line); and while Abimelech took another man's wife, he did so innocently, without a full awareness of his actions.

In contrast to Canaanite culture, Abraham is destined to be 'a blessing to all the nations' by teaching his children "to keep the way

14 Additional links will be addressed below, and are noted by Alter 1994, 36–38; Hamilton 1995, 58–59; Mathews 2005, 248–49.

15 Lipton 1999, 52.

of the Lord by doing what is charitable and just” (18:19). While the sexual conduct of the people of the land is immoral, Isaac is born and immediately circumcised as part of Abraham’s covenant with God, which obligates him to be charitable and just. Abraham comes “from there” but journeys elsewhere, and distinguishes himself with higher values and better morality than the cultures he encounters on his way.

The second detail that demands explanation is the geographical location given by the narrator: “Abraham journeyed from there *to the region of the Negeb* and settled between *Kadesh and Shur*, and he settled in *Gerar*.”¹⁶ Gerar is a city on the border of Canaan: “The Canaanite territory extended from Sidon as far as Gerar” (10:19).¹⁷ Since the previous wife-sister story took place in Egypt, there is significance in the fact that this story takes place inside the borders of the Promised Land.¹⁸ Perhaps this is the reason for the emphasis of the location “between Kadesh and Shur” – in other words, in the south of Canaan.¹⁹ As previously stated, some feel this fact portrays Abraham in a positive light since he remains within the boundaries of the Promised Land. However, the main conflict in the narrative does not relate to Abraham

16 Note the alliteration **וַיָּגֵר בְּגֵרָר** (“va-yagar bi-Gerar”), mentioned by Skinner (1930, 315) and others. Beno Jacob (1974, 131) noted the link between Gerar and **גֵּר** (“ger” – “foreigner”); both associations are appropriate in the context of the narrative.

17 Albright surmised that Gaza and Gerar are adjacent, while Alt claimed that they are situated along the same border but are not adjacent. See: Aharoni, “Gerar.”

18 Previously noted by R. David Kimhi (Radak) on Gen 20:1. Therefore, it is inaccurate to view the “foreign land” motif as a common denominator of all three stories (e.g., Van Seters 1975, 183). Although Abraham is faced with a foreign culture, which considers him a foreigner, he is still on the same land.

19 On the debate regarding the location of Gerar between “Kadesh and Shur,” see Westermann 1995, 320. Note that Abraham’s permanent dwelling is said to be between “Kadesh and Shur,” while he is only a temporary “stranger” in Gerar. Perhaps the detailed description wishes to create the association with Hagar’s flight, where the angel appears to her “on the road to Shur” (16:7), a place characterized later in the chapter as “between Kadesh and Bered” (14). In ch. 16, Abraham “separates” from Hagar when she escapes from his home, and Hagar is returned to Abraham through divine intervention. Here, too, Abraham separates from his wife, who will only be returned through divine intervention.

leaving the land but whether Abraham is justified in deceiving a foreign king in his own land.

The third detail is a question of omission. Unlike the two parallel narratives in Gen 12 and 26, no famine is mentioned in the text as the reason for Abraham's journey to Gerar. There is no textual justification for assuming that there was a famine based on the parallel narratives;²⁰ on the contrary, the missing reason sets the tone that differentiates this story from the others.²¹ In Gen 12 and 26, Abraham and Isaac endanger themselves by traveling to foreign cities due to the famine. Why does Abraham expose himself and his family to the dangers of Gerar? Various reasons were suggested for Abraham's dangerous journey, while on a literary plane the silence of the narrator is more significant than deduced possibilities. The absence of a reason makes Abraham's deception voluntary.

These three details at the outset of Abraham's journey set the tone for the evaluation of the characters throughout the narrative.

Abimelech Takes Sarah (2)

While the narrative largely relies upon the lengthy parallel description in Gen 12, two brief details are mentioned: "Abraham said to²² Sarah his wife, 'She is my sister.' So King Abimelech of Gerar took Sarah."

20 Aharoni (1979, 213) wrote: "in all three narratives the patriarch is forced to travel outside the borders of his dwelling due to a famine." He added in note 1: "the second narrative did not mention a famine explicitly, but based on the two parallel stories one can assume this was the case in the second narrative as well." Aharoni himself expresses reservations from his previous statement: "the source of the crisis (famine) is not mentioned here, and we do not know the reason Abraham went to live in Gerar" (p. 220; see also p. 221, note 30).

21 R. David Kimhi (Radak) on Gen 20:1 proved that the journey was not the result of a famine from the opening verse of the narrative of Isaac and Rebekah in Gerar: "There was a famine in the land – aside from the previous famine that had occurred in the days of Abraham" (26:1).

22 NJPS translated "of Sarah" instead of "to."

The preposition לָ (‘‘to’’) denotes ‘‘of’’ or ‘‘regarding.’’ But use of this phrase in contrast to ch. 12 emphasizes the absence of direct communication between Abraham and Sarah. In the Egypt narrative Abraham justified his actions to Sarah, and seems to have asked for her permission to act as he did (Gen 12:11–13). The Egypt narrative creates the impression that Abraham is uneasy about his actions, which demand explanation and justification. In contrast, the succinctness of the Gerar text creates the impression that Abraham’s actions are automatic. The verse creates anticipation for direct communication between Abraham and Sarah (‘‘Abraham said to his wife Sarah’’), but in reality Abraham speaks *of* her, instead of communicating *with* her. The time description, which is present in the Egypt narrative but missing in Gerar, correlates with this detail: Abraham had asked Sarah whether she would pretend to be his sister *before* they reached Egypt (12:11). In contrast, only once Sarah and Abraham reach Gerar is the plan exposed to the reader: ‘‘The impression given is that the episode in Egypt was well planned and carefully thought. The episode in Gerar reads as a more spontaneous event.’’²³

Despite the fact that all of these details can be attributed to the succinct writing that results from reliance of the text on the parallel story, the opening verses create a significantly different reading experience. The succinct style is continued in the king’s actions as well; Pharaoh takes Sarah after hearing rumors of her beauty, while the king of Gerar takes her seemingly for no particular reason. Even if the reader is capable of filling in the narrative gap him or herself, the fact that it is not written explicitly has bearing upon the plot design.

23 Hamilton 1995, 59.

The Dialogue between God and Abimelech (3–7)

The meaning of a story is created throughout the reading process, in what Perry called the “dynamic of the literary text.”²⁴ Some details that might seem trivial at first glance become deeply significant in the context of the full narrative. The information is offered in a deliberate order that affects the reading process and the deciphering of the story. The Gerar narrative is a classic example of this literary style: Information provided at the end of the narrative sheds new light on the entire story.

The Gerar narrative is based on two broad dialogues, between God and Abimelech (3–7) and between Abraham and Abimelech (9–13). Despite the initial conflict, both dialogues end on a peaceful note, and all parties work toward creating a solution to a problematic situation: God instructs Abimelech to return Sarah to Abraham, and Abimelech offers Abraham safe residence on his land.

Despite the criticism in the content of God’s revelation,²⁵ the fact of the revelation to a foreign king contributes to the positive evaluation of the character, and contrasts Abimelech with his Egyptian counterpart.²⁶ The positive evaluation of Abimelech is reinforced by the narrator’s remark, which is inserted into the dialogue between God’s reprimand (“You are to die because of the woman that you have taken”) and Abimelech’s response (“will You slay people even

24 Perry 1979.

25 The phrase “You are to die” might indicate an imminent death (Gesenius 1889, 454–55, and see also note 2 on p. 455; Gunkel 1997, 221). However, the phrase can also indicate a changed message (e.g., Judg 9:31–33); the simple reading of the verse is the threat of punishment for Abimelech’s behavior; Jacob (1974, 131) and Westermann (1995, 322) cited Is 38:1 as an example. Samuel David Luzzato, followed by Fidler (2006, 26), believed “Avimelekh did not understand that this decree was conditional, and so he said ‘would You kill a nation, although innocent?’” (Luzzato 1998, 187). However, Abimelech is correct in assuming that even if God’s threat was conditional, there is room to inquire whether a person is innocent.

26 Alter 2004, 98.

though innocent?”), by offering the critical information: “Abimelech had not approached her.” Westermann remarked on this verse: “The introductory sentence... does not fit the process and is not necessary for it; the guilt consists in Abimelech’s abduction of a man’s wife. The sentence has been added out of excessive caution.”²⁷ However, had the information not been provided, the reader might have had doubts about whether Abimelech had indeed had relations with Abraham’s wife. The use of the verb ויקח in the initial general description, “King Abimelech of Gerar *took* Sarah” (20:2),²⁸ might merely indicate a legal action, but could also imply a sexual act. God’s harsh words, “You are to die because of the woman that you have *taken*,” seems to support a more severe scenario. The dilemma is resolved by the narrator’s remark, and is therefore insignificant; however, as Westermann noted, the insertion of the comment in the midst of the dialogue seems out of place and prevents a natural resolution through the dialogue. The narrator “intervenes” on Abimelech’s behalf, reinforcing his actions and defending him from God’s wrath before he even has a chance to defend himself, thereby creating identification with and empathy toward Abimelech’s cause.

Abimelech’s response to the divine accusation opens with a theological statement: “O Lord, will You slay people even though innocent?” (20:4).²⁹ Abimelech’s statement is reminiscent of Abraham’s remark in Gen 18:24–25: “Far be it from You to do such a thing, to bring death upon the innocent as well as the guilty... Shall not the Judge of all the earth deal justly?” Both plaintiffs use the term צדיק (“innocent”), and design their rhetorical question in a similar manner; both turn to God using the name Adonai (18:27). The premise of both

27 Westermann 1995, 322.

28 NJPS translated “had Sarah brought to him.”

29 Many noted the possibility of a dittography in the words הַגִּי גַם (Skinner 1930, 317, based on Geiger; Speiser 1964, 149; Westermann 1995, 318; Fidler 1991, 34 note 42). Gunkel (1997, 220) wrote that the dittography was the result of a later addition. However, the grammatical difficulty remains, since the concept of the kingdom being punished for the actions of its leader is expressed in v. 9 (Fidler *ibid.*).

statements is that God is just and will not punish the innocent.³⁰ The demands for justice by both Abraham and Abimelech portray the latter in a positive light. As well, the phrasing of Abimelech's declaration of innocence, "my heart was blameless and my hands were clean," is similar to God's demand of Abraham to "walk in My ways and be blameless" (17:1). The context of the demand was the Covenant of Circumcision, which is based on the reciprocity between fertility and sexual purity.³¹ Abimelech parallels Abraham's position in the Sodom narrative, but also in the Covenant of Circumcision: he is blameless, and expects God to reciprocate impartially.

Abimelech's response further supports a positive evaluation. The justification of his actions is not eloquent or well-expressed; the brief successive syllables and repetitive information ("He himself said to me, 'She is my sister!' And she also said, 'He is my brother!'") express the confusion and embarrassment of one who has fallen into a trap. An allusion to this trap might even be found in God's accusation: "You are to *die* because of the woman that you have taken, for she is *the wife of another man*." The phrase *בעלת בעל*, which denotes "a married woman," is found in only one other biblical reference in Deut 22:22: "If a man is found lying with the *wife of another man*,³² both of them – the man and the woman with whom he lay – shall die." Both verses sentence the offender to death; however, the law in Deuteronomy specifies that both the man and the woman who engage in such an act must die, while in Genesis the "wife of another man" is the only one of the two who is aware of her status. Beneath the surface of God's severe accusation the reader must wonder whether Abraham and Sarah should be blamed for Abimelech's actions, rather than the innocent and deceived king.

30 Davidson 1979, 81; Moberly 1995, 71–72.

31 Similarly, Cotter 2003, 131–32. The grammatical link is sufficient for the desired effect on the reading consciousness, especially in light of the broader connection between the two characters, which is based on additional components as noted below.

32 NJPS translated the phrase *בעלת בעל* – "married woman" in Gen 20:3, and "another man's wife" in Deuteronomy 22:22.

God's response to Abimelech is in two parts: v. 6 approves Abimelech's claim of innocence and v. 7 provides instructions regarding future actions. Despite the initial attack on Abimelech, God acknowledges his innocence and justifies his actions. Abimelech uses the word אַל ("also") twice in his plea of innocence (4–5), and the phrase appears twice in God's response, to emphasize that God is indeed on Abimelech's side:

I *also* knew that you did this with a blameless heart,
and so I *also* kept you from sinning against Me.

God's reference to Abimelech's "blameless heart" is a direct response to Abimelech's appeal, "my heart was blameless and my hands were clean." God accepts the fact that Abimelech was deceived.³³ The concentric structure of the dream suggested by Alexander accentuates God's approval:³⁴

- a. You are to *die*
 - b. because of the woman that you have taken, for she is *the wife of another man*
 - c. Now Abimelech *had not approached her*.
 - d. He said, "O Lord, will You slay people even though *innocent?*"
 - e. When I did this, my *heart was blameless* and my hands were clean
 - f. And God said to him in the dream
 - e1. I knew that you did this with *a blameless heart*
 - d1. and so *I kept you from sinning against Me*
 - c1. That was why *I did not let you touch her*
 - b1. Therefore, restore the *man's wife* – since he is a prophet
 - a1. he will intercede for you – so you may live.³⁵ If you fail to restore her, know that you shall *die*, you and all that are yours.

33 Wenham (1994, 71) wrote that the reader realizes at this stage that Abimelech never touched Sarah due to his illness, based on the comparison with ch. 12; however, there is no reason to assume the narratives will have an identical outcome, and the reading consciousness cannot be based upon this assumption.

34 Alexander 1997, 39. Alexander claims that the verses surrounding the dream loosely parallel one another (8–13/14–17).

35 NJPS translated "to save your life."

The phrase **לֹא נִתְחַיֵּךְ לְנִגַּע אֵלֶיָּהּ** (“I did not let you touch her”) further emphasizes that Abimelech was distant from sin. The common phrase used to describe contact with another is **נִגַּע ב־** (cf. Gen 26:11; Ex 19:12); the expression **לְנִגַּע אֵלֶיָּהּ** conveys a greater distance, closer in meaning to the narrator’s comment “Abimelech had *not approached her*.” The phrase **לְנִגַּע** means “to touch,” while the clever use of the specific spelling uses the same letters as the word **נִגַּע** (“affliction”), creating a grammatical association with the parallel story of Pharaoh, who had suffered afflictions as a result of taking Sarah (12:17). While God afflicted Pharaoh for taking Sarah, He helped Abimelech avoid sin by speaking to him. Despite the overwhelming evidence in favor of Abimelech, there is an indication that Abimelech’s innocence should be attributed not to his righteousness but to God’s intervention.³⁶ Additionally, although God repeats Abimelech’s remark about his blamelessness, He omits the “cleanliness of his hands.”³⁷ These two details, which will be discussed further below, do not detract from Abimelech’s innocence in the sin that is initially attributed to him.

The second part of God’s response includes instructions on how to correct the situation, and the demand to return Sarah to Abraham. In contrast with the positive portrayal of Abimelech, a harsher tone is taken with regard to Abimelech’s future actions (20:7):

Therefore, restore the man’s wife – since he is a prophet, he will intercede for you so you may live.

If you fail to restore her, know that you shall die, you and all that are yours.

The word **וְעַתָּה** (“therefore”) is a common opening to the conclusion of a speech. In view of all that was previously stated, Abimelech is expected to take action to rectify the situation. Abimelech is given two options; he can either “restore” or “fail to restore,” and as a result, he can “live” or “die,” respectively.

In light of the positive evaluation of Abimelech, and God’s assurance of his blamelessness, in addition to the narrator’s testimony of his innocence, the threatening tone seems out of place, as does the

36 Cf. Wenham 1994, 71.

37 See Rashi on Gen 20:6.

possibility that Abimelech will fail to return Abraham's wife. If Sarah was taken innocently and under false pretenses, there is no reason to assume that Abimelech would not rectify the situation. The threat of punishment is expanded beyond Abimelech, and includes his dynasty and household: "you and all that are yours." The severity of the threat indicates divine wrath toward Abimelech. Even according to the "positive" scenario, in which Abimelech returns Sarah, Abimelech's survival can only be ensured with Abraham's intervention once his wife is restored; in other words, Abimelech's life is very much in danger. The reason Abraham can save Abimelech's life by interceding on his behalf is his identification as a "prophet." Clearly the power of the revelation was previously overrated; otherwise, why would Abimelech need Abraham's intervention if Abimelech himself can communicate with God?³⁸

The second part of God's response conveys anger at Abimelech, indicating a negative evaluation of the character, in contrast with the previously positive evaluation. These are the seeds of the dual evaluation and twofold reading of the narrative, which are developed and enhanced throughout the narrative.

Early Next Morning (8)

God's revelation to Abimelech took place in a dream at night (3:6),³⁹ and the following scene occurs "early next morning." The time definition emphasizes Abimelech's urgency. Abimelech's instant action and

38 Fidler 1991, 28. See also Shemesh 2002 – Lies. Perhaps the definition of Abraham as a prophet emphasizes Abraham's greatness in comparison to Abimelech: while Abimelech had a revelation, he is not categorized as a prophet like Abraham.

39 For the specific significance of a dream revelation see Oppenheim 1956, 192 (who believes there are religious or literary reasons for a revelation through a dream); Fidler 2006, 91–124.

the disclosure of God's command to his servants are to his merit.⁴⁰ Abimelech and his servants are God-fearing, and heed His warning. The kingdom is in an uproar when Abimelech's actions are discovered, which indicates that taking another man's wife was an uncommon offense.

The phrase "early next morning" contributes to the positive evaluation of Abimelech's character. This formulation is present in all stories surrounding the Gerar narrative (19:27; 21:14; 22:3), but all three narratives remark on *Abraham's* early start. The Babylonian Talmud viewed the expression as a connotation of activism and enthusiasm to fulfill a task: "the zealous are early [to perform] their religious duties, for it is said, 'And Abraham rose early in the morning'" (*b. Pesahim* 4a). Abimelech's eagerness to fulfill God's command continues the trend of "walking in Abraham's ways"; not only does Abimelech argue morality with God, he also wakes up early to heed the word of God!

Abimelech's urgency does not bring him to Abraham's doorstep immediately. First, he gathers his servants and shares the contents of his dream.⁴¹ The reader is unaware of any involvement of Abimelech's household in the story, and Abimelech's disclosure of his own folly seems noble; he could have returned Sarah to Abraham discreetly. This implies that like Abraham, Abimelech is intent on teaching his household justice and righteousness; he is not ashamed of his mistake, which he uses to demonstrate the correct path. The reaction of Abimelech's people, "and the men were greatly frightened," indicates shared values and moral discourse. The root ירא, which denotes both fear and sight, is used interchangeably in the parallel narratives of Gen 12 and 20: Whereas "Pharaoh's courtiers *saw her* (וַיִּרְאוּ) and praised her to Pharaoh," Abimelech's servants "were greatly *frightened* (וַיִּירָאוּ)."⁴²

40 The form באזניהם... וידבר ("and told them") is often used in the context of revealing something new (Gen 44:18; 50:4; Ex 11:2), but could also express a report or review (1 Sam 8:21; 11:4; 18:23).

41 The king's address to his servants is linked to his reprimand of Abraham; from a literary perspective Abimelech might have summoned his servants and Abraham simultaneously.

42 "Who wants to admit publicly that he has been tricked? His willingness to be open and tell the truth contrasts with Abraham and his subterfuge" (Hamilton 1995, 67).

Abimelech only addresses Abraham after he has informed the people of his household, who react to the news with great fear.

Abimelech and Abraham (9–13)

Abimelech accuses Abraham of acting against laws of natural morality, which he views as a great sin. Abimelech testifies that he is honest, in contrast with Abraham who has brought “so great a guilt upon me and my kingdom.” He describes taking another man’s wife as “things that ought not to be done.”⁴³ Since Sodom was described in similar terms of great sinfulness and immorality (18:20), the formulation of Abimelech’s words seems to compare Abraham to the Sodomites, and indicate that he, too, practices sexual immorality!

The double caption (Abimelech said...) in vs. 9–10 might indicate Abraham’s silence at the initial accusation.⁴⁴ Abraham is dumbfounded when such severe accusations are made against him, specifically because they contain a grain of truth; had God not intervened, Abraham would have been responsible for a great sin.

Abraham’s justification, “I thought surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me because of my wife” (20:11),⁴⁵ provides no new information to the reader; however, the claim’s appearance

43 The expression חטאה גדולה (“a great guilt”) has the connotation of sexual sins in ancient Near Eastern literature (Rabinowitz 1959, 73; Moran 1959, 280–81; Milgrom 1976, 132–33; Sarna 1989, 143). Abimelech seems to be using a common term for a sexual offense.

44 Alter 2004, 99. Based on this suggestion, the example should have been included in what Shiloah called “waiting for a response or reaction” (Shiloah 1964, 251). Shiloah attributed this example to the group in which the dual caption differentiates between “two claims” (p. 253), while Jacob (1974, 132) and Westermann (1985, 325) felt the first caption related to a general criticism (to which Abraham was not expected to respond), while the second was a concrete question to which Abraham was expected to offer a response.

45 “Fear of God” is a biblical expression of a morally conscientious world. See Van Pelt & Kaiser, ירא, 533.

here instead of at the outset of the narrative supplies the reader with ample information to know that Abraham is wrong. In addition to the overwhelming evidence that Abimelech is just, honest, and moral, his servants react to his revelation by becoming “greatly frightened (מאד ויראו)” (20:8) in contrast with Abraham’s assumption that “there is no fear of God (יראת אלהים).”⁴⁶ The design of the narrative compares Abraham’s concern with the reaction of the servants. Abimelech rises early and speaks to his servants, and to Abraham. A comparison of the dialogues reinforces the ironic link between Abraham’s wrong assessment and the true colors of Gerar:

| <i>Abimelech and his Servants (8)</i> | <i>Abimelech and Abraham (9–11)</i> |
|--|---|
| Abimelech called his servants | Then Abimelech summoned Abraham |
| and told them all that had happened (הדברים האלה). | What, then, was your purpose in doing this thing (הדבר הזה). |
| and the men were greatly frightened. | I thought surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me because of my wife! |

Abraham further justified his deception by explaining that Sarah was indeed his “sister” (family member). Many scholars viewed this reasoning as a moral portrayal of Abraham’s character in the story, in contrast with ch. 12: “The purpose of every detail of the story is to purify (from guilt or impurity) all of the protagonists – God, Abraham, Abimelech, and Sarah – through justifying their behavior, which is fair and correct under the circumstances.”⁴⁷

In addition to the vague expression “my sister,” which is used explicitly in the narrative (“she is in truth my sister”), some scholars

46 Similarly: Emanueli 1978, 198; Wenham 1994, 72; Westermann 1995, 324–25. Alter (1996, 94) wrote: “In the event, he is entirely wrong: Abimelech is a decent, even noble man.” Wenham (1994, 68) also noted a concentric structure surrounding v. 8, which describes Abimelech’s conversation with his servants. This position gives centrality to Abimelech’s speech and the servants’ reaction, which affects the evaluation of the characters.

47 Fidler 1991, 20, among others.

“justified” Abraham’s formulation based on marriage documents found in Nuzi. The documents were revealed by Speiser, who demonstrates the use of the word “sister” in the context of a betrothal (the agreement was generally made between a brother of the bride and the future husband).⁴⁸ Koschaker believed the terms “wife” and “sister” were identical in Nuzi culture.⁴⁹ This hypothesis was rejected by various scholars,⁵⁰ and was later revived by scholars of the literary school, who noted that the word “sister” is often “borrowed” to connote “love” and “wife.”⁵¹ This alternative meaning is particularly prevalent throughout the Song of Songs 4:9–12: “You have captured my heart, my sister, my bride... How sweet is your love, my sister, my bride! ... A garden locked is my sister, my bride, a fountain locked, a sealed up spring.”⁵²

The implication here is that Abraham did not lie when he called his wife “sister,” even if by using an ambiguous term he created the impression that he was not Sarah’s husband. While this suggestion is captivating, the text fails to support this reading.⁵³ The term “sister” in reference to a beloved wife is found nowhere in the Abraham cycle outside the three problematic narratives of Gen 12, 20, and 27. In fact, the term is found nowhere else in ancient biblical literature.⁵⁴ Moreover, Abraham’s justification intends to downplay the deception in the story by defining Sarah as his sister. But Abraham’s response fails to justify the possibility of the immoral outcome of his lie, which could

48 Speiser 1964.

49 Koschaker 1933.

50 Like Thompson 1974, 315–30. For a detailed discussion on this issue see Greengus 1975; Eichler 1978; Davidson 1979, 25–26.

51 E.g., Jacob 1974, 89; Sarna 1989, 95; Zakovitch 2005, 141.

52 See also Prov 7:4. Regarding the meaning of sister, see KBL, 31 (“zur Geliebten”); BDB, 27 (“beloved, bride”).

53 See Shemesh 2002 – Lies; Grossman 2004. Thompson wrote: “Speiser’s ‘interpretation’ of Gen 12, 20 and 26 is not based on the Genesis text, but is rather the construction of a historical hypothesis based on historical record.” (Thompson 1974, 235).

54 Alternatively, the term “brother” is found in reference to males who are not blood relations (Gen 17:7; 29:4; 31:37); this might support the position that there is a half-truth in Sarah referring to Abraham as “brother.”

have led to illicit relations between his wife and Abimelech! Abimelech is not concerned with Abraham's semantics, but rather with the detrimental consequences of Abraham's dishonesty.⁵⁵ The addition of another explanation with the adverb **וְכֵן** conveys Abraham's embarrassment and confusion; even he realized that the initial explanation was insufficient, and so he offered another reason for his actions, which was worse than the former.⁵⁶ Abraham had requested of Sarah "Let this be the kindness that you shall do me," while her kindness toward Abraham was damaging to others. Abraham has difficulty defending himself in light of Abimelech's claim. "You have done to me things that ought not to be done!"⁵⁷

The evaluation of the characters in the narrative is deepened by the comparison of the two dialogues on which the story is based: that between God and Abimelech in his dream, and that between Abraham and Abimelech. Westermann noted that the writing style shows that the dialogues are the main purpose of the story.⁵⁸ While Gen 12 focuses on the events, Gen 20 concentrates on the evaluation of the various characters through the two dialogues:

55 Nahmanides on Gen 20:12. Mathews (2005, 258) wrote harshly: "The impotent excuses the patriarch presents casts him in an even more distasteful light."

56 Abimelech's reference to Abraham as Sarah's "brother" at the conclusion of the narrative (16) does not prove that Abraham's claim "was accepted by Abimelech" (Fidler 1991, 26–27). Abimelech's formulation is meant to be sarcastic. Sarna (1989, 103) added that the fact that the Isaac narratives use the "sister" motif proves that the argument is unrelated to the actual paternal connection, "my father's daughter though not my mother's." This argument further weakens Abraham's claim in the eyes of the reader, who is familiar with all three texts.

57 The word **חֶסֶד** ("kindness"), which Abraham uses to describe Sarah's willingness to pretend she is his sister, also appears in the context of incest between a brother and sister in Lev 20:17. Carmichael (1997, 14–44) believed the order of Leviticus 18 correlates with the stories in Genesis, and that the prohibition on incest between a brother and sister is a response to the sister-wife stories in Genesis. See also Meacham 1997.

58 Westermann 1995, 319.

| | <i>God and Abimelech</i> | <i>Abimelech and Abraham</i> |
|---|---|--|
| The characters meet | God came to Abimelech in a dream by night and said to him | Abimelech summoned Abraham and said to him |
| Accusation:
The sin of taking another man's wife | You are to die because of the woman that you have taken, for she is married to another man | <p>"What have you done to us? What wrong have I done that you should bring so great a guilt upon me and my kingdom? You have done to me things that ought not to be done!"</p> <p>"What, then," Abimelech demanded of Abraham, "was your purpose in doing this thing?"</p> |
| The narrator justifies the "defendant" | Now Abimelech had not approached her | |
| Defense | He said, "O Lord, will You slay people even though innocent? He himself <i>said to me</i> , 'She is my sister!' And <i>she also said</i> , ' <i>He is my brother</i> .' When I did this, my heart was blameless and my hands were clean." | <p>"I thought," said Abraham, "surely there is no fear of God in this place, and they will kill me because of my wife.</p> <p>And <i>also</i>, she is in truth my sister, my father's daughter though not my mother's; and she became my wife. So when God made me wander from my father's house, I said to her, "Let this be the kindness that you shall do me: whatever place we come to, <i>say there of me: He is my brother</i>."</p> |
| Reconciliation | And God said to him in the dream, "I knew that you did this with a blameless heart... Therefore, restore the man's wife – since he is a prophet, he will intercede for you – so you may live. If you fail to restore her, know that you shall die, you and all that are yours." | <p>Abimelech took sheep and oxen... and he restored his wife Sarah to him.</p> <p>Abraham then prayed to God, and God healed Abimelech and his wife and his slave girls, so that they bore children.</p> |

Both dialogues center on the allegations of immorality and defense by the accused; in both cases the two parties eventually reconcile. According to the table above, Abimelech parallels God; God accuses Abimelech of immorality, and Abimelech accuses Abraham of unethical conduct. Before Abimelech responds to God's accusations, the narrator sides with him; this literary justification is not paralleled in the case of Abraham. The word "also" is used in the responses to both accusations, as is the repetition of the deception ("he is my brother"). These links reinforce Abimelech's grievances; even Abraham admits the deception, using the very same formulations Abimelech had quoted. The third part of each interaction creates an atmosphere of appeasement, and God's demands of Abimelech are met at the conclusion of the second dialogue.

Based on the positive characterization of Abimelech; God's approval; Abimelech's eagerness to rectify the situation; the portrayal of Abimelech's household as God-fearing; Abraham's lack of faith in a God-fearing community; and Abraham's unsatisfying explanations regarding potentially disastrous behavior; Abimelech seems to have the upper hand in the ethical debate with Abraham.

Reconciliation (14–18)

Abimelech's actions are recorded without interruption:

Abimelech took sheep and oxen, and male and female slaves,
and gave them to Abraham;
and he restored his wife Sarah to him.
And Abimelech said, "Here, my land is before you; settle wherever you please."
And to Sarah he said, "I herewith give your brother a thousand pieces of silver;
this will serve you as vindication before all who are with you, and you are
cleared before everyone."

Abraham and Sarah's reunion is not described in the text; the narrator fails to disclose whether Abraham accepted Abimelech's generous

offers of land and silver; and Sarah's reaction to Abimelech's suggestion is omitted. The text conveys a sense of activity and eagerness on the part of Abimelech, who wants to make things right and compensate those who were hurt in the process. The focus on Abimelech's actions demonstrates how much more he gave than what God had demanded of him: to return Sarah to her legitimate husband.⁵⁹ This might be viewed as a happy conclusion to the story, and the evaluation of Abimelech's character remains altogether positive.

Abimelech's gifts set him apart from Pharaoh: while Pharaoh offered Abraham goods when he thought he was receiving Sarah in return, Abimelech offered Abraham cattle and silver when he knew he would have to return Sarah. The narrator creates a correlation between Sarah and the gifts that almost trivializes her as one of the many objects offered to Abraham. The strange order, which places the gifts before Sarah, is reminiscent of the order of the text in the Egypt narrative, where the gifts are offered as a dowry; here, however, the gifts are offered as part of Sarah's return to her husband. Cassuto read the order in correlation with the Assyrian law that stated that a married woman who was taken on a journey by another man, who did not know she was married, was required to take an oath upon their return that he did not dishonor her, in addition to offering her husband two tin loaves.⁶⁰ Cassuto assumed that the Assyrian law was known and practiced in Israel.⁶¹ Weinfeld demonstrated that the Alternative Genesis found in Qumran reflects a similar reading, according to which Pharaoh swore that he did not know Sarah was married, and offered to compensate Abraham. Weinfeld concluded that "one should take note of a prevalent custom throughout the ancient Near East for over one thousand years."⁶² However, as Weinfeld himself noted, the Assyrian law can shed light on Gen 20, and reinforce the giving of gifts as a compensation instead of a dowry. The Assyrian law highlights the distinction between the Egypt and

59 Cf. Westermann 1995, 319.

60 Middle Assyrian Laws I:22 (Driver 1916, 392).

61 Cassuto 1964, 357.

62 Weinfeld 1983, 640.

Gerar narratives, and once again reinforces the positive evaluation of Abimelech in contrast to Pharaoh.

An additional distinction can be found in the actions of each of the kings after Abraham's deceit was revealed. After discovering that Abraham made a mockery of Pharaoh and his kingdom, who were afflicted by Abraham's God, Pharaoh banishes him from his land and wants nothing to do with him (12:20). In stark contrast, in addition to offering Abraham gifts, Abimelech invited him to stay as a permanent resident in his land, despite the deceit he had suffered (20:15). The climax of Abimelech's decency is with regard to Sarah; he announces publicly that Abraham and Sarah are legitimately married, and then proceeds to appease Sarah.

Sarah's appeasement is not a necessary detail to further the plot, and serves the sole purpose of emphasizing Abimelech's kind nature. He humorously relates to Abraham as Sarah's "brother," perhaps also demonstrating his acceptance of the excuse Abraham offers for his lie.⁶³ Various explanations have been offered with regard to v. 16: "And to Sarah he said, 'I herewith give your brother a thousand pieces of silver; this will serve you as vindication before all who are with you, and you are cleared before everyone.'"⁶⁴ Abimelech's declaration

63 Skinner (1930:319) suggested that the gifts to Sarah are a cynical act: when a single woman is harmed, she receives gifts, while the husband is compensated for damage done to a married woman. Abimelech compensates Sarah as though she had been a virgin. As noted above, I believe Abimelech's act is not cynical, but particularly sensitive to Sarah, who personally suffered.

64 The verse is difficult, and various interpretations were offered. Many viewed the pronoun **זה** (above: "this"; literally: "he") in the phrase "this will serve you as vindication" as a reference to the money. Westermann (1985, 317) and von Rad (1963, 229) suggested that the money was a vindication to those who looked at Sarah: a protection from criticism. This explanation correlates with their interpretation of the rest of the verse: "and you are cleared before everyone." Rashi wrote: "They will cover their eyes, so that they will not denigrate you, for had I returned you empty-handed, they could say, 'After he violated her, he returned her.' Now that I had to spend much money and to appease you, they will know that I returned you against my will, and through a miracle." Dillmann wrote that this is Abimelech's confession about what he did to Sarah. In addition to his suggestion above, Wenham (1994, 74) suggested that the

regarding Abraham and Sarah's married status prevents such a mistake from being made by others. Whereas Pharaoh looks after his own interests, Abimelech attempts to prevent future injustice.

In conclusion, the narrator directs criticisms at Abraham, while Abimelech is portrayed as acting on a higher moral plane. God reveals Himself to Abimelech and speaks with him; He accepts and reinforces Abimelech's innocence, which is also supported by the narrator; Abimelech is open with his subjects about his dream and his mistake, and they react appropriately. Despite Abraham's deceit and inadequate explanations, Abimelech offers him gifts and land.

On Abraham's part, the story offers no overt justification for going to Gerar (no famine is mentioned); the absence of dialogue between Abraham and Sarah depicts the deceit as standard procedure ("whatever place we come to"); Abimelech is critical of Abraham, and Abraham fails to offer a satisfactory explanation for his actions. Coats added that Abraham uses God's treatment as one of his excuses: "when God made me wander from my father's house..." (20:13),⁶⁵ which may evoke Adam's reaction when his sin was revealed. In his attempt to justify his own actions, Abraham only reinforced Abimelech's grievances toward him.⁶⁶

A Double Reading

Abraham's prayer for Abimelech is mentioned in God's revelation. Some scholars viewed the classification of Abraham as a "prophet" as

"cover" is for "Sarah's eyes"; a bribe to make her overlook and forgive what Abimelech had done to her. Gilad (1977, 45) explained that the pronoun *היא* refers to an actual cover for her face, worn by married women to alert others of their status. For other suggestions that involve altering the text see, among others, Ball 1896, 72; Gunkel 1997, 222; Skinner 1930, 319–20.

65 Coats 1983, 150.

66 Some concluded accordingly that in this narrative Abimelech is portrayed as better than Abraham. See Westermann 1995, 329; McConville 2006, 46 ff.

the reason for divine intervention; as a man of God, harming Abraham is taboo.⁶⁷ Others linked the definition of Abraham's prophecy with Abimelech's need for prayer.⁶⁸ Prayer is the traditional role of the prophets, who mediate between God and man. However, in addition to Abraham's prayer, the conclusion of the narrative offers new information that was previously omitted: "and God healed Abimelech and his wife and his slave girls, so that they bore children" (20:17). Not only is this crucial information omitted throughout the text; even Abraham's prayer, which is mentioned in the very same verse, fails to mention the need for urgent healing or assistance in childbirth.⁶⁹ The integration of this detail at the end of the narrative demands additional explanation, which is offered in the following verse: "for the Lord had closed fast every womb of the household of Abimelech because of Sarah, the wife of Abraham" (20:18).⁷⁰ Two features in the verse support scholars who attribute the verse to a separate source: God's name is changed from Elohim to YHWH; and the divine affliction in the verse is directed specifically at women, while according to v. 17 God struck Abimelech as well. Some scholars adopted the Samaritan version that integrated the name "Elohim" in the final verse as well,⁷¹ while others claimed that the last verse is a later addition by the final redactor.⁷² Such a conclusion would assume that the final redactor was sloppy and failed to notice the incongruities created by the editing process. Westermann wrote about the contradiction between vs. 17

67 Procksch (1913, 303) discusses the danger of interacting with prophets; see also Gunkel 1997, 220.

68 See Westermann 1995, 325.

69 The atmosphere of the revelation indicates that the words "so you may live" do not imply that Abimelech's life was in danger.

70 Commentators debated the meaning of the phrase "for the Lord had closed fast every womb." Rashi on Gen 20:17 wrote that pregnant women were prevented from giving birth. R. David Kimhi (Radak) offered this possibility, but added as an alternative possibility the rabbinic position of b. Bava Kama 92a, that the entire kingdom could not defecate. Wenham and others claimed that in addition to preventing childbirth the epidemic created temporary infertility (Wenham 1994, 74).

71 E.g., Speiser 1964, 148.

72 E.g., Skinner 1930, 320.

and 18: “But this argument does not hold. Would a glossator have made an insertion intended to explain the preceding sentence which does not fit?”⁷³ Once again, a complication that diachronic scholars have trouble explaining can be solved on a literary plane.

The illness mentioned at the end of the story has a severe effect on the entire reading process, and sheds new light on the evaluation of the characters.⁷⁴ God’s comment about Abraham’s prayer for Abimelech’s survival is given new meaning.⁷⁵ Abimelech is not only promised that his life will be spared, but that the malady plaguing his people will be lifted. In light of this new information, God’s threat to Abimelech’s life in v. 7 clearly included his entire household, since the plague affected the wives of all his servants.⁷⁶ A new reading in particular should be attributed to Abimelech sharing his dream with his servants: whereas this detail was previously held to Abimelech’s merit, now the reader is aware that Abimelech’s household was in an upheaval before they had learned of Abimelech’s dream, due to the unknown and life-threatening plague that tortured their wives. The fear of the servants in v. 8 might not be a reaction to Abimelech’s revelation at all, but to the realization that the epidemic is divine in nature. Apparently, the fear is not a spiritual reaction to sexual immorality, but a natural fear for their health and lives.

Three phrases in the text are given new meaning as well. As previously noted, while God repeats Abimelech’s remark about his blamelessness, He omits the “cleanliness of his hands.” Rashi commented: “It is true that you did not intend at first to sin, but you cannot claim purity of hands, for it was not due to you that you did not touch her; rather, I prevented you from sinning.”⁷⁷ Rashi’s commentary might seem inappropriate according to the initial reading, since even God justifies Abimelech. However, based on the new information offered

73 Westermann 1995, 328.

74 Sternberg 1985, 315–16.

75 Fidler 2006, 112. The word “live” denotes “to get well” (and not only “not die”) in Josh 5:8; Is 38:22; BDB 311.

76 Westermann 1995, 328.

77 Rashi Gen 20:6.

at the conclusion of the narrative, God also chose to punish Abimelech for his actions.⁷⁸

The affliction also sheds new light on the use of the verb **לנגע** (“to touch”). As previously noted, the verb seemed to differentiate between God’s conduct toward Pharaoh, who was afflicted “with mighty plagues” (**נגעים גדולים**), and Abimelech, who is prevented by God from touching Sarah: **לא נתתיך לנגע** (“I did not let you touch her”). However, in light of the information offered at the conclusion of the narrative, apparently Abimelech did suffer a plague at God’s hands. The previous distinction between Abimelech and Pharaoh is withdrawn in the final verse, which uses the identical formulation with regard to Abimelech as in the case of Pharaoh:

20:18: For the Lord had closed fast every womb of the household of Abimelech *because of Sarah, the wife of Abraham.*

12:17: But the Lord afflicted Pharaoh and his household with mighty plagues *because of Sarai, the wife of Abram.*

Whereas the use of **לנגע** was previously perceived as a distinction between the two narrative and the two characters, based on the new information the words should be viewed as a link and bond.

Lastly, Abimelech’s accusation that Abraham brought a “great a guilt upon” Abimelech and his kingdom (20:9) should also be read in a new light. Whereas in the initial reading the “guilt” seemed to refer to the sin of taking another man’s wife, in light of the new information the integration of “kingdom” seems to indicate that the guilt that Abimelech lays upon Abraham’s conscience is not the guilt of immorality but rather of the plague he brought upon Abimelech’s kingdom.⁷⁹

78 Sternberg (1985, 315–16) and Novick (2004) believed the “second reading” reveals that it was Abimelech’s illness that prevented him from approaching Sarah, and that Abimelech was not so “innocent.” I believe the second reading does not detract from the first, and should not be viewed as a “correction” but as an additional perspective.

79 Now, the phrase **חטאה גדולה** (“great guilt”) expresses the result of the sin (in other words, the punishment); see Kaddari 2006, 290. BDB interpreted the word **חטא** (“sin”) as an expression of punishment, but not **חטאה**.

This assessment illuminates the use of the name YHWH in the final verse. In the Egypt narrative God afflicts Pharaoh, and God is called YHWH throughout the narrative. God is called Elohim throughout the Gerar narrative, since Abimelech is initially evaluated positively, and Elohim is an appropriately general name that relates to foreigners as well as the chosen people.⁸⁰ The general name enables an intimacy between the king and God, who speaks in a language Abimelech could understand. Abraham's reference to God in the plural in 20:13 conveys the feeling that the entire chapter is conducted on Abimelech's semantic playing field. Abimelech understands that Abraham's God protects him, just as Abimelech's own god defends him. At the conclusion of the story, when the reader discovers that God afflicted Abimelech, the narrator created a distance between God and the foreign king, by calling God by the name reserved for his chosen people.

The essential question is, of course, why this information was concealed instead of being integrated into the appropriate place in the narrative. Gunkel attributes the initial omission to esthetics: "This narrative style is chosen by authors who wish to narrate somewhat more artfully and, at the same time, to heighten the tension through such lacunae."⁸¹ Gunkel assumes that when the reader discovers the "truth" at the end of the narrative, the initial reading should be entirely abandoned.⁸² His hypothesis utterly ignores the powerful effect the initial reading creates; the new information might illuminate various details in the narrative, but it does not eliminate the reading experience. The surprising detail offered just as the reader believes the story

80 Cf. Šanda 1924, 24–30, Cassuto 1989, 45.

81 Gunkel 1997, 219.

82 Novick (2004) made a similar suggestion; however, he believed the design is not merely aesthetic, but ironic, for the purpose of ridiculing Abimelech's initial statement. Novick believes Abimelech's abstinence was a result of the impotence God had inflicted upon him, and the opacity in the narrative reflects the king's desire to conceal his illness; however, the moment his illness is revealed Abimelech's becomes a mockery. The Hittites recorded a ritual of healing a man from impotence; an essential component of the process is dream incubation. According to Novick, the dream revelation should cure Abimelech's impotence. On the Hittite ritual, see Singer 2009, 206–09.

is over does not change the initial reading, but rather creates two parallel readings of the narrative, thereby creating a dialectical critique of Abimelech's character. Throughout the initial reading the reader identifies with Abimelech, who falls into a trap set by Abraham and Sarah; the affliction provides the reader with the opportunity to view Abimelech as a more complex character, who was perhaps not altogether deserving of the entirely positive reviews he was previously offered. The complexity might diminish the empathy toward Abimelech but should not invalidate the reader's compassion altogether, since Abimelech was wronged, and suffered, and indeed rectified the situation in accordance with God's instructions.⁸³

The double assessment in the narrative relates to both Abimelech and Abraham. Whereas the initial reading is critical of Abraham's behavior, the second reading is more critical of Abimelech. The ambivalent assessment of Abimelech in the narrative is cleverly embedded in the links to the destruction of Sodom. Many scholars attribute the two narratives to different sources, and therefore allowed themselves to ignore the links. A close reading, however, shows that the links are apparent both in the narrative materials and the fabric of the language.

As previously noted, both narratives share a common theme: the sexual corruption of the people of the land. This corruption led to the destruction of Sodom, and almost led to Abimelech's demise. Some compared Abraham's estrangement from his wife for the sake of his own safety to Lot offering his daughters to the mob outside his house

83 Von Rad (1963, 223) addressed the dual reading of the story, while considering the synchronic element: "One could almost say that our story has two faces, an ancient and a modern. Ancient is the emphasis on Abimelech's guilt: the king infringed on another's marriage which was absolutely protected by the divinity...In contrast to that is the advanced reflection over the subjective ignorance that caused Abimelech to act in good faith. Indeed, the personal blamelessness of the heathen king is delineated by the narrator to the profound humiliation of Abraham." Cf. Fidler (2006, 109), who focused on another difference: "On the one hand, this is the implementation of divine will: to prevent Abimelech from approaching Sarah saves the king from sin (instead of punishing him); on the other hand, there is an emphasis on Abraham's prophetic prayer which heals Abimelech and the women of his household." See also Cotter 2003, 134.

in order to save his guests.⁸⁴ Both narratives include a moral argument against God's judgment, resulting in Abraham's prayer for the "defendant." Both narratives discuss the dwelling of a "stranger" among the people of the land (Lot in 19:9 and Abraham in 20:1). Finally, both narratives portray a sexual offense against guests/foreigners within the boundaries of the land of Canaan.

In addition to the narrative materials above, the texts share similar phrases that link the two stories:

- Abraham asked Sarah: "Let this be *the kindness that you shall do me*" (20:13) in a similar formulation to Lot's request of the angels: "You have been so gracious to your servant, and have *already shown me so much kindness* in order to save my life...it is such a little place – and let my life be saved" (19:19–20).
- God warned Abimelech: "If you fail to restore her, know that you shall die, you *and all that are yours*" (20:7), just as the angels had warned Lot: "Sons-in-law, your sons and daughters, or *anyone else that you have in the city* – bring them out of the place" (19:12).⁸⁵
- Abimelech demands of God, "will You slay people even though innocent?" (20:4), in correspondence with Abraham's statement: "Far be it from You to do such a thing, to bring death upon the innocent as well as the guilty, so that innocent and guilty fare alike... Shall not the Judge of all the earth deal justly?" (18:25).⁸⁶
- As mentioned above, the formulation "early next morning" appears in both narratives (20:8 and 19:27).

The shared motifs, the analogous phrases, and the proximity of the texts within the Abraham cycle reinforce reading the Gerar narrative in relation to the destruction of Sodom. Scholars debate whether the

84 Gossai 1995, 111–39; Hamilton 1995, 58.

85 Mathews (2005, 255) felt this statement is reminiscent of the description of Abraham's wealth in 12:20: "they sent him off with his wife and all that he possessed," and in 13:1: "From Egypt, Abram went up into the Negeb, with his wife and all that he possessed, together with Lot." However, the phrase "all that he possessed" is a common formulation; the motivation to link the expressions is based on other similar phrases throughout both literary units.

86 Lipton 1999, 52.

justification of a literary analogy requires an exact parallel to the character in the corresponding story,⁸⁷ or whether literary analogies can be based on links between varying characters in each of the stories.⁸⁸ Indeed, sometimes the contrast with a variety of characters better serves the purpose of the analogy.⁸⁹ In the analogy above, Abimelech in Gerar is compared to Abraham in the Sodom narrative (e.g., challenging God's judgment; rising early in the morning), and Abraham in Gerar is compared to Lot in Sodom (e.g., the separation from the wives; the "kindness" request). But other components in the text compare Abimelech to Lot (e.g., the threat to everything one has; the need for the intervention of others to save one's life). In this case, the inconsistency serves the purpose of the analogy. Abimelech seems at times to be an ethical alternative to Abraham; but not always. He sometimes requires the strong hand of God Himself to prevent him from immorality. Abimelech might remind the reader of Abraham, but the parallel is incomplete, and before long he is compared to Lot, another morally questionable character.

There are no winners in the moral debate between Abimelech and Abraham. While initially Abimelech seems to have the upper hand, the final verse moderates this conclusion. Even after the moderation of the final verse, however, the results are overwhelming: in the midst of the Abraham cycle the reader is presented with an alternative moral figure, which successfully challenges Abraham's morality; this occurs shortly after God attests: "I have singled him out, that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is just and right" (18:19). Since God's choice is based on Abraham's morality, is Abraham more worthy than Abimelech, who is on a similar moral plane?⁹⁰ The order of the narrative designs Abimelech as a moral character; even if the conclusion of the story demonstrates that Abimelech's actions are not entirely voluntary, the reader is left with an uneasy feeling with regard to Abraham.

87 Noble 2002.

88 Rendsburg 1986; Ho 1999.

89 Grossman 2009; Grossman 2015 – Text and Subtext, 364-68.

90 Bin-Nun 2003, 109.

The undermining of Abraham's morality is devastating within the context of the Abraham cycle; references to the story throughout the rest of the cycle attempt to deal with the implications and correct this impression. As previously noted, the final verse of the Gerar narrative sublimates the negative impression of Abraham. Next, after the unrelated episodes of the birth of Isaac and the eviction of Ishmael (21:1–21), Abraham and Abimelech interact once more, in the episode discussed below. Later, the binding of Isaac references the “fear of God” of Abraham, and lastly, Isaac's Gerar narrative in ch. 26 clarifies the preference for Abraham and his offspring. In contrast with Abraham, Isaac goes to Gerar because of a famine, and despite the fact that Rebekah was not taken to the king's palace, Abimelech acted like Pharaoh and banished Isaac from his land.⁹¹ Here Abimelech demonstrates that when he is not threatened, he is not eager to please Abraham's family.

A supplement to this discussion is found after the birth of Isaac and banishment of Ishmael, in a future interaction between Abraham and Abimelech (20:22–34). The episode balances the evaluation of the characters, and should be viewed as a direct extension of the Gerar narrative. This is apparent both in the narrative materials, in which the characters reference their previous conversation and Abimelech's kindness toward Abraham (21:23), and in the fabric of the language (one example noted by Coats is the repetition of the verb *לגור* [“to settle”] in Gen 21:23 as a wordplay on the opening remark in Gen 20:1 about Abraham settling in Gerar).⁹² While the narrative continues the previous episode with Abraham and Abimelech, their roles are reversed: in this narrative, Abraham accuses Abimelech of seizing his

91 Van Seters (1975:177–80) noted correctly that the narrative in ch. 26 contains motifs that are similar to the Egypt narrative (12) and the Gerar narrative (26). He wrote that the final narrative in ch. 26 responds to both.

92 Coats 1983, 149. Abimelech's request for “kindness” (*חסד*) in the later dispute (21:23) ironically hints at Abraham's request for Sarah's “kindness” in pretending she is his sister (20:13); it was Abimelech who dealt with Abraham kindly, not Sarah.

well; Abimelech mumbles a number of unsatisfactory excuses; and eventually Abraham offers Abimelech gifts of cattle.⁹³

| | <i>The Wife (20:1–18)</i> | <i>The Well (21:22–34)</i> |
|----------------------------|--|---|
| <i>Accusation</i> | <i>Abimelech:</i>
“What have you done to us? What wrong have I done that you should bring so great a guilt upon me and my kingdom?” | <i>Abraham:</i>
Then Abraham reproached Abimelech for the well of water which the servants of Abimelech had seized |
| <i>Justification</i> | <i>Abraham:</i>
“I thought, surely there is no fear of God in this place... And <i>besides</i> , she is in truth my sister...” | <i>Abimelech:</i>
But Abimelech said, “I do not know who did this; <i>besides</i> , you did not tell me, <i>nor</i> have I heard of it until today |
| <i>Reconciliation</i> | <i>Abimelech:</i>
Abimelech took sheep and oxen, and male and female slaves, and gave them to Abraham | <i>Abraham:</i>
Abraham took sheep and oxen and gave them to Abimelech |
| <i>Conflict resolution</i> | and he restored his wife Sarah to him... And to Sarah he said, “I herewith give your brother a thousand pieces of silver” | “You are to accept these seven ewes from me as proof that I dug this well” |

Wife and well are both part of the semantic field that relates to fertility: the fertility of man and the fertility of land. Clearly, seizing a woman is worse than seizing a well, but to shepherds in ancient society owning a well gives one the ability to survive. Nonetheless, the images are reversed: the wrongdoer in the initial scene becomes the accuser in the latter, while the accuser in the initial scene becomes the wrongdoer. Abimelech’s accusation in the first episode (“what have you done to us?”) becomes his defense in the second (“I do not know who did this”).⁹⁴ Abimelech reprimands Abraham: “what was your purpose

93 See also Grossman 2004, 487–90.

94 The semantic similarity between seeing and knowing is noteworthy (Seeligman 1992, 142–68). Zakovitch wrote: “To see is to know; these concepts are easily interchangeable” (Zakovitch 1997, 17). Therefore, there might be a link

(מה ראית – literally: ‘what did you *see*’) in doing this thing?” and later defends himself: “nor have I *heard* (לא שמעתי).”

The role reversal further clarifies the character evaluation in both narratives. The “sister-wife” story creates the impression that Abimelech has the moral upper hand; the well narrative necessitates a reassessment of this conclusion. The role reversal in the second episode demonstrates that Abimelech’s morality is not superior to Abraham’s, and shortly after he accuses Abraham of unethical behavior he has to defend his own people. Nonetheless, in the context of God’s choice of Abraham, his actions necessitate correction; this correction will come in the form of the binding of Isaac.

between the beginnings of each of the two verses: “what did you see” – “I do not know.”

Chapter 14: The Birth of Isaac and Ishmael's Expulsion (21:1–21)

Gen 17 and 18 bring tidings of the birth of a son and heir to Sarah and Abraham within the year; the promised son is finally born in ch. 21. One might assume that the narratives integrated between promise and implementation – the destruction of Sodom (19) and Abraham and Sarah in Gerar (20) – occurred over the course of that year. Since ch. 21 begins with Sarah's conception, presumably she conceived shortly after leaving Gerar.¹ The chronological proximity is also expressed on the literary plane, through joint narrative materials. The Gerar narrative ends with God opening the wombs of the women of Abimelech's household (20:17–18), while the following narrative describes God fulfilling His promise to Abraham and Sarah and opening Sarah's womb (21:1). Perhaps the previously discussed integration of the name YHWH in the last verse of the Gerar narrative also serves the purpose of linking the two narratives, since Sarah's conception is in the name of YHWH. Additionally, the phrase “for the Lord had closed fast [עָצַר עָצַר] every womb” (20:18) is reminiscent of Sarah's infertility, which she had previously described in similar terms: “The Lord has kept me [עָצַרְנִי] from bearing” (16:2).² Moreover, the placement of the next episode in the Abraham–Abimelech relationship (the quarrel and covenant over the well in 21:22–34) after the birth of Isaac and expulsion of Ishmael reinforces the link between the episodes, and might be the purpose of the order of the narratives. In an attempt to create a more comfortable reading, Josephus placed the quarrel at the end of the Gerar narrative but lost the literary link between the births.³

Some viewed the link as a contrast: while God prevented birth from the women of Abimelech's household, He offered Sarah the gift

1 Cf. Clines 1990, 75–76; Hamilton 1995, 73 note 7.

2 Mathews 2005, 260.

3 Josephus, *Antiquities* I:212 (Feldman 2000, 80).

of fertility.⁴ The approach that compares Sarah's conception to Abimelech's women portrays Abimelech as a positive character, while the contradictory view portrays Abimelech in a negative light. As previously noted, the tension regarding Abimelech's evaluation is encouraged by the narrative.

The initial verses describe the implementation of God's promises to Abraham and Sarah. The execution mirrors the double promise to Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision (17) and to Sarah in the tent (18). In v. 1 YHWH "took note of *Sarah* as He had promised," and "did for *Sarah* as He had spoken." The name YHWH and the focus on Sarah indicate that this verse correlates with the promise of Gen 18. There, Sarah is the focus of the angels' promise, which is given in the name of YHWH. Verse 2 describes Isaac's birth once more: "Sarah conceived and bore a son *to Abraham*...at the set time of which *Elohim* had spoken." This time, the focus of the verse is on Abraham and "Elohim's" promise to Abraham. Abraham names his son and circumcises him. The story of Isaac's birth ends with the festive announcement: "Now Abraham was a hundred years old when his son Isaac was born to him." These components all correlate with God's promise to Abraham in ch. 17, where the Covenant of Circumcision is made between Elohim and Abraham; a child is promised "at a given time" (7:21); the child shall be named Isaac (17:19); the son will be circumcised (17:9–14). Mention of Abraham's age is an extension of Gen 17:1 and 24.

4 The dilemma is apparent in early exegesis. R. Berachiah's homily on Eze 17:24 compares Abraham and Sarah to fertile trees, and Abimelech and his household to dried up trees (Genesis Rabbah 53:1). Other midrashic texts support a reading that perceives a similarity between the narratives, such as: "The Holy One, Blessed be He, said: 'Abraham prayed before me on behalf of the evil Abimelech, and I took pity on him; now I shall remember Abraham along with him, as it is said, 'God healed Abimelech and his wife and his slave girls, so that they bore children,' and soon after it is written, 'The Lord took note of Sarah as He had promised'" (Tanhuma, Vayera 14). See a similar interpretation by Zakovitch 1992, 39, who believed that the last two verses of ch. 20 are a late midrashic addition designed to generate such a link between the narratives.

The word פקד in v. 1 has been interpreted in a number of ways. The King James translated, “And the Lord *visited* Sarah as he had said.”⁵ The motive behind this interpretation is the realization of the previous promise: “I will return to you at the time next year, and Sarah shall have a son” (18:14). Onkelos and Pseudo-Jonathan translated “remembered” or “remembered favorably”⁶ based on the parallel between the two parts of the verse. Many modern translations interpreted similarly: “Now the Lord was gracious to Sarah as he had said”;⁷ “The Lord took note of Sarah as He had promised.”⁸ Other biblical birth stories – particularly narratives involving barren women – include the remembrance component; however, God’s memory or notice is more commonly indicated by the word זכר (“remembered”).⁹ The associative meaning of the verb might indeed relate to a visit and justify the alternative interpretation above.¹⁰ Although an actual physical visit is not described, the text might deliberately create the association with the previous visit by the angels, to enhance the sense that God took note of Sarah as a fulfillment of the promise in ch. 18.

Isaac’s birth is described in similar terms to the birth of Ishmael,¹¹ while two significant differences set the two apart:

-
- 5 And so: American Standard Version (1901). Cf. Westermann 1995, 330; Hamilton 1995, 71.
 - 6 Jacob (1974, 136) compared God’s remembrance to the memory of the nation in Egypt that came before God (he notes Gen 50:24; Ex 4:31; additional relevant verses include Ex 3:16 and 13:19). According to this position פקד is not a visit, but favorable attention, as he translated: “ER aber hatte Sara bedacht, wie er gesagt.”
 - 7 NIB; NIV.
 - 8 NAB; NAS; NAU; NJPS.
 - 9 The verb פקד is used in the context of Hannah’s birth: “For the Lord took note (פקד) of Hannah; she conceived and bore three sons and two daughters” (1 Sam 2:21).
 - 10 E.g., “Some time later, in the season of the wheat harvest, Samson came to visit his wife, bringing a kid as a gift. He said, ‘Let me go into the chamber to my wife.’” Cf. Mathews 2005, 266.
 - 11 Blum 1984; Knauf, 1985; Römer 2012.

| <i>The birth of Isaac (21:2–5)</i> | <i>The birth of Ishmael (16:15–16)</i> |
|---|---|
| Sarah conceived and bore a son to Abraham in his old age | Hagar bore a son to Abram |
| at the set time of <i>which God had spoken</i> | |
| Abraham gave his newborn son, whom Sarah had borne him, the name of Isaac | and Abram gave the son that Hagar bore him the name Ishmael |
| 4 And when his son Isaac was eight days old, Abraham circumcised him, <i>as God had commanded him</i> | |
| Now Abraham was a hundred years old when his son Isaac was born to him | Abram was eighty-six years old when Hagar bore Ishmael to Abram |

Three components are included in both births: the birth itself; the naming of the child, based on previous instructions;¹² and Abraham's age. Isaac's birth includes an additional component, circumcision, and more significantly, Isaac's birth includes two statements attributing Isaac's birth and circumcision to God's promise: "which God had spoken" and "as God had commanded." Isaac's birth and Abraham's actions are described in light of the covenant between Abraham and God: Sarah birthed a child as God had promised, and Abraham circumcised his son as God had commanded. This atmosphere is absent from the birth of Ishmael, and the birth of Isaac stands out as an essential part of the covenant, unlike the birth of Ishmael. The conclusion of the story is nuanced accordingly: whereas Abraham is 86 'when Hagar bore Ishmael to Abram,' he is 100 "when *his* son Isaac was born *to him*."

12 Hamilton (1995, 73) wrote: "'Isaac' is God's choice for the name of this child. 'Ishmael' was Abraham's choice for the name of his firstborn. 'Ishmael' evolves as a name only after the child's birth. 'Isaac' is revealed as the name for the second child before he is even conceived." He concludes accordingly that in the naming process Isaac, and not Ishmael, seems to be Abraham's successor (p. 74). However, the angel ordered Hagar to name her son Ishmael before he was born, and Abraham did.

Reactions to the Birth (6–8)

Abraham and Sarah's reactions to the birth of Isaac have certain aspects in common: both relate to their environment. Sarah declares that "God has brought me laughter; everyone who hears will laugh with me" (6); Abraham holds "a great feast" when Isaac is weaned, including those around him in his joy.¹³ Abraham and Sarah experience the joyous birth of their son differently; the difference is expressed through the description of each parent's reaction.¹⁴ While the narrator allows Sarah to speak about her feelings ("showing"), Abraham's happiness is expressed through his actions ("telling"). The reader is therefore given an opportunity to experience Sarah's happiness ("God has brought me laughter") but also become aware of the complexity of her social situation as a barren woman, despite the happy ending ("everyone who hears will laugh with me").¹⁵ Her second statement is given a new caption, "And she added, 'Who would have said to Abraham that Sarah would suckle children! Yet I have borne a son in his old age.'" This statement expresses her frustration during the long years of her childless marriage, the shared disappointment, and

13 About the idea of a "feast" as a social function, see: Jenks, *Eating*, 252–53; O'Connell, שְׂתֵּה, 261.

14 Many scholars viewed the description of Abraham in v. 8 as an introduction to the following scene, and background for Sarah's assessment of Ishmael's laughter. This is apparent in various modern translations for v. 9, such as NIV: "and Sarah saw." Verse 8 might be viewed as a transition between the birth of Isaac and Ishmael's laughter, but the celebration of Isaac's weaning cannot be separated from the joy of his birth. Sonek (2009, 62) proved this point from the literary style: v. 8 reports Abraham's actions ("telling"), which correlates with the initial verses in the chapter, while v. 9 describes Sarah's emotions, which were previously described in her own words ("showing"). The latter style correlates with the following unit. See also p. 147.

15 E.g., Jacob 1974, 136–37, unlike others who viewed the laughter at Sarah's expense. JPS 1917 translated "every one that heareth will laugh on account of me," while the NJPS version reads "everyone who hears will laugh with me."

perhaps the guilt over her inability to give her husband a son.¹⁶ In contrast with Sarah's complex emotions, the report of Abraham focuses on his actions; he does not speak, and no emotions are described. Nonetheless, the "great feast" Abraham makes in honor of Isaac's weaning expresses his joy. The phrase "*great feast*" appears only in one other biblical narrative (Es 2:17), and the emphasis on the "greatness" of the feast indicates that the size or nature of the feast was unusual.¹⁷

An additional difference between Abraham and Sarah relates to the timing of their reaction. Sarah is delighted at Isaac's birth – "I have borne a son in his old age," and expresses wonder at the suckling stage – "That Sarah would suckle children!" In contrast, Abraham's reaction to the birth of his son is delayed until after he is weaned – "The child *grew up and was weaned*, and Abraham held a great feast on the day that *Isaac was weaned*." The reader accompanies Isaac from birth through the years of his infancy, and the joy extends from Sarah's wonder to Abraham's feast, becoming a permanent feeling throughout the early years of Isaac's life. In addition to prolonging the happiness of Isaac's birth, the text distinguishes between "Abraham's son" and "Sarah's son," in correlation with the "purpose" of the son in chs. 17–18. Sarah had wanted nothing more than to hold a baby in her arms, to suckle her very own child; Abraham desired a son to maintain God's covenant and carry on the family line. Appropriately, Isaac's birth is the greatest joy of Sarah's life; his weaning will, in fact, symbolize the forced separation of parents from their children as they grow independent. From Abraham's perspective, as long as his son is suckling at his mother's breast he cannot be educated and trained to be Abraham's successor. Once Isaac is weaned, he is ready to begin his life as the heir of Abraham's household and his covenant with God.

16 Saran (1989, 146) suggested that the unusual Aramaic verb מלל is a wordplay on ברית מילה – circumcision.

17 Rashi, based on the midrash, understood "a great feast" as "a feast involving the great leaders of that generation: Shem, Eber, and Abimelech." This reading is possible in the context of Esther 1:3 as well, where Ahasuerus explicitly invited "the nobles and governors of the provinces in his service." Alternatively, "great" might simply describe the number of people (O' Connell, שנה, 261) and amount of effort that was put into the feast.

The laughter is mentioned twice in Sarah's speech: "God has brought me *laughter*; everyone who hears will *laugh* with me." Van Seters noted that scholars who attribute the chapter to different sources ignored the silent dialogue between this laughter and Sarah's laughter when she was given tidings of a son in Gen 18:12. He rightly claimed that the dialogue between the two narratives gives significance to Isaac's name.¹⁸ The episode in ch. 18 is also implied in Sarah's reference to Abraham's old age, which was previously referenced when she was told she would have a child (18:12).

The link indicates Sarah's admission that she was wrong to doubt the promise. Now Isaac's name no longer commemorates Sarah's doubt, but rather her joy and wonder at the birth of her son. This might be the reason behind the absence of the common naming formulation, in which a name is assigned and then explained. Abraham names the child in v. 3, but the reason for Isaac's name is explained only three verses later (6).¹⁹ The omission of the explanation indicates that while Abraham is obligated by divine decree to name his son Isaac (17:19), the name is also indicative of Sarah's change of attitude, from a laughter that once indicated doubt, to a laughter of joy.

Ishmael's name is implied in this context as well: "everyone who *bears* (השמע) will laugh (יצחק) with me." The juxtaposition of the two verbs – השמע יצחק – might predict the tension between the two brothers, and indicate that the tension exists from the moment of Isaac's birth.²⁰

The Expulsion of Ishmael (9–21)

Scholars debate whether the expulsion of Ishmael (8/9–21) should be viewed as part of the narrative of Isaac's birth or as a separate story.

18 Van Seters 1975, 206.

19 Cf. Mathews 2005, 257.

20 Cf. Garsiel 1991, 156.

The separation of the stories is primarily based on the theory that the stories are attributed to different sources: while the birth of Isaac is a combination of P/J, the expulsion of Ishmael is attributed to E.²¹ Other scholars separated the stories according to the literary structure or narrative materials. Westermann wrote in regard to verses 8–21: “It is nothing less than the classical structure of a narrative from the patriarchal period, coherent and self-contained.”²² Others, however, among them scholars of the documentary hypothesis school, viewed the chapter as one story, such as Skinner, who entitled the chapter “Birth of Isaac and Expulsion of Ishmael.”²³ The literary structure of the chapter supports its cohesion, as we will see below.²⁴

Sarah’s Demand (9–10)

Many interpretations were offered in an attempt to decipher Ishmael’s “playing”, which are described by the verb *מַצַּחֵק* (9). The verb in its

21 E.g., Gunkel 1997, 225. The division is especially salient among those who divided Genesis up according as a sequence of different sources. Procksch, for example, holds that the biblical text jumps from v. 7 to v. 25, with no mention of Ishmael’s expulsion in this context. (Procksch 1913, 130–1).

22 Westermann 1995, 338.

23 Skinner 1930, 320. See also von Rad 1963, 225–30, and Speiser 1964, 153–57. Saran (1989, 144–45) related to “two episodes” of one story; Brueggemann (1982, 177–85) defined the chapter as “The narrative of the two sons of Abraham,” but proceeded to analyze each scene separately; Coats (1983, 152) claimed that the entire chapter is one unit about the birth of Isaac, and divided the sub-units as follows: “General fulfillment of annunciation” (1); “Birth report” (2–7); “Crisis rejoined” (8–13); “Denouement” (14–19); “conclusion” (20–21). Altar (2004) divided the unit into two: 1–13 and 14–21.

24 See also Padilla 2014. The claim that a new episode begins in v. 8 (an opinion held, for example, by Gunkel 1997, 225) is challenged by the fact that Isaac is referred to as “the boy,” indicating that the identity of the boy should be understood from a reference in the previous verses. See Van Seters 1975, 196; Sonck 2009, 62. This argument is irrelevant to most scholars, who cite v. 9 as the beginning of the new narrative.

simple form generally denotes the positive action of joyful laughter, while the active-intensive form (*pi'el*) can carry negative connotations and additional meanings, some of which are related to the primary meaning above.²⁵ The meaning of the verb in the present context is unclear, and some claimed the main purpose of the integration of the verb was the wordplay with the name Isaac:

Though we have here yet another word play on Isaac's name, the exact meaning is opaque. Is Ishmael playing with Isaac?²⁶ Or is Ishmael simply playing? Or is Ishmael playing Isaac – that is, pretending to be Isaac and thus usurping his role as legitimate heir?²⁷ We simply do not know the precise intent – only the presence of the root פנח echoes Isaac's name, suggesting some type of pun.²⁸

Since Ishmael's "playing" was the reason for Sarah's insistence that he be banished from the house, clearly the action has an important role in the separation of the boys and Ishmael's rejection. God had revealed to Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision that Ishmael will not be the one to carry on the covenant (17:21); however, the biblical narrative often justifies a divine decree through the characters' choices and actions. Ishmael's action in this narrative should justify God's decision to eliminate him as the heir to Abraham's covenant with God. While Coats suggestion that Ishmael "was pretending himself to be Isaac" correlates with Sarah's demand that Ishmael will not inherit with Isaac, the verb in the active-intensive form (*pi'el*) is never used with this connotation.²⁹ The meaning of the verb affects the design of Ishmael's character, as Sonek wrote: "The question is whether Ishmael,

25 Rashi names the three classic possibilities of involvement in idolatry, adultery, and murder. These possibilities are disputed in rabbinic literature; the fact that Rashi mentions all three indicates that he believed the verb to possess multiple meanings. This is one of many examples of Rashi's awareness of the multiple meanings of biblical expressions. See Gelles 1992, 121 (Only in the Hebrew edition); Shapira 2001; Grossman 2006, 15–16; Maori 2008.

26 The Septuagint explicitly added Isaac: "Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian playing with her son Isaac" (Zipor 2005, 258–69 – for Wevers' reasoning for the Septuagint's addition, see p. 259).

27 This was suggested by Coats 1983, 97.

28 Exum and Whedbee 1990, 127.

29 Coats 1983, 153.

as portrayed in v. 9, is an innocent victim playing with his younger brother, or a vile brat humiliating Isaac.”³⁰

Two reading possibilities are expressed in various translations. Based on the Septuagint and the Vulgate, Westermann inserted Isaac into the text:³¹ “But when Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian, whom she had borne to Abraham, playing with her son Isaac.” This reading portrays Ishmael as an enthusiastic babysitter, and the criticism of Ishmael is unclear. The negative connotations are more apparent in Driver’s translation:³² “And Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian, which she had borne unto Abraham, mocking.” The broader context indicates that Ishmael’s actions were negative, and in fact led to his banishment from the house of his father.

The various interpretations stem from the multiple meanings of the active-intensive form (*pi’el*) of the verb פָּתַח .³³ Two central meanings are “to laugh, jest, play, fool around,” (e.g., Gen 19:14) and “sexual activity” or “lovmaking” (e.g., Gen 26:8; 39:17).³⁴ Fleishman noted that the contextual reading indicates that the verb in this narrative is used with a sexual connotation; he believed Sarah saw Ishmael involved in illicit sexual activity: “it is noteworthy, that when Sarah saw Ishmael ‘playing’ he was not yet married...therefore he was not ‘playing’ with his wife, which would be a legitimate act, but rather with a man or a woman to whom he is not married.”³⁵ According to this position Ishmael is influenced by Canaanite sexual norms instead of the principles

30 Sonek 2009, 43.

31 Westermann 1995, 336–37, as well as Ball, Holzinger, Gunkel, and more.

32 Driver 1916, 210–11.

33 For a broad discussion of this verb and humorous biblical narratives see Brenner 1990, 46–52.

34 BDB, 850. The Akkadian verb *šāhu* has a double meaning as well: “to laugh, to smile, to be seductive, to sexually seduce (including acts outside of accepted norms)” (*CAD*, §, 64–65). The verb פָּתַח (“laughed”) is found in Arabic, Syrian, and Ugaritic as well (Brenner 1990, 46–47). On the relationship between the Akkadian and Hebrew verbs see Fleishman 1999, 154–55, and note 41 in reference to additional studies. On the double meaning of the verb פָּתַח in Gen 39:17, see Sternberg 1977, 142–43; Polak 1999, 76; Grossman 2006, 102–04.

35 Fleishman 1999, 154. Trible (1984, 244, note 46) suggested similarly that Ishmael was involved in self-indulgent sexual games.

that govern his father's household. Ishmael is contrasted with Isaac, who was recently born into the reality of a covenant through circumcision, which represents, among other things, elevated sexual standards. As mentioned above, all of the narratives since the Covenant of Circumcision related to sexual ethics: the Sodomites who want to rape their guests (after Lot made them a banquet); Lot's offer of his daughters; the incest between Lot and his daughters (after they made him drink wine); Abraham's wife in the house of Gerar; and finally Ishmael, who "fools around" after Abraham's banquet, is banished for a similar reason.³⁶

Sarah's demand to banish the "slave's son" is better understood in light of the laws of the time. The Hammurabi code and documents found in Nuzi relate at length to the legal status of a maidservant offered by the wife for the purpose of childbearing. Scholars dispute the practical application of the Hammurabi code; nonetheless, they are in agreement that the code reflects active social-legal awareness.³⁷ Law 146 arranges the status of a maidservant, to prevent the mistress from selling her after she has borne children to the master: "because she has borne children, her mistress shall not sell her." According to this law, and the similar law found in Nuzi, Sarah's demand is neither fair nor appropriate.³⁸ However, two other laws in the Hammurabi code clarify Sarah's demand. Law 170 states as follows (translated by L.W. King):

If his wife bear sons to a man, or his maidservant have borne sons, and the father while still living says to the children whom his maidservant has borne: "My

36 Reis (2000, 95–96) suggested that the word denotes inebriation: Ishmael drank at Abraham's banquet (the word *משתה*, which denotes banquet, is derived from the verb *שתה* – "to drink," specifically connoting drinking wine). The verb *מצחק* is also used with regard to Lot's view in the eyes of his sons-in-law (19:4), and Lot, too, later shows an affinity with the bottle. Reis believes Ishmael's drunkenness explains Ishmael's rapid dehydration the following day.

37 "The reasonable conclusion is that the judges rules according to legal norms and not according to the book. In other words, the legal codes reflect prevalent custom, and prevalent custom is not evidence of following the rulebook" (Finkelstein, *Mishpat*, 611).

38 Parrot 1968, 103–04.

sons,” and he count them with the sons of his wife; if then the father die, then the sons of the wife and of the maidservant shall divide the paternal property in common. The son of the wife is to partition and choose.

The following law (171) states that if the father failed to call the sons of the maidservant “my sons” throughout his life, the sons of the maidservant cannot share in the goods of their father’s house along with the sons of the first wife. They are released, and the first wife has no right to enslave them or their mother, but they have no status in their father’s household. A similar regulation is brought in clause 24 of the Lipit-Ishtar code, which preceded Hammurabi by approximately 200 years. Saran and Grintz believe this is the law at the foundation of the expulsion of Ishmael narrative. The law states:

If a man married his wife and she bore him children and those children are living, and a slave also bore children for her master but the father granted freedom to the slave and her children, the children of the slave shall not divide the estate with the children of their former master.³⁹

Joseph Fleishman disputed the link of this law to the expulsion of Ishmael for two reasons: first, the law relates to the son of a slave, while Ishmael is defined as Abraham’s legal son. Second, Sarah demands that Abraham banish the maidservant and her son, not free them.⁴⁰ Clearly Sarah disputes Ishmael’s status in her statement, which explicitly refers to Ishmael as “the son of the slave,” and not “Abraham’s son.” Perhaps Sarah’s emphasis relates directly to the abovementioned law. Although Sarah uses the term גרש (“cast out”), in practice Abraham’s actions are described with the verb שלח (“sent away”), the legal term for freeing a slave. Regardless, the general atmosphere of the episode is reminiscent of prevalent norms. The expulsion of Ishmael includes two elements that reflect the laws of the time. First, the laws relate to a situation in which the first wife births sons; otherwise, the status of the maid remains undisputed. The narrative opens with the

39 *ANET*, 160; Grintz 1983, 53–54; Sarna 1989, 156. On the dispute about the translation of the law (whether releasing the maidservant is the case [protasis], or the law [apodosis]), see Fleishman 1999, 151, note 25.

40 Fleishman 1999, 151.

birth of Isaac, which puts Ishmael's status into question. Second, both laws ultimately leave the status of the children to the father's discretion. The father's formulation of his relationship with his sons determines whether they are legitimate sons, and this fact directly affects their rights as their father's heirs.⁴¹

Sarah links her demand to expel Ishmael to her concern for Isaac's inheritance – “for the son of that slave shall not share in the inheritance with my son Isaac.” Although this claim is part of a broader issue that relates to Ishmael “playing,”⁴² Sarah chooses to focus on the issue of inheritance. This emphasis lends legal significance to Ishmael's expulsion. Sarah calculatedly calls Ishmael “the son of that slave” – not Abraham's son. Leibowitz demonstrated the expression of various viewpoints in the story through the various names for Ishmael, who is not mentioned by name at all throughout the narrative.⁴³ The emphasis of Ishmael's position reinforces the legality of Sarah's demand, in light of prevalent law. The verbal definition of the child as his father's son affects the emotional bond and legal attitude toward that child. Therefore, when Abraham's displeasure with the idea is expressed in the following verse, Ishmael is appropriately referred to as “his son.” The definition of Abraham's relationship with Ishmael is the source of disagreement between Abraham and Sarah.⁴⁴

41 On the significance and ramification of the recognition of a child in Mesopotamian law see Fleishman 2009, 13–41. On the recognition of children in biblical literature see pp. 42–56. Fleishman believes that in biblical literature the recognition of an individual as one's child is unrelated to the relationship between the parents. See pp. 55–56.

42 Lohfink (לופנק, 967; and so on p. 190, n. 167) wrote that Sarah's claim relates to Abraham's heir as head of the family: “Es geht um Sukzession des Familienchefs.”

43 Leibowitz 1973, 136. See also Fischer 1994, 25.

44 Nehama Leibowitz insisted that Abraham views Ishmael as “his son” (Leibowitz 1973, 136; Willi-Plein 2010, 40). The situation seems to be more complex: while Abraham initially views Ishmael as “his son,” when he sends him away in 21:14 Ishmael is once again referred to as “the boy.” This internalization is the main process Abraham undergoes in the story. See Willi-Plein 2010, 42.

Ishmael is Sent to his Future (11–14)

As noted above, Abraham views Ishmael as his son (11). This is apparent as early as the Covenant of Circumcision, when Abraham asks God to take care of Ishmael (17:18). Although God agrees with Sarah in principle,⁴⁵ He addresses Abraham's concern for his son: "But God said to Abraham, Do not be distressed over the boy or your slave; whatever Sarah tells you, do as she says, for it is through Isaac that offspring shall be continued for you. As for the son of the slave-woman, I will make a nation of him, too, for he is your seed" (21:12–13). God refers to Ishmael as "the son of the slave-woman," in correlation with Sarah's demand, but earlier he is referred to as "the boy" and Hagar as "your slave." God agrees with Sarah's demand, but not out of identification with her reason, though Isaac is the sole heir to Abraham's household and faith. But the expulsion will provide Ishmael with the opportunity to establish a nation of his own: "I will make a nation of him." The term "son" or "child" links one with one's parents, while the term "boy" portrays Ishmael as an independent personality, with an independent potential.⁴⁶ Ishmael is not expelled as the son of the slave, but as a boy; while Sarah banishes him from Abraham's house to make room for Isaac, God focuses on his own future. Ishmael is "the son of the slave-woman," but also a "boy" who is Abraham's "seed."⁴⁷ As such, he is sent away to realize his potential and establish a nation.⁴⁸

45 "One could call vs. 12 f. the "tense moment" in the structure of the narrative, for the reader has not expected that God would be in Sarah's side, but rather on Abraham's" (von Rad 1963, 228).

46 Cf. Hamilton 1995, 81.

47 Grintz (1983, 54) inaccurately wrote: "We now understand why the author explained, time and time again, that Ishmael is indeed Abraham's son...in other words, despite the expulsion, Ishmael is still 'a son!'" God defines Ishmael as the son of the slave, not the son of Abraham.

48 God also tells Abraham, "Do not be distressed over...your slave," whereas the narrator only expressed Abraham's concern about his son. Bekhor Shor interpreted the addition as God addressing Abraham's innermost fears, while Reis (2000, 98) believed this to be a criticism of Abraham, who should have been more concerned with his servant. Both interpretations are supported by the

This new theme is expressed through the verb used in the expulsion of Ishmael. Whereas Sarah demanded, “cast out (גָּרַשׁ) that slave-woman and her son,” and God agreed: “whatever Sarah tells you, do as she says,” Abraham “sent her away (נִישְׁלָחָהּ).”⁴⁹ Although the verbs גָּרַשׁ and שָׁלַח are frequently used as a pair (e.g., Ex 6:1; 11:1, etc.), the connotations of each vary. Hamilton noted that the verb גָּרַשׁ is cruel, as opposed to the milder שָׁלַח, as Daube wrote: “but whereas the latter (shillah) often refers to friendly release, the former is invariably a hostile act.”⁵⁰ Abraham did as Sarah had said, and as God had commanded him – but instead of casting her out, harshly and cruelly, he simply sent her away. Additionally, the integration of the verb שָׁלַח transfers the text from the personal perspective to the legal realm. The term שָׁלַח, which denotes legal divorce, has legal ramifications.⁵¹ The same terminology is used when one “divorces” a slave; here, too, the separation has legal significance and carries legal ramifications and responsibilities.⁵² The legal ramifications of Sarah’s demand reflect on the loss of Ishmael’s position in Abraham’s house, but also on Abraham’s responsibilities toward Hagar and Ishmael.⁵³

The verb change touches on one of the essential themes of the narrative. The term גָּרַשׁ (“to cast off”) is usually used in the context of expulsion *from* a particular place, with no regard for the destination; for example, in Exodus 2:17 the shepherders came and “drove off”

fact that as opposed to Sarah, who calls Hagar “that slave-woman,” God calls Hagar “your slave.”

49 The verb שָׁלַח is also used to describe Abraham’s separation from the sons of his concubines: “but to Abraham’s sons by concubines Abraham gave gifts while he was still living, and he sent them away” (25:6).

50 Daube (1963, 29–30) believed the “casting out” or “sending away” here implies divorce. See also Hamilton 1995, 82–83.

51 E.g., Deut 24:1 and 3; Is 50:1; Jer 3:1 and 8.

52 E.g., Ex 21:26–27; Deut 15:12–13. See Galpaz-Feller 2006, 26.

53 Note that a divorced woman is called a גֵּרוּשָׁה; in other words, the root גָּרַשׁ has legal ramifications as well (Ringgren, גָּרַשׁ; Fleishman 1999, 146. See also Lev 21:7; 14:22 and 13; Num 30:10; 18:44 and 22). However, the verb לְגַרֵשׁ (“to divorce”) is never found in the context of ending a marriage, which is always expressed through the verb לְשַׁלַּח (“to send away”). The relationship between the two verbs requires additional analysis.

Reuel's daughters. The girls were free to go anywhere they pleased; the herders only wanted them to vacate the well.⁵⁴ In contrast, separations that focus on the destination rather than the origin frequently use the term *לשלח* ("to send away"); for example, in Gen 8:8, Noah "sent out the dove to see whether the waters had decreased." Similarly, the angels tell Lot "that the Lord has sent us (*וישלחנו*) to destroy it [Sodom]" (19:13). This distinction is particularly notable in the expulsion of Adam from the Garden of Eden. There, both verbs appear side by side: "So the Lord God sent him (*וישלחהו*) from the garden of Eden to till the soil from which he was taken. He drove the man out (*ויגרש*) and stationed east of the garden the cherubim and the fiery ever-turning sword, to guard the way of the tree of life" (Gen 3:23–25). While some believe the combination of the two verbs proves that "two originally independent accounts of the expulsion have come together,"⁵⁵ a closer look will show that the verbs are carefully placed in correlation with the content.⁵⁶ God *sends* (*שלח*) Adam "to till the soil from which he was taken;" the emphasis of this verse is on the destination and purpose to which Adam was sent. The following verse, which emphasizes the involuntary separation from the Garden of Eden, reads "he drove the man out" (*ויגרש*). This verse emphasizes the origin, not the destination.

This distinction touches on one of the essential themes of the expulsion of Ishmael. Sarah's goal is to distance Ishmael from Abraham's home, to prevent him from inheriting with Isaac. Abraham is unhappy about the demand, but God's revelation supports Sarah's position. However, the revelation also revealed new information about the banished son: "As for the son of the slave-woman, I will make a nation of him, too, for he is your seed" (13). Apparently Abraham's son has a glowing future outside his father's home. Sending Ishmael away

54 Similar examples include Ex 33:2; Job 30:5.

55 Westermann 1994, 274.

56 Note the wordplay between *וישלחהו ה' אלהים* ("the Lord God sent him") and God's concern in the previous verse, *פן ישלח ידו* ("lest he send his hand and take also from the tree of life"). According to Cassuto (1961, 173), "God did not just 'send him forth,' an act that would not have precluded all possibility of his returning, but 'He drove him out' – completely."

no longer has to be viewed as an expulsion, but rather as a branching out of Abraham's family.

Saving Ishmael (14–21)

Hagar's pain and frustration at being expelled from the house of her master and the father of her child is only an introduction to the greater suffering of seeing her son dying. There is no negative evaluation of Hagar in the text; the premise of the text empathizes with the suffering of a discarded slave and suffering mother. Nonetheless, there is some implied criticism of Hagar's abandonment of her dying son.⁵⁷ The criticism is particularly apparent in the verb **וַתַּשְׁלֵךְ** – “she cast off the boy under one of the bushes” (21:15).⁵⁸ The verb could easily have been replaced with a more moderate phrase such as: “she put the child into it and placed it (**וַתִּשֶׁם**) among the reeds by the bank of the Nile” (Exod 2:3). This verb seems more appropriate when describing a son being placed by his mother than **וַתַּשְׁלֵךְ** (“cast off”), which is more often used in the case of casting away inanimate objects or corpses.⁵⁹ Other narratives that describe people being “cast off” intend to express unique violence and a deliberate annulment of humanity. This is the case with Joseph's brothers who “took him and cast him (**וַיַּשְׁלִכוּ**) into the pit” [37:24 (and 20)] and Jeremiah: “So they took Jeremiah and they put him down the pit” [Jer 38:6 (and 9)].⁶⁰ Beno Jacob erroneously describes Hagar's action: “She still carefully places the child in

57 In contrast to Monika Egger approach (Egger 2011).

58 NJPS translated **וַתַּשְׁלֵךְ** – “*she left* the boy?”

59 BDB, p. 1020–1021.

60 In the parallel description of Jeremiah's incarceration (Jer 37:15) the language is harsher in comparison with the abovementioned episode: “they beat him and put him into prison.” Regarding the position that views the two episodes as two versions of one story, see Skinner 1922, 258 ff.; Bright 1965, 233–34. For negative connotations of “throwing” living people cf. Ex 1:22. See also HALOT 4: 1528.

the shade under bushes.”⁶¹ His portrayal of Hagar’s action is incongruent with the verb **ותשלך**.⁶² Additionally, Ishmael is referred to as “the boy” in this scene, rather than “her son.” The narrative is designed to create a distance between Hagar and Ishmael; she could only bring herself to “cast him off” as she does if she dissociates from him.

The distance between Hagar and Ishmael is particularly emphasized in the first part of v. 16: “and went and sat down at a distance, far away, a bowshot away.”⁶³ The repetition of Hagar’s distance, which is described in three different terms, is unnecessary for understanding the plot, and seems to call special attention to Hagar’s actions, and to the various levels of distance she creates between herself and her dying son.

The implied criticism of Hagar is also expressed by an inconsistency between vs. 16 and 17. In v. 16 Hagar cries: “And sitting thus afar, she burst into tears.” In v. 17, God reacts to the cries – of Ishmael: “God heard the cry of the boy.” The narrator had not previously mentioned Ishmael’s tears, only Hagar’s. The Septuagint resolved this issue by replacing Hagar’s crying with Ishmael’s: “and she sat opposite him, and the child cried aloud and wept.”⁶⁴ While some adopted this version due to the difficulty mentioned above, the sudden description of her

61 Jacob 1974, 138. Jacob emphasized that **ותשלך** cannot possibly be translated “she threw” (*sie warf*), since no mother would treat her son in that manner (Jacob 1934, 482). He is probably correct that Hagar did not actively throw her son, which makes the use of the verb even more surprising and significant.

62 Gershonides was aware of these connotations, and wrote: “when she saw this, she was afraid that her son would die of dehydration, and angrily tossed him under one of the bushes, so that he will not be darkened by the sun.” he does not specify at whom Hagar was so angry (God? Sarah? Abraham? Her situation?).

63 NJPS omitted the words “far away,” which are perceived as an unnecessary repetition.

64 Zipor 2005, 260. The Greek verbs for “cried out” and “shouted” do not distinguish between male and female; however, the addition “the boy” indicates that they are in the male form. Zipor raises the possibility that the translation was not understood, and that “the boy” was added later for clarification (p. 262). According to this, the original version of the Septuagint does not reflect the male form.

son seems unnatural in the context of the verse.⁶⁵ Rather, the narrator prepared the reader for God's reaction to Hagar's emotional outburst, only to surprise the reader with God's reaction to the crying of the boy. While Hagar distanced herself from her son, God heard his cry. The angel's implicit reprimand of Hagar reinforces this assumption: "What troubles you, Hagar? Fear not, for God has heeded *the cry of the boy* where he is." The angel notes ironically that while Hagar abandoned her son, God heard his cries, "where[ever] he is." The angel therefore calls Hagar to action: "come, lift up the boy and hold him by the hand."⁶⁶ The situation requires the support of a mother, despite Hagar's distress.⁶⁷ Interestingly, despite the fact that Ishmael's name takes on new meaning – "for God (*Elohim*) has heeded (*shama*) the cry of the boy" – he is not mentioned by name even here.

The unique phrase used to describe the distance Hagar puts between herself and her son further emphasizes the criticism of Hagar's choice: "a bowshot away." The phrase appears nowhere else in biblical literature. A bowshot is in the semantic field of warfare; while the reader might empathize with Hagar's difficulty, her action is accompanied by a violent association. She brings his death closer by leaving him alone, by failing to hold his hand in his final hours. The psychological effect of Hagar's distance might be reflected in Ishmael's choice of profession later in life, when he becomes an archer (21:20).⁶⁸

65 For additional critique on the Septuagint version see Hamilton 1995, 76. Tribble wrote appropriately: "But masculine emendations cannot silence Hagar." (Tribble 1984, 235).

66 Tribble (1984, 20 ff.) noted the use of the word יד (hand), which characterized Hagar's flight, rebellion, and suffering (16:6; 16:9; 16:12). Tribble reads the narratives as one unit, and points to a decline in Hagar's emotional state. She views the Sarah–Hagar relationship as the focal point of both narratives. She believed there is no implied criticism of Hagar, who is caught in a conspiracy to prefer Sarah's offspring to the son of the Egyptian maidservant.

67 I disagree with Beno Jacob's assumption that "[a]lthough she says that the child will die and that she does not want to see she sits within sight waiting for help." (Jacob 1974, 138). I believe the narrator emphasizes the fact that Hagar distances herself, and there is no indication that she seeks help.

68 The Septuagint reads "and he grew and dwelt in the wilderness, and became an archer." The Masoretic text, which reads רֶכֶּה קֶשֶׁת is repetitive. For this reason

Bow and arrow narratives are rare in biblical literature; the mention of this weapon twice in one narrative implies a link between the two appearances. In light of the above, one might say Ishmael experiences his mother's distancing as abandonment, and spends his life trying to bridge that distance: shooting at what is out of reach.⁶⁹

The implied criticism of Hagar presents Ishmael as one who was abandoned twice: first he was banished from the house of his father, and later his mother cast him off and distanced herself from him. Although the words do not share a root, the actions of both parents have a similar sound: וישלחה ("he sent her away"), and ותשלך ("she cast [him] off").⁷⁰ Once both parents had abandoned Ishmael, only God could hear his cry, and encourage him in his darkest hour. God will be with him in the wilderness, where he will grow and become a great nation. As noted above, the narrative portrays Ishmael as one who will fulfill his destiny outside the house of Abraham. This reading is reinforced by the angel's words, "for I will make a great nation of him." "A great nation" is, of course, reminiscent of Abraham's blessings, but the combination of great nation and the verb אשימנו ("I will make...of him") is used only in one other biblical narrative. In God's revelation to Jacob on the eve of his descent to Egypt, He tells Jacob: "Fear not to go down to Egypt, for I will make you there (אֶשְׁמְךָ) into a great nation" (46:3).⁷¹ Like Ishmael, Jacob is forced to leave his home and the land of his fathers. God's encouragement at this crossroads is based on the assumption that Jacob's great destiny can only be realized through a disengagement from his homeland. He will become a great nation – but in Egypt. The angel similarly encourages Hagar: he will

some prefer קֶשֶׁת (Zipor 2005, 263) or קֶשֶׁת (Gunkel 1997, 229). According to the latter version the link between Hagar's distance (הִרְחַק כִּמְטָחַי קֶשֶׁת) and Ishmael's profession (רֹכֵב קֶשֶׁת) is enhanced.

69 Alternatively, one might say that Ishmael adopted his mother's attitude toward stressful situations: he shoots far; he does not look his prey in the eye; his arrow does the job while he stands at a comfortable distance.

70 Hamilton 1995, 83.

71 Mathews 2005, 274.

fulfill his destiny far from Abraham's home, and will become a great nation – but only in the wilderness.⁷²

How Old is Ishmael?

According to the chronological sequence of the Abraham cycle, Ishmael should be 16 or 17 at the time of his expulsion. Ishmael was born when Abraham was 86 (16:16); he was circumcised at 13 (17:25), and Isaac was born one year later, when he was 14. Ishmael was expelled when Isaac was weaned, presumably two or three years later. However, the narrative seems to portray Ishmael as a young child. When Abraham sent Hagar away, he “took some bread and a skin of water... He placed them over her shoulder, together with the child, and sent her away” (14). A boy of sixteen would not be placed on his mother's shoulder.⁷³ Some linked “the boy” to the phrase “Abraham took [some bread and a skin of water]” instead of linking “the boy” to Hagar's shoulder; in other words, Abraham put the bread and water on Hagar's shoulder, and gave her the boy.⁷⁴ The main motive for this interpretation is Ishmael's age, as Weinfeld wrote:

72 The promise creates yet another link between the Covenant of Circumcision and the flight of Hagar, which was addressed in the analysis of ch. 16. Here the context of the link is the fulfillment of both promises: God accompanies those who were banished, and will see that they become a great nation in another land.

73 This reading was adopted by various modern translations, including among others NRSV, NJPS, and NAB.

74 Nahmanides wrote on 21:14: “together with the child – in addition to the above: he gave Hagar the child, to take with her to wherever she may go.” This reading is mirrored in several modern translations such as NIV, ASV, NASB, NKJV. Reis (2000, 100) noted interestingly that women do not carry children over their shoulder, but rather tie them to their hip or back: “she does not perch it on her shoulder like an organ-grinder's monkey.”

“The boy” is linked back to “he took.” There is therefore no reason to wonder how she could have carried Ishmael on her shoulders, since he was sixteen or seventeen years of age. A similar grammatical structure can be found in the verse “So the men took that gift, and they took with them double the money, and Benjamin” (43:15). “They took” also refers to “Benjamin.”⁷⁵

This reading supports Wenham’s assertion that delaying the phrase “the boy” to the end of the sentence is part of a deliberate delay, intended to indicate Abraham’s difficulty. Abraham places the bread and the skin of water on Hagar, and only when there was nothing else left for him to do, he reluctantly gave her the child.⁷⁶ However, even if this interpretation is possible in the context of v. 14,⁷⁷ it is challenged throughout the narrative. In addition to certain specific details, such as the angel’s instructions to Hagar to lift up her son, which is unfathomable if Ishmael is 16, the general atmosphere of the chapter portrays Ishmael as a small child: the heat and lack of water affect him sooner than they do his mother; he requires his mother’s assistance, instead of helping her; and the conclusion of the story is followed by God’s accompaniment of Ishmael’s maturation: “God was with the boy and he grew up,” indicating that Ishmael had not yet reached maturity.

This tension is simplified by the documentary hypothesis, which attributes all chronological data in the Abraham cycle to P, while the expulsion of Ishmael was authored by E, a source uncommitted to the chronological details found in other narratives.⁷⁸ But it is hard to imagine that the story cycle was edited while omitting a chronological detail that is so crucial to the narrative.⁷⁹ Moreover, presenting Ishmael

75 Weinfeld 1992, 136. See also White 1975, 302; Hamilton 1995, 82.

76 Wenham 1994, 84 and 87.

77 See discussion by Lyke 1994.

78 E.g., Gunkel 1997, 227. Von Rad (1963, 230) wrote: “With the combination of the sources JE and P, a further difficulty arose, for one must now assume that in ch. 17 Ishmael is about seventeen years old (chs. 16.16; 21.5), which was certainly not the opinion of the narrator (see at ch. 21.15).”

79 When Hagar escaped, the angel informed her that her son will become a great nation (21:18), in correspondence with God’s promise to Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision: “I will make him fertile and exceedingly numerous” (17:20). Here, too, there is a “dialogue” between what is generally accepted as

as מצחק (according to the sexual interpretation mentioned above) is also appropriate to his age (16–17) rather than to his portrayal as an infant in the continuation of the story. Therefore, one must assume that there is a purpose to describing Ishmael as a young child, even if the chronological sequence indicates that he is a young adult. The design is linked with the overall purpose of the narrative.

The Structure and Purpose of the Narrative

Most scholars failed to note the creative literary structure of the narrative, due to the accepted assumption that the chapter comprises two separate literary units as discussed above. The perception of the chapter as one narrative with two different focal points reveals a chiasmic structure:

- a. **God's blessing – the birth of Isaac (1–5)**
 - b. **Sarah laughs at the birth of her son (6–7):** Sarah said, “God has brought me *laughter*; everyone who hears will *laugh* with me.” And she added, “Who would have said to Abraham that Sarah *would suckle children*! Yet I have borne a son in his old age.”
 - c. **Abraham and the weaned Isaac (8):** ...Abraham held a *great feast* on the day that Isaac was *weaned*.
 - d. **Sarah demands Ishmael's expulsion (9–11):** ...*The matter distressed* Abraham greatly, for it concerned a son of his.
 - d1. **God supports Sarah's demand (12–13):** But God said to Abraham, “Do not *be distressed* over the boy or your slave...”
 - c1. **Abraham and the expelled Ishmael (14):** Early next morning Abraham took some bread and *a skin of water*, and gave them to Hagar. He placed them over her shoulder, together with the child, and *sent her away*.
 - b1. **Hagar cries at the dying of her son (14–16):** And she wandered about in the wilderness of Beer-sheba. *When the water was gone from the skin*, she discarded the child under one of the bushes, and went and sat

P (Covenant of Circumcision) and what is generally accepted as E (Hagar's flight).

down at a distance, a bowshot away; for she thought, “Let me not look on as the child dies.” And sitting thus afar, *she burst into tears.*

a1. God’s blessing – the rebirth of Ishmael (17–21)

The structure of the narrative emphasizes the contrast between the birth of Isaac and the expulsion of Ishmael. Before Isaac was born, there was no disputing Ishmael’s place and standing in his father’s house; once Isaac is born, the status of the son of the slave is questioned, and he is sent away. The structure represents the story of the two brothers: the brother who entered the house of Abraham (first part) and the brother who had to leave the house of Abraham (second part). Sarah’s demand (d) belongs to the first half of the narrative, since from Sarah’s perspective the purpose of Ishmael’s banishment is to eliminate possible competition for Isaac’s inheritance and position as Abraham’s heir. In contrast, the divine revelation that supports Sarah’s demand (d1) belongs to the second part, which contains a promise that Ishmael will become a great nation. The divine revelation is the introduction to the Ishmael narrative.⁸⁰

The parallel emphasizes different parental situations with regard to their children; this difference is particularly apparent in the description of the two mothers (b-b1). Sarah, who finally “holds” the sons she had endlessly prayed for, laughs joyously, while Hagar “casts off” her son, is forced to distance herself from his fate, and turns away to cry in misery. While Sarah is delighted by the abundance of milk that fills her breasts for her baby, Hagar watches her dying son without an ability to provide him with the water of life. A similar distinction is apparent in the father’s description in relation to each of his sons (c-c1). Abraham celebrates the day of Isaac’s independence from his mother with a great feast, while Abraham sends Ishmael away with only enough bread and water to sustain him until he reaches his final destination, far from Abraham’s home.

80 Garsiel (1991, 156) noted that the names Isaac and Ishmael have opposite meanings in the narrative. Sarah saw Ishmael מצחק (“laughing-playing”) and God told Abraham שמע בקולה (“listen to Sarah”). The structure of the story parallels these two statements.

The two parallel halves of the narrative contrast the happy parents who bring a new child into their home, and the unhappy parents who are forced to separate from their son. Since Ishmael and Isaac have different mothers, the distinction between them is clarified throughout the plot, but the contrast in Abraham's relationship with each of his sons is more complex. The heart of the transformation in the story involves the development of Abraham's character throughout the narrative. Initially he is "distressed" over the expulsion of "his son" (11) and is reluctant to listen to Sarah before God Himself intervenes, and tells him not to be distressed. In God's revelation Ishmael is referred to as "the boy (12),⁸¹ and when Abraham finally sends Ishmael away, he is "the child" – not "his child" (14).

The two reversed parts of the story focus on the development of two characters: Abraham and Ishmael. Abraham internalizes the fact that Ishmael is not "his son," and will not be the one to "carry on his name." This development is linked with Ishmael's changing status; initially he is to be "cast off" or banished; but in reality he is "sent away." The focus is not on Ishmael leaving the house of his father, but rather on the destiny that awaits him in the desert, where God will accompany him and bless him.

Against this background, I wish to explore the narrative frame (a-a1). As already mentioned, the two halves of the story mirror each other, pitting Isaac's relationship with his parents against Ishmael and his parents. The two frame components, however, do not oppose each other. God initially blesses Sarah and her son, and eventually blesses Hagar and her son; not only by saving Ishmael from thirst, but by watching him closely as he grows up: "God was with the boy, and he grew up" (21:20). This connection shows that Ishmael's rescue is configured as a rebirth. In the fiery heat of the desert, God appears and drags him from death's door by opening his mother's eyes. In a certain sense, Abraham's circumcision of Isaac (a) is parallel to Ishmael's marriage, arranged by Hagar (a), as both are related to fertility and family continuity. Thus, in parallel to Isaac's naming at the beginning of the chapter, the episode concludes with an implicit explanation for

81 Among others, Hamilton 1995, 81.

Ishmael's name: "God heard (שמע) the cry of the boy...Fear not, for God has heeded (שמע) the cry of the boy" (21:17). Perhaps the reason Ishmael's name is omitted from the text until this point is that he had lost the name given to him by his father when he lost his status, and had to regain an independent name through his rebirth. His name represents the reason for his rescue: God had heard Ishmael's prayers, and helped him when his own parents had abandoned him, as the speaker of Psalm 27 declares: "though my father and mother abandoned me, the Lord will take me in." God opened Hagar's eyes so she could sustain her son, just as Sarah nursed her child.⁸² Finally, Isaac's growth to maturity ("The child grew up") is mirrored by Ishmael's development, but while Isaac's development is accompanied by his father, who celebrates his weaning with a great feast, Ishmael is accompanied by a surrogate father who accompanies him to maturity: "God was with the boy and he grew up."

Perhaps Ishmael is portrayed as a young child since the narrative is designed as a birth story. While a simple calculation of the chronological data proves that Ishmael is not a child but a young man, his rebirth necessitates a depiction of one who is placed to be carried by Hagar, and requires the protection of adults. Only at the end of the story does the boy "grow up." Ishmael, who is abandoned under one of the bushes, is as a fetus waiting to burst into reality. This transformation can only occur far from Abraham's house, in the wilderness.⁸³

The concluding verses clarify how the Ishmaelite tribes, the archers, settled in the desert, and explain their link to Egypt:⁸⁴ "God was

82 The Septuagint reads: "the God opened her eyes, and she saw a well of *water of life*" (Zipor 2005, 261) in correlation with Gen 26:19. Some scholars preferred this version (e.g., Ball 1896, 73), which emphasizes Ishmael's rebirth: the well symbolizes a new life for the dying boy.

83 Some central motifs of this scene are narrative conventions symbolizing "re-birth," which feature in both biblical and extra-biblical literature. In this context, the motif of the child's separation from his parents as a prerequisite to rebirth is especially noteworthy. See more in: Daniel and Grossman, 2016.

84 Von Rad (1963, 229) disagreed with the etiological explanation. He believed Hagar's flight in ch. 16 was etiological (both the well and the son were named), while in the expulsion narrative the naming is absent.

with the boy and he grew up; he dwelt in the wilderness and became a bowman. He lived in the wilderness of Paran; and his mother got a wife for him from the land of Egypt” (20–21). The verses also conclude the final separation of Ishmael from his father.⁸⁵ The involvement of the mother in her son’s marriage is unusual, particularly in light of the fact that Ishmael was portrayed as a grown man who had developed a profession and settled in Paran. Instead of Ishmael “taking a wife,” his mother got one for him from her homeland. The description is generally congruent with the book of Genesis, in which fathers – not the mothers – take a wife for their sons from their place of origin, or send a messenger in their place (24; 28:1–5; 29:19; 34:4; 38:6 and 8; 41:45).⁸⁶ The narrative materials explain why Abraham is not the one to obtain Ishmael’s wife; Hagar’s continued involvement indicates that Ishmael was not abandoned in the desert and continues to be cared for by his mother. Hagar appropriately selects a wife for her son from her place of origin; the conclusion of the story therefore determines that Ishmael is Hagar’s son, not Abraham’s.⁸⁷

Gunkel believed that the two verses that report Ishmael dwelling in the wilderness (20 and 21) are the result of a combination of two sources.⁸⁸ Westermann read v. 21 as an independent verse, since Ishmael is described there as dwelling in the desert of Paran, as opposed to v. 14, which places him in Beer-sheba.⁸⁹ The culmination of the narrative in Beer-sheba would have been appropriate, where Hagar

85 Mathews (2005, 274) wrote: “he is the son of a slave woman, married to an Egyptian, lives outside normal social bounds, and is remembered for his hostilities.” See also Jacobs 1974, 193. According to an etiological reading of this narrative, this is not only the geographical location, but the cultural as well: the reader is exposed to the source of their independence, and the chronicle that led to their savagery.

86 Hamilton (1995, 85–86) was mistaken in writing that Hagar providing Ishmael with a wife was the prevalent custom. The father was responsible for marrying his children, not the mother.

87 Hamilton (1995, 86) noted that just as Abraham took a wife for his son from his homeland (Gen 24), Hagar decided Ishmael should marry an Egyptian: “An Egyptian with an Egyptian and an Aramean with an Aramean.”

88 Gunkel 1997, 229.

89 Westermann 1995, 343.

lost her way, and where Ishmael nearly dies and was miraculously reborn. However, had Ishmael settled in Beer-sheba, he would have been “too close” to Abraham and Isaac. Beer-sheba is an integral part of Canaan, and at times a holy site for the Israelite nation. The unrealized anticipation that Ishmael will end up in Beer-sheba emphasizes the distance between him and Abraham. Ultimately, Ishmael’s marriage to an Egyptian woman places him on the Egyptian side of the border, with his mother, instead of the Canaanite side with Abraham.

Hagar’s Flight (Gen 16) and Hagar’s Expulsion (21)

Hagar’s flight from her mistress in Gen 16 is paralleled in the expulsion of Hagar in ch. 21. The parallels include major motifs and grammatical links. Culley wrote: “Thus, for the two Hagar stories, the outline of the action common to both is very short and rather general: (a) Hagar flees or is driven out to the wilderness from Abram (Abraham) with Sarai (Sarah) as instigator. (b) Messenger intervenes with promise about son.”⁹⁰ The two focal points can be described in broader terms to enhance the similarity.⁹¹

- a. Hagar, along with her son (in the womb in ch. 16 and on her shoulders in ch. 21), is separated from the house of Abraham.
- b. Both separations are linked with Sarah (her actions or demand).
- c. Hagar and her fetus/son venture into the wilderness in the south.
- d. God’s angel appears to Hagar in the vicinity of water and blesses her offspring.
- e. Ishmael’s name is given significance in each of the episodes: while he is named in ch. 16 in commemoration of God hearing Hagar’s suffering in ch. 16, his name is given a new and independent meaning when God hears his suffering in ch. 21.

90 Culley 1976, 45.

91 Cf. Dozeman 1998; Willi-Plein 2010.

Additionally, the two narratives are linked through similar language:

- a. Abraham “heeded (שמע) Sarai’s request” in 16:2; in 21:12 God commands Abraham: “whatever Sarah tells you do as she says (שמע בקולה).”⁹²
- b. Both narratives feature the motif or keywords שמע-ראה (“to see” – “to hear”).⁹³ In 16 the pair affects the naming of the child (שמעאל) and of the place (אל-ראי).⁹⁴
- c. In both narratives the angel addresses Hagar with a question: “Hagar, slave of Sarai, where have you come from, and where are you going?” (16:8); “What troubles you, Hagar?” (21:17).

This apparent duplicity has led many scholars and biblical critics to assume that two sources or traditions found their way into the final design of the Abraham cycle. The differences between the stories are generally considered evidence that the chapter is composed of two unrelated sources.

Alexander noted the following differences:⁹⁵

- The stories begin at different points in Abraham and Sarah’s lives.
- A different reason is given for the tension between Sarah and Hagar.
- Abraham acts differently in each narrative.
- Hagar’s character is designed differently.⁹⁶

92 Needless to say the verb שמע (“to hear”) carries unique significance in the Ishmael narratives. See Garsiel 1991, 121, who wrote that שמע is a keyword in ch. 16.

93 Regarding this pair of keywords in the biblical narrative, see Frish 1999; Terrien 1978. Regarding the pair of verbs in relation to the link between the two narratives, see also Trible 1984, 26.

94 Garsiel 1991, 119.

95 Alexander 1997, 52–69. See also Mathews 2005, 180–81.

96 See similarly, Speiser 1964. Speiser believed the escape narrative portrays Hagar as “rough,” while in the expulsion narrative she cries for her son. He used this fact to assert that the two stories could not have come from a single hand, and viewed the detail as further proof of the documentation hypothesis. Cf. von Rad 1963, 230: “In ch. 16 she is courageous and proud, in ch. 21 she finds herself in a miserable, pitiable situation.” Hamilton (1995, 77) also contrasted Hagar’s character in ch. 16 (“In ch. 16 she is haughty and contemptuous”) with

- Hagar leaves Abraham's house in a different fashion (escape/banishment).
- The well/spring serves a different purpose: in the expulsion the main purpose is to save the dying child.
- The names "Ishmael" and "lahai-roi" only appear in ch. 16.⁹⁷
- The conclusion of each narrative is different: whereas Hagar returns to Abraham's home in ch. 16, she disengages permanently in ch. 21.

Alexander added that Sarah's concern for Ishmael's inheritance is implausible without familiarity with ch. 16; similarly, Van Seters wrote that ch. 21 cannot be understood without the background given in ch. 16.⁹⁸ He believed the expulsion narrative is written based on the assumption that the reader is familiar with Hagar's flight,⁹⁹ while Alexander concluded: "The differences noted above far outweigh any similarities that exist. The widely held opinion that chs. xvi and xxi preserve parallel records of the same original event must be rejected."¹⁰⁰

Despite Alexander's distinctions, which prove beyond a doubt that the two chapters reflect two different occurrence and not two versions of the same story, the major motifs that link the two narratives cannot be overlooked. The distinguishing elements in each narrative

her character in ch. 21 ("In ch. 21 she is totally passive"); however, he refused to view the narrative as a combination of two sources or traditions. As mentioned above, ch. 21 can be read an implicit criticism of Hagar, while in ch. 16, God identifies with her pain.

97 Von Rad (1963, 229) believed that the etymological foundation of the story was almost entirely suppressed in the Hagar narrative.

98 Van Seters 1975, 196–97. Among others, he assumed the phrase "Hagar the Egyptian had borne to Abraham" (21:9) leans on ch. 16, as does Sarah's concern that the son of her maidservant would inherit Abraham. He believed that "The son of [an] ordinary slave-girl could never challenge the inheritance rights of the son of the principal wife. It is only in the special circumstances such as portrayed in chap. 16 that Hagar's son can acquire the full status of a son and heir." (p. 197).

99 Van Seters 1975, 200. He wrote that the Covenant of Circumcision should be read as background to ch. 21 as well.

100 Alexander 1990, 134.

emphasize specific factors that contribute to the individual purpose of each of the narratives; by contrasting the narratives, one may define the unique purpose of each of the narratives.

1. *The Protagonist*: The protagonist of the narrative describing Hagar's flight (16) is Sarai. The narrative opens with Sarah's barrenness and ownership of an Egyptian maidservant (16:1); Sarai initiates the idea of using Hagar as a surrogate mother (16:2), and makes this suggestion to Abram, while focusing on her personal gain, "perhaps I shall have a son through her." Abram "heeded Sarai's request," once again emphasizing that Sarai is the active and leading character in the story, while Abram is entirely passive: his opinions are not expressed, he fails to investigate the matter; he just listens to his wife. As noted in the analysis of ch. 16, Sarai's dominance is expressed through the use of the verb לקח ("to take/to marry") in relation to Hagar: "So Sarai... took her maid...and gave her to her husband Abram as concubine" (16:3). While Abram will be the one to have marital relations with Hagar, Sarai is the one who "marries her."

The plot is therefore driven by Sarai: she initiated Hagar's relationship with Abram; she suffered the implications of that relationship and chose to react by mistreating Hagar; she drove Hagar away by reacting as she did. Adar wrote appropriately: "here Abram lacks personality...which is very different from the parallel narrative in ch. 21."¹⁰¹ In ch. 21, too, Sarah seemingly initiates the expulsion (21:10), but this time Abraham takes a clear stand: "The matter distressed Abraham greatly" (21:11).¹⁰² Abraham undergoes a process of change throughout the narrative; he initially views Ishmael as "his son," but ultimately recognizes that he is merely "the child"; he is initially distressed, but ultimately understands that the expulsion of Ishmael is part of God's plan. Abraham is active on the realistic plane as well: he rises early, prepares food for the journey, helps Hagar pack, and sends her off. The expulsion narrative emphasizes Abraham's actions in light of the change he undergoes.¹⁰³

101 Adar 1967, 54.

102 Von Rad 1963, 227.

103 Cf. Zakovitch 1987, 32, note 6.

2. *The Content and Recipient of the Blessing (and the evaluation of Hagar):*

The literary links between Hagar's flight and the preceding narrative – the Covenant of Circumcision – were noted in the analysis of ch. 16. Hagar's character is compared to the offspring of Abraham, who were sentenced to suffer under Egyptian rule but promised that they would someday be free.¹⁰⁴ Hagar is therefore compared to Abraham: she, too, would merit land and the blessing of fertility.¹⁰⁵ Hagar's blessing is a compensation for her suffering, and a reward for returning to Sarai's home as she was instructed by the angel.

In the parallel expulsion narrative, Hagar once again hears a blessing by the angel of God; however, this time the blessing is not addressed to her directly, but to her son. The angel does not offer Hagar a new blessing; he simply reveals God's promise to Abraham, using the same words: "I will make a (great) nation of him too" (21:13). Since Hagar's actions are criticized in the narrative, there is no justification for a new blessing. The reason for the blessing is not Hagar's suffering, or her distress; Ishmael is blessed in this case because he is Abraham's son. In contrast with ch. 16, the blessing of Ishmael is not compensation or reward; it is part of God's historical plan for Abraham and his descendants.¹⁰⁶

104 Trible (1984, 20 ff.) compared ch. 21 to the exodus from Egypt, but her interpretation was that the comparison between Israel and Hagar portrays Hagar as disadvantaged and wronged, as opposed to the Israelite nation, who had God at their side throughout the process.

105 This detail is especially prominent if one accepts Drey's position, that the placement of Hagar's escape between the two covenants affects the reading of the story (Drey 2002). However, he believes Hagar's escape is a fulfillment of the promise of great nations, since God saved Hagar's son and promised her that he would become a great nation.

106 Fensham 1969, 81; Trible (1984, 22) wrote that now that Ishmael received a second blessing, this time as Abraham's offspring, the blessing to Hagar become obsolete, and her significance diminished. There is no justification for reading the second blessing as a replacement of the first; Trible prefers this interpretation, which supports her claim that Hagar is discriminated against. In this context I disagree with Ehrlich (1969, 57–58) who wrote: "the first story [the escape of Hagar] indicates what God will do for those who are part of the household of Abraham our forefather – even for a maidservant. The last story

These are the two central differences I wish to rely upon in the following discussion; it is also worth noting several other differences:

3. Alexander noted that the reason for Hagar's flight is her relationship with Sarai. Hagar was disrespectful toward her mistress, and as a result Sarai mistreated her; this tension led to Hagar's escape. In contrast, the reason for Hagar's expulsion was Ishmael's conduct, and the issue of the inheritance of Ishmael and Isaac. In other words, the reason for the expulsion involves the relationships of the next generation.¹⁰⁷

4. In the escape narrative, Hagar is the initiator of the separation from Abram's household. Abram and Sarai are not even aware of her decision to flee, and God is uninvolved until He addresses Hagar's distress in the wilderness. In contrast, in the expulsion narrative the separation from Abraham's house is initiated by divine decree.

5. When Hagar escapes to the wilderness, the angel suggests a name for her unborn child, and her son is indeed named Ishmael by Abram.¹⁰⁸ In contrast, Ishmael's name is not mentioned once in the expulsion narrative. This detail contributes to the independent purpose of each narrative. In the expulsion narrative, Ishmael is blessed by the merit of being Abraham's offspring, while in the escape story Hagar receives blessings for Ishmael independently of Abram.

6. The revelation: When Hagar flees, the angel finds her by a spring and speaks with her. The conversation is direct and personal, as though two people were speaking with each other. This quasi-human

[the expulsion] shows that God would change his ways when the attaché is no longer part of Abraham's household." I believe the opposite to be true: the first story portrays Hagar as an independent personality, while in the second she only merits her blessing due to her relationship with Abraham!

107 Van Seters 1975, 39; Willi-Plein 2010, 199–200.

108 When Hagar escaped in ch. 16, both Ishmael and the well are given names, as opposed to ch. 21, where only Ishmael was named (Garsiel 1991, 119), see also Skinner 1930, 324; Alexander 1990, 133. Gunkel (1997, 229) believed the expulsion story originally included a naming of the well, which was omitted due to the alternative name in the following chapter.

element is emphasized in the fact that the angel “found her” (16:7).¹⁰⁹ In the expulsion story the angel did not “find Hagar,” and he does not converse with her; rather, he “called to Hagar from heaven” to deliver his divine message.¹¹⁰

7. An additional distinction, which led to the narrative’s separation into various sources, is the use of different names for God in each of the narratives: the name YHWH is used throughout the escape narrative, while the name Elohim is prevalent in the expulsion narrative.

The different objectives in each of the stories can be understood in light of these differences. Hagar’s flight is a personal-ethical narrative, involving a quarrel between a maidservant and her mistress, causing the maidservant to flee, only to be encouraged to return to her former position by an angel of God, who promised her compensation for her suffering. The plot is driven by the choices made by the characters in the narrative: Sarai offered Hagar to Abram; Hagar was disrespectful to her mistress; Sarai was unkind to her maidservant. God became involved in the narrative only after Hagar escaped, in response to her distress and unfair treatment. The dialogues in the narrative are all personal and intimate: Sarai complains to Abram, and he responds; the angel speaks to Hagar and encourages her, and even suggests a name for her unborn child. The name YHWH is appropriately used for God, who becomes involved at a personal level and is even concerned with the distress of a suffering maidservant.

In contrast with the escape narrative, the expulsion narrative is an extension of the historical-national axis of the Abraham cycle. This is a story about the implementation of God’s plan. Even if Sarah initiates the expulsion, she is not the force behind the plot, which is ultimately only implemented because of God’s revelation to Abraham. This is not a personal or private quarrel between two characters; the argument relates to the essential issues of Abraham’s inheritance and

109 The root נָצַח, which denotes “to find,” is used in the context of direct contact (e.g., Gen 37:15–16). Ehrlich (1969, 57) noted that the phrase implies a chance meeting.

110 As opposed to Gunkel (1997, 228), who viewed the conversation as divine, similar to the Burning Bush.

Abraham's heir. Sarah's motive is not personal; she acts out of concern for the legal status of her son. God's intervention in the argument between Sarah and Abraham is crucial, since the main purpose of the story is to distance Ishmael from Abraham and his chosen offspring. Statements regarding the establishment of the nation (21:12: "for it is through Isaac that offspring shall be continued for you") are entirely absent from the escape narrative. Ishmael's "rebirth" and blessing is part of the fundamental theme of the choice of Abraham: even Abraham's rejected sons are blessed, and they, too, fulfill the blessing to Abraham that he will be "the father of a multitude of nations," despite the fact that they do not inherit his covenant with God.

The personal tone that accompanied Hagar's flight is absent from the expulsion narrative. While Ishmael's name is given in the initial narrative, in the expulsion story he is not referred to by name, but rather by his position ("son," "boy"); he is a nameless child. The angel in the expulsion narrative appears to Hagar "from heaven," as opposed to the personal treatment she had received previously. The name Elohim reflects the universal administration of history by God; this is the appropriate name for a narrative that points history in the direction of the divine plan.

This essential distinction is expressed in the formulation of the blessing Hagar receives. When she had fled from Sarai, the angel blessed her with a multiplicity of offspring: "I will greatly increase your offspring" (16:10); however, when she was expelled from Abraham's home, the angel blessed Hagar with the promise that "a great nation" will come from Ishmael. As mentioned in the introduction, the word nation, "גוי," has national connotations, and features appropriately in the context of Ishmael's expulsion. This, too, is the expression of the distinction between a narrative about choice and rejection, which includes a general national message (ch. 21) and a personal-ethical narrative, whose purpose is to support and encourage a woman in distress (16).

The main difference between the two narratives relates to Hagar and Ishmael's status. In the private story of a maidservant who escaped from her mistress out of misery, God addresses Hagar and

compensates her for her suffering. In contrast, Ishmael's expulsion is part of God's original plan, which is mapped out before Abraham knows he will father Isaac (17:19–21).

The protagonist of each of the narratives is changed accordingly. Abraham was chosen to father a new nation; therefore the narrative describing the choice of Isaac and the rejection of Ishmael focuses on Abraham. The reader is exposed to his dismay, and to his ultimate decision (after God's encouragement) to disinherit the son of the maidservant. Abraham is also the one to actively send away Hagar and her son. Sarah represents the personal yearning of a simple couple for a child, and the household that reflects Abraham's education and personality, independent of the broader national and divine context. Therefore, she plays a defining role in Hagar's flight, which is a story of personal and internal affairs in Abraham's household and family.

Ishmael's position differs from that of the other rejected members of Abraham's family (Lot and Esau); in ch. 16 he received an independent blessing that was unrelated to his relationship with Abraham. Perhaps this is also the explanation for Ishmael's place of dwelling in the desert of Paran, south of Canaan, in contrast with Lot and Esau who inherited areas east of the Jordan River.

In earlier expulsions in Genesis, those who were rejected from before God went to the east: Adam went east of the Garden of Eden (3:24);¹¹¹ and after murdering his brother, Cain also "left the presence of the Lord and settled in the land of Nod, *east* of Eden" (4:16).¹¹² Lot chose the Transjordan, and traveled east (13:9–13) to what became the land of his descendants, Ammon and Moab; Esau traveled to Seir, south of the Transjordan and east of Canaan; and the sons of Abraham's concubines were sent away "eastward, to the land of the East" (25:6). As mentioned in the discussion of ch. 14, Cassuto demonstrated the link between their settling east of Canaan and Moses' warning to the Israelite nation that they may not conquer those areas,

111 See Cassuto 1961, 174.

112 See Westermann 1994, 314 ("It is not a piece of geographical information but a reference to life "outside," in a state of alienation from God").

which were given as an inheritance by God (Deut 2:4–20),¹¹³ while Ishmael's absence is notable in the verses discussing portions of land surrounding Canaan that were given by God as an inheritance to Abraham's offspring. The absence is linked with another anomaly: Ishmael is Abraham's only rejected offspring who fails to settle in the east, and chose instead to settle in the desert of Paran (21:20–21).

The story of Ishmael's expulsion seems to function as an etiological explanation for this anomaly.¹¹⁴ Hagar's flight, Ishmael's expulsion, and the double revelation in the wilderness explain why the Ishmaelites settled the harsh environment of the desert. There Hagar was ordered to return to Sarah and suffer her harsh treatment; there her eyes were opened to the well that hid in the dunes of the burning sand. These episodes suggest that the Ishmaelites learned to thrive in the wilderness because *there* they were blessed by God; *there* God "was with the boy and he grew up" (21:20). The flight narrative emphasizes the location of the angel's revelation to Hagar. The exact location is named in its conclusion: "Therefore the well was called Beer-lahai-roi; it is between Kadesh and Bered" (16:14). This emphasis anticipates that this location will become their home; that the wild nature of the "wild ass of a man," ancestor of the Ishmaelites who are able to thrive in the wilderness, is the result of divine compensation for Hagar and her son. God promises Abraham that Ishmael, too, will be the father of a great nation; as part of Abraham's offspring, he will inherit an independent portion of land in the south – the site of his mother's double revelations, where she learned to "see" where water hides in the wilderness; where Ishmael was raised by God and bloomed in the harsh desert environment.

113 Cassuto 1964, 367.

114 Noort writes that "the author looks at nomadic life in complete amazement and astonishment. Nomads and nomadic life are strange and dangerous to him. They are a threat. Nevertheless, these people are brothers and neighbours; and although they are distant brothers, they are still family" (Noort 2010 – Abraham, 17). Nomads were a regularly encountered Other in everyday life, and this episode seeks to explain why and how they came to thrive in the desert.

Chapter 15: The Treaty of Abraham and Abimelech (21:22–34)

The next episode in the Abraham–Abimelech relationship is postponed until after the birth of Isaac and expulsion of Ishmael (21:1–21), despite the fact that this episode is a direct continuation of the “sister-wife” episode in ch. 20. Continuity is apparent from Abimelech’s request that Abraham “will return the kindness that I have done for you, to me and to the land in which you have sojourned” (21:23),¹ and from literary links between the texts.² The significance of this delay should presumably be found in the link between the current unit (the treaty of Abraham and Abimelech) and the previous or following units (the birth of Isaac and expulsion of Ishmael or the binding of Isaac). The treaty narrative begins with a time reference to the previous episode: “At that time...” (21:22).³ However, textual links also exist between the treaty narrative and the binding of Isaac,⁴ and the episode might have been moved so that the binding narrative can be read on the background of the treaty narrative.⁵ Another possibility is that postponing the

1 NJPS translated: “...will deal with me and with the land in which you have sojourned as loyally as I have dealt with you.”

2 Coats (1983, 155) wrote that a literary frame surrounds both units: The frame opens “he settled in Gerar” (20:1) and concludes: “And Abraham resided in the land of the Philistines a long time” (21:34).

3 Coats 1983, 155.

4 See Bin-Nun 2003, 107.

5 One purpose of the treaty narrative is etymological, regarding the name Beer-sheba (Coats 1983, 155–57). According to this reading there is another link between the narratives: the sanctified location is named Beer-sheba in commemoration of Abraham’s pact with Abimelech, while in the binding narrative the sanctified place is named Adonai-yireh, in commemoration of his relationship with God. Note that the binding narrative concludes with a double mention of Abraham’s return to Beer-Sheba (22:19): “Abraham then

treaty episode enabled the juxtaposition of the closed wombs of Abimelech's household and Sarah's birth. Additionally, the significance of the treaty between Abraham and Abimelech is validated with the birth of Isaac; had the treaty taken place before his birth, the responsibilities of the treaty might only have obligated Abraham and Ishmael. Forging the treaty after Isaac's birth means that Isaac is included in the pact, and clarifies the significance of the treaty.⁶ Another obvious link exists between the treaty narrative and the expulsion of Ishmael: Abraham banished his son, who almost died of dehydration as a result, but was saved when his mother was made aware of a well in the wilderness, while in the treaty narrative Abraham fought over wells with the people of Gerar. Alter emphasized that the well in both narratives is necessary for the very existence of the relevant party – "obtaining a source of life in the wilderness."⁷ The dispute between Abraham and Abimelech is a matter of life and death. Additionally, Hagar was lost in the wilderness of Beer-sheba, and the name Beer-sheba was given meaning in the treaty narrative.⁸ Another connection between the episodes which touches upon the scene's narrative objective is a phrase that appears in both of them: "God was with the boy" (21:20) and "God is with you in everything that you do" (21:22). As Brody writes, the connection shows that "despite the separation of Abraham and Ishmael, God is with both."⁹ In our story, however, the latter declaration is made by Abimelech, a gentile king, and the significance of this will be clarified below.

returned to his servants, and they departed together for Beer-sheba; and Abraham stayed in Beer-sheba."

6 Emanueli (1978, 293) suggested that the pact between Abraham and Abimelech took place at the great feast Abraham held in 21:8, "therefore there was no need to announce their arrival."

7 Alter 1981, 182.

8 See Hamilton 1995, 87. Hamilton added other less convincing elements, such as Abraham providing Hagar with bread and water compared with Abraham giving cattle to Abimelech.

9 Brodie 2001, 262.

Beyond the context and placement, the internal sequence of the narrative is problematic, particularly in the transfer from v. 24 to v. 25. In v. 24 Abraham is willing to swear, and while the reader anticipates that his oath will follow, an unexpected element is inserted in v. 25: Abraham's grievance against Abimelech stealing his well. Many scholars assume this is the combination of two separate narratives: in the first (22–24; 27; 31), Abraham agrees to Abimelech's offer to make a friendly pact, and the place is named Beer-sheba in commemoration of the pact ("sheba" from the root שבע – "to take an oath"). The second narrative (25–26; 28–30; 33) is about a treaty that resolves a long-term conflict over wells, and validates Abraham's claim to Beer-sheba. Abraham plants a sanctified tree in commemoration of the validation.¹⁰ According to this position, the narratives should be read in the following order:¹¹

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- 10 See von Rad 1963, 230–32. Some scholars viewed this as a combination of two sources (Gunkel 1997; Skinner 1930; Procksch 1913. The division above is based on their analysis). Others viewed the section as one primary source with added narrative sections (e.g., Dillmann; Speiser; Coats). However, an alternative position values the current design of the narrative, regardless of the original sources (Wenham 1994, 91).
- 11 Gunkel (1997, 230–31) discussed the issue at length. The division of verses above is based on Skinner 1930, 325, although he fails to note the double pacts in 27 and 32. For alternate suggestions see Gunkel *ibid.*; Westermann 1995, 346.

| <i>The Friendly Treaty</i> | <i>The Ceasefire</i> |
|--|--|
| <p>(22) At that time Abimelech and Phicol, chief of his troops, said to Abraham, “God is with you in everything that you do. (23) Therefore swear to me here by God that you will not deal falsely with me or with my kith and kin, but will deal with me and with the land in which you have sojourned as loyally as I have dealt with you.” (24) And Abraham said, “I swear it.”</p> <p>(27) Abraham took sheep and oxen and gave them to Abimelech, and the two of them made a pact.</p> <p>(31) Hence that place was called Beer-sheba, for there the two of them swore an oath. (32) When they had concluded the pact at Beer-sheba, Abimelech and Phicol, chief of his troops, departed and returned to the land of the Philistines.</p> <p>(34) And Abraham resided in the land of the Philistines a long time.</p> | <p>(25) Then Abraham reproached Abimelech for the well of water which the servants of Abimelech had seized. (26) But Abimelech said, “I do not know who did this; you did not tell me, nor have I heard of it until today.”</p> <p>(28) Abraham then set the seven ewes of the flock by themselves, (29) and Abimelech said to Abraham, “What mean these seven ewes which you have set apart?” (30) He replied, “You are to accept these seven ewes from me as proof that I dug this well.”</p> <p>(33) Abraham planted a tamarisk at Beer-sheba, and invoked there the name of the Lord, the Everlasting God.</p> |

Both narratives include similar elements: a dialogue between Abraham and Abimelech; Abraham presents Abimelech with cattle; testimony of commitment (an oath and “proof”); finally, significance is given in both narratives to the name Beer-sheba; in the first, the name “sheba” relates to the oath, and in the second, “sheba” commemorates the seven ewes that are proof of Abraham’s ownership of the well.

The separation into two separate narratives is convincing: whereas the narrative begins in the atmosphere of friendship and appeasement, the second scene brings forward hostility between the parties. Coats did not view the two stories as separate or contradictory but sees the disagreement over ownership of the well as a difference between friends and allies, whose treaty was stable enough to withstand the

crisis without a real conflict.¹² This reading is difficult to accept, since the design of the characters in each of the episodes is indeed contradictory: a different character is responsible for the commitment in each of the narratives, and a different character compels the other to act. From the political perspective, Abraham is the stronger presence in both narratives, which explains why Abimelech is interested in a pact. From an ethical perspective, however, Abimelech seems to be more powerful; he asks Abraham for a treaty because Abraham is indebted to him, and Abraham seems to have no choice but to take an oath. In contrast, in the second scene Abraham accuses Abimelech of immoral conduct.

Despite his analysis, Coats is correct that the narrative should not be viewed as two separate stories, but rather as a complex account that intentionally presents opposing facts. Sarna proved the unity of the narrative based on the prevalence and centrality of the number seven throughout the narrative: in addition to Abraham offering Abimelech seven ewes and the name of the place that commemorates this number, the names “Abraham” and “Abimelech” each appear seven times throughout the narrative.¹³ Sarna therefore viewed the narrative as a harmonious unit, despite the intentional incongruities that enhance the purpose of the narrative, as demonstrated below.

Abimelech’s request is based on two elements: God’s blessing to Abraham, and Abraham’s moral obligation to Abimelech.¹⁴ Abimelech’s recognition that “God is with you in everything that you do”

12 Coats (1983, 156) proved the unity of the narrative from the mention of cattle in both narratives; however, the cattle is not a viable link since it serves a different purpose in each of the narratives. Speiser (1964, 160) also claimed there is no room to divide the narrative, but failed to explain why. Nahmanides on Genesis 21:23 preceded Coats with a similar explanation.

13 Sarna 1989, 145.

14 The parallel narrative describing Isaac’s pact with Abimelech also relies on these two elements: “And they said, ‘We now see plainly that the Lord has been with you, and we thought: Let there be a sworn treaty between our two parties, between you and us. Let us make a pact with you that you will not do us harm, just as we have not molested you but have always dealt kindly with you and sent you away in peace. From now on, be you blessed of the Lord!’” (26:28–29). However, while Abraham’s Abimelech can rely on an actual “kindness” offered

plays an important role in the purpose of this scene. Abimelech reflects Abraham's political acceptance by the people of the land. The acknowledgment by a foreign king of Abraham's covenant with God is a new stage in the establishment of Abraham's rights to the land. But the second element founds the pact on the unique relationship between Abraham and Abimelech: "return the kindness that I have done for you." This moral claim refers to the kindness with which Abimelech had treated Abraham, which he now expects Abraham to repay. Instead of banishing Abraham in anger for the wife-sister scandal (as Pharaoh did), Abimelech offered him riches and permanent residency in Gerar. The term חסד ("kindness") was the phrase Abraham used when he had asked Sarah to pretend she was his sister (20:13). Abimelech repaid this dubious "kindness" with true kindness. There is no acceptable response to the moral demand other than "I swear it" (24).¹⁵

Had the narrative then proceeded to Abraham's oath, the conclusion and message of the narrative would have been as follows: although God is with Abraham in everything that he does, Abimelech has the moral upper hand; Abraham's commitment toward Abimelech is the reason he agrees to the treaty. To negate this conclusion, vs. 25–26 cause the reader to rethink the relationship between Abraham and Abimelech. Before Abraham actually takes the oath, the dispute over the wells emerges. Here the relationship is reversed: apparently Abimelech's servants stole Abraham's wells,¹⁶ but Abraham decided to

to Abraham in the form of land and riches, Isaac's Abimelech can only say he "sent you away in peace."

15 The relationship between "אני" and "אנכי" has received much scholarly attention. It is generally agreed that the word "אנכי" emphasizes the speaker more, while "אני" is usually used in certain phrases (see more regarding this issue in: Giesebrecht 1881; Driver 1882; Cassuto 1990, 101–04; HALOT 1:72; BDB, 59). Bin Nun (1996, 115–116) wrote that the form אנכי (instead of אני – both denoting "I") is integrated in contexts where the speaker has difficulty expressing himself, or is ambivalent about his own actions. If his assumption is correct, Abraham's אנכי is appropriate in this context, since he cannot act entirely according to his own free will; Abimelech's kindness obligates him.

16 The rabbis interpreted the verb גזל ("to seize") as "taking something by force," in contrast with גנב ("to steal"), which "emphasizes stealth" (Domeris, גזל;

keep silent until Abimelech expressed interest in a treaty, and reminded Abraham of his old debt. Abimelech cannot come up with satisfactory reasons or shed his responsibility for the actions of his servants. Nonetheless, Abraham “took sheep and oxen and gave them to Abimelech” (27). The conclusion of our analysis of ch. 20 referred to the links between the well narrative and the Gerar narrative. There, we noted the role reversal in each of the scenes: the wrongdoer in the first scene (Abraham) became the accuser in the second scene, while the accuser in the Gerar narrative (Abimelech) became the wrongdoer in the well narrative.¹⁷ Abimelech’s accusation in the first episode (20:10: “what have you done to us?”) becomes his defense in the second (21:26: “I do not know who did this”). Abimelech reprimands Abraham: “what was your purpose (מה ראית – literally: ‘what did you see’) in doing this thing?” and later defends himself: “nor have I heard (לא שמעתי).”¹⁸

The integration of the conflict into the narrative is essential to prevent the impression that Abraham commits to a treaty because of Abimelech’s moral superiority following the sister-wife narrative. This conclusion is reassessed and sublimated: the interchangeable roles demonstrate that Abimelech, too, stammers when faced with an ethical grievance, while Abraham knows how to offer generous gifts to one who brought him harm.

After the grievance is resolved, Abraham and Abimelech come to an agreement. While Abraham’s commitment was previously described as his willingness to take an oath, the final agreement takes a different tone: “and the two of them made a pact” (27). The verse implies a

b. Bava Kamma 79b; see also the Amoraic dispute regarding an armed robber on 57a). Milgrom (1976, 91) claimed that the opposite emerges from the text, and גל seems to indicate stealing in secret.

17 See Grossman 2004, 487–90. Wenham (1994, 90) suggested the following structure: “The tale itself consists of one scene (vs. 22–33) made up of three speeches by Abimelech, Abraham’s responses, and some short concluding comments.” However, in the well scene Abraham is the speaker and Abimelech responds, which is significant in understanding the interchangeable roles in the scene.

18 The verbs “to see” and “to know” are almost synonymous in the biblical narrative (Seeligman 1992, 153; Zakovitch 1998, 17).

mutual commitment rather than a one-sided oath.¹⁹ This discrepancy is even more apparent in the etymological conclusion of the narrative: “Hence that place was called Beer-sheba, for there *the two of them* swore an oath” (21:31). Perhaps the emphasis of this equal standing is the reason for the repetition of Abraham and Abimelech’s names an identical number of times in the text, as Sarna noted. Abimelech no longer has the moral upper hand; the treaty is made between equals.

The narrative could easily have ended here, when another surprising element is mentioned: the seven ewes that Abraham had separated from the others (21:28). The text is vague regarding whether the ewes are part of Abraham’s original gift to Abimelech or a separate parting gift. The text indicates that the ewes should be viewed as one detail of the general gift Abraham offered Abimelech: a definite article precedes the mention of the cattle (אֵת שֶׁבַע כְּבָשֹׁתַי הַצֹּאן – “*the seven ewes*”), indicating that these were previously mentioned.²⁰ Additionally, the text omits a repetition of the verb “Abraham took” before Abraham sets the ewes aside, implying that they were present.²¹

This writing style is clarified in light of the previously mentioned link between the dispute over the well and the sister-wife episode. There, too, Abimelech had offered Abraham cattle (and more), and there, too, Abimelech’s gifts were to be “evidence” of sorts: the 1000 pieces of silver were to serve as proof that Sarah and Abraham are married, just as the seven ewes were to serve as proof of Abraham’s ownership of the well. The gifts serve a dual purpose: they are proof

19 Therefore, the assertion that v. 27 is a direct continuation of v. 24 (e.g., Westermann 1995, 348) contradicts the primary purpose of the narrative. V. 27 indicates the change that Abraham’s commitment underwent since his suggestion in v. 24.

20 Even Westermann, who believed v. 27 is not attributed to the same source as v. 28, admits that v. 28 refers to v. 27 (1985, 349).

21 Wenham (1994, 93) claimed that the definite article before the cattle refers to the author’s future comment; Abraham’s clarification in the next verse that Abimelech should take “the cattle” proves that he is not referring to cattle that were already taken by Abimelech. However, the following verse could also be read as a detail of the previous generalization: Abimelech specifically takes the cattle at this point.

of Abraham's generosity despite the injustice of Abimelech's actions, but also proof of Abraham's ownership of the well, paralleling the purpose of the silver in the Gerar narrative. The giving of cattle is repeated twice to emphasize the dual role of the gift.

Abraham's generosity is highlighted when one considers the prevalent Hittite law regarding concealment of an ownership mark on a lost sheep:²²

If anyone finds a ram and removes the brand,²³ [if] its owner traces it out, he shall give seven sheep; he shall give [specifically] two ewes, three rams, [and] two lambs and he shall pledge his estate as security.²⁴

If this law reflects the accepted norms of the time, the one expected to give "seven ewes" is the offender who took possession of stolen property.²⁵ Here, Abraham offers seven ewes to the offender who had stolen his wells. Abraham thus reciprocates Abimelech's kindness, and the two characters carry equal weight on the reader's moral scale.

The concluding verses (31–34) are also clarified on the basis of the newfound reciprocity between the two characters. As mentioned above, the narrator emphasizes that the location was named Beer-sheba "for there *the two of them* swore an oath." The narrative opened with Abimelech's demand that Abraham will swear an oath, and Abraham agreed (23–24). The process described above led to the desired conclusion

22 This law does not relate to common theft (which according to section 59 of Hittite law obligates the thief to pay the sum of 15 sheep), only to indirect theft – finding a ram and removing the owner's identification sign.

23 Singer (2009, 147) and Malul (2000, 242) translated: "if one should find and purify a ram." Hoffner believed the ram was castrated; see Singer, *ibid.* 150; Malul *ibid.* 242, note 89.

24 Section 62, based on translation by ANET, 192. The conclusion of the law is unclear; see Hoffner 1997, 168–69; Malul 2000, 229, note 9. This is a common signature in Hittite laws, which might signify: "it is the right of the harmed party or the people of his household to demand compensation from the household of the offender" (Singer 2009, 130).

25 Similar to Prov 6:30–31: "A thief is not held in contempt for stealing to appease his hunger; Yet if caught he must pay sevenfold; he must give up all he owns." The Septuagint has David respond to Nathan regarding the sin of stealing the sheep from the poor: "he must pay sevenfold."

of a reciprocal oath between equals. This conclusion could only be reached by integrating the dispute over the well into the treaty process. The “pact” is mentioned twice, in vs. 27 and 32, both in the plural to emphasize the reciprocity between the two parties. The concluding verses note that both Abimelech and Abraham returned to the land of the Philistines, and that Abraham remained there “a long time.” Abimelech originally requested a treaty of friendship on the basis of his kind offer of land; Abraham’s ultimate acceptance of Abimelech’s offer indicates the close bond between them.

The return of Abimelech and the chief of his troops to the land of the Philistines (32) is a classic conclusion to a short story;²⁶ however, since the text did not previously mention that Abimelech and Phicol had come to Abraham, there is no need to mention their return home. Perhaps the purpose of this information is to emphasize the distinction between Abimelech and Phicol, who return to the land of the Philistines, and Abraham, who “planted a tamarisk at Beer-sheba.”²⁷ As Hamilton noted, “They leave, but Abraham remains.”²⁸

Abimelech’s acceptance of Abraham’s rights to the land creates a border by Beer-sheba between Abraham and the King of Gerar. This border is a major contribution to the development of the sequence of the implementation of God’s promises to Abraham. As a result, Abraham plants a tamarisk and “invokes the name of the Lord” (33).

The tamarisk is mentioned in two other biblical narratives: “When Saul heard that David and the men with him had been located – Saul was then in Gibeah, sitting under the tamarisk tree on the height, spear in hand, with all his courtiers in attendance upon him” (1 Sam 22:6); and: “Then they took the bones and buried them under the tamarisk

26 Bar-Efrat 1989, 131.

27 V. 33 the verb is not attributed to a specific subject: “he planted a tamarisk is Beer-sheba.” The subject is indisputably Abraham, despite the fact that the last mention of Abraham was in v. 30 (this is congruent with the documentary hypothesis, which links 30 and 33 to the same source and reads them consecutively). Ancient translations (Septuagint, Pshitta, vulgate) integrated the subject, “Abraham,” into the sentence, probably for clarification, not as an indication of another version. See Sarna 1989, 22.

28 Hamilton 1995, 93.

tree in Jabesh, and they fasted for seven days” (1 Sam 31:13).²⁹ One might ascertain from the two verses about Saul that “The tamarisk was a tall distinctive tree which provided plenty of shade.”³⁰ In light of this, it is conceivable to posit that although Abraham protects his own and reclaims his stolen wells, he is ultimately interested in the good of others, and plants a tree alongside his wells to benefit passers-by.³¹

Indian emperor Ashoka the Great (ruled 273–232 BCE) carved inscriptions of Buddhist wisdom on pillars and rocks throughout his empire, for the purpose of educating the people in Buddhist ways. One inscription described the deeds of the king:

Along roads I have had banyan trees³² planted so that they can give shade to animals and men, and I have had mango groves planted at intervals of eight krosas, I have had wells dug, rest-houses built, and in various places, I have had watering-places made for the use of animals and men. But these are but minor achievements. Such things to make the people happy have been done by former kings.³³

Despite the many centuries separating Ashoka from Abraham, the needs of travelers for water wells and the shade of trees did not change much. In addition to claiming the wells that he had created, Abraham plants shade trees to enable his own herdsmen – and perhaps other passers-by as well – to have respite from the hot sun.

However, the planting of the tree specifically in the context of the pact with Abimelech remains unclear. Some noted that Abraham’s journey through Canaan consistently relates to trees.³⁴ Abraham’s first stop was in the terebinth of Moreh (12:6); later, Abraham built an altar near the terebinths of Mamre (14:13), where he was visited by

29 The parallel description in 1 Chr 10:12 reads: “all their stalwart men set out, removed the bodies of Saul and his sons, and brought them to Jabesh. They buried the bones under the oak tree in Jabesh, and they fasted for seven days.”

30 Zohary 1982, 115.

31 See also Bar 2010.

32 The translator added in a footnote: “this is the ficus of Ngalesis – a tree with a broad and extensive top.”

33 Edicts of Ashoka, Rock Edict Nb7.

34 Among others, Wenham 1994, 94; Hamilton 1995, 93; Mathews 2005, 282.

the angels (18:1); Abraham invited the angels to “recline under the tree” (18:4), and later served them “under the tree” (18:8).³⁵ But this is the first time Abraham plants a new tree. The tree is symbolic of a new future; instead of Abraham’s previous reliance on existing trees, Abraham creates and contributes something of his own. Additionally, the type of tree stands out,³⁶ since this is the first mention of a tamarisk in the Abraham cycle.³⁷ Nahum Sarna compared planting the tree to building an altar in other narratives, and added that the tree was the foundation of the later temple of Beer-sheba.³⁸ Sarna’s position is well based in the text, since when Abraham builds an altar he invokes the name of God (12:8; 13:4; Isaac in 26:25), and here Abraham invoked the name of God when he planted the tree. The broad concentric structure of the Abraham cycle (as described in the introduction) also presents invocation of God’s name alongside the tamarisk in parallel to the invocation of God’s name alongside the building of the altars in 12–13. However, the link between the altars and the tree also highlights the fact that Abraham did not build an altar in Beer-sheba, and that the tree was a replacement of the usual altar rather than an addition to it.

The main significance of the event, as noted earlier, was the fact that Abimelech wished to make a treaty with Abraham, expressing the acceptance of Abraham’s position by the nations of the land: “the kings make treaties with him in recognition of his greatness.”³⁹ Creating a pact indicates the realization that Abraham is not a nomad

35 Sarna (1989, 71) noted that the word tree is designated by a definite article (הָעֵץ), in reference to a specific and well-known oak in the terebinths of Mamre.

36 Hamilton (1995, 93, note 28) noted the possibility of a deliberate link between tamarisk and the Akkadian word *ašlu* (“rope”) and in the biblical context (as well as texts found in Nuzi) can also denote “region” or “estate.” The Septuagint and Vulgate translate accordingly.

37 Assuming this is the correct reading. Gunkel (1997, 233) raised the possibility that the original text read Asherah, and the word was changed to prevent idolatrous connotations. Whether the tamarisk is a correction or not, there is significance to the deviation from Abraham’s oak.

38 Sarna 1989 – Genesis 21:33, 21.

39 R. Joseph Bekhor Shor, commentary on Gen 21:33.

who will eventually abandon the area. Abimelech asked that Abraham take an oath in the name of God, that he will not lie to him and to the three generations that follow (21:23). The perspective of time signifies that Abimelech is aware of Abraham's permanency on the land. Planting a new tree appropriately signifies Abraham's confidence that he will enjoy the fruits (or shade) of the tree in years to come. The tree is symbolic of Abraham's permanence in Canaan. Subsequently, Abraham invokes the name אֵל עוֹלָם ("El Olam" – "Everlasting God").⁴⁰ The phrase can be found in Canaanite culture, signifying that El – the private name of the Canaanite God – is everlasting.⁴¹ However, Abraham invoked God with a new name, "the everlasting God."⁴²

This divine appellation is also in dialogue with the specific kind of tree Abraham planted – a tamarisk. Many commented that one of the tamarisk's distinguishing characteristics is its long life span,⁴³ and its perennial quality symbolizes eternity and perpetual renewal.⁴⁴ In a certain sense, planting a tamarisk also suggests permanent residence in the land, even more than the erection of an altar. Unlike Parrot's formulation that "Isaac built an altar at Beersheba (Gen 26:25), at the place where Abraham had *only* planted a tamarisk tree,"⁴⁵ this planting should not be considered inferior or preliminary to the building of an altar. In context of the promise of the land, the tree stands for eternal blessing.

40 Gen 21:33. אֵל עוֹלָם denotes "a long time" in Ugaritic as well. See Tomasino, עוֹלָם. Von Rad (1963, 232) objected to the common translation for אֵל עוֹלָם ("eternal"/"ewig") – since the biblical term denotes "forever," but not in the sense of "beyond time." therefore, von Rad translated: "des Gottes der Urzeit an" (*Das erste Buch Mose: Genesis*, Göttingen: Vandenhoeck und Ruprecht, 1958, 201–02).

41 E.g., Cross 1962, 236–41; Cross 1973, 47–48. In contrast, see Wenham 1980.

42 A similar phenomenon was discussed in relation to Gen 14:22.

43 Stigers claimed that because of this quality, its planting in the narrative symbolizes the perpetual need to recall God's kindness with humanity (Stigers 1976, 187).

44 Davidson 1979, 90; Kiel 2000, 209 (He holds that the tamarisk symbolizes the ongoing covenant between Abraham and Abimelech). See also Weissbluth 1990.

45 Parrot 1968, 111, n.4 (*italics mine*).

Once Abraham's position is recognized by the kings of the land, Abraham looks to the everlasting quality of God, the giver of his land, who serves as a permanent assurance that Abraham's offspring will inherit the land: "In other words, after so many delays, the promises of land and descendants at last seem on their way to fulfillment."⁴⁶

46 Wenham 1994, 94.

Chapter 16: The Binding of Isaac (22)

Introduction I: Did Abraham Pass the Test?

The binding of Isaac has been discussed broadly from a variety of perspectives throughout the generations, as Greenstein noted: “No narrative in the Hebrew Bible has evoked so many readings, and so many passionate ones, as the ‘masterpiece’ known to Christians as the sacrifice of Isaac and to Jews as the binding of Isaac or *Akedah*.”¹ One particularly significant introductory question is whether or not Abraham passed the test to his faith. This issue was debated on both the moral-philosophical plane and the historical-literary plane. Emmanuel Kant is a prominent representative of the position that undermined the common conception of Abraham faithfully withstanding God’s test. Kant’s ethical philosophy was based on the values of freedom and personal autonomy. Kant wrote in the *Conflict of the Faculties*:

For if God should really speak to man, man could still never know that it was God speaking. It is quite impossible for man to apprehend the infinite by his senses, distinguish it from sensible beings, and recognize it as such. But in some cases man can be sure that the voice he hears is not God’s; for if the voice commands him to do something contrary to the moral law, then no matter how majestic the apparition may be, and no matter how it may seem to surpass the whole of nature, he must consider it an illusion.²

1 Greenstein 2012, 102.

2 Kant 1979, 115. Kant repeats this principle several times throughout his work. He wrote in *Religion Within the Limits of Reason Alone* (1960, 171): “After all, the revelation has reached the inquisitor only through men and has been interpreted by men, and even did it appear to have come to him from God himself (like the command delivered to Abraham to slaughter his own son like a sheep) it is at least possible that in this instance a mistake has prevailed.”

He related this matter specifically to the binding of Isaac:

We can use, as an example, the myth of the sacrifice that Abraham was going to make by butchering and burning his only son at God's command (the poor child, without knowing it, even brought the wood for the fire). Abraham should have replied to this supposedly divine voice: "that I ought not to kill my good son is quite certain. But that you, this apparition, are God – of that I am not certain, and never can be, not even if this voice rings down to me from heaven."³

Assuming that revelation will by nature always be debatable, Kant concluded that morality takes precedence over revelation; therefore, Abraham should have rejected the voice that ordered him to sacrifice his son with the claim that it is not the voice of God. Kant's position is based on two assumptions: the morality of God and the questionability of His revelation to man.⁴ According to this approach, Abraham should have objected, or at least argued against God's command. The fact that Abraham was willing to sacrifice his son – a norm that is considered an "abhorrent act that the Lord detests" (Deut 12:31) according to biblical standards – demonstrates an immature relationship with God, and a moral and spiritual failure.

The second approach, which relates to the narrative sequence, is based on an analysis of the text. Boehm's extreme position is a meaningful introduction of the broader discussion below. Boehm believes the binding narrative is the result of intervention by a late redactor; the original narrative included no revelation – not initially (11–12), and not "a second time" (15–18). His position is based mainly on the interchangeable names for God in the narrative; the two revelations

3 Kant 1979, 115. On the rational theory, which, according to Kant, should prevail over biblical theology in the binding narrative, see Levenson 1998, 260–62.

4 Maimonides proved the certainty of revelation from the binding narrative; he claimed that Abraham would not have gone to sacrifice his son had he not been certain that God had indeed spoken with him (Guide to the Perplexed III: 26). Rabbinic literature alludes to the dilemma with a story of the devil, who attempts to plant uncertainty in Abraham's mind regarding the revelation. See Tanhuma on Gen 22.

utilized the name YHWH, while most of the narrative makes use of the name Elohim:

In the original account Abraham actually disobeyed the divine command to slay his son, sacrificing the ram “instead of his son” (v. 13) on his own responsibility. This interpretation thus brings together the textual and narrator understandings of the text, explaining the reason for the later redaction of this story: anxious to conceal Abraham’s disobedience, a later redactor interpolated the figure of the angel, thereby shifting responsibility for interrupting the test from Abraham to the angel.⁵

According to Boehm, Abraham’s failure (in the “original account”) was his inability to slaughter his son, and finding a last-minute replacement in the form of a ram. This approach describes a reverse failure from the position presented above: while Kant believed Abraham failed by adhering to the command, Boehm claimed that Abraham failed by backing out.

Despite the essential differences between the two approaches, they both make the same methodical error of excessive interference by the reader. A reader can only decipher the existing text; while Gadmar and others correctly assert that the reader’s perception of the narrative is influenced by culture and personality, an honest reading of the text takes it at face value, instead of bending it to the reader’s worldview. Kant undermined the meaning of the text, while Boehm subverted its existence; these challenges enabled them to reach the conclusion that Abraham failed the test of the binding. The design of the narrative indicates that Abraham passed the test (“For now I know that you fear God” – 22:12), and is commended by God for his actions; therefore, there is no justification for the omission of the initial revelation (11–12) from the narrative sequence. Abraham is portrayed as one who has proven his fear of God through great difficulty, and has merited God’s blessing as a result.

Nonetheless, the position that views Abraham’s actions as a moral failure is understandable. The binding narrative stands out in the Abraham cycle; until this point Abraham was portrayed as a highly

5 Boehm 2007, 23; see also Boehm 2002.

moral character, who is particularly concerned with the good of others (saving Lot [14]; hospitality [18]; etc.); the text in fact indicates that Abraham was selected because of those qualities: “For I have singled him out, that he may instruct his children and his posterity to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is charitable and just” (18:19). The ethical worldview that was developed and encouraged by the book of Genesis up to ch. 22 is suddenly shattered. The previously mentioned verses about Canaanite customs are particularly jarring in this context: “When the Lord your God has cut down before you the nations that you are about to enter and dispossess, and you have dispossessed them and settled in their land beware of being lured into their ways after they have been wiped out before you! Do not inquire about their gods, saying, ‘How did those nations worship their gods? I too will follow those practices.’ You shall not act thus toward the Lord your God, for they perform for their gods every abhorrent act that the Lord detests; they even offer up their sons and daughters in fire to their gods” (Deut 12:30–32). The custom of sacrificing children is idolatrous, and detested by God. These verses clarify Kant’s claim that Abraham should have refused God’s command, since the God of Abraham would never ask him to sacrifice his son. Perhaps the test to Abraham’s faith was the internalization that despite the human desire represented by idol-worshippers to sacrifice that which is most precious to one’s god, the God of Abraham is not worshipped in a way that contradicts natural morality.

However, this understanding does not justify Kant’s reading. Since Abraham is portrayed in the narrative as withstanding the test, Kant’s question should address the text itself: why is Abraham, in the final narrative of the story cycle, to act in a way that defies the very premise of his selection, as well as the underlying assumptions of biblical ethics? Conversely, Boehm’s reading adds a true challenge to the analysis of the text: what accounts for the sudden change and possibility of a replacement for Isaac? Does the possibility not indicate that Abraham could have offered a replacement from the outset?

Introduction II: The Binding Narrative in Context

The purpose of the binding narrative can be determined without taking context into account. Nonetheless, the caption places the narrative firmly within the concrete context: “Some time afterward” (22:1).⁶ However, the specific context remains vague, since the narrative follows two different stories. R. Samuel ben Meir read the binding narrative in the context of Abraham’s relationship with Abimelech (21:22–34).⁷ But the pact between Abraham and Abimelech is only the conclusion of the elaborate narratives concerning the birth of Isaac and the expulsion of Ishmael (21:1–21), while the binding narrative opens *אחר הדברים האלה* – literally, “after these events.” Coats wrote: “The context of the unit is important. It stands as a complement to the sacrifice of Ishmael that Abraham made in ch. 21.”⁸

From a literary perspective both readings are acceptable due to a number of grammatical and thematic links between the binding narrative and the Abimelech pact on the one hand, and the expulsion of Ishmael on the other. The treaty scene concludes the relationship

6 Contra Jon Levenson who believes that “‘some time afterward’ announces the onset of a new narrative, temporally disconnected from one that directly precedes it.” (Levenson 2012, 67). The purpose of the caption might be to emphasize the difficulty of the test: “after overcoming many difficulties, and removing all of the false heirs such as Lot, Eliezer, and Ishmael, the appearance of the true heir brings with it an anticipation that things will develop normally from this point forward...and then disaster strikes: Isaac, for whom we have waited for so many years, will be taken from us...this is the significance of ‘some time afterwards’” (Emanueli 1978, 296). However, the link between the two narratives is reinforced by other details as well, which encourage a broader comparison between the texts.

7 This suggestion was analyzed at length by Japhet (1994). Regarding R. Samuel ben Meir’s influence on other commentators (such as R. Aaron b. Yossi Hachen; R. Hezekiah ben Manoah (Hizkuni); the Tosafists), see p. 363. Some modern commentators objected to R. Samuel ben Meir’s reading of the text (Rosin 1880, 109; Melamed 1975, 455; Kamin 1986, 270), while others agreed (Japhet 1994, 365–66; Bin Nun 2003, 104–13).

8 Coats 1983, 158.

between Abraham and Abimelech; therefore, Bin-Nun believed the binding narrative should be read in the context of both conflicts with Abimelech (over the sister-wife in 20 and the well in 21).⁹ The debate over whether Gerar was “God-fearing” (20:11) is particularly relevant, since it was Abraham’s concern that Gerar lacked this quality that led him to deceive the people by presenting Sarah as his sister. The conclusion of the binding narrative reveals that the purpose of the test was to determine whether Abraham was “God-fearing” (22:12). Apart from this detail, no obvious significant thematic links exist, other than the general theme that links all episodes in the Abraham cycle – succession and inheritance. (See below in regard to the separation from a family member, which is common to both narratives). Nonetheless, the linguistic fabric of both narratives reinforces the assumption that the binding narrative should be read with the Abraham–Abimelech relationship in mind. Abimelech rose early in the morning as a result of his dream-revelation (20:8) and Abraham rose early as a result of his revelation (22:3). Abimelech reprimanded Abraham: “what was your purpose in doing this?” (20:10) and the angel encouraged Abraham in the binding narrative: “Because you have done this... (עשית זאת)” (22:16). God told Abimelech: “I *knew* (ידעתי) that you did this with a blameless heart, and so I *kept you* (נאחזשך) from sinning against Me” (20:6), and the angel who prevented Abraham from harming Isaac told Abraham: “For now I *know* that you fear God, since you *have not withheld* (לא תשכת) your son, your favored one, from Me” (22:12). In the conclusion of the second Abraham–Abimelech episode the two parties swore an oath to each other (21:24 and 31), and at the conclusion of the binding narrative God swore to Abraham (22:16). Additionally, both narratives serve an etymological purpose: the location of the Abraham–Abimelech episode was called Beer-sheba in commemoration of the oath, and the location of the binding was called Adonai-yireh to commemorate Abraham’s vision.¹⁰

9 Bin-Nun 2003, 104–13.

10 Bin-Nun (2003, 107) added two other (less convincing) links: the similar sentence structure and use of the words וישלח (“sent”) and ויקח (“took”) in 20:2

In the analysis of ch. 20 we concluded that the narrative seems to position Abimelech as a possible alternative for the selection of Abraham. Abraham deliberately deceived Abimelech, while the latter claimed to be moral and God-fearing, and proved to be kind toward Abraham despite the hardship he had brought upon his kingdom. While the second Abraham–Abimelech episode mitigated the criticism of Abraham and the praise to Abimelech, and placed them on equal grounds, the binding narrative is absolute confirmation of the strength of Abraham’s faith, and the fact that he certainly deserves the blessings reserved for him.

In addition to the Abraham–Abimelech analogy, the narrative compares Sarah with Isaac. Based on the grammatical analogy between the two narratives, an additional theme emerges: two situations in which Abraham is forced to give up on his family. He is separated from Sarah in Gerar (20), and later from Isaac (22). This theme might be expanded to include the expulsion of Ishmael, where Abraham is forced to part with another beloved son.

The links between the binding narrative and the expulsion of Ishmael are broadly discussed in rabbinic literature, by early exegetes and by modern commentators and scholars.¹¹ Here the narratives share not only a common grammatical fabric, but a similar narrative development. Wenham introduced his analogy with the following statement: “In content and outline, the stories in chs. 21 and 22 run parallel, with Abraham in a role like Hagar’s, and Isaac like Ishmael.”¹² Wenham proceeded to track the parallel development of the two narratives:

- God commands the expulsion of Ishmael (21:12–13); God commands the sacrifice of Isaac (22:2).
- Water and bread is prepared for the journey (21:12–13); sacrificial materials are prepared for the journey (22:3).

and 22:10; and the phrases הֵנָּה – הֵנָּךְ (“you are” – “here I am”) followed by the verb לקחת – קח (“you have taken” – “take”) in 20:3 and 22:1–2).

11 Regarding this analogy, see, among others, Schwantes 1992; Leviant 1997; Mirguet 2003; Simon 2003; Naumann 2007.

12 Wenham 1994, 99.

- Hagar and her son travel together (21:14); Abraham and his son travel together (22:4–8).
- Ishmael faces death (21:16); Isaac faces death (22:10).¹³
- God’s angel appears to Hagar “from the heavens” (21:17); God’s angel appears to Abraham “from the heavens” (22:11).
- God opens Hagar’s eyes and she sees a well (21:19); Abraham opens his eyes and sees a ram (22:13).
- Hagar gives her son water to drink, returning him to life (21:19); Abraham sacrifices the ram instead of his son, giving him his life (22:14).

In addition to the similar development of the two plots, a variety of grammatical links reinforce the analogy. The appearance of the angel in both narratives is described in almost identical terms: “*An angel of God called to Hagar from heaven and said to her, “What troubles you, Hagar? Fear not, for God has heeded the cry of the boy where he is. Come, lift up the boy and hold him by the hand, for I will make a great nation of him”* (21:17–18); and “*An angel of the Lord called to him from heaven...*” Do not raise your hand against the boy, or do anything to him...I will bestow My blessing upon you and *make your descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven* and the sands on the seashore...” (22:11–17). As a result of the revelation, “*God opened her eyes and she saw a well of water. She went and filled the skin with water, and let the boy drink*” (21:19); after Abraham’s revelation, “*Abraham looked up; his eye fell upon a ram, caught in the thicket by its horns. So Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering in place of his son*” (22:13). In both narratives Abraham’s son is referred to as a “boy” (21:12, 17, 18, 19; 22:5 and 12); Abraham rises early in the morning (21:14; 22:3); and his son is promised to “inherit” (21:10; 22:17). The pair of verbs רָאָה (“to see”) and יָרָא (“to fear”) are key words throughout the two narratives (21:9, 16, 17, 19; 22:2 [“Moriah”], 4, 8, 13, 14).¹⁴

13 While Hagar “casts away” Ishmael and leaves him to die under “one of the bushes” (21:15), Isaac initially carries the wood on his back (22:6) and later the wood is placed “on the altar on top of the wood” (22:9).

14 Wenham (1994, 100) noted that the verb “to see” is more prominent in the narrative about Hagar’s flight (16) than her expulsion (21). In the flight narrative

Various interpretations were offered for this analogy. Some attributed a divine “test” to Hagar’s story, and viewed her as another role model of faith in God.¹⁵ This position does not withstand the implicit and explicit criticism of Hagar in the expulsion narrative, as noted in the analysis of ch. 21. The analogy seems not to compare two different characters, but rather to create a sequence of two separations that were forced on Abraham: first he was forced to drive away his firstborn son, and later to separate from his youngest child. Abraham was distressed by the idea of the expulsion; he reluctantly sent Ishmael away as a result of God’s revelation. Both separations nearly resulted in death, but in both cases the intervention of the angel brought Abraham’s sons back to life. The main purpose of the expulsion narrative was the rebirth of Ishmael outside the house of Abraham. A similar idea might emerge from the binding narrative: Isaac, too, is given the gift of life through the angel’s intervention. In this context, the plots stray from the analogy: while Ishmael was reborn and given to his mother (who finds him an Egyptian wife from her homeland), Isaac is reborn and given to Abraham (who will find him a wife from his homeland). However, the analogy is incomplete; while Hagar and Ishmael journey on together, after the binding episode Abraham returns to his servants quite alone, on a literary-textual level. Isaac’s conspicuous absence might indicate that his rebirth on the mountain that God had selected ultimately left him in a permanent state of commitment to God. While Ishmael was reborn in the desert, under a bush, and subsequently made his life in the desert, Isaac was reborn on a wooden altar in the land of Moriah.

the place was named for her sight – Beer-lahai-**roi**; this is paralleled in Abraham’s naming of mount Moriah – Adonai-*yireh*.

15 Ararat 1986.

Introduction III: The Land of Moriah

The Chronicler identifies the Temple Mount as the mountain of Moriah: “Then Solomon began to build the House of the Lord in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah” (2 Chr 3:1). This reading is ratified by Abraham’s naming of the mountain: “And Abraham named that site Adonai-yireh, whence the present saying, ‘On the mount of the Lord there is vision’” (22:14). A simple reading would link a place in which God is “seen” and where people are “seen before Him” to Jerusalem.¹⁶ The “land of Moriah” in Genesis is therefore commonly believed to be Jerusalem.¹⁷

Some scholars, however, objected to this identification. Sarna noted that Jerusalem is not a three-day walk from Beer-sheba;¹⁸ moreover, why would Abraham carry wood on his back on a journey through the Judean hills? The need to take wood indicates that Abraham traveled south and was unsure whether appropriate trees would be available.¹⁹ Yaira Amit added, “if the purpose of the narrative was to sanctify Jerusalem, the obvious question is why Abraham did not name the place appropriately,” and instead offered another name: Adonai-yireh.²⁰ Glueck wrote similarly, and suggested Mount Sinai as a better option for the binding:

It would not have been necessary to Abraham for days on end to drag a supply of kindling with him for the altar fire had his mission been to the wooded hills of Judah. God’s revelation, which is a free translation of what Moriah means, is

16 See in particular: Cassuto 1979, 93–95; Loewenstamm, Moriah.

17 See: Jubilees 18:13; Josephus, *Antiquities* I:224 (Feldman 2000, 86 and n. 692). Josephus understood that the command was to go not only to the land of Moriah, but to “Mount Morion”).

18 His claim is unrealistic. Loewenstamm, (Moriah, 459) wrote: “it is noteworthy that one can travel from Beer-sheba to Jerusalem in three days.” Cassuto wrote similarly: “one who travels on foot from Beer-sheba to Jerusalem will, after two days, on the third morning, see the Jerusalem mountains from afar” (Cassuto 1979, 95).

19 Sarna 1966, 159–60; see also: Skinner 1930, 328–29.

20 Amit 2003, 52.

pictured on the contrary as having taken place in the severe and treeless ranges of Sinai. The new horizon glimpsed by Abraham was seen in the loneliness and austerity of the wilderness.²¹

The verse in Chronicles might not be a geographic indication that Mount Moriah is Jerusalem; Mount Moriah is identified with the place God had revealed Himself to David: “Then Solomon began to build the House of the Lord in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, where [the Lord] had appeared to his father David.” Perhaps another link can be made between the location of the binding and the place of David’s revelation.²² The association of Temple Mount with the land of Moriah might place an emphasis on the sanctity and significance of the location, rather than a geographical identification. However, in this case one would expect a direct reference to the binding of Isaac, instead of a general hint at the location.²³ Additionally, Sinai is also referred to as “the mount of the Lord” (22:14) in Num 10:33; the name is not exclusive to the Temple Mount in Jerusalem (Is 2:3; 30:29; Mic 4:2; Zac 8:3; Ps 24:3).

The identification of Moriah with Mount Sinai would reinforce the link between the binding narrative and two other narratives that took place in that location: the revelation at Sinai, which includes grammatical and thematic links to the binding narrative, and Elijah’s escape to Mount Horeb.²⁴ In addition to the significance of

21 Glueck 1959, 63.

22 For a survey of positions on this matter see Kalimi 1997.

23 Some scholars wrongly assumed that the name “Moriah” was inserted into the binding narrative based on the influence of 2 Chr 3:1 (Montgomery 1930, 279; Skinner 1930, 328–29; von Rad 1963, 237–38; Kilian 1970, 31–37; Westermann 1995, 437). Williamson (1982, 205) and Kalimi (1997, 183) stated correctly that the integration of the name “Moriah” is appropriate to the design of the narrative in light of the repetition of the key root מרה throughout the narrative. This idea is supported by the structure suggested by Crotty (2005), who parallels “the land of Moriah” with Abraham’s new name for the mountain, “Adonai-yireh.”

24 Regarding the link between the revelation at Sinai and the binding of Isaac, see Grossman 2003. Regarding the link between the binding narrative and Elijah’s journey to Horeb, see Spiro-Applebaum 2007. Amit (2003, 51–52) wrote:

the identification in relation to the nature of Jerusalem and the sanctification process of the Temple Mount, the issue also affects the purpose of the binding narrative. The new name of the location, Adonai-yireh, is appropriate both for Mount Sinai and Temple Mount; however, if the land of Moriah is Sinai desert, the binding narrative should be read as an introduction to the revelation at Sinai. In this case, the “sight” element is the crux of the narrative, and it is this element that is expanded to become a public revelation on Sinai. The firestone and knife (אש ומאכלת) of the binding become the eating fire (אש אוכלת) at the mountaintop in the Sinai revelation (cf. Gen 22:7 and Ex 24:17). Conversely, if the binding narrative took place in Jerusalem, the narrative is an introduction to Solomon’s Temple and the inauguration of sacrificial custom on Temple Mount. The focus of this reading would be the sacrifice of the ram as a replacement of Isaac, and a sanctification of the altar in Jerusalem by Abraham, through the binding of Isaac.

Despite the importance of this question, the answer remains ambivalent. The significance of the absence of the binding narrative in Kings and the absence of a direct reference in Chronicles is impossible to decipher. The silence might serve a literary purpose, just as Abraham gathering the wood contributes to the design of his character and mood. Nonetheless, the prominence of the expression “the place” leads to the inclination to perceive Jerusalem as the site of the binding, as we will see below. The loneliness that accompanies the narrative does not characterize the geographical location of the narrative but the emotional space of the characters within.

“perhaps Abraham, like Elijah, who also departed from Beer-sheba, travelled in the direction of Horeb, which is referred to as ‘the mountain of Elohim’ and once as ‘the mountain of YHWH.’”

Exposition (1)

The opening verse immediately categorizes the episode as a “test”: “Some time afterward, God put Abraham to the test.” Rabbinic literature categorizes ten Abraham narratives as tests of his faith (m. Avot 5:3), but this is the only narrative that is explicitly defined as such. Some scholars claimed that this introduction softens God’s command from the outset; this is only a test of Abraham’s faith, so Abraham will ultimately not be expected to sacrifice his son. Therefore, instead of concern for Isaac, the reader can concentrate on Abraham. Emanuelli interpreted the purpose of the statement as follows: “Why was this explained? The author is sensitive to the feelings of the reader or hearer. Instead of concern for Isaac’s life, the author plants curiosity in our hearts, regarding whether or not the man will withstand the difficult test.”²⁵

However, Emmanuelli’s analysis is inaccurate. The clarifying caption is unable to mitigate the reader’s concern for Isaac’s life, since the test of Abraham’s faith might actually be the sacrifice of Abraham’s son.²⁶ Defining the event as a test emphasizes another point altogether: God has no need for human sacrifice.²⁷ Even if God had asked Abraham to go through with sacrificing Isaac, it would only have been a test of Abraham’s faith, not a divine need for human sacrifice.²⁸

25 Emanuelli 1978, 296. Similarly, von Rad 1963, 239. Berlin (1983, 102) viewed the caption as a “summary” of the entire narrative.

26 Cf. Amit 2003, 7, note 11.

27 Cf. Fokkelman 1999, 124.

28 Others viewed the caption from a psychological perspective: “the fear and trepidation for the fate of Isaac, who is to be sacrificed by his father, might impact the reader’s mental equilibrium” (Talmon 1965, 31). See also Licht 1973, 21; Sarna 1989, 393; Zakovitch 1985, 86; Tzohar 2005, 50–59.

God's Command (1–2)

God beckons Abraham, and Abraham immediately responds, “here I am.” Abraham’s response expresses utter obedience. The Hebrew term **הִנְנִי** is difficult to translate; some translated “here I am,” as NJPS above,²⁹ and others made do with the generic “yes,”³⁰ while the response expresses so much more than its literal directive. The phrase denotes acquiescence to any command, and indicates absolute compliance and obedience.³¹ The exact meaning of the phrase is particularly significant in the binding narrative, since it is one of the key words in the text.³²

Early exegetes noted the gradation in God’s command: “Take your son, your favored one, whom you love, Isaac.”³³ This design contributes to the magnitude of the test but also clarifies that God knows exactly what he is asking of Abraham.³⁴ God is fully aware of the meaning of the human relationship between Abraham and his only son; God Himself emphasizes Isaac’s uniqueness and Abraham’s love. Nonetheless, God demands that Abraham make this ultimate sacrifice.

Isaac’s sacrifice cannot take place in Beer-sheba or the by the terebinths of Mamreh; Abraham is required to travel to the land of

29 This is the common translation. See, among others, NJPS, NAS, NAU, NIB, NIV, NRS.

30 See Crenshaw 1984, 19; Walters 1987, 301; Hamilton 1995, 97.

31 BDB, 244. Another option, which is farther from the literary meaning, but closer to the definition of the phrase is “ready” (Speiser 1964, 162; NAB).

32 Simon 1973; Emanuelli 1978, 305–06; Zamudi 1997, 163–65; Licht 1973, 116–17; Polak 1999, 230–32; Jacobs 2010, 557–58.

33 The Septuagint reads “your beloved” in place of “the favored one.” This should not be viewed as an alternate version, but rather as an interpretation of **יָחִיד** (translated “favored one” above), which can denote “close,” “preferred,” “beloved,” etc. See Berlin 1978, 38 note 15; Hamilton 1995, 97 note 3. Nonetheless, it would be naive to deny the literal meaning of **יָחִיד** in this context: “singular,” “only one.” Even if Abraham does have another child, Isaac is his “only one” by his wife Sarah.

34 Skinner 1930, 328. See also: McEvenue 1984, 323; Hamilton 1995, 102; Polak 1999, 284; Amit 2003.

Moriah and sacrifice his son there. This demand is linked with the sanctification of the “one place,” which is emphasized throughout Deuteronomy. Additional significance should be given to the journey itself: the journey forces Abraham to accept his decision anew every step of the way.

The command is reminiscent of God’s initial revelation to Abraham, which began the story cycle.³⁵ The link is particularly apparent in the use of the phrase *לך לך* (“go forth”), which appears only in these two biblical narratives.³⁶ In addition to the unique phrase, the structure of the command is identical.³⁷ The initial description is repetitive (12:1: “Go forth from your land and from the place of your birth and from your father’s house” and 22:2: “Take your son, your favored one, whom you love, Isaac”), and the repetition serves as a rhetorical design of an inward spiral. This gradual design is apparent throughout the Abraham cycle, but particularly in the first and final narrative.³⁸ Additionally, the characterization of the destination is similarly vague in both narratives (12:1: “to the land that I will show you” and 22:2: “on one of the heights that I will point out to you”). The implementation also begins similarly (12:4: “Abram went forth as the Lord had commanded him” and 22:3: “he set out for the place of which God had told him”). Lot joined Abraham on his journey to Canaan, and on his journey to Moriah he is accompanied by his son Isaac. As already noted in the introduction, these two units are parallel within the concentric structure of the entire narrative cycle.

35 This link, which is both thematic and grammatical, poses difficulties for the documentary hypothesis, according to which Abraham’s journey to Canaan is attributed to J, while the binding narrative is generally attributed to E. As Avishur wrote: “the substantial and direct link between the two narratives – in descriptive patterns, language, and even conceptual thought – question, and perhaps even contradict, the foundations of the documentary hypothesis” (Avishur 1993, 101). Perhaps for this reason Van Seters (1975, 213–29) attributed the binding narrative to J.

36 Noted by Buber (1997, 293–94) in his discussion on key words.

37 E.g., Sarna 1966, 160–61; Jacob 1974, 143; Avishur 1993; Cotter 2003, 154.

38 Cf. Amit 2003.

This link contributes to the purpose of the narrative on three levels. First, the link of the first and final narratives of the cycle has literary-esthetic value, and the two narratives might be viewed as a literary frame (*inclusio*) for the entire cycle. The first and last tests of Abraham's faith present the reader with the foundation for the selection of Abraham, and his suitability for his designated role: Abraham obeys God even in the most difficult commands. The second level relies upon the first: the final test might be viewed as continuous to the initial command, since the common theme is Abraham's disengagement from his surroundings. Shanks wrote that in the first test Abraham was asked to disengage from his past, while in the final test he was asked to abandon his future.³⁹

The third level, based upon the first two, is the distinction between the two tests. Despite the similarities mentioned above, there is a major gap between the two commands. While God requires Abraham to leave his past behind him, He accompanies the demand with a promise of offspring and multiple blessings (12:2).⁴⁰ The journey toward the unknown promises to be beneficial to Abraham; despite the difficulty of leaving one's past behind, Abraham did so in anticipation of a better future. The disengagement from Abraham's family is comparable with the command to leave his home behind and sacrifice his only son on a deserted hilltop. In addition to the obvious emotional effects, Abraham is expected to sacrifice all that he has worked for: the death of Isaac is not only the death of a beloved son, but also the death of Abraham's hopes and God's promises. The contrast demonstrates the great difficulty of the final test, since this new command undermines the achievements of all the other tests. In this light, the link becomes almost ironic.

A mutual component in both commands requires special attention. As noted above, the exact destination remains unknown to

39 Shanks 1987, 8; similarly, Jacob 1974, 143; Fretheim 1994, 495.

40 Indeed, Tribble stresses that the lack of blessing mentioned in the command to sacrifice his son e the difficulty of this trial in relation to God's first command to Abram to go to Canaan, where the blessings were already incorporated in the command (Tribble 1991, 172).

Abraham when he embarks on his journey “to the land that I will show you”/ “on one of the heights that I will point out to you.” This detail has no direct bearing on the development of either of the plots. In ch. 12 Abraham simply arrives in Canaan, while in the binding narrative Abraham “looked up and saw the place from afar” (4). The initial concealment of the exact destination creates an anticipation that the plot will revolve around this issue, perhaps through an explanation of how Abraham knew he had arrived, or the significance of the discovery of the location. The absence of this theme emphasizes the true purpose of the initial concealment: God will lead the way. Abraham might know where to go, but the place is selected by God.⁴¹ The naming of the mountain in Moriah signifies this concept: Adonai-yireh – The Lord will show (= select the location). The wording links the selected location to the selected sacrifice, as Abraham explains ominously to Isaac: “God will see to the sheep for His burnt offering” (8). Divine selection is metonymic for the choice of Isaac as a sacrifice; there is no questioning God’s selection, as Auerbach wrote:

Just as “early in the morning” serves as a temporal indication, “Jeruel in the land of Moriah” serves as a geographical indication; and in both cases alike, the complementary indication is not given, for we know as little of the hour at which Abraham lifted up his eyes as we do of the place from which he set forth – Jeruel is significant not so much as the goal of an earthly journey, in its geographical relation to other places, as through its special election, through its relation to God, who designated it as the scene of the act, and therefore it must be named.⁴²

41 This undermines Cogan’s suggestion that the absence of the binding narrative from Solomon’s Temple stems from the emphasis that “the location of the Temple was selected by God, not by man. The possibility of a historical site is negated, since it would detract from the Deuteronomistic concept of divine selection” (Cogan 1986, 307). This is indeed a central idea, however, it is already reflected during the binding. See Kalimi 1997, 185.

42 Auerbach 1968, 10.

Abraham's Implementation (3)

Abraham's mouth and heart remain mysteriously sealed throughout the narrative. He neither argues nor expresses emotion, and the text fails to divulge his feelings (as opposed to his distress about Ishmael in 21:12). Instead, the narrative focuses on his intensive activity through a plethora of verbs: arose, saddled, took, split, set out. Replacing speech and emotions with concrete actions preserves the unattainability of Abraham's emotional state, and the "background story," in Auerbach's terminology, remains vague.⁴³

Privileging silence over the attempt to formulate Abraham's unfathomable sorrow in words recalls Michel de Montaigne's essay on sorrow. He writes about an artist who attempted to express the grief of those who watched Iphigenia's sacrifice, and having depicting them with "the utmost power of his art, when he came to that of her father, he drew him with a veil over his face, meaning thereby that no kind of countenance was capable of expressing such a degree of sorrow."⁴⁴ Focusing upon Abraham's intensive activity serves as such a veil, hinting that such emotion cannot be expressed in mere words.

Nonetheless, a careful analysis of the verse might provide a glimpse of Abraham's emotional state. Absolute compliance might not indicate unequivocal identification with God's command; and within the context of compliance one might find hesitation and an attempt to postpone the act. Two different readings were suggested accordingly, both based mainly on v. 3. Some stressed Abraham's haste to implement God's command early in the morning; Rashi wrote:

"Arose early": He hastened to [perform] the commandment.

"He saddled": He himself, and he did not command one of his servants, because love causes a disregard for the standard [of dignified conduct].

43 Auerbach 1968, 12.

44 Montaigne 1580, 34.

“On the third day”: Why did He delay from showing it to him immediately? So that people should not say that He confused him and confounded him suddenly and deranged his mind; if he had had time to think it over, he would not have done it.⁴⁵

The approach is broadly accepted in modern commentary as well. Abraham’s early rising demonstrates his haste; he prepares for the journey himself instead of commanding his servants; he prepares wood in his house instead of delaying until he reaches Moriah;⁴⁶ all of these details design the character of one who does not hesitate to do as he was told.⁴⁷

Nonetheless, others have claimed that the verse describing Abraham embarking on his journey portrays hesitation and an attempt to delay the binding. Jonathan Jacobs noted the literary procrastination which emerges from the comparison of Abraham’s implementation with God’s command:⁴⁸

| <i>Command (2)</i> | <i>Implementation (3)</i> |
|---|---|
| | So Abraham woke early next morning, and saddled his ass |
| <i>Take your son, your favored one, Isaac, whom you love,</i> | and <i>took</i> with him two of his servants and <i>his son Isaac</i> . |
| | He split the wood for the burnt offering, |
| and <i>go forth</i> to the land of Moriah | and he arose, and he <i>set out</i> for the place of which God had told him ⁴⁹ |

45 Rashi on Gen 22:3–4.

46 E.g., Hamilton 1995, 107.

47 Fischer (2007, 175–76) suggested that Abraham purposely rose early to ensure that Sarah was not present when he embarked on his journey.

48 Jacobs 2010.

49 NJPS translated the verse as follows: “So early next morning, Abraham saddled his ass and took with him two of his servants and his son Isaac. He split the wood for the burnt offering, and he set out for the place of which God had told him.”

While Abraham rises early in the morning, the saddling of the ass does not promote the plot and seems like an unnecessary description – as though Abraham is adding tasks to his list in order to delay the implementation of God’s command. While God commands Abraham to “take” Isaac, Abraham “takes” two servants, and only then, almost as an afterthought, he takes his son Isaac as well. God’s emphasis on Isaac’s singularity is contrasted by Abraham taking two servants in addition to his son.⁵⁰ Abraham was not prohibited from taking an entourage along on the journey; however, saddling the ass and taking the servants are actions that stray from the formulation of the commandment. Jacobs added that splitting wood at this point – despite the long journey to the mountains, where presumably trees can be found – is Abraham’s way of delaying the inevitable.⁵¹ Perhaps Abraham had hoped that his willingness to prepare for the journey would suffice, and God would call off the binding; “Abraham broadcasts his message to the heavens: See, I am serious; I’ve taken everyone and I’ve even hewn wood for the sacrifice. Is this not sufficient proof of my willingness to obey God?”⁵²

The text enables both approaches, since each focuses on a different emotional plane. Abraham’s activity indicates that he ultimately succumbs to the will of his master, while the hesitations noted by Jacobs are indicative of his emotional state. The delays and added actions indicate Abraham’s difficulty in fulfilling God’s command, though there is no doubt in his mind that what the Lord has commanded he must obey.

Another distinction emerges from the comparison. While the command focuses on the place (“go forth to the *land of Moriah*, and offer him *there* as a burnt offering on *one of the heights* that *I will point out to you*”), it is Abraham’s actions that are emphasized, and the location briefly hinted at (“he set out for the place of which God had told

50 Alternatively, Trible claimed that Isaac is actually placed in the spotlight in this verse because he is surrounded by six verbs, three on either side: “and he rose early – saddled – took – *his son Isaac* – split – arose – set out.” (Trible 1991, 173–74).

51 On splitting the wood as a delaying tactic see Levenson 1993, 135.

52 Jacobs 2010, 554, note 17. See also Boehm 2007, 41–48.

him”). From the divine perspective, the location is crucial, while in Abraham’s emotional state the horrific action he is required to perform blocks out all other details; the place is insignificant compared with the enormity of what Abraham is expected to do. Once Isaac is out of danger, the place will become significant to Abraham as well, and Abraham will be the one to name the mountain in commemoration of the event.

First Dialogue: Abraham and the Servants (4–5)

The narrator fails to explain how Abraham recognized his destination: “On the third day Abraham looked up and saw the place from afar.” Perhaps he saw the land of Moriah, which was explicitly mentioned in God’s command; according to midrashic texts Abraham saw “a cloud tied at the top of the mountain.” The idea might be based in the analogy mentioned above between the binding narrative and the revelation at Sinai (Ex 24); the rabbis transferred the explicit cloud from Sinai to Abraham’s Moriah.⁵³

Abraham does not speak until this point in the narrative, and his first words address his servants. While the literary purpose of the servants is vague from the outset, Abraham’s longest speech is made to them. Additionally, the conclusion of the narrative involves the servants as well: “Abraham then returned to his servants, and they departed together for Beer-sheba” (19). After Isaac is saved, he is never mentioned again in the narrative, which focuses instead on Abraham’s return to his servants.

The literary purpose of the servants seems to be their absence from the central act.⁵⁴ The initial focus on the servants emphasizes

53 Sasson and Grossman 2007.

54 The emphasis on a minor character in a narrative sometimes serves to highlight the absence of that character later on. On this literary technique see: Grossman 2012.

Abraham and Isaac's separation from them, and enhances the intimacy of the second leg of their journey. The servants represent the mundane, while Abraham and Isaac proceed to do something extraordinary. Abraham distinguishes between the servants ("You stay here with the ass") and himself and Isaac ("The boy and I will go up there"). The linguistic fabric highlights the distinction between the two groups:

| | |
|--|---|
| Then Abraham said to his <i>servants</i>
(נערים),
<i>You stay here</i>
with the ass | The <i>boy</i> (נער) and I

<i>will go up there</i>
we will worship and we will return to
you." |
|--|---|

The "servants" (נערים) are contrasted with the "boy" (נער);⁵⁵ one party "stays," while the other goes "up there." Mathews noted the word-play used to emphasize the distance between those who remain and those who continue on their journey: while the former remain "here" – פה (*po*) the latter proceed "up there" – כה (*kho*).⁵⁶ The servants are designed as a contrast to Abraham and his son, who depart from the mundane reality represented by servants and asses: "Now we hear Abraham say: 'sit here with the ass.' He wants to be alone. Something unique and unforgettable is about to happen up there."⁵⁷ At the end of the story, Abraham returns to the mundane reality represented by his servants. The binding is an isolated incident, disconnected from logical psychological context. The event cannot be explained by any external parameter; any outside view cannot fully comprehend the occurrence. Therefore, reality has to be left behind on the way to the binding.

Abraham fails to reveal the truth of his actions to the servants; instead, he says: "we will worship and we will return to you" (5). Dillmann suggested that "we will return to you" is an expression

55 Cf. Hamilton 1995, 108.

56 Mathews 2005, 292.

57 Emanuelli 1978, 303. Jacob (1974, 495) compared this to the reinstitution of the Sinai covenant after the sin of the Golden Calf. There, too, the "people" and "cattle" were forbidden to approach the mountain (Ex 33:3). He also compared the event to the High Priest entering the Holy of Holies in Lev 16:17.

of Abraham's secret hope that he will somehow return with Isaac.⁵⁸ Although naturally Abraham might have harbored hopes for a better outcome, the text indicates that Abraham knew he would not be returning with his son. The reader can only experience Abraham's words as an inadvertent prophecy,⁵⁹ since at this point both Abraham and the reader expect Isaac to be sacrificed on the altar as a test of Abraham's faith. Abraham simply chose to refrain from telling his servants the truth.⁶⁰ Since the binding was clearly not public knowledge, one must question whether Abraham shared his plan with Isaac – and with Sarah.

Second Dialogue: Abraham and Isaac (6–8)

After leaving the servants and the ass behind, father and son embark on the second part of their journey. The second leg of the journey, like the first, is filled with verbs describing Abraham's actions: "Abraham *took the wood* for the burnt offering and *put it on* his son Isaac. He himself *took the firestone and the knife*; and the two *walked on together*" (6). Here, too, the items that Abraham takes with him are listed in detail.

The new start separates the journey into two parts. The first stage included servants and an ass, while the second is the intimate journey of father and son. Some read Abraham's placement of the wood "on his son Isaac" as an intentional irony, since Isaac will later be put on those same pieces of wood (9). More significantly, placing the wood on Isaac separates "Abraham items" and "Isaac items"; the repetition of the verb "he took" distinguishes Isaac and the wood from Abraham

58 Dillmann 1897, 292; similarly, Gross 1989.

59 Jacob 1974, 144. Cf. Heinemann (1954, 130): "the purpose of Abraham's statement, 'we will worship and we will return to you,' was to conceal his intention from his servants; however, the reader knows that Abraham is correct, and his words therefore receive special significance." See also Wenham 1994, 108–09; Zakovitch 2005, 113–14.

60 E.g., Skinner 1930, 329.

with his knife and firestone. Isaac carries the wood on which he will later be sacrificed; they will be burned together. Abraham carries the knife and firestone; these are his responsibility as the bringer of the sacrifice. At the same time, the wood is not as nightmarish a substance in this context as the knife and firestone, which are killing instruments. Abraham distances his son from the more frightening elements, protecting him in whatever way he could.⁶¹

The firestone, the wood, and the knife contribute to the sequence and advance the plot. When Abraham set out on his journey, he took “his ass and took with him two of his servants and his son Isaac” (22:3). Now that Abraham has disengaged from the servants and the ass, the narrative focuses on smaller items that are not symbolic of the journey but of the impending sacrifice.

The absence of the donkey and servants enables a constructive dialogue that portrays the father–son relationship in an intimate and loving light. Abraham is consistently referred to as Isaac’s “father,” while Abraham addresses Isaac with an endearing “my son” every time he speaks. The familial terms highlight the difficulty and tragedy of Abraham’s test. This is especially apparent in the first line of the dialogue: “Then Isaac said to his father Abraham, ‘Father!’ And he answered, ‘Yes, my son’” (7). This stage, which lacks any content of substance, is rare in the biblical narrative, and has no impact on the remainder of the dialogue. The sole purpose of the opening sentence is the emphasis on the father–son relationship; but Abraham’s response is noteworthy due to his repetitive use of the phrase *הִנְנִי* – “here I am.”⁶² As noted earlier, the phrase expresses absolute compliance; an early agreement to any possible demand. Abraham expresses this compliance toward God, but also toward his son.⁶³ The tension in the narrative reaches its climax: Abraham is not a cold-hearted father who is indifferent to the fate of his son; Abraham’s dual loyalty will force him to choose

61 Compare: Von Rad 1963, 240; Tribble 1991, 175.

62 See Steinmetz 1991, 51–53; Wenham 1994, 101; Buber 1997. The prominence of the word in the narrative led Tucker and Freeman (1990, 27–28) to create a “binding dance” based on the rhythm of the phrase *הִנְנִי* (“here I am”).

63 Note the ironic wordplay between Abraham’s response to his son – *הִנְנִי* (*hineni* – “here I am”) and the son’s question *הֲנֵה הָאֵשׁ* (*hineh ha-esh* – “here is the fire”).

between his God and his son. The Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard developed the idea of Abraham's complete loyalty to his son; he believed that the paradox of faith is expressed by Abraham's love for Isaac, which is only intensified in the binding narrative.⁶⁴

Isaac's question reminds the reader once again of the threatening knife, this time due to its omission. Isaac mentions the wood and the firestone when he asks what it is they are sacrificing (22:7), but he fails to mention the knife. The reader knows that Abraham and Isaac are traveling with a knife; perhaps Isaac's omission in addition to the question itself indicate that he is beginning to suspect the identity of the sacrifice. Isaac's knowledge is crucial to the analysis of the emotional state of the characters in the narrative, but Abraham's response only adds to the ambiguity.

In the initial dialogue, Abraham chose to omit the true destination and purpose of his journey (5). In response to his son's question, Abraham refrains from lying and says: "God will see to the sheep for His burnt offering, my son" (8). Indeed, God will see (= select) that which will be sacrificed.⁶⁵ Abraham's response led to two interpretations of his position. Medieval commentators viewed Abraham's response as having a double meaning, which hints at the bitter truth. R. David Kimhi (Radak) wrote:

He offered him a response that could be understood in two ways; according to one, "my son" addressed the questioner, as in "here I am, my son" (v. 7); in other words, "my son, God will see to the sheep for His burnt offering." He knows the sheep, and he will provide it for us.

Alternately, "God will see to the sheep for His burnt offering," and who is that sheep? It is "my son!" Isaac understood that he would be that sheep; therefore it is written, "And the two of them walked on together."⁶⁶

64 Kierkegaard 1939. See also: Boehm 2007, 101–109.

65 Regarding the verb *ראה* denoting "to select" see Greenstein 2012, 120, note 32. Greenstein noted that the verb "to see" includes both meanings in Akkadian literature as well.

66 R. David Kimhi on Gen 22:8. Rashi and Bekhor Shor suggested a similar interpretation.

Isaac might have understood from Abraham's response that he is the sacrifice; the missing sheep and Abraham's evasive answer, given in a time and place where sacrificing children was not entirely uncommon, might have been sufficient for Isaac to figure it out. However, Radak's claim that Abraham grammatically hinted at the fact is unsatisfactory. Abraham's use of the affectionate term "my son" agrees with the multiplicity of familial terms throughout the dialogue,⁶⁷ preventing the attribution of special attention.

Others claimed that Abraham's response demonstrates his confidence that ultimately a sheep will be sacrificed, and not his son. Frank Polak wrote: "This response can resolve the distinction between God's demand and the love of the son. These things do not only attest to total acceptance of God's command, but also to utter confidence in the fact that 'God will see the sheep for his burnt offering.'"⁶⁸ However, this suggestion ignores the order of the details in the narrative and the building tension toward a solution that the reader is unaware of at this point. When rereading the story one might insert new meaning into Abraham's words, in light of the ram that is ultimately sacrificed;⁶⁹ at this stage, however, neither the reader nor Abraham have any way of knowing that Isaac will not be sacrificed on the altar.⁷⁰

This idea is highly significant in the design of the character of Abraham. When Abraham sets out to sacrifice his son, he is utterly convinced that his son will be sacrificed. The narrative demonstrates

67 See Sarna 1989, 152; Wenham 1994, 108–09.

68 Polak 1999, 285. For an expansion of this approach and its representatives see Greenstein 2012, 121.

69 Don Isaac Abarbanel commented on Gen 22: "the text signifies that anything that was spoken [by Abraham] in passing, even as a deferral for the purpose of keeping the peace, came true, like the words of a man of God who cannot speak falsely." While Polak believed Abraham was expressing his wish, according to Abarbanel Abraham was not aware of the significance of his statement. Cf. Hamilton 1995, 113 (in the context of his commentary on the ram). On Abarbanel's general theory regarding ambiguous phrases, see Grossman 2007 – "Abarbanel Stance."

70 Kierkegaard viewed this as Abraham's greatest quality; particularly the magnitude of his faith. Abraham accepted God's command, but still believed "it is through Isaac that offspring shall be continued for you."

Abraham's great fear of God and complete devotion to His will. Conversely, Abraham faces the impossible question by Isaac; he wants to protect him from the bitter truth, but cannot bring himself to lie to his son at this time. Abraham's solution is an evasive and ambiguous answer. His simultaneous inability to face his son with the truth and his inability to lie reinforce the difficulty of his situation and the immensity of his test.

The question of Isaac's knowledge is one of the great unanswered mysteries of the narrative: did Abraham have to struggle with Isaac and bind him against his will? Did Isaac understand and cooperate? After Abraham's answer, the narrator repeats the description "And the two of them walked on together" (8). If Isaac understood or even suspected that he was the sacrifice, the identical phrase should be read entirely differently. Now they truly walk together, with the same intent.

Abraham Binds Isaac and Picks up the Knife (9–10)

Before the integration of the two dialogues, the narrator comments: "he set out for the place of which God had told him" (22:3). After the dialogues, the narrator returns to the plot sequence and relates, "They arrived at the place of which God had told him" (9). After Abraham and Isaac's dialogue, Abraham no longer is described walking in the singular but rather in the plural; Abraham and Isaac walk side by side.

The rhythm of the narrative changes significantly in the following scene. After three days of walking and nothing to report, suddenly the reader is provided once again with a plethora of verbs associated with Abraham's actions: "They arrived," "Abraham built," "he laid out," "he bound his son," "he laid him on the altar," "Abraham picked up the knife to slay his son." The sudden activity is particularly apparent in the additional verb integrated into the text when Abraham takes the knife: "And Abraham raised *his hand* (וישליח) to *pick up* the knife to slay

his son.”⁷¹ The sudden deceleration in the pace of the narrative clearly stems from the moment of truth – of test – described in the two verses. All the while, Abraham and Isaac remain silent; what more can be said?

The phrase “Abraham built *the* altar *there*” indicates the specific significance of the location. This is the standard formulation for the construction of altars in the Abraham cycle (12:7; 8:13; 8:18).⁷² Previous episodes indicated that Abraham had built an altar in a specific location, but in 22:9 the word “altar” is preceded by the definite article in its initial appearance (הַמִּזְבֵּחַ – *the* altar”), indicating a unique altar built for an unusual purpose. Laying out the wood serves to decelerate the plot as noted above, but it is also linked with the sacrificial world, which values the act of preparing the wood for sacrifice (e.g., Lev 1:7). However, while fire is commonly placed on the wood before the sacrifice (Lev 1:7–8; 6:5), Abraham binds his son and places him on the wood that is on the altar, without lighting a fire. Moreover, Abraham seems to have meant to slaughter his son when he is bound on the altar, in contrast with ordinary sacrifices that are slaughtered and then burned upon the altar unbound.⁷³

Some scholars have suggested that different customs prevailed between the sacrifice of children and animals.⁷⁴ However, the definition of Isaac’s sacrifice as “a burnt offering” specifically links God’s command with the world of animal sacrifice. Boehm viewed the distinction as proof that Abraham never had intended to sacrifice Isaac (and that Abraham decided of his own volition to sacrifice the ram as a replacement). Therefore, instead of lighting a fire on the wood,

71 NJPS omitted the additional verb and simply translated “Abraham picked up the knife.”

72 In contrast with Noah’s altar, which was built in an insignificant location: “Then Noah built an altar to the Lord” (8:20). See also Gen 26:25 (Isaac in Beer-sheba); 35:7 (Jacob in Bethel).

73 Jacob (1974, 498) claimed that the binding of animals in Leviticus is obvious, and therefore not written explicitly; however, even if the animal is bound for slaughtering, it is not placed bound on the altar. Wenham wanted to prove from Abraham’s need to bind Isaac that Abraham knew Isaac might resist. His lack of resistance proves his devotion to God as well (Wenham 1994, 109).

74 Levenson 1993, 135.

Abraham bound his son upon the altar but left him alive.⁷⁵ However, the narrative process, and especially the statement “Abraham raised his hand (וַיִּשְׁלַח) to pick up the knife *to slay his son*,” leave no room to doubt Abraham’s intentions.

The order of sacrifice should be examined from a literary perspective rather than a realistic one. Had there been fire on the altar, the angel would have had to appear to Abraham and stop him before he had placed Isaac on it. Of course, if Abraham had slaughtered his son before placing him on the altar, the angel would have had to intervene earlier as well. The current order of events enables the angel to appear when Isaac is bound and already upon the altar. The wood beneath him prevents the suspicion that Abraham was not willing to go through with his plan, to the bitter end. Everything was prepared, and from a dramatic perspective the reader’s nerves have been stretched to their limit; only then does the angel appear and prevent Abraham from slaughtering his son. After Abraham “raised his hand” (10) the angel can instruct him “Do not raise your hand!” (12).

The Angel’s Revelation and the Sacrifice of the Ram (11–14)

The angel’s second revelation parallels the initial revelation, and the abrupt end to the test parallels the initiation of the test. The parallel is emphasized by the repeated model of Abraham being called (“He said to him, ‘Abraham’” / “Abraham! Abraham!”) and his response (“Here I am,” on both occasions). The command to sacrifice Isaac includes the terms “your son, your favored one, Isaac,” and when the test is stopped Abraham is commended: “you have not withheld your son, your favored one.” Despite the similarities that create this parallel, three minor distinctions exist in the formulation of each revelation. In the former revelation God appeared to Abraham, while in the latter the message is

75 Boehm 2007, 47.

delivered by “an angel of the Lord... from heaven.”⁷⁶ Second, in the first revelation Abraham’s name was called once (“He said to him, ‘Abraham’”), while in the second Abraham’s name is called twice (“Abraham! Abraham!”). These two distinctions stem from the different narrative materials, and both indicate that Abraham is coming closer to God, since the appearance of an angel in the book of Genesis often indicates greater intimacy. This was apparent in the two tidings of a son brought to Abraham and Sarah by angels (17–18); the more intimate, personal message was delivered by angels (18) while the national message, which is unrelated personally to Abraham and Sarah as a couple, was delivered by God Himself (17). Here, too, the content of the initial message necessitates a distance that does not take the collapse of Abraham’s personal life into consideration; the message is delivered by God, Lord of the Universe, while the empathetic solution and message of reconciliation is delivered by an angel. Addressing Abraham by calling out his name twice conveys a similar placating message, as in the case of Jacob on the eve of his departure from the land (46:2), Moses by the burning bush (Ex 3:4),⁷⁷ and Samuel in his inaugural revelations (1 Sam 3:4). The revelation in all of the above is delivered in a pacified and encouraging atmosphere. Calling Abraham’s name twice and the appearance of an angel are both an appropriate introduction to rescuing Abraham’s son.⁷⁸

The third and final difference relates to the references to Isaac. The command to sacrifice Isaac includes the terms “your son, your favored one, *whom you love*, Isaac” and when the test is stopped Abraham is commended “you have not withheld your son, your favored one.” The angel omits Abraham’s love for his child; Abraham expressed his absolute willingness to sacrifice that which is dearest to him to God; he had to overcome his love for Isaac in order to do so. Love cannot be mentioned while Abraham still holds the slaughtering knife in his hand.

76 On the change from Elohim to YHWH see below.

77 On the comparison between the binding of Isaac and the revelation at the burning bush see Habel 1965, 301–02.

78 Some scholars wrote that calling a name twice is an element used when God or an angel attempt to stop the protagonist from acting (Gunkel 1997, 235; Jacob 1974, 144; Hamilton 1995, 111–12). This interpretation is fitting in the binding narrative and the burning bush (Ex 3:5), but not in Samuel’s inaugural revelation.

The scene ends with Abraham naming “the place.” The term “the place” accompanies the entire narrative and becomes one of the focal points of the story, starting with God’s command to go to an unidentified location in the land of Moriah (2), through Abraham’s journey with his servants to “the place of which God had told him” (3) until finally Abraham “saw the place from afar” (4). When Abraham leaves his servants behind and walks alone with his son, finally “they arrived at the place of which God had told him; Abraham built the altar there” (9). Finally the “place” is revealed, and ultimately named as one of the central motifs of the story (14). The group Abraham travels with is reduced until the text can focus on father and son; in correlation, the vague and general destination is narrowed down from one of the hilltops in “the land of Moriah” to a place that is visible, but “from afar,” until finally Abraham and Isaac arrived at the place, and Abraham sanctified the location by building an altar. Finally, “the place” was given a name in commemoration of the event. The purpose of this gradual focus is, of course, to serve as background for the sanctification of the mountain. It is noteworthy that Abraham does not name the place when he builds the altar, or even after experiencing the relief of the rescue of his son; instead the naming is delayed until after the sacrifice of the ram.

Misleading Conclusion

The conclusion of the scene with the sacrifice of a ram and naming the location conveys the feeling of an ending. The solution to the initial problem came in the form of an angel, who stopped Abraham from slaughtering his son at the last minute; Abraham was then reassured that the command was only a test of his faith. The sacrifice of the ram emphasizes the rescue of the son (“Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering in place of his son”) and the successful conclusion to the story. The etymological note (“Abraham named that site Adonai-yireh”) is “a common ending

to a biblical narrative, often providing an explanation for a natural phenomenon, a custom, or another manifestation which might be of interest to the reader.”⁷⁹ The etymological conclusion is made even more prominent by the integration of a distant perspective: “whence the present saying, ‘On the mount of the Lord there is vision.’” This statement surpasses accepted conclusion formulations; it creates the sense of leaving the time-frame of the story to address the reader directly and creates “a link between the literary world and the reader’s world. Therefore, the statement is an appropriate ending, since the narrator accompanies the reader (and especially the hearer), and returns the reader’s cognition to reality.”⁸⁰ Some scholars viewed the etymological conclusion as a culmination of the narrative, and the following verses as a later addition.⁸¹ Westermann wrote: “There are only a few texts in Gen 12–50 which are so easily recognizable as an addition.”⁸²

The structure of the narrative supposedly reinforces this assumption. Coats divided the narrative into two parts:⁸³

1. Complication (1–10)
 - a. Command to sacrifice (1–2)
 - b. Implementation (3–10)
2. Resolution (11–14)
 - a. Command to delay sacrifice (11–12)
 - b. Implementation (13)
 - c. Naming the location: etymological conclusion (14)

79 Amit 2003, 49. We have already encountered this in: Gen 16:14; 19:37–38; 21:31.

80 Polak 1999, 111.

81 Among others, Skinner 1930, 331; von Rad 1963, 242; Bailey 1981, 148; Emerton 1982, 18; Thompson 1987, 99; Carr 1996, 169–76; Gunkel 1997, 236. Avishur (1993) took this idea one step further, and claimed that v. 14 is outside the range of the story.

82 Westermann 1995, 363.

83 Coats 1983, 159.

According to this structure, the narrative ends with naming the place “Adonai-yireh.” This conclusion is also apparent from Robert Crotty’s alternative suggestions:⁸⁴

- a. God sends Abraham to the land of Moriah (1–2)
- b. Abraham implements the divine command, and prepares to sacrifice his son (3–10)
 - c. God’s angel appears and commands him, “Do not raise your hand against the boy”
- b1. The ram is sacrificed in place of the son (13)
- a1. Abraham names the location “Adonai-yireh” (14)

Both models demonstrate that the second appearance of the angel is not an integral part of the narrative. Other scholars contested this position and proved that the verses are essential to the narrative,⁸⁵ due to the parallel with the expulsion of Ishmael, which would be incomplete without a promise of multiplicity of offspring,⁸⁶ or because of the parallel with Gen 12, or because the narrative concludes with a repetition of the blessings, which Abraham has now earned through his willingness to sacrifice his son.⁸⁷

Additionally, in light of the links between the binding narrative and the Abraham–Abimelech relationship, the angel’s second revelation has to be read as an integral part of the binding narrative. The Abraham–Abimelech episode ended with a treaty and an oath, and the binding narrative ended with a repetition of the covenant and a promise.⁸⁸

84 Crotty 2005.

85 Among others, Van Seters 1975, 239; Alexander 1983; Sternberg 1985, 55; Rendsburg 1986, 33–34; Hamilton 1995, 115. From a structural perspective, some scholars suggested a chiasmic structure that includes vs. 15–19 (Ska 1988).

86 Wenham 1994, 102–03; similarly, Kundert 1998, 32.

87 Van Seters 1975, 239: “The whole purpose of testing would have no real consequence...it is only with the inclusion in the second speech...that the ultimate aim of the testing becomes clear. Because of Abraham’s obedience his children will be blessed.” See also Moberly 1988.

88 Beer-sheba is named as a result of the dispute with Abimelech: “Hence that place was called Beer-sheba, for there the two of them swore an oath” (21:31); at the conclusion of the binding narrative Abraham and his servants return the

The solution of later redaction is therefore unconvincing. The literary contribution is similar to a *cadenza d'inganno* in music;⁸⁹ the new caption, “The angel of the Lord called to Abraham a second time from heaven” (22:15), is meant to surprise the reader, who had believed the story had come to its end, while the true conclusion of the narrative is Abraham’s return home with his servants, after receiving God’s promise.

Why, however, is this promise only mentioned in the second, surprising revelation, after the ram is sacrificed, rather than during the first revelation? Through a close reading of the “second” revelation, we will explore this question and the contribution of the pseudo-conclusion; the sacrifice of the ram; and the general narrative objective.

God’s Promise (15–18)

The focal point of the promise that concludes the narrative is Abraham’s offspring. The blessing has three components: the multiplicity of Abraham’s offspring: “I will bestow My blessing upon you and make your descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven and the sands on the seashore”; their success at conquest: “and your descendants shall seize the gates of their foes”; and their political success: “All the nations of the earth shall bless themselves by your descendants.” The relevance of the blessing is obvious: once Abraham agrees to abandon his only child out of loyalty to God, the multiplicity and success of his offspring is a fitting and encouraging message.

The blessing seems to be designed in a concentric structure:⁹⁰

Beer-sheba: “and they departed together for Beer-sheba; and Abraham stayed in Beer-sheba.”

89 For additional examples see Simon 1996, 117 note 4 (regarding Judg 15:16–17); Grossman 2011 – Esther, 201–07 (regarding Es 9:29–32) ; Grossman 2015 – Text and Subtext, 210–218.

90 For an alternative chiasmic structure see Avishur 1993, 96.

- a. Because you have done this
 - b. and have not withheld your son, your favored one,
 - c. I will bestow My blessing upon you
 - b1. and make your descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven and the sands on the seashore; and your descendants shall seize the gates of their foes. All the nations of the earth shall bless themselves by your descendants,
- a1. because you have obeyed My command.

The structure signifies the internal process: the frame of the blessing (Abraham's actions) justifies its content (God's blessing). The blessing is explicitly designed as a reward for Abraham's actions, in contrast with all other blessings in the Abraham cycle. In the parallel frame episode that opens the story cycle (ch. 12) the blessings are a destiny and an unconditional promise. The concluding narrative of the cycle portrays the blessings as a reward for Abraham, who proved that he deserves to be blessed. This difference is also expressed in the changing order of the narrative. Chapter 12 is written in the following order:

1. **Command:** "*Go forth* from your land and from the place of your birth and from your father's house to the land that I will show you.
2. **Blessing:** "I will bless those who bless you, and curse him that curses you; And all the families of the earth shall bless themselves by you."
3. **Implementation:** "Abram took his wife Sarai...and they set out for the land of Canaan"
4. **Building an altar:** after reaching Canaan and another revelation in the terebinths of Mamre, Abraham "built an altar there to the Lord who had appeared to him."

All four components are present in the binding narrative; however, the order is changed:

1. **Command:** "*Go forth* to the land of Moriah."
2. **Implementation:** "So early next morning, Abraham saddled his ass and took with him two of his servants and his son Isaac...and he set out for the place of which God had told him."

3. **Building an altar:** “Abraham built the altar there... And Abraham named that site Adonai-yireh.”⁹¹
4. **Blessing:** “I will bestow My blessing upon you and make your descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven and the sands on the seashore; and your descendants shall seize the gates of their foes. All the nations of the earth shall bless themselves by your descendants.”⁹²

The context of the blessing in Gen 12 demonstrates that the blessing should be viewed as conditional: if Abraham agrees to God’s demand to journey to Canaan, he will merit multiple blessings. The integration of the blessing in the command makes the blessing itself a source of encouragement to Abraham to begin his journey. The blessings are offered to him, and all he has to do is “go forth” and take them. In contrast, the binding narrative delays the promises to the end. Abraham cannot be promised a multitude of offspring on his way to sacrifice his only child; such a promise would undermine the nature of the test. Nonetheless, the nature of the promise changes as a result: the promise is no longer encouragement to act, but reward for having acted.

In light of all this, the content of the blessing is all the more surprising. One would have expected Abraham to be rewarded for his extreme fidelity with a new blessing, but the content of the blessing is identical to previous blessings Abraham had been given in various stages of his journey through Canaan.⁹³ The blessing might be viewed as a reinforcement or culmination of all previous blessings.⁹⁴ But the

91 The nature of the altar in each of the narratives is entirely different. Nonetheless, Avishur (1993, 100–01) compared the construction of the two altars; the contrast emphasizes the delay of the promise in the narrative.

92 “We should consider the fact that once more in Abraham’s story, between these two incidents, God said of Abraham ‘all the nations of the earth are to bless themselves by him’ (18:18).” (Buber 1997, 294).

93 In reference to the metaphor of stars and sand, see Gen 13:16; 15:5; 17:2. Regarding overcoming enemies, see Gen 15:7–21. In reference to the blessing of the people of the land, see Gen 12:3.

94 Emanuelli 1978, 308.

context of the blessing (“Because you have done this and have not withheld your son...because you have obeyed My command”) indicates that Abraham’s actions merit something new.

Three possible solutions are offered to this dilemma. Bin-Nun claimed that while the content of the blessings is not new, since the selection of Abraham was questioned in Gerar, there is a need to reaffirm the original blessings:

When Abraham agreed to make a pact and take an oath with Abimelech, and their agreement is officially sanctioned, a question might be raised regarding the selection of Abraham, regarding his designation, and particularly regarding the promise of the land. Perhaps Abimelech is also deserving? Why should Abraham be given more blessings than Abimelech?

...The binding of Isaac responds to these misgivings...[T]he purpose of the test is to renew Abraham’s selection after his descent to Gerar and the land of the Philistines...to reinstate his mission, to renew his destiny, to restore the selection and blessing.⁹⁵

Alternatively, some scholars refuted the basic assumption that the blessing is the same, and attempted to find something new about the promise that followed the binding of Isaac. Wenham explained that the phrase **בֵּרַךְ אֲבִרְכָךְ** indicates a special blessing, and found the innovation in the multiplicity of offspring promised to Abraham. While the image of the stars was used previously, the metaphor of sand is new. Wenham also found innovation in the promise of land: he believed the statement “your descendants shall seize the gates of their foes” is realistic, as opposed to previous theoretical promises of land without a promise of military victory.⁹⁶

The difficulty with Wenham’s reading is that richer literary metaphors do not indicate an innovative message. Although the sand metaphor was not previously used, the metaphors of sand or stars represent the same thing: a multiplicity of offspring. The festive occasion might call for new metaphors and poetic language,⁹⁷ but does it not also call for additional reward?

95 Bin-Nun 2003, 108–11.

96 Wenham 1994, 111–12.

97 Moberly 1988, 318.

A third option adopts the assumption that the content of the blessing contains no innovation. The innovation of the blessing in the binding narrative is not in its content, but in its legal validity. Moberly suggested similarly that the promises throughout the Abraham cycle were based on the will of God and His objectives, while the promise in Gen 22 was also based on Abraham's loyalty.⁹⁸

I believe that the blessing's novelty lies in its caption: "By Myself I swear" (16). This is the only time that Abraham is vowed something by God; in fact, this is God's only oath toward one of the forefathers. When God speaks to Isaac, he reinforces "fulfilling the oath that I swore to your father Abraham" (26:3–5). Unlike previous blessings, a promise is binding. God promises in His own name – He is bound to His word. The purpose of the blessings bestowed upon Abraham at the start of his journey was to set goals. If the following generations cease from walking in God's ways as Abraham had instructed them, God is not bound to those blessings, since Abraham's offspring no longer realize the destiny that merits those blessings. A covenant obligates both parties, even if one is a lord and the other a vassal; the violation of the covenant by one party exempts the other from all obligations. Conversely, an oath is unconditional. Abraham's willingness to sacrifice his son bought him an everlasting oath. The nature of the blessing therefore correlates with its place in the story cycle. In the opening narrative Abraham was encouraged to pursue a blessed destiny, while in the culminating narrative he is given blessings he had earned by his own deeds. The final words God utters to Abraham in the cycle are, "you have obeyed My command."

Although the promise could simply be attributed to the enormity of the test, it might also be a manifestation of "measure for measure." God's unconditional commitment is a reaction to Abraham's unconditional loyalty. When the episode is read in its wider

98 Moberly 1988, 320. Similarly, Hamilton 1995, 116. Some viewed God's promise as a result of the sacrifice, and paralleled the promise to God's promise to Noah after the flood, which followed Noah's sacrifice (Alexander 1983, 21; Wenham 1994, 112).

context, it emerges that Abraham had the legal right (which, in this context, also reflects the moral right) to refuse God's command to sacrifice his son. God had told Abraham in the Covenant of Circumcision that the covenant would be implemented through Isaac: "Sarah your wife shall bear you a son, and you shall name him Isaac; and I will maintain My covenant with him as an everlasting covenant for his offspring to come...But My covenant I will maintain with Isaac, whom Sarah shall bear to you at this season next year" (17:19–20). The general promise of offspring was anchored in a concrete promise that Isaac would be born in one year, and that Isaac would be the one to maintain God's covenant. Assuming that God would have allowed Abraham to slaughter Isaac, His command would have been a violation of the covenant with Abraham; Abraham therefore had every legal and moral right to refuse. Nonetheless, Abraham's unequivocal loyalty led him to follow God's command; by doing so he expressed unconditional devotion to God, independent of the actions of the "other party." Abraham's devotion overpowered the content of previous covenants and mutual agreements. Every step of the three-day journey to Moriah was an expression of utmost faith in God, despite His violation of the covenant from Abraham's perspective. God's response is a promise; the blessings are now anchored and independent of Abraham's loyalty. Even if Abraham's offspring should sin and become unfaithful to the covenant, they will maintain the merit of the binding of Isaac, and their relationship with God will prevail.

In light of the link between the test and the result, the blessing is an appropriate conclusion for the narrative, and cannot be viewed as a later addition. While one would have expected the promise to follow Isaac's rescue, instead, the angel only delivers the message of the promise in a second revelation, after the sacrifice of the ram and the naming of the mountain. As mentioned above, the narrative design creates the impression that the story ends with the naming of the mountain, and the promise is integrated into an episode that seems out of place. What is the meaning of this design?

The purpose of a “false conclusion” is often to surprise the reader with an additional element or stage that seems unnecessary to the progression of the plot. The design of the binding narrative in this way contributes to the portrayal of Abraham’s character, since Abraham acts without intending to be rewarded. While the blessings in Gen 12 accompanied the demand to “go forth,” here the blessings were “appended” to the main message of the text, instead of distracting from Abraham’s true and unadulterated intention. The blessing is not the main purpose of the narrative, but the realization of Abraham’s faith and loyalty. Abraham did not act in order to be blessed. This explanation, however, is insufficient.

Sacrifice of the Ram and the Structure of the Narrative

The purpose of the ram sacrifice relates to the division of the narrative. Some viewed the short dialogue between Abraham and Isaac on the final leg of their journey to the mountain (7–8) as the climax of the narrative. This dialogue is bordered at both ends with the statement “and they walked on together” (vs. 6 and 8), which emphasizes the dialogue that occurs between the two statements. Some noted that the dialogue is the heart of a concentric structure throughout the narrative (apart from the second revelation of the angel), and view the dialogue as “the dramatic climax of the narrative.”⁹⁹

However, from a literary viewpoint the transition from v. 10 to v. 11 should be viewed as the climax: “And Abraham picked up the knife to slay his son – Then an angel of the Lord called to him from heaven.” This is the “solution stage” – the angel stopped Abraham from slaughtering his son. The change in the plot is marked by the change in God’s

99 Avishur 1993, 93; Doukhan 1993. Avishur viewed v. 13 (!) as the conclusion of the narrative. Both considered the dialogue between Abraham and Isaac as the central axis of the concentric structure.

names: from v. 11 onward God is referred to as YHWH,¹⁰⁰ in contrast with the first part of the narrative, where God is called Elohim.¹⁰¹ The division of a unified narrative into two parts, each represented by another name, is unusual in biblical literature. This fact so disturbed Boehm that it drove him to claim that the entire second part is to be attributed to a different source, despite the substantial literary contribution of the writing style, which will be discussed below. In any case, the obvious division of the narrative does not occur in the dialogue between Abraham and Isaac (7–8) but in the angel’s revelation (11), which is also marked by the change in God’s name.

The significance of this division is the parallel it creates between the two halves of the narrative, which centralizes the sacrifice of the ram as a parallel to Abraham’s preparations to sacrifice Isaac. The initial caption in which God turns to Abraham (“He said to him, ‘Abraham,’ and he answered, ‘Here I am’” [1]) is paralleled by the angel’s demand of Abraham (“Then an angel of the Lord called to him from heaven: ‘Abraham! Abraham!’” [11]). God’s initial demand, “Take your son, your favored one, whom you love, Isaac” (2), is paralleled by the angel’s demand, “Do not raise your hand against the boy, or do anything to him.” The first part of the narrative describes Abraham lifting his eyes and viewing “the place” from afar (4); this is paralleled by Abraham lifting his eyes to see a ram caught in the thicket (13).¹⁰² Finally, God’s command to “offer him there as a burnt offering” (2) is paralleled by Abraham’s initiative: “Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering *in place of his son*” (13). The verbs לקח (“took”), and הלך (“went”), which reference Abraham’s actions in the first part of narrative, when he takes his son and goes to offer

100 The integration of the name YHWH in v. 11 is problematic for those who attribute the narrative to E; some therefore viewed the integration of YHWH as an addition by the final redactor (Skinner 1930, 330).

101 The phrase “For now I know that you fear God (Elohim)” in the second part strays from the division; however, “Fear of God” should be viewed as an idiom. (For example: Deut 25:18; Job 1:8; Ecc 7:18).

102 For another arrangement of the verses and the claim that v. 13 parallels vs. 7–8, see Douglas 2007, 23.

him as a sacrifice to God, reappear in the second part when Abraham “takes” the ram and “goes” to sacrifice it instead of his son.

The narrative therefore portrays the ram as a substitute for Isaac; the parallel between God’s command and Abraham’s actions indicate that the offering is indeed “in place of his son.”¹⁰³ Despite the wider parallel, however, there is an essential distinction in the nature of each of the sacrifices. The angel’s revelation prevented Abraham from slaughtering his son (12) but did not include a command to sacrifice another animal in his stead. The ram was offered voluntarily, whereas the son was to be offered by divine command. The process of replacing Isaac is described as Abraham’s innovation; the initial mandatory offering was replaced with a voluntary offering.

This analysis leads to the purpose of the binding narrative. Some scholars emphasized the test element as the main purpose; others viewed the sanctity of the mountain, or a polemic against the sacrifice of children as the message of the narrative.¹⁰⁴ The attempt to define one objective is often met with difficulty, since a complex narrative includes various elements that emphasize various messages.¹⁰⁵ While all three of the attempts mentioned above find expression in the narrative, the first part of the narrative emphasizes the test, while the second focuses on the significance of sacrificing animals, which eliminates the need to sacrifice children. Gunkel refuted this position, stating that the message of the narrative prohibits the sacrifice of children: “Indeed, the narrator knows that, in the final analysis, God does not desire this sacrifice. But the legend still reckons with the possibility that God could require it. Polemic against child sacrifice is, accordingly,

103 The word אַחֵר (literally: “after”) in 22:13 complicates the verse: “When Abraham looked up, his eye fell upon a [אַחֵר] [after] ram, caught in the thicket by its horns.” Numerous attempts were made to decipher the odd expression, including the adoption of the alternative version recorded in several Masoretic manuscripts (and some translations), substituting אַחֵר (“after”) with אֶחָד (“one ram”) (see a list of manuscripts in Skinner 1930, 330). This version reinforces the link between Isaac (יְחִידָא – “your only one”) and the “one” ram.

104 Many adopted this reading; see, among others, von Rad 1963, 243; Spiegel 1967, 67; Nielsen 2013.

105 See esp. Greenstein 2012, 112–22.

quite remote here.”¹⁰⁶ Levenson and Delany wrote similarly that since Abraham’s test was the willingness to sacrifice his son, and since Abraham received the blessing due to his agreement to sacrifice his son, it is unlikely that the purpose of the narrative is to negate the possibility of human sacrifice.¹⁰⁷ However, two details prove that the matter is more complex. The first part of the narrative certainly expresses the unyielding obedience expected of Abraham. The polemic against child sacrifice does not emerge in the first part of the narrative; on the contrary, the position of the first part seems to be that if God should demand such a thing, a true believer would have to acquiesce. The second part of the narrative, however, reveals that there is no real need for child sacrifice, and a replacement is sufficient. Second, polemic narratives frequently present the idea to which they object as a hypothetical possibility that is then rejected. The purpose of this style is to express the rejection of the idea itself; otherwise the polemic might be indiscernible:

The human sacrifice in this story thus serves as an extraordinary and one-time instruction, one that God commands but that in retrospect was never meant to be realized. For purposes of the burnt offering a ram suddenly appears in the thicket caught by its horns. Thus, already in the manner of structuring of the plot, this story entails an indirect criticism of human sacrifice, presenting it as an offering in which God is not interested.”¹⁰⁸

106 Gunkel 1997, 237.

107 Levenson 1993, 13; Delany 1998, 101–04.

108 Amit 2000, 68. For a critique on this reading see Delany 1998, 72–86. Delany believed there was no prevalent custom of child sacrifice before Abraham, and so there was no reason to criticize a prevalent custom. In fact, claims Delany, the only solid evidence of human sacrifice is apparent in biblical texts (87–104). Amit (2003, 82) wrote that the use of the terms “knife” and “slaughter” are not coincidental: “this diminishes the description to focus on technical matters; the glory and splendor of the occasion was removed, and all that is left is the horror of a father killing his son. These diverse indirect measures come together to protest human sacrifice.” Amit’s conclusion is correct; however, in light of the delays and decelerations of the text in the narrative’s climax, the “glory and splendor” of the occasion are very much present. Focus on every detail of Abraham’s every action and the unusual verb *מִאֲכִילֵת* to describe the knife contribute to the design of a ceremonial scene, full of glory. Speiser, however, and

The binding narrative is an introduction to the perception of sacrifice in Israel, including the appropriate mood and the purpose of the sacrifice. Once God exempts Isaac, he does not request an alternative animal sacrifice. Sacrificing the ram is Abraham's decision, and he was the one who made the ram into a replacement for his son. By Abraham's choice, the narrative does not end with Isaac's rescue.

Appropriately, the mountain is only named after the sacrifice of the ram. Abraham sanctifies the altar and the location; both will become a model for the future sacrifice of Abraham's offspring. The narrative establishes that sacrificing an animal to God demonstrates unequivocal loyalty to God, as though one were willing to sacrifice that which is dearest.¹⁰⁹ Later, the Bible will state explicitly that human sacrifice is an "abhorrent act that the Lord detests" (Deut 12:31).

Changing names and titles in the biblical narrative carries literary significance,¹¹⁰ which emerges with regard to God's name in the binding narrative, in light of the analysis above. Elohim as a general name represents the strength and might of God, while YHWH is the exclusive name of the Lord of Israel. In the first part of the narrative God portrays Himself as one of the ancient gods, who demand human sacrifice. However, when the God of Abraham reveals His true intention and lack of desire for human sacrifice, His private name emerges: "Then an angel of YHWH called to him from heaven...Do not raise your hand against the boy, or do anything to him!"¹¹¹ At the start of

Alter in his wake, claim that the tool to be used was not a knife but a cleaver, and therefore was described with the rare word "מַאֲכֶלֶת." Fischer (2007) claimed the purpose of the narrative was to demonstrate that sacrificing a son is an abomination; furthermore, he claimed that Abraham's test was not to follow the simple meaning of God's words. The preferred outcome was Abraham refraining from binding Isaac and placing him on the altar.

109 On the sacrifice of animals as a substitution for human sacrifice, see references in Gunkel 1997, 236.

110 E.g., Leibowitz 1973, 99–104; Alter 1981, 182–84; Weiss 1987, 303–06; Sternberg 1991; Gelandner 1997, 52–55; Polak 1999, 329–30. The concept is also prevalent in other ancient Near Eastern texts; see Uspensky 1973, 26–33; 110–33.

111 Lodovico Cardellino noticed these details as well, but he explains them incorrectly, thinking that Abraham received the order to sacrifice his son from another God, not from YHWH (Cardellino 1996).

the narrative God claimed what is rightfully His, while the culmination of the narrative reveals that God has no interest in human sacrifice; only in the loyalty of his servants.¹¹²

Conclusion (19)

There are two intriguing points in the concluding verse: The narrator omits Isaac's name from the return journey and emphasizes (twice) Beer-sheba, the place to which Abraham returns. The reader's anticipation to hear about Isaac's safe return home - and perhaps, his reunion with his mother - is embedded in the narrative materials, since the turning point of the narrative was Isaac's rescue. Abraham had told his servants that *they* would go and sacrifice and then *they* would return (22:5); now that Isaac was given the opportunity to return, one would expect to hear the realization of Abraham's inadvertent prophecy. While the narrator uses the same verb to describe Abraham's return ("we will return to you" – "Abraham returned"), Isaac is omitted. Isaac's omission downplays the turnaround of the narrative; moreover, the repetition of the phrase "and they walked on together" (vs. 6 and 8) in the context of Abraham and Isaac's journey emphasizes the omission of Isaac from the final leg of the trip, which only mentions Abraham and his servants, who "walked on together" (19).

According to one midrashic tradition, Isaac was indeed slaughtered. He went up to heaven and remained there for three years.¹¹³ According to this midrash, Isaac returned to earth only when Rebekah arrived with Abraham's servant, and he returned to greet her. According to Boehm

112 "The purpose is to convey that in theory one should be willing even to sacrifice a son to the high divine presence of the universe, while in practice the God of Israel, Hashem, does not demand such sacrifices; on the contrary, He neither accepts them nor permits them" (Cassuto 1989, 46).

113 Midrash Hagadol on Genesis. See also commentary by R. Hezekiah ben Manoah (Hizkuni).

this is an ancient tradition,¹¹⁴ based on the absence of Isaac from the conclusion of the text. Ibn Ezra (on Gen 22:19) was familiar with the tradition, which he rejected: “Isaac was not mentioned because he was his [Abraham’s] property. Anyone who says he slaughtered him and left him and then he returned to life – contradicts the text.” Ibn Ezra views the absence of Isaac as no different from an omission in any other text: the reader is meant to understand that Isaac had accompanied his father on the journey back home. However, his need to object to the position that Isaac was slaughtered and returned to life indicates that the tradition was not trivial or distant.¹¹⁵ There is no question that Ibn Ezra is correct; the assumption that Isaac was slaughtered indeed negates the text.¹¹⁶ But while the early tradition negates the text itself, it may be based on the atmosphere of the concluding verse. Although Isaac returned to Beer-sheba with Abraham and the servants, the ending generates the dramatic impression that Abraham returned alone, without his son.¹¹⁷ The ram that was sacrificed in Isaac’s stead represents the sacrifice of Isaac himself; this realistic representation links Isaac to the mountain, which in some sense he can never leave. The narrative successfully and powerfully represents two opposing ideas: Abraham’s absolute loyalty to God, to the point of sacrificing his own son, and God’s objection to the sacrifice of children. Abraham’s ram sacrifice sufficed to express his unequivocal loyalty; from the perspective of Abraham’s withstanding of God’s test, it is as though Isaac was indeed sacrificed, and left up on the mountain.

The second surprising detail is the return of the protagonist to Beer-sheba. Returning to one’s home is a classic story ending, but since the narrative failed to mention that Abraham had departed from Beer-sheba his “return” seems out of place. In addition to mentioning the

114 Boehm 2007, 47.

115 Medieval Jewish commentators were sensitive to readings of the text that might reinforce Christian beliefs. Ibn Ezra’s rejection might be based on this concern.

116 Kierkegaard suggested alternative endings for the narrative: according to one, Isaac stopped believing in God. According to another, after the binding Abraham could never find happiness again.

117 Tribble expressed this similarly, but she focused on Abraham’s emotional detachment from his son” (Tribble 1991, 181).

“return” to Beer-sheba, the narrator continues: “and Abraham stayed in Beer-sheba” (22:19). The meaning of this detail seems to be related to the previous episode. The city of Beer-sheba becomes the final chord of the entire binding narrative. In the previous narrative Abraham had named Beer-sheba in commemoration of the oath between Abraham and Abimelech (21:31). Mentioning Beer-sheba at the conclusion of the binding narrative maintains the link to the oath that is hinted at in the name of the city, and also gives the name new meaning: Abraham arrived in the city because of God’s oath. God’s promise supersedes Abimelech’s oath and reconfirms Abraham’s selection.

Chapter 17: The Sons of Nahor (22:20–24)

The binding narrative is followed by an account of the birth of the sons of Abraham's brother Nahor. Genealogical lists are generally presented for the reader's benefit, but the list of Nahor's sons was delivered to Abraham: "Some time later, Abraham was told, 'Milcah too has borne children to your brother Nahor'" (22:20). The caption links the sons of Nahor with the previous episode: "some time later" (or literally, "after these things").¹ While some commentators view the binding narrative as a background for the list of Nahor's sons,² others believe the concrete literary unit should not be separated from the greater narrative context, and read the list in light of the birth of Isaac: just as Abraham had a son, his brother Nahor also had sons.³ This possibility is supported by the phrase "Milcah *too* has borne."

The juxtaposition of Nahor and Abraham's sons is, of course, ironic. Abraham and Sarah waited many years for their son, who finally came in their old age; after Isaac was born, Abraham almost lost him again. Nahor, on the other hand, has twelve sons. While Abraham took Sarah's maidservant to overcome Sarah's fertility problem, and ultimately had to send that son away, his brother Nahor took a concubine

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- 1 Mathews (2005, 306) claimed that the list of Nahor's sons begins the epilogue of the Abraham cycle (22:20–25:11). This position is congruent with the narrative materials; however, the opening caption links the list to previous stories as well. Mathews also accepts the link between the sons of Nahor and the binding due to the caption "some time later," but he believes the links indicate that the sons of Nahor are a fulfillment of Abraham's blessing to the nations of the earth (22:18).
 - 2 This category includes those who link the episode with the binding narrative in general, as well as the position that links Rebekah's mention with God's promise about the success of Abraham's offspring.
 - 3 Westermann 1995, 366–67. Westermann claimed that based on this detail the list was originally adjacent to 21:1–8 (the birth of Isaac). The units can be linked despite the episode of Isaac's binding and "rebirth," which interrupts the sequence.

so that he could have twelve sons instead of eight (at this point in the narrative, the reader has not yet been introduced to Keturah, who bore six more sons to Abraham). The link between the two episodes, and the opening remark “some time later,” highlights this irony. Perhaps this is the reason for the emphasis that the list is not only intended for the reader but for Abraham as well. One might imagine Abraham returning to his tent after the binding ordeal, and hearing the news of his brother’s impressive family. (see further below).

As mentioned in the introduction, the purpose of the list can be viewed in three different contexts. The general caption of the entire Abraham cycle is the “line of Terah” (Gen 11:27). The cycle follows three branches of Terah’s descendants: Haran – through Lot – culminating in Terah’s great-grandsons Amon and Moab; Nahor, who had twelve sons; and particularly the Abraham branch, the narrative protagonist, who had a son at 100 years of age and nearly sacrificed him to God. The list of Nahor’s sons indicates that the line of Terah culminates in Ur of the Chaldeans.⁴ Since according to the common reading Milcah, Nahor’s wife, is the daughter of Haran, who dies in his father’s lifetime (11:29), the marriage of Isaac (son of Abraham) to Rebekah (granddaughter of Nahor and Haran’s daughter Milcah) reunites all three family branches. Mentioning Nahor’s sons here contributes to the conclusion of the Abraham cycle: Abraham’s last revelation sealed his story, and all that is left is to report about the remaining brother. This frame is supported by the artistic structure of the entire unit, and defines the following narratives as an appendix to the story cycle.

The narrator looks not only to the past but to the future as well. Rashi wrote:

When he returned from Mount Moriah, Abraham thought, ‘Had my son been slaughtered, he would have died without children. I should have married him to a woman of the daughters of Aner, Eshkol, or Mamre.’ So the Holy One, blessed be He, announced to him that Rebekah, his mate, had been born; that is why it says, ‘after these matters,’ – after his thoughts following the binding.⁵

4 “[R]eminding us that the tradition we are reading is really the *Toledoth* of Terah, of which the story of Abraham is but a part.” Thompson 1987, 99.

5 Rashi 22:20.

Rashi interprets the caption not in relation to the previous episodes, but in reference to the Isaac's future relationship with Rebekah.⁶ This reading is supported by a careful tracking of the names of the sons: while the focus of the episode is the sons of Nahor, when the narrator reaches Bethuel there is a diversion from the list for the purpose of mentioning Nahor's granddaughter Rebekah. Nahor's grandson Aram is also mentioned in the list (22:21), not as a separate stage but as part of the description of the life of his father.⁷ In addition to skipping a generation by mentioning Rebekah, the appearance of women in biblical genealogical lists is rare. Family lines focus on sons, since they are the successors of the dynasty. As daughters traditionally joined their husband's family, there is no reason to mention them in a genealogical list.⁸ Therefore, the mention of Rebekah is unusual and surprising, and probably anticipates Isaac's future right after his rescue. Mention of Rebekah will be followed by news of the death of Sarah.

However, the mention of Rebekah is an insufficient explanation for the entire list; certainly the sons of Nahor's concubine Reuma do not contribute to this purpose. The list should therefore be viewed in light of the important role played by the family of Nahor throughout

6 See Sternberg 1985, 133; Teugels 1994, 91–92.

7 However, the mention of Aram – even if merely as an extension of his father – is related to the centrality of Aram in the broader biblical consciousness. In addition to the long-lasting political dispute with Aram, Abraham's family that remained in Mesopotamia is referred to as Aram, and the place of origin is called "Paddan Aram." Regarding Aram's relationship with Nahor (as opposed to the sons of Shem in Gen 10:22), see Guttman, ארם.

8 The name Maacah at the end of the list of the concubine's children might be the name of a girl or a boy. The fact that the name is mentioned in the list would indicate that Maacah is a son, but the biblical name is more commonly feminine (2 Sam 3:3; 1 Kgs 15:2; 1 Chr 2:48; 1 Chr 7: 15–16; 1 Chr 9:35). Some early commentators (e.g., Sforzo) and some modern scholars (e.g., Sternberg 1985, 133) therefore noted that Maacah was a daughter, not a son. However, the name Maacah was originally linked with a geographical region (2 Sam 10:6), and in other places probably indicates a masculine name (1 Kgs 2:39; 1 Chr 11:43; see Kaddari 2006, 642); therefore, Maacah is more likely to be a son than a daughter.

the remainder of Genesis narratives (sending Abraham's servant to Nahor's family; Jacob's escape to Haran) and as a foreshadowing whose contribution will only become clear in future narratives.

This might be the reason the list is not reported to the reader, but rather described as news heard by Abraham. Abraham has to have information about the birth of the sons of Nahor, so that he knows to send his servant there to find a wife for his son.⁹

The third context moves from the literary plane to the theological. The list should not be read outside its literary context; in fact a special effort is made to link the episode with Abraham's life. According to the two contexts mentioned above, the list of Nahor's sons parallels Abraham's family – from the joint father to the reunification of the next generation. But the parallel can also be viewed as a contrast: the abovementioned irony of mentioning Nahor alongside Abraham in reference to fertility and establishing a family is in itself part of the purpose of the list. The journey of the Abraham cycle began with Abraham's departure from his family with a promise that by leaving his past behind him he goes toward a better future, and will become a great nation. Contrasting Nahor with Abraham undermines this perception; apparently Nahor, who stayed behind in Ur of the Chaldeans, and did not even join his father on the first leg of the trip that ended in Harran, was blessed with fertility and many sons, while Abraham, who went to Canaan as he was commanded, was blessed with one son, after great difficulty. God's promises to Abraham are thus portrayed as intended for future generations, not to be enjoyed by Abraham himself. The inheritance of the land was delayed to the distant future (Gen 15:13–16), and the blessing of

9 See Sarna 1982. The claim above does not contradict Wenham's position that the statement "Bethuel birthed Rebekah" should be attributed to the narrator, and should not be viewed as part of the rumor that reached Abraham. Based on this assumption Wenham claimed that there is no reason to say Abraham knew about Rebekah before sending his servant, and that Abraham sent his servant based on the information that his brother Nahor had established a family (Wenham 1994, 120).

fertility will also not be fulfilled in the days of Abraham. The juxtaposition with Nahor seems to indicate that had Abraham remained in Harran, he might have had his brother's luck; nonetheless, Abraham chose to follow God's command, and his blessings will be fulfilled in the time of his children, and the nations they will establish.

Conclusion

As depicted in the introduction, the narrative is arranged in a concentric structure, with the Covenant of Circumcision and the protagonist's name change at its center. Wenham appropriately questioned the significance of such structures: "But how significant this is for exegetical understanding of the material remains open."¹ Noting the existence of the parallels is not enough; contrasting the character of Abraham with Abram and examining the differences between the parallel stories in each half contributes to the analysis and development of the narrative throughout the cycle.

- A. The line of Terah: Abram, Nahor, and Haran (11:27–32).
- B. Abram's separation from his father's house: "Go forth...to the land" (11:27–32).
- C. Abram journeys through the land and invokes the name of God (12:1–5).
- D. Abram's separation from family members: Sarah is taken by Pharaoh, but returned to Abram (12:10–20); Lot departs for Sodom and does not return (13:1–18).
- E. Lot is rescued from captivity (14:1–24).
- F. The promise of offspring and land (15:1–21). Abram complains (15:2: "what can You give me") and the word *zedaka* ("righteousness") is used in the context of his belief in God (15:6).²
- G. The angel's tidings to Hagar regarding the birth of Ishmael (16:1–16).
- H. The Covenant of Circumcision: Abram and Sarai's names are changed (17:1–27).

1 Wenham 1987, 263.

2 The analysis of this narrative will clarify why the tidings of offspring (15:1–6) and the tidings of land (15:7–21) should be viewed as one story that includes two separate units.

- G₁. The angel's tidings to Sarah regarding the birth of Isaac (18:1–15).³
 - F₁. Debate over the destruction of the land (18:16–33). Abraham complains (18:25: “Far be it from You to do such a thing!”) and the word *zedaka* is used in the context of God's decision to reveal his plan to Abraham (18:19).⁴
 - E₁. Lot is rescued from Sodom's destruction (19:1–37).
 - D₁. Abraham's separation from family members: Sarah is taken by Abimelech but returned to Abraham (20:1–18); Ishmael is expelled to the desert of Paran, and does not return (21:1–21).⁵
 - C₁. The covenant of Abraham and Abimelech: Abraham invokes the name of God (21:22–34).⁶
 - B₁. Abraham's separation from his son: “Go forth to the land of Moriah” (22:1–19).
 - A₁. The line of Nahor (22:20–24).
- Transitional Narratives and Conclusion (23–25).

B–B1: Abraham's Separation from his Father and Son: “Go forth”

The caption “Go forth” is only one expression of similar content in the two texts. Both narratives convey a similar divine demand to “go forth” to an unknown place. In the first part Abram is commanded

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- 3 The analysis of ch. 18 will demonstrate that this message is intended for Sarah (and not Abraham).
 - 4 The term *zedaka* (זֶדָקָה) is mentioned only in chs. 15 and 18 throughout the story cycle. The borders of the unit depicting Abraham's argument with God over the destruction of Sodom are complex; v. 18:16, which prefaces the argument with the conclusion of Abraham's hospitality, deliberately links the episode of Abraham's hospitality with the destruction of Sodom.
 - 5 The reason behind the inclusion of the two parts of the narrative (the birth of Isaac and the expulsion of Ishmael) in one literary unit is discussed in the analysis of ch. 21.
 - 6 The analysis of these narratives will demonstrate that by journeying through the land and by creating a pact with Abimelech, Abraham in fact assumes ownership of the land.

to leave behind his native land and the house of his father to go to Canaan. In the second part, Abraham is commanded to go to an unknown hilltop in the land of Moriah and sacrifice his son there. Despite the similarity between the two tests, each is accompanied by a different atmosphere. The initial test demands the resilience involved in leaving behind what is familiar and facing a new human culture. Abram is expected to go to a “land” with political borders, and cope with the political significance of emigrating to that land. In his final test, Abraham is asked to go to the “land of Moriah,” but the significance of the geographical destination is diminished in light of the emotional and spiritual road Abraham is required to travel. The significance of Abraham’s initial journey is to arrive in physical Canaan, while the purpose of his final journey is to come to the point of willingness to sacrifice his future to God.

C–C1: Abraham Builds Altars and Invokes the Name of God

Abram invokes the name of God by the altar he had built near Bethel (12:13–4), while Abraham invokes the name of God by a tamarisk he had planted in Beer-sheba (21:33). The two narratives create a geographical frame – from the northern city of Bethel to the southern city of Beer-sheba.⁷ When God’s name is invoked in Beer-sheba, He is referred to by the unique title “The Everlasting God” (21:33). Planting the tamarisk (and later creating a pact with Abimelech) is symbolic of Abraham’s belief in the permanency of his relationship with the land. Abraham’s God is therefore given a title that expresses His ability to maintain Abraham’s permanent ownership of the land.

D–D1: Abraham’s Separation from Family Members

The difference between the two parts is particularly apparent in the two narratives describing Abraham’s separation from various family

7 Cf. Amos 5:5.

members. In four different narratives Abram/Abraham is required to separate from a close family member: Sarai/Sarah is taken from him twice, although he is reunited with her at the conclusion of both narratives. Additionally, Abram is separated from Lot, his adopted nephew (d), and from Ishmael son of Hagar (d1). Various scholars have pointed to the cohesion of the Abraham–Lot narratives, and some went as far as the assumption that this is the core for the entire cycle.⁸ The fact that the two stories are paralleled in the structure (e-e1) reflects this correlation, but the concentric structure of the cycle provides a new context for the separation from Lot. Paralleling the separation from Lot with the separation from Ishmael gives the former new meaning. Emotionally, the relationship with Lot is compared to the relationship with a son. The ramifications on the cycle are profound, since in view of Sarah’s infertility Lot – like Ishmael – might have been perceived by Abraham as a possible heir. The separation from Lot challenges Abraham’s security in an existing – albeit not a biological – heir, while the separation from Ishmael denies him the hope of an existing heir.

Water plays an important role in both the Ishmael and Lot narratives. Lot separates from Abraham when he sees the fertility of the Transjordan “Lot looked about him, and saw how well watered (משקה) was all the plain of Jordan, all of it” (13:10), while Ishmael is saved from death after his mother was shown a well: “Then God opened her eyes and she saw a well of water. She went and filled the skin with water, and let the boy drink (ותשק)” (21:19). The water, which enables life, serves an opposing function in each of the narratives. In the Lot narrative the water represents “riches hoarded by their owner, to his misfortune” (Ecc 5:12). The permanent fertility of the land leads to the corruption of the people of Sodom, who become overconfident and uncompassionate. In the Ishmael narrative the water symbolizes giving new life and growth. While Ishmael is reborn in the desert, Lot settles in a place whose inhabitants are “very wicked sinners against the Lord” (13:13).

The changing image of God is noteworthy in the context of the story cycle, and particularly in the separation narratives. God’s

8 Blum 1990. See also Rudin-O’brasky 1981, 48–49.

affliction of Pharaoh is negligible compared with his involvement in the Abimelech narrative. God reveals Himself to Abimelech and commands him, in addition to physically restraining him from touching Sarah and punishing his household. While Lot's separation from Abraham does not involve God, God encourages Abraham to follow his wife's instructions and send Ishmael away; but God also accompanies Ishmael on his new path. Ishmael's rebirth portrays God as an alternative to the parents who had abandoned him.

E–E1: Lot is Rescued from Sodom

The similarity between the two Lot narratives is obvious. Although Gen 14 differs in nature and style from the other narratives in the cycle, the chapter finds its place in the concentric structure of the cycle, and is paralleled by Lot's rescue from the people of Sodom. Here, too, God's involvement is infinitely greater in the second part of the cycle: In ch. 14 Abram rescues Lot without God's command or involvement. In fact, God is absent from the narrative altogether, and Abram's unlikely success is not attributed to God's assistance. In the parallel narrative Lot is rescued by God and His angels. While Abraham is involved in the theoretical debate regarding the fate of Sodom, he is not actively involved in the destruction of Sodom or in Lot's rescue from the city.

F–F1: The Promised Land and the Destruction of the Promised Land

The Covenant between the Pieces (15) and the discussion of the destruction of Sodom (18) might at first seem unrelated, but both episodes demonstrate Abraham's partnership with God in relation to the future of the Promised Land. In response to Abraham's question, "how shall I know that I am to possess it?" (15:8), God confided His plans about the inheritance of the land by Abram's descendants. In the parallel narrative, God revealed His plan to destroy an area of the land that was promised to Abraham. The debate between God and

Abraham on the fate of Sodom should not be viewed as “Abraham’s prayer,”⁹ but rather as a legal debate on the parameters of what is “charitable and just.” The design of the narrative emphasizes the partnership between God and Abraham in the decision to destroy Sodom; Abraham seems to have the right to be heard in the matter of a decision that will affect the land he was promised on the merits of charity and justice.

Chapters 15 and 18 include the only two instances in the cycle in which Abraham complains before God, and is perhaps even critical of His ways (15:2–3; 18:22–25). Interestingly, these are the only two narratives in which the word צדקה (“justice/charity”) is mentioned as justification for the selection of Abraham (15:6; 18:19).¹⁰ But in this instance as well, the interaction between God and Abraham is much more involved in the second part of the cycle. While a covenant expresses a degree of partnership, the covenant between man and God cannot be viewed as an agreement between equals.¹¹ Abraham’s passivity in the Covenant between the Pieces is especially emphasized by his mental state – he is asleep throughout the ceremony, and is told of God’s plans and terms without the ability to influence the agreement. The debate on the destruction of Sodom gives Abraham the opportunity to express his position, and God’s edict is affected by Abraham’s involvement.

G–G1: Tidings of the Birth of Abraham’s Son

The two narratives in chs. 16 and 18 share similar content: an angel appears to announce that Abram’s wife will bear a son. In addition to content, the narratives are linked by a similar ethical theology: the birth of the son is a reward or compensation for human action. Hagar’s son is a compensation for her unjust suffering at the hands of Sarah, while Sarah merits a son for her hospitality. The personal reward to each of

9 As indicated by the caption offered by Skinner (1930, 304).

10 On the importance of this phrase, see: Artus 2013.

11 Weinfeld 1970.

the wives is the reason the tidings are not delivered to Abraham, and the reason for a direct and intimate meeting with God's angel.

The distinction between the revelation to Hagar in the wilderness (16) and the revelation to Sarah in the house of Abraham (18) is particularly noteworthy. An angel appeared to Hagar "by a spring of water in the wilderness" (16:7). Hagar has disengaged from Abram and his household, and meets the angel on her way to Egypt; therefore the angel's message can only be attributed to Hagar's merit, not to Abram's influence. The visit of the angels to Abraham's tent – immediately after the Covenant of Circumcision and Abraham's name change – expressed God's closeness to Abraham in the second part of the cycle. God descends to Abraham's tent to discuss the fate of Sodom, and promises Abraham and Sarah a son as a reward for their hospitality. The intimate relationship between God and Abraham is an introduction to the atmosphere that will accompany the Abraham narratives throughout the second part of the cycle.

H: The Covenant of Circumcision and Changing Abraham's Name

The eighth story, which is the central axis of the cycle, centers on the Covenant of Circumcision. God demands of Abraham: "Walk in My ways and be blameless" (17:1), and in return promises: "I will maintain My covenant between Me and you, and your offspring to come, as an everlasting covenant throughout the ages, to be God to you and to your offspring to come" (17:7). This verse describes the essence of the transition from the first part of the cycle to the second. In the Covenant of Circumcision, Abraham commits to "walk in God's ways," while God promises to "be Abraham's God." The parameters set by the Covenant of Circumcision enable a uniquely intimate relationship between God and Abraham. God's personal visit to Abraham's tent (g1) is appropriately positioned after this covenant, followed by Abraham's "partnership" with God, which is expressed by the discussion on the destruction of Sodom (f1) – which is absent from the first part of the cycle.

This essential change in the relationship can shed light on the differences between parallel narratives in the concentric structure. The change is expressed in Abraham's character, but also in a greater degree of initiation and intervention by God in the second half of the cycle.

God commands Abraham to "go forth" in both parts (b-b1), but while Abraham follows God's command both times, his actions in the second part seem to express an unusual closeness to God, who acknowledges that "For now I know that you fear God" (22:12). In the first part of the cycle Abraham was told, "Up, walk about the land, through its length and its breadth" (13:17); the Covenant of Circumcision replaces this demand with the expectation that Abraham "Walk in My ways and be blameless" (17:1). The new expectation is tested in the final test of Abraham, when he is told to go to the land of Moriah and sacrifice his son to God. The new significance of Abraham's "going" or "walking" in the second half of the cycle sheds light on the physical journey to the binding of Isaac – which is a realization of walking in God's ways.

In conclusion, the first part of the cycle describes Abram's acceptance of God's authority, while the second part portrays the close interaction between God and Abraham and the strengthening of Abraham's loyalty to God. God becomes more heavily involved in every aspect of Abraham's life; He consults with Abraham regarding the fate of Sodom; He intervenes in Abraham's personal relationship with Ishmael; and Abraham's faith in God is tested and proved time and time again. This idea was previously expressed by the Sages in the following midrash:

Abraham said: Before I was circumcised passers-by would come to me, perhaps now that I am circumcised they will cease from coming? The Holy One, Blessed Be He, said to him: Before you were circumcised people would come and visit with you, now I come and reveal Myself to you in all My glory, as it is written "and the Lord appeared to him by the terebinths of Mamre."¹²

12 Genesis Rabbah 47:10. Another version reads: "He said, before I was circumcised passersby would come to me; God said to him, before you were circumcised the uncircumcised would come, now I appear before you with my host, as it is written, 'Looking up, he saw three men standing near him'; 'he saw' the presence of God; 'he saw' the angels" (Genesis Rabbah 48:9).

The midrash portrays Abraham's ongoing relationship with "passers-by" before his circumcision, while after he was circumcised Abraham was visited by God Himself. This idea is indicated in the Covenant of Circumcision, and is reflected in the literary structure of the story cycle.

The design of the cycle as two parallel halves that reflect the process experienced by the protagonist overshadows the division of the text based on form criticism. Based on this structure, narratives that are generally attributed to different sources converse with one another: the binding of Isaac (22) is linked with Abram's journey to Canaan (12); Ishmael's separation from the house of Abraham (21) is linked with Lot's separation from the house of his uncle (13); the rescues of Lot from Sodom mirror each other (14; 19); in addition to other paired narratives, which are considered to originate from different sources. These latent dialogues between the narratives led some scholars to reject the documentary hypothesis altogether; however, even if one accepts the premise of a variety of sources at the core of the text, there is no question that the text in its final form is wrought with artistic and ideological significance. If the Abraham narratives were originally separate stories with separate inclinations, formulations, and theological perceptions, they were woven into a unified structure with internal logic.

A general overview of the Abraham cycle cannot be limited to an exploration of the process that the characters undergo in light of the narrative's structure. Besides arranging the story into two mirroring halves, we must consider the broader themes of the story as a whole, some of which we mentioned in the introduction. Two major themes bind the story cycle: the theme of national blessing (the tidings of Isaac's birth in the Covenant of Circumcision [17]; the expulsion of Hagar [21]; Lot's rescue in merit of Abraham [19; 29]) and the theme of moral blessing (tidings of Isaac's birth in Abraham's tent [18]; Hagar's flight [16]; Lot's rescue in merit of his hospitality [19:1–28]). These themes express the essential duality of the story cycle. Abraham is portrayed as a complex character who successfully established a nation committed to a covenant with God, while maintaining moral sensitivity by instructing his children and his descendants to keep the way of the Lord by doing what is charitable and just.

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